Magic of Etheria (old)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29859327.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Background & Cameo Characters

Additional Tags:
POV Adora (She-Ra), Magic, Adventure, Adventure & Romance, Post-She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018) Season 5, catradora, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Useless Lesbians, Romance, Angst, Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Adora (She-Ra) is a Dork, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra has magic, Glimmer doesn't get out much, Adora learns what marriage is and overthinks when to propose, Implied/Referenced Sex, Illustrations, Illustrated, Marriage Proposal, Minor Character Death, Outdated work, This Work Is Being Rewritten

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Magic of Etheria (old)

by IorekoftheHorde

Summary

This work is in the process of being rewritten

Lance and George supplied the stack of blank books as promised, fulfilling their end of the favour - for now. They stand, tall and patient, piled high at one end of the desk. Adora adjusts her dress to a more comfortable position before wiggling in her chair. She supposes she's going to be here for a while. After all, there's a lot to think about...

Where to begin? She ponders. At the beginning, she decides.

And after that? An adventure beyond anything she could have imagined. From the long-lost depths to the magical skies of Etheria. With the Horde truly gone, the rebuilding is all but complete. But that wasn't the case back then. Adora smiles at the thought of Catra; she was there that morning, quite unexpectedly. That was before they knew about her magic, before she learnt to control it.

Adora takes a final deep breath, thinking about everything they've been through since the Heart. It's all important, the good days, the bad days; she'll write about them all. With that thought in mind, she reaches for the first of the blank books and, after opening it to the first page, puts pen to paper...

Notes

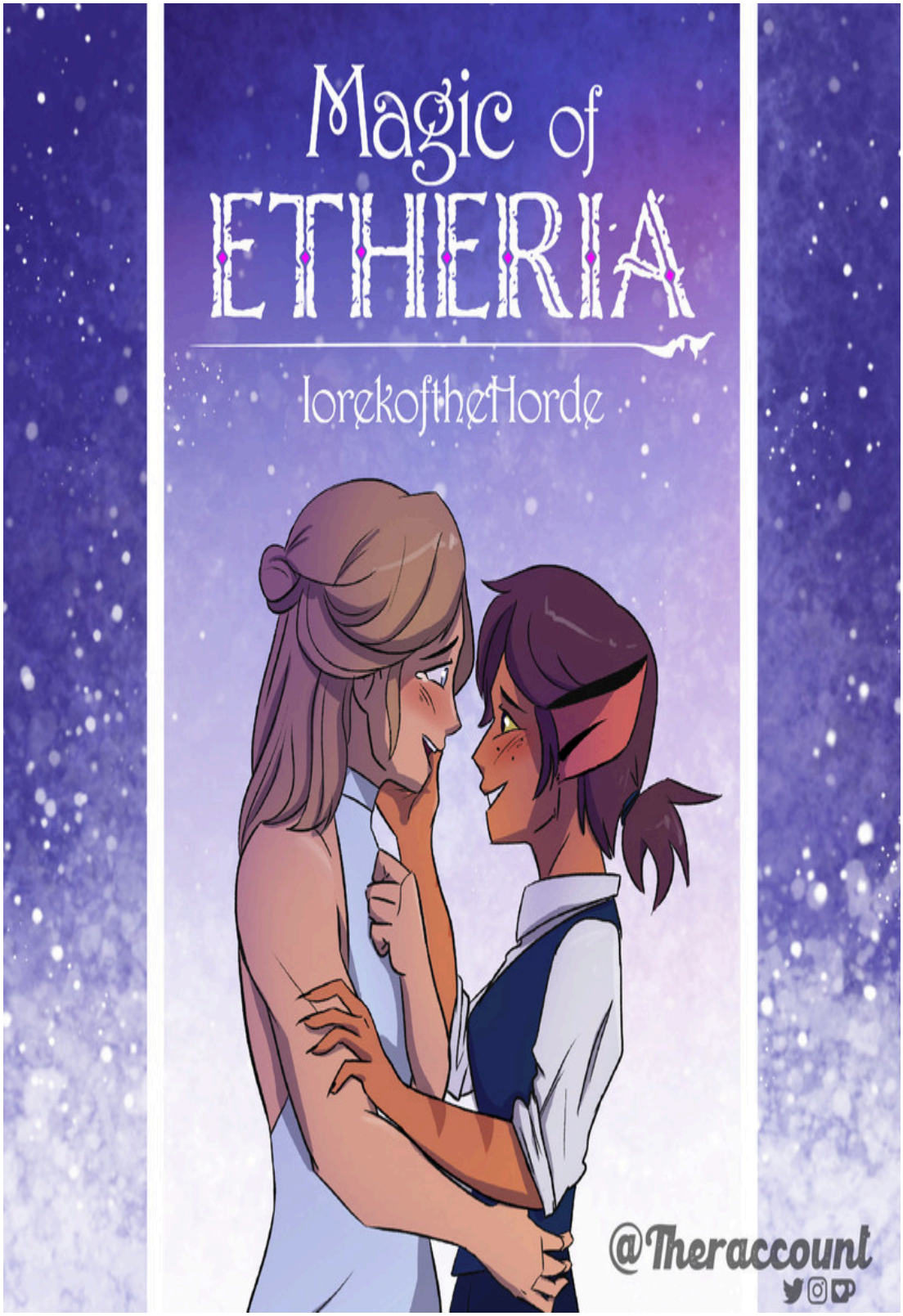


Illustration by @the.r.account on Instagram and @theraccount on Twitter

The First Morning of Peace

Chapter Notes

- This story expands upon the She-Ra Netflix series.
- Takes place after the events of Season 5.
- Written from Adora's POV.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Three years. Or thereabouts. That's how long it had been since I last woke up to find Catra in my bed. Those three years away from her had filled me with a loneliness I could never hope to describe in any kind of meaningful way, even though Glimmer and Bow were there to support me through it all. They had even gone to the length of sleeping in my room with me for the first few nights while I adjusted to not sleeping in a barracks surrounded by the other cadets. I will always be incredibly thankful for everything they did to help me feel at home in Bright Moon.

However, even though three whole years separated the last time I was in a bed with Catra (I still wasn't really sure if sharing the cot with her that time on Darla counted) this was the first time I had woken up to the sound of her purring softly against my collarbone. A warmth spread through me as the realisation hit that this was, in fact, real. Catra really was here, in my bed with me, with an arm draped over my waist. I dared not move for fear of waking her, for fear of shattering the dream of a moment I had woken up to. I couldn't think of a better way to wake up on Etheria's first morning of true peace.

Daylight streamed in through the open balcony doors and a light breeze gently nudged the curtains into a fleeting impromptu dance. The rest of the room bathed in the golden light, soaking it up and beaming it back out, giving the impression that the room itself was glowing.

I closed my eyes and relaxed back into the bed, just listening to the sound of Catra's purr, revelling in the feeling of the vibrations stirring in her chest against me. For the first time that morning, I let my mind wander beyond the walls of my bedroom. Yesterday had actually happened. I still couldn't quite believe it. We defeated Horde Prime, saved Etheria, and Catra…

Catra confessed to me, and I to her.

I could feel my face flushing bright red as that moment flashed though my mind once again; the Heart of Etheria glowing fiercely behind Catra, framing her face in a golden-green glow. Then, she leant down and kissed me, and everything clicked. I had always danced around these feelings, never quite being able to put a name to them until yesterday, but I realised when the temple showed me all of Catra at different moments in her- in our life, that I loved her. That I had always loved her, and always will. That kiss, that overwhelming feeling of love, had been enough for She-Ra to appear, if involuntarily on my part. I remembered parting from the kiss and putting Catra back down on the ground, staring down at her with a stupid grin on my face. "Wow." I had said. "Don't ruin it." She replied.

After arriving back in Bright Moon yesterday we found that the majority of the city's residents had already returned, having seen Bow's message and joined the fight against the Galactic Horde, leaving the safety of their hidden camps and returning home once all the clones disappeared. The spired remained, but no-one seemed to care just yet, they were a problem for a different day. The city threw a huge impromptu celebration upon our return to Bright Moon, welcoming us home as heroes and celebrating our collective victory over the Horde. All of us danced, sang, ate, drank, and laughed the night away, just enjoying the feeling of complete freedom at long last. Once the festivities started slowing down, well into the night, everyone began turning in one by one, or two by two in some cases.

I absentmindedly began tracing the stripes on Catra's arm, still draped over my waist, with my free hand. My other arm still firmly

trapped at my side underneath her. Catra had followed me when I left the party to turn in for the night but seemed to get quite defensive and standoffish when I suggested staying with me. She had turned around, blurted out "see you in the morning," before bounding away down the hallway with Melog in hot pursuit. After hearing her say that, I had not expected to find her in my room in the morning, much less wake up with her half-draped over me – but here she was. She must have come back at some point during the night once I had managed to still my worry enough to fall asleep, getting changed into just her grey top and shorts that I had grabbed for her from my bag of clothes on Darla.

It then occurred to me that this is only the second time Catra has slept *next* to me instead of being curled up at the end of the bed. In the Horde, you were not allowed to share a bed, let alone sleep next to one another. A collective fear of Shadow Weaver's wrath had kept us from going that one step further. We had talked about it, of course, after I asked Catra why she didn't sleep next to me. "Shadow Weaver," she had said. She didn't have to say any more.

Catra's ear suddenly twitched and her purr stopped abruptly. I froze, my fingers still trailing over the darker fur of her stripes on her arm. After a moment, nothing happened, so I started pulling my hand away from her arm, but Catra's hand met mine and held it in place on my chest. I dared not move my head, in case she was still asleep, and this was just her involuntary moving in her sleep. But that idea was shattered when she leant up on her other arm and met my gaze with tired, half-lidded eyes. I couldn't help but smile wide when I saw her face. It was, after all, the first time I saw it since she ran off the night before. After a moment, her expression softened, and she returned my smile with one of her own before beginning to stroke the back of my hand with the one that had pinned it to my chest.

'Hey, Adora.' She whispered. The sound of her voice sent a shiver of happiness coursing through me. I moved without thinking, reaching up to cup her cheek before reaching behind her head and threading my hand into her hair and pulling her towards me. Catra let out a startled whimper as our lips touched for only the

second time and instinctively tried to pull away. I let her, meeting her eyes as she held herself above me. But after a moment she licked her lips and dived back down again, kissing me with more force than I had been expecting, cupping my face with her free hand, holding me as I kissed her back gratefully. In that moment, I was convinced I had never been happier. It was perfect, it felt so right, good, happy. If I had the choice, I felt that I could have stayed there, in that moment, forever.

Catra then moved her hand to my shoulder and buried her face in my neck before I had chance to see her face. I could feel her heavy breathing against me and used the hand in her to scratch just under her ear. I leant my head back to give her more access and sighed when she began to rub her cheek against me, slowly working up towards my jaw. Suddenly, thoughts that Catra may not have wanted me to kiss her flashed through my head and I started worrying that I had just majorly overstepped.

'Was… was that okay? I'm sorry for kissing you out of nowhere, I just-' I was cut off by a low growl coming from Catra as she paused her movements against my jaw. 'Catra?'

'Never say sorry for kissing me. You- you can do it whenever you want. I liked it.' Her voiced trailed off towards the end as her stern tone died down and she buried her face in my neck once again.

'Okay,' I acknowledged, letting go of the lump of worry that had formed in my throat. 'I can do that.' I felt a surge of confidence well up within me as her words sunk in. 'Maybe don't forget to breathe next time though.' I said, smirk evident on my face.

'Shut up, I can still take it back.' Catra huffed into my neck.

I heard a snort escape me before I grinned and wrapped my arms around her, pulling her close and holding her against me. Catra's arms slowly reached around me too, but her face remained where I couldn't see it, no doubt hiding the blush that definitely covered her face.

There was something I wanted to know before we started the day, before we had to get out of bed and leave the room. If I didn't ask her the question before then, I knew that I would just end up worrying about it until I got the chance to ask again. So, I closed my eyes and took a deep breath, savouring the moment. I relaxed my arms around her, giving her the means to escape and run if she felt the need to. 'Catra?'

'Hm?'

'Where did you go last night? I kind of thought you wouldn't be coming back.'

Catra's claws dug into my back, but she didn't run. She just held onto me for a moment, before releasing a deep breath. 'I just – I needed to think. So much happened yesterday… I left you behind, Horde Prime hacked the planet, Shadow Weaver… and *you*. I just needed some time, some quiet to process it all.'

Shadow Weaver. Right at the last moment she had sacrificed herself to take the guardian with her, allowing Catra and I to go on to the Heart of Etheria safely. Without her, without her sacrifice, we may not be here right now, holding each other close – I had never, *never* considered that Shadow Weaver could have some good left in her, and I never would have considered, or even imagined, that she would do anything as selfless as that when she was so close to having all the power she had ever wanted.

My hand moved back up and threaded itself back into Catra's hair, stroking through it gently, and I smiled when I heard and felt the soft purr vibrate against me. I couldn't believe how long we had been fighting each other on opposite sides of a war, always trying to get one up on one another. At some point, I realised that I had started hoping to run into her on our missions, if just to see that she was okay. I angled my head down and kissed into her hair, relishing in the little sound she made as I did. 'You can take all the time you need; I'm not going anywhere. I'll never leave you ever again.'

For only the second time that morning, Catra looked up at me and I met her gaze. She had such beautiful eyes, practically glowing at me with tears forming within them. I slowly moved my hand up to her face, aiming to wipe the tears from her eyes.

But I stopped dead as a familiar twinkle of magic sounded in the room, and I became suddenly aware that we had guests.

'Adora! Are you awake? We can't find Catra anywhere-' Glimmer started to say, speaking incredibly fast, even for her, but cut herself off when her eyes landed on the bed and saw Catra and I in each other's arms. Catra buried her face back into my neck, her tail thrashing around behind her, displaying her embarrassed annoyance for all to see. At least, I could tell that's what it means, I wasn't sure about Bow and Glimmer, who seemed to have ceased functioning as their brains caught up with their eyes.

'Morning, guys.' I greeted, wrapping one arm around Catra and using the other to pull the duvet up and over her in an attempt to make her feel more comfortable. I struggled against her trashing tail for a bit but got there in the end.

'Good morning, Adora,' replied Glimmer, '*and* Catra,' she added pointedly, 'I should have known she would be in here with you.' I felt my face warm up as the blush spread across it.

Catra growled against my neck, but I could tell there was no menace behind it. 'Ugh. Leave me alone, Sparkles.' She leant up on her arms and hissed in their general direction.

'She didn't mean that.' I added, not wanting my friends to get the wrong idea about her little outbursts.

'It's okay, Adora, it's just soo cuuute!' Bow cooed, his eyes grew two sizes and seemed to sparkle while he watched this scene unfold. Catra would likely hiss at me if I admitted this, so I didn't say it out loud, but I had to agree with Bow: she was adorable. I suddenly felt extremely lucky to be able to have this moment and be a part of it. Had events not played out the way they did, had

Catra not found her way to the Heart, I might have actually died. For a brief moment, the vision of the future I saw in the Heart flashed in my mind, all of us together just like this. Well, not quite like this, but together, alive, and smiling. Or snarling. I'll take whichever.

'So, what's the plan?' I asked, bringing myself back to reality. 'Now that the Horde is gone, what's our next move? Rebuilding? Bringing magic back to the universe?' I noticed Catra was looking at me and I briefly met her gaze before she moved away and buried her face in the pillow next to mine. I felt a frown encroach on my face – had I said something wrong?

'For now,' Glimmer began, falling into her routine of explaining plans as Queen, 'we'll focus on clean-up of Bright Moon and all nearby settlements. There will be a meeting of the Princess Alliance in a couple of days to discuss more long-term plans. I just wanted to let you know that you can take it easy until then – we could all do with some time to recharge. I'm just sorry we can't have longer to rest.' She smiled at Bow, taking his hand in hers before squeezing it. He returned her gaze reassuringly. 'Well!' She continued, 'we'll leave you two to… whatever it was you were doing. Bye!' And with that, they were gone, just as quickly as they arrived – a cloud of sparkles dissipating where they once stood.

As soon as they were gone Catra got up from the bed, walking over to where her red and black Horde uniform was crumpled in a pile on the floor. She bent down to pick it up and clutched it to her chest, her tail swayed slowly behind her, twitching every so often – she was unsure, conflicted.

'Catra?' I prompted, not wanting to pressure her. 'Are you okay?' I moved across the bed until I was sat at the edge dangling my legs over the side, looking up at Catra patiently, waiting. After a moment I stood up slowly and began making my way over to her. I placed a tentative hand on her shoulder, but she shrugged it off. I paused, stunned, my chest starting to ache with worry. 'Catra? What's wrong? Talk to me, please.'

‘I just – I just want…’ Catra sighed, pausing and clutching her clothes tighter to her chest.

‘Catra? You can talk to me. I’m here for you, I’m not going anywhere.’

‘I know! I just want – I need – some time… with… you.’ Her words trailed off toward the end, growing quieter as she let herself speak the truth unmarred by snarky, deflective remarks.

I let out the breath I hadn’t realised I was holding and smiled. That’s exactly what I wanted too, just to spend some time with her before the Alliance meeting. ‘Catra, that’s-’

Catra spun round to face me, her eyes sparkling with tears and glaring at me with an intensity that took my breath away once again. ‘I just want to spend time with you! Okay?’ Her eyes went wide as she realised how brutally honest she was letting herself be. Her ears pinned back as she flushed a bright red, she looked at the floor to avoid looking directly into my eyes as she continued. ‘I mean, I – I’ve done nothing but fight against you for so long, and even after we got back to Etheria you were always busy helping others and had no time for… for me.’ I watched as she closed her eyes and buried her face in the bodysuit she was still clutching on to. ‘Just ignore me. It’s stupid. Go and help people, it’s what you’re best at.’ Catra turned away and moved away towards the door, unfolding her clothes from her arms and preparing to put them on.

‘Oh, Catra…’ I watched her go for a moment before moving after her, grabbing her wrist to stop her before wrapping my arms around her from behind, stroking my fingers through the soft fur on her stomach. ‘I will always have time for you. *Always.* You were right – in the Heart – I am an idiot. I didn’t realise how I felt until just before you arrived, when the temple showed me a vision of you. I hated leaving you behind in the Horde. *Hated* it. It tore me apart and I’ll never forgive myself for doing that to you. I’ve been worrying about you ever since – I never stopped thinking about you, I couldn’t just leave you behind on Horde Prime’s

flagship either.' I felt tears welling up, and they dripped down my face as I blinked to clear my eyes. 'I never meant you make you feel like I didn't care for you – like you didn't matter. You always mattered to me, and I never stopped thinking about you.'

I spun her round and held her down with my hands on her shoulders, as if she may float away if I let go and looked her directly in the eye. I could feel the tears still trailing down my face but seeing her also crying made a lump form in the back of my throat. 'Catra…' I fought against the knot, swallowing it down. 'I really do love you. I love you *so much*. I'm sorry it took me so long to realise it. I'm sorry it took me almost dying for you to say it first. But ever since you did, I've thought of nothing but you. I can't think of anything but you. My head is full of you and how I feel about you. You are the centre of my world; you always have been. From now on, you're my priority, and I will never prioritise anything else above you or your – *our* happiness ever again.'

Catra just stared at me in silence, wide eyed and stunned. I watched as another lone tear dripped down her face as she slowly turned bright red. The clothes she was loosely clutching were suddenly flung across the room – I watched them land across the floor, but my gaze was torn away as I felt her hands on my face, turning me to look back at her. 'Adora…' I shuddered as Catra breathed my name. She had never said it like that before, there was a hint of something new there, something I hadn't felt before but sent a warmth flooding through me regardless as Catra moved closer. I felt my heartbeat thundering in my chest as her lips closed in on mine…

All at once my body reacted to her, it was nothing like our first kiss in the Heart, or our second from earlier just after waking up; this was so much more. I felt a shiver shoot up my spine and I gasped at the sensation, Catra took the opportunity to deepen the kiss through my parted lips. I immediately shut down, lost myself, and stopped thinking clearly as Catra filled all my senses. My hands were on her, pushing her back against the door which rattled under the impact. I felt a tug and realised her hands were threaded through my loose hair and *pulling,* her claws trailing over

my scalp in-between as she held my head in place. I stroked my hands down the curves of her back and felt the door handle behind her, locking it absentmindedly. Her ear twitched as she heard the click of the lock and her hands fell to my hips, pushing against me and forcing me backwards across the room. I fell back against the bed and leant up on my elbows, breathing heavily as I looked up at Catra standing between my legs. Our eyes fixed on each other, breathing ragged and pupils dilated. The way she was looking at me… I had never seen it before. I wanted more, but…

'Catra…' was all I managed to say. I wanted to say more, needed to say more, but I didn't have time to get out any more words between my heavy breaths before she straddled my thighs, grabbed my wrists and pinned me back against the bed with my hands above my head. Her face was inches away from mine and I could feel myself slipping further into whatever this was becoming, her breath hot against my face. She was staring deep into my eyes with a want, a *need*, and I felt myself squirm underneath her. 'Catra… wait…'

Her reaction was immediate. She sat up, releasing her grip on my wrists, looking down at me like she had just accidentally attacked me. 'Adora…I – I'm sorry I don't-'

'No! Don't be sorry. It's okay, I just… I want to make sure this is what you want.' I made sure to leave my hands above my head as I looked up at her, letting her know that I wasn't uncomfortable.

'I – I think I… Do you want this? I was just so overwhelmed with what you were saying I wasn't thinking and… I didn't ask or-'

'I do.' I said, the words coming to me easily, confidently. 'I do want it, Catra. It feels… I don't know – right? I've always felt an attraction to you, and I couldn't really explain why until recently but-'

'I have too. But you know that already.' Catra leant down above me again, her tail thrashing behind her. 'Adora, what you said was amazing and it… I feel like I *need* to have you. I feel like I've been

waiting for this my whole life. Now that I know how you feel I can’t hold it down anymore.’

‘Then don’t.’ I breathed, sighing as Catra’s hand found my wrists once again and pinned them to the bed. ‘I want you too, I want this. I just needed to know that you wanted this as much as I did.’

‘Adora…’ Catra leant down and started kissing along my collarbone, slowly working up my neck until she reached my jaw. I shuddered as I felt her fangs brush against my skin, and a moan I didn’t know I was suppressing managed to escape. Catra grinned a mischievous smirk, leaning up to whisper into my ear. ‘I want you, Adora. You’re mine.’

‘Yours.’ I rasped between shaking breaths.

That seemed to be all the confirmation Catra needed. I heard a low growl rise from deep within her throat as she leant up to look my in the eye one more time. I have no idea what expression she saw on my face, but it seemed to spur her on, causing her to drop down and seal our lips together – kissing me as if the world really was about to end.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi! Welcome to start of a journey that wouldn't leave my head when I finished watching this show for the first time in Jan 2021. To me, what happens in this story is just where my mind went after finishing the show. The story spans all across Etheria, and is absolutely a labour of love for this show. Hopefully I can do it justice.
>
> This chapter has been entirely rewritten and was updated on 12th April 2021.

Whispers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Warm. Soft. Fluffy.

Those were the three sensations that went through my half-asleep mind as I came-to from the involuntary nap. I still felt dazed, not quite awake enough to open my eyes, so I opted to relax for a little longer, burying my face further into the softness that surrounded me and being rewarded with the sound of a heartbeat next to my ear. *Catra*. I smiled softly as I realised where I was, draped over Catra's naked form with my face buried in her sternum. She must be awake, else she would be breathing much deeper than what I could feel under my arm as her stomach rose and fell with each breath. I let my mind wander, decidedly not ready to move from my current position.

That morning may very well have been the best morning of my life. I could never have imagined that me leaving the Horde all those years ago would lead us to this moment – Catra and I, together, happy, in love. Once my mind decided that it too would like to start waking up again it opted to replay that morning's events in my mind's eye. I had never felt anything like it before, just letting go, surrendering myself to Catra and letting her take care of me. It had been easy to let go, easier than I thought it would be. I hadn't realised how much I wanted it until she pinned me to the bed, but knowing that she wanted it too had been the spark that ignited the fireworks within me. The culmination of our activities featured a shared moment of pure bliss, a moment filled to the brim with so much pure emotion that far surpassed anything I've ever experienced before.

So much so, that Catra had been able to draw out She-Ra from within me. It had been completely involuntary on my part, but in that precise moment I felt such a sudden rush of love, joy, and

satisfied fulfilment that I lost control and couldn't keep her down. She-Ra, as I've come to understand, is a being of pure magic, love, and hope. I couldn't summon her before because I was confused, Catra had been all I could think about and when she left it created a void in me that I couldn't fill until that confusion had lifted. The poison hadn't helped either. But since the Heart, Catra had now summoned She-Ra twice. Twice more than I had, and I am her.

I held my breath as Catra's fingertips trailing down my back, tracing old scars and following the lines of very recently made raised scratches. It stung a little as her fingers trailed along them, I couldn't help but wince as she pressed just a bit too hard on one of them. Despite the stinging, I felt an immense loss when her hand suddenly pulled away, leaving my back completely exposed.

'Adora? Are you awake? I'm so sorry, I didn't realise I was digging in this hard.' Catra's voiced was hesitant, laced with worry. I smiled and nuzzled into her some more, stroking one hand up her side and threading my fingers through the short fur of her torso.

'It's okay, Catra. It's not that bad, I promise.' I planted a kiss to her sternum before moving up, kissing a line to her collarbone. Catra's breath caught in her throat at the sudden affection, and her hand slowly returned to my back before steadily making its way up to rest on the back of my neck. The scratches had mostly healed anyway, thanks to the transformation into She-Ra, but her healing had always been more effective when directed toward other people anyway.

'I- I had no idea. I should be – *ah* – be able to c-control my claws better than that.' I smirked into the kisses as I started up her neck, revelling in the sounds I was able to coax out of her even while she attempted speech.

'It really is okay, Catra, honestly,' *kiss*, 'I lost control at one point too,' *kiss*, 'we'll just have to practice a lot more,' *kiss*. Eventually, I

reached her jawline and began kissing back along it as she angled her head upwards to give me better access.

'I rememb-*ah* some of those older sc-*ah*-ars too. *Ahh!'* I nibbled on a spot just below her ear and soaked up the sounds it lured out of her. 'I feel bad, for all the times I've hurt you.' Pausing my assault on her neck, I leant up on one arm and looked down into her eyes. There was such a mix of emotion on her face. Her mouth was wide and breathless, her cheeks flushed red, her short hair a mess above her – but her eyes… her eyes contained a conflict like I've never seen. I could see the love there, she looked up at me with an adoration no one had ever shown me, but beyond that there was worry, regret, guilt. Her hand slowly moved up from the back of my neck to thread her fingers through me hair, I closed my eyes, leaning into the touch gratefully.

'Catra… We can't dwell on the past. We fought against each other our whole lives. Growing up the Fright Zone, and during the war. I know you have your fair share of scars too, even if your fur hides them. I still feel them.' I moved my other hand to her waist, tracing a scar there long hidden by fur. It was a scar no-one else would know about because it happened while we were younger, climbing across unsafe rooftops, looking for a new hiding place. She had caught herself on a particularly sharp loose screw, forcing us to abort that quest as I had to carry her to the infirmary and clean the wound before anyone (Shadow Weaver) saw.

'That doesn't make me feel any better about it. I still hurt you.' Her eyes closed as she turned her head away, her ear almost slapping my in the face.

'You can't keep feeling guilty. All we can do now is move forward. You and me, together.' I moved my hand from her waist and used it to cup her face, bringing her back to face me. Once she opened her eyes and met my gaze, I couldn't help but smile. 'Hey. This was amazing.'

A small smile encroached on the corner of her mouth as I caressed her cheek with my thumb. 'Yeah, it was.' She admitted,

leaning into my touch. ‘I just want to avoid hurting you - if I can.’

‘Well…’

‘Well what?’ Her eyes met mine and I looked away, immediately feeling my face turning red at what I was about to admit.

‘It was… nice? I kind of… enjoyed it.’ I closed my eyes and sighed as I felt her claws extend against my head where her fingers were still threaded through my hair.

‘You like my claws, princess?’ There it was – her sultry, confident voice that melts me every time I hear it. I nodded, careful not to move too fast with her claws right there. ‘I’ll work on getting them under control for next time then, I promise.’

‘Next time?’ I opened my eyes and looked down at her, taking in the smirk plastered to her face. ‘I suppose I’ll work on keeping She-Ra down too, then.’

‘You do that. Although, I might be up for her taking a more *active* role in future…’

I blushed furiously upon hearing her say that, immediately hiding my face in her neck as she laughed and started to purr. ‘We should probably get up soon…’ I whispered against her. The purr immediately cut off and was replaced with a low growl. I slowly prised myself away from her before hopping off the bed and quickly grabbing a lilac dressing gown from the wardrobe, slipping it on and tying it together before turning and walking out onto the balcony.

Once outside, I took a deep breath, properly breathing in the air of this new day for the first time. I then opened by eyes and looked out over Bright Moon, trying, and failing, not to imagine anything relating to *that* little suggestion Catra threw out there. I couldn’t believe the effect she has on me, the hold that her words have over me. That morning had made me realise just how much I had been longing for this kind of connection with her. A deeper bond, beyond that of just being childhood friends or sparring

partners. It felt so *right*. Catra is able to make me feel things I never thought I would ever be allowed to feel, and being here with her – in Bright Moon – both of us together, far away from the Horde, the war behind us… It felt like a dream. A dream that I hoped would never end.

Catra's arms were suddenly wrapped around my waist, holding me against her as she buried her face in the softness of the dressing gown at my shoulder. I hadn't heard her approach but feeling her there against me reassured me that it was no dream. It was real. This was actually happening – we were here, happy, and most importantly, not at war. Content, I leant back into her, resting my head against hers and stroking along her arms with my hands.

Far below us, the people of Bright Moon had already started clearing up, both from the celebration last night and the destruction caused by Horde Prime's occupation. Bright Moon had fallen into Prime's hands early on, while Bow, Entrapta and I were going after Glimmer and Catra, held captive on the Galactic Horde's flagship. I squeezed Catra's arms, unable to help thinking about the pain she must have endured after saving Glimmer, having the chip implanted – losing herself… I tried to push those thoughts down, worrying about it now wouldn't help. Catra will talk to me about it when she's ready, I have no doubt.

'Soo… shall we go for a walk?' I asked, breaking the silence. Catra groaned into my shoulder. 'Oh, come on, we should go and see if anyone needs my help – see if She-Ra can be of any use, maybe do some heavy lifting.'

Catra lifted her head and let her chin rest on my shoulder. 'Sure thing, princess. I wondered how long you'd last without needed to go out and help people.'

'I can't just stand by-'

'-if someone needs your help. Yeah, I know, Adora. That's just how you are.' She gave me a gentle squeeze before moving away and walking back into the bedroom. I turned to watch her go,

only just seeing that she had already put her Horde uniform back on. Catra continued walking until she reached the door, she then unlocked it and knelt down, welcoming Melog into the room with a quick embrace and muttering something to them too quiet for me to hear from outside.

It was at that moment that I remembered about Swift Wind. He and I were linked through the sacred bond, we can feel what the other feels, especially when I'm She-Ra… 'Oh no,' I whispered to myself, hoping that by some miracle he hadn't been as attentive as usual and didn't *tune in* at the moment She-Ra had appeared, but if he had, I hoped that he hadn't been around anyone else at the time. If Swift Wind was aware of it and said anything to anyone… Catra probably wouldn't take that very well. Rather than letting the worry get to my I pushed the thought down and took a deep breath. 'It's fine. It'll be fine…'

'Hey, slow-poke!' Catra called from inside the room, 'we're ready. Are you going out like that or will you be wearing clothes?'

I looked up at her and smiled. She was standing by the door, now closed, with one hand on her hip. Melog was sat nearby. 'I'll be wearing clothes, Catra. I doubt you want anyone else seeing me like this.' I retorted as I fumbled around the room, collecting my clothes as Catra watched with a raised eyebrow.

'I have to agree with you there. You're all mine, princess.'

**

Bright Moon was more colourful than ever, despite the rubble and clearing up that was taking place, a reminder of the war that ended literally yesterday. Though despite that, everyone seemed… happy. The sky had never looked so beautiful, all manner of creatures flying through it and basking in the light of the first morning of a brand new, rejuvenated Etheria. Releasing the magic that had been collected and stored up within the Heart over the last thousand years had impacted everywhere. I couldn't begin to image what the Fright Zone must look like now if the effect of

Bright Moon was this staggering. Trying to imagine that industrial wasteland covered in plant life and populated by all kinds of magical creatures returning to their original habitats was, it turned out, quite the challenge.

It soon became clear, as we walked down the streets, weaving between people carrying this and that from one place to another, that news of Catra being here and who she used to be was no secret. The majority of folk who passed us by greeted us with friendly smiles and thanked us for helping Etheria and defeating Horde Prime. However, there were those on the side-lines who kept their distance, giving us uneasy glances and whispering amongst themselves as we passed by. Others, rather rudely, greeted me warmly while blatantly ignoring Catra entirely. It stung. All I wanted was for Catra to feel at home here, to feel safe, but I knew that she would be able to hear every word of what they were whispering about. After a while, Catra dropped my hand, instead opting to hug her arms around herself, hang her head, and wrap her tail around her leg in an attempt to shrink and become as unnoticeable as possible. I knew Melog had been with us the whole time, but they must have picked up on Catra's distress because they had turned invisible at some point.

Of course, the black and red Horde clothes didn't do much to help her blend in, especially not in Bright Moon. All these people also haven't known Catra their whole lives, unlike me, and until recently she had been their enemy actively leading an army to capture them and destroy their homes. Everyone knew Catra's name. She was seen as dangerous, ruthless, unforgiving. And yet here she was, following She-Ra around with her tail between her legs. It broke my heart to see it, but I knew there was nothing I could say in that moment to help her feel better about this whole situation. Things as deeply engraved as this needed time to heal, people needed time to get used to the new Catra, they needed time to forgive.

I asked Catra a few times if she wanted to stop, to go back to the palace, but she would just shake her head and continue on. So we did, we continued on our walk around the city and I helped out as

She-Ra where I could, smashing up rubble and lifting bits of buildings onto carts. After a while I spotted Swift Wind through the crowd. He was standing with Scorpia and Perfuma and they were clearly chatting about something while being careful not to be too loud. I felt a sense of dread rising in my stomach, but I took a deep breath and walked toward them, Catra following close behind. As we got closer, I made eye contact with Swift Wind and he froze to the spot. That can't be a good sign.

'Heey! Fellow… magical princesses.' I greeted, chuckling nervously before aiming finger guns at them, 'pew pew.' Swift Wind followed me with his gaze but didn't move a muscle. 'How goes… the day?' I was vaguely aware of Scorpia and Perfuma turning and waving but my attention was focused on trying to decipher Swift Wind's current expression. I watched as he turned his head to look at something suddenly incredibly interesting up a nearby tree. Oh, he definitely knew something.

Scorpia was the first to speak, Perfuma just had a huge grin plastered to her face. 'Hey! Adora! Good to see ya! Wow. Oh hey, and Catra too! There's my wild- wildcat! What are the chances, huh? Yeah… wow…' Swift Wind had definitely said something. I hate it when I'm right.

'Hey, Scorpia,' Catra greeted, 'what's up? Why are you acting so weird?'

Scorpia looked at Perfuma, who quickly glanced at Swift Wind before looking back to Scorpia and laughing nervously, still with that huge grin on her face. Scorpia looked back at Catra, her cheeks starting to turn red. 'Well, uh, funny story! Actually. Uh. Swift Wind! Here. Was just – um – just talking to us about – asking about, uh…' She looked at me as I started motioning for her to stop talking. 'He was just telling us about… uh, all those loop-de-loops he's been doing! Yeah! That's – that's what it was. Wow. What a rush, huh Swifty? Whew. Aha…' She scratched her head with one of her pincers. 'Wow. Look at the time… we should get going, actually! Yeah. We've got to help out… over there!' She pointed in a random direction. 'Catch you later, Wildcat!' She then

shuffled off in a completely different direction to where she had pointed.

Perfuma chuckled nervously. 'Isn't it great to be completely… honest… with friends?' She placed her palms together in front of her and breathed out. 'Okay. I should probably…' She pointed after Scorpia before giving us a quick wave and briskly walking after her.

Catra watched them go curiously before looking back to me quizzically. 'What was up with them…?' Concern clouded her eyes as she scanned my face, 'Adora – you're bright red. What's happening? Scorpia's never been *that* weird before, and I've known her for three years.' I hid my face in my hands, suddenly aware of how warm it felt. 'Adora? Answer me – what's wrong?'

I looked up at Swift Wind, who was shifting uncomfortably where he stood. 'Um… Swift Wind. Do you happen to know why they were acting so weird?'

He met my gaze properly for the first time since we walked over. I couldn't quite read his expression, but through the bond I could tell he felt uneasy, guilty. 'What? Why would I… pfft. No. It had absolutely nothing to do with what I asked them. Nothing. Nuh-uh.'

Catra looked dumbfounded, although I couldn't really blame her. I was having very vague conversation with a horse and we were both skirting around the subject. He smiled nervously as he looked over at Catra, but I heard an uneasy growl sound in her throat. I decided to interject, hopefully able to carefully shed some light on my hunch, which was definitely more than a hunch right now. 'Swifty – you didn't happen to uh… form a *connection* with me this morning when She-Ra appeared, did you?

'Ha!' Swift Wind broke into a practised monologue, 'I am the She-Ra's mighty steed! Whenever I sense her appear, I must form link through our sacred bond to check if she needs my assistance!' There was a pause, and his eyes went wide as he realised what

he had just admitted to. 'But what I experienced was very… intense… so I flew around until I found Perfuma because I thought she may be able to help me understand what it meant…' He trailed off as he finished speaking, slowly lowering his head to the ground as he found a tuft of grass to absentmindedly chew.

If it was possible, I felt the heat of my blush travel down my neck as what he said sunk in, and I re-covered my face with my hands. In that moment, I felt like I would have liked to disappear entirely. Of course this would happen, I had completely forgotten that Swift Wind could just tune-in whenever and would know whenever She-Ra appears. So of course he would check to see if I was alright. We would need to set some ground rules. I risked a peek at Catra through my fingers. She was stood stock-still, apparently in shock like she'd just seen ghost, her eyes wide and mouth gaping. I watched as colour returned to her face and then *kept going* as she turned the brightest shade of red I've ever seen. Then, without warning, she dropped onto all fours and pelted herself back down the street away from us.

'Catra!' I called after her, but she was hell-bent on being *anywhere else*. 'Ugh! Swift Wind! We're going to talk about this!' I yelled in frustration before running after Catra.

I heard him shout after me, 'I'm sorry! I didn't know!'

It's not your fault, I thought to myself, hoping he picked that up through the bond, at least.

**

'Catra!'

I raced through the streets of Bright Moon, narrowly avoiding passers-by, jumping around carts and boxes, and sliding around corners in an attempt to not lose sight of her in my pursuit.

'Catra! Wait!'

Catra was fast, even faster when she ran on all fours like this. It always took all of my concentration to keep up with her, figuring out shortcuts and ways to keep her in sight while doing my best to avoid knocking people down or breaking anything. It became clear pretty quickly that she was heading back towards the palace, so I focused myself on getting there, using my experience of living in Bright Moon longer to my advantage in the hopes of catching up to her.

Swift Wind had definitely said *something* to Scorpia and Perfuma about what he "experienced" earlier, but it would be impossible to know exactly what he had said until I had the chance to talk to him. He wouldn't have said too much, he's not like that, but I also know that he usually only gets feelings or sensations through the bond, so he won't have seen anything. *Seeing* requires a mutual consent on both sides, and as I hadn't sensed him on my end that was definitely not the case. I forced my doubts down as I neared the palace, instead focusing myself on trying to locate her again. I couldn't see her anywhere outside – I must have just missed her.

Inside, I found myself within a long hallway stretching off in opposite directions – she could have gone anywhere…

'Catra! Where are you!?'

I looked back and forth restlessly, weighing up which direction she could have fled down.

BANG!

I heard the tell-tale sound of a door slamming down the hallway to the left – that way! I took off, running toward where I had heard the sound and stopped outside the spare room when I noticed the door was ajar. Or was it the prison? Doesn't matter. The door must have bounced open again after being slammer so hard. I knew the guards were tasked with keeping the doors closed unless someone was inside and had told them to leave the door open, so seeing one ajar with no guards around stuck out. I took a moment to centre myself and calm my breathing before

slowly pushing on the door, hoping it wouldn't creak. It didn't. Inside, the room was dark, the curtains drawn. This room hadn't been used since Double Trouble was held prisoner here after we caught them red-handed. I couldn't help but wonder where they had gotten to, or what kind of mischief they were up to now that the war was over.

Catra was sat in the far corner of the room, her legs were pulled up to her chest with her arms around them, her face buried behind her knees, her ears pinned back, and her tail wrapped around her feet. Melog was sat next to her, pressed as close as they could get in attempt to reassure her. Catra's position was one I was very familiar with, having seen her do this plenty of times after being scolded by Shadow Weaver while growing up the Fright Zone. It was an attempt to make herself as small as possible, to fold in on herself and disappear. Tentatively, I took my first step into the room, trying not to startle her, but her hearing was too good for that. Her ears twitched and she snapped her head up to snarl at me before hissing, her eyes ablaze in the low light of the room. After a moment, her expression softened as she realised who I was, once again burying her face behind her legs.

'Hey,' I whispered, stepping closer, 'it's just me.' Seeing her like this always made my chest ache. Catra had always seemed so confident, proud, unshakable before Horde Prime took her away and forced his mind into hers, trapping her as a spectator in her own body. I picked up a couple of the many cushions from around the room and approached her, still being careful not to move too fast. I placed one of the cushions on the ground next to her before sliding down the wall and sitting on it. The other cushion stayed on my lap, just in case. I moved my arm ever-so-gently around her back until my hand rested on her opposite shoulder and squeezed lightly. Melog laid down next to her, communicating the safety Catra felt at my contact. 'It's okay.' I whispered again, quieter this time.

'It's not okay.' I barely heard her muffled voice, but now that I had my arm around her, I could feel that she was shaking, her breathing unsteady.

‘It will be okay. Swift Wind just didn’t understand-’

‘I don’t care about that!’ She yelled suddenly, cutting me off. ‘I just – I wanted that moment to be ours. Just ours. Now Scorpia knows, and I haven’t had chance to properly apologise to her yet. She didn’t even look me in the eye.’ Catra buried her face again, somehow curling in tighter against herself.

I looked out across the empty room for moment, considering what to say. ‘I haven’t had the chance to get to know Scorpia yet but… she seems really nice. I’m happy you had someone like that with you, you know, after I left.’ Catra’s ears twitched, she was listening. ‘I can’t imagine how alone you must have felt, and I promise I’ll make it up to you. Starting with interrogating Swift Wind – I’ll ask what he said to them, but I know he wouldn’t have gotten more than a sensation, or a feeling, so it can’t be that bad. It was… new, for me. So if he tuned in when I think he did… I can’t imagine what that would have been like for him. If it were me, I would want to talk to someone about it too, just to try and work out what it means. I can’t blame him for not coming to me either, Perfuma is probably the best person he could have found.’

Catra visibly relaxed. She lifted her head enough to spot the cushion in my lap, then looked me in the eye. There was unspoken question there, asking for permission. I could only just make her out in the dark, but I knew she would able to see me perfectly, so I nodded and smiled reassuringly. Catra then proceeded to lie down, resting her head on the pillow in my lap. Melog rested their head on her thigh, and Catra pet their head softly. Unable to resist, I joined in, letting my hand find its way to her hair and scratch just below her ear, eliciting a purr almost immediately.

‘Adora?’ Catra’s voice sounded uncertain, but not as emotional as before.

‘I’m here.’

‘What do I do if the people here never accept me?’

It was such a sad question, one laced with a deep-rooted worry of never being forgiven, never being offered the chance to redeem herself, never being allowed to live in peace.

'They will. They just need time to see that you're working on being better than who you used to be.' Catra shifted, adjusting her position, and pushed her head up into my hand. Accepting her request, I scratched a little harder. 'Catra? Talk to me.'

She let out a loud sigh and opened her eyes to look up at me. They shone in the darkness, and I found myself entranced. 'It's no different to the Horde out there.'

I frowned, thinking for a moment about how Bright Moon was nothing like the Horde at all. 'What do you mean?' I asked, requesting clarification.

'Everyone hates me. I don't know why I thought it would be different, but it isn't. Everyone was whispering about me… "It's *her,*" "why is *she* here," "devil-cat…" Blaming me for everything. I could hear all of them, every word they said. So many of the people out there came from places that I destroyed…' I heard a faint sob. When I moved my other hand to her face, I felt that her cheeks were wet. She had been crying silently while she spoke and I hadn't noticed because of the dark, or maybe that was why she was able to say all of this, because I couldn't see her. 'I can't do anything right,' she continued, voice more broken than before, 'I don't belong anywhere anymore… I just want to disappear…'

'You can't.' I stated clearly, fighting back tears of my own as I wiped Catra's away and continued to stroke through her hair and at the base of her ears. It hurt to hear her say these things, to see her like this, but she had been through so much and it had started catching up with her, destroying her from the inside. I couldn't lose her again.

'What?' Catra asked, quietly, looking up at me through tear-soaked eyes.

‘You can’t disappear. People will learn to accept you for who you are, you’ll see. I- I can’t lose you, Catra, not again… You have to stay – I need you.’

Catra looked up at me for a moment before closing her eyes. I felt her smile through my hand that remained on her face, cradling her cheek. Then, her ears perked up a little and she leant up, holding my face in her hands as she planted a soft kiss on my lips, whispering against them, ‘of course I’ll stay with you, dummy.’

Chapter End Notes

This chapter has been entirely rewritten and was updated on 13th April 2021.

A New Quest

Chapter Notes

> Hi there, it's the author from the future coming to give you some *information*.
> So, my writing got so much better over the course of writing this fic, that I started going back and rewriting older chapters. So far, I've only done chapters 1 & 2, but am intending to go back through chapters 3 to around 15 to embellish them and fix any issues.
> By all means, continue reading, but know that the writing does get better. I promise.

'Come on, Adora, you're going to be late for your *suuuper* important Princess tea club.' Catra giggled and she ran on ahead of me toward the Princess Alliance meeting room where everyone would no doubt already be waiting.

'It's not a tea club!' I shouted back defensively, 'It's a strategy meeting.' I ran after her, trying to grab her as she sped down the hallway, 'I think.'

'Yeah, sure, whatever you say,' she continued down the hallway, keeping out of reach, 'Though I don't believe you for a second.'

The last couple of days had flown by and I had spent most of them together with Catra. I had also managed to find Swift Wind and talk with him about what happened. He explained to me that he had sensed She-Ra appear and tried to *tune-in* to gauge what was happening in case I was in danger, but the sensations and emotional feedback he received were... not was he was expecting. Catra and I had appeared not long after he found Scorpia and Perfuma, catching all three of them off-guard during their discussion. Us being together was definitely not a secret after that, but no one seemed surprised – apparently everyone except me had picked up on it already.

We spent most of yesterday outside the city, flying around on Swift Wind. After I explained to her that it was his way of apologising, Catra seemed to warm to him and he seemed to become protective of her in turn, no doubt responding to the way I feel about her.

As we neared the meeting room, I realised that I had barely seen anything of Glimmer, Bow and the others since we got back. I had been so enchanted by the thought of spending time alone with Catra that it hadn't even occurred to me to see how the others were doing.

Catra managed to dodge my last attempt to catch her before she bounded through the open door into the meeting room, the murmur of voices stopped almost immediately. I followed her into the room and found her stood stock-still. I looked around the meeting table counter-clockwise, there was Scorpia, Perfuma, Frosta, Mermista, Sea Hawk, Bow, Glimmer, Micah, Castaspella, Spinnerella, Netossa, Entrapta, and unexpectedly... *Hordak*. Two empty chairs remained in-between Scorpia and Hordak. Catra was staring at him in stunned disbelief, 'Why is *he* here?' she growled, before moving forward and taking the seat next to Scorpia.

I heard Scorpia whisper, 'Hey there, Wildcat,' as I sat down in the chair between Catra and Hordak.

Catra deadpanned a 'Hey,' in response, not averting her gaze.

Entrapta rose out of her seat, but before she could speak Glimmer stood up and spoke first, '*Hordak* is here, for now, because he's volunteered to be *Entrapta's* lab partner. They will be heading off to Dryl to continue their research soon.'

Catra folded her arms, glaring daggers at Hordak, who simply sat still, neither moving nor speaking. 'Yeah, sure, whatever. As long as he stays *far* away from me.'

'I'm sure he will,' replied Glimmer. 'Now that that's out of the way... we have a few things to work through. I'll start with the

matter of the Horde ships.' Bow held up his pad and pressed a button, then a hologram of the planet appeared in the centre of the table, surrounded by small red blips. 'Thank you, Bow. We received reports from across Etheria over the last couple of days that the clones have vanished. We think it's safe to assume that they have teleported back to their ships. But the fact that they're still there is a concern. Do we have any ideas?'

Mermista raised her hand, 'Yeah, why don't we just get, like, She-Ra to blast them with that massive energy beam or whatever?'

Catra laughed, 'Oh yeah, I'm all for making them burn,' she said, closing one hand into a fist.

'I'm not going to do that! I don't even know if I *can* do that again.' I protested.

Catra turned to me, 'Why not? You saw what they did to me!'

'I saw what *Horde Prime* did to you.'

'That's the same thing!'

'But what if it's not? I... I destroyed Prime's mind. He's gone. Without him, the hive mind that connected all his clones may have vanished too. For all we know, we have thousands of Wrong Hordak's panicking in space and questioning the meaning of life right now.'

Entrapta rose out of her seat by her hair and climbed up onto the table, looking at the hologram from all angles, 'That's a GREAT theory! Just imagine it – all those lost souls with nowhere to go, just waiting for something, anything, to give their lives meaning again. Oh, the possibilities!' she beamed a crazed smile while staring at the hologram.

Hordak rose slowly, and when he spoke it was slow, careful, considered, 'Whatever you decide to do with them, it should be soon. I know what those ships are capable of, the destruction

even one can cause. If a ruthless, unknown, outside force were to get to them first, it could be catastrophic for Etheria.'

Everyone was stunned into silence by his contribution. Just the fact that Hordak, the former leader of the Horde that most of these people had been fighting for decades was stood here at the table was bizarre, but for him to offer advice?

Micah rose and addressed Hordak directly, 'You mean to say there's more out there who would wish harm to Etheria? To other worlds?'

'Without a doubt,' Hordak replied. 'Why do you suppose Horde Prime needed such an army? Just to take worlds? No. He had to both occupy *and* defend them. Some worlds welcomed him because of the promise of protection against the greater evils. However, if all of his forces have indeed retreated back to their ships, then thousands of worlds will now be reclaiming their independence. The force that surrounds us now is but a drop in the ocean of Horde Prime's true military might. Now that Etheria, a planet overflowing with pure magic, has reappeared in the wider universe, and defeated Horde Prime, it shines like a beacon. The darkness will come, in time, like a moth to a flame.'

Hordak, Entrapta and Micah returned to their seats, the weight of this information left the air heavy in the room, and no one spoke for a moment. I looked at Catra, her eyes were wide and her ears low, could she be scared? I noticed that Melog had appeared next to her and she was absentmindedly stroking behind their ear. I reached across to her and held out my hand; her ears twitched, and she looked at it before looking at me and smiling, gently accepting my hand in hers.

'Wow. Now that's... That's pretty terrifying, actually,' Scorpia laughed nervously, 'I'm definitely going to have nightmares for like a *whole* week now. At least.'

'Yes...' Micah agreed, 'It is definitely something that will require further discussion. We'll have to talk about this more, Glimmer.'

'If the safety of Etheria is still at risk then it should absolutely be a priority. For now though, we have to focus on rebuilding the damage we sustained from the Horde,' Glimmer cleared her throat before continuing, 'a few of you have already let me know what your plans are. Castaspella is going back to Mystacor, Frosta to the Kingdom of Snows, Mermista and Sea Hawk are returning to Salineas to lead the re-build –'

'And for a romantic *OCEAN ADVENTURE*!' Sea Hawk was suddenly stood, and planted one foot on the edge of the table.

Mermista groaned, 'Just sit down.'

Sea Hawk immediately sat down again and coughed, 'Please, Queen Glimmer, do continue.'

'Thank you, Sea Hawk.' She took a breath, 'Perfuma will be going back to Plumeria before continuing with Scorpia to the Fright Zone. All the Horde soldiers there are displaced and in disarray and will need some leadership,' she smiled at Scorpia, 'Scorpia is the descendant of those who once owned the land where the Fright Zone was built, so it's only right that she returns there as the rightful heir to the land and the Black Garnet.'

'Aw, shucks,' said Scorpia, 'I will absolutely do my best, there's a lot to do over there.'

'Spinnerella and Netossa,' continued Glimmer, 'Will be travelling to Elberon, Erelandia, and Thaymor to lend any help they can. And finally, me and my dad will be staying here in Bright Moon, I need to catch him up on all the changes he missed while he was... away.' She let out a sigh, 'I think that about covers everything. Adora, Catra, Bow and I have something to show you if you could stay behind.'

'Oooo, a secret mission? I want in!' Frosta jumped up out of her chair.

Bow stood up, flicking through information on his tracker pad, 'It's in the Crimson Waste, still want to go?'

Frosta turned to leave, 'No, that's okay. Keep your secrets.'

The rest of the Princess Alliance also stood to leave. I got up as well, letting go of Catra's hand, and thanked them all for their help, wishing them well on their new ventures. Catra remained seated.

'Look after my Wildcat for me, will ya?' said Scorpia as she gave me the biggest *crushing* hug I've ever received.

'Will do... she's in... good hands...' I managed to get out while gasping for breath.

'Ha, I don't doubt that for a second,' she replied, putting me down. She then put an arm around Perfuma and continued towards the exit.

Glimmer and Bow were still stood on the other side of the table, looking at Bow's tracker pad. As I began walking around to them, I felt a hand grab mine. Catra had gotten up and was quietly following me around the table, I smiled and squeezed her hand, interlocking our fingers.

'So, what's happening in the Crimson Waste? Has Huntara been in touch?' I asked.

Bow put his pad down on the table before tapping a series of buttons, another hologram appeared. It was a rough map of the Crimson Waste, but it was incomplete, a large portion of it seemed corrupted. 'There's been no word from Huntara. The data shows that this area has a large amount of atmospheric disturbance and no signals can get in or out.'

'This'll be a walk in the park. Last time I was there I conquered the whole place in a day,' Catra smirked.

I squeezed her hand again, 'That was actually pretty impressive, even if you did end up capturing me and almost ending reality right after.'

She let go of my hand and turned away, 'Whatever, shut up! It worked out in the end didn't it?'

'Yeah...' I replied, 'but I don't think you can take credit for that.'

'No, she can't.' Said Glimmer, a stern tone to her voice, 'It's my mother that gets the credit for that.'

Catra's ears lowered and she glanced at Glimmer, 'I... I really am sorry, Glimmer. I'll regret that for the rest of my life.'

'It's in the past now. Make it up to me by keeping Adora safe out there.' She gave Catra a reassuring smile, and Catra returned it. 'She may need it, as we have no idea what could be wrong. I'll teleport you around here,' she pointed to one edge of the anomaly, 'and you'll have to go the rest of the way on foot. I shouldn't get lost again. See if you can find Huntara too, she may have some more information on what's going on.'

'I'll be coming along to have a close-up look at this myself and analyse the readings,' said Bow, 'It's a shame we all can't go, otherwise it would be the new best-friend squad's first official quest!'

'Wait...' I mused, 'Wouldn't we be more of a... double-date squad?' I looked between the three unimpressed faces that were staring back at me. 'O-kay, never mind,' I said, laughing nervously.

'If you two want to wait outside, we'll be along in a sec. I'm just going to say goodbye to Bow,' said Glimmer, smiling at him.

Catra and I exited the meeting room with Melog following and closed the door behind us. Catra looked puzzled, 'Wait, why do we need to leave the room for them to say goodbye?'

I shrugged, 'Maybe they're doing this,' I gently held her head in my hands and pulled her towards me. Even though I initiated the kiss, I still felt the heat rise from my stomach to my chest as I felt her warm lips on mine, the song of her purring resonating within

me. She took my hands in hers and intertwined our fingers before pushing me back against the wall, a soft moan escaped from the back of my throat as she pinned my hands up either side of my head and pressed herself up against me. I could never get enough of this sensation. I never wanted it to end.

But end it did.

Catra jumped away just as the door opened, taken by surprise, as Glimmer and Bow exited the meeting room hand in hand. I quickly tried to gather myself, but I was still breathing hard and my face felt like it was on fire. 'Hey guys!' I chuckled nervously, glancing at Catra who had her back to us, hiding her face in Melog's side, 'Don't mind us, we're just standing here... In the corridor...'

'Out of breath? I didn't know standing was so tiring, you should have found a chair,' teased Glimmer, and it worked. An image of Catra straddling me on a chair and kissing me flashed into my mind, a soothing warmth briefly took over my body again for a second. I pushed down the thought – now was not the time. Glimmer laughed and took my hand, 'Ready to go?'

I felt Catra take my hand, her other hand resting on Melog's back. 'Yeah, we're ready,' I replied before we teleported away, leaving behind a quickly dissipating cloud of sparkles.

The Anomaly

'Well, I definitely don't *see* any anomaly, but my pad shows its somewhere in this direction,' said Bow, looking around and holding his tracker pad out in front of him as if it was a window through which he could see the secrets of Etheria.

Glimmer had teleported us here like she said she would before wishing us well, asking Bow to keep her updated, and swiftly teleporting back to Bright Moon to start her dad's reconditioning.

'Huh,' I said, looking around. 'I was kind of expecting it to, I don't know, *not* look like a wasteland anymore? When I released the magic from the Heart of Etheria, everything else turned green, but this place hasn't.'

'Hmm,' Bow considered for a moment, 'Maybe this place was too far gone already? It is a wasteland after all.'

'Yeah, maybe.'

'We had better get moving,' he said, walking in the direction he had held out the pad, 'I do not want to be here for too long.' Melog ran up and started walking alongside him and I began to follow.

'Adora, wait.' I turned to see Catra stood still, her tail wrapped round her legs and her ears low, 'I just... I want to apologise.'

I smiled and held out my hand to her, 'C'mon, we can't fall behind.' She accepted my hand in hers and we walked together a few paces behind, 'So, what's up?'

She took a moment to gather her thoughts, 'I've been a mess these past few days. I've had so many conflicting thoughts and emotions and I... I'm struggling to process it all.'

'You can take as long as you need,' I reply, 'I'll always be here to talk, if you need it. You've been through a lot. It'll will take time to

adjust.'

'Yeah... Thanks, Adora.'

'Anytime.'

She took a breath. 'There's one other thing.'

'Shoot.'

'Are we... good? As in... *us*.'

I frowned, 'I think so, why?'

'It's just...' She rubbed her forehead with her free hand, 'That kiss... in the corridor just now. That's the first time you kissed me since that whole thing with your magic horse a couple days ago. But when you did it, I realised how much I had been... how much I... and, I lost myself in it. In... you.' She looked away, hiding her face again.

I smiled, so that's why she pinned me to the wall. 'So what you're saying is, I should kiss you more?'

I felt her tense up as her grip on my hand tightened, 'What! No! Get over yourself...'

I laughed, 'So I shouldn't kiss you?'

'No I... Ugh! This isn't easy for me to talk about...'

'Catra, believe me, if I kissed you every time I wanted to we'd never get anything done.'

She looked at me then in a way that almost made my chest burst. Her face had turned bright red and she was biting her lower lip, her eyes pleaded with me. *I win*.

'You want me to kiss you right now?' I whispered.

She nodded, her lips parting in anticipation.

I felt a smug expression creep onto my face, 'I don't know... We did *just* kiss back in Bright Moon...' There was a huge part of me that would absolutely have kissed her right then and there but another part, the part that won, wanted to play the long game to see what she would do if I dragged this out.

She let out the breath that she had been holding, 'You're so not fair...'

I laughed, 'I'll make it up to you, I promise.'

'You better.'

**

We continued like that for a while longer, traversing the dry sun-scorched landscape and being careful to avoid the patches of quicksand that littered the valleys. After all, Glimmer wasn't there to teleport us out of them should we misstep and be pulled in. I shuddered as I remembered the time I dove into a pool of quicksand after Glimmer, only for her to teleport out and then have to rescue me. I pushed the thought down and looked out across the arid landscape that stretched on for miles in all directions. Something nagged at me, but I couldn't put my finger on it. 'It doesn't feel right...', I said to myself.

'Huh?' Catra asked, re-entering the world from her daydream.

'Nothing... or, I think it's nothing. Something just seems off about this place.'

Bow had stopped walking and must have heard me, because he replied once we had caught up to him, 'I *think* I may know what it is...' He squeaked, staring ahead.

I looked over his shoulder and whistled at the sight in front of us. Melog was stood sniffing what must have been a large, thriving cluster of cactuses that now looked deathly brown, sagging across the rough terrain and looking almost... *drained.* 'Well... that could mean anything, right? A few dead plants?' I reasoned, not

wanting to base any theories on one patch of dead foliage in an expansive wasteland.

'Uh, Adora?' I hadn't noticed Catra let go of my hand, but she was now stood a short distance away up a slope to the right, looking back at me. 'It's not just those, and it's not just the plants.'

I joined her on the slope and looked out across the landscape. She was right, every cactus looked the same as the cluster Bow had found, but there were also the dried remains of scary looking creatures of every size polka dotting the crimson expanse. 'How did we miss this?' I ask as Melog jumps up next to us and starts to investigate some of the smaller critters.

'It must be something to do with the anomaly,' said Bow, walking round in front of us and holding up his tracker pad for us to see, the screen crackling with some kind of interference but just managing to hold the image of the map. 'According to this, we're pretty far inside it. It must somehow be affecting what we can see? Like a mirage – I wonder if it's a side effect of whatever is going on here,' he mused, scratching his head.

Catra bobbed down as Melog returned to her, nuzzling into her side and making those chirruping sounds, 'Looks like none of us noticed, including Melog.' Catra's ears suddenly twitched and she stood bolt upright, Melog entering into a defensive stance in front her, glowing bright red and snarling, 'Something's coming,' she said, looking around frantically, 'There!'

My eyes followed the direction she was pointing, and sure enough a huge mass was hurtling towards us across the dunes, kicking up a small sandstorm in its wake. 'Stay back!' I shouted before jumping forward and running straight toward the massive creature, holding my open palm out above me. As She-Ra's sword appears in my hand I yell, 'For the honour of Grayskull!' The familiar bright light envelops me, and I feel myself becoming taller, stronger, faster as the new She-Ra form takes hold. I leap into the air with ease, aiming my sword right at the beast's head as I begin my descent – but it doesn't connect, instead my sword

is buried into the ground as a cloud of sand erupts around me. I cover my eyes as I wait for it to settle, regretting my impulsive decision to try pulling off a leap in the desert. As the cloud dissipates, I don't have to look far before I spot the toothy maw that had just been boring down on us. It had stopped moving just ahead of me and lay lifeless on the ground, its long body stretching off behind the dune ahead. I stood in front of it, stunned, watching as its body started to *deflate* in front of me.

'Adora!' I heard Catra shout before I heard Melog running up behind me, but I didn't look away. 'Adora! You have to stop jumping straight into... Whoa. What did you do?'

I looked toward her voice, she was sat up on Melog's back, staring at the corpse of the massive desert snake that lay dead at my feet. 'It wasn't me.'

'What? What do you mean it wasn't you?'

I looked down at it again as Catra slid down from Melog's back, 'I mean I didn't even touch it. It just... *died.'* Melog was now sniffing the creature, and Catra seemed to be listening. 'What's Melog saying?' I ask.

Catra stroked their glowing blue mane, 'They say that... the life force? Taken? Its life force has been forcibly taken.'

'Well that doesn't sound good,' I state, shrinking back down to my regular size before bending down to get a closer look at the monstrous creature. Each of its teeth were as long and sharp as daggers, its eyes the size of my fist, its scales a deep orange but with what appears to be a reflective sheen. I reach out and touch one curiously, gasping as it fell loose, landing upright in the sand. It shimmered as I picked it up and looked it over in my hand. It was about as wide as one of Entrapta's tiny cupcakes and had a good weight to it, the surface glossy and incredibly smooth to the touch.

'Hey! Adora! Get up here!' Catra had followed Melog up the crimson sand dune that the snake creature had surmounted before coming to a grisly halt. I pocketed the scale before climbing up after them, Bow following not far behind. 'Look over there.'

Bow held his hand up to try and block the sun from his eyes, 'It looks like –'

'A First One's ruin!' I beamed, spotting the familiar dark shape of a spire against the hue of its surroundings before looking at Catra excitedly. She gave me a soft smile in return, placing a hand on my cheek and gently bringing our foreheads together. I could feel her breath on my face, her warmth through her hand. She moved forward, closing her eyes, and her soft lips gently brushed against mine as she started *purring*. I could feel myself wanting to kiss her, I wanted to so badly, the longing for her lips on mine building up inside me the longer we stayed like this. I almost gave in. But then I remembered what I had said just after we arrived, *I'll make it up to you, I promise.* I felt a smirk encroaching on the edges of my mouth, because I knew what I had meant by that and I wanted to keep her waiting. I wanted to build up this feeling within her, within me, the feeling of *needing* the other. I placed a finger to her lips, and a shiver crawled up my spine as I heard a whimper of protest sound from deep within her. She opened her eyes, staring straight into mine, pleading with me. 'Not yet,' I whispered, running my fingers through her hair before cupping her head in my hand, 'I promised I'll make it up to you, and I will. But not yet.'

'Argh!' She growled, moving swiftly away from our embrace, 'You can't keep doing this to me, Adora!' Melog turned red and spiky behind her as she tried to calm herself down, taking deep breaths as they nudged her leg. She looked back up at me after Melog returned to their usual blue with a neutral expression, speaking in a flat voice, 'It's not fair.'

I chuckled at her sudden change in tone, 'It's not easy for my either,' I said moving toward her before grabbing her wrist and

pulling her close, my lips against her ear. 'I want you so much it *hurts*,' I whispered, dragging out the last word and smiling as I felt her physically shiver against me and saw her tail fritz up behind her; a quiet moan following, escaping from somewhere deep inside.

'If you two are quite done...' said Bow, bringing us back to reality.

I laughed as I saw Catra's bright red face before she turned around, flattening down the hair on her fritzed tail with one smooth motion. 'Sorry Bow, what you got?'

'Nothing on the pad, the data is still too garbled from all the interference. But have a look through these,' he said, handing me his binoculars.

Looking at the spire through the binoculars, it definitely resembled other First Ones temples that we had found, but this one seemed to spread out at the top forming a kind of funnel shape. Then I noticed what Bow was likely showing me. Not far from the spire there was a wispy thin plume of smoke trailing up into the sky, 'Smoke!' I exclaimed.

'Mmhmm,' hummed Bow in agreement.

'That must mean someone is there already.' I lowered the binoculars, handing them back to Bow. 'Could it be Huntara?'

'It's more than likely.' He agreed, scanning the horizon one last time with the binoculars, 'We've not seen her in a while. But if she has taken over this place again, she'd definitely be where the trouble is.'

'Okay, let's get to it.' I looked over at Catra, who was bobbed down looking off into the distance, making trails with her index finger in the sand. 'Hey, Catra? You good to go?'

She took a deep breath before standing up and looking me dead in the eye with a determined stare, 'Let's get this over with. You owe me, princess.' She said, prodding me in the chest before

starting to trudge off toward the spire, kicking sand as she went. Melog and Bow not far behind.

I felt a smirk encroach on my face and chuckled before making my way down the slope after them. A yell almost escaped me as I tripped over my own feet, flapping my arms to steadily myself. Melog looked back briefly but quickly moved on – Catra and Bow hadn't noticed. I breathed a sigh of relief before making my way after them, being extra careful not to fall over anything else.

By the Light of the Campfire

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

'So you just thought it would be a great idea to wander into the Crimson Waste with no gear, no food, no water? I swear, I don't know *how* you've survived this long. If everything here weren't already dead, this place would have chewed you up and spat you out long ago.'

I listened to Huntara's lecture while guzzling mouthfuls of water between stuffing my face with delicious mystery meat she had given us. It was much later now and the Wastes and grown dark. We had immensely underestimated just how far the spire was, and when I first caught the whiff of cooking meat I had actually started crying. Now Bow, Catra and I were sat on rocks around a campfire ravenously digging into the meat that Huntara's gang were roasting over a larger fire a short distance away. I didn't care what kind of freaky desert creature the meat was from and judging by its taste I didn't want to know, but right then and there and I could have eaten anything. I looked over as Catra flung a spare chunk of her food at Melog, who caught it and gulped it down in one.

Once the lecture was over, Huntara sat down opposite us and held a lizard on a stick over the fire. 'So,' she began, slowly spinning the lizard, 'All that aside, I'm guessing you're here for this thing.' She jabbed a thumb over her shoulder toward the spire behind her. Now that I could see it up close it really was impressive, and far taller than it had looked through the binoculars when I first saw it, the glowing blue markings on its exterior singling it out against the dark sky. It was unmistakably a First Ones temple, and I had seen enough of them by now to know that this one was definitely active.

Bow answered first, 'We think so, we had no idea what we were looking for when we first arrived. The only clue was a large area of the Crimson Waste that had been hidden by some kind of interference on our maps.'

Huntara sighed and observed us solemnly, 'I'm not even going to go into how stupid it was to come here, not only without supplies, but without knowing where you were going either. You kids must have one hell of a death wish.'

I finished my food and washed it down with the last of the water in my flask, 'I have a question,' I began, holding my hand in the air. 'Did you happen to notice any magic returning to the Wastes sometime in the last few days? I kind of released the magic from the Heart of Etheria and while it's helped the rest of the planet thrive this place... seems deader than ever.'

She looked at me quizzically for a second, then scoffed, 'Nope.'

'What? Nothing? Nothing at all?'

'So this place wasn't affected by She-Ra unleashing thousands of years of built up magic *at all?* ' Asked Bow, he had also finished eating now and was eagerly listening to the conversation.

Huntara took a bite out of the small lizard creature, spitting out a couple of small bones, 'Well... now that I think about it... the sky *was* filled with a kind of sparkly... glow? That was just before all those pointy eared Horde doppelgängers up and vanished. But that didn't last long.'

I frowned, 'What happened to it? Where'd it go?'

'Hmm... That's actually why we're here at this thing. One of my people said they saw it rise out of the ground on its own. Then they saw the top open up, as it is now, and it sucked up what I guess was your magic.' She started using one of the more angular bones to pick at her teeth. 'We've been digging ever since, trying to find a way in and scavenge for loot.'

'Great, so the temples can suck magic out of the sky now.' Catra groaned, rolling her eyes.

'I've been wondering this for a while, but why are you even here, *Kitten?* You left everything in quite the mess after your last visit. Got quite the stomach on you to show your face around here again.'

Catra burst into laughter, 'A mess? If anything I tidied this place up. Unified it under one banner. That's something you could never do on your own.'

Huntara stood up, towering over the fire, and throwing down her now burnt lizard, 'Maybe it didn't need unifying. There's a way of doing things, of operating out here, and you messed it all up!'

Catra sprung to her feet baring teeth and claws, followed quickly by a growling Melog who lit up the surrounding area in red light, 'If you've got a problem with me, I'll take you on right here!'

'I'd like to see you try, *kitty cat*!'

Just as Catra was about to pounce I jumped forwards and grabbed her by the waist, holding her back, 'Catra! No! She's on our side!'

'Adora! Let go! She's asking for it!

I moved in front of her, blocking her path, 'Let it go, Catra! She's one of us!'

'Get out of the way!' She moved to try and get past me, but I was faster. I caught her head in my hands and brought her face to mine, planting my lips on hers. She stopped immediately, a surprised moan sounding in her throat as her eyes went wide and stared into mine. Steadily I felt her relax, her claws retracted and Melog turned back to their neutral blue colour. Then she closed her eyes, and another, softer moan sounded within her as she kissed me back, steadily pressing herself against me and wrapping her arms around me, her hands on my shoulder blades keeping

me close. I must have lost myself as she returned the kiss because suddenly our lips were parted, and our tongues had found one another. In that moment I forgot about everything else, completely losing myself in Catra, her lips, her tongue, her warmth, and the warmth that she caused to rise up within me.

Bow coughed. 'Um, guys?'

I broke from the kiss, watching as Catra tried to follow my lips and catch them again. She still wanted more. I felt myself blush before smugly grinning at Bow, 'Hey, what's up?' I asked before laughing awkwardly, my hands travelling down to rest on Catra's waist.

Catra laughed and buried her face in my shoulder, 'You're such an idiot.'

'Wow,' I heard from behind me, 'Now that... I was not expecting.' Huntara had sat back down again, an expression somewhere between surprise and bewilderment plastered all over her face. 'Seems like not that long ago you two were at each other's throats trying to off one another and now you're... *in* each other's throats. How'd that happen?'

I laughed as I steered Catra back to the rocks we had been sat on. I sat on down on my rock first before scooching back slightly, and guiding Catra to sit between my legs, which she reluctantly did. I smiled and wrapped my arms around her from behind, holding her close and burying my face in the back of her neck before softly planting one kiss after another just below her hairline.

'Well...' answered Bow, 'It's been a long time coming, actually. Glimmer and I were pretty convinced there was something there after we rescued Catra from Horde Prime's flagship.'

A contented purr had started to sound within Catra, and she leant her head back against my shoulder and closed her eyes. She

gasped quietly as I started kissing around her ear, and I noticed her fangs pressing against her lower lip.

'Huh. The flagship? You went up there, in Space?'

'Yeah...' continued Bow. 'It was a whole thing; we were gone for a while and when we got back most of our friends had been chipped and were being controlled by Horde Prime.'

Catra's hands moved to rest on my thighs either side of her, and I felt her claws start to dig in and her breathing become more ragged as I started kissing down her neck.

'Yeah I know the feeling,' said Huntara, rubbing the back of her neck where the chip had been. 'Uh, well... I had asked one of my guys to set you up with three tents for you to rest in after your journey while we carried on digging through the night while it's colder, but by the looks of *them* I guess you'll only be needing two.'

Suddenly Catra sat bolt upright and jabbed me just below my ribs with her elbow, 'Adora!'

'OW!' I laughed before squeezing my arms around her tighter as she tried to escape.

'Adora! Let me go!'

'Never!'

I heard Bow audibly sigh, 'I should have seen this coming, although I'm sure that Glimmer will love hearing all about this.'

**

After a while, Huntara got sick of watching me relentlessly tease Catra, shooing us off in the direction of the tents to get some sleep while she re-joined the dig. We found the tents without much difficulty, set up a short distance away from the rest of the makeshift camp that Huntara's gang had been temporarily living

out of while they dug up the First Ones ruin seeking treasure. They were much smaller than I had been expecting, with just enough room for two regular sized people to lay down side-by-side, or one Huntara. The walls of the tents seemed to be made of some old, stitched together sun-bleached leather, and as Huntara had said there were three here arranged in a rough semi-circle.

'We really should get some rest,' said Bow, heading to the tent on the left, 'Who knows what we'll find when they finish digging up that ruin.

'Whatever it is it can't be good; I've never heard of anything sucking up magic from the air before.' I replied, looking back at the partially illuminated spire behind us.

Bow yawned, 'Well as far as I'm concerned, that's a problem for future Bow. I'm going to *try* to get some sleep now. Please don't be loud,' he said while disappearing inside the tent.

'We won't!' I called as his tent door flapped shut, then I looked at Catra, putting my hand on her shoulder before whispering, 'What do you say we get comfy and I make good on my promise?'

She had been quiet for a while, stood with her arms crossed frowning at the floor, 'Just... choose a tent, Adora! I'll sleep in the other one...'

I smirked, 'Okay. Alright,' I said, opening the door of the tent on the right, 'It's your loss though.'

Catra moved up, silently entering the middle tent. I smiled to myself before entering my tent. There was enough room inside to stand, which I was thankful for, and I took my belt, jacket and boots off before letting down my hair. I quickly stuck my head out the entrance to my tent, watching as Melog curled up outside of Catra's.

'Goodnight, Catra,' I sang towards her tent. I heard a muffled "whatever" in response. I couldn't stop smiling to myself. Catra

was conflicted. On one hand, she wanted to get back at me for teasing her all day, but on the other... I laid down on the floor of the tent, closing my eyes with my hands behind my head. There was no duvet, mattress or anything soft for that matter, but I had slept exclusively on hard surfaces in the Horde for most of my life so this was nothing new. I wondered if what I was thinking was right, that Catra would give in and come over to my tent. I had picked the one farthest from Bow on purpose, but I wondered if she noticed. As if on cue, I heard a frustrated shout followed by the flapping of a tent door. I beamed a dorky grin while leaning up onto my elbows just as Catra burst into my tent. She looked *mad*.

'Not. A. Word,' she growled.

'I mean, I didn't – I didn't say anything.' I could feel that I was still grinning. *I win*.

Catra started moving towards me, 'I mean it, Adora.' She positioned herself over me, her feet either side of my waist, and looked down at me, 'If you so much as utter another word, I'm leaving.' I flattened myself onto my back and looked up at her. I could barely see in the darkness, the only light was a faint blue-orange glow seeping through the entrance of the tent, a combination of the glow from the various fires around the camp and the spire that stretched into the sky.

As I stared at her eyes, glowing in the shadows, it occurred to me that Catra could see just fine in this light, so I didn't take any chances. I held my tongue, instead biting my lower lip, playing along with her as she slowly lowered herself on top of me. I felt her warmth course through me as she finally straddled my waist, and a shiver sped up my spine. Then her hands grabbed my wrists and held them either side of my head, and suddenly her face was inches away and I could feel her breath on me, her eyes glaring into mine. 'You've been teasing me all day. Screw your promise, Princess. I'm taking what I'm owed,' she whispered, leaning down to my ear and nibbling it gently, 'And you're going to lay here, be quiet, and take responsibility.' A whimper escaped

from deep in my throat as her words caused an ache of yearning to flare within me. Catra moved back so she was looking into my eyes, a fierce blaze raging behind them, 'Do we have an understanding?' I kept my mouth shut, not daring to make a sound, and nodded quickly.

She licked her lips and smiled, 'Good.'



Chapter End Notes

Illustration by @apples_dashie on Instagram and Twitter!

HmmHmHm

'Rise and shine, Cupcakes!'

Huntara's nearby shouting forcibly roused me from my dream and I immediately forgot what it was about, feeling a twinge of loss shoot through me as I desperately tried to hold on to it. I felt like I could have slept for hours more, but the light and the breeze that filtered in through the entrance of the tent carried the warmth of the morning sun with them. I took a deep breath, struggling to fill my lungs all the way, and then I saw why. Catra was laying half-on me, her right arm across my chest and her right leg in-between both of mine, her head cocooned between my shoulder and my neck. She was purring gently, far gone in a deep sleep. I soon realised that I couldn't feel or move my right arm at all, which told me we must have been laid like this all night. With my left hand, I gently ran my fingers along the short, but extremely soft fur on Catra's arm, tracing the darker patches with my index finger. We were both in our underwear, Catra's was much more military looking than mine, almost identical to our old Horde-standard shorts and sports bras, whereas I wore much comfier shorts that I had found once and stocked up on from a stall in Bright Moon's market as well as a sports bra that wasn't too dissimilar to Catra's.

Had I not pointed out to Catra last night that there was, in fact, no way to actually seal the entrance to our tent and Melog on guard wasn't enough we would have absolutely woken up naked. A small detail that I was pleased about because, just as I was starting to feel Catra join the waking world from me stroking her arm, Huntara leant into our tent, two pans in hand, and started clanging them together as hard as she could. The sound was deafening and caused Catra to immediately leap into a defensive stance above me, hissing with teeth and claws bared before getting overwhelmed by the noise and flattening her ears to her head.

Huntara burst into a raucous laughter, finding her little stunt incredibly funny, 'Come on, sleepy heads, we think we've found the entrance to that thing, your friend Bow's already there.' Then she left, her laughter steadily getting quieter as she moved further away.

'Aww, were you protecting me?' I beamed a dorky grin at Catra as she stood over me, wiping the sleep from her eyes.

'What! No! I - Shut up!'

I laughed and held out my left hand to her, 'Help me up, my other arm's dead.'

'Dead? What happened to it?' She grasped my hand and pulled me up, and I started rubbing some life back into my floppy arm.

'I think you were sleeping on it all night, it's okay though, you looked super comfy and adorable, so I forgive you for partially paralysing me.' I cupped her face with my working hand and kissed her softly on the lips.

As I pulled away to find my clothes, still willing my right arm back to life and feeling the first tingling sensation run down it as my circulation returned. I noticed that Catra's stunned expression at the sudden show of affection didn't last long, her smile forming a fiendish grin. 'Is that all? I thought it might have been a lasting effect.' Images from the night before suddenly flashed through my mind, stopping me from concentrating on what I was doing. Then I felt one of Catra's nails slowly trailing up my back, and heard her voice by my ear, 'Because as I remember it, Princess, you couldn't move for a *looong* time.'

'Mmm,' I hummed contentedly, as more vivid imagery and sensations flooded my senses. 'Catra... we have to get ready or Huntara will –'

Suddenly she cupped my face with her hand, her thumb on one cheek and her fingers on the other, before spinning me round so I

was looking directly into her eyes, 'And who gave you permission to speak, Adora?'

I snorted a laugh before giving in, wrapping my arms around her and pulling her close, my heart fluttering as our lips touched once again.

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Huntara looked over at us as we descended into the hole they had dug around the base of the spire. Its circumference was a good distance from the spire itself, and the walls weren't too steep. The inclusion of a makeshift scrap metal and bone ladder made it much easier to get down, however. Catra and I both using it in turn. Melog was able to effortlessly jump down without assistance, of course.

'Took you long enough.' Huntara began, 'What, have you forgotten how to get up and get dressed quickly? I know you're both ex-Horde, so unless you liked getting an earful you must have been fast at some point.'

'Hmm Hmm Hmm,' I nodded and hummed my agreement.

Catra looked at me, puzzled. 'Uh, yeah we uh... were just getting dressed. Although using pans is new, and loud. And I thought wake up calls in the Horde were bad...'

'Ha! Where do you think I got my inspiration?'

Bow was stood next the unearthed entrance to the spire, trying to scan it with his tracker pad but having little luck. Melog had walked over to look at the door while Catra and Huntara spoke, and Bow looked over to us when he noticed them. 'Adora!' He called, walking over to join us, 'Do you think you can open it?'

'Hmmm,' I walked to the door and looked it over, this one didn't say "Eternia" like some of the others, instead it said... "sanctuary"? I stuck a thumbs up toward the group. Catra was eyeing me suspiciously, and I tried not to break into a wild grin. If

she hadn't noticed what I was doing yet, she was certainly about to. I took a step back from the door and tried to say "sanctuary" without opening my mouth, but what I actually sounded like was, 'HmmHmHmmHm!' I burst out laughing and fell to the floor, clutching my stomach.

'Ugh...' Catra hid her face behind her hand, which only made me laugh harder, 'Adora! Give it a rest already!'

'Hmm?' I looked over at her with a questioning look on my face.

She growled and walked over to me before kneeling and looking down at me. I looked up at her, returning her gaze. 'You can speak, Adora.'

I sat up and whispered, 'Do you give me permission?'

Catra blushed and whispered back, 'Yes, dummy. Now get on with it!'

'Hmm. Thank you, my love.' I said, pecking her on the cheek before standing up. I knew for a fact it was the first time I've called her that and couldn't help but smile when I saw she was still knelt down, frozen in shock, her tail all fritzed behind her.

'What the heck was that all about?' Huntara directed the question at Bow, but he just held his hands out and shrugged, none the wiser.

I smiled the most devious of smiles. 'Oh sorry about that guys. Catra just had to give me permission to speak again...'

'WHAT! No! Adora!'

'HA!' Huntara started laughing at the top of her voice, 'Permission! I like the sound of that, Kitten, I'll have to try that myself.'

Bow had his head in his hands, 'Why me?'

Catra groaned before standing up and shooting me a death glare, which was less impactful than I assume she hoped it would be with her face as red as the sandstone around us. I mouthed "I love you" toward her, and her expression softened for the briefest of moments before she huffed and turned away. Knowing that I could get through her defences even a little just by mouthing words was enough for me though, and I moved to stand in front of the spire's entrance once again.

I took a moment to breathe and calm myself, before speaking the First One's password written on the door as clear as I could, 'Sanctuary!'

I couldn't help but gasp as the floor before me became a ramp leading down into the ruin, stepping forward to get a better look inside when it had finished rising. The basic interior looked like that of all the First Ones ruins I had been to before – all featuring blue and purple, all being made out of chiselled stone and metal, and all with those blue lines that pulsed with energy – with one distinct difference. It was overgrown with magical plants, the likes of which I hadn't seen until Madame Razz first took me to the deepest part of the Whispering Woods. The blue light from the patterns on the walls was almost lost in the light of all the glowing plants that lined the edges of the corridor, as well as the light from the magic that lingered in the air. Some of the wisps escaped from the corridor, floating up and around us as we stood gawking at this unexpected discovery.

'Well that's... new,' said Bow, stepping forward and standing to my right. 'Not only was the password *not* "Etheria" for once, but the inside looks like the Whispering Woods.'

'Yeah, I think we know where all the magic went that this place... collected. But why?'

Catra moved to my left and took a look down the ramp before us, 'I've got a weird feeling about this.' Melog nudged into her leg and she listened as they chirruped at her.

I looked at Catra expectantly, meeting her eyes, 'Oh, uh... they say that while it does look pretty, it feels sinister. Reminds them of some beautiful flower that used to bloom on Krytis that was actually carnivorous.'

Bow sighed, 'Well that's put a downer on the pretty magical corridor. Now it's the pretty magical corridor that's going to *eat* us.'

'Well...' I said, taking the first step down the ramp, 'Weirder things have happened.'

Catra followed me down the ramp first, followed by Bow who was fiddling with his tracker pad again. As we got to the bottom of the ramp, I realised that Huntara and Melog weren't with us. Looking back, they were still at the top of the ramp, looking unsure. 'Are you coming?' I asked, but just as Huntara was about to respond the entrance sealed itself, followed by a distinct *clunk* of a lock engaging.

'Uh... what just happened?' Bow asked, looking up toward where the ramp was.

Catra sighed, 'Oh great... Melog was right, this place is bad news.'

I stepped forward, 'No it should be alright, right?' I cleared my throat, 'Sanctuary!'

Nothing happened.

I continued, 'Eternia!... She-Ra!... Mara!... Serenia!... Uh, cape?'

'Adora, stop just shouting random words!' said Catra, laughing.

'She's got a point,' Bow agreed, 'That has never worked in the past.'

I shrugged, 'I guess we go on then. I'm sure it's fine. It'll be fine. Being locked in is fine. First Ones temples like to start collapsing

when their entrances lock, but that won't happen again.' I said while laughing nervously.

'We'll be okay,' Catra reassured me, holding my hand and interlacing our fingers, 'Because we're all together.' She caught Bow grinning at her, 'Or, y'know, whatever...'

'Just as a precaution,' Bow began, 'Here's some earpieces in case we get separated. If the temple can lock its own front door who knows what else it might pull.'

'Good idea,' I said, taking one and passing the other to Catra before putting mine in my ear.

Walking down the corridor steadily become more difficult the further we travelled, the mass of magical foliage growing thicker step by step. I had also noticed that the glow from the plants all around us grew brighter as we passed by them, the wisps flying around us as if dancing with giddy excitement. Bow suddenly stopped walking and stared down at his tracker pad as I heard a familiar voice sound from it, steadily becoming less distorted.

'Bow!?'

'Glimmer!' Bow shouted before hugging the device to his chest.

'Bow! It's so good to see you, I've been trying to reach you all morning!'

'The signal must be getting stronger the further into the temple we travel. Glimmer, I've got so much to catch you up on that you wouldn't believe - but could you *please* tell Adora and Catra to stop teasing each other for five minutes? It was adorable at first, I'll grant them that, but now I'm just uncomfortable.' He spun the tracker pad round to face us and Glimmer burst into a grin.

She waved wildly, 'Hi, Adora! Hi, Horde Scum.'

'Hi, Glimmer!'

'Hey, Sparkles.'

'Aaah! You're holding hands!'

I smirked, 'That's not all we've been doing.'

'Adora!' Catra let go of my hand and walked over to a wall, leaning her back against it and looking down the corridor, hiding her face.

Glimmer squealed, 'Adora,' all of a sudden, she changed tone and spoke more calmly, sort of reminding me of the way her mother spoke, 'As Queen, I formally request that upon your return to Bright Moon we convene for a private meeting where you will tell. Me. EVERYTHING!'

I bowed deeply, 'A-yes, your Majesty.'

Bow turned the pad back around, 'Glimmer! Don't encourage them! I've already seen too much!'

'Aww, let them have their fun, Bow.'

He sighed, 'Fine.'

Without warning I heard an abrupt yell from behind me and just managed to catch sight of Catra as she disappeared into the wall she had been leaning against, the edges of her form framed by a golden light. 'Catra!' I yelled, immediately running towards what I recognised as an illusionary wall like those we encountered on Krytis. I heard Bow shout something behind me, but I didn't stop to think or listen before throwing myself through it after her.

Focus

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

'For the honour of Grayskull!'

I shouted the words quickly as I realised I was falling into darkness as a result of leaping through the wall after Catra, feeling the light and strength of She-Ra envelop me. I had hoped I could catch her, hold on to her, pull her back through. But I was too late and now I had no idea where she was. I couldn't see her anywhere. I couldn't see anything around me at all. Everything was pitch black and I felt wind rushing against me as I seemed to be falling forever. I brought my arms up to shield my face, expecting to hit solid ground at any moment. But no ground came, nothing except the feeling of falling, the feeling of the wind making my hair flap around violently behind me, the thunderous sound of it filling my ears.

'...dora?'

I heard something. Something faint through the deafening sound of the wind.

'...Adora?'

There it was again, slightly louder. Someone was saying my name, but I couldn't tell where from. The darkness seemed to stretch on forever.

'Adora!'

Catra! It was Catra's voice! I could hear her clearly now. Where was she? I frantically looked around, trying to see where her voice was coming from.

'ADORA! Snap out of it!'

I suddenly felt hands on me, shaking my shoulders and my eyes snapped open. I immediately jumped up, breathing heavily and looking around - Catra! She was here! I wrapped my arms around her and held her close to me as I tried to control my breathing.

'Adora! What's wrong? Calm down! Haaaaaa- can't breathe! Breath! Need air!'

I relaxed my arms and Catra filled her lungs once again. 'Sorry... I... I don't...' I tried to get the words out but couldn't.

'It's okay, we're okay.'

I took a deep breath, resting my forehead against hers, 'What happened?'

I felt her hand reach up and gently rub my cheek, 'I found you here – you looked asleep, but you were writhing around like you were having a nightmare.'

'What do you mean you found me here?'

'Exactly that, Dummy. I've been wandering around this place for a while, but I think it's leading me in circles. I've definitely passed by this area before, but you weren't here then.'

'You've been here a while? It felt like I only just arrived.'

It was only then that I stood to my full height and looked around. It looked exactly like the Whispering Woods; tall, winding trees stretched upwards towards the canopy, all kinds of plants and mushrooms glowing with magic densely populated the soft, damp ground, and the light of golden wisps danced between the trees. I even caught sight of a few other magical creatures darting between the undergrowth. 'Is this a memory? Or another illusion?'

Catra buried her face in my chest and wrapped her arms around me. I looked down at her, in this form she only stood as high as my shoulders and I smiled at the reminder of just how small she

was. Small, but fierce, strong, fast, and brave beyond belief. 'Hey,' I asked, running a hand through her hair, 'Are you okay?'

She squeezed me gently, 'I am now. I'm glad you're here. I thought I was on my own. I can't believe you followed me through that wall, you're *such* an idiot.' She chuckled.

'Yeah, I know.' I wrapped my arms around her, 'And now that I've got you, I'm not letting you out of my sight.'

'I can live with that.'

Not long after that, having stayed in that position in each other's arms for a short while, it occurred to me that we should both still be wearing the earpieces that Bow had given us as we entered the temple. 'Oh! Catra, have you heard anything from Bow? Did he follow me?'

'Hmm. No, I tried to contact you and Bow when I first fell in here through that wall, but I didn't get any responses. That's when I started walking. In *circles,* apparently.'

'So you just fell over? There was no endless void?'

'What are you talking about? I just fell through that rude wall. Then when I opened my eyes, I was in the middle of what I thought was the Whispering Woods. I can't find the wall I fell through anywhere.'

'Did you just call a *wall* rude?'

'If I ever lean against you and you let me fall, I'll call you rude too.'

**

Subterranean magical forests are not my specialty, but this one could definitely take top spot. It was completely undisturbed, untouched, and overflowing with magical energy. Once again, the plants and wisps seemed to be brighter and dancing around us as

we picked our path through the woodland. I heard something to my right and stopped to look - a curious four-legged, three tailed green creature stared at me with three eyes through the undergrowth, before skipping away as I noticed it.

'Are you going to stay as She-Ra the whole time we're here?' Catra asked, a little further ahead now.

'Yeah,' I said, glancing back, 'We don't know what...'

As I looked at her I realised something - something that would never have occurred to me if I wasn't stood far enough away from Catra to see it. The patch of forest where I was stood looked dark compared to the luminosity that surrounded Catra, the wisps dancing around her as if she were a bonfire and this was the biggest party they had ever been to. I felt my pulse quicken as I saw her, surrounded by the magical light. She looked beautiful, the glow highlighting different areas of her body as the wisps twirled about her form. Catra looked back, and caught my gaze, her eyes shining like stars. Then she smiled, and it sent shockwaves through my heart.

'What's wrong? Cat got your tongue?' She laughed, 'You look like you've seen a ghost.'

I stumbled over my words as I tried to speak, 'I... Uh... You... You're beautiful... No, I meant to say - well, you are, but, uh - look around you!'

She blushed, looking around her, 'What's wrong? These things have been around me the whole time.' As she held her hand out, a group of wisps settled in her palm, one after another.

'Yeah, but, look at me! I'm She-Ra and they're ignoring me.'

Catra chuckled, 'What, are you jealous? These little light things like *me* more than *you,* Adora. What a shame.'

I sighed, 'No, Catra, I'm saying there must be a reason. Right?'

'Oh, so you're saying there has to be a reason why I'm getting more attention than you in a magical forest?'

'Well... Yeah?'

She considered for a second, 'You may have a point. If there is one, I am *not* looking forward to finding out what it is.'

I smirked, 'Unless everything in here really does just find you as attractive as I do.'

'I am not cute!'

'I didn't say you were cute. You did.'

'No I didn't!'

'Well, you must have been thinking it, because that's not what I said.' The wisps in Catra's hand flew out erratically as she covered her face and I couldn't help but laugh, 'You almost crushed your little light things!'

She groaned, 'I just want this place to stop leading me in circles and show me a way out!'

A light suddenly shone through the trees ahead of Catra, I could feel the amusement on my face and made no effort to hide it. 'Catra, you just asked the forest to show you the way out - and it did!' I moved over to her, finding her annoyed expression priceless.

'Whatever, let's just go look.'

We made our way through more undergrowth and dense glowing foliage, eventually coming across a patch of ground that was apparently untouched by the magical forest that surrounded it. It was purple, with glowing angular blue lines threading through it at sharp angles, unmistakeably part of the First One's temple we were in. It was a stark contrast to our surroundings, so much so that I had almost forgotten we were in a temple and not the

Whispering Woods. The glow from the blue lines was at its brightest in the centre of the clearing, where a circle was very clearly etched into the ground, all the blue lines leading into it. As we stepped off the soft ground of the forest and on to the hard stone of the temple floor, the circle in the centre started to slowly rise out of the ground. The column stopped moving when it rose to around Catra's shoulder height, and we exchanged a cautious glance before moving towards it.

'What is it?' Catra asked, walking around it.

I bobbed down to get a better look, 'I don't know, but there's a word on this side.'

'What does it say?'

'Uh... Focus.'

'What's that supposed to mean?'

'No idea, maybe it's a password, like for the doors?'

'Try saying it clearer.'

I stood up to my full height and cleared my throat, 'Focus!'

Nothing happened.

I looked at Catra, noticing the blue lines glowing slightly brighter under her feet as she moved around, 'You say it.'

'What? Why?'

'Just try it.'

She shook her head, 'Oh, no, I do not want anything else magical happening to me.'

'Why not?'

'Because you're the magical one. *You're* the one who talks to forests, *you're* the one who can open doors with words, *you're* the one who's friends with everybody, who everyone likes being around, and *you're* the one that was chosen to be Etheria's hero. You're the one that's special, Adora, and that's just not who I am... It never will be.' She held her arms close to her chest, looking at the ground.

I put my hand on her shoulder, shrinking back down to regular Adora size, 'You're special to me.' She looked at me, and I gazed into those eyes I loved so much, 'Have I ever told you how much I love your eyes?' I said, moving my hand from her shoulder to rest on her cheek.

A small smile crept onto her face, 'Whatever, Dummy, I'll say the stupid word.' I stepped back as Catra moved to stand in front of the First Ones writing on the pillar, 'But what do we do if this doesn't work?'

'Then we'll look for another way out, but I've got a feeling it'll be fine.'

Catra took a deep breath, before speaking clear and calm. 'Focus.'

Nothing happened.

'See, Adora! You were wrong, it's not... Oh no.'

The writing split in two, and both halves of a small door slowly slid around the back of the pillar.

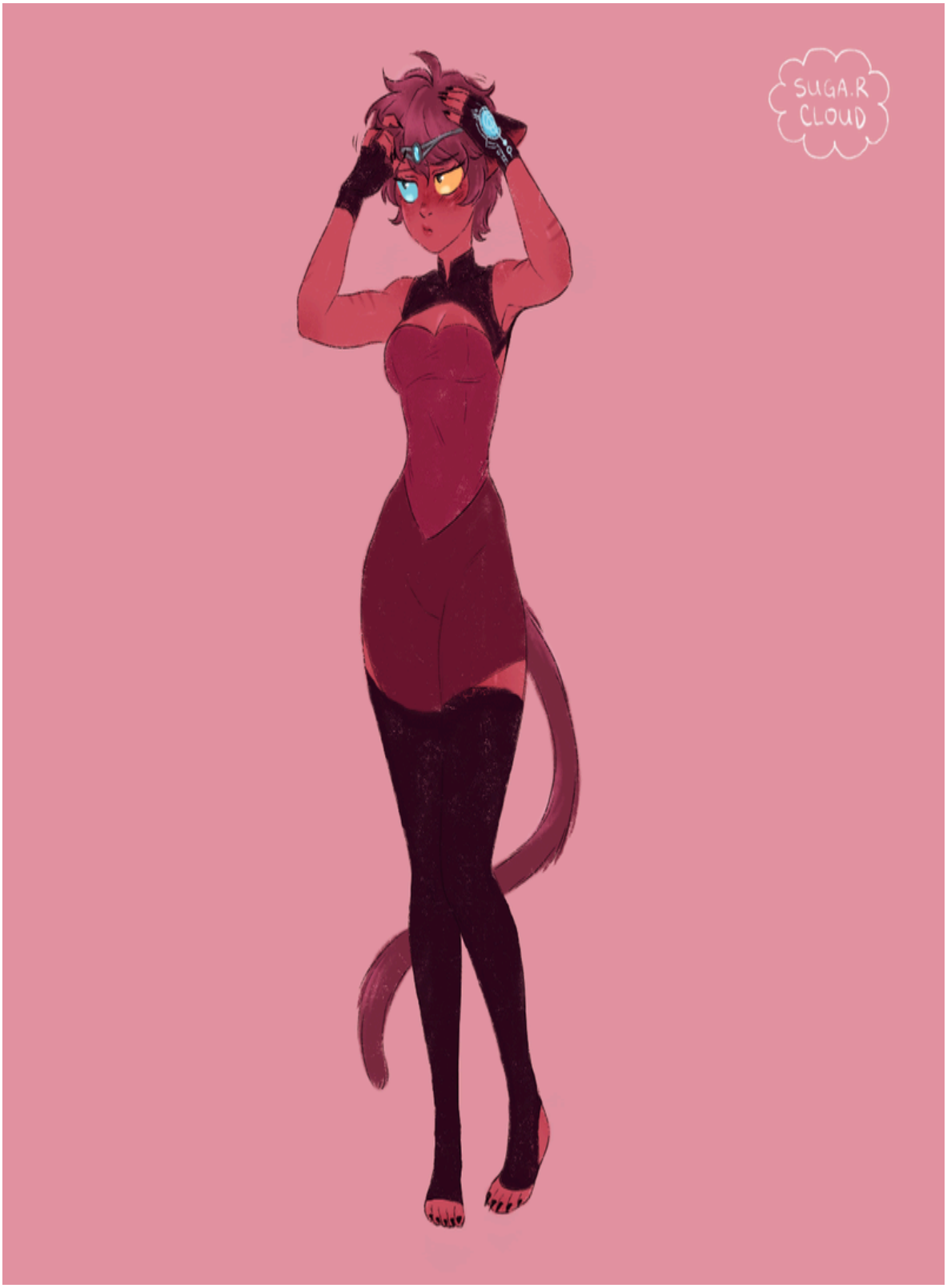
I grinned, 'What was that? It's *not* working? Oh, I guess we'll go then.' Catra wasn't listening, instead she was staring inside the pillar. I looked over her shoulder, 'What is it?'

'It looks like... gloves? And a *tiara*.' She said the word "tiara" like she was allergic to it. 'Well go on, Adora. Try them on.'

'Oh, absolutely not.' I said, shaking my head and wagging my finger, 'You opened the thing, you have to put them on.' She

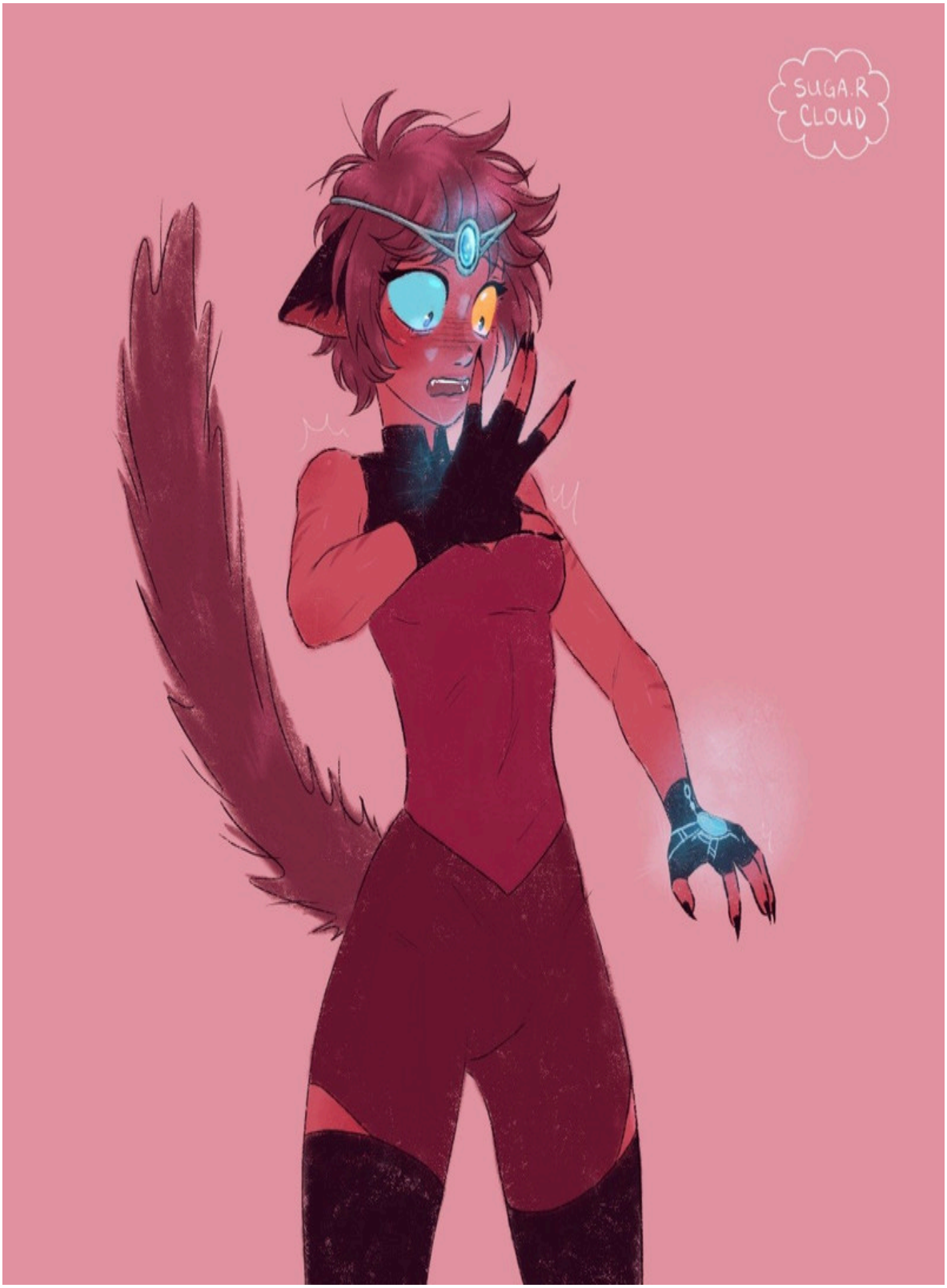
frowned at me. 'Catra, it didn't open for me. If I was supposed to wear them it would have opened when I said the word. But it didn't, it opened for you, so try them on.'

Catra sighed before picking up the gloves and putting them on. They were relatively thin, but padded, black fingerless gloves. They had blue First Ones patterns all around, which stemmed from a blue crystal disc on the back of each glove. I couldn't help but be reminded of the crystal Mara's sword was made from, it looked identical. Catra then picked up the circlet; it was made from two bands of gold metal that met at an angle at the front and ended with two circles at the back. At the front, covering the join between the two halves, a small blue oval gemstone. 'Do I really have to wear this?'



'Yes!' I beamed, 'If it makes you feel better, I think those are called circlets, not tiaras.'

'For the record, that does *not* make me feel better.' She put it on before fiddling with her hair, making it sit more comfortably on her head. Now all that was visible was the front of it resting on her forehead, a triangular shape with a gemstone in the centre. After a moment the gemstone shone brilliantly, followed by the crystal discs on the back of the gloves, the glow then spreading throughout the rest of the pattern. 'A-Adora! They're glowing! What do I do!'



'Uh, focus!'

'On what?'

'Uh... Imagine Melog is bright red and you have to turn them blue again!' She closed her eyes, and focused on calming her breathing. I noticed her physically relaxing after a moment before she opened her eyes again and smiled at me. 'Can I have a look?' She nodded. I stepped forwards, leaning in to examine the gemstone on her head prior to having a closer look at the discs on her hands. 'Catra, this looks like Mara's sword, the one I broke.'

'What do you mean?'

'I mean it's made the same way. You've got the hilt with the gemstone, your circlet; and the blade of crystal, your gloves.' I gasped as a realisation dawned, 'I get to be your Light Hope!'

'What?'

'I could help you figure out how to use it - them, if you want me to?'

Catra looked down at her glowing gloves, considering, 'Let's just concentrate on getting out of here, for now. I don't know what these things do, and I don't want to chance anything.'

I shrugged, 'Alright, whatever you say.'

The sound of stone grinding against stone suddenly filled the silence of the forest. As we turned around, we saw a triangular temple door rising slowly just beyond the now descending glove pillar. It was part of a wall, a long wall, that had definitely not been there a few moments beforehand.

'Didn't we come from that direction?' Catra asked, looking around.

'Uh... I vote that we just go through the door and leave the confusing forest that likes you more than me behind.'

'Agreed.'

The door started closing as soon as we passed through. On the other side, we found ourselves in a familiar looking corridor filled

with flourishing magical plants and wisps.

'Wait... You were jealous, I knew it!'

Chapter End Notes

the illustrations in this chapter are by the wonderful @suga.rcloud!

Unstable Memories

Voices echoed down the corridor as we neared what used to be a doorway, a tree now growing proudly where a door would once have been. The magic in this place that caused all the plants to grow must have been hundreds of years old, all of this couldn't have been the result of the magic the spire collected just a few days ago. We were close enough now that I could make out Bow's voice clearly, he was talking to someone about how to work some controls.

Catra and I stepped over the thick roots of the tree in the doorway and looked around the hall we found ourselves entering. The ceiling was high, the walls lined with many pieces of First Ones writing with what looked like angular representations of landscapes worked in-between them. The tree in our doorway was much bigger than I thought, it snaked up the side of the nearest wall before leaning out and filling a large part of the hall with its long, twisting branches and flourishing leaves. There were two other intact doors to our left, and ahead of us a staircase leading up to a central dais which had an open door behind it. I could see Bow up on the dais, he was crouching around what looked like another pillar, similar to the one we found in the forest, aiming his tracking pad at various parts of it.

'Bow!' I called, getting his attention. 'Hey!'

Bow looked up, surprised, and smiled when he saw us, 'Adora! Catra! I'm so glad you're okay!' He called back, waving us up to join him on the dais.

As we climbed the stairs, I got a better feeling for the layout of the hall. It was oval shaped, and there were four doors in total. The one behind Bow looked like the way out with three more opposite, the left door being the one we just came out of. The dais with the short pillar was almost central to the room, with two sets of stairs leading up to it on either side.

Bow walked over, flipping the tracker pad round to face us, 'Glimmer went and found - '

'Entrapta?' I smiled, 'You're still in Bright Moon?'

'Yes, I already explained that packing up my lab has taken a lot longer than I predicted... Oh! Adora! It's you! I thought Bow's voice had cracked again - it's good that you're here! There's some kind of terminal that doesn't have buttons on it and Bow's hand doesn't work.'

'My voice is fine! My hand works fine!' Bow protested, his voice cracking slightly.

Catra laughed, and I couldn't help but join in. The sound of Catra genuinely laughing filled me with joy, and I smiled at her before looking at the pillar nearby. It looked like the one we had just encountered, but it had an angled top, with the shape of a hand engraved into it. 'I've got a feeling this one's on Catra.' I smirked, moving towards her.

'Wait, what?' She asked as I grabbed her wrist and pulled her forward, 'Why me!' Once I placed her hand on the pillar her glove shone brightly, that glow then travelled down the pillar and spread throughout the room, following the patterns on the floor and walls.

'Woah, what's happening?' Bow asked, moving round to stand in front of Catra, 'Catra has fancy gloves now? And a little tiara? When did this happen?'

'It's not a tiara!' Catra growled.

A scream suddenly sounded from the tracker pad Bow was still holding up, he almost jumped out of his skin and had to juggle the device to avoid dropping it, 'Catra has First Ones' tech!?' Entrapta shouted, 'And it's wearable!?' She looked like she was about to faint. 'You must let me examine it!'

Just then, a familiar hologram appeared in front of Catra, floating just beyond the edge of the dais. Its purple form distorting every few seconds.

<< Administrator detected. What is your query? >>

Catra looked at me and I shrugged, 'Just say some words.'

She thought for a second, 'Uh... Focus? Sanctuary?'

<< Administrator password accepted: Focus. >>
<< Destination selected: Sanctuary. >>
<< Please proceed. >>

The middle door below us lit up and started to rise.

'Ohhh, I wish I was really there!' Entrapta yelled through the screen.

Catra looked up at the hologram, 'Thanks?'

<< Query not recognised. >>

She gingerly removed her hand from the pillar, and although the glow dimmed it did not vanish entirely, unlike the hologram.

'Okay, Entrapta, I'll call you back,' said Bow.

'Affirmative!' She replied, 'Wrong Hordak! Make some tiny snacks - '

Bow ended the connection and looked at us. 'Could I have those earpieces back? I want to have a look at what went wrong with the connection when you guys passed through that wall. Thanks.' He said, as we passed them over.

We then started walking towards the stairs, and Bow looked at me as I walked alongside him, Catra following behind, 'So what happened to you guys? What was through that door?' He motioned towards the door we came from as we reached the

bottom of the stairs and headed towards the newly opened central door.

'We were in some kind of magical forest. It looked just like the Whispering Woods, acted like them too. At first, I thought it was a hologram or a memory, but there really is an entire magical forest down there. And... it was responding to Catra, ignoring She-Ra almost entirely, that's how we able to find our way out.' I looked around as we entered the new corridor, this one wasn't as overgrown as the others and seemed to be less so the further down it we travelled.

Bow considered for a moment, his hand on his chin, 'And what about the First Ones' tech you found? Is it okay for Catra to be wearing it?'

'Hmm. I'd be lying if I said I wasn't a little worried about it, but something's happening with her. When I found Mara's sword in the forest, it started me in an entirely new direction. I can't help but think Catra finding a similar piece of tech must mean something. It has to. It can't be a coincidence.'

He looked back at Catra, frowning, 'She's been awfully quiet for a while, I think you should talk to her, see if she's okay. I'll have a quick look at these earpieces,' He took one of them out and started frowning at it.

'Okay. Thanks, Bow.' I dropped back to walk alongside Catra, she didn't say a word and just kept walking. She was holding her arms to her chest again and walking with her eyes down. 'Hey, what's on your mind?' I asked, placing a hand on her shoulder.

She looked up at me, a worried look in her eyes, 'I just don't understand what's happening. This kind of stuff doesn't happen to me, Adora. I'm the one that messes everything up, puts people in danger, pushes people away. Since we returned to Etheria, everyone has slowly started being nice to me, despite everything I've done to hurt them. And now this...' She holds up her gloved

hands, 'I just don't know what to make of it. I don't know what to do. I - I'm scared, Adora.'

Before I think about anything else I wrap my arms around Catra as tight as I can, burying my face in her neck, 'Catra, everyone is forgiving you because they can see that you've changed, that you're trying to be better than you were. And whatever is going on with you now, we'll work through it together. You, me, and all our friends.' I feel her arms around me, holding me close. 'It's not just you and me anymore, like it was in the Horde, we have so many people who care about us now and will help if we need them. Everything will be okay, I promise.'

Catra leant back from the embrace, looking into my eyes, 'I love you, Adora.' My cheeks started to ache as I felt a wide smile take over my face, that was the second time she had said it out loud. I knew she meant it when she called me things like "dummy" or said that I'm "such an idiot," but hearing the words themselves sent a shiver of sheer happiness through me that I could barely contain. But then a sadness flashed in her eyes, and she dropped her gaze. 'There's something I've been meaning to tell you for a while. I've been having - '

'Guys!?' Bow called from up ahead, 'I've found something!'

'We'll be right there, Bow!' I called back, 'I'm really sorry, Catra. Tell me later, okay?' I tried to smile reassuringly, but I could tell that not knowing what she was about to say would weigh on me until she did. I made a mental note to ask her about it once we were back in Bright Moon.

She forced a smile, 'Yeah, okay.'

We quickly caught up with Bow, who was tapping rapidly on his tracker pad, 'I'm calling Entrapta back, she's going to want to see this.'

The room was oval shaped, like the hall, but this one had rows of blue tanks lining the walls. Most had some level of glowing blue

fluid inside, but some were broken, the glass long since shattered. A kaleidoscope of different coloured glowing mushrooms sprouted from where the liquid would have once been spilled. In the centre of the room there was a pool filled with the same blue fluid that seemed to have steps leading down into it, plants growing around its edges. Bow was making his way over to the terminal, as if he knew where to go. I looked down into the pool and saw my own reflection shimmering back at me.

That's when it happened.

'No. No no no no no....' I looked up to see Catra glancing around frantically, clutching at her head, her eyes wide in panic and fear. 'Argh!'

'Catra!?'

She suddenly dropped to her knees and screamed while clutching at her hair, a strong shockwave of wind erupting from where she fell, pushing Bow and I away. The wind didn't die down, instead becoming a swirling gale with Catra at the centre, picking up bits of mushrooms and shards of glass, flinging them around the room. I shouted the words despite not hearing them over the howl of the wind, but I could still feel myself becoming She-Ra. I summoned the shield, leaping in front of Bow, holding it against the wind just as a wave of glass shards thundered against it. Peeking over the top, I tried to see Catra, but the wind was too strong for me to keep my eyes open for long. I pushed the shield onto Bow before standing and making my way slowly around the pool, the blue fluid inside crashing against the edges. Each step was agonising, as shards of glass sped past me, cutting through the white and bouncing off the gold of She-Ra's armour. I held my arms up to cover my face, I didn't know how far I was from Catra, but I kept pushing towards where I remembered her falling.

The wind stopped.

I had broken through into the eye of the storm, the wind still swirling around me as I stood in front of Catra. She was on her

knees, her face to the floor, still clutching at her head. A small dome of blue energy surrounded her, protecting her from any flying debris. She looked like she was screaming but I could barely hear her from inside the bubble. Placing my hand gently against it I could feel it was solid, it was powerful, and it vibrated with built up force. One wrong move and this thing could send me flying back into the vortex of wind and glass. I was shouting Catra's name, asking her to stop, but my voice wouldn't reach her.

I took a deep breath, crossed my legs, and sat on the floor facing Catra with my hands on my knees. I took one last look before closing my eyes. I concentrated on the power of She-Ra, the brightness of her energy within me, and called on it. I called on her light, to shine through me and light the way for Catra to come back, for it to distract her, for her to latch onto it and pull herself out of whatever darkness she had fallen into.

I could feel it, She-Ra's light was enveloping me, I felt its radiance flow through me and shine out of me.

I opened my eyes.

Catra was looking at me, her eyes pained and red from crying, her ears low. The jewel on her circlet and the discs on her gloves were glowing brighter than ever. She caught my gaze and looked into my eyes, placing a gloved hand against the bubble from the inside. I nodded to her, letting her know it was all okay. She knew what to do. Catra moved to copy my position, crossing her legs with her hands on her knees. I watched as she closed her eyes and started taking deep breaths.

The wind around us slowly died down, the glass clattering to the floor, and the energy shield around Catra fizzled out of existence. She opened her eyes again and looked at me, visibly exhausted, 'Adora...' I leapt forwards just as she fainted backwards, catching her in my arms.

Cast out the Shadows

After carrying Catra over to Bow and healing all three of us together, then shrinking back down to my normal self, I sat on the floor cradling her unconscious body in my arms. I had lightly removed her gloves and circlet, placing them carefully to one side, and now I just looked down at her with tears in my eyes as I stroked her expressionless face.

Bow had called Entrapta back and plugged the tracker pad into the console so that she could help him go through the information, to work out what was going on. They were talking about having to crack through security without tripping any alarms, but I wasn't listening. Not really. All I could do in that moment was hold on to Catra, just like I had after saving her from Horde Prime less than a month ago. Feeling her body limp like this again was tearing a hole in me. I pressed my forehead against hers and whispered, 'Catra... I love you... Please be okay...'

What had caused this? I now knew there was something she wanted to tell me; she had mentioned it moments beforehand. What was it? What was wrong? I knew she had mixed feelings about a lot of things since leaving the Horde, her conscience was heavy with all she had done, and she was working through that, bit by bit - but this seemed like something else. Something about this room caused her to mentally collapse in moments. She hadn't told me about anything specific about what happened on Prime's flagship, could it be to do with that? Was this place somehow connected? Had it triggered more flashes? A lasting effect from the chip, perhaps? My mind raced at the possibilities, trying to work out what could have caused such a response.

Wait. The response. I looked over at the First Ones tech. That energy barrier, that wind, was that from the tech or from...

'Adora.'

Bow's voice snapped me back to reality and I looked up to find him kneeling in front of me.

I felt tears drip from my eyes at the sudden movement. 'Yeah?' There was a lump in my throat, my voice barely made a sound.

'Sorry, but you're going to want to see this.'

I nodded, and Bow stood before walking back over to the console. I gently lifted Catra's head and moved myself from under her, then carefully placed her head back down. Then I took my jacket off and folded it before tenderly lifting Catra's head again and sliding my folded jacket under, before lowering her head back onto it slowly. I stroked her cheek and smiled softly, before kissing her forehead, standing up, and making my way over to the console.

Bow had questions, and concerns, and doubts. I could tell. They were plastered all over his face. But I knew that, for me, he was being considerate and not voicing them. Yet. 'Okay,' I said as I joined him at the console, looking up at the holographic screens that had appeared over it, 'Hit me.'

'From what we've been able to find,' he began, 'The First Ones used this place to heal their wounded and sick. But they did it by using the magic of Etheria.'

I frowned, 'Wait, what? How.'

Bow pressed some buttons on the console and a diagram of the spire came up, 'By using the spire, they collected the magic out of the surrounding area. Harnessing that magic, they were able to develop ways of using it for healing and medicine. For thousands of years, long before Mara, this temple drained the magic from a huge portion of Etheria - and once it ran out of magic from the land, it started draining the life force from the wildlife too. Adora, this place *created* the Crimson Waste, it's the reason this place is so dead. And for whatever reason, restoring magic to Etheria restarted it, which is why everything has been dying again. The

systems that are draining magic and life-force are also the reason for the interference on the maps since they're powered by a combination of tech and magic.' He brought up another screen flashing with warnings and errors, 'And it looks like at some point after the First Ones left, leaving this place running, wherever they were storing the magic filled to the brim and burst, causing a major leak inside the temple. Which explains all the plants and glowing... things.'

I couldn't believe it. I stood there for a moment, shocked into silence. 'If it's draining life-force, why weren't we affected?'

'I'm not sure, could be something deep in the programming to do with how the First Ones stopped it from affecting themselves. Maybe it's advanced enough that it can tell the difference between Etherians and wildlife.'

I nodded, that would do for now, 'So how do we stop it?'

'The easy way would be to get Catra to do it, as she seems to have administrator access for some reason, but since she's... out,' He glanced over at Catra's still form, 'Entrapta is currently trying to break through their firewalls and shut it down manually without triggering any alarms.' He sighed, before pressing his palms together in front of his face, 'Please be no spiders.'

At the mention of Catra I turn back to face her, she was still lying where I left her, unmoving and still. 'I hope she's okay.'

Bow turned to follow my gaze, 'I... I know what happened to her, Adora. After seeing her reaction to this room, I asked Entrapta about it.' I looked at him, stunned, urging him to continue with my eyes, 'This room is almost identical to one Entrapta and I found Wrong Hordak in on Horde Prime's flagship. It was filled with pods, similar to these vats. And... While you were busy, Hordak explained to me what Horde Prime did to Catra.'

'What did he do to her?'

'Are you sure you want to know?'

I nodded.

He turned to face his tracker pad, 'Entrapta, you still there?'

After a moment the screen fizzled and Entrapta's face suddenly filled it, 'Yes! Hi! Sorry, these security systems are incredibly fragile. One wrong move and the temple's defences will kick in and kick you out.'

'Is Hordak still there?' Bow asked, his gaze and tone stern.

'HORDAK!' Entrapta shouted, 'Bow wants to talk to you again.'

There was a moment where nothing happened, and then the picture shook before being lifted and spun around, revealing Hordak's white and grey complexion, complimented by his green eyes and mouth. 'This is Hordak. Speak.'

'Hordak,' said Bow, looking at me, 'Tell Adora what you told me. About Catra.'

Hordak frowned, considering, 'Are you certain you wish to know, child?' He asked, addressing me.

I averted my gaze. Did I want to know? It seemed like Catra was about to start opening up, am I right to take the opportunity to tell me herself away from her? I shook my head. I had to know, I needed to know what happened so that I could help her. 'Tell me.' I said, having made up my mind.

'Very well. But do not blame me for any consequences.' There was a pause, and the camera shifted before focusing back on Hordak's face, he must have sat down.

He spoke slowly, his voice low, 'After Catra helped your Queen escape, Horde Prime was displeased. He was not surprised, nor was he wrathful, but he decided to punish Catra all the same. He did it at first because he knew you would come for her, and he wanted to watch as the hope drained from your eyes. But he also did it simply because he could. She would be more cooperative,

and Horde Prime would have access to her entire mind, as we all did. He knew she felt for you, cared for you, and she couldn't help but prove it, try as she might to suppress it.

'And so, he took her to be purified. He told her to get into the pool, and she did so, willingly. She could not, after all, have hoped to oppose him. We all stood by, chanting as she lowered herself into it. Horde Prime then activated the machine, and Catra screamed. She screamed as her personality and memories were suppressed deep into her mind. It would have felt as though she were a spectator in her own body.

'Once the procedure was complete, Catra was still, her eyes dead. My brothers carried her out and laid her on a pedestal. There Horde Prime stripped her himself, cut her hair himself, and applied the chip himself. He relished it, took pride in it. I could feel all he felt, and it was *vile*. Once the chip connected, Catra was a part of the hive mind. I felt her. I felt her suppressed anguish, her regret, guilt, sorrow, pain and... love. And then it was gone, replaced with the Catra who did not feel, who was glad to be a part of Horde Prime.

'She relished in the peace Prime gave her, she dropped to her knees and thanked him for his release from her pain. Then, he provided her with our uniform, and told her to rest, for she would be having a visitor. You.' He stood and put the tracker pad back down, facing Entrapta. 'Do not ask me to tell that story again.'

Everything after that was a blur.

My mind stopped. I could feel myself moving, but I felt far away. I think I was crying. Catra... Suddenly she was in my arms. I was cradling her. Rocking her. Her face was wet. I was crying on her. I rocked her back and forth, saying her name, apologising to her.

I was sorry.

I was sorry for not going back sooner.

I was sorry for leaving her there.

I was sorry for ever hurting her.

And then I vowed.

I vowed to protect her.

I vowed to always be with her.

I vowed to make her happy.

And then I told her I loved her, again and again.

I love you.

I love you.

I love you.

Melog was before me, nuzzling into Catra. Huntara followed, looking around. Bow was talking to her but I couldn't make out what they were saying, I felt far away... Glimmer was there. I hadn't noticed her arrive... I think Bow picked up my jacket and Catra's tech. I felt a hand on my shoulder and the room changed. I looked down; I was still holding Catra. That's all that mattered to me... Someone tried to prise me away from Catra, but I wouldn't let go... The room changed again... I felt weightless, as if being picked up, then felt my body connect with softness... I was lying down with Catra next to me. I moved closer to her, hugged her to me, and closed my eyes.

**

I had awoken the next morning in my bed, in my room, lying next to Catra. Glimmer and Bow were asleep on chairs by the bed, her head on his shoulder, his head on hers. I could barely remember how I got there. All I remembered was hearing what Horde Prime did to Catra, and then... it was all blurry.

Glimmer and Bow explained to me what happened once they woke up. Bow said that it was like I had vanished, I wouldn't

leave Catra's side for a second. Entrapta had managed to disable to temple's security, stopping the collection of magic, shutting it all down. Melog and Huntara had entered after she saw the temple power down, using the password I had said to open the entrance. Then, with the anomaly gone and the interference cleared from the map, Bow sent Glimmer our exact coordinates and she came to get us. Apparently Huntara was told not to scrap the temple, and she agreed after seeing the state we were in. She said she would tell her people there was nothing inside, and to go home, promising not to share the password.

Entrapta and Micah explained to me that Catra had most likely suffered an extreme psychological shock at seeing a place that bore resemblance to somewhere deeply traumatic to her. They said she just needed rest, that fatigue was a normal symptom of trauma, and that she should wake up soon.

And so there I was, sat next to the bed, holding onto Catra's hand waiting for her to wake up. My jacket had been placed over my shoulders at some point, and Catra's First Ones tech was across the room on my desk.

I wondered about what I should say to her when she woke up. I wondered if I should tell her Bow's theory: that Horde Prime had possibly found another healing pool on a First Ones world a millennia ago, copying the design and using it to breed thousands of clones. I wondered if I should tell her my theory: that she somehow had magical powers, and the tech was her focus much like Mara's sword had been for me. I wondered if I should just talk to her, tell her about how much I loved her, and wanted to spend the rest of my life with her, share in her trauma and help her grow past it.

And then I didn't wonder anymore, as I was snapped back into the room, away from my idle thoughts.

I felt a pressure on my hand, and Catra's eyelids slowly fluttered open. She looked around the room, slowly taking it in, before meeting my gaze and smiling softly. I felt my heart tighten at her

smile and smiled back, almost laughing with relief, tears in my eyes.

'...Hey, Adora.'

Take Care of Each Other

'Hey,' I replied softly.

Smiling through my tears, I squeezed her hand. I was happy to see her awake, but a pile of difficult questions formed a lump in my throat, and I held my tongue.

'Adora...' Catra's voice was hoarse and quiet, 'I'm sorry.' Her hand moved to my face and touched my cheek.

I placed my hand over hers and leaned into it, finding comfort in the small gesture. 'It's okay, it wasn't your fault.'

Her fingers gently rub over my face, as if trying to find something, 'I hurt you again...'

She must have seen me covered in cuts when she looked at me in the eye of her storm, I had been so focused I forgot all about it, 'It's alright, I healed us all. We're all okay.'

A small Melog jumped up onto the bed and snuggled next to Catra, she smiled warmly, stroking them with her other hand.

'How do you feel?' I asked, almost fearing the answer.

'I don't know. I feel like that was the deepest sleep I've had in a while.' Sitting up didn't seem to pose a problem for her and she crossed her legs, leaning forwards. Melog got up and curled into her lap, and she continued to stroke them. 'Listen, Adora...'

I looked up at her, meeting her gaze.

'I know you must have a thousand questions, and a thousand more worries. And...' She paused, looking down at Melog, 'This is going to make me sound crazy, but while I was asleep, I felt like... I felt like Etheria itself spoke to me. Told me not to be afraid. I felt a connection I - I can't explain it.' Melog jumped off of her lap and onto the floor, returning to normal size before sitting near the

door, waiting. I turned back to see that Catra was shuffling toward me, and she dangled her legs over the edge of the bed as she faced me, holding my hands in hers and interlacing our fingers. 'I've decided I'm not going to run anymore. I'm not going to hide anything from you anymore. Right now I feel this... clarity. I don't know how long it will last, but I wanted to tell you that that's what I've decided. I'm going to trust you with all of me.'

I felt a weight lift off my shoulders, and I leant forwards, embracing the love of my life. 'That's everything I want.' She had said exactly what I needed to hear, and I felt a warmth rise deep inside myself.

'I'm going to elaborate on what I started telling you in the temple, and then we're going to talk about what happened in the... in that room.' I nodded. 'But first, I need to wash.'

I laughed, 'That sounds great... Do you want me to join...?'

Catra grinned a devious smile, 'Not today, Princess, but I'll keep that offer in mind.' She got up and made towards the bathroom door, stopping briefly to collect a new grey top, grey shorts, and a towel. I watched the sway of her hips and the swishing as she walked in the bathroom, Melog following behind, before closing the door behind her with a thud.

I let out a huge breath and flopped onto the bed. That hadn't gone the way I expected. I would never have thought Catra would wake up after suffering something so traumatising and actually be more willing than ever to talk to me. Had she really had a vision? Had it impacted her that hard that she now trusted me with all of her? I couldn't help but smile. It seemed too good to be true. I heard the faint sound of the shower turning on.

At that moment Glimmer teleported into the room, frowning as she saw me on the bed, 'Adora? Where's Catra? Is she okay?'

I looked at her, and she must have seen my smile because she walked over and laid on the bed next to me, her head almost

touching mine. Had she not been in formal queen clothes, I got the feeling she would have jumped on the bed and not cared if she made a mess.

'She's just in the bathroom having a wash. And... honestly? She seems fine. So fine I'm wondering, deep down, if she's *too* fine. She said she was going to tell me everything, trust me with all of her. Glimmer, she said she had a vision. What if she's got magic now?' I stared up at the ceiling as I spoke, and I knew Glimmer would be doing the same.

She hummed in thought before replying, 'Bow told me everything that happened. He said you got separated, and when you found him again Catra had that First Ones tech. He did also explain what happened with Catra... Oh, and he also said, and I quote, "I don't think Adora was being as quiet as she thought she was."'

I felt my life leave my body as she said that last part, and then my face flushed red and I covered my eyes with my hands. 'Oh no.'

'Oh, yeah. He did not sleep well.' She chuckled; I could tell she enjoyed teasing me about my new relationship with Catra.

'Well, that's it. I can never look at Bow ever again.'

Glimmer sat up and I peeped through my fingers at her. She was looking down at me, concerned. 'Adora, Bow also told me what Hordak said. Does Catra know that we know? It sort of feels wrong that we've learnt about it indirectly. Is she really fine?'

I sighed. 'No, I don't think so. Part of me wants her to just wake up one day and be fine, but part of me wants to help her through it, help her overcome it, help her conquer it. She said she would talk about everything with me. I just need to be strong. For her, but also for myself. Hearing it from Hordak was sudden and... well, you saw what I was like. I was in shock. But hearing it from Catra, I think that will be harder. So I have to be strong, for her and for me.'

Glimmer nodded, sitting up, 'Okay, just remember to take care of yourself too.' I nodded. 'Oh! I need to catch you up on some things,' she said, spinning round to face me and crossing her legs on my bed.

I sat up, listening, 'Okay. What kind of things?'

She chuckled, 'Just mundane boring stuff, don't get excited. There's been no reports of fighting or anything since Horde Prime was defeated.'

'Why would fighting excite me?'

'Oh, you don't have to pretend with me. We both know you like to show off.' Glimmer grinned a mischievous smile.

I scoffed, 'I do not!'

'You do.' She patted my arm, pretending to console me and nodding solemnly. 'Anyway, my dad has been doing well. He seems to have caught up on how things work now, it's not all that different, which is good. I'm going to remain Queen, and if for any reason I leave Bright Moon, on any best friend squad adventures, he is prepared to take over in my absence as Steward of Bright Moon.'

Frowning, I asked, 'What's a steward?'

Glimmer's eyes widened; she had probably forgotten that I wouldn't know what that is. 'Oh, it just means that while I'm gone, he makes decisions on my behalf. He said he doesn't feel like he can be king, not with my mother gone, but he's prepared to stand in for me.'

The hug that I pulled her into was long and warm, we didn't have to say anything to understand what it was for. Angella's last words to me echoed in my head...

Take care of each other.

I smiled sadly at the memory of her, and I couldn't help but wonder what she would say if she were here. Micah was alive, the war was over, we had won. There was peace. She could have finally relaxed. I wondered how proud she would be of her daughter now. Glimmer had matured a lot since becoming queen, she no longer teleported head-first into combat, instead considering things first. That change is what had pushed us apart. I was always so raring to go and just assumed Glimmer would go along with it, but as Queen she had been burdened with so many other responsibilities overnight. But we had moved past it and grown stronger from it.

'Speaking of adventures...' Glimmer said, pulling back from the hug. 'Bow and I were talking, and we think it would be best if you and Catra took a break. We only just saved the world, and then I immediately sent you on another mission. That was wrong of me, and you and Catra suffered because of it. Despite your... activities.'

'Glimmer -'

She cut me off, 'No, Adora. Let me finish. Entrapta has almost finished packing the last of her equipment onto Darla. She had to get some of it out again to help Bow hack the temple. But she'll be leaving with Hordak and Wrong Hordak for Dryl... soon. I can't remember when she said. Tomorrow or the day after. Honestly, I get lost when she speaks sometimes. But we think you should go with her. You and Catra. To just get away from all...' she motioned around her, 'This.'

I leant back, thinking. It could be good to get away. We haven't had much time to properly rest since... well, ever. We had those couple of days before, but they didn't last long.

'Entrapta is... enthusiastic about it.' Glimmer continued, 'Bow may have mentioned Catra's recent *outburst* to her, and she's also desperate to study the First Ones tech you found and how Catra can connect with it.'

I looked back at Glimmer and nodded.

'Okay.' I said.

She looked shocked, 'That's it?'

Smiling, I asked, 'Yeah, why? It sounds like a good plan.'

Apparently, she had been holding a breath, because she let it out, 'I was sure you would protest being sent away. Well, not sent away as such, but more like a *go relax or else* kind of thing.'

I smirked, 'You just want us out of the palace, don't you? You're gonna do something with Bow.' I prodded at her chest playfully.

She turned bright red and looked away, 'I... uh... I can't *deny* that the thought... had crossed my mind. But that wasn't our main motivation! You guys were!' She held up her hands defensively.

We continued talking for a while, I lost track of how long exactly. Glimmer told me all about her dad not knowing how all the recent additions worked, like the tracker pads, the war room hologram table, and the showers in the palace washrooms which had been a recent addition that Entrapta had installed in all the bathrooms without telling anyone. She also told me that he had been awestruck during his tour of Darla, asking about every little thing, and Entrapta had shown him every minute detail of what she had added to the ship. She told me about all the other princesses leaving to go on their missions or to go home and how empty the palace now felt. Glimmer then talked about how worried she had been while she couldn't contact us in the Crimson Waste. Which reminded me about Catra, and I looked to the door of the bedroom.

She had been gone the whole time; we must have been talking for nearly an hour at least. Glimmer assured me not to worry, that she would come back soon. I nodded. She then asked me about how I met Catra, back in the Horde. I laughed, remembering the day Shadow Weaver had brought in a small wet cardboard box and dumped it in our barracks, before huffing and leaving again. I

told her how I had slowly lifted the lid, seeing Catra's glowing eyes for the first time and immediately been captivated by them, before receiving a swift slash of her claws on my arm. I tried to find the cut, but it was long faded by now.

The bathroom door opened slowly. A regular-sized Melog entered first, followed by Catra, who was now wearing her grey top and shorts and aggressively drying her hair with a towel. Her fur was a shade or two darker than usual, which meant she hadn't quite fully dried off yet. Glimmer shot up and teleported across the room, catching Catra by surprise as she wrapped her arms around her.

'Whoa, Sparkles!' Catra laughed, her voice a little hoarse, hugging her back.

Melog wondered over to the carpet before walking in circles and laying down, curling up.

Glimmer had told me about how her and Catra had been able to talk a lot on Prime's ship, how she was able to relate to her, on some level. I smiled as I watched my two best friends hugging. Wait, was Catra still my friend? I hadn't even considered what we were now, but after kissing and... other things, I was sure it was more than friends. Was there a word for someone who you loved more than you did other friends? We were never taught about any of this in the Fright Zone, and any mention of friendship or anything else was taboo, but even if there wasn't a word to summarise our current relationship, I knew we would always be best friends. Inseparable. Or, at least that's what I wanted. And then I remembered about what Catra had said before she left, that she would tell me everything, trust me with all of her. Suddenly, I was nervous.

'Okay,' said Glimmer, pulling back from the hug, 'I'll let you two catch up now. Tell her about our offer, Adora. It'll be good for you.' Then she vanished, teleporting away.

A silence settled over the room, my nerves holding me back from speaking. I looked over at Catra, who was still stood by the door. She looked deep in thought. I also noticed that her eyes were red and puffy, which, combined with her hoarse voice, gave me a clue as to why she had been so long. I felt a pang of sadness shoot through me as I imagined Catra, crying alone on the floor of the bathroom while I was sat in here having fun talking to Glimmer, but I had to trust her.

Catra took a deep breath before walking over to me, sitting where Glimmer had been moments before. As she looked up at me, looked me in the eye, I could now clearly see tell-tale signs that she had been crying. I moved to hug her instinctively, but she held up a hand.

'No. Wait.' She took another deep breath, 'If you hug me, I think I might cry. And then I won't be able to stop, and I won't be able to tell you what I want to tell you.'

I nodded, leaning back again.

Catra took another breath, her eyes tearing up, 'Uh... Oh, I thought I was ready...' she wiped her eyes. 'Um. I think I need a minute. What did Glimmer tell you? Something about an offer?'

I nodded again. 'Yeah, she... she said that we should go with Entrapta and the Hordaks to Dryl. Apparently Entrapta wants to study what's happening to you, and your connection to the new tech, see how it all works. I think it's a good idea. We could do with an actual break, away from all this.' I motioned around me, as Glimmer had done earlier.

Catra took a deep breath and looked over at the tech on the desk. 'Look, Adora, I trust you. I said I would trust you, and I will. So if you think making me wear those things again is a good idea, then I'll do it. I'd like a break too.' She looked back at me, smiling with her ears low.

I smiled back, I wanted nothing more than to hold her in my arms and kiss her. I *so* wanted to kiss her.

'Okay,' she said, before looking deep into my eyes, 'I'm ready.'

Catra

'Okay, I'm ready.' She looked around for a moment, before pointing to the pillows, 'Can we lay down?'

I nodded, 'Yeah, of course.' I took the elastic out of my hair, letting it drop down and cover my shoulders.

Catra seemed to smile at me before moving up the bed and lying on her back, her head against the pillow. I moved back up the bed, before lying next to her in the same position. We were both looking at the ceiling, taking a moment. Then I felt movement next to me, and I started to turn my head but was stopped by Catra's hand on my cheek. 'No, please. Don't look at me. Not yet.' I nodded and looked back at the ceiling.

I think she was lying on her side, staring at my face. I felt her hand on my cheek, touching it gently. She then held onto my hand, before pulling it towards her and holding it tightly between both of hers.

Catra took a deep, shuddering breath before squeezing my hand once more.

Then she began.

'You were always my number one priority, Adora. Our friendship was the most important thing to me in the whole world. What I didn't realise, is that it wasn't the same for you.

'It hurt. When you left. When I realised you weren't coming back. I had been so excited to find you in Thaymor, I remember throwing myself on you and feeling so relieved you were okay.

'But then you started telling me to stop, to call off the attack. I panicked, I zapped you, I didn't know what to do. That was the first time I saw She-Ra. As soon I saw her turn into you my heart... it felt like a part of me died. I ran. I ran away. It hurt to run from you, but I felt so betrayed.

'Everything we had ever whispered to each other in the night, hiding from Shadow Weaver. All those promises and plans we made under the blankets, on the rooftops... it all felt like a lie. Like you had lied to me the whole time and then just abandoned me like I was nothing. Worthless. Pointless. A distraction.

'I scratched the drawing of your face off the bunk. I ripped up your mattress while crying my eyes out because you were gone. Without you I didn't know what to do. Everything I ever wanted was to rule the Fright Zone with you and you just left me. Alone.

'Hordak made me Force Captain. I didn't fully understand why, but it gave me a purpose again. For the first time I felt like maybe I didn't need you. I could do it on my own. But I still dressed up nice for you, at the Prom, did you notice? That was for you. I almost kissed you like three times that night. You looked so beautiful. But the plan went ahead.

'We took Sparkles and Arrow Boy. I took your sword. I felt a victory for the first time in a long time. But what Shadow Weaver was doing to Glimmer... what she would have done to you... I had to get you out of there. I gave you your sword and you asked me why. It's because I loved you, dummy. I didn't want you to get captured again, I didn't want Shadow Weaver to hurt you. Anything but that.

'After we found Entrapta... I felt like she would turn the tide of the war. She had so much potential for making weapons, and she didn't seem to mind when I used them against you. It was her that told me where to look for First Ones tech, and I found you there. I followed you, into that temple. It was hard, being in there with you. It showed us memories of us as kids. I felt so confused. I loved you. But you were my enemy. I said horrible things to you that I didn't mean and left you there. It hurt so much but I convinced myself it was right.

'Then Hordak gave us permission to use the Black Garnet. Shadow Weaver didn't like it and attacked us. I beat her. I think she knew that once Hordak gave us the runestone she would no longer be

needed. We used it to attack you. Froze the woods. Marched on Bright Moon. It felt so good to get so close. That was where you were. It was where you lived. I wanted to destroy it. If I destroyed it maybe you would return to me.

'I dug my claws into you that day. I raked them down your back. I still feel it... I still remember trying to scrub the blood out from under my nails. I'm so sorry... You still have the scars and you always will...

'The entire time I was in the fright zone it felt like everything was crumbling around me. Shadow Weaver was in prison. Entrapta was helping Hordak. I was being sent all over to find parts for their portal project... the portal... When Shadow Weaver escaped, Hordak almost killed me. But he banished me instead. Sent me to the Crimson Waste. I took over that place in half a day. It was nothing compared to the Fright Zone. But of course you would be there. You told me about Shadow Weaver, how she abandoned me *exactly* the same way you did... Something inside me snapped. I wanted to destroy everything. And I almost did... I still remember the look you gave me after you shut down the portal. It pierced something deep down within me. It was the first time I thought you genuinely hated me...

'It was easy to take over the Fright Zone after that. Hordak was a mess. I told him Entrapta betrayed him and went back with you but that's... that's not what happened. I sent her to Beast Island. That's why Scorpia left... She looked me in the eye and called me a bad friend... Double Trouble helped to keep you all busy while we destroyed Salineas. I remember trying to contact Scorpia, but I couldn't. I found a note in her room. She had left me too... Everyone was leaving me. I wouldn't be surprised if Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio left either. I've not seen them for a while. I worked them too hard, I worked all of them too hard. So they probably hate me too. After Double Trouble betrayed me, made me send our whole army to be destroyed, Hordak attacked me. He had found out about Entrapta. We practically destroyed the Fright Zone in our fight. Then Sparkles showed up, and the next thing I remember...

'Horde Prime... I thought I could survive there the same way I did in the Horde. Try to make myself essential. But it didn't work. He saw through everything, even how I felt about you. He used it against me. Everyone had turned against me. There was nothing left. I lost you, Shadow Weaver followed you, Scorpia left, Double Trouble manipulated me, Hordak attacked me... You should have seen the way Horde Prime picked up Hordak and tossed him aside.

'After all of that I was broken. I felt lost. I had absolutely nothing left. I was allowed to walk around his ship, but I was still a prisoner. Sparkles and I, we... we spoke a lot. We talked about a lot of things. It was nice. She told me to do one good thing in my life. So, once I knew you were on your way to get her, I got her out. I got her out to you, so that you wouldn't come to the ship. And then...

'He...

'It *hurt*...

'He made me walk into that green pool of my own will and he... I remember screaming. The pain... I couldn't stand it. I couldn't stand it so much that I felt myself receding into my own body to escape the intensity of it. When it stopped, I couldn't move. I couldn't do anything. But I could *feel...* I felt his hands on me. He took off my clothes. He cut my hair. He put the chip on me and then... it was agony. Thousands of minds in my head all at once, I wanted to scream but I couldn't. I couldn't do anything. Instead I was on my knees, naked, thanking Prime for releasing me from my pain... He hadn't released me from anything. He just pushed me back inside my own head and made me a puppet. A puppet to be used.

'And then, like an idiot, you came for me. You fell into his trap. I started fighting it. I wanted to tell you to leave, but I also wanted you to stay. I wanted you to help me. I wanted to go home. And then I fell...

'I woke up in your arms. I thought I was dead... I thought I had died. But there you were, holding me. You really had come back for me. I decided I would change, that I would need to change so you wouldn't leave me again... Scorpia had been right, I had been a bad friend...

'Spending time with you was nice. I loved hearing you laugh, I loved not fighting you. Every time I looked at you, I thought... I love her. She's beautiful. I want to stay with her forever, even if that meant putting up with Arrow Boy and Sparkles.

'While we were fighting Horde Prime on Etheria, I tried everything I could to keep you safe. I wanted you to stop flinging yourself at danger, to stop protecting everyone by endangering yourself. For the last three years, the Princesses did nothing but use you. I wanted you to decide for yourself. But then Shadow Weaver got to you, made you take the Failsafe. Once you did that, once you chose her over me... I thought you didn't want me there. That I was just in the way. I was a distraction. I thought you didn't want me like I wanted you... Like I had always wanted you...

'So I ran. Just like you had. But I found out what Prime was doing to Etheria and I had to warn you... But I was too late. Shadow Weaver was talking but I stopped her, I told her to help me help you, to do one good thing in her life...

'She sacrificed herself for us. For Etheria. Do you remember what she said...? *"You're welcome."* I'm still so confused by that. Had she really cared for us? Even though she treated us so horribly. Tortured me relentlessly through my childhood, endlessly making me feel like I was less than the ground she walked on. She used me at every opportunity for her own self gain, and only kept me around at all because you seemed happier when I was around. And yet through it all I still sought her approval, I kept trying to make her see what I could do - that I wasn't useless. But she left the Horde to go after you, so she never saw any of it... *"You're welcome."*

'And there's you, you idiot. You were about to face the Heart of Etheria alone. As if I would have left you to do that on your own, dummy. When I was holding you, I thought I had lost you. I begged you to stay, not to leave me again... and I finally told you. I told you what I should have told you a long time ago. That I loved you. I had always loved you. I always will...

'But you... you looked me in the eye with a look I had seen plenty of times before. A look I never paid attention to, one I shrugged off as being in my head. I always thought I was imagining things, running off in my own little fantasies. But no, at that moment you looked at me with those eyes, and gave me the meaning behind them... They meant you loved me too... This whole time you'd been looking at me the same way I was looking at you and I never noticed. I held your face in my hand and I kissed you. It felt so right, so good, so perfect. It was everything I had ever wanted...

'And then you were She-Ra. I was kissing She-Ra. You ended up holding me above the ground, so I wrapped my legs around you as you held onto me. Then the Heart released its magic. It flowed into you, you were absorbing it but you were kissing me. I felt it flow through you and into me too. Then you stopped and looked into my eyes. I think I melted on the spot. Once I saw you, all big and shiny and glowing, I knew you had done it. You'd survived, we made it.

'You released the magic back into Etheria. You stopped Horde Prime. We won. I felt such a wave of relief, some of the princesses hugged me, which was strange. Then you made some random declaration that we would bring magic back to the universe. Yeah, right. As if we could that just the four of us. I almost died laughing when Bow started freaking out about long that would take.

'Then there were celebrations that night in Bright Moon, but I felt out of place, like I didn't belong. I needed time to think. I walked around the palace, hiding from guards, looking out the windows. I could barely believe where I was, let alone that I was allowed to

be there. And not to mention you had just asked me into your room like it was nothing. It took me a while to work up the courage be alone in your bedroom with you.

'When I did go back to your room you were fast asleep, I must have watched you for ages. Then, I decided I that I would lie next to you. I was nervous at first but when I did, I felt at peace. I remember thinking that it was good, that it was where I belong.

'Then the next morning... it felt like our lives had led up to that moment. Like it was always going to happen, like we had always wanted it to happen. I could still barely believe that you loved me back, but you kept reminding me, you kept saying it, over and over and it felt... right. It was right. It was good. It felt good.

'We didn't kiss and barely touched each other for a full day after that, so when you kissed me outside the war room, I felt a... *hunger*. I've never felt anything like it. But you continued to tease me all day, spouting something about a promise, that you'd make it up to me. Then at the campfire, you nearly sent me crazy. I tried so hard to be mad at you, to get back at you for teasing me all day but I decided: no. I would take what you owed me, what you said you owed me, and you would do it on my terms. So I told you not to say a word, to be quiet. You were anything but quiet, nowhere near. Sweetest revenge of my life.

'What I've not been telling you, what I was going to tell you in the temple, is that the flashes never stopped. I didn't tell you because I didn't want to worry you, but almost every night I've been having nightmares. Sometimes it's Horde Prime, sometimes it's Shadow Weaver. You never woke up, and I didn't wake you. I would just get some air then get back into bed. Hoping they wouldn't come back.

'Then today, when I saw that room with the tanks and the pool... it came flooding back. What Horde Prime did to me. It felt like there was a *storm* in my head. But then I felt a warmth. A glow. I opened my eyes and you were there, covered in cuts, bleeding. I

remembered what you told me. I had to calm Melog. I had to turn him blue again. And I did.

'Then I must have passed out because everything went black. But I felt a reassurance, I felt like everything would be okay. Something told me not to worry, not to let go, but to trust in those I love. I saw us, kissing under the Heart. I felt the magic course into me, through you. You released the magic that you absorbed back into Etheria. But I... I think the magic I absorbed is still in me. Changing me. Which is why I'll go to Dryl with you. I'll trust you. I want to figure this thing out as well.'

I was staring at the ceiling, taking in everything she said. My face, the pillow, and my hair were all wet from the tears that fell silently during Catra's story. I had no idea what she had been through. But now I knew, now I could help her overcome it. I felt her hand on my cheek, pulling me to look at her. Her eyes were puffy again, she had been crying too. I was so proud of her for telling me all of this and I was about to say so, but no words came out; a lump at the back of my throat stopped me from speaking.

'Adora. I love you,' she said softly, looking into my eyes, 'I love you. I trust you.'

Her lips brushed against mine, and what followed was the sweetest kiss of my life. It wasn't hungry, or forced, or desperate. It was full of love. Hers, and mine. It was full of trust. Calm, patient, wonderful.

Catra pulled back, looking into my eyes, before cradling my head and pulling me close. I wrapped my arms around her and buried my face in her chest.

That's when I let myself cry.

A Sudden Curiosity

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Falling asleep while crying in the arms of the person you love isn't all that bad, it turns out. Especially when you wake up and they're still there, holding on to you as if you might float away if they let go. I could hear the comforting hum of Catra's purring, and I suddenly wished to see her face. Carefully, and without moving too quickly, I lifted my head away from her chest, leaving behind the sound of her heartbeat but instead being greeted by the sight of her calm, sleeping face. I reached up and rubbed some of the sleep from my eyes before opening them wider to take in the sight before me.

I had been curled up into a ball and she was curled around me, her arm around my waist and her legs up against mine. I couldn't help but stare at her face. She looked so calm, so peaceful. So beautiful. The ear that wasn't pressed to the pillow twitched every so often, but she didn't stir from her sleep. I let my eyes travel down her form. She was still wearing the grey top and shorts, so a lot of her was still on show. Her short fur was now dry, and as I gently lifted my hand to her waist I was reminded of just how soft and warm she was. I slowly lowered my head to her chest again, listening to the rhythmic drumming of her heartbeat. I could see the arm that stretched around my waist well from here, and I admired it. Catra had been especially scrawny for a long time in the Fright Zone, but now I could see there was more muscle there. Her forearm was especially well toned, and I found myself running my hand down it, feeling the contours of the muscle beneath, causing her fur to part slightly at my touch. Again, I marvelled at how soft she was. I could cuddle with her forever, never getting cold and always being comfortable.

I sighed contentedly; this was perfect. I wished this moment could last forever. Being wrapped in Catra's softness, her warmth,

her love. I decided in that moment that this was what I needed for a long life. A long life with Catra. I then allowed thoughts from before the nap to encroach on me again. Catra had told me everything, everything that was weighing her down. I now shared that burden with her and would help her carry it forever.

A thought popped into my head. A sudden curiosity. I thought about Spinnerella and Netossa and their relationship. I was fairly certain that how I felt about Catra was the same way that they felt about one another, but they each referred to the other as their "wife." They were married, I knew that much, in the same way that Angella and Micah had been married. I knew it was a way to show devotion to the other, to signify your bond to that person. Suddenly, all I could think about was...

I want Catra to be my wife.

But I didn't know how. How do you form that bond? Obviously, nothing about that had been taught in the Fright Zone, and I had never asked anyone here about it before.

I want to marry Catra.

I wondered if Glimmer would know. I wondered if she would tell me about it seriously without freaking out.

I want to be with her forever.

But was it too soon? It had only been five days since we first told each other how we felt at the Heart of Etheria. But we had known each other forever, we had loved each other forever. We had spent almost our entire lives together, so was it really too soon? Or was it just the next step?

I decided I would talk to Glimmer about it before we leave for Dryl.

All of a sudden, I was being squeezed. Both Catra's arms were around me and I could feel her cheek against the top of my head,

and I heard a contented hum rise from deep within her chest. 'Are you awake?' She asked, her voice quiet and sleepy.

I smiled, wrapping my arm around her, 'Yeah, I'm awake.'

'You cried for a long time,' she said, chuckling.

'So did you.' I looked up at her, my gaze immediately meeting those gorgeous blue and gold eyes.

She whispered, 'You started it.'

'I had a good reason.'

'Did you?'

'You know I did.'

'Yeah, I suppose hearing my entire life's trauma at once will do that to you.'

I lifted my hand up to her cheek, 'How do you feel?'

Her hand moved up to mine and her fingers drew small circles on the back of my hand, 'Honestly? I feel great. It felt great to talk about it all like that. I feel... safer now, somehow. Lighter.'

'That's good.' I slowly moved my hand up into her hair.

'What about you? Was it too much?'

'At first, I suppose so. I didn't realise quite how much there would be but... I'm glad you told me. I'm happy to share your burden. I'm happy that you trusted me with it. I feel more connected to you now than ever, like there's nothing left for me to learn. No more mystery. Just you, and all the time in the world.'

Catra smiled into my hand, and I swear I could see a tear forming in her eye, 'That sounds amazing. What about your burden?'

'My burden? I don't have one... I don't think.'

'Everyone has something they carry with them, Adora. Yours is definitely not just your hair envy with She-Ra.'

I considered for a minute. There were definitely things I was thinking about, like where I came from. If I still had a family out there, somewhere. The fact Catra practically confirmed my theory about her having magic now. I wanted to ask her about that, but I knew it could wait until we were in Dryl. I didn't want to spoil these moments with questions that could worry her too, especially when the time to ask them was only a day or two away.

'I do have some worries, some things I can't help thinking about. I have questions that will likely never be answered. I also have... something I want to ask Glimmer about.' I felt myself blush and my face suddenly burned, Catra definitely noticed. 'But I don't think any of it can hold a candle to your epic tale of betrayal and woe.'

Catra laughed, 'Betrayal and *woe?* If that weren't accurate, I'd punch you.'

I smiled, 'How about you kiss me instead?'

I watched as a grin spread across her face, 'Deal.'

**

Catra had eventually put our kiss on hold to mention that I stunk. It was true, I did. I hadn't changed out of the clothes from the days before and I still had sand hiding all over me. So much so, that when I got up from the bed, the duvet was littered in the fine crimson grains.

So there I was, in the bath. By order of Catra. I had filled the tub quite high and put in a little too many bubbles, causing a few of them to float over the side and onto the floor. I laid back, letting my ears rest just below the waterline but keeping my face above it. I couldn't hear anything, and I relished in the silence, thinking about nothing in particular. Catra crept into my mind's eye, disturbing my moment of thoughtlessness. I smiled; I just couldn't

keep her out of my head. I wondered if she would want to bathe with me, instead of just using the showers in here. She's probably never had a bath in her life, her only real experience of being in water was swimming and... pain. Her words flashed into my head, *"I remember walking into that pool of my own will and he... I remember screaming. The pain... I couldn't stand it..."* Maybe bathing with me could help her on her journey of overcoming that part of her past, I hoped it could. It would just be a small step, I knew that, but it could help. Replace those feelings of pain with feelings of warmth, comfort, safety. I suddenly felt a longing to see Catra again, to have her here with me.

I looked up at the ceiling. It was around mid-day now, my conversation with Glimmer had been quite early, and then after Catra told me her story we had slept for a short while. I felt a rumble within me as my stomach growled at the prospect of food. I should take Catra to get some air, some food, and then we would need to find Entrapta and ask about when we're leaving.

A knock sounded on the door. Catra?

I leant up slowly, careful not to disturb the water too much and send more bubbles flying. The door opened slowly, and Glimmer poked her head through the gap.

'Glimmer?'

She smiled, 'Hey, just came to check on you. Catra is wandering around the palace, said you'd be in here. You've been gone a while.'

'Yeah, everything's great. We just had a long nap.'

I slid back down into the water as I felt a blush encroaching on my face. My questions about marriage had immediately popped into my head at the sight of Glimmer. I hadn't expected to be given the chance to talk to her about it until much later on. I wanted to ask her about it. How to do it. If it was too soon.

'That's good. I spoke with her for a bit, she said she felt great. She looked good, like there was less troubling her. She mentioned that she agreed to go to Dryl, which is good. I also didn't really expect to see her out on her own so soon, I guess your talk went well? '

'Yeah, it was great. Well, what she said wasn't great. Though some of it was. It's great that she trusted me enough to tell me. She's also just... great. She's amazing. She told me everything and it made me feel... Glimmer, there's... There's something I wanted to ask you about...'

She gasped, 'Secret things?' I nodded and she smiled before making sure the door was closed, 'How can I help?'

After a deep breath I said, 'I wanted to ask you... about... marriage.'

I buried myself in the bubbles. A face in a sea of foamy pinkness. What was worrying me was the expression that slowly crept onto Glimmer's face. I couldn't decipher that glint in her eye, or the devilish smile that possessed her mouth.

I may regret asking.

'You want... to ask me... about marriage?' That grin never left her face. She was clearly enjoying this. I sunk into the bath, wanting to disappear.

I nodded.

'Is it about Catra?'

I nodded.

She squealed, bringing her fists up near her face and shaking them excitedly. 'I can't believe it! Well I can... but my best friend wants to ask me about marriage! And it's about her childhood friend who she's always loved!' Glimmer tried to calm herself. 'So,' she asked, still grinning, 'Anything specific you want to know?'

The bath was warm, but my face felt like it was on fire, 'I wanted to know... we were never taught about it in the Horde. I know Netossa and Spinnerella are married, Angella and Micah, Bow's dads. I know it symbolises their love for one another... but I don't know anything beyond that, really. So... yeah.'

Glimmer nodded, crossing her arms. 'I see. I see.' She found a dry shower stool and sat down, facing me, 'I can tell you the Bright Moon custom for marriage. The other kingdoms may have other methods, their own ways of doing it. But I can tell you ours.'

I nodded, 'That's okay! This is where we live, so it makes sense.'

'Okay. So,' she began, 'Marriage is sort of like a contract. But a nice one, not a scary one. It's basically a mutual and public statement of your love for one another. Many people do it because they feel it's the closest they can get to somebody. Almost like saying "I want to spend the rest of my life with you."

'It starts off as a question. One person asks the other if they will marry them. Then, if the other person accepts, it becomes a promise, called engagement.' I frowned for a second, and Glimmer noticed, 'It's not like engaging the enemy in battle, it's much more personal than that. You then decide on a time and place to marry, and you have a ceremony with the people who mean the most to you in attendance. Generally, upon proposal, that's the name of the question, if the other person accepts you give them something that means a lot to you. It can be pretty much anything, but generally it's something with importance to you personally, and you entrust it to that person. Then on the day, to solidify the marriage, they present you with something. My parents did it with rings, Spinnerella and Netossa had necklaces. What else happens during the ceremony is up to those getting married.'

Glimmer finished her explanation looking proud of herself, and then giggled excitedly before tapping her heels on the floor. 'Are you thinking about asking Catra? To marry you?'

I nodded; I liked the sound of it. It definitely felt like that could be the next step for us. 'It's not too soon?'

'Too soon? Adora, you've known each other forever, loved each other forever. If anything, now that the war's over and you've finally gotten together, it's perfect timing. But you could always wait, think on it, find the right time to ask. Do you know what to give her if she says yes?'

I wondered about that for a second, I suddenly couldn't think of anything that I owned that would be worthy enough to give to Catra if she were to agree to marry me.

'Oh!' Glimmer suddenly teleported over to my clothes, looking for something, before picking up my belt, 'How about this?'

'My belt?' I frowned, confused.

Glimmer laughed, 'No, Adora. Not the belt. The wing! You've been wearing it ever since you joined the rebellion, it would be perfect.'

That wasn't a half bad idea, I felt myself blushing from ear to ear, 'Yeah, that is perfect.'

Now all I had to do was ask.

Chapter End Notes

Hi all, the first 12 chapters were written while I waited for my A03 invite email, which took almost a month, so they've all been uploaded together.
Subsequent chapters will be uploaded every few days or so.
Thanks for reading!

The Moon Market

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had been exploring, that much was clear. The guards I asked were eager to tell me which way she went, but just as I thought I was catching up other guards would point off in a different direction. I couldn't help but wonder if she was testing me, to see how long it would take me to find her. Or if she was messing with the guards just to pass the time.

Eventually, I did find her. She was lying down on the grass near the greenhouse, Melog not far away, surrounded by the plants Shadow Weaver had been tending to while she was here. As I saw her, my pulse quickened, and I found that I was tracing the edge of the wing on my belt with my finger. Why was I nervous? I wasn't planning on just asking her to marry me straight away. I had to wait for the perfect moment. I tried to calm myself, now definitely wasn't the time. I had only just learnt what marriage was, I couldn't just ask as soon as I laid eyes on her. Though, as I got closer, I realised I was staring at her, all of her. She looked amazing as she basked in the sunlight, with her hands up behind her head and her legs stretched out lazily. Her eyes were closed, and I watched as her chest steadily rose and fell with each breath. Catra actually looked... *relaxed.* I marvelled at the sight and tried to commit it to memory. She was still wearing that sleeveless replica of her Horde uniform that Entrapta had made for her, which made perfect sense because she didn't actually own any other clothes here.

Before she had left to let me get out of the bath, Glimmer had reminded me that today was Moon Market day. The Moon Market was the biggest convention of traders on Etheria, with people coming from all over to sell their various specialty wares and food. I decided then and there that I would take Catra and have her

pick out some clothes from my favourite stall. Besides, I also had something I wanted to do, someone I wanted to see.

Melog then raised their head and made what sounded like a low gurgling noise.

A small smile encroached on Catra's lips, 'Hey, Adora.' I don't know what it is about the way she sings my name, but she definitely knows what she's doing and is fully aware of the impact it has on me. I could tell, because Catra was currently smiling the most mischievous of smiles, keeping her eyes closed.

I smiled and stood over her, using my shadow to block the sun from landing on her face. 'Hey, Catra. Did Melog tell you I was here?'

'Well, for one, I can smell soap.' She opened her eyes and looked up at me, 'Secondly, I can't think of anyone else who would walk over to me and stand still without saying anything. And yes, Melog did just make sure I knew you were staring at me.' She smirked, 'You like what you see?'

I placed a hand on my hip and felt a small blush make itself known on my cheeks, 'Pfft... I mean... *Yeah*. Of course.'

She laughed and sprang swiftly to her feet. 'Damn right you do,' she said, wrapping her arms around my shoulders and leaning her face up towards mine.

I wrapped one arm around her waist and used my other hand to run my fingers through her hair, before closing the distance between us and feeling the warmth of her lips on mine.

I could tell something had changed about Catra, because she kissed me without holding back, without reservations, without worry. I felt how at ease she was through the way she accepted me wholeheartedly, her tail wrapping around my waist. Our lips parted and I felt her tongue clash with mine. I continued to hold her head with one hand while letting the other slip under her top, running my fingers through the incredibly soft fur beneath. A soft

gasp escaped her as she felt my hand on her, and the kiss became faster, more passionate. I felt one of her hands tugging the elastic out of my hair before it fell to my shoulders, followed by the sensation of her fingers collecting my hair between them. Her claws weren't quite retracted, and I felt them sharp against my head; one hand formed a fist and gently pulled my hair, coaxing a sudden moan from deep within me. I opened my eyes and pulled back, looking into those beautiful mis-matched eyes.

'If you start doing that, we won't have time for what I've got planned...' I whisper, looking down her form and running my hands down her sides.

'Don't pretend like that's *not* what you've got planned,' she whispered back.

'Well... not for right now.' I smile as Catra beams at me before giving me a quick peck on the lips and turning around, picking up a well-worn leather messenger bag that I hadn't noticed. 'What's in the bag? And... where'd you get the bag?' I asked, arching an eyebrow as she slung the strap over her torso.

'It's got my First Ones tech inside, I figured I should keep it nearby in case Entrapta tries to steal it. As for where I got it, I asked Arrow Boy for a bag. He said he used to use it as a pretend... school bag? Or something... didn't need it anymore. I don't know, I just needed a bag and he gave me this. It does the job.'

I nodded and smiled to myself, recalling the time I briefly became a triple maJOR to help cover for Bow when he was still hiding who he really was.

'So, Princess. Now that we know what you have planned for *later*... what do you have planned for right now?'

Smiling, I took her hand in mine and began leading her away, 'Oh, just you wait and see.'

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Catra looked mortified.

I had led her down and out of the palace with following close behind, before steering us into the city of Bright Moon, then making for the main road. It was the widest road in Bright Moon, and as such was used to host a market once a year where folk from all the allied settlements gathered together to trade their wares.

Melog turned invisible as we neared the busy street, no doubt concentrating on keeping themselves out of the way. The sky still had that magical shine to it, which I found to be a small comfort as the sky in the Crimson Waste was anything but magical. I would have to go back eventually and thank Huntara for her help, even though she ended up getting nothing out of it. Although I suppose their food would stop dying now.

I brought myself back from my thoughts to marvel at how good the city looked already, the people had been working non-stop on the renovations and clear up, and Bright Moon looked almost as good as new. If not for the piles of rubble here and there and the odd hole in the ground. The stalls lined each edge of the street, most likely stretching on until the end of the road at the entrance to Bright Moon, and the road itself was sparsely crowded with a diverse mass of potential customers, but the numbers would grow as the market stretched into the night. There were Sea Elves from Salineas, Satyrs from Thaymor and Plumeria, Butterfly People from Elberon and Mushroomfolk from Erelandia. As well as your standard healthy mix of humans. There were even a few other Felines and Reptilians dotted throughout the crowd.

Because of the war there hadn't been a Moon Market last year. All the traders here were itching to sell some goods, hoping to pump some money back into their pockets. Unlike the majority of the stalls manned by Sea Elves, most of which had signs on or nearby that read "Profits go towards the rebuilding of Salineas, our home." I saw Catra wince when she saw those signs and remembered that she had been there with Hordak on the day of that particular attack.

I stopped, looking back at her, 'How are you doing?'

Catra looked around nervously, her ears twitching, 'There's so many people here...'

I put my hands on her shoulders, 'Catra, none of these people hate you.' I put a hand to her cheek, caressing it softly, 'Look at me, you're fine. No one is whispering about you; everyone is here to enjoy the first Moon Market in months.'

She looked at me then, and almost chuckled, 'Moon Market? What kind of name is that?'

'I'll explain it to you later,' I said before looking around. I was trying to find one of my favourite stalls, one which always had a huge variety of... there! 'Come on!' I shouted, leading her through the crowd by her hand.

I loved this stall, it always seemed to have exactly what you wanted. There were lines of tables with piles of clothes on top, seemingly just thrown there at random and not neat or orderly at all. Catra seemed sceptical.

'*This* is why we're here?' She asked while frowning at the mess.

'Yes! I figured we would have some time before we have to find Entrapta and knowing her she's probably here somewhere doing some kind of social experiment. Besides, you need some clothes, you can't keep wearing this forever,' I run my hand down her back before stopping at her hip, 'despite how good you look in it.'

I smiled victoriously when I saw the blush appear on her cheeks, 'Yeah, well... I mean, I guess it wouldn't hurt to look... wait we do even have any money?'

'Aha!' I said, reaching for my pocket and pulling out a small amulet with moon emblazoned on the front, 'This is one of the perks of being a princess in Bright Moon.' I said, holding it up to show Catra, 'I get access to the "princess fund" and can pretty much buy whatever I want.' I beamed.

'No way! They are spoiling you! No wonder you never came back!' Catra laughed, and I felt my heart ache at seeing her enjoying herself.

I shook myself from the trance, 'See that lady there?' I pointed at an old Satyr woman, sat on a rocking chair while knitting something together. Catra nodded. 'She owns the stall, she's awesome, come say hi.'

Hesitantly, Catra joins me in walking over to the ancient-looking Satyr. She had long, grey hair covering most of her face, with long winding horns forming spirals above her head. By all accounts, she was tiny, but seemed to fill the chair just fine. Her eyes were closed, with the hint of a smile on her lips. She never stopped knitting. I stood in front of her and bowed deeply, putting my hand on Catra's back and urging her to do the same.

When we rise again, Catra whispered in my ear, 'Why did we just bow?'

I look back at her, confused, 'I have no idea, everyone does it though. Must be a sign of respect, I think she's always been in this market.' Now that I looked at her, she did remind me a little of Madame Razz.

'Does she have a name?'

'Uh... Bleatrix, I think?' I turned back to the old Satyr and presented my amulet, 'Hi there! My...' I looked at Catra quizzically, not knowing what to call her. She was more than a friend, but we're not married so I can't call her my wife. I gave up. 'Catra, here, would like to pick out some clothes.' I put my hands on her shoulders, as if presenting her to the woman. 'It's Adora, by the way. The palace will cover the costs of what she picks out in my name.'

Bleatrix rocks forward in her chair once, seemingly without moving a muscle and without pausing from her knitting. I find her bewildering, and anyone you ask in the Moon Market will tell you

that they've never seen her arrive, never seen her leave, and never heard her say a word.

'I think that means "yes." Look, I'll show you what to do.' I say, leading Catra over to the nearest pile of clothes on a table. Before sticking my hand into the pile and rummaging around.

Catra looks amused, 'What *exactly* am I looking at here?'

'Just watch!' I grin excitedly, and I pull out a red jacket almost identical to my own, except without the shoulder pads.

Catra's eyes almost double in size, 'You pulled that out without looking?'

'Isn't it great?' I put the jacket against myself and look up to Catra, 'What do you think?'

She has her hand on her chin, considering, 'You should definitely get that, and wear it instead of your old one.'

I frown, 'What's wrong with this one?' I look down at the jacket I'm currently wearing.

'Oh, nothing... I just think that one could suit you more.'

I follow Catra's gaze to my shoulders, and sigh, 'Alright, fine. I'll get it, but only because you said I should.' I find a cloth bag nearby and stuff the jacket inside, before handing it to Catra, 'Here, pull some things out that suit you. Not that anything you find won't, that's kind of the point. I look forward to your fashion show. I'll be right back.' I kiss her on the cheek and start moving away, towards another of my favourite stalls.

'Wait!' Catra grabs my wrist, 'Where are you going?'

'I'm just heading to another stall; I won't be long. Got a little personal errand to run.' I tried to stop myself from smiling.

Catra seemed suspicious, but eased off her grip on my wrist, 'Alright... don't leave me here on my own for too long.'

I smiled and cupped her face with my hands before kissing her on the lips, earning a few startled glances from passers-by. 'I won't, I promise.'

Catra watched me go for a second, before turning back and facing the mound of clothes and gingerly reaching inside it. I turned to look for the stall I wanted and found it quickly. It was almost directly opposite Bleatrix's clothes stall, as it usually is, and the owner was grinning at me. She was a strong looking Sea Elf, her head resembling that of a deep-sea angler fish, with a little light glowing at the end of a unique dorsal ray protruding from her forehead. Her skin was bronze, and she had two big, claw-like hands which clasped together as she watched me approach and a wide, toothy grin possessed her face.

Her name was Anga, and we had become friends during my first Moon Market when she saw me looking lost and out of place after being separated from an overexcited Bow and Glimmer. She was a blacksmith, and her stall was filled with intricate looking plates of armour and a few small daggers. But she also dabbled in jewellery, which was inside a small case to one side. A small forge burned hot behind her, with an anvil and rack of tools stood nearby. There was also a grindstone for sharpening swords. She was known for making quick, small adjustments to things that needed a quick fix, but was also able to take items off your hands and have them repaired back in her village at her main forge, where she made all the armour on show here today. Much of it reminded me of the kind of armour Mermista wore, as much of it resembled shells or featured patterns seen in coral.

'Adora!' Anga called as I drew closer, 'It's so good to see you!' She came around the side of her stall and pulled me into a tight hug, winding me instantly.

'Ah! Hi... Anga... good to... see you... too...' I managed to say between shallow breaths as I clumsily hugged her back.

She released me and walked back around behind her stall, and I noticed she had a sign up that read "all profits go toward the rebuilding of my home." A pang of guilt shot through me as I read it, we had been too busy exposing Double Trouble at the time, and her village was one of the ones that Hordak and Catra destroyed when they took Salineas.

'I really am sorry about your village, Anga.'

'Oh, don't dwell on that, Adora! We're all fine now, getting on with rebuilding. I'm just happy I had enough supplies left over so I could open up my stall!' She released a loud, throaty laugh, 'And I suppose I have you to thank for ending the war and making all this possible.'

I held up my hands defensively, 'Oh, no! I can't take all the credit! All the other princesses helped too, including Mermista.'

Anga nodded, 'You're not wrong, but I just wanted to thank my friend for helping out anyhow. Say, you look happy, Adora. I'm glad to see you found yourself a good-looking girlfriend.'

Girlfriend? I looked back at Catra, who was sticking her arm into a different pile of clothes on Beatrix's stall. Is that what we were? *Girlfriends?* I felt myself blushing as I watched her.

Catra's my girlfriend.

Anga followed my gaze, 'Yeah, that's the one. I saw you two smooching over there, my jaw near fell off out of shock!' There was that laugh again, loud and friendly. She leant down on the table in front of her, speaking lower and quieter now, 'So what can I do you for, Adora?'

I snapped myself back to the moment, looking away from Catra and back at Anga, who was waiting patiently for me to speak. I reached into my pocket and pulled out the scale that had fallen off the snake creature in the Crimson Waste, its glossy deep orange surface shimmered in the sunlight.

Anga whistled, 'Now you don't see those very often.' She held it up as I passed it to her, examining it, 'I guess you want it making into something?'

I nodded, 'Yeah, I was thinking I might need a new belt clip soon. Y'know, just in case I lose this one...' I ran a hand over the golden wing, immediately thinking about proposing to Catra.

'Ha! You better not lose that, you little scamp.' Anga bellowed, 'I gave you that as a gift the first day we met. Cheered you right up, you've worn it ever since!' She took the scale over to another worktable and sat down, fishing through some drawers and pulling out some small tools before measuring the scale. 'This shouldn't take long.'

Leaning back on the stall table, I looked back over at Catra. She was holding something burgundy up against her torso, but I couldn't quite see what it was, exactly. Melog seemed to be watching and bobbed his head, which was followed by Catra stuffing the garment into the bag before reaching into the pile of clothes again.

Girlfriend.

I couldn't help but wonder if Catra knew about that word, the word that describes us as we are now. My mind then wandered to the closing ceremony of the Moon Market, which takes place after dark and features an aurora as the main attraction, projected from the Moonstone. It's a spectacle that can only be pulled off by the Queen as they have the closest connection to it. No wonder Glimmer kept coming to check on me this morning, she was likely distracting herself from the expectation of all these people to see, once again, those beautiful lights that shine in the sky. I had seen Angella do it plenty of times, and it really was a sight to behold. Part of me wondered if I could propose to Catra under that light show, and if she would accept.

I felt my finger tracing the edge of the wing as it hung on my belt. Maybe today would be too soon, just spending tonight watching

the lights with her would be enough. After all, I had just found out that we were girlfriends, and I wanted to be Catra's girlfriend for a little while longer.

'There you go, scamp.'

Anga roused me from my daydreaming as she passed the scale back to me, it had been fitted with the same clasp on the back as my current belt clip. Attached lengthways across the scale so that it points downwards, resembling a shield.

I smiled, 'Thanks, Anga. It looks great.' I admired it in my hand, watching it shimmer in the light before pocketing my future belt clip. 'You can charge it to the palace, as usual,' I flashed her the amulet; she knew I had it, but she had to see it anyway.

'You're not planning on losing your other one on purpose, are you?' She asked, an eyebrow raised.

I hesitated before answering, 'No I'm not, I'm... planning on giving it to someone.'

Anga grinned, looking back over at Catra. She couldn't have guessed...

She tapped the side of her nose with a sharp claw while giving me a knowing look, 'Go get 'em, tiger.'

I felt a wave of warmth flood my face. How could she have... never mind. I gave Anga my thanks once again, almost stuttering on the words, before making my way back over to Catra.

It seemed like Catra had finished as she was stood at the edge of the stall, looking out into the crowd, trying to spot me. The cloth bag hung loosely in her hands and seemed to be filled to the brim with clothes that Catra had picked out for herself. There was some kind of magic around Bleatrix's stall which meant you could only really find things that suited you, but I hadn't expected Catra to choose quite so much. I couldn't help but feel a spring in my step as I got closer, excited to see what she had picked out.

Melog noticed me first once again, nudging Catra's leg. She looked over in my direction and her eyes lit up as she saw me, an adorable smile spreading across her face. I felt a wave of giddy glee wash over me at the sight of Catra looking genuinely happy to see me.

'So... what did you find?' I asked, trying to peer into the bag as I stopped in front of her.

Catra pulled the bag back, hiding it behind her. 'I'll show you. Eventually,' she quipped, 'Is that all? Are we done here?'

I looked around, 'If you don't want to stay any longer then I guess we can go.' I shrugged, 'We really should head over to Darla and see if Entrapta is around. We need to know how long it's going to be before she's setting off.' I wished inwardly that it would be at least tomorrow so I could experience the Moon Market closing ceremony with Catra.

'Alright then, let's go.' Her eagerness to leave was not masked in the slightest.

I waved my thanks to Bleatrix who just rocked forwards on her chair in response, and I led Catra through the crowd back toward the palace.

But we didn't get far.

My nose and growling stomach had given away how hungry I was, and we ended up sampling various foods from a huge variety of vendors who seemed genuinely happy to see people eating and enjoying their food once again.

Catra had to practically drag me away from plenty of other stalls in the market too, one in particular had a knife that was just *asking* to be kept under my pillow. But Catra argued that her claws would be better than a knife any day, to which I responded, 'Are you saying that you'll be in bed with me *every day* from now on? To protect me?'

She fumbled over her words after that, as her face steadily turned redder, 'Well... I mean... I guess... if you want me there... I would like to be. Haven't we shared a bed every night since I told you I loved you anyway?'

A Mushroomfolk couple walking nearby chorused an "Aww" as they overheard us and Catra immediately tensed, embarrassed that someone overheard her, but relaxed as I placed my hand on her cheek.

I didn't think it would be possible to love someone this much, and I pressed my lips to hers before whispering, 'We have. And I love you too.'

'You're such a sap.' She whispered, and I could hear the low hum of a purr above the hubbub of the crowd as I rested my forehead against hers.

'Don't pretend you don't love it.' I replied, kissing her again. And again. And again.

'Adora...' I saw a nervous smile take over her mouth, 'We're in the middle of a market...' her ears twitched, 'People are starting to notice that I'm being kissed by She-Ra.'

It was true, a small crowd had started gathering. Everyone had started whispering gossip about Adora, saviour of Etheria, kissing Catra, ex-horde soldier. I couldn't help but chuckle, 'I guess all of Etheria is going to know we're together now.'

Catra sighed, 'You're such an idiot.' She leant in to kiss me again, just as Melog appeared at her side and turned us invisible, hiding us from our little audience and allowing us to escape unseen.

Chapter End Notes

Anga is based on a background character seen in three short scenes on the boat at the start of S4:E8 Boys' Night Out.

Aurora

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With Melog's help we were able to get away from the market without anyone noticing, before making our way towards Darla and, hopefully, Entrapta. The streets of Bright Moon were quiet now compared to the market, as the daylight began to fade. This heralded the busiest time for the market, and it wouldn't be long now until Glimmer had to amplify the Moonstone's power to cause an aurora to appear in the sky, as was tradition. I made a mental note to check in on her after finishing up here, just to make sure she wasn't too nervous.

It didn't take long for us to reach the palace courtyard which served as a temporary landing area for Darla. Wrong Hordak was stood at the foot of the ship's ramp, looking up inside it. As he saw us approaching his face displayed a huge grin.

'Brothers!' He exclaimed, swinging his arms wide and dropping the crate of components he had been holding with a clatter, the contents spilling out over the stone slabs. He winced at the sound it made, before bending down and starting to pick up the bits and pieces that had fallen out of the crate.

'Will you be careful!' A deep voice bellowed from inside the ship, 'I gave you a simple task, to hold that crate and stand still! Don't say you are incapable of such a simple...' The voice stopped as its origin paused halfway down the ramp. Hordak looked identical to Wrong Hordak now, especially without the cloak, but his expression and anger singled him out immediately. He regarded us with a passive curiosity, 'Ah, Adora, and Force Captain Catra. Entrapta has been anticipating your visit for some time.'

'Do NOT! CALL ME THAT!' Catra yelled. She caught me off guard and I almost jumped back out of surprise, but I was able to stand

my ground and placed a reassuring hand on her shoulder. Melog had started glowing red and sharp behind us, growling. Catra took a deep breath, placing her palms together in front of her face before lowering them. 'Please,' she continued, calmly, 'It's just Catra.'

Hordak seemed almost amused, the hint of a smile tugging at the corner of his mouth. 'Very well, *just* Catra.'

I beamed. Hordak had just made a joke. I turned to see that Catra was much less enthusiastic about it than me, and she started heading off towards the palace. 'Just come find me when you're done, Adora. I need to put this bag down.'

I ran after her when I realised how far away she had managed to get so quickly, grabbing her wrist before she could go any further, stopping her in her tracks. 'What?' She barked, but I didn't reply. Instead, I spun her around and held her face in my hands before pressing my lips against hers, causing her to drop the bag full of clothes.

'Did you think you could just walk away without kissing me?' I asked, melting under her surprised gaze.

Finding her composure was something Catra was getting better at, annoyingly. 'What's gotten into you, Adora?' She whispered softly, stroking a loose strand of hair behind my ear. 'You've been kissing me all day.'

I smiled and pressed our foreheads together, 'Maybe it's because I want to. Maybe it's because I've always wanted to.' I kissed her again gently, 'Maybe I never want to stop.'

Catra bit her lip and whispered hungrily, 'Never stop,' before initiating a longer, deeper kiss than before. Time always seemed to slow down when Catra kissed me, but every time she pulled away I felt as if it was too soon, 'But maybe we shouldn't make a habit of doing it in wide open spaces in the middle of a city.' She grinned, before peeling herself off of me and picking the bag back

up off the floor and adjusting the other bag on her shoulder. 'I'll be in your room,' she sung back to me as she started walking away again, Melog following close behind.

'It's *OUR* room!' I shouted back, smiling.

I want to marry her.

After watching Catra enter the palace I turned and walked back towards Darla, smiling to myself. Something about deciding that I would propose to Catra one day, perhaps soon, made me feel like kissing her all the time. It was a hard feeling to pin down, but it was even harder to resist kissing Catra. Which is why I just let myself go for it a bunch today, she never shied away after all, even in front of all those people. It definitely wouldn't be long before news travelled, merchants and traders lived for this kind of gossip to share over their next deal at their next destination.

Hordak was watching Wrong Hordak closely as he carried the box of components into the ship, putting it down next to a huge pile of other strange looking machinery and crates filled with tech. Then it occurred to me that Entrapta still wasn't anywhere in sight. 'Hey, uh... Hordak,' he looked down at me from the top of the ramp, 'Is Entrapta here?'

Hordak narrowed his gaze, 'No. However, she implored that she would be back soon.'

Shrugging, I decided to wait. I hopped up the ramp, deciding to have a look around Darla to pass the time. To say it was a mess was an understatement, especially considering how tidy the ship was before Entrapta was given the all clear to tinker with it. Now, panels lay on the floor with wires spilling out of the walls. Not to mention that the ship was also currently being loaded with all the equipment that Entrapta had been using while in Bright Moon. The majority of it was just crates of tech she had collected, including a couple of broken up Horde drones. I picked my steps carefully through Darla's main corridor, being careful not to trip over anything important.

Arriving on the bridge, I looked around at the chaos that was the computer systems. Whatever Entrapta was doing to Darla, it went deep. She may even be rewiring the entire ship, top to bottom. I sat in the chair in the centre of the bridge, the captain's chair, the same place Mara had sat centuries before. But that thought flickered and dimmed in my mind's eye as I was reminded of Catra leaping over and sitting in my lap, trying to distract me. It had worked, and I had still been distracted long after she got up.

A deep voice sounded from behind me, startling my thoughts back to the present, 'Adora. Do not be alarmed.' Hordak walked around the chair slowly, before stopping in front of me. 'I had hoped we might... clear the air between us, considering you'll be accompanying Entrapta, my brother, and myself to Dryl.'

I looked him over quizzically. The ex-leader of the Horde, someone I worked to please for 18 years of my life, was now stood before me asking to clear the air. I laughed at the fantastically bizarre nature of how we came to be here, in this moment, before clearing my throat and nodding. 'Yeah, sure. Why not? I'll just have a heart to heart with my ex-boss. I've definitely had stranger things happen.'

Hordak made a grunting sound I couldn't quite decipher, before grabbing a nearby crate and planting it a short distance in front of my chair. Then, he sat on it, facing me. 'I have had a long time to think,' be began, choosing his words carefully, 'I don't believe I have ever directly caused you harm. I was always obsessed with the notion of making my brother proud. Getting a message to him, showing him what I was capable of after he cast me out.' He paused, 'I found you, on your own, in the middle of nowhere, after tracking the energy signature of a portal. I took you back to the Fright Zone with me and gave the order for you to be put with the other orphans in the infirmary. However, Shadow Weaver sensed something in you, and took you in as her own. I can only... apologise... for the way she treated you, the way she treated Catra. I was too blinded by own ambition to pay any mind to what she was doing. The way I am now, the person I am trying

to be - for Entrapta - would never stand by and allow such things to happen.'

He held my gaze while he spoke, and I could tell it was something he had been contemplating for a while. Hordak, the ex-leader of the Horde, the man who caused pain and anguish to flood across Etheria for decades... was sat in front of me on a crate, dejected, apologising for the way I was treated. I could tell he was trying to change and Entrapta had certainly had a powerful influence on him to elicit this kind of response.

'Listen, Hordak...' I began, 'I never did meet you while I was in the Horde. You would always speak through Shadow Weaver. But I know that you *did* hurt Catra after I left and a part of me will never forgive you for that; and if I know Catra, she won't either. I do appreciate that you're trying to change, and I think it's sweet that you're doing it for Entrapta. She's lucky to have a lab partner who cares about her as much as you do.'

Hordak looked down at the floor between us and seemed to be considering what I said. 'Would Catra listen... if I tried to apologise?'

I leant back in the chair, resting my head against the firm backrest. 'I don't know. But you'll have a lot of chances to talk to her, maybe you could get through to her eventually.'

'Very well.' He stood up, apparently content with the outcome of our little conversation, and moved to return the crate to where it had been before.

As he placed it down, I heard the clanking of metal on metal steadily getting louder. The door slid open just fast enough to allow Emily to charge through the door unobstructed onto the bridge, Entrapta sat atop the bot holding a rattling crate above her head.

'HORDAK!' She squealed, before leaping off of Emily and using her hair to rush over to him. 'Look what I found in the market!

Random bits of tech I'll probably never need! Isn't this exciting! After observing the people trading, I decided to have a go myself!'

Hordak did not look impressed with the contents of the crate, and instead coughed pointedly while motioning towards where I was sat with his hand.

Entrapta whirled around on her hair, before looking genuinely confused to see me there. 'Adora? What are you doing here? We're not leaving for Dryl until the morning.'

I stood up, completely taken aback by her limitless energy, 'I was just wondering when we're leaving for Dryl?'

'I just told you, in the morning.'

I facepalmed. 'Yes. You did. Uh... okay. How long are we staying? And what's the plan regarding Catra's First Ones tech?'

She put the crate down before forming her hair into a seat and perching on it, 'Well, I'm going to need to scan her for a start. Possibly compare the readings to other magical entities, such as yourself. It would also be greatly appreciated if you could somehow make her do it again!'

'Do what again?'

'Use the tech! I don't know how it was triggered last time, but my hypothesis from what I've pieced together is that it was not intentional. What you need to do is have Catra use the tech intentionally and, in theory, effectively. Then I can *really* start to see how it works!'

I considered for a moment. It would be good for Catra to learn to use the tech properly, and I would be lying if I said I wasn't curious to find out what else it could do. 'Alright, fine.' I stated, 'I'll talk to Catra and see how she feels, but I'm on board.'

'GREAT!' Shouted Entrapta, her voice echoing around the bridge, 'I'll see you in the morning bright and early! Oh, and to answer

your earlier question, you can stay as long as you want but the longer you stay the more research I can do!'

'We'll see, Entrapta. See you tomorrow!' I waved my goodbyes before making my way out of the ship, Wrong Hordak winked at me as I left. I let him have that one, he seemed to enjoy it.

It was dark out now, which meant that Glimmer would be preparing for the closing ceremony of the Moon Market. I decided I would pay her a visit to check up on her and see how she was doing. She would no doubt be nervous and would be feeling the pressure of wanting to pull off a flawless aurora. It would be her first time doing it, as the last time a Moon Market was held was a couple of months before Queen Angella never came back from the portal reality.

There was a certain eerie atmosphere to the palace at night and seeing the halls drenched in shadow always sent shivers down my spine, briefly awakening a deep-rooted paranoia that any of them could stand upright at any minute and berate me about my shoelaces being tied wrong. I hurried my pace, hunting through the palace for any sign of life. Eventually, I reached the throne room and discovered why the rest of the palace seemed so empty. It was fully lit, with guards lining the walls. I spotted Micah off to one side, talking to an attendant. He smiled and snuck a small wave at me before pointing further back, singling out Glimmer and Bow who were talking nearer the thrones. I shot him a smile and a nod before making my way across the floor towards them.

Glimmer shone a huge smile at me once she spotted me and teleported closer, before wrapping me in a huge hug. 'Adora!'

I hugged her back, being careful not to stumble, 'Woah! What's happening?'

Bow came over and let out a sigh, 'Glimmer has been freaking out since we came up here, the nerves are getting too much – I've been trying to calm her down but nothing I say seems to help.'

I pulled back from our hug and locked eyes with Glimmer, staring into her soul. She stared back, obviously not expecting this sudden intense eye contact. 'Glimmer,' I started, making my voice sound as stern as I could, 'You're the Queen of Bright Moon. If anyone can do this, it's you! I believe in you, and I know Angella would too. Just channel all your feelings into that Runestone, and I'm sure you'll be able to put on an amazing first show that no one out there will forget anytime soon.'

Glimmer nodded, 'Channel my feelings... I can do that...' She pulled out of the hug and turned to face Bow. 'I think I need a boost,' she whispered, before wrapping her arms around him and pulling him close, pressing their lips together gently. Bow soon eased into it too, wrapping his arms around her and holding her to him. I suppressed an excited yelp. This was the first time I had seen them kissing, but it soon became apparent that it was going to go on for a lot longer than I thought it would. I looked around the room, smiling nervously, wondering if I should just leave. A few of the guards had noticed and were trying not to look whereas Micah had his back turned entirely, still talking to that attendant who had noticed and was looking wide-eyed over Micah's shoulder.

I took a few steps backwards, inching away from them, and almost jumped when Glimmer turned to look at me. She laughed and looked apologetic, 'Sorry, Adora. Thank you for your help, I feel much better.'

'I feel like Bow did most of the work there,' I insisted, holding my hands up in defence.

'Even so,' replied Glimmer, 'You gave me the idea.'

'Well, glad I could help.' I gave her another quick hug, 'You'll do great.'

She smiled and squeezed me back, 'Thanks, Adora. Now go, I can tell you're itching to go find Catra. Where is she anyway?'

'Unless she's wandering around again, she should be in our room. We'll have a good view of the city from there too, so we should be able to see the aurora when its time.' Glimmer looked at me with a look that suggested she knew otherwise, 'No, Glimmer! We will be watching! I'll make sure of it!'

Glimmer laughed, 'It's okay, Adora. I won't be offended if you're busy.'

'It's your first Moon Market aurora, I wouldn't miss it for anything.'

Bow's eyes suddenly lit up as he remembered something, 'Adora!' He whispered as quietly as he could through his excitement, 'When are you proposing to Catra? Have you done it already?'

I felt my face heat up instantly and Glimmer gave me an apologetic look while mouthing "sorry."

'I... I, uh...' I struggled to fine the words and placed my hand on the back of my neck, suddenly feeling quite shy, 'I haven't yet, I'm going to wait for the right moment. I've decided I want to be her girlfriend for a little while longer first.'

Glimmer and Bow exchanged excited looks before pulling me into a hug.

'I'm so happy for you, Adora!' Giggled Glimmer, burying her face into my shoulder.

'You make such a good couple!' Bow wailed, seemingly on the verge of tears.

I couldn't help but laugh at the sudden show of support, squeezing the both of them back as hard as I could, 'Thank you, guys. You're the best.'

'Of course we are,' said Bow, leaning back, 'We're the best friend squad!'

Eventually, I was able to peel myself away from the crushing embrace of my two best friends and promptly left the throne room in search of Catra. I felt giddy, excited. I wasn't sure why, but I felt the urge to wrap Catra up in my arms, bury my face in her fur and never let go. The hallways seemed less spooky this time around, as I practically skipped towards our shared bedroom. It didn't take long before I was outside the door. I pressed my ear against it, I could hear Catra mumbling, probably talking to Melog. I smiled to myself, before swinging the door open and being greeted by a sight that made my face heat up immediately.

Catra was stood in front of the mirror, wearing nothing but a pair of black underwear and a black bra. This was nothing like the usual grey shorts and top she had been wearing and was nothing like the undergarments we were supplied in the horde. This showed off a lot more of her, and I couldn't help but stare. Catra was usually fast, but my sudden entrance had frozen both her and Melog to the spot, and it took a second for her to process what was happening. Once her mind caught up, she let out an embarrassed yell before diving under the covers of the bed. Melog simply laid back down, in a way that seemed almost amused.

That was not what I had been expecting. I slowly closed the door behind me before clumsily stepping over towards the bed, eyeing up the open bag of clothes near the mirror and her black and red Horde clothes in a pile nearby. She must have gotten bored of waiting and decided to try on some of the clothing she had picked out from Bleatrix's stall. Catra steadily repositioned herself, poking half her head out of the top of the duvet and watching me. Her face was as bright red as mine must be.

'Hey, Adora...' It was almost a whisper, and I had definitely caught her off guard.

I smiled, and found that I couldn't stop, 'Hey... you okay?'

Catra nodded slowly, before grumbling, 'You could have at least knocked!'

I slowly sat on the end on the bed, facing away from her, and started taking off my jacket. 'I didn't think I would need to knock,' I said as I started taking off one of my boots.

I felt the bed dip slightly behind me and stopped to centre myself. I couldn't help but smile as I imagined Catra crawling along the bed towards me. I didn't look round, instead letting her have this moment. I leant down to start taking off the other boot, and once I had finished, placing them neatly side-by-side at the foot of the bed, that's when I felt it. That warmth I loved so much. Catra pressed herself up against me, her arms slowly wrapping around my waist, her face against my neck.

'You... you don't have to...' she whispered.

I felt a shiver course through me as I felt her breath on my neck, and then I let out a gasp as her fangs brushed against my skin. 'Catra...'

'Do you like what I'm wearing, Adora?' She teased; her confidence restored. I was tense as I felt her fangs slowly moving across my neck.

'Mhm...' was the only sound I could make at that moment, before I managed to say, 'I do... you look amazing... I... I want to see you again...'

'You do?'

I nodded.

'I don't know...'

I groaned, 'Catra...'

Her hands edged down towards the base of my top, careful working their way under the fabric. They were so warm, so soft...

A flash from outside brought me back to reality, and I suddenly remembered about the aurora. 'Wait!' I yelled, 'We have to watch

Glimmer's aurora!' I jumped up from the bed and ran to the balcony, looking across towards the Moonstone.

I couldn't see Glimmer from here, but I could see the Runestone pulsing with energy. Glimmer was pouring everything she had into it, all her strength, her feelings, and emotions. The sight that unfolded next reminded me of the Crystal Castle's beacon. The Moonstone beamed a surge of light into the sky, before it exploded far above like a firework, brilliant flashes of colour lit up the sky in a dazzling display of magic, joining with the energy that was already present in the sky and making it all the more impressive. Then, as the beam of light faded, the magic settled into slowly waving streaks of light that seemed to stretch across the horizon. Every time I saw it, I was amazed, and this time knowing my friend was the one that created it made it even more impressive. I was frozen in wonder as I watched the colour dance across the twilight, then felt a surge of pride that Glimmer was able to pull it off. I then felt a warmth covering my shoulders as the duvet was draped over me. Catra was behind me again and wrapped her arms around my waist while looking up into the sky. She had been stood behind me, watching in awe, and now surrounded us both the warmth of the bedding.

'What is this?' She wondered out loud.

'It's the closing ceremony for the Moon Market,' I explained, 'It only happens once a year, so the Queen of Bright Moon puts on a show for all those who came.'

'Huh. Good job, Sparkles.'

No longer being able to look away, I turned around to face her, making sure not to knock the duvet from around us. I closed my eyes and leant into her, letting my hands travel. She purred as I explored her, brushing over her new underwear, weaving my fingers between her fur. I felt her grip tighten around me as I dug in my fingers, applying pressure. I started kissing her collarbone, and worked my up her neck, satisfied with the noises she was making as I went. Then I leant back and looked into her eyes, my

arms around her waist and her arms around my shoulders. The aurora danced above us, its colours spectacular and its form extraordinary.

But all I was looking at in that moment was Catra. Looking into those eyes that make my heart melt.

Ask her.

I shook the thought away. I had decided not to, not yet.

But she looks so beautiful...

Ask her to marry you.

I gulped and started to speak before I could stop myself, 'Catra...'

She tilted her head quizzically, 'Hm?'

'Catra... will... will you...'

She smiled, and I found myself entranced by it, 'Will I what, dummy? Use your words.'

'I... Catra...' I leant forwards and kissed her before I could speak any more. She kissed me back, welcoming my lips on hers. 'Catra... I love you.'

'I love you too, Adora. Now let's go back inside before I catch a cold.' She pulled back, taking the duvet and wrapping it around herself before heading back into the room.

I sighed and looked up at the aurora, putting my hand on my chest. My hands were shaking, and my heart felt like it was going to beat out of my chest. I had never felt that nervous before in my entire life. I jumped on the spot a couple of times to regain some control over my legs, which were seconds away from turning to jelly.

'This may be the most difficult thing I've ever had to do,' I whispered to myself, looking up at the swirling magic in the sky. It really was a sight to behold, and watching it helped me to calm my raging nerves.

'Adora!' I always loved the way Catra says my name, 'If you don't come back soon I'm going to get changed!'

'Don't you dare!' I called back, before heading back inside.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading so far and I hope you're enjoying the story!
Follow me on Instagram @iorekofthehorde for updates or to let me know what you think!

Stay Close to me

I couldn't sleep.

I stared at the ceiling, watching the reflection of the aurora as it bounced off the pool of water into the room. It looked like the whole room was underwater, as the colourful light waved across the walls. I never did get a response from Glimmer about what that waterfall pool was actually for, or why it was part of my room. She would always laugh and shake her head, as if I had told a funny joke.

Catra laid on her side, facing away from me, radiating an endless supply of warmth. I looked down what I could see of her neck and back before my wandering gaze was blocked by the duvet.

We had... made out. A lot. Catra had then stripped off her underwear and relinquished me of my clothes, before teasing me for a while and then, after giving me a devilish grin, decided that it was time to sleep. I had never felt frustration like it, to just be left hanging after so much build up... Catra had fallen asleep quickly, and normally I would have too, but the combination of only being teased with the fact I couldn't stop my mind from racing about how I had almost proposed earlier was keeping me awake.

Will you marry me?

It seemed like such an easy question, but it had almost bested me. Waiting and being her girlfriend was still my plan, but in that moment she had looked so beautiful that I almost asked her then and there. I hadn't even managed to say all the words but I had started shaking, my knees almost giving way and my heart pounding out of my chest. I greatly underestimated what it takes to ask that question and I felt a newfound source of respect for Micah and Spinnerella, who had been the ones to ask. I wasn't sure which of Bow's dads had proposed, but I guessed it could have been Lance. Or George. Either of them could have, actually.

Breaking from that line of thought I instead thought back to Catra and my question. My lingering question. Patience was not one of my strong suits, but I would have to wait. Wait for the right moment.

I could tell this was going to hang over me, but I couldn't worry about it too much. The moment would arrive, and I would know it when it did.

Catra was breathing slowly, deeply, probably lost in a sea of dreams. I cast my mind toward her and wondering what she could be dreaming about. Unable to picture anything I smiled, just hoping that I was in it somewhere and we were happy.

Flashes of red suddenly started appearing across the room, illuminating it far more than the pool's reflection did. I sat up, and saw that it was Melog, flashing an angry red periodically in their sleep. But if Melog was turning red then that means...

Catra. Her breathing had suddenly become more erratic, I had only just looked at her and she had seemed fine. Small whimpers escaped her and her whole body started twitching, her legs jutted out at random angles sporadically. Was she running from something in the dream? I didn't know what to do. She had mentioned that she still had nightmares, but I had never been awake to see one.

'No... no...'

Sleep talking was something I had never seen her do before either, the words sent a pang of worry shooting through me.

'No... A-Adora...'

My name? What was the nightmare about? I looked around the room as if trying to find something that would help. Melog was still asleep but was glowing a fierce scarlet.

'No... stop... Adora!'

I swallowed my worry and moved up behind her, wrapping my arm around her and pressing myself up against her.

'I'm here...' I whispered, 'I'm here.'

A few seconds passed, and I thought the nightmare must have subsided.

All of a sudden Catra sat upright and shouted, 'Adora!' Now wide awake she gasped for breath, wiping sweat from her forehead. Seeming confused of her surroundings she looked around the room, taking it in, reminding herself of where she was.

I sat up and wrapped my arms around her from behind. She yelped, not expecting the contact, but I held on. 'It's just me, Catra. I'm here.'

Her hands held mine and I felt her body start to shake, and something dripped on my arm. She was crying...

'Adora...' she turned and wrapped her arms around me, crying into the crook of my neck. I held her, stroking one hand through her hair and keeping the other firm against her, holding her close. I tried to spot Melog, but they had vanished.

'I'm here, Catra. I'm okay. You're okay.' I felt her claws dig into my back as she cried, and we stayed like that for a while. I let her cry for as long as she needed. Tears started to fall from my eyes too, it wasn't easy listening to person you love cry their eyes out while clinging onto you. Just this morning I had done the same thing, crying into Catra as she held onto me. We were such a mess.

When it seemed the worst had past, when her cries had quietened, her claws retracted, and her hands started slowly stroking the scars on my back; I smiled a gentle smile and whispered, 'I love you.'

Slowly, Catra moved back from my embrace, keeping her arms around me. Her eyes glistened in the twilight. I had never seen her look so vulnerable before, her ears had never been lower. She

looked into my eyes, not averting her gaze, 'Say it again,' she whispered.

'I love you,' I whispered in response. Smiling as her ears twitched and started to rise.

'Again.'

'I love you.'

'Again.'

'I love you, Catra.'

Tentatively, her face moved closer to mine, until our noses were side-by-side and her amazing eyes were all I could see, glowing in the partial darkness. 'Again.'

I smiled and stroked my hands up her back, relishing in how soft she was and how her fur felt as it shifted under my fingers. 'I love you, Catra, and I always will.'

A smile spread across her mouth and I felt my heart flutter in my chest. 'Adora...' she whispered, before gently pressing our lips together.

The kiss was slow, calm, reassuring. I kissed her with all the love I could muster, hoping to let her know through it that that she was safe, I was okay, and I wouldn't be going anywhere.

I hadn't noticed when, but I suddenly became aware that Catra was sat in my lap with her legs wrapped around my waist and her arms around my shoulders. I was kissing upwards, which was new, as I was slightly taller than her so would usually be the one kissing down. She felt so warm against me, so soft. I pulled her closer, pressing us together as much as I could.

Loss flooded over me when she pulled back from the kiss, but when I looked at her I didn't mind. Her hands trailed through my loose hair, massaging my head. I closed my eyes and rested my

head against her chest, listening to her heartbeat. My hands trailed down her back and along her thighs, before repeating the journey, there and back.

'Do you...' I started, nervous at how she would respond, 'Do you want to talk about it?'

I felt her take a deep breath, her chest rising and falling against my head, 'Do you really want to know?'

'I think it will help. It's okay if you don't want to.'

'Hmm.' Catra was quiet for a moment, 'Okay.'

Catra moved her legs from behind me, straddling me, before pushing me back so I was lying down again. Then she joined me, resting her head against my chest, our legs intertwining. A hand rested on my torso and her tail latched onto my leg. Her fingers started tracing imaginary lines across my stomach, my chest, my neck, before working their way down again. I pulled the duvet up to cover us, before kissing Catra on the forehead.

'Comfy?' I asked.

'Very.'

We laid like that for a while and I held onto her, cradling her in my arm.

'It was about you.' Catra whispered.

'Me?'

She nodded, 'You were there. You've never been in one of my nightmares before.

'It was Horde Prime's ship. I watched as he lowered you into the green pool. I started running towards you, but I couldn't get any closer. I was running on the spot, as fast as I could but I couldn't reach you. The clones were chanting; you were shouting for help.

Then I was turned around and Shadow Weaver was there. She was the one holding me back from you. *"This is for the best,"* she said. Then I was turned around again and watched as Prime activated the machine. You started screaming as the pain took over and then I felt it too. Then I was the one in the pool and... and then I woke up and you were there. You were okay.'

'Are all your nightmares similar?'

She shook her head, 'No.'

'I'm here for you, Catra. It will help to talk about them.'

Her breath staggered for a second as she took in a deep breath.

'In one of them, I was surrounded by everyone. All the princesses, our squad from the Horde. Even Double Trouble. We were all laughing, joking, having fun. Then wherever we were darkened, and everyone stopped talking. Their eyes went black and they stood around me in a circle. It was quiet, I didn't know what was happening. Then they all started shouting. Shouting at me for every bad thing I've done. Every misstep was hurled at me with angry voices. They all spoke at once, but I could hear each of them perfectly. I think I was on the floor, curled up. I tried to cover my ears, but I couldn't drown them out. Then they all stopped at once, before turning around and walking in straight lines away from me. I followed after Scorpia, pleading, and apologising for everything. She stopped, looked me in the eye and said, *"you're a bad friend,"* before disappearing. Then I was alone, in a crushing black void. I felt like I couldn't breathe, I was panicking... and that was it, I woke up.'

'Catra...'

'Yeah?' She asked, looking up at me.

'Your nightmares are terrifying.'

She scoffed, 'Tell me about it.'

I ran a hand through her hair, 'No one hates you anymore. No one's trying to hurt you, to hurt me. We're okay.'

'I know, Adora. I know. I can't help what I dream about.'

'None of it is your fault, Catra. We were manipulated our whole lives, raised to be fighters who survived by whatever means necessary. Even after I left the Horde, I was still used. Light Hope lied to me, hid things from me, almost made me destroy Etheria and the entire universe. If I hadn't broken that sword...'

'Is this you telling me about your burden?' She whispered.

I laughed, 'Don't ruin it.'

'Sorry, Princess.' I felt her hand travel down my chest, to my waist, across my hips before resting on my thigh.

I closed my eyes and continued, 'The pressure to be She-Ra was enormous. To be a saviour to everyone. I didn't even realise it at the time, but I was so stressed out for so long that it became almost normal. I remember feeling so tired, but I had to fight.' I laughed, 'I had to stop whatever plot you were cooking up next. You really kept me on my toes.'

Catra laughed too, 'Yeah, sorry. I just really wanted to best you. To prove to myself that I didn't need you. But I always needed you.'

I looked down at her, 'I remember when we took Darla from you in the Crimson Waste, I think your face got scratched and I trapped you behind a grate. How did you get out of that?'

A mischievous giggle sounded from within her, 'That wasn't me, Dummy. It was Double Trouble's audition.'

I put my other hand over my eyes, 'You're joking...'

'No, they are scarily good at impersonating people. Especially if they spend long enough around you. I don't know whether I

should be offended you thought you could win in a one-on-one against me.'

'As She-Ra? Of course I could.'

'Pfft, get over yourself! We both know I'm faster. And besides, that old She-Ra had such massive hair that it gave you a huge blind spot.'

'It was big wasn't it? I never really felt comfortable in that form. I much prefer the new She-Ra.'

'Hmm. Me too.'

'You do? Why?'

Catra looked up at me and stroked a hand down my cheek. The light from the aurora was fading now, and the room had gotten steadily darker. Catra's eyes shone as bright as ever. 'Because she looks like you. She is you.'

I wrapped both my arms around her and squeezed, 'Bow is right you know, you are cute.'

Catra started to purr, I felt my heart squeeze. 'Whatever you say, Adora. And if you ever want to talk about anything else, I'll listen. You listened to me this morning and it helped, so I want to do the same for you.'

'Thank you, Catra. Honestly, I've never stopped to think about myself, at all really.'

'I know, Adora. That's just the kind of person you are, always throwing yourself out there to protect other people. Now that the war is over, you have to think about protecting yourself too, before whatever weighs you down catches up to you.'

I closed my eyes, thinking. I really hadn't cared for my own health, my own safety, at all before. I always wanted to

protect... *everyone.* 'Okay... I'll think on it some more and then I'll tell you.'

Catra yawned, 'Sounds good, Princess.'

'Come on, let's get some sleep. We're heading to Dryl tomorrow. Stay close to me, I'll protect you from the nightmares.'

Catra nuzzled into my neck, kissing it gently. 'I'm not going anywhere.'

The Long Game

It's been two days since we arrived in Dryl.

One thing I found strange as we first stepped off of Darla was seeing everything covered in magical plants. The last time I was here it was a rocky wasteland and the city was dull and lifeless, but now there was life and little critters everywhere. Winged creatures flew through the skies which still shone with that magical aura. I remember absentmindedly wondering at one point if it would settle one day, or whether we would have beautiful skies forever now...

For the majority of our first day in Dryl, we all helped to unload the endless crates of tech and machinery from Darla. I had been surprised to see that Entrapta was able to mostly put Darla back together again overnight before we set off. Each of us stacked the crates in the Crypto Castle's courtyard while Entrapta rummaged through them, sorting the contents into different crates before handing them off to a line of waiting robots. For all intents and purposes, we were like a well-oiled machine. Entrapta's kitchen staff, the Baker, Soda Pop, and Busgirl also came back with us and they've been busy making tiny food alongside Wrong Hordak since we arrived. For whatever reason, the Horde never cleared out their supplies from Dryl when they ended their occupation, so the courtyard was still filled with the remains of their camp, tanks, skiffs, and weaponry. Entrapta insisted on keeping it there so that she could study it some more, and we were happy to oblige as there was really nowhere else to put it.

During day two, Entrapta asked for some time to herself so that she could set up the various experiments and tests she wanted to run on Catra and her First Ones tech. So, not having anything else to do, Catra and I spent the day sparring. After a while, Hordak asked if he could join. Catra refused to spar with him at first, but I agreed. After all, I knew he was trying to change for the better and wanted to give him the benefit of the doubt. As it turns out, Hordak is actually quite skilled both in hand-to-hand combat and

with the training batons left behind by the Horde. I had never had the chance to fight him head-on before, and I initially struggled to keep up with him. He explained that since Horde Prime *"renewed"* him he had felt stronger, faster, and much more agile than before but had not been given the chance to do more than stand guard until now.

Eventually, Catra gave in and agreed to spar with Hordak. I couldn't keep my eyes off her, she was so fast, darting around him and firing blow after blow his way. I knew she had fought him before, and won, but he seemed to be holding his own this time. He was able to block most of her strikes and by comparison was using far less stamina. After a while, I could tell Catra was enjoying herself. She'd seemed angry at first while frantically trying to attack him, but then she calmed down and started thinking, employing more strategy into her strikes, and landing them more and more, using Hordak's size against him. Hordak ended up winning that sparring match after tripping Catra with his baton and pinning her to the ground with one end of it. He had said something about that *making them even*, which annoyed Catra to no end and for the rest of the night she insisted that he had cheated and that she would get him back.

We had slept in the castle on the first night, but after finding it super eerie and creepy we agreed to instead sleep in one of the Horde barracks outside. Catra still swears she heard the little pitter-patter of feet running around within the walls, and that had been plenty motivation for me to suggest that we sleep elsewhere.

So that's where we woke up on the morning of day three in Dryl.

There was something oddly relaxing about waking up in a Horde bunk. I had, after all, slept in them for most of my life. But waking up in one that was almost completely empty, with no one shouting about getting up and ready for inspection, was something that initially threw me for a loop in my half-asleep state. Part of me had expected Commander Cobalt to barge in through the door and shout, *"get up and ready for training, Cadets!"* But no shout

came. When I finally realised why, I relaxed back onto the hard, uncomfortable, yet familiar mattress.

Catra should still be in the bunk above mine. She always was the heavier sleeper, and after we didn't get much sleep the night before (because of the scuttling) I fully expected her to still be asleep. And so, like any loving girlfriend, I donned my best smirk and reached up, knocking on the bottom of her bunk.

'Anyone home?' I asked as politely as I could. I heard a loud groan in response and stifled my laughter.

'No...'

'You sure?'

'Five more minutes...'

I rolled out of the covers, pulled on my leggings, top, and the jacket I got from Bleatrix's stall before sitting on my bunk and sliding each of my boots on. Then I stood up, peeking over the top bunk at Catra. The bunk we chose was against a wall, and she laid facing it now with her back towards me. I reached a hand over and started prodding her sides. Her tail flicked at my arm, but I didn't relent, instead starting to tickle her on her waist just above her hips, between her grey shorts and sports bra. Catra hadn't brought many of her new clothes with her, insisting that she didn't want them to get ruined.

It wasn't long before she couldn't hold in her laughter anymore, and she started swatting at my hand while curling and arching her body, trying to get me to stop. 'Adora! Adora, stop! Fine! I'll get up! Just quit it! Stop ticking me!'

I stopped, peering at her innocently from the edge of the bunk. Catra turned to face me and locked her gaze with mine, 'I'm so getting you back for that, Princess.'

'Oh, are you?' I asked, arching an eyebrow.

'I am. You won't know what hit you...'

'Hmm.' I stepped back from the bed and started walking towards the entrance, before turning back and catching her watching me, 'I look forward to it.'

As I stepped into the morning light, stretching my arms in every possible direction, I cast my mind to the worries that hid within me.

The first: Melog had still not reappeared. The last time I saw them was when Catra had her nightmare, the night before we left for Dryl. I could tell Catra was worried, she had even made us wait for almost an hour before leaving Bright Moon. All I could do was reassure her that they must have had a good reason and they must be doing something important, otherwise they would be here with her now.

Secondly on my list of worries, today was the day when Entrapta said she would be ready to start running her tests on Catra. After all my experiences with magic and First Ones tech, I couldn't help but be a little sceptical about the whole thing. Although, the prospect of Catra being able to use magic did stir the curiosity within me and part of me was excited to help her get the hang of it, if we're able to find out how it works.

Lastly... Catra had barely touched or kissed me since the night Melog went missing. I was trying, yet failing, not to think too hard on this last one because it could be any number of things. For instance, it could just be that she's too worried about Melog to think about anything else. She could just need some space. She could be anxious about Entrapta's tests that have been looming over us the last couple of days. I tried telling myself time and time again that it was just me overthinking everything, that it was all fine and nothing was wrong.

But overthink I did.

What if she doesn't want to be together anymore?
What if she's only kissing me every so often out of pity?
What if she figured out that I've been planning to propose and doesn't want me to?
Have I done something to make her mad?
Is she punishing me for something?

I shook the thoughts from my mind just as Catra appeared, wearing her usual black and red uniform, looking at me with a curious expression. 'What's up with you, Princess? You seem frustrated.'

'What? No I... what's up with you?' I laughed nervously, trying to focus on putting on a more normal face.

'I'm fine, Adora.' She leant in close, whispering into my ear, 'It's you I worry about.'

I felt her warm breath on my ear and a shiver shot up my spine, she then trailed her lips across my cheek before kissing it softly, grinning as she pulled away. I had never focused so hard on keeping a straight face before, but I felt my cheeks betray me. Catra tilted her head and looked me up and down before turning on her heel on walking towards the castle. Once she was far enough away, I let out a huge breath before falling to my knees and covering my face with my hands. I hadn't felt anything like this before. I needed her touch. I needed her lips on mine. I needed to feel her against me. It all started after she teased me before leaving me hanging three nights ago, during Glimmer's aurora...

Wait.

No.

She wouldn't.

NO.

She was still teasing me.

When I dropped my hands from my face, I saw that Catra had stopped. She was leaning forwards, looking back at me with a devilish smirk and a glint in her eye. I let myself fall further, holding myself up with my hands and staring at the floor.

'I'm such an idiot...' I mumbled to myself. After seeing me like this, completely defeated, she knew she had won. I could try to fight back, now that I knew the game, but I was spent, and she knew it. Over the last two days she had been wearing down my defences, coaxing me further out into the open, teasing me until I no longer had any way to fight back. All she had to do was whisper in my ear and watched as I literally fell to my knees. She hadn't been avoiding me, she hadn't been pitying me, she wasn't mad, and she certainly wasn't punishing me. She had been providing the slightest of touches in just the right places, breathing on me, giving me the smallest kisses, lingering just long enough for me to lean in for more before pulling away.

I could barely believe it.

Two. Whole. Days.

This was the third day.

I looked up to see if Catra was still there. She wasn't. She must have carried on inside. I took a few deep breaths before standing and brushing myself off. Since it was too late for me to fight back, I accepted my fate. I would have to play along.

Or would I?

I started walking towards the castle, trying to push down the excitement that rose within me.

**

Entrapta had given us both a customised tracker pad once we arrived in Dryl, which had a map of the castle installed on it as well as a tracking beacon. It allowed for you to see where everyone was in the castle at any one time, with the aim of

making sure no one gets lost while walking around inside. Once inside the castle I referred to the map and eight blips shone back at me; four were in the kitchen, three in the lab, and the last one was me, wandering through the halls.

The lab looked similar to how I remember it from our last visit, which involved rampaging robots and a very giddy... me. Although the walls were now stacked high with the crates the robots had brought in, and new machinery filled a lot of the once empty space. Entrapta and Hordak were stood at the computer muttering to themselves with a small Horde bot sat off to one side, spinning itself round on the spot. Catra was stood to the left, watching the map on her tracker pad. She must have been watching my blip because she looked up as I walked in, firing that demon smirk at me. I smirked back and her expression dropped, she hadn't been expecting that.

'Adora! Good! You're here!' Entrapta swung over to me, using her hair to suspend herself from beams that stretched across the room above our heads. 'We need to start with you, to test the machine but also as a point of comparison for future reference data.'

I looked her quizzically, 'Uh, okay? Sure? What is it I'm doing, exactly?'

'NOTHING! Well, standing, but on this platform over here.' Entrapta swung over to the right, pointing to a small platform that had a multitude of wires leading away from it. She then tapped the top of the spherical horde bot, 'Make sure you record this, Emily!' It beeped a response.

I moved over and stood on the platform, glancing at Catra briefly. She was watching me curiously.

Entrapta seemed as excited as ever, squealing under the prospect of whatever she was about to do. 'I've always wanted to scan you while you were awake!'

'Wait... what? Awake?'

The base of the platform suddenly glowed with an orange light, and a small arm extended from it. It spun around me and another light shone from it as it scanned over my legs, waist, torso, arms, and head before folding back up and vanishing back inside the platform.

Entrapta studied the data appearing on her screen. 'Hmm. You obviously have a great deal of magic within you, but there seems to be a lot more going on physiologically than there should... do you feel okay, Adora? Are you ill?'

'I- I'm fine!' I tried to glare at Catra but that victorious smirk was back, plastered to her face.

'Oh! That's good! The data suggests otherwise but if you think you're fine then I suppose that's okay!' Entrapta started tapping something on the keyboard. I had almost forgotten Hordak was there, he was just stood to one side, watching. He must know how Entrapta operates by now and was waiting for his cue. 'Okay! And now we should see...'

A rough outline of my body appeared on one of the larger monitors, it seemed to be glowing gold. 'This is a representative diagram of the magic within you!' Beamed Entrapta, 'Now if I load up the other princesses' data...' Outlines of the other princesses appeared on the screen, each glowing their respective colour.

'When did you scan the other Princesses... you know what? I don't want to know.' It was probably while they slept.

'I scanned them in their sleep!'

I facepalmed. 'Entrapta, you can't just -'

'NOW!' She interrupted, 'I need to do a scan of She-Ra to analyse possible differences in the concentration of your shared magical energy!'

I sighed, 'Okay, Entrapta. But you need to stop scanning people in their sleep.'

Stepping down off the platform, I reached a hand out above me, 'For the honour of Grayskull!' A light flickered in the palm of my hand before fizzling out, 'Oh! Not again!' I held out my hand again, willing She-Ra to come out. 'For the honour... of... Grayskull!'

Entrapta swung over to me, looking at something on her tracker pad before scratching her head. 'Have you tried concentrating?'

'Yeah, Adora! Concentrate!' Catra laughed from behind her. This was her fault as she knew it.

Entrapta moved back over to Hordak, looking over the data with him. I glared towards Catra. I think.

Catra's smirk turned into a wide, toothy grin, showing her fangs. I'd never seen her looking so mischievous before. She looked over at Entrapta and Hordak, who were busy running through the data and discussing possible reasons why I can't transform. Obviously, I couldn't tell them the real reason.

After a moment, likely deciding the pair were completely distracted, Catra moved over to me, her tail swishing behind her. I expected her to stop in front of me, smirk at me before teasing again. But she didn't. She walked right up to me, wrapping one arm around my back, and using her other hand to grab the back of my thigh. This is the most she's touched me in the last few days; I clamped a hand over my mouth to stop myself from making any noises, looking over to Entrapta and Hordak to make sure they weren't watching.

Then Catra leant in closer, pressing her cheek to mine before whispering, 'Looks like you've finally caught on, Dummy. Enjoying the game?' I kept my eyes fixed on the other two, not lowering my hand from my mouth. 'I meant what I said earlier. I'm going to make it up to you, and you are *not* going to know what hit you...'

My heart skipped a beat as I yearned for whatever it was Catra was planning.

I'm not sure what expression my face was betraying me with, but Catra's eyes shone with victory. Her hand let go of my thigh and grabbed my wrist, moving my hand away from my mouth. She leant forwards until our noses touched, before whispering again, 'Sorry, Adora, but they need the other one.'

The kiss that followed cleared my mind immediately. Suddenly it was all I could think about, the warmth of her lips, her hands moving up to hold my head. I wrapped my arms around Catra, holding her close, never wanting it to end. Her hands moved to my shoulders, digging in, and I felt the pressure of standing leave her legs. When she pulled back and I opened my eyes I saw that I was taller, and Catra was hanging on to me, supported by my arms around her waist.

Catra smiled that victorious smirk yet again, 'Hey, She-Ra. Thought I might find you here.' I looked around, Entrapta looked stunned whereas Hordak looked like he'd rather like to leave. Then I noticed Emily, who was still doing as she was told, recording the whole thing. Great.

Catra also noticed the bot and laughed, before planting her feet on my torso and pushing off of me, doing a backflip in the air and landing on her feet. 'She's all yours, Entrapta.'

'Fascinating...' She pulled out her small voice recorder from somewhere in her hair before rambling, 'She-Ra observation log, entry one thousand and... sixty... two? It seems She-Ra can be called upon externally by emotional and physical stimulus, potentially exclusively provided by Catra.'

I huffed, I could feel how hot my cheeks were, 'Can we just get this over with? Please?'

Entrapta beamed a crazed smile, 'Absolutely! Same thing again!'

I stepped onto the platform and it creaked slightly under She-Ra's weight. The scan proceeded the same as last time, and I stepped down once it finished. Entrapta squealed excitedly before loaded the data to the visual diagram, as before, and the outline of She-Ra appeared next to mine. She also had a golden glow, but it seemed brighter, almost pure white. Entrapta let out a giddy squeal as she looked up at her collection of glowing princess outlines, 'This is the first time I've been able to successfully scan She-Ra! I'm going to look over this data so many times!'

Catra coughed, 'Uh... Etheria to Entrapta, is it my turn now?'

Entrapta peeled her eyes away from the monitor screens, 'Oh! Catra! Yes, go ahead!'

Same thing again, Catra stepped on, she was scanned, she stepped off. What wasn't the same, however, was that Entrapta was silent. Frozen to the spot, looking at her tracking pad.

I stepped forward, 'Uh, Entrapta? What's wrong?'

She didn't respond, instead tapping away on the pad. Then, the outline of Catra appeared underneath all the others. It turned grey, then pink, then blue, green, red, then it sped up, quickly flashing through all the colours of the princesses. All except mine and She-Ra's.

Catra looked perplexed, 'Uh... that doesn't look good, what does that mean?'

All eyes fell on Entrapta, who slowly turned around, regarding Catra with awe.

'It means,' she said, slowly, double checking the data, 'that you may be able to use *all* the magic of Etheria!'

Dip Down

'I have brought tiny food for my beloved brothers!'

Wrong Hordak broke the stunned silence that had fallen over the lab with his sudden declaration of food. Entrapta was immediately enthralled by it, swinging past a frozen Catra before stuffing her face with one tiny cupcake after another. Hordak simply turned to observe the data on the screens, before picking up the tracker pad and flicking through more readings.

Catra turned to face me; she looked dazed, with just a dash of confusion sprinkled on top. I returned to my normal size before shrugging, I didn't have any answers to give, but I would certainly try and bring Entrapta back to us.

'Entrapta.' She turned her head and regarded me curiously, 'Any chance you're maybe going to, oh, I don't know, elaborate on what you just said? For all of our benefits.'

She swallowed the cupcake she had been munching before picking up another and swinging back over to the computer, 'Absolutely! Just one question... What was I saying again?' I was about to speak when she held up her hand, 'WAIT! I know! Emily! Play back recording!'

Emily beeped in understanding before projecting an image of Entrapta working on the scanning platform, *"...can't wait to finally scan She-Ra! I've been wanting to do this for so -"*

'No that's not it,' Entrapta interrupted herself, 'Fast forward to today.'

The recording sped up before returning to normal speed, *"...hope this doesn't blow up. Adora would NEVER forgive me for blowing up Cat-"*

'Nope, a bit more.'

'Wait.' I said, pointing, 'What was that?'

'What was what? ... STOP! That's it, play.'

"It means you have it all. You may be able to use all the magic of Etheria!"

Entrapta planted one fist on top of another, 'That's right! That's where we were at.'

I sighed, 'I could have just told you that.'

'Oh don't worry, Emily likes to be included.'

Emily beeped enthusiastically in response.

Only then did I look back over at Catra. Wrong Hordak was hovering around her, offering her the last of the tiny cupcakes but she didn't seem at all interested. I walked over and grabbed the petite confectionery, chucking it into my mouth and relishing in its sweetness.

'Ah! Brother, thank you! I was afraid I was never going to able to leave.' Wrong Hordak hugged the tray to his chest and beamed a bright green smile at me.

Once I finished the cupcake, which really didn't take long, I asked, 'Why would you not be able to leave?'

'Ah, you see, the kind Baker said not to come back unless all the food had been eaten. I was truly distressed to think I would never be able to return to the kitchen. You have freed me, brother! Thank you!' At that, he winked at me before turning on the spot and sauntering back towards the kitchen.

'Ugh, he's so annoying.' Catra mumbled to herself.

I lightly placed my hand on her shoulder, 'I kind of love him though, he's awesome.'

Catra was growing impatient, I could see her frowning at Entrapta and rapidly tapping her foot on the floor. I squeezed my fingers, gently pressing on her collarbone, 'Hey, just give her a sec. She'll tell us more when she's rea-'

'OKAY!' Entrapta shouted, spinning around on her chair and tapping away on a tracker pad. 'After analysing the data I have some more specific information for you... here we go. You technically *could* use a bunch of different kinds of magic, but I wouldn't advise it.'

'Why not?' Catra asked, stepping forwards. She took the words right out of my mouth with a confidence I had not been anticipating.

'Because you're not a magical being, unlike She-Ra. If Adora were to use too much of She-Ra's power when not in the She-Ra form, she would likely faint or collapse. Any damage would then be healed by She-Ra, bringing her back to normal as if nothing had happened.'

'...but?' Catra pressed, this must have been what she was waiting for. The downside, the risks.

'But... because you're not She-Ra, and you technically have a similar level of magical energy within you, overusing it will cause you to lose consciousness... or worse... and you won't be able to heal yourself. Which gives us a second reason as to why you collapsed in the temple! Not only did you suffer a severe psychological shock, but you also lost control of your magic, using too much at once, draining you and overloading your body! These two factors combined must have amounted to the point where you just completely shut down!'

'I... lost control...' Catra looked back at me and I caught the pain in her eyes, I tensed my body knowing what was coming next, 'I hurt you.' She started to turn and run but I was ready; I immediately caught hold of her wrist, holding her back, 'Adora! Let go!'

'No, Catra, I won't. You said you would trust me, well it's time to trust me. Stay, and we'll work it out. Together. Just like we said. It's okay, I was scared too.' Reassuring people is not something I was overly used to doing, but I knew Catra. I knew that she needed someone just to tell her it's okay.

Catra quickly stopped pulling away. After a moment she moved toward me, her arms threading around my waist and her head nestling into my shoulder. 'I'm sorry...' she whispered against my neck.

'It's okay,' I replied softly, stroking the softness behind her ear, 'It's a lot to take in.'

'I theorise!' Entrapta continued, completely oblivious to our small altercation, 'That with considerable practice you should be able to manage the flow of magic within you... If you are able to somehow control what triggered it last time, your emotions, your memories, everything that sparks strong feelings within you, you should be able to use most magic at will... magic is very emotional... unlike SCIENCE!' Entrapta was laughing maniacally, apparently lost in her own little world of science vs. magic.

Hordak stepped forward now, making himself known for the first time since we entered the lab. He placed his tracker pad down on the desk and moved over to us before talking directly to Catra, 'I would suggest, Catra, that we reconvene for a... *rematch*. Following on from my victory during our sparring yesterday.' I smiled at him. I could see what he was doing and it would absolutely work.

Catra moved away from me, meeting Hordak's challenging stare. 'Oh, you want a rematch, do you?'

Hordak smiled, his eyes narrowing, '*Yes*. Even with your magic, you will not be able to best me. I am stronger than I've ever been, faster than even you.'

Hordak riling up Catra to fight him by using her magic was a stroke of genius. If she was able to use it without overthinking... it could work. Being thrown into familiar situations can relax you, Hordak knew this. I forget that at some point he must have trained the first Force Captains and Commanders in the Horde, the ones that would eventually train us. I was looking forward to watching a Hordak training session first hand.

'And,' Hordak continued, 'If you *are* able to best me, if you can manage even that, then you shall fight... She-Ra.' He shot his challenging glare in my direction, with Catra following his gaze with an assured look of confidence.

Her eyes shone keenly, I could tell she was in her element. 'Oh you're on. I'm taking you down, and then I'm taking down the hot warrior princess.' A beat of silence passed. When our eyes met they doubled in size and our cheeks flushed a violent crimson as we simultaneously realised what she said, 'Uh... I mean...'

'No... no... it's okay.' I stammered while nodding, 'You think She-Ra's hot, but you've never said that about me. I see how it is.'

'No! Adora! That's not what I -' Catra started to defend herself but was cut off by Hordak laughing.

'I shall be waiting in the square, *just* Catra. Join me when you are ready.' Hordak started walking away, cracking his knuckles and gearing himself up for the imminent sparring match.

'Ooo, magical combat... with First Ones tech... Come on, Emily! We have to record this so I can analyse it for future research and study!' Entrapta hopped on top of Emily and they sped after Hordak, heading outside to the courtyard.

Catra was standing in front of me, fidgeting nervously. 'Catra?' I asked, 'Are you okay?'

She looked up at me, locking her eyes with mine. She was still blushing furiously. 'I wasn't talking about She-Ra, okay?' She

turned on the spot, quickly walked out of the lab as she turned on her tracker pad and observed the map as she left.

I couldn't help but rest a hand on my chest, where my heart had suddenly started to feel a little tighter... *I love her so much*, I thought to myself, before taking out my map and following after her.

**

Entrapta was busy double checking the camera in Emily and fiddling with some other internal wiring as I stood next to her. I wondered if the bot was still the same Emily that Entrapta had first reprogrammed in the Fright Zone, or if enough of her parts had been replaced or swapped out to make it an entirely new bot.

I shook my head, where did that come from? That was a confusing line of thought.

Ahead of me, within the loosely marked border of the sparring ring me and Catra had constructed by lying flag poles down to form the edges, Hordak stood patiently. He was testing the weight of the weapon he had chosen, a long shock-stick. It looked like a spear, but the end formed two probes that crackled with electricity when activated. Hordak held it at various points and angles, getting a feel for its weight and balance. He was taking this seriously.

Catra emerged from our barracks. She was wearing the silver circlet, the blue gemstone glowing faint, and one of the gloves. Our eyes met and she smiled nervously, pulling on the other glove before stepping over the flagpole and entering the ring.

Hordak smiled proud, planting the blunt end of the shock-spear into the ground in front of him. 'Are you ready to be bested, again?' He taunted.

Catra stretched her arms over her head, then readied herself into a low stance, preparing to lunge, 'Just you wait, Hordak. I'll show you who's boss.'

'Be careful, Catra!' I was hoping that she would be able to control her magic if it did appear, but I stood ready just in case.

She smiled back confidently, 'Always am!'

After a moment of daring each other to make the first move, Catra leapt forwards, initiating the match. She bounded towards Hordak, taking huge strides on all fours before leaping into the air with claws at the ready. Hordak moved backwards, dodging the strike as Catra landed where he had just been standing.

'Too slow,' he snarked as he dodged to the left, avoiding another of Catra's slashes before bringing up the staff to accurately block a sudden kick. The staff swung at Catra but she ducked just in time to avoid a nasty headache. After righting herself she moved in on Hordak's back, sensing an opening. But Hordak didn't stop the swing of his staff, instead twirling it around and catching Catra in the side before roaring, 'Too easy!'

Suddenly she stopped, taken by surprise at the unexpected attack, gripping at her side. Before she had chance to react, Hordak jabbed her in the stomach with the blunt end of the staff, forcing the air out of her lungs, winding her. She fell backwards to the floor, gasping for breath as Hordak raised the staff above his head. He aimed the dual probes down, igniting the cackling of the electricity, bringing it down towards her. Catra yelled out, closing her eyes and holding up her hands in a last-ditch effort to defend against the attack that would inevitably find its target, win Hordak the match, and most likely stun Catra into a temporarily unresponsive state. I instinctively moved forwards but stopped as I observed what was happening in front of me.

The strike never landed.

The gem in Catra's circlet and the discs on the gloves shone a bright blue, I watched in awe as the shock-staff was being repulsed by a shield-sized disk of bright blue energy. It was the same energy that had surrounded Catra in the temple and seemed to be vibrating with the same force and power that I had

felt when I placed my hand on it. In the temple, I hadn't applied any pressure to it, instead leaving it well alone. I had felt that if I tried to break through it would push back. This time, Hordak was actively straining against it, trying to push the shock-staff down and through it. But the staff wasn't even connecting to the blue of the energy, instead being held an inch or so above, the end steadily shaking more and more violently as it was held in place against the shield.

Entrapta was frozen to the spot next to me, her mouth agape, watching the scene unfold. Even she hadn't predicted something like this.

'Catra!'

Catra's eyes flew open and met mine as she heard me call her name, she then looked up at Hordak who was struggling against the energy barrier. She yelled with a mixture of surprise and shock, accidently firing a pulse out from the shield, releasing the built-up vibrations and flinging Hordak backwards across the edge of the sparring court. The disc of energy dissipated in front of Catra as she lowered her hands and hastily scrambled to her feet.

'Oooo,' Entrapta watched as Hordak flew backwards, before taking out her voice recorder and rapidly speaking into it. 'Catra First Ones tech magic observation log one: It seems that while wearing the First Ones tech Catra can conjure some kind of magical energy field that defends against incoming attacks! It also stores up the potential energy and redirects it, releasing it as a pulse shock-wave, knocking back who or whatever is within the line of sight! This is so exciting!'

Now it was my turn to gape in wonder. That must have been what I felt when I placed my hand against the bubble before, if I had pressed much harder or surprised Catra I would have been flung backwards into the swirling gale that had surrounded us.

'What kind of magic was that?' I asked, I can't do that...

'GREAT QUESTION!' Entrapta leaped up onto her hair, towering above me, 'I hypothesise that it's an ability exclusive to those pieces of First Ones tech! I wonder if it can form any more shapes, like your sword can...' She trailed off as she looked back towards the ring, Hordak was shuffling around the edge toward us.

Catra was staring intensely at her gloved hands, the discs and gem of her tech still shining with a bright magical glow. 'Your turn, Adora,' being challenged by Catra was nothing new. In that moment however, after watching her fling our old boss across the sparring ring, I was a little apprehensive.

Shaking those thoughts from my mind, I stepped forward, 'Awfully confident, aren't we?' I hopped over the flagpole, watching as Hordak took my place standing next to Entrapta. She immediately started looking over him, no doubt trying to see if there were any other effects loaded with that energy pulse.

'Against you? Always.' Catra smirked, before crouching into a similar position as before. 'Bring out the big guns, Adora.'

There was something hypnotic about seeing Catra in a glowing magical circlet, seeing her in any kind of jewellery always seemed too far fetched and I had thought I would ever have the pleasure of seeing her wearing any.

'Uh... hello? Adora? Are you going to be able to bring out She-Ra or do you need some help?'

I felt my cheeks flush red and I drew in a sharp breath, 'Um...' I extended my hand, ready to call forth She-Ra... but stopped, 'I think I might some help, actually.' I didn't, I just wanted to kiss Catra again and fought against the dorky grin that I felt encroaching on my face.

Catra frowned and glanced over at Entrapta and Hordak who seemed to be conversing quietly, before tentatively walking over to me. 'Are you serious, Adora? How bad do you need me to -'

'Try and dip down!' Entrapta called out of nowhere. Hordak leant down and whispered into her ear and she expanded on her advice, 'Dip down into your emotions! Draw them out and use them to control your magic!'

Stopping a few feet away from me, Catra looked over to Entrapta and tried to work out what she meant. I rolled my eyes and walked over.

'What does she mean "dip down?"' Catra asked as I stood in front of her, blocking her view of Entrapta and Hordak.

I held her face in my hands, lifting her eyes to mine, 'Well, whenever I turn into She-Ra, I think about how much I love you.' I leant down and kissed her, letting her fill my senses, my heart fluttering at the contact and her warmth as she kissed me back. I needed more, but I knew I would have to wait. 'Maybe something like that?' I suggested as I pulled back from the kiss.

The sight before me was not one I was expecting, Catra had her eyes closed and was already leaning back up for more. I smiled, for the first time considered that her teasing me for the last few days must have had a drastic impact on her as well. I leant forward and kissed her on the cheek before smiling and walking back over to my side of the makeshift sparring ring. Catra must have recovered quickly, because she was once again on her side facing me, albeit with a much softer expression than before.

Once again, I extended my hand out and confidently spoke the mantra which helped me bring forth She-Ra. I realised some time ago that I didn't need to say the words, but saying them out loud helped me to focus myself. That, and I had been using them for three years. Stopping now would be like trying to break my habit of keeping a knife under my pillow at night. I held the sword ahead of me, pointing it toward Catra. I could feel She-Ra's hair billowing in the wind behind me as we, apparently, began our staring contest.

Catra seemed to be trying something new. She stood up straight and closed her eyes, concentrating. I readied my sword as she lifted her hands towards me. For a while, nothing happened. Entrapta and Hordak watched in curious silence as Catra stood, unmoving, focusing on *something*. Then, out of nowhere, she smiled. A gorgeous smile that distracted me and pulled at my heartstrings. The smile was immediately followed by her tech glowing, which preceded the green aura that soon surrounded her form.

Wait, green?

I felt a tickle at my foot and looked down to see a root wrapping itself around my ankle, having prised itself through the metal plating that made up the ground within Dryl. Catra suddenly lowered her arms to her sides, forming her hands into fists. Once she opened her eyes again, I could see that they were also glowing with a faint green aura, her pupils dilated. There was a glint in her eye, and I suddenly felt concern about the root which was now halfway up my leg.

Before I had chance to slash at the base of the root, Catra steadily jerked her arms upwards, as if lifting something heavy. Immediately afterwards the floor rumbled as the rest of an ancient root system shot out of the ground, carrying me with it and suspending me in the air upside down. I looked across at Catra who was staring in utter disbelief at the tree of roots that now stood tall in the courtyard of Dryl.

Entrapta practically screamed. She then took out her voice recorder as Catra ran towards me, 'A HUGE SUCCESS! Catra was able to summon an ancient root system and tunnel it through the metal flooring of Dryl! Trapping She-Ra by the ankle and suspending her approximately six feet above the ground! Truly fascinating!'

Catra held my head in her hands and kissed me while I dangled from the root. I could feel the blood rushing to my head but I ignored it, instead running my free hand through her hair. After

all, when was the next time I was going to get the chance to kiss my girlfriend while hanging upside down from an ancient root?

After she moved away, I started swinging myself back and forth until I was high enough to slash at the root under my foot and land, more or less, on my feet. Catra hugged me after I finished prising the remaining bits of old plant from my leg, and I put an arm around her in return. I marvelled at how adorable she was. I always forgot just how tall She-Ra is compared to Catra, her head only just reaching my shoulders.

Catra looked up at me, her whole face smiling, 'I did what you said! I thought about you, how much I love you, how much you mean to me... and then I could *feel* it, this life, under the ground. I willed it to grow and it did, all because I thought about how much I love you.'

I smiled down at her, placing a hand on her cheek. She leant into it, purring contentedly. 'Catra, you're amazi-'

'Fascinating...' Entrapta seemed to appear out of nowhere and was stood right next to us, listening in to what Catra had been saying. Addressing her recorder, she muttered, 'It seems that the emotion known as "love" is responsible for control over plant-life. Which would lead to suggest that "fear" may be the controlling factor for wind...' She dropped her bug mask over her face and peered at Catra before hoisting herself up with her hair and moving back over towards Hordak.

'You know,' I drawled, twirling my sword around in my hand, 'I'm not actually out of bounds, so the match is still going.'

Catra laughed, 'Oh, you're on, Princess. Come and get me,' she taunted, before turning tail and putting a good amount of distance between us. I smiled and was about to run after her when I felt a hand on my shoulder. It was Hordak.

'Adora,' he spoke low, hushed, 'Once you are... finished here, please find me within the castle. There is something I wish to

discuss. Something potentially... troubling.'

I nodded, wondering what it could be about. Worry nagged in the back of my mind, but I pushed it back, I had my match to settle with Catra first, 'Yeah, okay. I'll find you.'

Hordak hummed in response, before turning and walking away. Entrapta followed him into the castle, talking about something while looking at her tracking pad. Emily stayed outside, fixed on Catra.

I turned my full attention back to Catra, who was focusing again with her arms outstretched and her palms open. Her tech shone a brilliant blue. Then, materialising in the air in front of her, a staff. It was made of the same blue translucent energy as her shield from earlier, glowing and pulsing softly in the air as it formed. Catra opened her eyes and smirked, before snatching the staff straight out of the air and twirling it around her body. She locked eyes with me and motioned for me to come at her.

I scoffed, 'Show off!'

'You're no better!' She called back.

We both charged at the same time, clashing sword against staff as blue energy fizzled around us. As our eyes met in the heat of the moment, we smiled at one another, before pulling back from the bind and continuing the duel without reservation.

Fizzy Thievery

Catra was a fast learner, this I knew, but I was not prepared for how quickly she would get the hang of conjuring weapons of blue energy from nowhere. Unlike my sword, which changes form to become almost anything I can think of, Catra's energy does not shapeshift. Once she summons something it stays in that form until she releases it or it's taken away from her. I was able to disarm her a few times, but each time the energy staff would disappear from my hand and she would simply summon a new one.

After a while she was also able to form multiple things at once, and it wasn't long before she started duel-wielding shorter baton-length rods or using a shield alongside a weapon. Her confidence grew with every match we sparred, but I was always able to win. Fighting against the new She-Ra is not something Catra had experience doing and she hadn't been prepared for how much faster I was than before, easily outpacing her within the confines of the makeshift ring. Regardless of losing, Catra seemed to be enjoying herself. It wasn't until I pinned her to the ground with my hands around her wrists that she surrendered, laughing as I stared down at her.

Seeing her like this made my heart ache. I would never get over the sight of Catra honestly laughing, having fun, all while spending her time with me. I shrunk back down to Adora size and laughed along, before lying down and looking up at the sky beside her.

It was mid afternoon now and the moons were easily visible through the clouds. Shadow Weaver had once taught us about the moons. There were twelve of them, they provided light to Etheria and each one helped the princesses control their power and played a role in keeping the magical ecosystem of Etheria in check. But most of all, we weren't to be fascinated by the moons; they were evil as they helped boost the enemy's power. We were

to look on them with disdain and dream of the day we could break their connection to the princesses.

It seemed such a wild fantasy now. Catra and I spent a few nights after that whispering about what we would do if we could jump from moon to moon, which one we would claim as our own...

Catra's hand reached for mine and I held it, interlacing our fingers before squeezing gently. I looked over and saw her staring upwards as well, I wondered if she was thinking about the same thing as me. Her ear twitched and she turned her head, meeting my gaze and holding it as we stared into each other's eyes.

After a short while Catra turned to look at the sky again, before sitting up and taking off her gloves. She then turned to look me in the eye before smirking and trailing a hand up the inside of my thigh. I accidentally let out an involuntary moan at the sudden contact before clamping my hand over my mouth. I had forgotten that I was still completely defenceless, but I knew she was too and I secretly plotted my revenge. Catra laughed before standing up, leaving me lying on the floor.

'I'm going to wash, Princess,' Catra said as she started walking toward the Horde shower block.

I gathered my senses and sat up, watching her go, 'Is there any water left in the tanks?' I called after her.

Catra shrugged, 'Guess I'll find out!'

Once I stood up and brushed myself down, I made my way toward the Crypto Castle. It was about time I found Hordak and listened to what he wanted to tell me. I felt that worry from earlier steadily creeping back to the front of my mind, emerging from its temporary lair in my subconscious.

**

It wasn't difficult for me to find Hordak, I just had to check all the blips on the map one by one. The first blip I checked was in the

main laboratory, but it was just Entrapta practically drooling over a scrolling mass of data that I would not even pretend to understand. Wrong Hordak was cooking in the kitchen, with the Baker standing nearby watching what he was doing. Busgirl and Soda Pop were arguing in a storage room, apparently someone had been drinking all the fizzy drinks from storage.

Eventually, I found Hordak in what looked like his own personal study. The door was open, so I let myself in and wandered through to stand in the middle of the room. He had watched me enter but turned his gaze back to his monitor screen before typing something on the keyboard built into the desk.

'So...' I began, breaking the silence while spinning around and taking in the room. It was much smaller than his sanctum in the Fright Zone, with a few worktables dotted around and the beginnings of tinkering starting to take shape. There was also a dissected Horde scout drone on one of the tables, with various wires and components spilling from inside it. 'How do you like your new workspace?'

'It is... adequate,' he summarised, turning to face me. 'But as for why I asked for you...' I nodded and walked over to the desk he was standing at, observing the monitors above it. 'You will remember I addressed the issue of the clones that returned to their ships in orbit during the meeting in Bright Moon.' I nodded, and an image of Etheria appeared on the screen with a number of red triangles surrounding it, 'I have kept a close eye on them since then. The clones themselves should be fine, we don't need sustenance, sleep, nor anything else a regular being needs for survival. We were bred for combat, to be expendable, bodies to fling into an endless inferno of death and -'

'Hordak!' I shouted, cutting him off, 'You're getting a bit carried away there.'

He coughed, 'Apologies. As I was saying, the clones will be fine up there on their own. They will survive as it is what our DNA is programmed to do. However, this scan was made five days ago.'

He tapped a series of buttons on the keyboard, 'and this one is from yesterday.' A handful of the triangles disappeared.

I frowned, 'Wait, what does that mean? Have they gone?'

Hordak looked down at me, 'Gone? Where would they go? They have no orders, no directive. They cannot even access the hive mind to contact other ships. No... Something else is happening around Etheria, and it does not bode well.'

My mind started racing as I paced back and forth within Hordak's workshop.

Were they under attack?
Were we under attack?
Had they slipped into portals?
Had they turned the ships off?

'While this is a troubling development, I feel that if Etheria were under attack we would know by now. There are numerous possible explanations behind the scans losing track of those ships, but two are the most likely; one being that the clones have simply flown into a panic and managed to disable the vessels. This would not matter, as we can survive without air and within the vacuum of space. The second and more plausible is that they have been externally disabled.'

I stopped and looked at him, 'You don't mean blown up do you?' I motioned an explosion with my hands, making a slow explosion sound that trailed off as my hands moved further apart.

Hordak blinked, then frowned, 'There is no sound in the vacuum of space, so it would not make... *any* noise. But yes, explosion is likely, but not exclusively the explanation. Hence, "externally disabled."'

'So what do we do? Can't we just fly Darla up there and take a look?'

He hummed in thought for a second, 'I would not advise it, not until we know what is out there. Else we may find ourselves being -'

'"Externally disabled,"' I nodded, 'Got it.'

'For now, I only wished to inform you of this development as you now seem to be... the protector of this world.' I laughed nervously, rubbing the back of my neck. 'I shall continue to monitor our atmosphere and those ships still in orbit, which I can do much easier from Dryl than I could from Bright Moon. I am also in the process of developing a means of looking into the stars. Horde Prime used a combination of concave and convex objective lenses, enhanced through his technological prowess, to look through the stars as you would look across the land with binoculars.'

'So... space binoculars?'

Hordak sighed, then nodded, 'Yes... space binoculars.'

'Okay, so... to summarise...' I let the information tick over in my head for a second, 'Some of the ships in Horde Prime's fleet have dropped off the radar, we can't go look in case we get "externally disabled," and you're working on a way to look into space without going into space.'

'Yes.' Hordak replied, 'That is an apt summary of the available information, my advice, and my plans.'

'Okay.' I nodded again, this was fine, 'So there's nothing we can do right now? I'm just leaving you to watch over this whole... *thing*, right?'

'Yes...'

'Okay... yeah... I can do that. That's easy. I can not worry about that. Okay, cool.' I breathed out heavily, Hordak looked concerned. I waved a hand towards him, 'I'll be fine.'

His eyes narrowed as he observed me.

'Is that everything?' I asked, straightening up.

Hordak nodded, 'I shall contact you if there are any major developments.'

'Okay, well... not to be rude, but for that reason alone I hope you don't contact me.' A nervous laugh escaped me.

Hordak turned and sat down at the worktable with the dissected Horde scout drone, before picking up a tool and starting to work on it some more. I waved a goodbye, even though he wasn't looking and turned to leave, closing the door as I left. Once in the corridor I leant against the wall and placed my fingertips to my temple, massaging my head slowly. How was I *not* supposed to worry about any of that? Horde ships going missing? That seems like a big thing!

I sighed and moved off down the corridor, coming to terms with the fact it was out of my hands and Hordak would keep an eye on the whole situation from here.

As I rounded a corner, I almost bumped into Busgirl. She was carrying a tray of tiny food in one hand from the kitchen and managed to swerve around me and I stumbled around her.

'Woah! Sorry!' I yelled as we narrowly avoided one another.

'That's okay!' She replied, 'Oh! Adora, wait!' I stopped and looked at her, 'This is dinner, for you and... and...' she clicked her fingers, thinking hard, 'your girlfriend.' She must have given up.

'Catra.'

'Ah! Yes, Catra. Dinner for yourself and Catra.' Busgirl handed me the tray and I thanked her before turning and continuing down the corridor. I quickly glanced at the map on my tracker pad, committing the route out of the castle to memory, before turning it off and focusing on not dropping the tray. I wondered why they

still made tiny food for us, when it was only Entrapta that insists on having it bite-sized.

My thoughts were interrupted by a scuttling sound coming from the storage room that had been the site of Busgirl and Soda Pop's argument earlier. Curiosity got the better of me and I leaned in closer to the door, listening. I heard the *hiss* of a frizzy drink being opened, followed by the sounds of loud guzzling. I pushed one hand against the door gently, trying not to make a noise. It didn't work, the door creaked regardless, and I cursed it for betraying me. Then, I heard the bottle hit the floor followed by the sound of tiny footsteps. I gradually eased into the storage room, looking around. Sure enough, there was an open bottle on the ground, spilling its contents across the floor.

I gulped, '...H-hello?' I asked into the empty room.

A loud burp answered me from the darkness, behind some boxes. I started walking over but a clattering behind me caught my attention. Straining my eyes in the dim light I tried to see what made the noise... it was the cap from the drink. Suddenly I heard the pitter-patter of tiny feet once again, quickly followed by the *clang* of metal on metal. I hurried round behind some boxes to try and spot whatever was there, but I was too late. The only evidence that something had been here was the open drink bottle, and an ajar metal grate in the wall.

**

The barracks door closed behind me with a satisfying click, Catra was already back from the shower and was sprawled on her front across a towel she had laid out on my bunk. She was talking to someone on the tracker pad, having quite an energetic discussion that I couldn't quite hear. As I neared the bunk, tray in hand, I couldn't help but let my eyes wander over her body, her legs, her back, her arms... It seemed Catra had found some actual Horde issue underwear, and while it wasn't exactly revealing it didn't hide the dips and curves of her form at all... I felt my body start to ache at the sight of her.

Catra looked up as I got nearer, her eyes widened at the sight of food and she held her index finger to let me know she was almost done with her call. I sat on the bottom bunk opposite mine and placed the tray next to me, from this distance I was able to catch the end of their conversation.

'... and then Perfuma told them which mushrooms they *should* use in future...'

Ah, it was Scorpia, that makes sense.

'Listen Scorpia...' Catra said after a minute or so, 'Adora is here with food so I'm going to go. It was nice to catch up.'

'Absolutely! Anytime, Wildcat. Hi, Adora!' Scorpia shouted through the screen.

I leant over and smiled, waving, 'Hello, Scorpia!'

Catra hung up the call and quickly spun round, reaching her arms up and wrapping them around me while I was still leaning over her and pulled me down on top of her, hugging me tightly.

'Catra!' I yelled before bursting out laughing, it became immediately obvious that she had put no effort into drying herself after her shower, 'You're still wet! Let go!'

'You know it takes me forever to dry off, Adora! This is one of the many reasons why I hate water!'

I stopped struggling and looked down at her, her hair was swept back leaving her forehead wide open, there were so many things I could have done in that moment, but I resisted. Instead I kissed her exposed forehead before leaning back up, 'Come on, Catra, we've got food. I also need to talk to you.'

She let go at that, and sat up as I sat back down on the other bunk, 'You need to talk to me? Is it bad?'

After shoving a couple of the tiny pieces of food into my mouth I passed the tray over to Catra, and she picked out a couple before handing it back. 'Why would you assume me wanting to talk to you is bad?'

'Well... I don't know, maybe it was just the way you said it. We're good, right?'

I handed her the tray again before getting up and sitting next to her on my bunk. 'We're great, Catra. And it's not bad. Well, it might be - I don't know...'

Catra shifted from her position, leaving the tray where she had been sat and instead sitting back against the wall behind us, 'You can tell me anything, Adora. At this point I've heard it all.'

'Well...' I was going to tell her about Hordak told me but decided against it. It would probably cause her unnecessary worry on top of everything else she was dealing with. I picked the last few pieces of food off of the tray before placing it on the bench between the beds. Then I moved the towel and sat back down on my bunk, facing Catra. '...I heard more scuttling in the castle.'

'SEE!' Catra shouted, 'I'm not making it up! I could hear it all night before, I swear.'

'Oh, I believe you. Whatever it was, it was thirsty. I caught it stealing from a storage room.'

Her jaw dropped, 'No. Way. There's definitely something in there! Does Entrapta know?'

I shrugged, 'I don't know, even if she did it's not like she would tell it to leave. She'd sooner study it than let it get away.' I ate a couple of the pieces of food before holding the last one out to Catra. Rather than just take it, she leant across and opened her mouth expectantly. This was it, after seeing her like that I wouldn't be able to hold out anymore. I scoffed before placing the food in her mouth and she ate it hastily. 'You're adorable.'

'Well... shut up!' She looked away, hiding a blush.

I couldn't stop looking at her. In that moment I remembered what she had done in the Crimson Waste, taking my promise away from me. I decided to return the favour. 'Hey... Catra?' I said, trilling her name and slowly leaning forwards, steadily making my way towards her.

Catra suddenly blushed and started edging away, 'A-Adora? What is it?' She tried to hide the hint of a smirk on her lips - she caught on quick.

'I know what you've been doing to me.'

'What do you mean?'

'I know that it's been torture for you too.'

'I don't know what you're talking about.'

'I can't take any more. I can't wait any longer.'

'A-dora?' Catra whimpered my name as I straddled her. I didn't even mind that her fur was still damp against my legs. I held her wrists in my hands and pinned them to the bed.

I leant down gradually, burying my face in her neck, kissing it gently, coaxing out soft moans from her as I continued down to her collarbone.

'A... Adora...' She gasped my name between whimpers as she writhed beneath me.

Catra must have been torturing herself as much, if not more than me. I observed her as she lay below me and something took the reins, a desire for more that I could no longer subdue. Our lips clashed together without hesitation. Finally, I was able to kiss her the way I had wanted to for the past few days. Catra shuddered under me and there was a sound from the back of her throat, half growl, half moan. Shivers of pleasure shot through me as she

deepened the kiss, parting my lips. I lowered my hands from her wrists and pressed my body against hers, sealing what space remained between us. My body shivered from the contact of her damp fur on me, but I didn't care.

Her hands moved down, taking off my jacket before working their way under my top. Her fingers trailed over my skin, sending shocks through me as they travelled up my waist, easing my top up before it was pulled over my head and thrown to the floor, joining my jacket. Catra looked at me as I sat above her with a hunger in her eyes, ignited by my own. Her hands reached up and she trailed her claws down my torso.

'You're so beautiful,' She whispered before tugging me back down and kissing me deeply. Any kind of rational thoughts had left long ago, there was now only *want.* My body ached for more than just kissing and touching - I wanted more of Catra. I knew she did too.

I pulled back, placing a hand on her cheek, watching as she breathed heavily. Her pupils were dilated, her lips swollen. 'I love you, Catra,' I whispered.

'Just kiss me, Dummy,' she pleaded, reaching her hands up to my face and trying to pull me back down.

I smirked and resisted, before taking her wrists in my hands and pinning them above her head. 'Say "please,"' I whispered. Catra bit her lip.

'You're making me beg?'

I leant down and moved my face up her neck, teasing her with my open mouth but not giving the satisfaction of contact. Catra shivered and let out a series of low whimpers while trying to break free from my grip on her wrists, but I was much stronger than her and she knew it.

'Hah... ah... Adora...'

After arriving at her ear I whispered into it almost silently, knowing she could hear me perfectly with my mouth this close. I let all my desires accumulated over the last three days out into the open. I told her all the things I wanted to do to her, relishing in the response she gave by trying to buck her hips under me.

'I'm not hearing a "please" yet...' I said, leaning back up slowly. My eyes lit up as I saw the expression on her face, it was one I had never seen before and I found myself moving toward it, taking it in.

'Ah... Adora... please... I want it all, please, all of it...'

I licked my lips as my face neared hers and I stopped when our noses were side-by-side. She breathed heavily under the anticipation, her mouth open as she reluctantly waited for me to initiate the kiss. *Good*. She was already doing one of the things I had whispered in her ear.

Catra moaned noisily as my lips finally met hers and the kiss deepened almost immediately. I held both of her wrists under one hand before moving the other steadily down her form, tracing all of her curves with the tips of my fingers. She whimpered into the kiss and I heard the faint sound of her purr rising from within.

This was going to be fun.

Those that Dwell

'...dora...'

'...Adora...'

'ADORA!'

I woke up with a start and yelled, sweat pouring off of me and my breathing ragged. Catra was sat up next to me in the bed, her hands on my shoulders shaking me awake. When she saw my eyes open her expression softened and she caressed my cheek.

'Hey, Adora.'

'Catra? What happened?'

She frowned, 'What do you mean? You were freaking out in your sleep. It freaked me out. So I shook you awake. Was it a nightmare?'

'I... I don't know.' A nightmare? I couldn't remember dreaming about anything, let alone something that could make me freak out in my sleep. I shook my head, 'I can't remember.'

'You can't remember?'

'No, nothing.'

Catra was silent for moment, most likely weighing up whether I was telling the truth.

'Catra, I honestly can't remember what I was dreaming about.'

'Well... whatever it was, you're all sweaty now. And you didn't even shower after sparring yesterday so now you're doubly smelly. It's clogging my nose, Adora. I think I might pass out.' Catra smirked while pinching the bridge of her nose.

I laughed while looking up at her, taking her in. We were both still nude from our night of relieving our self-inflicted *frustrations*. I knew Catra was beautiful, I'd seen her naked enough times to know it, but that didn't change the fact that she still took my breath away every time I laid eyes on her. She wanted me to shower, but I wasn't quite ready to let her out of my sight.

An idea sparked in my mind.

'Hey, Catra?'

'What, Stinky?'

I grinned, 'Shower with me.'

Her eyes widened and I saw a blush appear on her cheeks, 'What? No! Why? I already showered yesterday, plus you know I hate water.'

I leant up and the sheet dropped away from me. I was rewarded with Catra staring at my chest, her blush glowing brighter. 'Don't tell me you didn't stare, you know, before...' I reached for her hand.

She gulped, 'Before... when?'

'We weren't allowed to shower in the same stall in the Horde, but I know I used to steal glances at you. Did you look at me, too?' I slowly lifted her hand to my breast, and I closed my eyes as she gently squeezed it. When I opened them again, I saw that Catra looked more flustered than ever. I was being more bold than usual, it's true, but seeing that I had this effect on her filled me with a giddy confidence.

'Uh...' Catra's eyes flicked between her hand and my eyes, 'O-of course... of course I did, Dummy. You-you're amazing. You look amazing.'

'Let's do it then, we'll shower together in a Horde shower. It'll be like we're breaking the rules.' I let go of her hand.

Catra scoffed, 'You? Breaking the rules? Plus, the Horde is gone now so there aren't any rules... stopping... us...' Her voice trailed off at the end and I grinned.

'So let's do it! We've both always wanted to, plus, it's not as if you're still completely clean after what we did last -'

'Okay!' She interrupted. 'Okay. Let's shower together, I guess.'

I smiled at her.

'What?'

'You're still holding on.'

'You expected me to let go?'

I leant forwards and pecked her on the lips before moving to get off the bunk, 'Come on, let's go!'

'Alright, alright. I'm moving.'

**

The showers were just as I remembered them, cold and uninviting. A row of six stalls stood opposite a blank wall, furnished only by a long bench that ran the length of it. I put my clothes and towel down on the bench before opening one of the stalls and testing to see if the water worked. It sputtered to life. Good. These portable showers used water tanks as their supply, I only hoped it had enough water left or else this would be a very short first time showering with Catra. I took off the loosely fitting Horde fatigues, made for someone more Rogelio's size than mine, and chucked them out of the shower stall onto the bench. I closed the door but didn't lock it.

I angled my head under the stream of water, wetting my hair and running my hands through it before squeezing the shampoo I brought from Bright Moon onto my hands and rubbing it into my hair, foamy bubbles quickly forming. Once I was finished, I angled

my head under the water again and let it drain my hair. It wasn't long after that when I heard Catra enter the block and put her things down on the bench. The stall door slowly opened behind me and I smiled to myself as I lifted my head and swept my hair back, anticipating the warmth of Catra any second.

Hearing the lock slide closed on the door behind me made my breath hitch, and I let out a gasp as I felt the heat of Catra's hands tracing the scars on my back before settling on my waist. Her hands steadily continued, inching around my stomach, tracing the faint outlines of muscle. Then they moved up, cupping both my breasts and squeezing gently. I let out a moan and the breath I had been holding escaped with it. Catra's body was suddenly up against mine as she held us together. She buried her face in my neck and started kissing gently, coaxing sounds of pleasure from deep in my throat.

'I used to dream of this happening,' I rasped, 'I sometimes left my stall unlocked just in case you'd join me.'

'Hmm, really?' Catra purred, before moving back. I stood still with my eyes closed for a moment before peering over my shoulder, stealing a glance at her.

Catra was bobbed down, rubbing one of the Horde's standard bars of soap between her hands. That was the only way to use the Horde soap bars if you didn't want it to feel like you were washing yourself with a brick. Her tail flicked around behind her excitedly. I couldn't help but let my eyes wander up those legs, that back, those arms... she looked good. Strong. Athletic. I felt my face flush and my breathing heightened so I snapped my eyes away, looking back ahead of me at the shower valves.

It was only at times like these when I realised just how much she had changed physically since I left the Horde. It's not something that would be necessarily noticed if she were clothed, so being able to see her naked made me feel... lots of things.

Startled, I let out a yelp. Catra's hands were working their way across my body, rubbing the soap in. I fought to stop myself from melting into her, it was like she was everywhere at once. Touching, feeling, squeezing. I was losing myself, gasping at her massaging strokes.

Catra pushed me forward into the water, rinsing me off. 'All done. How was that?' She growled behind me. I could hear the smirk on her face.

'It was...' I fought to control my breathing, 'Amazing. That's exactly what I used to dream about you doing.'

I felt Catra's hands tighten around my chest and I let out a startled moan, 'Do you want to know what I dreamt about, Princess?'

Sparks shot through me as she whispered against my ear, '...yes,' I whispered in response, eager to know what she wanted.

Catra removed her hands slowly, then planted them on my shoulders before spinning me round and pushing me up against the side of the stall. She looked down my body slowly, taking it in. There was something about her stare that excited me, maybe it was the hunger in her eyes or the desire it fuelled within me. Catra's hands lowered from my shoulders, travelling down my arms before arriving at my wrists. Then she lifted my arms above my head and pinned them there under one hand. Her eyes locked onto mine with such a fierce gaze that it hypnotised me to the spot. I dared not move. Not even as her free hand held my face or as she leaned in, sealing the distance between us with both her body and her lips, her tail wrapping around my leg. She kissed me hungrily, parting my lips and fighting with my tongue. I moaned against her, lost in her warmth and the feeling of our mouths locked together in a battle I was desperately losing.

Her free hand then started cruising down my body. I closed my eyes as I felt her fingers trace my collarbone, moving to my side and working down my waist. All the while she kissed me with

such *hunger*. I could barely focus; I was losing myself in the kiss, but the touch of her hand was driving me crazy as it gradually edged lower. It was taking too long, I started writhing under her, begging her with my body to hurry. Her hand finally reached my hips, and I could feel her fingers crawling towards where I wanted them most...

The water cut off.

Catra moved back, letting go of my arms and breaking from the kiss, leaving me gasping for breath and wanting for her. That devilish grin creeped back onto her face as she watched me slide down the stall wall, my legs buckling from under me.

'Time's up, Princess.' She chuckled, looking down at me as I stared back up at her.

'No... Catra... please...' I spoke between heavy breaths, pleading with her not to stop there, to keep going.

Catra turned and unlocked the stall door, before looking back, 'Got to love you and leave you, Adora, the shower was fun. We should do it again sometime,' and she left, chuckling to herself.

I slowly rose to my feet and gradually left the stall, my legs still shaking from the anticipation of what Catra denied me. I couldn't believe she did it again, especially after getting so close...

'I should have checked the water tank...' I muttered to myself, as I wrapped a towel around my hair and dried myself off with the other one.

**

Catra was back in the barracks already, she apparently hadn't stepped under the water very much at all because she looked dry and was already wearing underwear. There were a few new items of clothing spread out on my bunk. Were those some of what she picked out from Bleatrix's stall? Was she going to wear something new?

I glared at her as she looked up at me entering, 'That was low, Catra.'

She giggled, 'You should know by now that nothing's too low for me, Adora.'

'You didn't even wash yourself! Or... let me wash you.'

Catra faltered, stumbling over her reply, 'Well... I... what do you want me to? *Magic* up more water?'

The gears starting turning in our heads, 'Maybe?' I suggested, 'You've already controlled plants and wind.'

She scoffed, 'I wouldn't exactly call what happened with the wind *control,* Adora.'

I sat down on the opposite bunk once again, like I had the previous night, and watched her curiously.

'What you doing?' I asked, as she hadn't moved for a while.

'I was...' she began, 'Choosing something new to wear... to apologise, I guess.'

'Hm. Well it had better be good to make up for leaving me there.'

I stood and removed the towel from around me before getting my clothes out. I felt Catra's tail tickling the back of my legs and turned to see her glancing over her shoulder at me.

I prodded her cheek, making her turn to look straight ahead, 'You don't get to look. You could have had this, but you chose not to. So no looking for you.'

Catra sighed, 'Fine, I deserve that.'

We then proceeded to get dressed, facing away from each other. I didn't look at Catra because I wanted to see the whole outfit she

was about to pick out and Catra didn't look at me because I forbade it.

Once I was done, I sat down on the bunk and looked up at Catra. She was wearing a pair of skin-tight grey pants, tail-hole included (good ol' Bleatrix) and was in the process of rolling the legs up to her shins. As she stood up, I saw that she was wearing a white and blue sleeveless top which looked to be a similar style to mine. She then put on her belt, and turned around, spreading her arms wide.

'What do you think?' She asked.

I was still taking her in, 'Um... It's definitely different. But in a good way, it doesn't look bad on you.'

'I think wearing relatively normal clothes will take a while to feel right...' She said, running her hands down her legs. 'I've been wearing nothing but uniforms and armour pretty much all my life. And you're still wearing the same thing you always have.'

'Hey! It's comfy!' I protested, 'And anyway, the jacket is new.'

She scoffed, 'Barely, it looks just like your old ones except the shoulders aren't trying to poke my eyes out.' She then turned and started putting away the other clothes that were sprawled on the bunk.

I sighed and laid back, landing with a soft thud. 'How's Scorpia doing? She called you last night, right?'

Catra sat down on the bunk across from me, '*I* called *her*. I know, who'd have thought, right? She was happy about it though. Her and Perfuma are still in Plumeria, she really likes it there. Says everyone treats her like family, treats her like she belongs there. They've been doing meditation and yoga and all sorts of awful sounding torture.'

I chuckled, 'What was that I overheard about mushrooms?'

'Oh. Some of the kids tried cooking, and handed out what they made to a few people, but those people started acting all... floaty. Turns out they used mushrooms that dull your senses or something.'

I sat up and looked across at Catra. She had her knees up and her arms wrapped around them. 'Are you okay?'

'Yeah, it's just... I really did treat her horribly. So it's nice to know she's happy without me around. Her and Perfuma seem really close.'

I switched bunks and sat next to Catra, she leant her head on my shoulder and I wrapped an arm around her. 'Scorpia has a huge heart, Catra. I know for a fact she doesn't hold anything you did against you. She knows you're working on yourself. We'll have to see them in person soon, maybe we could try some torture yoga.'

Catra laughed, 'I'd be way better at it. You're not flexible at all.'

'I can be flexible!'

'Not that far, you can't,' she said, shaking her head. 'I'm hungry. I'm going to go grab us some food, maybe try and pester them for normal sized portions. You wait here, I'll be back soon.' She stood and kissed me on the forehead before leaving the barracks, the door clicking closed behind her.

Sighing, I laid back on the bunk and stared upwards at nothing in particular. My fingers found the wing attached to my belt and traced it slowly. I still hadn't asked Catra to marry me. With everything that had been happening in Dryl I hadn't had the chance. It was always at the back of my mind, pestering me, but I didn't want to just blurt it out randomly. I wanted it to be special, memorable. Catra deserved that much.

Melog was also still missing. Catra wasn't showing it, but I knew she was worried. I was too. Where had they gone? Would they even be coming back? I would just have to trust that they were a powerful magical entity and they knew what they were doing.

I then remembered how I had awoken that morning, being shaken awake by Catra. Had I really had a nightmare? I must have - I was sweaty and breathing hard. I couldn't picture anything that I could have been dreaming of, however. Should that concern me? Maybe it was nothing...

My idle thoughts were interrupted by something nudging my foot. I sat up slowly, 'Melog?'

It was not Melog.

A small green creature wearing a brown cloak was prodding at my boot while looking up at me with a mischievous grin, 'SHE-RA!' It shouted. Its voice was high yet gravely and the sudden outburst took me by surprise. I yelled, jumping back onto the bed away from it.

'Dug!' Another voice, equally high and raspy, sounded from somewhere nearby, 'Don't scare the She-Ra!'

I watched as another creature crawled out from under the bunk, joining its friend in peering over the edge at me. They weren't very tall, and they seemed to be struggling to see over the height of the mattress.

'Are you the She-Ra?' The new one asked.

I nodded.

'The Elder has called for you!' The creature jumped up on the bench next to the bunk, before climbing up onto the mattress and standing across from me. It really was short and didn't seem to have much for clothing other than the brown cloak that surrounded it. It pulled down its hood, revealing its bald head and two long, green ears. 'I am Dig. My twin is Dug.'

The one called Dug climbed up onto the bed and stood next to Dig, before reaching their hands into the air and shouting, 'SHE-RA!'

'Um...' I didn't know what to say. My mind was blank but as it steadily caught up with what I was seeing questions started forming. 'Hello?' That wasn't one of them, but it would do for now.

Dig frowned and held up a hand, waving slowly. 'Is it alright? Has Dug scared it?'

I shook my head. 'Have you been stealing the fizzy drinks?' What a stupid question to start with. Good one, Adora.

Dug burped deeply.

I rubbed my eyes, making sure I wasn't dreaming, 'Okay, what are you? I swear I've seen something like you before...'

'We are known to us as those that Dwell. Those like you called us Goblins. Bad name.'

'Okay... does Entrapta know about you?'

Dig shrugged. Dug was still stood staring at me with their hands in the air.

'Did you mention an Elder? They wanted to see me?'

Dig nodded, 'Yes. Elder summons the She-Ra!' Dig spread his arms wide, knocking Dug off balance and causing him to fall from the bunk with a thud. Dig didn't seem to mind.

The door to the barracks opened and Catra walked in, holding a sack, 'Adora, you'll never guess what happened; Hordak tried apologising to me for -'

'SHE-RA!' Dug shot up from his prone position on the floor and ran at Catra.

Startled, Catra shouted in surprise before pelting Dug across the room with a swift kick. Dug hit the wall with a thud before sliding down it and landing on the floor.

'Dug is fine.' Said Dig, unconcerned. Dug shot a thumbs up into the air to confirm.

'Adora!?' Catra shouted, 'What the heck are these things?'

'Um.' I looked between them and smiled nervously at Catra, 'I think they're the fizzy drink thieves. They want me to meet their leader.'

'Elder.' Said Dig.

'Yes, Elder, sorry.'

Catra looked bamboozled, 'Does Entrapta know there's little green things running around Dryl?'

Dig and I shrugged. Dug groaned as they sat up slowly.

'Okay, we're going to Entrapta. This is too much weirdness for me to handle right now.' Catra walked over and picked up Dug by his cloak, carrying him to the door. 'Come on, Adora!'

Dig jumped down from the bunk as I moved off of it and we left the barracks, walking toward the Crypto Castle. Dig reached up and held onto my finger with his tiny green hand - I had to admit, they were kind of cute.

On Track

We didn't get far from the barracks before I spied Entrapta across the courtyard, darting to and fro between clumps of magical foliage. She was sprinting after something with her hair trailing behind her, holding a net by the handle with both hands above her head. Every so often she would stop and *thwack* the net on the ground in an effort to catch whatever she was relentlessly pursuing. Catra spotted her as well. She dropped Dug on the ground before arching her hands around her mouth and shouting Entrapta's name, getting her attention.

Entrapta looked over at us, startled, a few seconds later a small creature flew into the air. She quickly followed after it, using her hair to swing the net wildly to try and get it before it soared away. It was too late; the creature was now too high and too far away. Entrapta lowered to the ground and her shoulders slumped before she made her way over to us.

'Hey...' she sighed.

'Hey, Entrapta. What were you doing over there?' I knew she liked being asked about whatever it was she was doing, and she looked like she needed cheering up.

'You want to know what I was doing?' Her eyes lit up immediately and shone toward me. I nodded hesitantly. She squealed before starting what I knew would be a monologue, 'All morning I have been trying to capture some of the magical wildlife that has moved into Dryl since... "*the Resurgence.*" That's what I'm calling the effect of you releasing all...' she glanced at Catra, '... most of the magic from the Heart of Etheria back into Etheria! The creature I was just trying to catch takes approximately four seconds to unfurl its wings. So I thought I would have a good chance of being able to capture maybe one or two of the them and run some tests to see...' she trailed off as her eyes lowered to observe the two green fellows at our feet.

Dig was still holding onto my finger, observing Entrapta with a passive curiosity like seeing a character from a book standing in front of you. Dug, by stark contrast, was still laid on the ground staring into the clouds exactly where Catra had dumped him moments earlier.

I had anticipated Entrapta having a meltdown upon seeing the creatures, but to my discredit she bobbed down and spoke calmly.

'Well, hello. What might you be?'

Dig let go of my finger, stepped forward and... bowed? 'It is an honour to meet the Princess Entrapta. We are known to us as those that Dwell.'

Entrapta thought for a moment, 'Well that name's too long. How about just... Dwells?'

Dig shrugged. 'It is not my place to decide.'

Entrapta's eyes lit up, 'Ooo. And who's place is it?'

'The Elder,' stated Dig, 'The Elder has called for the She-Ra. Dig and Dug must take the She-Ra to see the Elder!'

Catra walked over to me and held my hand. I smiled and interlaced our fingers. I didn't know what she was thinking, but she must be as wary as I was about what was going on.

Entrapta stood back up before hoisting herself into the air with her hair and quickly speeding off toward the castle, calling back, 'Go with them! I'll catch up!'

I felt Catra's grip on my hand tighten so I squeezed back.

'Are we actually doing this?' She seemed incredulous to the situation.

'I guess so. Aren't you even a little bit curious? They don't *seem* bad.' I looked over in time to catch Dig kicking Dug,

startling them, before pulling them to their feet.

Sighing, Catra nodded. 'Alright. But if this goes wrong it's on you. I'll be right back.' I watched as she jogged back to the barracks, disappearing inside.

When wasn't anything on me? I looked to the sky, suddenly overcome with thoughts of how this entire world was looking to me for protection. I had also inspired other worlds to rise up against Horde Prime, those people would no doubt see me as some kind of saviour too. I want to rest. I want to marry Catra. I want to not bear responsibility for so much and for so many. But I'm She-Ra. As Light Hope said, I was "chosen," I "do not get to choose."

I sighed. I had hoped for some time to rest after the Heart, after defeating Horde Prime, but for the last week there's just been one thing after another. Now, Catra could use magic, Horde ships were disappearing, and these... Dwells, as Entrapta named them, have popped up saying their Elder wants to talk to me.

Catra soon reappeared wearing the fingerless gloves and circlet. Yesterday was the first time she used her magic on purpose and was able to control it. Considering this, she was able to get the hang of it incredibly fast. Perhaps it was the effect of the First Ones tech acting as a conduit as Mara's sword had for me.

'Okay, Dig,' I said as Catra neared, 'Where are we going, exactly?'

Dig looked up at me before glancing at the castle that towered above us, scanning it for something. After a moment they pointed a finger upwards, just left of the castle itself, where a long bridge stretched from it and met with the side of the rocky mountain.

I nodded, 'Okay, lead the way.'

**

Dig and Dug seemed to know their way around the Crypto Castle incredibly well, leading us down hallways and up staircases I had

never even seen before. After a very confusing journey through the labyrinth of a castle, we finally exited out of a tower and stood on the bridge that stretched across to the grey and foreboding cliff-face. It was easy to see the extent of the change that releasing magic had on Dryl from up here. Even the bridge had vines dangling down from it.

Entrapta had joined us, somehow, about halfway into the journey and was talking about where she had gone. 'Hordak said he would be staying behind to work on his observatory! Isn't that exciting? To be able to see into Space without going into Space! Oh, I would love to go into Space again, the weightless of floating through the void is intoxicating... oooh, I haven't been up here before,' she remarked as she realised where we were.

The bridge was incredibly high up and there were no barriers to speak of, Catra and I held on to one another, sticking close to the middle as we steadily walked along it. Dig and Dug were up ahead, leading us forwards while every so often tripping one another over, which was usually followed by Dig running on ahead to escape Dug's counterattacks. It became increasingly clear, as we neared the sheer wall of rock, that there was nothing at the end of this bridge. Once we reached the wall of stone, I put my hand against it, but it was just rock. There was no door or runes to read, just a blank rocky surface. I stepped back, looking back at Catra who just shrugged. Entrapta was busy looking at her tracking pad and seemed uninterested.

Without warning, the wall in front of us lit up with bright yellow runes. The magic looked similar to that cast by sorcerers and it spread across the wall, steadily forming the shape of a large arched doorway. I looked down at Dig and Dug, who were stood at opposite sides of the bridge with their hands against small rocky outcroppings that the magic seemed to be originating from. They looked focused, eyes closed, frowning with concentration.

Entrapta now seemed interested. She hid the tracker pad in her hair, and we all watched as the outline of the door steadily moulded into shape. Catra's hand found mine and squeezed,

neither of us said a word as we watched the sight before us. Purple started spreading across the door, as the colour and texture of the rock face vanished, replaced with the familiar smooth metal that the rest of Dryl was made from. The runes still shone their bright yellow but dimmed somewhat as the door finished forming.

Dig and Dug moved away from the wall and joined us once again. I barely noticed, still staring at the doorway that appeared out of nowhere. I had touched it, it felt like rock, but now there was a huge metal double door in its place, standing three times as tall as us.

Dig tapped my leg and I looked down as they pointed at the door, 'Heavy. Push.'

'Alright,' I was dumbfounded, 'Let's get this door open...'

I planted my hands on the cool metal of the door and pushed. Then I pushed some more, pressing myself up against it as my feet slid across the surface of the bridge. This thing was *heavy.*

I heard a scoff and snickering from behind me, looking back I saw Catra was laughing, 'You really are an idiot, Adora. As if *you* would be able to open *that.* Bring out She-Ra already and stop messing around, Dummy,'

'I didn't know how heavy it would be!' I protested.

Catra laughed again, 'Adora, it's an eighteen-foot-high metal door. Who knows how thick it is. Just get on with it.'

I sighed; she was right. I planted my hands against the door once again, 'For the honour of Grayskull!'

Strength flowed through me as the She-Ra form took hold, this time the door gave. It split down the middle, forming two half doors, which each opened inwards before flattening against the walls of the tunnel ahead. A second passed, then I watched as

rows of lights procedurally shone from the walls, steadily lighting up the darkness ahead.

Dug spread his arms wide before tightly hugging my leg, 'SHE-RA!'

Dig was also pleased and jumped on the spot, 'The true entrance opens! Come! Come! The Elder told us where to go! Come!'

Dig prised Dug off my leg and they both proceeded down the tunnel. I let the She-Ra form go and looked back as Catra and Entrapta stepped forward into the tunnel. Entrapta lowered her mask and started examining one of the wall lights. I held my hand out to Catra and she took it, and we proceeded down the tunnel following after the Dwell twins.

'So, Entrapta, did you know this was here?' We just opened a secret door at the end of a bridge leading to her castle, but she didn't seem familiar with it at all.

'Yes - maybe, I don't know. There's a lot of files in Dryl's computer systems about secret tunnels and whatnot. Besides, I always did wonder why there was a bridge going nowhere, so naturally I had some theories. But this is much further than I ever theorised possible!'

'So there's a secret door attached to your Castle and you didn't know about it?' Catra asked, 'And what even are those little green things?'

Entrapta lifted her mask and shrugged. 'I don't know, but I can't wait to find out!'

'This way! Come!' Dig shouted once again, visibly excited.

**

It wasn't long before we arrived at the place Dig was leading us. I didn't know what I had been expecting, but what stood before me now was not it. Entrapta was immediately fascinated by the

purple metal cart. It had four wheels which seemed to be attached to two strips of metal leading away into a tunnel of darkness and a lamp hung from a pole on one end. Dig and Dug climbed the steps next to it eagerly and peered inside.

Dig pushed Dug into the cart, 'Come! This is fastest way! Elder decreed it so!'

'I am *not* getting into that. It looks like a death trap.' Catra protested.

I tugged on her arm, 'Come on, Catra, we can't turn back now.'

'Yes we can, Adora. You can always turn back.' She let out a long sigh, 'But I know you won't. So sure, let's get in the death trap. Just so you know, I'm only doing this because I like you.'

'Aww, you *like* me?' I teased.

'Shut up!'

We all carefully stepped into the cart. Dig and Dug stood on a shelf that was built halfway up the inside, peering over the edge down the tunnel. There were no seats inside it, only a few loose rocks.

'Oooo, what does this do?' Entrapta mumbled.

'What?' I asked, only just registering what she said before she pushed down a lever next to the cart, releasing the brakes.

We suddenly jolted before the cart started rolling forwards into the tunnel, being carried by its own weight.

'Huh, this isn't so bad.' I looked around as the tunnel steadily passed us by, the lamp behind us swaying gently as it illuminated the jagged walls.

'Uh, Adora... it's speeding up.' Catra clung to the side of the cart. She was right, the tunnel must be sloping downwards because we

were quickly picking up speed.

Entrapta leant against the back of the cart, letting her hair flail out behind her as Catra and I clung to the sides. The cart had sped up enormously, and now thundered down the tracks, the lamp swaying side to side threatening to break loose.

Dig and Dug threw their arms into the air, 'Weeee!'

Entrapta laughed as the wind whipped her hair back. Catra and I screamed, clinging onto the sides of the cart, not daring to let go. The tunnel suddenly turned to the left, then the right, left again, zig-zagging us back and forth until it straightened out once more. I could see light at the end of the tunnel, fast approaching. I closed my eyes and braced myself...

The thundering of the wind in my ears subsided, everyone in the cart fell silent. I felt a hand on my shoulder, shaking me.

'Adora! Adora! Snap out of it! Look!'

I opened my eyes to find that it was Catra shaking me, but my gaze was immediately captivated by the sight that surrounded us. Firstly, I noticed the ceiling. It was covered in some kind of glowing green crystals. Of were they blue? Or red? Yellow? They seemed to be shimmering through a spectrum of colours, lighting up the... enormously expansive cavern below. My eyes went wide as I looked down. We were suspended in the air, the cart still travelling along the rails, but with nothing supporting them. As I looked around, I saw other carts apparently flying through the air, but as I looked closer, they too were travelling on rails.

Below us: a city. The architecture was almost identical to that of Dryl, everything made from the same purple metal. Spires rose from the ground like stalagmites. In what I assumed to be the center of the cavern, towered a gigantic metal column that rose from the ground to meet the ceiling. The whole place was astonishing. I ducked instinctively as another cart whizzed

overhead, full of giggling Dwells. One of them, hanging off the back, blew a raspberry at us as the cart quickly sped out of sight.

I was lost for words. This wasn't what I had been expecting either. Catra suddenly clung on to me, and I soon felt why. The tracks dipped once again, and we quickly picked up speed. I hung onto her as well, holding her tight as our cart sped toward the enormous central column.

After levelling out nearer the floor of the cavern, below the rooftops and spires, the cart began to slow down. We were able to see, up close now, that this really was a thriving underground city. Dwells were everywhere, peering at us out of their purple metal houses and towers, looking up at us as we passed over the streets in our cart, still impossibly suspended on rails with no supports.

'Hello! Hi, there! Hi!' Entrapta greeted most of the curious Dwells that watched us pass them by.

I looked up as we arrived at the base of the central column. It stretched upwards for miles, the sheer scale of it had been hard to gauge from so for away.

The cart finally came to rest next to a platform. Dig and Dug hopped out of the cart and hugged one another tightly. Entrapta lifted herself out of the cart with her hair while peering around. For once, she was stunned to silence. Cara got out next and held her hand toward me to help. I took it, pulling myself out of the cart with her help before she tugged me forwards into a hug. She wrapped her arms my waist and I hugged her tight in return.

'So,' she whispered into my ear, 'what now?'

A regular beat being tapped on the metal surface of the platform answered her question. It was followed by a deep, smooth, calming voice that was so gentle it eased any worries I had in my gut. 'Dig! Dug! Good job, you brought the She-Ra and the

Princess Entrapta. Very well done.' Our two Dwell guides rushed over and gripped the new arrival in a tight embrace.

Catra and I watched this happen and peered over at the newcomer with curious interest. The gentle voice came from an older Dwell, who walked along with a wooden cane that tapped against the metal as he approached. His long grey hair was tied back between drooping green ears in a braid, the hair of his beard equally taken care of. He was taller than our two small companions, approaching hip height against me. Unlike Dig and Dug, he was not clad in a simple cloak, instead wearing finely woven clothes that made him stand out enormously against the others.

He regarded us with a warm smile, while trying and failing to prise himself away from Dig and Dug's tight embrace. 'Welcome to the Etherium Mines of Underdryl! I am the Elder. It is so nice to meet you all, at long last.'

Tales of History

Chapter Summary

Are you sitting comfortably?
Then let's begin...

Info-dump warning

'So, you've been expecting us?'

Entrapta, Catra and I were following the Elder through a large corridor, paintings and drawings lined the walls and seemed to depict different parts of Etheria, although I didn't recognise some of them.

The Elder nodded slowly as he trudged forwards, his walking cane echoing through the corridor, 'Yes. Seer is almost never wrong. I sent Dig and Dug to find you based on something she said. I have become rather good at understanding her rambling over the years.'

Dig and Dug had been dismissed before we entered the base of the towering structure. I frowned as I looked over the pictures as we passed by them. That one sort of looked like Salineas, I recognised the gate, but there's not as many buildings there as there are now; it barely looks like a village.

'What's a Seer, exactly?' I wondered, smiling at Catra as she looked up at me. Having her holding on to my arm was nice and I liked the feeling of having her up against me, but she seemed nervous. I kind of understood why. There we were in a completely unexpected situation and place, being steadily lead along a familiar yet different purple metal corridor as an Elder of a race unknown to us until now talked to us as if we were old friends.

'Seer is a teller of fortunes and prophecy. Through her visions she sees the possibilities of countless futures, or so I have been able to deduce. After all, some of what she says does not come to

pass, yet most does. Yes, most does. It would do you well for you to look upon her and let her see *into* you. Perhaps after I show you why I had you called here, hm?'

Speaking with the Elder made me feel at ease somehow. He spoke with a wisdom, an assured confidence. It made me want to trust him, I felt that I was already trusting him. Asking him these questions was a way to fill the silence but hearing him speak was a comfort. Entrapta had been silent the whole way so far, her bug mask covered her face so I couldn't tell what expression she was wearing. Although, if I were a Princess of a kingdom and found another directly under it, many times larger than the one above ground, I think I would feel a little out of my depth too.

'Why did you call me here?'

'All in good time, my dear. First, though, I believe our Princess requires a history lesson.'

Entrapta's head tilted at the mention of her, 'History? I'd much rather learn about science...' Her voice was muffled slightly through the mask.

The Elder nodded solemnly. 'Yes, I don't doubt that. You remind me of them so much, after all.' He hobbled over to a doorway leading off from the corridor and peered inside. 'This is the portrait gallery. It holds the history of Dryl, Underdryl and you, Entrapta. Tell me, do you remember your parents?'

Entrapta stood still, 'My... my parents? Of course! They were such great robots! I've never been able to create something so lifelike since they passed away...'

Without responding, the Elder walked into the gallery. Entrapta followed slowly, driven by her curiosity. Catra let go of my arm as I started walking forwards, glancing back I could see she was worried.

'Adora, do you trust him?' She hugged her arms around herself.

I considered for a second, ‘I think so? I mean, I definitely want to. He seems nice.' Catra shuffled, unsure. 'How about we just hear him out for now?'

She sighed, 'It's not like we have much of a choice, Adora. I just wanted to know what you thought of him. Let's catch up to them, I'd hate to get lost down here.'

We entered what the Elder called the portrait gallery and saw that it was exactly that. Rows of pictures and paintings of all kinds of people and creatures were hung along the walls. Each one framed with a small passage written underneath. Entrapta was following the Elder down the left wall, he seemed to be talking to her as they passed by numerous vaguely similar portraits. Each one featuring one person with purple hair. Just after Catra and I caught up, the Elder stopped and inspected one painting in particular. Entrapta lifted her mask and looked up at the painting too, her eyes and mouth wide with wonder.

The portrait depicted a man and a woman standing proud, surrounded by crystals similar to those I had seen on the cavern's ceiling. The woman had short purple hair and welding goggles dangling around her neck. She wore a short-sleeved purple top with blue dungarees that were stained with oil. The man was bald with an incredibly impressive moustache and wore an immaculate looking lab-coat. These couldn't be...

'I'm sure you recognise the hair if nothing else. I did help design the robots that looked after you all those years. Your parents were insistent on having something recognisable included on the machines. Perhaps they spoke with Seer and knew this day would come. Even so, I was always dubious about the inclusion of a pre-programmed expiration date.' The Elder leant forwards, reading over the language written on the plate below the painting. 'Yes, I remember them well. Enara and Iven. These, Entrapta, were your mother and father.'

I watched in stunned silence as Entrapta stepped forward, looking up at the huge painting. 'These... are my parents?' Her voice was

barely more than a whisper, I had never seen her like this before.

Catra moved forward, placing a hand on her shoulder but not saying anything, looking up at the painting as well.

'Yes...' The Elder continued, 'This painting must have been completed a year or two before you were born. I believe one of the last rulers of the Scorpioni painted it for them as a favour. A brave thing to do, considering the war.'

'What happened to them?' Catra was the one to ask.

'For that, I must tell you more about where it is you stand.' The Elder walked across the gallery slowly, before sitting on one of the many benches available. I walked with him, standing nearby. Catra guided Entrapta to another bench and sat her down as she stared up at the painting of her parents.

'Thousands of years ago now, our forefathers worked alongside those you call the First Ones to build this place, the Forge, at the heart of Underdryl. It is a grand piece of First Ones ingenuity that allows for the safe refinement of Etherium. It was not long after that when people started to call it the Great Etherium Mine of Underdryl. Etherium is a precious, magical resource that allows for technology and magic to work closer together much, much easier. It could also be used to strengthen other metals if combined into an alloy. Those gloves you wear, Feline, those are made with Etherium wiring.' Catra looked over at him, before looking over the gloves which covered her hands.

'After the First Ones left Etheria and we were plunged into Despondos, Etherium continued to be mined. Great scientists, one after another, worked alongside my father and his father to develop our city and technology. Eventually, they formed a kind of royalty, and we helped them to construct their own kingdom on the surface; the kingdom of Dryl and the original Crypto Castle. Although I believe the initial design has been vastly modified over the centuries by those who inhabited it.

'The fires of the Forge raged for centuries and its produce was used for all manner of things. That is, until the war. Until Hordak. Enara and Iven, fearing the worst, created robots in their image and sent Entrapta off to Dryl. They then sealed the entrance, which remained sealed until *you* opened it to gain access today.' He looked up at me, but I wasn't watching him. I had my eye on Catra, she seemed to be watching Entrapta doing something, but I couldn't tell what from where I stood. I couldn't help feeling like this could be too much for Entrapta to handle all at once.

'The last thing your parents wanted to happen, Entrapta, was for the Etherium mines to fall into Hordak's hands. They gave their lives to shut down the Forge, ending the production of Etherium. It was a terrible accident, one that should have been avoidable. But shutting it down before Hordak learnt of it meant that Dryl never had any kind of strategic importance to Hordak, it was just an empty metal city laden with traps. And so, we were left alone, and Entrapta was able to grow up in peace. Extinguishing the Forge was a huge risk, its fires had raged uninterrupted for thousands of years and was not designed to be shut off by just anyone.' The Elder looked up at me once again. 'This is why you are here, She-Ra. The time has come. Seer has foretold it. Now that the magic has been returned to Etheria and the moons are due to align, it is time to ignite the Forge once more.'

Entrapta rose from the bench and turned to face the Elder. 'I... I can't mourn my parents because I don't remember them. To me, the robots *were* my parents. I mourned them when they expir... died.' Entrapta lifted her hair and beamed a wide smile, showing that she had been taking notes while the Elder was speaking, he looked genuinely perplexed, as did I. 'But I have SO MANY questions about the Forge, Etherium, and programming robots with personalities!'

'I have a question.' Stated Catra, raising her hand a little. 'Why did Entrapta's parents send her away to Dryl? Wouldn't she have been safer hidden down here?'

The Elder relaxed somewhat, perhaps this was the kind of question he had been expecting from Entrapta. 'Ah, yes. That was a hard decision for them to make. They were reluctant to send you away, Entrapta, but they had to stay to seal the door and deactivate the Forge. It's because they had to seal the entrance that it was impossible for you to stay. The atmosphere down here is not exactly... hospitable for races other than those that Dwell. You would be able to spend a few weeks down here quite comfortably, I'm sure. But years? No, I'm afraid I couldn't allow that. Not after...'

'I have a suggestion!' Entrapta interjected, 'How do you feel about calling yourselves "Dwells" instead of "those that Dwell?" It's much easier to say.'

The Elder closed his eyes and breathed in heavily. 'For us to begin calling ourselves something other than which we have known ourselves to be, for thousands of years, is not something that can be done overnight. We are those that Dwell. You, however, may refer to us in whichever way you prefer. Just don't say *Goblin* around anyone down here, that won't be welcomed.'

'I have some questions,' I spoke up, sitting next to the Elder on the bench.

'Ah yes, the mighty She-Ra. What do you wish to know?'

'You mentioned reigniting the Forge. Something to do with the moons...?' I hoped he knew where I was going with this.

The Elder nodded, 'Hmm. Yes, the alignment. You want to know how it works? I suppose that will be necessary if you are to reignite the Forge... Very well, follow me.' He got up once again and made towards the entrance of the gallery, leading us off somewhere else.

Catra moved over to me quickly and quietly as we entered the hallway once again before whispering in my ear, 'Are you actually

going through with this? Entrapta's parents *died* to turn whatever it is off.'

I stopped walking and looked her in the eye, taking her by surprise as she backed off slightly. I moved in, snaking my arms around her waist. 'Don't worry, Catra. I won't do anything if Entrapta says not to. If Entrapta says yes, I will need to know how to turn it on. I'm sure everything will be fine.'

She held my head in her hands and touched our foreheads together gently, 'I hope you're right, Adora. I'll follow you anywhere. I just don't want you to get hurt.'

'Catra, I'm She-'

'Yes, I know. You're *She-Ra.* I still worry about you. You've done nothing but throw yourself into danger ever since you left the Horde.'

I looked up into Catra's eyes as she stared at me with an intense focus. Seeing her like that, showing concern for me, stirred a warm fuzzy feeling deep inside that I just couldn't hide; even when I tried biting my lip to hide the smile that was spreading across my face.

'Adora? Why are you smiling? I'm being serious.'

'I know, I just...' I buried my face against her shoulder before whispering, 'It's nice... knowing that you care about me.'

Catra began to vibrate, a low purr rising from within her, 'Adora... of course I care. I've always cared.' She held onto my shoulders and pulled me away from her before looking my in the eyes again. 'We are definitely continuing this discussion when we get out of here. But I think we're being left behind...' She glanced over my shoulder.

I turned to look as well; Entrapta and the Elder had managed to get quite far, which was impressive considering how slow he was. 'Come on then,' I said, grabbing her hand, 'Let's catch up!'

**

This place was huge. The Elder explained while leading us to our next destination that this building was originally the castle of Underdryl, thousands of years ago. But because of its location the First Ones had to completely hollow it out and the build the Forge within it. Hundreds of remodels later and this *structure* was the result. It encircled the tower that was the Forge and contained all the systems necessary to monitor it. Of course, it still also acts as the castle of Underdryl, hence the gallery. However, due to the Forge not being used in about eighteen years very few of the other Dwells ever ventured inside anymore.

The room he led us to looked akin to Entrapta's lab, with monitors lining the walls showing various systems and their levels. Most of them were empty. Entrapta was immediately fawning over the computer systems, examining their wiring and various other hidden components.

Elder walked forwards and tapped something on one of the lower keyboards. 'This is where we used to monitor the Forge. Keeping an eye on its levels and so forth. It is not usually necessary to step inside as it is fully automated when running, all we have to do is load the unrefined Etherium onto the conveyors and the machine does the rest.'

An image came up on the screen, a diagram of the mountain that showed the Forge rising straight through the middle of it. 'As you can see,' the Elder continued, 'at the summit of the mountain there is a crater. It is closed at the moment, but once the twelve Etherian moons are aligned the summit will open. The concentration of magical energy, if effectively harnessed and redirected by She-Ra, will, in-short, jump-start the Forge.' The diagram showed the twelve moons forming a line above the mountain, and a blue streak fired downwards into the summit, down the column to the base of the Forge, where it was then redirected into something else apparently turning everything on.

Catra stepped forward, 'And only She-Ra can do this? There's no other way?'

I could see why Catra would be sceptical, it did after all sound just like the Heart of Etheria all over again. Absorbing all that magical energy and then firing it off at something...

The Elder nodded, 'I am afraid so. She-Ra is the single most-effective conduit for harnessing, storing, and redirecting magical energy of this scale. We tried once before, a few years ago, by creating a machine that would, in theory, redirect the energy. It was simply not strong enough.'

It all sounded reasonable enough, but one thing still nagged at me. 'Why is it that you're reactivating the Forge after all this time?'

He looked perplexed, as if I had just asked him why living things breathe. 'It... It is our purpose, as those that Dwell, to refine Etherium. Now that the war is over, it could be invaluable to developing Etheria's new period of peace. The applications of it are infinite, and I'm certain I know of someone who would be more than keen to test them.'

Entrapta appeared above one of the larger monitors across the room, 'I think he means me! I would love to explore an entirely new material... Think of the experiments!'

The Elder smiled at Entrapta and I couldn't help but wonder if he found some kind of solace in her presence if she reminded him of her parents. He looked at me after a moment, a quizzical brow raised, 'Well, She-Ra, will you help us restart the Forge at the heart of the Etherium Mine of Underdryl?'

I met Catra's gaze. She didn't hint one way or another, letting me choose, deciding what I want to do. I felt her hand on mine, her way of showing support for whatever it was I decided. After squeezing her hand in thanks, I looked back at the Elder and nodded, 'I will help you.'

He smiled a wide, genuine smile. 'That is good to hear, Adora. We have a while until the moons align, how would you like to meet Seer?' I nodded enthusiastically, 'Very well, I shall send for Dig and Dug once again, and they can lead you to her.'

Catra rolled her eyes as I beamed a wide smile toward her, tightening her grip on my hand.

I just hoped this adventure would have a better resolution than the last one.

Why is a Raven like a Writing-Desk?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The outer city of Underdryl reminded me of the Fright Zone. Huge metal buildings sprawled across the ground and up the edges of the cavern, each one polka dotted with brightly lit windows which shone bright against the dull purple metal of the structures.

Dwells were everywhere. They appeared to be running around doing little errands, weaving in and out of doorways as we passed by. The majority were a similar height to Dig and Dug, but it seemed the ear length was the best way to tell their age. It also seemed that there were limitless shades of green that the Dwells could be. Some were a bright green, some a murky green, some were very close to being yellow. Every so often we would also see Dwells being followed by robots that I could swear were nodding their heads in greeting. It seemed that having robot servants was normal down here.

Dig and Dug tripped each other over ahead of us as they lead the way to where the Elder said Seer lives. Somewhere towards the outskirts of the city that wasn't accessible by cart. I had never met a seer before, and my mind raced at the possibilities. A woman who could see into the future. My future? Would I actually want to know? I wasn't sure. Knowing what was coming could be useful, especially regarding the Horde ships stranded in orbit around Etheria, disappearing one by one. Maybe she'd be like Razz, old and crazy... wait, *Razz!* I still hadn't gone to see her after everything that happened. Once we get back to Bright Moon that would be high on my list of things to do. I hoped Swift Wind was keeping her company still, he did say he always checked up on her now and again.

A cart rattled above us on one of the suspended tracks and distracted me from my thoughts for a second as I watched it glide

away.

Thinking back to Swift Wind, I realised it had been a while since I had seen him or felt his connection to me. I held onto Catra's hand and closed my eyes while we walked, focusing on making that connection. I could feel him and in turn, he could feel me. He sensed my intention and let me see what he was doing. I felt the hard impact of wood against his hoof and he kicked in the doors to a stable, proclaiming, *"I am Swift Wind, and I decree that you are free!"* When nothing happened, and all the horses in the stable barely reacted, I felt the despondency wash over him. I burst out laughing as the connection faded, wondering when he would learn that-

I walked straight into something hard and metal and fell backwards, landing on the floor with a thud. Catra burst out laughing. I opened my eyes to see that she was doubling over, clutching at her stomach. I leant up on one arm and looked ahead, rubbing my sore forehead. There was lamppost directly in my path. I could've sworn we were in the middle of the street moments before, out of the way of any of the lamps that lined it. I watched as Catra started to recover and wiped a tear from her eye. She wouldn't have...

'Catra, did you lead me into a lamppost?' I sat up fully and held my hand out to her, realisation hitting me that Catra may be my girlfriend now, but she was still *Catra.*

She grabbed my hand and pulled me up, smirking. 'Who, me? Why would I ever do such a thing, Adora?' Her tone told me all I needed to know.

I rubbed my forehead as we continued following after the mischief twins, 'Ow... Why would you do that? My head hurts.'

Catra laughed, 'Adora, you held my hand and when I looked at you your eyes were closed. I can't pass up on a chance like that. Besides, I thought your hair poof might have protected you.'

My hands automatically reached up and patted at my hair poof. I don't understand why everyone keeps making fun of it. I always thought it looked nice...

**

The place Dig and Dug led us to couldn't have looked more out of place if it tried. There was no metal surrounding the rickety wooden house, the terrain rough and uneven. There were three floors, each seemingly held up by wooden supports that stretched all the way to the ground. I swear I could see the whole thing *swaying.* It looked like it had been here forever but could topple any second.

Catra and I exchanged a concerned glance. I was glad to see that she was equally apprehensive about the death-trap of a building that stuck out from the rest of the city like a sore thumb. Dig and Dug were already climbing up the porch. I let out a deep breath before stepping forwards and walking up the house. One thing that became clear as I neared the front door is that this building was not built with taller creatures in mind, or at least the front door wasn't. It was only a couple heads taller than Dig, who was only slightly taller than Dug, which meant the top of the door only just reached my midsection.

'Hmm.' Catra appeared at my side, apparently unimpressed with the low doorframe. 'Wonder why all the other doors we've seen are our size, but this one isn't.'

I shrugged, watching as Dig and Dug were peering into the windows, 'Maybe Seer doesn't get many tall visitors?'

Catra rolled her eyes, 'Wow, Adora, you're really kicking the boat out with that one, huh?'

'Hey!' I jabbed an elbow toward her, but she managed to back away before it connected, 'what's that supposed to mean?'

She was about to reply but stopped as her ear twitched. We both turned our heads at the same time, only to see that Dig had

opened the door and was stepping into the house with Dug close behind. There weren't any lights on inside, so I lost sight of them almost immediately.

'Is that allowed?' Catra asked, motioning toward them.

'I have no idea, let's follow them!' I moved forward quickly, bobbing down to squeeze through the doorway.

'Adora! Wait!' I heard Catra following behind, but she stopped as I disappeared inside. After a moment I saw her eyes appear under the doorframe, looking at me with a glare I couldn't quite decipher, 'Adora, this is ridiculous.'

'Fine, stay outside then.' I smiled as I heard Catra groan. I was still bobbed down, but as I looked around, I realised the ceiling inside was tall enough for me to stand. I rose to my full height and stepped carefully into the room, holding my arms out in front of me so as to not walk into anything. It was dark inside, and I had lost sight of Dig and Dug. I could vaguely see the outlines of furniture, but I couldn't tell what anything was. Was there a light somewhere?

'Adora?' I turned around to see that Catra had braved the tiny doorway and was standing just inside it, her eyes shining in the gloom.

'Finally decided to come in, did you?' I asked, but my smile dropped when I realised she was looking *past* me.

'What's that?' She asked, almost a whisper.

I gulped and turned around slowly, dreading whatever had caught Catra's attention. There hadn't been anything else in the room when I entered, or at least I *thought* there wasn't.

My eyes met with two bright yellow circles, glowing in the darkness, looking down at me. I yelped and jumped backwards but stopped and shut my eyes tight as the room was suddenly

filled with light. I heard Catra hiss behind me as I struggled to open my eyes, adjusting to the sudden brightness.

'Greetings! We have been expecting you. Please don't be alarmed, Seer will be with you shortly. I hope.' The voice sounded metallic, grating, artificial. When I could finally make out fuzzy outlines without my eyes hurting, I saw that there was a robot standing tall in front of me. One of its arms was retracting from across the room where it had turned on a light fixed to the ceiling. The rest of the robot's arms and legs soon retracted too, until it stood at waist height, looking up at me.

I blinked a few times, taking it in. The robot was *talking*. Properly talking. Emotively. Suddenly I remembered the Elder mentioning robots being programmed with personalities, and all the nods I received on the way here had been friendly greetings. 'Uh, thanks?'

'Not a problem! I shall go inform Seer of your arrival. She does get ever so sleepy...' I watched it leave through another side door before I looked around the room. It was... cosy? It reminded me of Madame Razz's house in woods, a bit of something here, a dash of something else over there. There were various tables filled with vials of interestingly coloured liquids, various furs and cloths hanging from the ceiling, a severe lack of chairs...

Catra had wandered over and was prodding at some of the mossy-looking things that were slowly sliding up the walls. They left a sticky trail behind them, and once I noticed them, I realised there were *a lot* of them. Seer definitely had come kind of pest problem.

I was about to suggest not to prod the slimy green things, but I was interrupted by the sound of thundering footsteps from the floor above. They ran across the upper floor before cascading down some stairs. Then, popping her head around a doorway at the far side of the room, an extremely old, wrinkly Dwell peered out at me. She had long grey hair, much longer than the Elders, that was in dire need of a brush. It seemed to be holding itself

together in the remains of a braid, but it didn't look like it would last much longer. I lifted a hand and waved nervously as she fully entered the room and looked me up and down. She appeared quite tall for a Dwell but carried herself with a hunch, so it didn't really make much of a difference to her height. I also noticed that her ears were incredibly long, so long that I had initially thought they were part of her hair, or a decoration.

'Adora!' She exclaimed, running over to me as her long green ears trailed behind her on the floor, 'You're terribly late, you know. Naughty.' Her voice was low and raspy, and her sudden outburst of energy had caught me off guard.

'Uh... I... Um... are you Seer?' I managed to ask.

'They call me *"Seer"* because they think I see into the future! That would be crazy! I just speak to Time.'

'Huh. Yeah that makes... loads of sense.' I glanced back at Catra, but she just shrugged and leant against the wall.

I yelped as Seer was suddenly right next to me, apparently trying to gauge how tall I was, 'Why is it you are always too tall or too small, hm?'

'I don't think-'

'Then you shouldn't talk.'

'Wha-?'

'People who don't think shouldn't talk. Come, come, follow me!' She grabbed my hand and led me back towards the door she had entered from. I caught sight of Catra as I was led away but she just watched, smug.

'Have fun, princess,' she called after me as I was dragged away.

The stairs were thin, winding, and steep. I struggled to fit round one of the bends in it as Seer sped off ahead, floating effortlessly

up the death-trap of a staircase. Once I pulled myself free, I stumbled into the room beyond. It was filled with candles, patterned draperies, and sticks of incense burned on a table in the corner. Seer sat down on a cushion atop a circular carpet in the middle of the room, also surrounded by candles.

'Well this is... dramatic.' I remarked as I steadily stepped into the room, being careful not to knock over any of the candles.

'Yes...' said Seer, 'it would be boring otherwise. Come, sit before me, before Loo-Kee takes your spot.' She shook her fist towards the window. I glanced at it, but there was nothing there. Where had I heard that name before?

Gingerly, I stepped into the circle and sat cross-legged in front of the wily old Dwell. She had her eyes closed and appeared to be concentrating, humming softly and slowly swaying forwards and back.

'Uhh... should I be doing something?' I asked, looking around nervously. I didn't know how these things worked but part of me was impatient to know more about my future.

'Shushhh!'

'Okay!' I sat up straight, focusing on not making any noise or distracting her in any way.

A few seconds passed before Seer suddenly gasped, yelling, 'come! Time is here, closer!' and reaching out a hand toward me.

Tentatively, I leant forwards and she placed her small wrinkly green hand on my forehead. Her touch was cold at first, but it seemed to grow warmer incredibly quickly.

'Close your eyes, hush and don't think. I speak to Time now...'

I did as she said and closed my eyes.

Not thinking.

Trying not to think.

Thinking about not thinking.

Wait, does that count as not thinking?

Oh no. Now I'm thinking about that.

Stop it!

'Shushh!' Seer hissed again.

Sorry! Ah! Stop thinking!

Then she spoke, her voice was suddenly calm, measured, 'Ahhh... Adora. I have met with Time and he has spoken to me. He speaks of happiness ahead. Yes... much happiness. A question asked, a question answered... Promises and sacrifices... But also sadness, pain...

'Time spins his wheel against you, Adora. Events unfold, even now, further than you can see. Eternia calls for you, for She-Ra... oh, my poor dear. You have so much left ahead... so much you have to do... Soon, you will have to-'

I opened my eyes and looked up at Seer, her hand falling away as she gasped, 'Wait, what? Eternia? That's just a password. But what question is asked? Did I ask it? Do I ask Catra?! What's the answer? What does she say!?'

Seer pulled her hand back and sighed, 'the connection is broken... Tell me, why is a raven like a writing-desk?'

I blinked, 'Uh... I don't know, why?'

She jumped up from her seated position, her voice no longer calm or measured like it had been when her hand was warm against my forehead, 'I have no idea!'

I sighed wearily, raising a hand to cover my face. 'I really hope this wasn't a waste of time...'

'If you knew Time as well as I do,' Seer said, apparently unconcerned with my presence anymore, 'you wouldn't talk about wasting it. It's him.'

'I don't know what you mean,' I replied, quietly, almost a whisper.

'Of course you don't!' said the old Dwell, starting to blow out some of the candles. 'I dare say you never even spoke to Time!'

'Speak to time...' I cautiously replied, 'how would I have spoken to time?'

'If you only kept on good terms with him, he'd do almost anything you liked with the clock. Suppose it were morning, time for breakfast. You'd only have to whisper a hint to Time, and round goes the clock in a twinkling! Haha! Mid-day, time for dinner!'

I sighed and stood up, walking back toward the staircase. 'You're madder than Razz. I just have more questions...'

'Just because I'm *mad* doesn't mean I'm not right.'

Pausing in the doorway, I remembered what the Elder had said. Almost everything Seer says comes true. I mentally kicked myself for interrupting her - she may have had more to say. Looking back, I watched as she started collecting the candles scattered around the room. 'You remind me of Razz actually... do you know her? Have you met?'

'Who? Razz? Who am I?' A candle dropped from her hands and rolled away as she looked up at me questioningly.

'You're... Seer.' I frowned, had she gone crazier than before?

'Am I?' Seer seemed to think deeply, apparently trying to remember her own name. 'I knew who I was this morning, but I've changed a few times since then.'

'Greetings!' The small robot with extending limbs had appeared ahead of me, standing at the entrance to the stairs and cautiously watching the old woman as the hair on her ears was singed by the remaining candles as she aimlessly pottered around the room. 'Apologies, Seer goes loopy after she reads possible futures. It may be best if you leave before she gets too attached.'

'Attached?' I looked back as Seer locked eyes with me. I did not like the look in her eye. At all. 'Okay! Thanks, Seer! Bye!' I turned tail and sped past the robot back down the stairs as quickly as I dared without falling down them.

Emerging into the main room once again, I found Catra being wrestled by Dig and Dug on the ground of the room below. She seemed to be struggling, apparently overwhelmed by the two small creatures jumping around her. 'Catra? What's going on?'

'Victory!' Dig shouted, clinging onto Catra's waist.

'They challenged me! Then they chucked water on me and jumped me!' She growled as she tried to throw them off. 'Don't just watch! Help me! Get them off!'

I clapped my hands and Dig and Dug stopped, looking up at me. 'She-Ra?' gasped Dug.

'I'm done. It's time to go.' I couldn't hide the disappointment in my voice. Not only had I interrupted Seer when she clearly had more to say, I also snapped at her out of desperation for a hint at how Catra might respond if I asked her *that* question. Seer hadn't even said what kind of question was asked, so it was entirely a moment of weakness on my part.

The Dwells jumped up off of Catra and made for the door. Dig opened it and tripped Dug as they walked through before laughing and launching themselves forwards, causing them both to roll off of the porch in a heap.

As I walked forwards Catra got to her feet and stopped me, holding my arm, 'Adora? How'd it go? Is everything okay?' She

was always good at spotting when I wasn't completely myself and must have picked up on my downturned gaze.

I sighed and looked at her, meeting her concerned eyes. 'I just... I have so many questions now. I'll tell you about it later, I promise. But we have to get back to the Elder.'

Worry flashed through Catra's eyes, but she nodded, respecting my promise to tell her more. 'Okay. I trust you. Let's do this thing.'

She took my hand in hers and squeezed reassuringly as we started back towards the Forge, passing more Dwells and robots on the way. The visit to Seer had been much shorter than I expected, the journey there had been far longer than I thought it would be. I sighed, remembering how far we would have to walk back. Our guides were apparently still full of energy, running between lampposts and weaving between other Dwells and the gangly legs of startled robots. Eventually, Dug caught up to Dig and tripped them, beginning a small brawl in the middle of the street.

'You got wrestled to the ground by *them?'* I asked incredulously, watching Dig and Dug playfought ahead of us.

'Shut up! I didn't want to hurt them...' Catra's ears pinned back as she looked away, avoiding my prying eyes.

'You've so gone soft.' I observed, just a hint of a smirk showing at the edge of my mouth.

Catra huffed, 'I have not gone *soft.'* Her tail flicked behind her wildly.

'You have. I'll have to double check just *how* soft when we get out of here.' I whispered, watching as her fur bristled and her tail stopped flicking angrily behind her, instead wrapping around my waist.

'Whatever.'

We continued on in almost complete silence. The short conversation had only distracted me for so long before I began recounting Seer's words in my head.

A question asked, a question answered...

Eternia calls for me, for She-Ra...

So much left ahead, so much I have to do...

What did it mean?

Chapter End Notes

Ah yes, extremely vague hints about the future.
About as helpful as guessing what the weather will be the next day.
If only Adora hadn't broken her concentration...

Forge of the First Ones

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Elder and Entrapta were waiting for us as we arrived back at the Forge. Entrapta was practically jumping on the spot from excitement and the Elder looked... *tired.* Their long talk must have gone well. Or perhaps interrogation would be a better word, I can only imagine the endless questions Entrapta must have had for the old Dwell.

'Welcome back, welcome back! How was your visit to Seer?' The Elder greeted us as we started walking inside, his low voice once again projecting that wisdom that I found strangely calming. Though I was still unsure what to make of it all.

'I'm not really sure, I just have more questions...' This was true, after all. The visit to Seer couldn't be described as enlightening. It could have been if I hadn't interrupted her, but all I was left with were vague hints that could mean anything. Except for the one that mentioned that door password, that one was more pointed but didn't really reveal anything useful.

The Elder hummed, considering his response while his walking cane tapped that regular beat on the metal floors. 'Yes, Seer tends to have that effect on people. She can only provide the slightest of hints sometimes. It gives me a lot to think about whenever I visit. Oftentimes, I'm unable to fully decipher what she means, but what I am able to understand usually comes to pass.'

'You mean like us being here - today?' Catra asked. She was still holding my hand, having not let go since we left Seer's house. She had also tried distracting me on the way back, asking what the rest of Seer's house had been like and commenting on how the lack of natural light down here made her fur feel itchy. I

appreciated it, if only to hear her voice, and to stop myself from falling too deep into my own thoughts.

'Precisely. That was about a month ago now. I sent Dig and Dug up through the pipes to wait for you. Until you opened the door, that was the only way to get up to Dryl. Come, come, the moons are almost aligned - the entrance to the Forge is just down here...'

Entrapta squealed in delight, holding a tracker pad out in front of her with her hair as she looked over a flowing chart of information. 'I'm just so excited! Refined etherium has so many potential applications! I already have multiple theories for new inventions that I can't wait to test out!'

'I just hope this doesn't go wrong somehow...' Catra mumbled, low and out of earshot of anyone else.

'I'm sure it will be fine,' I hushed back, trying to be reassuring. 'What's the worst that could happen?' I mentally facepalmed when I caught Entrapta looking at me. I had said that last bit too loud.

'Well...' Entrapta started.

Catra's ears perked up, her grip on my hand tightening while her tail thrashed behind her nervously, 'Well? Well what?' I had hoped nothing would get in the way, that this would be a simple in and out, but with our track record of course that would be a pipe dream.

My gaze was briefly drawn ahead as we approached a door that was entirely out of place against the purple metal of the structure that surrounded us. It was a triangular First Ones temple door with a password inlayed into the front in that First Ones constellation writing. I recognised the word immediately: *Eternia.* I was still unsure how a door password could *call* for you, but I decided to bury that thought for now as Entrapta finally decided to elaborate.

'Well... there's a tiny chance the *"Guardians of the Forge"* will activate. But they've been powered down for hundreds of years so you should have *absolutely* nothing to worry about!' Entrapta beamed at us, clearly excited by the prospect of centuries old guardians coming to life and attacking us. I saw the expression Catra made at this admission and winced.

'What! And you didn't think to mention this before!?' I could feel her fur standing on end as Entrapta's words sunk in.

Letting go of Catra's hand, I reached up and smoothed down the fur on her shoulders, trying to reassure her as best as I could, 'Catra, it's okay. She says they've not been turned on for a really long time. So there's nothing to worry about.' Part of me was saying this to try and convince myself of it too, Entrapta's history with supposedly friendly robots briefly flashed into my mind but I fought that image down.

Catra looked back toward me with her ears pinned back, clearly bothered by the thought of something bad happening. 'But what if-'

'The Princess Entrapta and She-Ra are indeed correct,' the Elder stated, interrupting Catra before she could start listing the ways it could go wrong. 'There are centuries old guardian robots within the Forge. However, they have been powered down for a considerable length of time. Their prime directive is also to protect to Forge, not to harm those who wish to activate it.' He pulled put a small circular device from his pocket that seemed to be attached to his jacket with a chain and observed it for a moment. It must be some kind of timepiece, as there was no way to know the time of day from below ground. 'The alignment is almost upon us. If you are ready, Adora, the time is now. I believe you know how to open the door.'

I took a deep breath and nodded, pushing down my worries about robots and resolving myself to tackle the task ahead. I turned back to look at the door once again. *That word* sticking out more than usual, like it was trying to draw me in and whisper its secret

meaning to me. Obviously, no whispers came. It was just a word on a door. Or a squiggly pattern of lines and shapes to everyone else who can't read it. I knew it must be important somehow, but it would have to wait. Perhaps I could find Bow's dads and see if they know anything about it...

'Elder and I will be keeping an eye on you from the control room!' Entrapta added eagerly, hiding the pad in her hair and hoisting herself of the ground to rest on those purple stilts. 'As soon as the Forge is activated it has to be turned on so that it can be in a constant state of refining, otherwise it will steadily lose power.'

'Good luck, Adora.' The Elder smiled and turned to leave, starting back in what I guessed to be the direction of the control room. Entrapta followed close behind, speaking *at* him and asking more questions about possible uses of etherium and its applications.

It was just me and Catra now, standing next to each other in front of the door. 'Okay, I can do this.' As I stepped forward, Catra didn't. She let go of my hand and stepped back, her tail wrapping around her legs as she hugged herself with ears low. I felt my brows crease together as a wave on confusion washed over me. Was she not coming?

'I know what you're going to say. Don't worry about me, Adora. I'll wait here. You have your hero moment.'

'Catra, that's nowhere close to what I want. You're a terrible mind-reader. I want you with me, by my side. I won't feel safe unless you're there with me.' I let the truth spill from my mouth. I can't imagine ever going into a situation like this without Catra ever again, though her anxiety about it is understandable. The last time we were in a First Ones temple together, it didn't end *brilliantly* after all.

I felt a wave of relief wash over me as her ears perked up once again and let out the breath that was caught in my throat. She looked at me for a long moment, apparently stunned. 'Adora... are you sure? What if I... What if I endanger you again?'

Fighting down conflicting feelings is something I've become somewhat of a master at over the years. On one hand, I wanted to keep her safe and would love nothing more than to keep her out of harms way. On the other, I love her an incredible amount and trust her completely. She has, after all, been training with her magic and at least has a better understanding of how it works. 'Come on,' I said, reaching my hand out towards her, 'I'd feel safer if you were with me.'

'You... you really want me with you?'

The answer to that one is simple, blindingly sappy, and will forever be true. 'Always.'

Despite the corny grin on my face, a sweet little smile appeared on Catra's as she reached out and took my hand, her tail swaying happily behind her as she wrapped herself around my arm. We stood there, just looking at each other for a moment. It may have been longer than a moment, I'm not always entirely sure when I'm lost in *those eyes.* Before I knew what I was doing, my hand was caressing her cheek and my lips were on hers. She kissed me back gently, squeezing my arm and sighing softly.

Catra pulled back from the kiss but didn't move away. Instead she smiled and bumped our foreheads together, something we've always done for as long as I can remember. 'Come on then, dummy, let's get this over with.'

I planted a light parting kiss on her forehead and pretended like I didn't hear the adorable trill it coaxed out of her. That was definitely a sound I wanted to hear again. Lifting my hand from her cheek, I stroked it through her hair before gently scritching behind her ear, coaxing out a soft purr. 'Okay, my love.'

Catra chuckled quietly, the purr getting steadily louder. 'That's the second time you've called me that.'

'Yeah... well, it's true. I don't plan on stopping at twice either... unless you don't like it.'

'It's fine with me, princess.'

Catra rubbed her cheek on my shoulder before stepping back and checking her circlet was still in place on her head properly. I had almost forgotten it was there, nearly completely covered by her fringe, but the gloves couldn't be hidden, black and blue against the hazel of her fur. Once Catra finished she took her place next to me facing the door, as we had countless time previously before running into the training arena in the Fright Zone, and nodded to signal she was ready.

I reluctantly tore my eyes from her and looked ahead, speaking the password loud and clear.

'Eternia!'

**

Stepping inside immediately made me feel small, insignificant, like I had emerged into a world far larger than our own. The absolute scale and atmosphere of the space within was exhilarating, like nothing I had ever seen before. It was huge. Expansive. Much bigger than I had been expecting but then, remembering the scale of it from the outside, I really should have expected it.

The chamber was circular, made up of that familiar blue and purple First Ones architecture. Huge pillars angled from the floor to the walls around the perimeter as if holding up the walls from collapsing under the sheer scale of themselves. In the centre of the chamber, a series of steps circled around a platform, decorated with First Ones patterns which flowed from the middle of it down the stairs and across the floor and walls.

Above us... I'll never forget the sight. The chamber just didn't have a ceiling. It continued up, straight to the summit of the mountain. I could only see so far, however, as darkness clouded the summit in shadow. Along the walls, various protrusions intruded on the otherwise perfectly smooth interior. Cogs and wheels jutted out at all angles, with conveyors of all lengths and

widths splayed at odd angles seemingly leading nowhere. I couldn't pretend to understand the inner workings of the Forge, all I had to do was jumpstart it. If I could jumpstart a skiff, this should be a piece a cake. A huge, ancient, dangerous piece of cake.

Only once I had climbed the stairs in the central to the chamber, and stood in the middle of the platform, did I see the ignition. It jutted out from the wall opposite the entrance, triangular and somehow foreboding. Various pipes led away from it, angling in odd directions, and disappearing into the walls of the structure.

I watched as Catra circled around the bottom of the stairs leading up to the central platform, looking at something along the walls. Following her line of sight, I saw what had commanded her attention. Four huge heavily armoured robots, spaced equally around the walls of the chamber, stood like statues on guard. They each wielded a long glaive, decorated with symbols of the First Ones. Wires and tubes connected them to the infrastructure they were built into, like they had been on charge for a thousand years. They didn't *look* like they would be moving anytime soon. Perhaps the Elder was right, and there was nothing to worry about after all.

After a moment, I became aware that I was surrounded by a low glow. As I looked upwards through the column of the Forge, I saw that the shadowy darkness near the summit had been replaced by a pinprick of white light. The glow from the moons. The crater must have opened, the alignment would be upon us soon, which meant I had to be ready.

'Catra!' I called toward her, 'It's starting!'

She looked up at me and nodded, before stepping away from the centre of the chamber. The moonlight shining down on the platform seemed to be having an effect on the Forge, all the First Ones inscriptions below me at the top of the platform steadily started glowing their familiar blue.

'Okay,' I said, talking to myself, reaching my hand into the air, 'I got this... For the honour of Grayskull!'

I smiled as I caught sight of Catra gaping at me once She-Ra's form took over, a bright golden light temporarily filling the chamber. The blue glow from the First Ones markings had spread quickly across the floor and reached the walls. Just as the Elder had said, the robots remained where they were. The glow from the moons surrounding me steadily grew brighter as the alignment came closer to completion. Suddenly, I had an idea. Perhaps I could reflect the beam instead of absorbing it?

'Adora! Be careful!' Catra called up to me. I wasn't looking at her, staring upwards, but hearing her voice was a comfort I gladly let wash over me.

'Always am!' I shouted back, summoning the shield and holding it ready. I then focused on the shield, changing its form to be circular with a larger circumference as well as giving it a reflective surface. Not quite a mirror, but it would have to do.

Catra scoffed, *'no you are not!'*

I would have laughed too, but she was right. I had no idea what was about to happen and there I was, preparing to redirect the combined magical energy of Etheria's twelve moons towards a specific point ahead of me. No pressure.

'Why didn't they just build the starting thing under the beam of light!?' Catra called up to me.

That did make me laugh, trust Catra to start questioning something like that right as I'm about to do something absolutely crazy. 'They're First Ones, Catra! Nothing's ever easy!'

The light seemed to gradually grow steadily brighter, but I couldn't see if it was getting closer or-

YES, YES IT WAS!

I was suddenly engulfed in a powerful beam of magical energy that felt like a building had been dropped on me. Luckily, She-Ra was able to hold herself up. Tensing her enhanced muscles, I brought the shield up above me, angling the beam towards the waiting triangular receptacle. As the magic made contact, the ignition started to spin and all the cogs and conveyers above us responded in kind, clanking and trundling into life.

'Adora!' I heard Catra shout from somewhere nearby, 'it's working!'

The urge to look round and see Catra's expression as all this took place was immense, but I felt that if I broke concentration for even a second then I would drop the beam. How long would this go on for? I could feel the pressure of the magical beam pressing down on me, She-Ra would be able to hold out for a while but...

'Uh...'

Was that Catra? She sounded worried. Was something happening?

'Um... Adora...'

I strained to lift the shield enough so that I could peer out from under it and I opened an eye to look toward Catra's voice...

It was green.

The whole chamber was green.

The familiar blue glow of the First Ones temples had been replaced with *that* green. I watched as it spread further, taking over more of the blue and working its way towards the guardians.

'Catra!' I shouted, immediately aware of the possible danger she was in. But I couldn't move, the weight of the magical beam was too much and if I dropped it the Forge wouldn't complete its reactivation.

The sound I desperately didn't want to hear flooded the chamber, thundering above the noise of the magical beam starting up the machinery around us. Footsteps. Heavy, loud, footsteps.

'Catra! What's happening!? Get out of there!' I desperately wanted to help, to go to her side.

'Adora!' Catra called back but I couldn't see her - she must be behind me somewhere. 'I'm going to try and draw their attention! I'll be fine! Keep going!'

I could see two of the guardians from my current position under the shield. They were either side of the ignition, slowly thudding their way forwards. Each of them readying their glaives, holding them above their heads as they approached me in the middle of the chamber. Both of them glowed that eerie bright green colour. I desperately wanted that green to be a coincidence, as I couldn't bear to think about the alternative in that moment.

Catra was fighting behind me, I could hear her jumping around and attacking the robots. The two in front of me moved ever closer.

'Catra!' I shouted. I desperately wanted to help but the moon beam was relentless, just how much energy did this thing need?

That's when I saw Catra running around the central platform to my right, her tech shining brilliantly as she swiped at the guardian's legs with two bright blue long thin energy swords, leaving deep cuts in the armour plating. Distracted, it started after Catra as she made for the other one, slashing it in the same way and drawing its attention away from me. I watched for as long as I could as she dodged and moved around the lumbering giants with ease. Cutting through the guardians' weapons with her own seemed to be no problem either, the swords passed right through the blade of one of the glaives, cutting it in half.



I had been so focused on watching Catra's fight in front of me that I didn't notice another guardian coming up behind me. It struck me with the blunt end of its glaive and I yelled out in pain, falling to one knee. I shut my eyes tight, clenching my teeth

together, only just managing to concentrate enough keep the shield aligned.

'GET AWAY FROM HER!' Catra shouted in *anger*. The outburst was immediately followed by a fizzing, crackling sound and a loud crash from across the chamber. I looked around to see that the guardian had hit the far wall and practically crumbled against it, the wall seemingly undamaged.

But what stole my attention next was Catra. A fierce scarlet aura surrounded her; her fists engulfed with a menacing red energy that sparked violently. It looked like lighting, or raw electricity. The last time I saw that kind of power was... *Scorpia*. Catra was channelling the magic from the Black Garnet, the runestone Shadow Weaver had always leeched from to gain her power. I couldn't count the amount of times that power was directed at Catra but here she was, wielding it for herself and unleashing it to protect me.

I faltered in my concentration, accidentally taking another full blast of the moons' concentrated magic. I yelled out, forcing myself to stand up slowly against the immense force of the magical beam and angling it back toward the Forge's ignition.

'Catra!' I shouted, getting her attention as she looked toward me, probably expecting me to tell her to run or leave. Instead, I smiled, and looked at her with an assured confidence. *'You've got this!'*

She shot me a self-assured smirk before launching herself forwards with the red energy, a trail of it lingering behind her. I couldn't see the ensuing fight as it was directly ahead of me, behind the shield, but I had a feeling Catra was winning. What had caused her to suddenly manifest this new magic didn't matter to me, not as long as she could control it. And, by the sounds of tearing metal, she was doing an amazing job.

The pressure of the magical beam steadily started to diminish, and I soon found that I could stand with ease, no longer pressing

against the floor with all my strength. 'Come on!' I shouted, willing for the ordeal to be over.

And it was.

The beam ceased as the moon's alignment ended. The Forge's ignition now spun independently, creating its own perpetual motion with the energy stored inside. Lowering the shield I could see that Catra was attacking the towering remnants of one of the guardians that seemed reluctant to give in, red energy crackling around her as she laid into it with ferocious tenacity. Another steadily encroached on her from behind, missing an arm. I willed the shield to transform back into my sword and took aim, firing a concentrated blast of She-Ra's magic straight at the remaining bot behind Catra. A gaping hole appeared in its torso and with a loud clatter it fell forwards, shattering into a sea of parts. I stepped down off of the platform and made my way towards her.

Catra's bot finally gave in, falling backwards. She looked behind her at the hollowed-out guardian before spotting me as I approached, 'I had it!'

'Sure you did. Come on, we should-'

I was cut off by Catra jumping on me and wrapping her arms around my neck, her legs around my waist, and her lips sealing against mine. Having taken me by surprise, a moment passed before I kissed her back. As soon as I did the kiss deepened, a startled moan escaped me as I felt her tongue exploring my mouth. I let go of my sword and wrapped my arms around her, holding her close and kissing her back just as passionately, immediately losing myself in her warmth and the softness of her fur despite the roar of the machinery around us.

Eventually, as they always seem to, the kiss ended. Catra buried her face in my neck and rubbed her cheek against my jawline, apparently having no plans to let go. I could see now that the green glow from before had vanished and the four guardians lay destroyed around the central platform. The ignition whirred

overhead, leading an orchestra of grinding gears and pumping pistons as the Forge steadily came to life.

'I'm so glad you're okay...' Catra whispered against me.

'Yeah, me too.'

Four pylons then started slowly rising from the floor around the central platform, energy cackling between them as they stretched upwards to fill the space in the middle of the chamber.

'Okay,' I gasped, catching my breath and holding Catra close, 'time to go.'

**

'I thought you said those robots *wouldn't* be an issue!' Catra was furious. She had jumped from my arms and stormed towards the Elder as soon as we neared the control room, apparently forgetting until then what he had said beforehand and how it didn't correlate with what had actually happened. I reverted to my normal self and hesitantly stepped in after her.

'You have my sincerest apologies, but those bots were not activated by the Forge or any of us in here.' The Elder stood his ground, planting his cane firmly on the floor before him. Entrapta was glued to the monitor screens behind him, paying no mind to the current argument.

'Then what did!? Because if it wasn't you, then...' I met Catra's gaze. She looked worried, scared. I knew what she was thinking. I was thinking it too. But it just *can't* be.

'Catra,' I whispered softly, moving closer, 'I know what you're thinking. I'm thinking it too. It can't be *him.* It just can't. He's gone.'

She looked me in the eye. It felt like she was gazing right through to my soul. 'You don't believe that.'

My breath caught in my throat and I stared at her. 'What?'

'I can tell, Adora. You may say that, but deep down you don't believe it. You're thinking about it, running through the possibilities.' Catra sighed, looking up at one of the monitors that showed the pylons within the Forge firing their energy at the middle of the central platform, beginning the refining process. 'I know you are - because I am too.'

I shook the thoughts from my head, not wanting to even consider them. 'Catra, I watched him cease to exist! I used the last of the Heart's magic within me to destroy him!'

'Now you're trying to convince yourself that that really was the end of it... look at what just happened, Adora! You can't see *that,* the same thing that happened at the Heart, and not believe it isn't *him!'*

'It can't be him! I- I don't... I can't...' I could feel tears threatening to fall from my eyes and my hands begin to shake so I turned away, quickly walking out of the room and down the corridor. I was suddenly feeling extremely short of breath and needed to calm down by getting away from that conversation, that line of thought. But my thoughts followed me, tearing into me and plastering themselves at the front of my mind.

He's come back!

He's going to kill everyone!

He's going to take Catra away again!

'Adora!' I could hear Catra following me, but I pressed on, struggling to control my breathing. 'Adora, wait!' She grabbed my arm, forcing me to stop, 'look... I hope it isn't him either, but we can't rule it out after what we saw in there. He's the only one who's been able to take over First Ones tech like that, I saw it happening in the Heart, all the walls turned green exactly the same way-'

You'll never get chance to propose to her!

She'll be dead before you do!

As will all your friends!

Suddenly, I felt dizzy, faint. I turned back to pull Catra against me and lean on her, hyperventilating as I hid my face against her neck and tears fell from my eyes, trying to drown out my thoughts with nothing but Catra and keep myself in this moment. The feel of her in my hands, her smell, her heartbeat. Catra's hands quickly wrapped around me, stroking me in calming motions. I melted under her touch, pressing myself against her and soaked in the feeling of comfort she stirred within me by just holding me and being close.

'A-Adora? What's wrong? Your scent...'

'I-I don't know... I just...' I tried to control my breathing, 'if it really is h-him, then it means this peace is a lie. I'm *tired*, Catra. I w-worked so hard for Etheria to be at peace and if it's slipping away...'

I couldn't explain the thoughts that were fighting to rise to the surface in my mind, but I couldn't completely ignore them either. If Prime really was coming back, then I shouldn't propose. It wouldn't be right, not with that danger there. But what if something did happen? Would it be better to propose sooner just in case? I wanted to marry her in peace, knowing that we wouldn't have to worry about anything else. I wanted to just *live* with Catra. No more fighting, no more risking our lives... And my friends... Prime would definitely go after them, it was our unity that defeated him last time, I wouldn't have been able to do what I did if everyone wasn't working - *fighting* together to save Etheria...

'No. We won't let it. *I* won't let it. If you want this peace to last, just say the word and I'll make sure of it.' I sucked in a deep breath and moved back, locking eyes with the determination on

Catra's face. 'This is what you've working towards for years. This is why you left the Horde, fought against me. I see now that you were right, the whole time. And now that you have what you've been fighting for, and now that... now that I have you I... I finally feel... *happy.* You complete me, Adora. All I want in the world is to see you happy too.'

The shaking in my hands was now much calmer than it had been, and I found that breathing was suddenly easier, less of a struggle. A small laugh escaped as Catra's words ignited a familiar warmth within me, and suddenly the tears were falling for a very different reason. 'Now who's the sap?'

'Shut up... You're not getting anything like that again until-' Catra cut herself off, her face flushed as she broke eye-contact, suddenly finding the walls especially interesting.

'Until... until what, Catra?' There were many things that could have followed those words, but I suddenly, desperately, wanted to know what she was going to say.

'Uh!..' Catra panicked, looking around for an out. 'Never mind! Doesn't matter! I'm going to go tell the Elder and Entrapta we're ready to go! Be right back!' She turned on the spot and ran back toward the control room on all fours, disappearing down the corridor and back into the control room.

While I had a moment to myself, I worked on controlling my breathing once again, closing my eyes and taking deep breaths. My hands had stopped shaking now, so I wiped my face of the tears I had cried just moments before. The thought of Prime returning forcing its way into my head was not a welcome one. *He was gone.*

I looked down at my hands and watched the residual shaking in them. I had never experienced anything like that before... What *was* that?

**

The trip back to Dryl was much calmer and slower than it had been on the way down. As we passed over the city of Underdryl, once again in a cart, I saw that activating the Forge had a much wider impact than I initially expected. All the Dwells were suddenly moving with purpose, carrying bits of the glowing crystal, etherium, towards the centre of the city. Other carts whizzed by overhead, filled to the point of overflowing with the recently mined ore. They were really not messing around. Entrapta had stayed behind, for now, saying she wanted to witness the refining process for herself up close to *"really study and understand it."* As I looked back at the central column of Underdryl, I could see that the Forge was alight, glowing with First Ones inscriptions trailing up and around the sides.

In the cart it was just Dig, Dug, Catra and I. Dig and Dug seemed to be playing some variation of *Bot-Shield Laser* which was a game we often played as cadets in the Horde. Though Catra and I came up with our own version of it: *Bomb-Shield-Knife.*

I heard Catra's words replaying in my head...

"Bomb beats knife, knife beats shield, and shield beats bomb. So because I used knife and you used shield - I win."

"What? That doesn't make any sense... I would just block it with the shield."

"No you couldn't, Adora. The shield weighs you down, plus I'm way too fast for you with a knife."

I smiled at the memory, Catra usually picked knife, and usually found a way to convince me that knife could beat anything I chose, even if I also chose knife. That was such a long time ago now. Looking over, I saw that Catra was sat at the other end of the cart, watching as the city passed by underneath. I wanted to ask what she meant earlier - was she onto me? Or was I overthinking it? I hoped to myself that Prime really wasn't back and I could still propose to her - some doubtful part of my mind

kept whispering that she would say no, which only made me want to ask sooner, to confirm for myself.

Maybe after this, once we're back in Bright Moon-

'Hey, Adora...' Catra was looking at me, her ears pointing down and her tail still behind her. 'What... what happened back there?' I knew what she was referring to. I swallowed.

'I don't- I don't know.' I looked down at my hands, checking to see if they were still shaking. They weren't. 'I felt like I couldn't breathe. My hands were shaking... I had to ground myself by clinging onto you... It felt like I was going to faint. I was so dizzy, all these awful things swirling around my head. I don't know what that was.'

Catra watched me, scanned over me, her eyes searching. 'I could smell it. It was the same as... That nightmare you couldn't remember this morning - you smelt the same then. Fear. Panic. I hardly ever smell that on you. I'm worried, Adora.'

'I'm fine now. I promise.' I tried sending her a reassuring smile, but she just growled quietly and looked back over the side of the cart. That was Catra code for *"I don't believe you."* I'd heard it countless times before, and it was usually followed by her brooding over whatever happened. I would just have to wait and welcome her with open arms when she decides to speak to me again.

**

After Dig and Dug waved us goodbye, exclaiming in delight as the cart sped back down the track, we made our way back through the Crypto Castle and into the courtyard of Dryl. I looked over at the tree of roots that Catra had summoned the day before, still standing proud within our temporary sparring ring. As we moved toward our barracks, something caught my eye, emerging from within it. I tensed, readying myself for an attack-

'Melog!' Catra shouted, running forwards.

Melog ran forwards too, dropping something from its mouth as it bounded towards Catra, landing on top of her and licking her face. They had been missing for four days at this point, ever since the evening of the Moon Market's aurora.

'Where have you been, buddy?' Catra asked, laughing as she was showered in affection.

The thing Melog dropped caught my eye and I found myself walking towards it, suddenly fascinated by what it could be. Melog started mewling at Catra and she listened intently, they must be explaining where they'd been. But the thing on the ground was *all I could think about.*

I want to pick it up.

I want to hold it.

I reached out just as Catra sat up and shouted out to me, 'No! Adora! Don't touch that!'

My hand grabbed the First Ones data crystal and I lifted it high. It shone with a brilliant *green* energy. I was hypnotised by it. It looked so-

The trance was broken as a sharp pain shot up my arm. I yelled, both in surprise and pain, dropping the crystal, causing it to shatter it on the ground. When I looked back down, the broken shards were blue, no longer glowing with that intoxicating green light.

Headaches were something I had experienced before, but the pain in my head at that moment was so intense that I felt myself blacking out immediately. I think I heard Catra calling my name, grabbing at my shoulders as I fell and easing me to the ground, but I couldn't hear her. My eyes were heavy and I couldn't fight them as they closed, sleep suddenly felt like such a *good idea.*

I was wrong.

I felt myself plunge far away, deep inside my own mind.

Deeper, until there was nothing but darkness.

Chapter End Notes

The absolutely amazing artwork in this chapter is by the awesome @the.r.account on Instagram and @theraccount on Twitter! Give them some love!

Fear is the Mind-Killer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

'Catra!?'

I ran down the familiar dull-green metal corridors, dodging out the way of hissing pipes and trying to ignore the thumping of my heart in my chest. Every room I glanced in was empty, even the spots Catra usually hides in are left vacant.

'Catra!? Where are you?'

Shadow Weaver had been horrible again, shouting at Catra for doing nothing wrong. Catra ran away the first chance she got after Shadow Weaver let her go, before turning her attention to me. I watched her go with a tight feeling in my chest when I saw the tears in her eyes, but I was pinned to the spot by Shadow Weaver's crushing grip on my arm. I tried to ignore what she was saying at the time, but the words found their way into my head anyway. Somehow, no matter how much I resisted, her words always found a nook in my mind to hide in.

'You don't need her, Adora.'

'Catra will only hold you back from your full potential.'

'She's a waste of your time and mine.'

'You're the only reason I have not rid the Horde of her already.'

'Forget about that insolent child and focus on your training.'

'I expect great things from you, Adora, do not disappoint me again.'

I shut my eyes tight and tried to drown out the words by focusing on my current mission. I had to find Catra, to make sure she was okay. Nothing Shadow Weaver ever said about Catra seemed real, not when I couldn't get her out of my head. Being around Catra feels good, right, she makes me a better person, a better cadet. She pushes me to be better, challenging me and supporting me in her own way. How can I forget about her when she's all I can think about?

'Catra!? It's me! Where are you?'

After sprinting down what felt like every corridor in the Fright Zone, I stopped to catch my breath. Catra was not usually this hard to find, so she must have found a new spot to hide in, one well out of the way of where I was able to climb. Out of the corner of my eye, as I leant against the cool metal of the corridor I had found myself in, I noticed a door that had been left open. A warm breeze, thick with the oily and smoggy smell of the Fright Zone, filtered through it. I didn't remember a door being there, but, now that I looked around, I didn't recognise where I was at all. I thought I had explored most of the Horde by now, sometimes being shown around in groups led by Shadow Weaver or other Force Captains, and sometimes exploring with Catra after hours as we dodged searchlights and patrols to find a new hiding place. But I didn't recognise that door or this place, even though I was sure I hadn't even crossed into another building or changed floor.

Cautiously, I made my way over to the door. Maybe Catra had gotten lost, as I seemed to be, and had found a way outside to see where she was. With a new string of hope to cling onto to, I stepped a bit more confidently towards the door, pushing it open so I could squeeze through.

'Catra?'

The door led out to a balcony overlooking the Fright Zone, but for some reason it didn't look... *normal.* All the smokestacks were shut off and the sky shone a brilliant blue, sparkling in the

daylight as pure white clouds soared overhead. What really caught my attention was the plant life, covering and draping over everything. Vines and Ivy snaked along the surface of the balcony and draped over the railing.

This felt wrong. Innately wrong. Like something bad had happened to the Fright Zone overnight. Only yesterday, our squad had been doing laps of the nearby tank hangar and it definitely didn't look like this then. Tearing my gaze from the scenery, I suddenly realized there was a crate on the balcony. It was a purple metal; unlike the dull green of the crates we're assigned to carry and sort from transports usually are. I felt my heart do a flip in my chest as I noticed the tail sticking out from around the back of it. *Found her!*

Carefully, trying my hardest not to make too much noise and spook my best friend - it would take me ages to find her again if she ran while we're lost - I approached.

As I neared the edge of the crate and reached out to rest my hand on it, the tail quickly vanished inside, followed by the tell-tale sound of Catra's claws digging into the metal as she sped away further *into the crate.* I froze. That can't be right. I could hear the thudding of my heart in my ears again as I suddenly felt that out-of-place feeling swallowing me again, like something is wrong but I can't quite place it. Peering around the edge of the crate, I saw that it carried on like a ventilation shaft. Catra and I had squeezed through plenty of them to recognise it as the inside of a vent, but this was not a vent. It was a crate. I could move it, pick it up, turn it. No matter what I did to the crate, the vent remained, stretching away into darkness.

This was definitely wrong. Everything in me screamed at me not to enter the vent but... Catra had. Catra had run away further inside and I had to find her. I had to make sure she was okay. I took a deep breath and steeled myself before dropping to my knees and crawling forwards, into the crate and into the ventilation shaft. It was a tight fit and seemed to stretch on for miles. The further in I crawled, the darker it became as the light

from the entrance only shone so far. My breathing became more laboured and I steadily grew tired from the exertion of dragging and pulling myself through the duct. I stopped for a moment, rolling onto my back, just to catch my breath - it seemed harder to get the air my lungs were demanding they needed.

Pressure. That was the first thought that popped into my head. Followed quickly by *restricted,* and, as I opened my eyes and tried to move but failed, *panic.* The walls of the shaft were pressing in on me, crushing me, all the light was gone now, and I couldn't see anything around me. All I could feel was the cold metal of the duct walls as they constricted me.

'No! Help! Catra!'

As I shouted out a plea for help, shouted out to Catra, I felt my hands come into contact with a familiar softness. Suddenly, I was surrounded by a comforting warmth. It didn't last though, as the walls and ceiling of what had been the duct seemed to move away, forming some kind of carpeted platform on which I was sprawled. I sat up, trying to see where I was but failing as the darkness did not recede. I moved my hands around on the warmth of the platform, rising and falling against the surface of it, my hands sliding through what could be grass but felt more like - fur? I looked up, gasping as I saw two huge heterochromatic eyes glaring down at me through the abyss.

In that instant, everything came back to me. I wasn't a cadet in the Horde, not anymore. I hadn't been for nearly four years. Memories surged into my head: The Rebellion, the war, the Heart, Dryl, the Forge and...

'Catra?' I spoke the word into the void. Saying it out loud struck a chord, and I felt a wash of affection and longing sweep through me. But then the realisation that this current situation was innately *wrong* dawned on me. This was a dream; one I was not in control of and...

I was in the palm of her hand.

Those eyes I loved so much narrowed at me with a hatred I had hoped never to see again. 'Hey, Adora.' The voice was deafening and seemed to come from everywhere at once. It was definitely Catra's. I had heard that tone of voice enough times to know that this was not *my* Catra. This was a memory. 'Time to go.'

Catra's hand suddenly started to move, rising upwards through the darkness. I panicked and rolled off of her palm, slipping away into the void just in time to escape being squashed as Catra's hands clapped together, the sound echoing through the emptiness. After too short of a moment, I landed on a hard, rocky surface. It was damp to the touch. I blinked furiously, rising to my feet as my eyes struggled to adjust to the new brightness around me.

'I don't need you, Adora.'

I looked up upon hearing Catra's voice and was met with the sight of Salineas in ruins. Exactly the same as it had been after Double Trouble's distraction. Then my eyes fell on Catra, walking towards me with claws out and glinting in the light of the fire. She wore her mask, her hair long, one arm covered by a sleeve with a red diamond just below the shoulder. I backed away; this wasn't right. This wasn't real. It was just part of the dream.

'Catra? What's going on?' I tried to hide the fear in my words at seeing Catra approach me like this, nothing but hatred on her face and the glint of death in her eyes.

'You mean nothing to me, Adora. You were always in my way.' Her voice was low and assured. She meant every word of it. There was no conflict behind her eyes.

'NO! That's not true! This isn't real!' I knew it wasn't real, but the words hurt anyway. I held my head in my hands and tried to drown out my surroundings. I wanted nothing more than for the nightmare to end. The rush of air registered within my subconscious and I dodged instinctively as Catra hissed, barely

moving out of the way as her claws sliced though the empty air where my face had been moments before.

'Don't dodge, Adora. You can't escape this.'

'Catra! Why are you doing this?' I felt tears stinging my eyes. *This is a dream. This is a dream.*

'I don't want you, Adora. I don't need you...' I froze. Catra quickly closed in on me and her hand locked around my neck, pulling me forwards as she hissed into my ear, her words like poison. 'And I will never, ever, *love* you.'

I croaked as I struggled to breathe, grabbing at her arm and trying to get her to let go. 'That's not true... I know it isn't... I love you, Catra... I want... I want to marry you...'

Catra laughed. A loud, cold, unfeeling laugh that pierced through my heart. 'Marry me? Why would you ever think I would *marry* you, Adora? After you left me behind, let me be tortured by Shadow Weaver, Hordak, Horde Prime... You think I would marry you, after *everything you've done to me?*'

I could feel the tears dripping down my cheeks, the need to cry welling up within me but stopping with my lack of breath. I choked on my sobs as Catra's grip tightened. 'Goodbye, Adora.'

She let go. I fell. Further than where I knew the ground to be. I could hear the sound of waves crashing against rocks fast approaching, and yet also receding. I closed my eyes and cried as I fell, waiting for the inevitable impact...

**

I awoke with a start, sitting up quickly as tears spilled down my face. My breath shuddered as I leant forwards on my knees, openly sobbing and screaming in the ground and clutching at... *grass?*

A light breeze caught me by surprise, causing me to shiver as I looked up, wiping the tears from my face as I surveyed my new surroundings. I recognised the field immediately, even though I have only ever seen it in visions. This was where Light Hope showed Hordak stealing me as a baby, where She-Ra had stood opposite me on the other side of a swirling portal when I was still finding my connection with her. I sat back on my legs and closed my eyes, taking deep breaths and basking in the warmth around me. I fought the urge to cry that was rising up within me. It wasn't real. This was a dream. Catra would never say any of that, never hurt me.

Even so, her words rattled around in my head as I fought against them. This wasn't real.

Right?

She didn't actually think that. She couldn't.

But could she?

'Adora?'

The rising doubt within my thoughts was interrupted by a voice. A warm, soothing voice that I recognised immediately.

Mara.

She was standing behind me, not as She-Ra but as herself, a look of worried concern clouding her face as she reached out to me. I took her hand and she helped me rise to me feet. But I kept going, taking her by surprise as I hugged onto her tight, letting myself cry into her shoulder. She just held onto me, stroking down my back, allowing me to let out the sadness within myself.

'Catra... she...' I sobbed, trying to find the words to explain what was happening, why I was like this.

'Shh... I know, Adora. This is all in your head.' Her hands continued to rub circles on my back, calming me down. Something

about hugging Mara, even if she wasn't real, helped to calm me down. 'None of this is real.'

'So... Catra does love me?' I whispered against her. I knew the answer, I knew this was a dream. But I wanted to hear her say it regardless. It all felt so real, even if I couldn't explain exactly what was going on.

'Of course she does, Adora. You know she does. She's said it herself enough times.'

'I know, but...'

'Adora.' Mara gripped my shoulders and moved me back so she could look me in the eye. Her gaze was stern, but there was a kindness to it. 'Don't forget what I said. You deserve love. What is it you want?'

I felt the tears continue to trail down my cheeks as my breath continued to shudder from crying, 'I... want Catra to be happy. I want to marry her and... I want us to be happy, together.'

Mara's expression softened, 'You're allowed to be loved, Adora. You're allowed to want. Don't doubt yourself, don't doubt her. Just trust in one another, as you have been doing.'

I nodded, wiping the tears from my face. 'Okay... Okay, I will. But, how will I know when to ask?'

Mara chuckled; her eyes full of a fondness that made me feel so at ease. 'Adora, I'm in your head. I don't have an answer to that, but... You'll know when.'

I closed my eyes, calming myself. Deep breaths. Everything would be fine, Catra doesn't hate me. Those were just old memories, my doubts and fears eating away at me.

'Ah...'

That voice.

My eyes shot open. Mara was gone. The breeze had stopped, and the grass was still. Everything was frozen and illuminated in a harsh green light, replacing the warmth from before with a chilling dread that froze me to the spot.

'Adora.'

I swallowed my dread and turned around slowly. I was scared. I could feel the terror rising within me, threatening to overflow, but I forced it down. Once my eyes met his I shut them tight, willing him to disappear. If this really was a dream, surely, I should have *some* control, even if it is my subconscious. 'NO! No, this isn't real. This is a dream. Get out of my head!'

'This isn't real? Can you not see me before you now?'

Reluctantly, I opened my eyes and forced myself to look at him. Horde Prime stood before me, tall and proud, arms behind his back as he smirked down at me with an amused glint in his eye. Once his eyes met mine, he held his head high and a wide green grin spread proudly across his face. I centred myself, trying to bring my thoughts under control. Prime was gone. This isn't real. HE's not really here. This is a dream, it's all in my head. Why was the thought of Prime terrifying me so much? I spoke aloud, refuting his existence directly. 'You're just in my head. A memory. I erased you, destroyed you. You're gone.'

He closed his eyes. His two main eyes, anyway. Those two smaller eyes stayed open, watching me. Prime was amused, dragging this out as long as he could. He took in a deep breath, then observed me with what seemed like a newly peaked curiosity, like I was on display in a museum, label and all. 'Yes. You erased me. Purged me from that failure's mind. But I am in your head, Adora. You doubt it. All it took was to see the colour green, your Catra stoked the flames. Deep down, you doubt it too, now. Though, you won't let yourself even consider it. Your fear of me stops you from thinking about it because the possibility of me still being alive *terrifies* you.'

I shook my head, stepping forward in defiance of his words, 'No. I'm not scared of you!'

Horde Prime laughed, deep and mocking. 'No. You're not scared of me. You're scared of the possibility me, of what I could do to your friends, your world, your love. You care for *everything* else above yourself. I had not considered this before and, as a result, you were right. I miscalculated.'

A surge of confidence grew within me and I stepped forwards, 'You're right, you did. Evil like you will always lose in the end. You lost because your poison failed, it wasn't strong enough. My love for Catra outweighed your power and my fear of you.'

Horde Prime simply smiled, impassive, 'Is that so?'

I faltered; my words caught in my throat. I wasn't expecting him to not react at all.

'I am in your head, Adora. Your thoughts flash through your mind before you speak them. But there are deeper thoughts there too. Ones you don't let yourself think. Do you want me to tell you what they are?' He started walking around me slowly, but I did not let my eyes follow him.

'No...' I shook my head, trying to force any and all thoughts from my head to stop him seeing them.

Horde Prime laughed once again, confidence radiating from him. 'Trying not to think about something only makes it more prominent. You think you don't deserve to have your Catra to yourself, to marry her. You harbour doubts that now the war is finished you'll no longer be needed. A tool to be discarded. Why do you think they sent you to Dryl, on this fool's errand? *It was to get you out of the way!'*

'NO! We came here for Catra, to help her understand her magic! It's working, she's figuring it out and I'm proud of her!'

'But what does your Catra want, Adora? She wasn't given a choice, was she? Just like you weren't.' He placed a hand on my shoulder, digging in with that metal covering on his index finger. I froze on the spot, screwing my eyes closed and trying not to let the action affect me. It's all in my head. 'This... magic she has. It was not her choice was it? It was thrust upon her and, if your memory serves you well, you know it's your fault. The raw magic from the Heart of Etheria still lingers within her, she told you so herself. The purple child, Entrapta, she warned you it could be dangerous... If anything happens to her, it will all be because of *your* weakness.'

A thought slipped into my mind and I regretted it immediately. Prime removed his hand, dragging that metal finger just a bit too long over the back of my neck. 'Oh, I see... Your thoughts betray you, Adora. Your worry for Catra outweighs your worry for the consequences for others should she lose control of her magic. You selfishly care more about her than if she were to hurt others-'

'That's not true!' I broke, giving in to his needling and foolishly showing a crack, a weakness, one that he immediately dug into.

'You feel responsible! If anything goes wrong, it will be your fault for neglecting to notice the magic flowing into her in the first place. If she uses too much of her magic at once, what will happen, Adora? Your worries are all very detailed. Will she die? Will she cause the deaths of others? She almost injured - perhaps almost killed - Bow, did she not? What would have happened to him had you not saved him?'

'Stop!' I held my hands over my ears and crouched down, closing my eyes tight. I couldn't listen to any more. This was my subconscious seeping into my mind, but for some reason I was picturing Horde Prime saying it. This is all just a dream. It's a dream.

If it's a dream, why isn't it ending?

'Because you're *more* than asleep.'

Horde Prime answered me - answered my thoughts.

'All of this is your thoughts, Adora. This is all *your* mind. Your fears, your worst anxieties. You have chosen me to represent everything you fear within yourself. You've given your fears a face. That's a very dangerous thing to do...' Horde Prime laughed again, booming across the frozen fields, 'You've given your worst fears a face, and now they can haunt you. Every time you see me in your mind, every time you see my clones, you'll be reminded of your fears! Fear is the mind-killer. Fear is the little death that brings total obliteration. Tell me, Adora, for how long can you outrun your fears before I *consume* you?'

Prime grabbed me by my jacket, lifting me up. I met his eyes for a moment. He looked amused, his eyes shining with glee, like he had just won a game at a festival. Then his other arm shot forwards, piercing my torso. I felt my jaw go slack, mostly from surprise. I couldn't feel it. I looked down at his arm, buried into my chest. The sight of it threatened to overwhelm me.

Horde Prime held me closer and whispered into my ear, 'Time to wake up.'

Suddenly, I felt the pain of being impaled shoot through my body all at once like a fire was eating me from the inside out.

I screamed as the darkness engulfed me once again.

**

I screamed and sat up with a start, I could barely control my breathing and clutched at my chest, feeling for the hole that I could still *feel,* even though it wasn't there. Every time I closed my eyes, I could see Horde Prime, I couldn't get him out of my head. I forced my eyes to stay open, taking in my surroundings. I was back in the barracks in Dryl, in my bunk. My hair was down, my jacket nearby on the opposite bunk. My face felt wet. Tears? I tried to control my breathing by taking deeper breaths, but the

nightmare flashed before my eyes and I started to sob loudly, reliving the horrible things I had seen and heard.

I looked up as the barracks door opened and Glimmer walked in, her eyes widened as she saw me, 'Adora! You're awake!' She ran over and pulled me into a hug and I accepted it gratefully, crying into her shoulder. 'Adora...' Her hand rubbed circles into my back, trying to calm me down. 'Adora, wait here.' Glimmer pulled back from the hug and ran back towards the door.

Once she was gone, I realised how sweaty I was. I remembered this morning when I had woken up sweaty too, breathing ragged. Did I have a similar nightmare then? If that was the case, why didn't I remember that one when this one was still in my mind, clear as day.

'*A...Adora?*'

Catra. That was Catra's voice. I raised my head to see her standing in the doorway. A panic rose within me as the image of her hate filled eyes filled my mind and I felt her hand around my neck, choking me. I backed away as reflex set in but regretted it immediately. This was my Catra, not the dream Catra with nothing but hate filling her eyes. I reached my arms out towards her as I felt more tears stream down my face, wanting nothing more than to feel her embrace me, *'Catra...'*

She didn't move at first. I could her face was wet with tears and more were falling. This must be the most broken Catra has ever seen me. I must look pathetic...

But after a moment she ran across the room and jumped onto the bed, wrapping her arms around my shoulders and her legs around my waist. 'Adora!'

I held onto her and buried my face into her neck, feeling the familiar softness of her fur against my cheek. I let myself take her in, to really feel her against me. She was real. She was here. She wasn't hurting me; she didn't hate me. She was crying for me,

worrying about me. I let myself breathe her in and tried to steal a moment of peace as my mind threatened to overwhelm me.

took her in, just letting myself have this moment of peace as my mind threatened to overwhelm me.

Catra whispered to me through shuddering breaths as she fought back tears, 'I was so worried, scared... You touched the thing and collapsed... I didn't know what to do so I called Glimmer... You've been out for hours... I was so worried...'

Being this close to her, hearing her voice, helped to calm me down. I felt the fear and terror that had been instilled in me from the nightmare steadily ebbing away as I focused on nothing but her. '*Catra...*' The sound was barely a whisper, but I knew she'd be able to hear me.

'Adora? What is it? Are you okay?' She sounded frightened, concerned. I knew how she felt as I had gone through something similar just a few days ago after the Crimson Waste. She wanted to help, to give me her full attention, care for me. Something I never would have expected from her not that long ago.

I desperately wanted to tell her I was okay. That she didn't have to worry. But at the same time, I knew that if we were going to be together, if I wanted her to say yes when I asked her to marry me, there would have to be trust between us. No more secrets. So, I swallowed the impulse to deflect the worry away from me, accepting her concern and admitting, wholly and truthfully, '*No... I don't think I am.*'

Chapter End Notes

> "I must not fear.
> Fear is the mind-killer.
> Fear is the little-death that brings total obliteration.
> I will face my fear.
> I will permit it to pass over me and through me.
> And when it has gone past I will turn the inner eye to see its

path.
Where the fear has gone there will be nothing. Only I will remain."

- The Litany Against fear as recited by Paul Atreides in 'Dune,' written by Frank Herbert.

Razzle Dazzle

Chapter Summary

> This chapter features the first actual time skip, and it's far from the last. Plot will really start picking up from here on out.

Catra called Scorpia and Perfuma a couple of days ago and they suggested that I try writing down my thoughts. So here I am, writing in a book.

It's been six days since we reactivated the Forge in Underdryl, and the nightmares still haven't gone away. I still see him. Every night. I feel like I'm going insane. I hate to see Catra so worried about me. I've been completely useless ever since we got back to Bright Moon, but I'm working on it.

I suppose I should catch you up, even though you're just a book.

Catra told me where Melog said they had been. Apparently on the night of the Moon Market they had sensed something watching us. It got away, but they tracked it for days. Eventually, Melog caught up to it. When Melog pounced the First Ones crystal fell from it as it escaped. That's when they picked it up and found us in Dryl.
Then I had this... urge to touch it - to hold it.
All I remember is feeling a pain in my arm and an intense headache.

After I blacked out, Catra panicked and called Glimmer. Glimmer and Bow came and helped her watch over me for... four hours. I think. Sometime after I woke up, Glimmer teleported us back. I've not been allowed to help out. I've barely slept. Catra has been helping Glimmer a lot. It's nice to see them getting along, she really feels like part of the group. Even though I'm not really a part of it right now.

She tells me about her day when she comes back to our room. She asks me if I'm okay. I say no. I've never felt like this before. I don't know what to do.

I need to take control of my fears, but I don't know how...

Apparently, Glimmer was not happy that we didn't tell her about the Dwells and the Forge and the entire underground city before we went and activated it. Thinking back, we definitely should of. But Glimmer was able to go as Queen and meet the Elder and discuss with him terms of an alliance. Micah went too, he had heard stories of Underdryl as a child. Catra and I stayed here.

I told her about the Horde ships disappearing. She was mad at first because I had kept it from her. But now she's keeping in touch with Hordak, staying updated on my behalf. I feel awful. Catra's doing so much for me, but she has her own problems too.

I feel so useless. Like a dead weight.

I've not been able to transform either. She-Ra feels out of reach. A result of my head being a mess. I keep feeling short of breath too, hands shaking, head dizzy. Apparently, it's called a panic attack. Admittedly, they have been rare, but they keep happening. As long as I don't let my thoughts spiral, I can maintain some level of control over it.

I've been left alone to think a lot these past few days. I sat in front of the mirror yesterday, when everyone left me alone, and just looked at myself. I got so many scars before I figured out how to heal. The biggest ones being those on my back from Catra. They represent a time in my past where I was willing to do anything, even lay down my life to stop the Horde. I charged into everything headfirst, dragging Bow and Glimmer straight into danger time and time again.

Hey, Book, did you know I almost died?

I remember how it felt. It was peaceful. I was ready. One last sacrifice to save everyone. Then Catra broke through to me. She

told me she loved me and suddenly I wanted to live. I didn't want to go, I wasn't ready. Hearing her say those words gave me new meaning. A new purpose. A new reason to live.

I probably shouldn't write this; in case she reads it.

But I need to say it somewhere.

All I want to do is marry her. I want to hear her say yes. I want to embrace her knowing that we'll spend the rest of forever together.

But do I have the right, if there actually is danger?
I feel like I need some advice - some guidance on what to do.

Everyone who ever did that for me is gone.
Shadow Weaver
Light Hope
Angella
Mara

Razz? I could go speak to Razz.
I don't know how much help she'll be.

Everyone is out of the palace right now, something to do with Elberon's supply lines.

Okay, Book, I've decided to have a 'me' day. I'll call Swift Wind and go see Razz. Maybe her rambling will cheer me up.

Bye?

I sighed, closing the book. Why did I say "bye?"

After a moment pondering the proper way to sign off in a book only, I would read, I chucked it to the end of the bed and threw back the covers before swinging my legs over the side and standing up. I walked over to the wardrobe while glancing out the balcony, the day looked nice, warm. Instead of my usual top and jacket I decided to switch it up a bit, pulling out a sleeveless white top with angular gold lines down both sides.

Once dressed I looked at myself in the mirror. Catra had picked this top out for me, warning me to be careful if I wore it without preparing her in advance. I wasn't sure what she meant by that, but I was sure it would be fine. It really did show off my arms though... I had been working out a lot to pass the time over the last few days. It was one of the only ways I could occupy my mind and distract myself from the poisonous words my own mind was throwing at me night after night. I often caught Catra watching, every time she would turn away quickly and act like she hadn't been. I frowned once I realised something looked off. What was it? I absentmindedly twirled a finger round some loose strands of hair...

Oh! My hair wasn't up. I looked around, quickly realising that my hair tie wasn't where I left it. My spare was missing too. I let out a loud sigh, giving up.

Hair down it is.

I stopped when I passed in front of the mirror. He was there, standing behind me. I had seen this before. The first time I saw Horde Prime standing behind me in a mirror I almost had a panic attack, but I was used to it now. I stared ahead, not acknowledging him in the reflection.

'I'm not afraid of you. I won't let you control my fears.'

'Oh, Adora. *Please.* If I don't control them who will? You? You and your pointless little book? You wear bravery like a mask, but it is cracking. I *will* break you.'

I took a deep breath, letting his words wash over me and through me. Just like Perfuma said. When I looked back in the mirror, Prime was gone. A shaky breath forced its way out my mouth and I clenched my fists to stop the shaking. I could do this.

I continued out onto the balcony and looked out over Bright Moon. The city was lively, colourful, all the rubble had been cleared now and life seemed to be returning to normal. This kind

of quick response was expected of Bright Moon, though. It was the jewel of Etheria, a beacon shining bright, leading by example. I knew from what Catra had told me that surrounding settlements and kingdoms weren't doing quite as well, but now that Bright Moon was done Micah would soon be authorising aid to be sent out to the other kingdoms.

It all sounded good. Everything was going fine. Yet my mind still plagued me with Horde Prime. I had to get rid of him. I had to take control of my fears.

Closing my eyes, I focused on my connection to Swift Wind. I could feel him, nearby. 'Swifty, I need you.' I opened my eyes again and looked out across Bright Moon, expecting to spot him flying up towards me from down below.

I yelped as a loud crash and splintering, followed by a low groan, sounded from behind me in the bedroom. Once I recovered from the shock, I turned and walked back in to see a familiar horn poking through the door. Rolling my eyes, I unlocked the door and opened the non-impaled half of it before peering out, unimpressed.

'Oh... heeeey, Adora! Ha... fancy meeting you here...' Swift Wind's legs were splayed around him and he seemed to be having trouble freeing his horn from the door.

'I called you here, Swift Wind. Here, let me help.' I moved back inside before starting to carefully push his horn back through the door. As soon as he was free, I heard him clear his throat and prepare himself. I rolled my eyes and stepped back.

'Did somebody say SWIFT WIND!' He burst through the door, this time managing not to impale his horn through it.

'Too late, buddy.' I stroked a hand down his neck and patted him gently. Swift Wind could be a lot sometimes, but right now I was silently glad for his theatrics. 'Come on, it's time I paid Razz a visit.'

His eyes lit up and he gasped melodramatically. 'You want to go see Razz? She'll be so pleased to see you. She's been asking after you a lot, you know.'

'Yeah, I figured it was time. I just... need to talk to her.' I closed the doors, not locking them this time, and led the way over to the balcony. He let me climb up onto his back before he spread his wings wide and raised his head, letting his mane billow in the breeze.

'It feels like forever since we went on a trip, just the two of us.' He said while starting to beat his wings, steadily lifting us off the ground.

I scratched his neck gently, 'I know, Swifty. I am sorry about that. Next time we go somewhere, you can come too, I promise.'

'Great! I look forward to it! Maybe we'll get to use our sacred bond!' Swift Wind then shot into the air, speeding towards the Whispering Woods.

**

The journey was short, but I was still able to appreciate, once again, just how different Etheria looks now that the magic is fully restored. Looking out across the Whispering Woods from above like that is something I'll never get tired of, it seemed so much more alive than ever.

After flying for a while, and watching the woods pass by under us, losing myself in the repetitiveness of the leaves, we arrived. Swift Wind put us down close to Razz's hut, being careful not to startle any creatures that may be nearby. It looked pretty much the same as always, if a little tidier.

'Razz?' I called, walking toward the hut. I could hear a low growling sound every so often. 'What's that noise?' I asked, looking back at Swift Wind.

'I believe...' He said, poking his head through the entrance of Razz's home before looking back at me, 'it means she's asleep.'

I stifled a laugh. 'This is her snoring?' I moved the covering from the doorway and peered inside. True enough, there was Razz on the floor, clutching her broom to her side and snoring loudly. The rest of the space within seemed unusually tidy, like she'd cleaned in advance expecting visitors. Knowing Razz, I wouldn't be surprised if that is what happened. Despite no one knowing, including myself, that I would be coming today until a short while ago.

Stepping back outside, I moved over to Swift Wind. 'Hey, Swifty, is it okay if I just have a minute with Razz? I want to try talking to her about... things. I don't know if she'll get it or if she'll be of any help, but I just need to get it out.'

He nodded, understanding written across his face. 'No problemo, Adora. I know what you're going through. I've experienced some of it. Although... I think you'll be pleasantly surprised with what Razz can *get* these days.'

'What does that mean?' I asked, furrowing my brow.

'You'll see.' He chimed, before turning and heading off into the woods, 'I'm going to my favourite apple tree spot. Call me using our *sacred bond* if you need me.'

'I will Swift Wind. And, thank you.' I watched him disappear into the woods before turning and walking back toward Razz's hut, taking a deep breath and running through what I wanted to say in my head a few times. Asking about Horde Prime was the priority - I wanted to know if she knew of way to deal with it or had any advice in general for a dead tyrant haunting my dreams. The second thing, to me, was far more important. But it could wait for now, until the opportunity for me to ask arises.

Inside, Razz was still asleep. I knelt down beside her and whispered, 'Razz? Razz, it's me, Adora.' When she didn't respond,

I spoke a little louder, nudging her gently. 'Razz?'

'Wah!' She suddenly sat upright, the broom whacking me in the face. 'Mara?'

I fell back, rubbing my cheek. 'No, Razz, it's-'

'Ohhh! Adora, dearie! Where've you been, hm? It's been so long since you visited Madame Razz.' She got up and looked down at me, confused. 'What are you doing down there, dearie?'

I groaned and sat up. 'Nothing Razz... wait - you called me Adora?'

'Is that not your name?' Razz asked, adjusting her glasses and peering at me.

'No it... it is my name.'

Razz breathed a sigh of relief. 'Ohh, that's good. Very good. I can't imagine how confusing it would be if I started mixing up people's names.'

I rose to my feet as she started collecting things together, observing her incredulously. 'Yeah that would... be really confusing...'

'Come, come, dearie. We have things to do today!' She pushed a basket into my hands and quickly sped out of the hovel. I should have seen this coming.

'Things to do? Like what? Razz... I wanted to talk to-'

'Hush, dearie,' she said, holding up three fingers. 'We have to make a pie for your friend,' one of the fingers went down. 'Then I have to make something for you,' a second finger went down, 'and there was something I needed to tell you...' The last finger didn't go down, instead she used it to scratch at her chin. 'Oh well! I'm sure it will come to me!' She cheered, before hopping off towards the treeline outside her hut.

'Wait! Razz!' I called, running after her while still holding onto the basket. A pie for my friend - what friend? Something for me - that sounds interesting. Something to tell me - I wondered what it could be.

Razz started picking berries off of bushes and collecting various plants and herbs as we travelled through the woods. Each time she would hurry back over to me and put whatever she found in the basket. After a while I was holding out the basket automatically whenever she approached.

After walking in silence for a while, the only sound being a tune Razz had started humming to herself, I decided it was now or never. 'Razz... I wanted to talk to you.' I began, ducking under a low branch. 'I keep seeing Horde Prime in my head, telling me awful things. I don't know how to get rid of him.'

She put something in the basket, quizzically looked up at me, then hurried back over to a nearby bush. 'What is he?' She called back.

'What is he? He's evil... He's horrible...'

Razz hobbled back over to me, depositing something else in the basket. 'No, dearie. Not what is he. What *is* he?'

I stopped walking, thinking for a moment. 'He's... my fears. He said I gave my fears a face.'

'Do you oppose these fears, Adora? Do you fight them? Do you deny that you are afraid?'

'I... I don't know.'

'You must accept yourself, dearie. You've been exposed to a part of yourself that you've buried for so long. The part that doubts, fears, wants. You cannot defeat your fears, only learn to live with them. Hold onto them. Cherish them. Only then can you grow past them, but you must never leave them behind.'

I was stunned. Razz was actually talking some sense. 'Razz, are you okay? You're making sense. I actually - sort of - understand what you mean.'

She suddenly beamed a bright smile and ran over to me, placing her hands on my cheeks. 'I remembered what I wanted to say! You did good, Adora, restoring Etheria's magic. Mara would be so proud.'

I felt a lump forming in my throat as the words sunk in. 'I did good? Mara would be proud?' Tears had started forming in my eyes, so I reached up and wiped them with the back of my free hand, 'oh, Razz...' I don't know what it was, but something about hearing Razz say those words affected me much deeper than I expected. Before I knew what I was doing, I pulled Razz into a hug, squeezing her as gently as I could. 'Thank you, Razz. For everything you've done for me.'

Razz soon broke free from the hug, brushing down her mass of clothing. 'I am just an old lady, dearie, it was you that saved Etheria. Now, come! We have everything we need!' She pinched the basket out my hand and started back the way we came, jumping through the undergrowth like an excited child.

'Razz! Wait!' I called, taken aback by her sudden exit. Moving quickly so as to not lose sight of where she was going, I followed after her.

When I arrived back at the hut, the fire in the stone oven was already raging and Razz was darting to and fro across the little room. I managed to get past without bumping into her and sat down on a bench, or a rock, at the far end while watching her. I couldn't tell what she was doing, exactly, but I knew it involved pie-making. There was also a vial she was steadily putting ingredients into at the same time as making the pie, but I didn't think anything of it until he shook it, whispered into it, then held it out to me.

'Here, dearie. This is for you. Drink.' She said, holding the vial of faintly glowing blue liquid out to me.

I took it, slowly. 'Thanks?'

Sceptical, I looked down at it, turning it over in my hand. It was just glowing blue liquid, can't be too harmful, right? Well, Razz made it for me - it would be rude not to drink it. I pulled the cork out the top of the bottle and sniffed. It smelled... fruity? Whatever it was, I knew Razz wouldn't wish me harm, so I swallowed my scepticism as well as the potion, drinking it all in just a few gulps. It was, to my surprise, delicious. I hadn't meant to drink it in one, but I couldn't stop once I started. Placing the now empty vial to one side, I looked back over at Razz who was placing something round into the oven.

I steeled myself, and ignored my nerves trying to stop me from talking. There was one more think I wanted to ask her. 'Razz... I want to marry someone. But I don't know if now's the right time...' I wasn't sure if she would know anything about this, but I wanted to talk about it.

'Hmmm... when is Time ever right, dearie?'

Sighing, I leant forwards and held my hands to my face, covering my eyes. 'I don't know, Razz. I want to marry her more than anything. I want to be with her and share my life with her but... something happened, something that hasn't happened since Horde Prime tried to hack the planet. I'm... afraid, of what that means. Would me asking her to marry me just get in the way of whatever else is happening out there? What if she doesn't even want to? What if she thinks it's too soon and... and says no. I don't know I would do if she said no...' I yawned. Weird. I didn't remember feeling tired, I had only got out of bed a couple of hours ago.

Razz's hands cupped my own and I looked up to see her smiling softly at me. 'Adora, dearie... I am just an old lady living alone in the woods, but it's clear to me what it is that you want. There will

always be fears that get in the way, but you have to embrace them and go for it anyway, hm?'

I yawned again, suddenly realised I did actually feel quite tired. 'Razz? I feel like I'm going to nap now...'

Razz squeezed my hands and smiled, placing them gently on my lap as I leant back against the wall of the hut. 'That's okay dearie, it means it's working.'

What does that mean? I thought, as I slipped into the most peaceful sleep I've had all week.

**

A hand gently stroked through my hair and I heard voices that grew steadily louder as I slowly woke up. I didn't remember lying down, but I felt so relaxed. My head was warm. I became aware that I was lying on someone's lap, but I didn't get up. I haven't felt this relaxed in so long. The voices were clearer now but I wasn't quite awake enough to open my eyes, so I just remained lying down and let the conversation continue.

'Is there anything I can do?'

That was Catra's voice, it came from across the room. How did she find me?

'Be patient, dearie.'

Razz - it came from above me. I was lying on Razz's lap and it was her hand stroking my hair.

'I... I just... I worry about her. She's been through so much and I want... I want her to be happy.'

'If that is what you want for her, what do you want for yourself?'

'For myself?' There was a pause, 'it doesn't matter what I want.'

'Indulge a crazy old lady, dearie. Tell me, what is it you desire most?'

'I... I want... *Adora*. I want to be by her side for as long as I can... I want... Ugh, it sounds so selfish. I don't even know how far she wants to take this. I've been talking with Sparkles and Arrow Boy a lot and they seem to think she'd never give me up but... do I really deserve this? Forgiveness? After everything I've done... Do I deserve to be happy? Do I have the right to want Adora after everything I've done to her?'

I can't believe I'm listening in to this. I shouldn't be. This is wrong. These are things she's not told me and probably didn't want me to know.

'Hmmm.' Razz paused for moment, apparently considering her response. 'People are like pies. Crusty on the outside and full of colour and flavour on the inside. But, only all together is it a pie. You focus too much on your crust and you think others do too. Have you considered a different possibility?'

'What?'

Razz started slapping my cheek, 'Wakey wakey, Adora!'

I bolted upright, sitting up and trying my best to act as if I had just woken up. 'What? Razz? Catra?' I rubbed my eyes, noticing it was now dark outside. 'How long have I been out?'

Catra was stood across the room, Melog lay nearby. She was wearing her more official-looking Bright Moon clothes that Glimmer had starting insisting she wears when on official Bright Moon business - slate grey stirrup-trousers with gold along the sides as well as a royal purple short sleeved keyhole top, also with gold accents. A bright blush covered her face a she stared at me in surprise. 'Uh... you... I don't know, I've not been here long.'

Razz got up and walked over to Catra, wafting her with a feather duster. 'What are you talking about, dearie, you've been here for hours. You ate the pie I made for you!'

'Ugh! Whatever! Come on, Adora. I've got something to tell you.' Catra turned and quickly walked out of the hut. Melog raised their head and watched Catra leave, before stretching and following her out.

I stood up and moved to follow her, pausing as I met Razz's gaze. 'Thank you, Razz. For your help. I feel... good. Lighter.'

'That's okay, dearie.' She leant forwards, cupped a hand next to her mouth and whispered, 'remember to invite Madame Razz to the wedding, hm? I'll bring the Razzle Dazzle!' She tapped the side of her nose knowingly.

I felt the blush spread across my cheeks and I froze for a moment, before collecting myself and nodding. 'I will. Bye, Razz.'

Catra was standing a short distance away, idly kicking at a tuft of grass. Melog was sat on the ground nearby, watching me as I approached. 'Hey, Catra. What's going on? How'd you find me?'

She didn't turn around, 'Your flying horse found me in the woods when I was on my way back from Elberon, told me you were here. So I came to see you and... how are you feeling?'

'I feel... I feel great. I spoke with Razz; she gave me some advice and something to drink. She doesn't usually make this much sense, I think returning Etheria's magic may have unscrambled her... Catra, why aren't you looking at me?' I placed a hand on her shoulder, pulling gently.

Catra turned slowly, her eyes glowing in the gloom. I noticed that her pupils were slightly dilated as she looked at me. 'I'm glad you're making progress, Adora... You - you're wearing the top I chose for you...' her hands trailed down my exposed arms, 'I wasn't... prepared for how... how good you would look in it.' She then lifted a hand and ran her fingers through my hair.

'You like it then?' Catra nodded. 'That's good. You wouldn't happen to know where my hair ties have gone do you?'

'Uh- no I...' she sighed, 'yes, I may have hidden them. I like your hair down, okay?'

'I see. For the record, I love seeing you in Bright Moon clothes.'

'What? No, these things are awful. I only wear them because Sparkles insists.'

'Yeah sure, you like them really. What was it you wanted to tell me?'

Catra hooked her arms around my waist and moved in closer. 'It's something Sparkles and Arrow Boy suggested. It's good that you're starting to make progress and we can work on it some more in the meantime - they've suggested a trip.'

My eyes lit up and I draped my arms around Catra's shoulders. 'A trip? Where? When?'

'To... Salineas. In five days. There's this... ship. Heading out with supplies and they've said we should go along. Something about a "best friend squad quest." It'll give me chance to... apologise to Mermista for- for destroying her home.'

I smiled and leant in, resting my forehead against hers. 'That sounds great. And you know you're part of the best friend squad now, right?'

'Pfft. Whatever, princess. As long as I'm with you I'll go anywhere.'

'Catra?'

'Hm?'

'I love you.'

'I love you too, dummy.'

'Will you ever stop calling me that?' I asked, chuckling.

'I don't know, will it ever not be true?' She retorted, a smirk playing at the edge of her mouth.

I sighed. 'No idea. I'll call Swift Wind and we can get back to Bright Moon. I want to hear about what happened in Elberon.'

'Okay, but... I'm not ready yet.'

'Why not?'

Catra leant up, sealing her lips around mine. I kissed back, thankful for the feeling of her warmth as I pulled her closer. Catra had been the one thing keeping me sane these past few days. I feel like I love her more than ever and now that I had a moment of clarity, I allowed myself to fill my mind with nothing but her. The softness of her hair as my fingers ran through it, the feeling of her tongue on mine as the kiss deepened, the warmth of her arms around me as she held me close.

I *will* ask her to marry me. Danger or no danger. I wanted this and, for the first time, I believed she might too.

Legend of the Pink Pearl

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The five days between my visit to Razz's and the day of the ship's departure passed by quickly. With Catra's help, I was able to start facing my fears and trying to accept them, just like Razz had said. My dreams had been nightmare-free for the last few days, each morning I woke up peacefully and rested with a topless Catra draped over me. She'd started sleeping in just her underwear and seemed pretty confident that my nightmares had gone as a result of that and had nothing at all to do with the advice from Perfuma.

I certainly wasn't about to start complaining. I will *never* get enough of running my hands through her fur in the mornings.

My reflections had also been fairly normal. No surprise visits from Horde Prime trying to freak me out, but I wasn't convinced he was entirely gone. I knew he was the face I had given my fears, but I could feel him, deep down, trying to claw his way back up. That nagging feeling at the back of my mind is the only thing holding back my confidence that this is actually working, but Catra is right: it has only been five days since my visit to Razz, I shouldn't try to rush anything. My current, if possibly temporary, peace-of-mind did mean that I was able to start showing Catra the same level of attention she was showing me. After all, she still had nightmares too, she was just better at putting on a brave face than me.

Her most recent nightmare hadn't shaken her awake, or even caused her to stir in the night. But yesterday morning Catra hugged me tight and whispered into my neck, 'I had another one.'

Catra's trauma seemed much deeper than mine. While she was talking to me about it more openly and telling me what she dreams about, she couldn't seem to escape her subconscious

attacking her with her deepest anxieties while she slept. Dreams about being left behind, about being tortured by Shadow Weaver, by Horde Prime and once... by me. She had cried a lot after that one in particular and seemed hesitant to let me embrace her at first. Catra also still insisted that she was unforgivable. Something that, no matter how much I tell her otherwise, she won't believe unless she is forgiven by those who she thinks won't.

This was partly the reason, as I stood looking out to sea on the forward deck of a cargo ship loaded with supplies and heading for Salineas, that I let myself smile. I believed that visiting Mermista would show Catra that she is not completely beyond forgiveness. Salineas was perhaps one of the worst wounds the Horde inflicted on the Princess Alliance towards the end of the war. This would be the first time since the Alliance meeting a few days after the Heart that we would be seeing Mermista in person, since all the princesses with kingdoms had gone back to them to lead their own rebuilding. My hope was that Mermista could see who Catra was trying to be now, that she would be able to see Catra really is trying to change for the better. If Mermista, who's entire kingdom was attacked while Catra stood by, could forgive her - or at least accept an apology - it would be a good first step towards Catra being able to leave the pool of guilt she's found herself stranded in the middle of.

I turned around, leaning back against the deck railing, and took in the rest of the ship. It was a fairly large vessel, as it needed to be. Its cargo was, after all, tons of supplies to help the Salineans with their rebuilding efforts. As I promised, Swift Wind had joined us on this trip. He was stood up on the quarterdeck, doing *something*, not too far from Bow. Bow wasn't paying any attention however, as his full attention was focused on a hologram projecting up from his tracker pad that he'd placed on a barrel. Catra and Glimmer were leant against the railing of the main deck, Melog laid nearby basking in the warmth of daylight. They'd been talking for some time after Glimmer had come and peeled Catra away from me, insisting they had something urgent to talk about. Finally, I looked up at the sails, watching as the wind filled them and pulled the ship ever onwards.

'Adora!' Glimmer suddenly appeared next to me. I almost jumped out of my skin, nearly falling back off the front of the ship.

'Glimmer!' I yelled, the surprise evident in my voice.

She giggled, not sorry in the slightest. 'That was not my fault.'

'I almost fell off the ship! That would have absolutely been your fault.'

'What if I just teleported you back up?'

'Then I'd still be wet.'

'Hmm. I'm sure Catra could dry you off.'

I looked over at Catra as she climbed the steps up to the quarterdeck. Melog wasn't following her, instead favouring their spot in the warmth. 'Yeah, I suppose so. She has been able to get the hang of controlling wind. It was really nice of Spinnerella to help her with that.' I glanced back at Glimmer, who was staring out ahead of us at the open sea. 'What were you talking about? With Catra, I mean.'

'I was just thanking her again.' She sounded distant, as if lost in thought for a moment.

'Thanking her? What for?'

Glimmer furrowed her brow, tearing her eyes away from the sea to look at me, visibly confused. 'What do you mean? Wait - how much has she told you about this relief mission?'

I thought for a moment. Catra hadn't mentioned much about the trip beyond what she said outside Razz's hut, but from what Glimmer was saying there must be more to it. 'Just that you guys suggested we make it into a squad adventure.'

'Huh.' Glimmer looked back at Catra, who was standing across from Bow and looking down at the holo-map, unimpressed and

pointing out a route. 'Well... what she *didn't* mention is that she practically planned the whole thing.'

'She *what?'* Catra had definitely not shared that information with me. I had spent the whole time thinking that Micah was in charge of this, seeming as he was the one to agree and sign off on it. Hiding my astonished expression at this point would have been a wasted effort.

Glimmer seemed to find the face I was pulling funny but continued anyway. 'Yeah. Maybe she feels bad about the state she left Salineas in - but this whole trip was planned by her, even down to which supplies we're bringing. I was all for it, of course, and my Dad gave his seal of approval not too long ago.'

'She's...' I looked over at her, just in time to see Bow facepalm before walking over to the skipper steering the ship and leaning in to say something to them. We changed course slightly. 'She's amazing.'

Glimmer nodded, she crossed her arms and leant back on the railing beside me. 'Which is why I just offered her the position of Royal Advisor.' My mouth practically hit the deck. Glimmer laughed but shook her head, 'she didn't take it.'

'What? Why not?' A position like that would be perfect for Catra. She told me that after Shadow Weaver left, she had basically been running the whole thing with Hordak just shut in his sanctum with or without Entrapta, either way demanding not to be disturbed.

'She said she doesn't deserve it. But from where I'm standing, her advice has been invaluable since you came back from Dryl. I don't know the details of what's haunting her, but Catra's an amazing strategist. Kind of makes me wish she had joined us when you did. The whole war would have gone in a *completely* different direction.' Glimmer sounded genuinely impressed with Catra, and I felt a surge of pride within me, but that pride soon faltered. I looked down at the floor as I felt a flood of guilt wash over me.

'I always used to wonder what would have happened if Catra joined us sooner. If I had been able to convince her to switch sides. If only I had talked to her more, not been as spontaneous as I was. Maybe I could have convinced her... to come with me.' What I hadn't understood at the time was the fact that Catra was fully aware. She knew she was on the side of the bad guys, but from what she's told me since, she just didn't care. She was so lost, so vulnerable, that she wanted to do nothing but aim that anger and frustration back at the world the only way she knew how.

I felt a hand on my shoulder and looked up to see Glimmer smiling at me. 'She came around in the end. Sure, we can sit and think back on things we did and how we would have gone about doing them differently but... as Queen, I have to look forwards. To tomorrow. I can't get stuck in the past or linger on my regrets.' Glimmer spoke confidently, not only from her own experience but no doubt remembering her mother's teachings, or those she actually paid attention to when she was younger.

'You're right. Thanks for telling me about Catra planning this. I'll... I'll ask her about it later.' For some reason the thought of Catra keeping something from me made me feel uneasy. What if there's more she hasn't told me?

'Speaking of asking her things...' I could practically hear the smirk on Glimmer's face. 'When are you going to pop the question? It's been - what, two weeks since you asked me what marriage was? I was expecting news of an engagement after the Aurora.'

My face flushed a violent red and I tried to hide it with a cough. Trust Glimmer to mention this when Catra was within eyesight. Luckily, the ship was far too long, and we were downwind from her, so she wouldn't be able to hear us. 'No I... I did almost ask that night but... I chickened out. I haven't been able to ask since. There's been so much going on and whenever I thought, you know, *maybe?* It just didn't feel right. I don't know what to do.' I didn't mention that I haven't exactly been in my right mind recently, either.

'You are still asking, right?' Glimmer was still smirking, enjoying my flustered state at being caught out by this sudden line of questioning.

'Oh, yeah, one-hundred percent... *why?'* I asked, narrowing my eyes at her accusingly. Glimmer didn't ask questions like that if there wasn't a reason.

Glimmer smiled knowingly. 'Oh, you know... Catra's been spending a lot of time with me recently and she... talks.'

'Talks? What about? Has she asked you about marriage too?' I tried to stay calm while asking those questions, but I definitely failed judging my look on Glimmer's face before she burst out laughing.

'From what she's been saying, she already knows about it.'

I felt a panic rising within me as I gripped my head in my hands, 'Oh no oh no oh no... does she know I'm planning on asking?'

'I don't think so. But I won't say any more.' Chimed Glimmer, as she mimed closing her mouth with a zip. Of course she would only give away part of the information. Enough to rile me up but not enough to betray Catra's confidence.

'Ugh! Fine. At least I don't have to worry about her not knowing what I'm talking about when I ask.'

'That's if you ever do... Come on, let's go see what they're talking about.'

Before I could respond Glimmer grabbed my arm and teleported us to the back of the ship, where Bow and Catra were standing either side of the map still projecting above the barrel. Swift Wind was still stood over to one side. I could see what he was doing from this angle - sneaking apples from an open sack.

'-so that's why we- Oh. Hey, Adora.' Catra smiled as we appeared next to them. I felt myself freeze as her eyes landed on me. I

managed to shoot her a smile and laughed nervously but for some reason I forgot all about words and how to speak them. Bow spoke first anyway, saving us from an awkward silence.

'Glimmerrrrr, Catra's being mean.' He wailed, gesturing toward my very smug looking girlfriend.

Catra scoffed, raising an eyebrow at him. 'I am not mean! You had us going the wrong way!'

Glimmer clapped her hands. Both Catra and Bow fell silent. 'Shush! Catra, you go first. What's happening?' Bow crossed his arms in a huff, turning away from the table.

'Well, *Arrow Boy* here was pointing us in the wrong direction. We have to stop off at Seaworthy first to load on the last of the supplies.' Catra placed a hand on her hip and fired a smug smile at Bow.

'Okay.' Glimmer glanced down at the map. 'Bow, what's the issue?'

He breathed out a long, defeated, breath. 'No problem here, Glimmer.' Catra stuck her tongue out at him.

'Well, now that that's settled... food time!' Glimmer declared, grabbing Bow by the shoulder just as he picked up the tracker pad and teleporting them away. No doubt purposefully leaving Catra and I *almost* alone together on the quarterdeck.

Catra jumped up onto the barrel and reached out to me, waving her hand in front of my face after I didn't move for a moment. 'Adora? Are you with us?'

I realised that I had been staring at Catra the whole time, questions from my conversation with Glimmer floating around in my mind. One bigger than all the rest. 'Oh! Uh, yes, I'm here.' I said, chuckling nervously and walking forwards until I was stood in front of the barrel between Catra's legs. 'Did someone say food? I'm starving.'

'Pssh, you're always starving.' Remarked Catra, draping her hands over my shoulders as I let my hands rest on her hips. She was much higher up than I was, but that didn't stop her from looking down at me with that face I had seen plenty of times by now. I glanced over at Swift Wind and the skipper - neither were looking our way, and Swift Wind's head was buried in the apple sack at this point, apples spilling everywhere. Catra apparently got tired of waiting as her hands cupped by face and pulled upwards. I let myself be led, rising on my toes to meet her lips as she leant down to kiss me.

My stomach gurgled thanks to the mention of food, but I ignored it. Deep down, I still had questions, turning round and around in my head despite the promise of food and the amazing kiss I hoped would last a little while longer.

Why didn't you tell me you planned this relief mission?
Why did you turn down Royal Advisor?
...
Will you marry me?

**

Once we docked in Seaworthy, Catra was immediately busy. I wanted to go and explore with her, take her to the tavern I went to last time I was here, but she was leading both our crew and those on the docks with what needed loading onto the ship. The bench I had chosen to sit on was the only one that wasn't wet, although it was quite close to shore which meant I was now far away from Catra. I laid down and looked at the sky while trying to get comfy. The sky was less full of magic now, having mostly settled, but there were still streaks of it crisscrossing between the clouds and forming interesting patterns.

My cloud-gazing was interrupted by a large shadowed head looking down at me. 'Swifty?'

'Hello, Adora! What's got you down?' He moved around to lean his neck over the back of the bench.

I sat up, glancing across at Catra before shaking my head. 'Nothing's got me down. I'm good.'

He regarded me with an impassive stare.

'Oh right, we're linked.' I sighed, 'fine. I just want to know why Catra didn't tell me she did all this. And I want to go to the tavern with her but she's busy.'

'Hmm. I don't know about what she's thinking, but *I* could go to the tavern with you. I have been there before, after all! Sea Hawk, Bow and I sang a great shanty about friendship and then... we were captured - and needed to be rescued... But until then it was a great day!' Swift Wind proudly raised his head and let his mane flow majestically through the sudden breeze.

I laughed, 'you timed that didn't you? Alright, let's do it.' I stood up and patted his neck, appreciative that he was trying to cheer me up.

'Aha! Onwards!'

The tavern wasn't far away, it didn't take us long to get there. We passed by all kinds of folk from all manner of places. Most of the folk that gather here are of the suspicious-looking category, but after Prime's defeat it seemed the place had begun some kind of clean-up. Seaworthy was primarily a port town, which meant that lots of trading happened here alongside the general movement of goods and supplies. When Salineas is fully rebuilt, this place will no doubt be even busier with all kinds of people coming and going from the oceanic kingdom.

As we neared the tavern, I swore I could hear... oh no. A shanty. I tepidly pushed open the entrance and cringed when I saw Sea Hawk standing on a table, singing a mournful sounding shanty.

'OooOooOOoooh!
I'm Sea Hawk,
I am,
I am.

I'll need a place to crash,
Hey, are you my man?
I'm on the streets, what did I do,
How could I have known,
What would ensue.
Guys, help me out,
I'm torn in two.'

Only one person in the whole place started clapping, it was coming from behind the bar. I recognised the sultry voice before I saw who it was.

'Oh! Fabulous singing, darling. I could really *feel* the hopeless sorrow in your words. Just sublime. *Bravo!'*

Double Trouble.

Swift Wind charged forwards, 'hey! Sea Hawk!'

'Ah! Horse-bird!' Sea Hawk's face lit up and he jumped down from the table, hugging Swift Wind's neck. 'It's so good to see a friendly face.'

'I'm just going to pretend you didn't call me a bird, okay.'

Double Trouble saw this, their eyes quickly scanned the room before finding mine staring back at them. 'Ah!' They exclaimed, ducking down behind the bar.

I walked across and peered over the bar, moving a half-empty glass out the way. 'Too late *Double Trouble,* I saw you.'

A small sea-elf boy in ragged clothes stood up, barely tall enough to see over the bar. 'Double Trouble? Whoever is that? I am but a humble server boy serving out my remaining days in service to the fine people of Seaworthy.'

After sitting on one of the bar stools I stared at them, amused. 'You know kids can't serve behind bars, right?'

'Ugh!' Double Trouble shifted back to their original form. 'Whatever. I panicked. So, what brings you to Seaworthy, *She-Ra?* Not here to arrest me, are you? Because that would *really* dampen the mood.'

A few heads perked up around us at the mention of the famous warrior princess. 'No, I'm not here to arrest you. Glimmer told us about you ended up helping before going missing, and besides, nearly every member of the Etherian Horde has been given a second chance. Even Catra, who's here. We're on our way to help Salineas. You know, if Catra sees you she might just claw your eyes out.'

That seemed to surprise them, but the momentary stun was quickly followed by a wide toothy grin. 'Catra? She's here? Oh, now that's *delicious*. Honey, what I did wasn't personal. I harbour no ill-intent towards my dear Catra, but she was on the losing side. Although, the idea of a second-chance opens so many new avenues...'

Speaking with Double Trouble was... odd. I knew they were neutral, just bouncing between whoever had hired them or whoever held all the cards but here, in this place, they were just a bartender. A bartender that knew and spent time with Catra during the war, even if we did end up capturing them which led to their subsequent betrayal of her.

'Oh! I did so enjoy *becoming...'* Their form shifted again, this time to Catra's old one-sleeve uniform, '...Catra. She was so much *fun* to observe. You should have seen her face whenever I became *you*. She most definitely feels something for you.'

I felt my face flush, it made sense that Double Trouble wouldn't know we're together yet. After all, I hadn't heard of any sightings until seeing them myself. 'Uh, yeah... I know.'

Double Trouble shifted back to normal, looking stunned. 'She actually told you? Oh, what a marvellous plot-twist! I so wish I could have seen it, a tale of one-sided love so tragic-'

'No! It's... It's not one-sided.'

They leant forwards on the bar, lifting an eyebrow and observing me with an alluring gaze. 'Well, *hello.* So the rumours were true... Spill.'

Oh, of course... The Moon Market. As Seaworthy was a port town it makes sense that rumours of me kissing Catra would have made it out here by now. 'I knew that would spread quickly... Why am I talking to you like you're an old friend? The last time I saw you we had you under guard in the pris- spare room.'

'I just have that kind of face, darling. You'd be surprised what people tell you when you're standing behind a bar. And that rumour of the legendary She-Ra kissing a Feline girl in the middle of the Moon Market was *not* going to stay quiet. I had my suspicions, *of course*. And if you were about to say *prison*, then that was simply the most luxurious prison I've ever been held in. And those guards? They definitely can't see or hear out of their helmets. I should know, I *became* one. That's right, honey, I *walked* out of there.' Double Trouble stood and started serving another patron. 'Now spill, I'm on the clock here.'

'Fine. We've been together since Horde Prime was defeated.'

'Oh? How far has it gone?'

'It's gone... pretty far.' I could feel the heat radiating from my cheeks, why was I telling them this?

'Oh, now *that's* more like it. How quickly did you give in?'

I planted my face against the bar. 'It was... the next morning.'

'I knew it would have been soon. You must have been pining for each other your whole lives, you *poor things.* I'd bet that you were very *busy* at first, weren't you?' They came back over while drying off a glass.

A furious blush covered my face. They were right, that first week we hadn't been able to keep our hands off of each other - the only thing stopping us recently was my mind attacking me with my own repressed fears. I turned my head to watch as Double Trouble dried off the glass with incredible efficiency. 'How did you even get a-'

'Job? Here?' They finished my question for me. 'I originally applied as *research* for... a role. But the owner saw through me immediately. Apparently, I smelt *too good* to be a Mushroomfolk. So now, during the day, I watch the bar. But at *night*... I put on a show!' They spread their arms wide, beaming a pointy grin from ear to ear. 'Although it's only once a week.'

'Maybe I'll bring Catra to watch one of your shows one day. But for now, you should probably stay away from her. I don't think she'd react kindly to seeing you just yet.' It could be fun to come back here with Catra, just the two of us without a schedule or other responsibilities.

'Oh, don't worry, darling. I have no intention of riling up our favourite *Kitten.'*

I scoffed, '"Kitten?"'

They nodded enthusiastically, 'oh yes. "Kitten." You should give it a try.' Double Trouble seemed distracted for a second, side-glancing across the tavern. They leant over the bar and whispered, 'don't look now, but that walking catastrophe is waving this way.'

Sure enough, Sea Hawk was frantically waving his arms trying to get my attention. He and Swift Wind were sat around a table across the floor in one of the booths. I didn't even know Swift Wind *could* sit like that, maybe his request for a seat at the Alliance table wasn't as farfetched as we thought. 'I should go see what they want,' I said, standing up and moving away before shooting a warning glare back at Double Trouble. 'Stay away from Catra.'

Double Trouble drew a cross over their heart and winked at me, before turning to another patron to start serving them.

'Hey, Sea Hawk.' I said, joining them at the table and scooching round the bench.

'Adora! Might I say, it's so good to see you again. I hear you and Catra have been getting along well since our *HEROIC SAVING ETHERIA ADVENTURE!'*

'Yeah, we-'

'Unlike myself and Mermista!' He suddenly burst into tears, crying onto the table with a practised and refined melodrama.

I looked to Swift Wind for help.

He cleared his throat, 'Sea Hawk and Mermista had an argument after he burnt down-'

'Accidentally!' Sea Hawk wailed.

'Yeah sure. He *"accidentally"* burnt down the royal yacht.'

'I simply knocked over an oil lamp and the ship set ablaze! T'was not my fault! You must believe me!'

'Anyhoo... He says he has-'

'But I have a plan!' Sea Hawk suddenly stood up, planting one foot on the table. 'I know the way to win back Mermista's heart of stormy seas!' He sat back down again and leant over the table, whispering, 'rumour has it, that there's an extremely rare pink pearl in Octopus Cove. It's been there so long, that it has its own legend. *The Legend of the Pink Pearl.'*

'Ooo, what's the legend?' I asked, suddenly interested.

'Legend says,' he began, 'that the cove is cursed. Whoever tries to receive the pearl is met with a horrific monster... and an even

more horrific fate... If you two can help me get that pearl and present it to Mermista, it will be the perfect top-secret *REDEMPTION ADVENTURE!'* He tried whisper-shouting that last part.

'That sounds *amazing!'* I whispered back. 'I would love to help!'

'Perfect! I shall ready my trusty vessel!' As Sea Hawk stood up, his moustache fell off and landed on the table. He let out a high pitch scream before quickly reaching down and reapplying it to his face, albeit upside-down.

I stared up at him, shocked. 'Has- has your moustache always been fake?'

'Of course not! What do you take me for? I simply... singed my real moustache in the blaze. You'd be surprised how often it occurs. So I keep a stash of spares just in case...'

'That's so cool! I want one! Can I have one?' I looked up at him with pleading eyes.

'Hmm. Very well. If you help me on quest to recover the Pink Pearl and win back Mermista's favour, I shall bestow upon you the highest honour I can give... one of my spare super-cool moustaches.'

I leapt up, fist-punching the air, 'Yes!'

'Meet me at my boat when you are ready to begin my *redemption ADVENTURE!'* He declared, before awkwardly shimmying around the table and taking off towards the door.

Swift Wind looked stunned.

'Do you think we should tell him his moustache is upside down?' I asked, getting up from the table.

'Nah, he probably knows.' Replied Swift Wind, somehow managing to pull himself out from behind the table. 'Besides, if he doesn't,

this trip will be one-hundred times funnier.'

'You've got a point there...' I trailed off as I realised Double Trouble wasn't behind the bar anymore. 'Hey, Swifty, did you see where the bartender went?'

'Hm? Oh, yeah, they left soon after you sat down. Why?'

'Oh no...' Realisation dawned. Of course they wouldn't have actually listened to me, doing what they want is Double Trouble's whole thing. I rolled my eyes and set off running back towards the ship.

**

'Get away from me!'

I heard Catra shouting before I saw what was happening. Double Trouble was standing on the dock, looking smug, as Catra snarled at them with claws bared. Melog stood defensively behind Catra, their back arched as they glowed a bright crimson.

'Catra!' I shouted, running over, Swift Wind close behind.

Her ears perked up as she heard me call her name and she looked toward me. 'Adora?'

I stood between the two of them, facing Double Trouble and holding my arms out wide. 'Leave her alone, Double Trouble. I told you to stay away.'

'Aw, darling - how could I resist? I just wanted to see how my favourite cash Kitten was doing after everything she worked towards crumbled from under her...'

Catra hissed behind me, but she didn't pounce, Melog also stayed back but continued to snarl in Double Trouble's direction.

'Just leave it.' I snapped, 'or we definitely won't be coming back.'

'Tch. Have it your way.' They said, before slinking away back towards the tavern, weaving through the small crowd that had started gathering. I quickly lost sight of them, no doubt they had blended in as soon as they could, becoming one with the crowd.

'Adora?'

I turned to face Catra, pulling her into a tight embrace. 'I'm sorry you had to go through that. I know that they hurt you. I should've kept my eye on them.'

She smiled and hugged back, burying her face into the pulse point on my neck. 'It's okay, Adora. I want to make up with them some day but, I'm not ready yet... what did you mean about coming back?'

'Oh... Double Trouble is a bartender at a tavern here, but they also do an evening show once a week. So I suggested we could come back at some point...? Unless you'd rather not.'

'We'll see, princess.' She pulled back from the hug. 'We're ready to go. Are you all done here?'

'Oh, I uh...' I rubbed the back of my neck nervously. Somehow, I had forgotten that I would actually have to leave the rest of the best friend squad behind if I was to help Sea Hawk on his top-secret redemption adventure. 'I'm actually going with Sea Hawk. He asked me for my help with... a thing. Will you cover for me with Glimmer and Bow?'

'A thing, huh? Sounds really important. I'll handle them, don't worry. You'll be meeting back up with us in Salineas though right? I would come but I can't leave the-'

'I know, Catra. Glimmer told me everything. I want to talk to you about that later. After I'm done helping Sea Hawk, I'll come find you.' I kissed her quickly on the lips, lingering long enough to feel her kiss me back before pulling away and scratching behind her ear.

She breathed out heavily, the beginnings of a purr sounding in her chest. 'Okay... I'll explain everything. I promise. Now go have fun with your crazy arsonist friend.'

I smiled at the accurate description of Sea Hawk. 'I will. See you later!' I waved and turned away, walking over to Swift Wind who was waiting nearby.

'You ready?' He asked, stretching out his wings for a moment to let a sudden breeze blow through them.

'I am.' I confirmed, climbing up onto his back. 'Let's go, Swifty.'

'Onwards!' He called, galloping towards Sea Hawk's boat.

I glanced over my shoulder at Catra as she watched us leave. She remained for a moment before turning and walking away, back along the dock toward our ship, stroking Melog's ethereal mane.

A pang of loss shot through me as we rode away from Catra, but I closed my eyes and looked forwards, focusing on the task at hand. I would see her again, I just had to help out a friend with a quick side-quest...

Chapter End Notes

Make sure to follow my Instagram for updates about the story! @iorekofthehorde

Octopus Cove

Chapter Notes

> You may notice there's a chapter count now - this is purely speculative at the moment, but gives you an idea of how far through I think we are.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'So... what do you think of the *Dragon's Daughter VII?'* Sea Hawk asked out of the blue as he tied down the sails. We had been on the water for nearly an hour but not much had been said up until this point. I had been too lost in my own thoughts, too busy thinking about Catra and if she was hiding things from me, to focus on anything else. I was extremely grateful for the calm sea though, as having to deal with stopping a boat from capsizing was not on my list of things to do that day.

Sea Hawk moved away from the knot he just tied to go check something else, but I noticed he had left it loose and used the wrong knot. I re-tied it once he moved away, making sure it was actually tight and definitely would not come undone on its own. 'It looks just like all your other boats. And what happened to the Dragon's Daughter V and VI?'

'I... don't want to talk about it.' He quipped. The last boat I had been on with Sea Hawk had been the Dragon's Daughter V, which we used to travel up to the Northern Reach only to find Entrapta didn't want to be rescued and a whole bunch of scary First Ones snow monsters had laid waste to the shelter there. I could imagine a very likely story as to the fate of those two boats, however.

'Hey guys,' Swift Wind poked his head out of the cabin, squinting against the light of day. 'How much longer until we get there? This boat is much more... bouncy than the other one.'

'That's because the other one was much bigger, Swifty.' I said, gently scratching along his neck. This trip had led to Swift Wind's realisation that he couldn't handle how small boats crossed the ocean, practically riding all the waves instead of cutting through them like the larger cargo ship had been doing. Even though the sea was calm, boats of this size were still affected to a moderate degree.

Sea Hawk held up his spyglass and scanned the horizon. 'We should be there soon, friends! We are fortunate to have clear skies and a calm sea this day, for Octopus Cove is known for claiming many a fine vessel.' He tweaked his upside-down fake moustache. Swift Wind and I stifled a laugh - Sea Hawk had still noticed it was the wrong way up, but we had no intention of pointing it out.

'That's good. I'd hate for you lose yet *another* boat.' I said, a smirk and raised eyebrow accompanying the teasing words.

'I'll have you know I love all my boats equally, each of them met with their demise bravely and will be dearly missed.' He sniffed and wiped away a genuine tear before it could roll down his cheek.

Swift Wind rolled his eyes before disappearing back inside the cabin and I sat down on the deck, looking out to sea. My mind wandered back to Catra, I was really hoping this conversation we had essentially booked in wouldn't lead to an argument or misunderstanding between us. Then, a thought popped into my head. I almost dismissed it immediately, but I supposed it wouldn't hurt to ask. 'Hey, Sea Hawk, can I ask you something?'

'Of course! Anything for my good friend who dared to venture with me on this perilous quest to-'

'I was just wondering...' I started, intentionally cutting him off before he began down a tangent that would end up being far too long. 'How do you and Mermista always make up after arguments? And does she ever keep anything from you?'

Sea Hawk placed his hands on the wheel, keeping us steady while apparently considering his response. 'Well... Mermista hardly tells me anything, truth be told. All I've been doing in Salineas is working to keep people's spirits high and jovial during these especially trying times. It's all I really know how to do besides setting-' he coughed, 'sailing boats. As for our arguments, well... she's usually in the right. So each time I accept that I was wrong and apologise to her. Why, pray tell, do you ask?'

I laid down, closing my eyes and taking in the warmth of the day. 'Catra kept something from me. It's not the first time and it might not be the last but... I don't know. For some reason, this time, I have this uneasy feeling in my stomach. I'm sure it's nothing. It will probably turn out to be nothing, but I also want to avoid arguing with her if I can.'

'If I know one thing, it's that love works in mysterious ways. Something that doesn't bother Mermista one day may annoy her to the deepest depths and back the next.'

'I suppose Catra can be like that too. Sometimes I don't know what she's thinking. Actually that's wrong, I hardly ever know what she's thinking.'

'That's why love is the greatest of *adventures*. There's nothing quite like it.'

I smiled, 'you've got a point there.' Another question popped into my head; one I'd been thinking about for a while but never really voiced to anyone before. 'Hey, this is a completely random question not at all linked to Catra, and you have to promise not to tell anyone I asked you this, but... where do you think would be a good place to... propose... to someone.' I opened an eye and dared to peek up at him.

Sea Hawk was trying his best to hide his obvious excitement, barely able to contain himself and bouncing on his toes. When he realised I was looking at him, he composed himself and cleared his throat with a loud cough. 'I'd be lying if I said I haven't given

this some thought, myself. I would have to say somewhere those people have shared a memory in the past. Somewhere familiar that has some kind of deeper meaning between both parties.'

I closed my one open eye and laid back against the deck of the boat. Somewhere with shared memories? Somewhere with meaning? Catra and I hadn't really had chance to share many experiences over our lives that weren't overshadowed by war or Shadow Weaver. There's got to be somewhere we enjoyed ourselves, even a little bit...

My thoughts were interrupted by Sea Hawk laughing loudly. 'What says the *mighty She-Ra* to a best-of-three arm wrestling tournament?'

I smiled and shot to my feet, eager for the distraction. 'Oh, you're on!'

**

We eventually arrived at the cove after an extended arm-wrestling tournament, which I won, of course, and after three or four shanties about boats and love.

The entrance to the cove was set into the side of a sheer cliff-face, dark and foreboding. A large, gaping hole that resembled a gigantic toothy maw that led through to a cavern beyond. As we sailed through the cavity, I wondered why it was called Octopus Cove and not something more... toothy. But, as my eyes adjusted to the dark, I saw why. The cave within was illuminated by a blue glow emanating from the water as it threaded between arrays of pointy stalagmites. In the very centre of the cove, surrounded by a deep moat of glowing blue water, stood a towering mass of wrecked ships absolutely covered in Octopuses.

'Woah...' I gaped up at the mound of dead ships, watching as many of the Octopuses flung themselves into the water as we approached. 'Why are there so many?'

'I have no idea...' Sea Hawk was also mesmerised by the sight ahead but managed to bring the ship around to avoid crashing into anything.

Looking over the side, I saw the glowing water swirling as we passed through it. 'How is the water glowing like this?'

'Ah! That's something I do know... You see, it's something called plankton, it glows when disturbed by the waves crashing against the rocks within the cave.'

'It looks amazing.'

'It truly is a sight to behold... Now, for the ultimate quest to find a pearl in a mountain of shipwrecks! *Huzzah!'*

The closer the Dragon's Daughter VII came to the mass of splintered wood and bent metal the more dangerous it looked. I started to doubt the validity of the "Legend" at the sight of it, surely if there were a pearl within the mess of shipwrecks no one would even know it was there.

'Are you sure there's definitely a pearl *inside* that?' I asked, suddenly aware of how long it would take to search through all the wreckage for a tiny pearl.

'Well...' began Sea Hawk, as he looped a rope around a nearby large stalagmite, holding the boat in place, 'it could be *anywhere.* That is... if it actually does exist. It is a legend, after all.'

'So you brought us all the way out here not knowing if what we're looking for actually exists?'

'Indeed! *Onward,* to a possibly entirely pointless *ADVENTURE!'* Sea Hawk yelled, his voice echoing around the cavern.

"ADVENTURE... VENture... enture..."

'Are we there yet?' Swift Wind appeared from below deck and looked around in stunned silence for moment, taking in our surroundings. 'Woah... so this is Octopus Cove...'

I nodded, it was impressive and definitely unique, but the scale was nothing compared to Underdryl. 'What do you say we get a look from higher up, Swift Wind?'

He nodded confidently, 'let's do it, Adora!' He spread his wings wide as I jumped up onto his back.

'Sea Hawk,' I said, getting his attention before he started climbing a nearby stalagmite, 'see if you can spot anything that might help from down here. Swift Wind and I will scope out the rest of the shipwrecks on the pile.'

'A brilliant plan!' He nodded, pulling out his spyglass and aiming it toward the mass of broken ships. 'I shall remain here and watch the ship.'

'Do *not* set it on fire.' I warned, smirking at the exasperated face I got in return before it settled into a more quizzical look as he considered to himself.

'Fair enough. Alighting boats on fire *is* my specialty after all, even if I do so accidentally.'

After a moment I patted Swift Wind on the neck and he took to the air, quickly rising into the cavern and circling the mountain of splintered wood at its centre. Hardly any of the ships looked to be in a recognisable state. All but one - Swift Wind spotted it first.

'Adora!' He called, 'that one looks stable, should we land on it?'

'Go for it!' I called back.

Swift Wind angled down, steadily lowering our altitude and landing on the deck of a decades old wooden ship that creaked dangerously as weight was applied to it. He stopped moving quickly, not wanting to disturb the delicate structure too much

before I could have a look around. Carefully, I slid off of his back and tip-toed my way across what was left of the deck, making sure to only put pressure on the planks that looked relatively stable. The flaky pink paintwork of the vessel was barely visible underneath the layers of algae and coral that had grown on top of it. I eyed my destination warily, a cabin door just a little further ahead. What were the chances I would find a chest inside that just so happened to contain a pearl?

I continued forward, choosing my path with greater confidence, testing each plank with my weight before committing to the route. Swift Wind was still standing still behind me, not daring to move for fear of distracting me. I could feel him in the back of my mind, a reassuring presence filling me with the confidence I needed. But the link works both ways, and in turn I felt how conscious he was of his heavier weight and how he could cause the whole thing to collapse if he wasn't careful.

After what felt like an age, I reached the door and pressed myself up against it. By some miracle, it hadn't already succumbed to the same fate as the rest of the ships on the pile. I skimmed my hand over the door, searching for the handle and turning it slowly when I found it, stepping inside once I saw that there was, in fact, a floor to step on to. But what confronted me inside was not at all what I had been expecting.

The room beyond the door ended abruptly, cut in half by a white, scaly, fleshy wall. It was like nothing I had ever seen before, rising and falling every so often as if... as if it was *breathing*. Drawn forwards by a wonderful curiosity, I stepped closer until I was near enough to rest my hand against the wall. It felt cold, sticky, slimy, but it was definitely *alive*. I moved back from the wall, processing all the new information circling around in my head. The entire stack of ships was hiding something, something monstrously large, alive, slimy, and... *corrupted*. I watched in horror as a glowing bright green vine snaked its way up the side of the pale wall, sprouting smaller offshoots as it went.

That can't be good.

I turned to leave, but stopped when something above the door to the cabin caught my eye: a sign, a nameplate...

"The Pink Pearl"

It was a *ship* - the legend was about a *ship*, not an actual pearl! Of course Sea Hawk would drag us out to chase something that never actually existed!

Annoying as that revelation was, I ultimately decided to make myself scarce. The glowing green vines on the wall had spread further, reaching the ceiling of the cabin, and I did not want to hang around to find out what came next. With a more conslusive story behind the legend of the Pink Pearl, I quickly and carefully made my way back over to Swift Wind, taking the same route as before.

Without warning, the entire tower of wrecked ships began to move - it felt as if Etheria itself was shaking. After a moment, it became clear that Etheria was not, in fact, shaking. We were, however, slowly *spinning* in place. After a moment, Sea Hawk came into view, gawking up from the deck of the Dragon's Daughter VII at the mass of moving shipwrecks turning in the middle of the cavern.

'Sea Hawk!' I called, arching my hands around my mouth, trying to project my voice down to him, 'I found the Pink Pearl!' My words were lost, drowned out by the crashing of the waves as the wrecked flotilla slowly woke up from its apparent slumber and disturbed the waters of the cavern.

I heard a faint, *'What!?'* in response from down below.

'Come on, Swift Wind, back down to Sea Hawk!' I shouted, jumping onto his back. He immediately took to the air, diving down toward the boat.

The waves crashed angrily against the boat as we landed on it, buffeting it up against the stalagmites on which octopuses had started clinging to escape the ferocious waters. Sea Hawk cut the

rope, unbinding the ship from the rocks, but the relentless waves kept it held in place regardless.

'What's happening!?' Sea Hawk shouted above the deafening sound of ferocious waves and splintering wood. 'Did you find the pearl!?' Bits of ships fell from the mound as it spun around, splashing into the water all around us.

Before I could respond, the boat was suddenly pulled forwards, caught in a current created by the woodpile of wrecked ships as they rose out of the water, causing waves to surge inwards, filling the void left behind. Two enormous claws rose out of the water either side of our boat, bright-green corruption covering them like vines, soon followed by two bright green eyes breaking the surface and swaying back and forth on the end of long spindly eyestalks. The wandering eyes soon locked on to us and the rest of a snarling, toothy face roared out of the thrashing waves ahead.

All three of us screamed as we were pulled underneath the beast, the twin masts snapping in half and the sails falling into the water below as they struck against the monstrosity. The boat was suddenly at the mercy of the currents, being thrashed back and forth as the gigantic crustacean rose out of the water on its six armoured legs, each one glowing with the snaking green corruption. It looked like...

'By the seas - It's a hermit crab!' Shouted Sea Hawk above the cacophony of thunderous roars and crashing waves filling the cavern, 'It's an enormous hermit crab! It must be - *woah!* - using the ships as a shell! Truly astounding!'

'And it's corrupted!' I shouted back. This looked exactly like what Catra said Melog had found, a living creature corrupted with green vines that snaked all over the body of the host. That means there must a First Ones crystal on it somewhere...

The creature roared once more, spinning around on the spot and causing a whirlpool to form below it, sucking in all the fallen

debris.

Come on She-Ra... Don't fail me now...

'For the honour of Grayskull!'

To my relief, I felt the familiar strength of She-Ra flowing through me. I picked up Sea Hawk and lunged toward Swift Wind as he took flight. We managed to get off the deck of the Dragon's Daughter VII before it was swallowed by the violent vortex.

I heard Sea Hawk sniffing, 'goodbye, my dear...' he whispered as he reached out toward the sinking boat.

Swift Wind took evasive action, weaving between the legs of the creature that towered above us and narrowly avoided being swatted out of the air by the giant claws that swung around, pinching erratically.

Eventually, we reached a height that the creature couldn't reach with its claws and Swift Wind stilled his wings, keeping us level. I was then able to get a good look at the overgrown critter, and saw that Sea Hawk had been correct, it was a hermit crab. Based on what I had seen inside the Pink Pearl, it was using the ships as some kind of shell. Possibly because there aren't any shells this big that accommodate such a creature. Those glowing green streaks covered its entire body, but where were they leading from? It thrashed its claws wildly, trying to pinch us out of the air. That's when I noticed, embedded into the side of one of its massive claws... the First Ones crystal.

'I know what I have to do.' I announced, a surge of confidence flowing through me. 'I have to get onto its right claw to destroy the source of the corruption.'

'What do you need, Adora?' Swift Wind asked. His tone was serene, calm, despite the situation we found ourselves in. He had total faith in me, and that in itself was a reassurance I was grateful for.

'Get me closer.'

'On it!' He yelled, closing his wings, diving us back down toward the creature.

'Adora! Do you know what you're doing?' Sea Hawk asked anxiously from behind me.

'Nope!' I replied, before launching myself from Swift Wind and aiming straight toward the afflicted claw.

I landed on it with a thud, immediately losing my footing. It was much slipperier than I had been expecting. As I slid down the side, I managed to grab hold of one of the many spines along its exoskeleton. The monstrous hermit crab started swinging its claw back and forth, trying to shake me loose, but I hung on tight, finding secure footholds on its claw's carapace. Looking up, I could see the glowing green First Ones crystal lodged into the surface of the claw. Had it been forced in there on purpose? Who would do such a thing?

Once the claw's shaking stopped, I began the climb up, lifting myself along the spikes of the armoured husk and avoiding coming into contact with any of the green corrupted roots.

As I neared the crystal, I could hear a faint whispering emanating from it, willing me to touch it - to connect with it. And, for the briefest of moments, it sounded like such a good idea...

Shouting from above me brought me back to my senses, I looked upwards to see Swift Wind and Sea Hawk dodge through another attack by the creature's other claw as it roared and starting spinning, following them around the cavern.

I willed the power of She-Ra to strengthen me, before leaping upwards towards the crystal and grabbing hold of a large spike just under its pincer. I was now eye-level with the source of the corruption, the whispering from it was deafening now and I could make out the voice coming from it perfectly...

Let go, Adora.

Give in.

Succumb to your fears.

Embrace the darkness.

'Not today!' I shouted, summoning the sword before striking it straight through the crystal, shattering it into dozens of tiny shards, the green glow fading from them as they rained down into the water of the cove below.

I watched as the glow that surrounded the beast steadily faded, the vines crumbling and dropping from where they had clung moments beforehand. As Swift Wind came round again, I leaped off of the claw, landing on his back in front of Sea Hawk. The behemoth was calm now, its erratic movements ceasing and the waves below calming down once more. We watched as it dunked its claws into the water, picking up the remains of the Dragon's Daughter VII and adding them to its shell of wrecked ships before sinking back below the water.

Swift Wind landed on a flat rocky perch, allowing us to get off and rest. Sea Hawk dropped to his knees, looking out at the graveyard of ships that served as a home to a massive sea creature where his own boat now rested.

After reverting to regular-old Adora, I placed a hand on his shoulder. 'She went down in a blaze of glory, Sea Hawk, you should be proud.'

'She had a valiant life!' He sobbed, dramatically reaching out and clenching his fist, 'and an even more valiant end! I couldn't wish for a better resting place. She was able to cut the finest of lines down the sea... Truly the daughter of the dragons...'

'What's Mermista going to say when you try and explain your way out of this one?' I asked, looking across the cove at the calm waters. It was just as it had been as we entered; the water

glowing blue, octopuses rising back out of the water onto the wrecks.

Sea Hawks face turned white as a sheet. 'I fear she may sooner believe that I just set it on fire...'

Swift Wind stretched out his wings behind us. '*Ohh wow.* I've not flown like that in a looong time. I can probably make it to Salineas before nightfall if you want to head back soon.'

I turned to face him, smiling. 'That sounds great, Swifty. I can't wait to tell Catra about this...' My face fell immediately. *Catra...* I had said we were going to talk about her keeping the truth about the mission a secret. In all the excitement, I'd completely forgotten.

'Tell me, Adora,' Sea Hawk began, standing up, 'were you, per chance, able to find the pink pearl from the legends?'

Once I climbed up onto Swift Wind's back, I held my hand out to Sea Hawk, helping him up. 'Yeah... about that...'

**

It was evening by the time we reached Salineas. I could see the sea gate glowing red from far away, still destroyed, full of holes. Our ship filled with supplies was docked just beyond it, the crew and a number of Salineans working together to offload the seemingly endless stream of crates. The rest of the town itself was unfortunately still in quite a sorry state, the ruined buildings still lay untouched and there were tents set up all around - temporary housing for the few inhabitants that remained.

'It looks like there's still a lot to do...' I muttered as we flew overhead.

'Indeed,' said Sea Hawk, sat behind me, 'progress has been slow... although I don't see our friends anywhere... perhaps they've convened in the throne room?'

'You hear that, Swifty?' I said, patting his neck.

He changed course, heading toward the Salinean castle. 'Throne room, here we come!'

There weren't any guards outside the throne room when we landed, so we let ourselves in. The space within was mostly how I remembered it. Drawings with First Ones inscriptions covered the walls on the left between the waterfalls and everywhere you looked everything was shiny and blue. Well, everywhere that wasn't cracked or black with scorch marks. It appears that Hordak was very thorough in leaving his stain on Salineas when it fell.

There were four people standing in the throne room and I felt my heart swell when I saw Catra... being *hugged*...
by *Mermista?* Glimmer and Bow were standing to one side, smiling to themselves. They looked up and waved as we entered.

'Oh, thank you thank you thank you.' I heard Mermista chanting into Catra's shoulder.

Catra looked incredibly uncomfortable, not quite sure if she should hug back or not. 'Uhh, you're... welcome?'

'I can't believe *you* did all this. You know, after you helped to tear it all down.' Mermista said, standing back up, back to normal.

'Hey...' I whispered to Bow and Glimmer as I stood next to them, 'what's happening?'

Glimmer giggled quietly, leaning in to whisper back. 'We just told Mermista that Catra planned the whole thing to apologise for what she did. She's... taking it well.' Then her expression fell, 'hang on! That's right, I'm mad at you! How come you're going off on your own!? With *Sea Hawk!'*

'It was a glorious and perilous *ADVENTURE!'* Sea Hawk shouted from behind me.

'Uhh. I wasn't there. Nope. Not me.' Swift Wind backed away slowly, before galloping out of the throne room.

Catra turned to face us, she looked relieved to see me and I noticed as she started to step forward before stopping herself. 'Adora? You're back?'

'Ugghhh. Sea Hawk. I thought I kicked you out.' Mermista crossed her arms and stared daggers at him.

'Ah. Yes, dearest, you did. *However!* Wait until you hear the tale of how we tamed the beast of Octopus Cove!' He threw his arm in the air, pointing at nothing in particular.

'A BEAST?!' Bow, Glimmer and Catra shouted in unison.

I whistled a random tune and looked around awkwardly, not meeting anyone's eye contact.

Mermista covered her mouth with her hands and gasped. 'You calmed Ol'Pointy?'

Sea Hawk looked confused, *'Ol'Pointy?'* He asked, looking at me.

I nodded furiously. *Go with it!*

'Ah! Ahem. Yes! Ol'Pointy! Of course... We were indeed able to calm the beast, a tale of woe I shall now spin... OoooOOoOoh-!'

'NO! No shanty!' Mermista strode across the room, standing in front of him. I saw the hint of a blush appear on her face and she crossed her arms before quickly kissing Sea Hawk on the cheek. 'You're out of the doghouse. I guess.'

Sea Hawk gasped, tentatively touching his cheek before swooning and dramatically flailing to the floor.

'You have to tell us *all* about it!' Bow exclaimed, placing a hand on my shoulder and beaming at me.

I laughed nervously, rubbing the back of my neck, supposing that I would be the one to break the news about Sea Hawk losing yet another ship. 'Yeah, I will.' I said before looking to Catra. She seemed unsure of what to do, hugging her arms around herself. No doubt she remembered what I had said before I left. 'Catra! What's the plan going forward?' I asked, trying to give her something else to think about for now.

That seemed to wake her up. She looked over at all of us as we waited to hear what she had to say. As her eyes met mine, I smiled reassuringly, her expression visibly softening as she untensed before beginning to tell us the plan for rebuilding Salineas.

'No, wait, time out.' Mermista interrupted, glaring at the sprawled form of Sea Hawk still on the floor. 'Is Sea Hawk's moustache *upside down?*'

Chapter End Notes

A few things to mention:

- Next update will be next Saturday (24th)
- Chapters 1 & 2 have been completely rewritten & updated
- Follow my Instagram to catch all updates as they happen: @iorekofthehorde

See you next week!

Honesty

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's plan sounded simple when she first explained it, but each step ended up requiring a great deal of manpower and perseverance to pull off.

Firstly, we cleared up any existing rubble from around the kingdom of Salineas, which made getting around a whole lot easier. This step was followed by deconstructing any partially destroyed walls and rebuilding them with the supplies we brought from Bright Moon and Seaworthy. Doing this kept much of the original architecture intact, but also made our use of supplies much more efficient as we weren't constructing whole new buildings, just walls.

The second part of the plan was to build a small temporary village on one side of Salineas for all those whose houses were completely destroyed. As most of the buildings in Salineas are either grown or built by hand with a special clay from a nearby reservoir, the townspeople would need time to rebuild their homes. I was fascinated to learn that this was a very personal process, as each family constructed their own home and would add to it as the generations progressed. This realisation made it all the more heart-breaking to see the kingdom in ruins. So many generations of Salineans' lives and effort had been destroyed in that attack. No one carried the burden of that guilt as much as Catra did. She worked harder than anyone to ensure these efforts to salvage the kingdom were not in vain.

Lastly, we were able to start welcoming back those that had fled from Salineas. It was very emotional, as many of them had never expected to be able to return home at all after the war left Salineas in ruins. Perhaps the one thing many of the returning townsfolk mentioned that they would have to get used to was the

sea gate being gone. Since being destroyed, the force field of the gate had slowly been dissolving. It wasn't until we had finished restoring Salineas to a fraction of its former glory that its connection to the Salinean Runestone, the Pearl, eventually gave in, causing the gate to vanish completely for the first time in centuries. Mermista didn't seem to care though, insisting that because the war was over, they had no need for a huge gate anyway, or whatever.

This initial rebuilding of Salineas, under Catra's guidance and leadership, took just under twelve days. Even though the kingdom was relatively small in comparison to Bright Moon, it had been the worst hit towards the end of the war, so to kickstart the rebuilding efforts like this in such a short amount of time with only what we brought with us on the boat was an incredible feat.

Mermista made sure that Catra knew, after doing all of this, that she was well and truly forgiven. And, when Mermista asked Catra if there was anything she could do or give in return, Catra said...

'I was wondering... if you would teach me how to control water...?'

So there I was, lying on a beach of pebbles watching my girlfriend and Mermista as they stood in the shallows swaying back and forth in time to the waves as they lapped against the shore. Both Catra and I were wearing Salinean swimsuits (made in Bright Moon), provided by Glimmer who had apparently packed one for all of us just in case we ended up having a day on the beach. Glimmer and Bow were also on the beach, just a little further up, splashing around in the shallows. Melog was sunbathing on top of a rather tall rock and Swift Wind... I hadn't actually seen anything of Swift Wind or Sea Hawk at all throughout the day.

'Argh! This isn't working!' Catra shouted, feeling the frustration of not grasping water as quickly as she had done with wind. Her First Ones tech hadn't lit up at all since they started.

'Ugh! You need to be more like... *whatever.* You know?' Mermista was not a patient teacher. 'It doesn't help that you fundamentally *hate* being in the water.'

'I can't help that; I've always hated it.' Catra protested, crossing her arms in a huff.

'Well you've definitely got to let go of *all* of that, okay? The water isn't going to respond to you if you *hate* it. Just empty your mind and *flow.* Try and be calm, like whatever.' Mermista started swaying again, moving her arms in time to the waves and gently pushing ripples of her own along with it.

Catra watched Mermista for a second, before closing her eyes and taking a deep breath. She started whispering something to herself, but I was too far away to hear what. Over to the right, Glimmer had started teleporting around Bow, splashing him from all angles at once.

I laid down on the blanket, looking up at the sky and running my hands through the tiny peddles either side of me. Staring up at the sky is something I've been doing a lot lately... I'm not sure why. Maybe I'm trying to see what's happening in space with the Galactic Horde ships, or maybe I'm curious about what else is out there... other planets, other people... I remembered the Star siblings that we encountered before - it's been quite a while now since we saw them. I wondered how they would be getting on now if their world was also recovering since Horde Prime was removed from the picture.

Adora...

Damn. There it was; his voice. Right on cue as I let his name slip into my mind. I closed my eyes, reciting the mantra in my head that Catra and I had developed one day while on a call with Perfuma, it seemed to help whenever I felt him creeping back in.

I am afraid. I feel my fear. But I accept it, as a part of me. I will allow it to pass through me, I will not resist. When the fear has

passed, there will be nothing. Only I will remain.

That seemed to work. I couldn't hear him anymore. His voice was much less frequent now, and far quieter than ever. Rather than trying to shut it out I now let the fear wash over me and become one with me. In the Horde, fear was a weakness. It was something to stamp out. But now, I was learning to accept it and make it a part of myself. I'd be lying if I didn't sometimes hear Catra whispering those words to herself too.

Suddenly feeling the urge to look at Catra, I sat up once again. Mermista had stopped swaying with the waves, instead watching Catra with a satisfied, smug grin. Catra's tech glowed a bright blue as she swayed back and forth, the water rippling more and more each time she did. I stood up and approached the shore, getting a better look. Catra was definitely having an effect on the water, causing it to rise more and more as she moved her arms back and forth in time to the waves.

'Open your eyes.' I whispered.

As I expected, her ears twitched. Catra had amazing hearing, after all. She opened her eyes and watched what she was doing, how she was manipulating the water around her. Her eyes met mine and she grinned, but there was a hint of something else there too.

Catra turned to face me and pulled her arms back, causing the shore to recede behind her and build up slowly. Then, she lunged her arms forwards, causing the water to surge forwards. I realised what she was doing and moved to avoid it, but I was too slow, engulfed by the wave that Catra sent hurtling towards me. It pushed me to the ground, and I landed in the soft bed of pebbles. How pebbles could feel this soft I'll never know... Sitting up, I moved my now wet hair out of my face and saw Catra laughing while Mermista just stood nodding, looking impressed.

'Catra! Did you just want to learn water magic so you could splash me?!'

Catra walked over, holding out a hand to help me up. 'Oh, yeah, definitely. Totally worth it, by the way.' I took her hand and she pulled me up. 'You should have seen your face! You were like, "Ahh! Noo! Betrayal!"'

'Oo-kay. Looks like my job here is done.' Said Mermista as she walked past us back towards Salineas. 'Just don't drown anyone that annoys you, alright? Trust me, it takes some holding back.'

'Thanks, Mermista.' I called after her. She waved over her shoulder. 'And as for you...' I said, looking back at Catra.

'What? What are you gonna-'

She yelped as I pushed her, causing her to fall back into the water, soaking her through immediately.

'Oh, you're on!' She laughed, sending a stream of water hurtling past my head as I ducked out of the way.

I blew a raspberry at Catra before laughing and running towards our friends, 'Bow, Glimmer! Help! Catra's learned how to magically *splash* me with water!'

'I can do more than *splash you,* princess.' I heard her call from behind me.

As I got closer to Bow and Glimmer, I heard Glimmer laugh mischievously before teleporting away. Now just Bow and I stood together in the shallows. I looked around, trying to see where Glimmer had gone.

Bow pointed behind me, and I turned to see Catra and Glimmer whispering together. 'Oh no.'

'Yeah...' said Bow, 'we're pretty much screwed...'

Catra and Glimmer grinned at one another before looking towards us like how a predator eyes up its prey.

'Well...' I said, reaching my hand out in front of me, 'if they're not going to play fair... then neither am I.'

**

Catra and I decided to stay on the beach as evening rolled around, even after Bow and Glimmer called it a day. It was still warm enough that we could get away with being in our swimsuits without getting too cold. We sat together on the blankets, watching as the brightest of Etheria's moons slowly made its way toward the horizon. As the light dimmed, some of the pebbles on the beach started glowing, making it appear as if we were sitting among the stars.

We hadn't yet had that chance to talk about anything I had wanted to since the conversation I had with Glimmer on the way to Seaworthy. Reluctantly, I decided it was now or never.

'Catra...' I began, laying down on the blanket and looking up at the real stars far above us, 'I want to have that talk now, it's that's okay.'

Catra sighed, still watching the moon set. 'Way to ruin the moment, Adora.'

'I know. I'm sorry. But it's been almost two weeks and I haven't been able to stop thinking about it, so now that we're done and alone...'

'It's okay...' said Catra, turning to face me. Her eyes glowing in the twilight. 'I would have had to tell you sometime anyway.'

'I just want to know why you didn't tell me you planned all this. It's been bothering me. It feels like there might be...' I took a deep breath, 'I worry that there's more you're not telling me.'

Catra laid down next to me, looking up at the stars. 'I guess... I didn't tell you I planned this because... I didn't want credit for it. I didn't do this to better my own image, I didn't do it for forgiveness, I did it... I did it because it was the right thing to do.

I was righting a wrong. I felt this enormous... Ugh, *I just wanted to help.* After going with Glimmer and Bow on those missions to help the settlements around Bright Moon, I knew that I wanted to help Salineas too. I watched as this place was attacked and I... *I just watched.* I lounged around in the ruins as if it was the most normal thing in the world.'

I changed position, lying on my side, and looked across at Catra, perfectly framed against the setting moonlight. 'So why did you turn down Royal Advisor? If you want to help, that must be the best way to do it. You've definitely proven yourself now, what with starting off the rebuilding efforts for Salineas and re-homing all those displaced Sea Elves.'

She lifted a hand, running it through her hair and scratching behind her ear. 'I... I don't know.'

'You're perfect for it, Catra. You practically ran the Horde for years. That's amazing.'

Catra glanced toward me and scoffed. 'Yeah, and what did I accomplish in the end? Nothing. All I did was hurt people, Adora. Everything I did, the aim was to hurt. Destroy. Conquer. I don't...' She cut herself off and sighed, looking back up at the stars, 'I don't deserve a role like that in Bright Moon. Not after what I did. I will never forgive myself for everything I've done.'

'Not even if everyone else forgives you?'

'Like that would ever happen.'

'It is happening, Catra. Everyone is slowly seeing you as I see you. How I've always seen you. You're amazing. The fact that you're able to plan something of this scale in less than a week, and pull it off the way you did... No one else could have done that.' I let my hand stroke circles on her stomach and smiled when I heard that soft purr that I loved so much.

'Adora... *stop,* you're making me purr.'

'You *like* it.'

'Shut up.'

We laid like that for a short while, Catra purring while I trailed my hands across her fur.

'Adora...'

'Hm?'

'I've been thinking.'

'What is it?'

'You know how... You know that I love you, right?'

I felt myself blush at hearing those words, but the way she said them made me worry. 'Of course.'

'And you love me.'

'Always.'

'Well... That's just it.' Catra placed her hand on top of mine, stopping my hands motions against her fur. 'I've been thinking... how far do you want this to go?'

I slowly removed my hand from its position on her hip, looking into her eyes. The fact that she was able to meet my gaze like this told me that she was serious. She wasn't playing around. 'What do you mean?'

'I mean *us,* Adora. What do you want from this?'

I want to get married.

'I... I want...'

'We've been a thing, together, girlfriends, whatever you want to call it now for five weeks. It's been a whole month since I told you

I loved you in the Heart of Etheria. I just... I want to know where we're going. I want to know us being together is okay. That it's right. That it's not a mistake, or a dream, or something that's going to vanish, Adora, because I don't...' Her eyes glistened in the low light, tears dripping down her face. Her voice quavered, becoming unsteady, 'I don't know what I'll do if I lose you. Or, if this whole th-thing has somehow been... just *pity.* Adora, I don't want to be a-alone again. I *can't* be alone again... *I need you.'*

'Catra...' I could feel tears welling up in my own eyes. Why was she thinking like this? 'Catra, I'm not going anywhere. I love you, okay? I will always love you. I know it took me longer to figure it out, but I've always wanted to be around you. I feel at ease when I'm with you. You complete me... I never want what we have to end. This month, being with you, has been amazing. It's everything I ever wanted. To be close to you, to hold you, to kiss you, to... to go further with you. I can't get enough of you, Catra, and I hope I never will. I fall in love with you more and more every day and I want you to...'

I want you to be my wife.

I've never felt a conflict within myself like this before. It would be so easy to say it now, to ask her to marry me, but... thinking back to what Sea Hawk said, to propose somewhere with meaning... to Catra, Salineas wasn't that place. She's helped them rebuild, but she hurt the people here. It wouldn't feel right to propose somewhere that doesn't feel right to both of us.

So, I held my tongue. Instead finding a different truth, one not so far from an actual proposal.

'...I want you to be a part of my life, for as long as I live.'

'Adora...' Catra held her hands up to her face, hiding her eyes. I watched as the tears dripped down her face and felt tears of my own dripping onto the blanket below me.

'Catra-' I reached out to her, but she sat up before I could touch her face.

'There's... there's something else.' Catra said, wiping her eyes and trying to bring herself back under control.

I sat up too, wiping my eyes and gently placing a hand on her back to reassure her. 'It's okay, Catra. What is it?'

'You- you were right. I was keeping something else from you.' I felt my heart drop to my stomach as Catra continued, 'I'm really sorry, I just didn't want to worry you while you were having those nightmares.'

My mind raced, searching for any hint as to what else she could have hidden from me; until I found it. 'Is it... is it to do with Elberon?' Catra had promised to tell me what happened on that particular mission, but when I had asked about it later, she put it off, changing the subject. I had completely forgotten about it until now.

Catra nodded. 'There was an attack.'

'An *attack?*' This couldn't be happening. We were at peace, who would attack during peace?

She turned to face me, sitting up on her legs. 'Yes. An attack.' Catra spoke with clarity now, but her face was still damp from crying. 'We don't know what caused it, but supplies were intercepted on their way to Elberon. The people escorting them said that they didn't see what attacked them, just that the carts exploded and that was that. Nothing was taken, there was no sign of traps, no lingering scents from whoever could have done it. Nothing.' She laughed, 'I couldn't tell you that *nothing* had attacked supply carts, could I? Not when you were still recovering.'

'Wait, so...' my head started aching, trying to make sense of all this. 'So, if you wouldn't tell me when there was no evidence... does that mean...?'

Catra nodded once again. 'We've found something. Well, Hordak did. A signal. He had been focusing on Etheria's orbit, not watching Etheria itself, but when I contacted him about what happened he cross-checked his data with Entrapta's systems. He found a signal coming from Etheria and...'

'And?'

'It correlates with the Horde ships vanishing off the scans. Every time that signal is detected coming from Etheria, a ship in orbit drops off the radar. That same signal was detected on the day Elberon was attacked, but no ships in orbit vanished.'

'So whatever is dropping ships off the radar in orbit is now...'

'Yeah,' Catra finished, 'it's started attacking Etheria.'

'Has it been detected since?'

'Yesterday.'

'And? Did anything happen?'

Catra sighed, 'another supply convoy was attacked in the same way and there were... there were casualties this time.'

I stood up, suddenly feeling enraged. What was attacking Etheria? *Killing* people? Destroying supplies? Possibly killing the lost clones that orbited us...

Catra rose too, grabbing me by the shoulders. 'Adora. I'm telling you this because... because I think you're ready to go back out there. I want you to know that I kept it from you because I care about you, I love you, and I didn't want you to hurt yourself if you weren't in the right place. I know what it's like to be - distracted. Overwhelmed.'

Her eyes gazed into mine and snapped me back to reality. I took a deep breath. 'Okay... So what can we do?'

'We wait. We wait until Hordak detects the signal again and then he'll try and point us toward it, so that we can help before anyone else is hurt.'

'Do Bow and Glimmer know about this? We were having fun today, but people *died* yesterday.' I felt a wave of guilt wash over me, thinking about how we could have done something, *anything.*

'Adora, it was over long before Hordak contacted me. And yeah, they know but... we agreed not to tell you yet, because of your nightmares and-'

'So you all knew? And you all kept it from me?' My heart tightened at the thought of my friends, my best friends, keeping things from me. *What else was I being left out of?*

'Adora! I need you to be calm. This is exactly why we didn't tell you. You needed this break, and it worked - you finally stopped having nightmares. I just... I need you to trust me.' Catra's voice was soft, unwavering, her eyes focused and her grip on my shoulders strong, grounding. I took a deep breath, focusing on the warmth of Catra's hands.

'So... so what, this was the calm before the storm?'

'Yeah, I guess...' Catra looked to the ground, 'I guess you could say that. From tomorrow, we're going to be focusing on detecting that signal again and stopping whatever it is before it strikes, I promise. I want to stop it just as much as you do.'

The moon finally set beyond the horizon, leaving us standing in near pitch-blackness. Catra's eyes shone like beacons in the gloom. I shivered as a cold breeze suddenly swept over the beach. Catra broke away from me, picking up the blankets at our feet and draping one over me, before covering herself with one too.

'Come on, Adora. We've been out here too long. I'll lead you back.' Her hand grabbed mine as she started pulling me back

toward the ship that had become our temporary home over the past 12 days.

My mind raced with thoughts about what could be behind the attack, but I couldn't think of anything that could cause such a level of destruction and remain unseen. Something that could leave no evidence it was ever there, except for a signal, needed to be stopped. Soon.

Chapter End Notes

Is this... plot?

Just to let you all know the next chapter will be next Saturday as well. This may end up becoming the new norm. I've been stuck on Chapter 32 for a couple weeks now but it will be so worth it once I'm through it.

The New Routine

Chapter Summary

> A month has passed, nothing's happened, they've gotten comfortable.
> Having a false sense of security is not a good thing.

Silence.

An entire, painstaking month passed by.

Nothing.

We returned to Bright Moon the day after Catra confided in me on the beach in Salineas, immediately setting up patrols around the nearby settlements and their supply routes. I also reconnected with Hordak, who filled me in on the situation in Dryl.

Entrapta was obsessed with experimenting with the refined Etherium, leaving Hordak to keep an eye on the signals. He had been monitoring the airwaves of Etheria non-stop while also working ever closer to completing his observatory. I checked in with him everyday, and everyday he assured me that he would contact me as soon as anything changes.

Catra has been very understanding. I expected her to tell me to take it slow, take a break, not to worry so much - but that didn't happen. She's been as motivated as me to find our phantom attackers, those that destroyed supplies and took innocent lives. Knowing she felt this strongly about it reassured me that this was right, that we were doing the right thing.

Since our talk, Catra and I were much more comfortable around each other. The passion we had toward one another at the beginning of our new relationship two months ago has been evolving toward comfort, solace, a loving warmth that I wouldn't trade for anything. That's not to say there weren't still moments of passion... And of course, I still hadn't asked her to marry me. It

hadn't seemed appropriate considering the reason for these apparently endless patrols.

There was a meeting scheduled with all available princesses, which wasn't many, for later that morning where we were to be given a new patrol route for the next week or so. The week before, we had been patrolling around Plumeria since Scorpia and Perfuma moved on to the Fright Zone.

Catra kept in contact with Scorpia throughout, checking in on them to see how it was going over there. From what Catra told me, the Fright Zone sounded like it was in a shambles at first. Before Scorpia and Perfuma arrived, Lonnie and Rogelio were trying to hold the whole place together on their own, Kyle being about as useful as he can be. Many of the Horde soldiers still refused to accept that the war was over, that Etheria was actually at peace now. Most of them had been raised in the Fright Zone or were zealots that joined of their own will. To have their ideal, their only way of life, stripped away after utter defeat had been hard for many of them to accept. Perfuma had started leading meditation sessions, which were not popular at all at first, but as the days turned into weeks more and more ex-soldiers began turning up and participating. It was a slow process, but the Fright Zone sounded like it was finally beginning to turn around. Catra also agreed to go and over there to visit them for a time once everything in and around Bright Moon calmed down somewhat.

Looking up from the tracker pad on my lap, I observed Catra sitting at the vanity in our room. We had woken up not too long ago, still not fully dressed, and needed to get ready for the upcoming meeting. Catra gazed intently at her reflection in the mirror, tugging a clump of her hair down her face, apparently trying to see if it had grown any longer.

I put the tracker pad to one side, having finished reading the reports from the other patrols from the day before, and picked up the book that I had been writing in on and off for a while. Mostly, I just wrote random thoughts. But today, as I watched Catra

staring at herself and messing with her hair, I felt like sharing a bit more than usual.

-

Hi Book, it's me again.

I've been writing about our patrols, how we still haven't found anything, but I haven't written about Catra in a while. So, here goes.

I love her. So much. We've been close this past month, ever since Salineas, and I've loved every second with her. I know I should be focusing fully on finding what it is that's attacking, but it's been a while, so I'm allowed to let my mind waver a bit.

Every other day we've been training together, keeping each other on our toes. Catra's been getting better with her magic too. Even though she's still not great with water, she's really taken to using the Electrokinesis, as Entrapta called it. Scorpia's power. She's also been using her energy weapons to spar with, and she's practically doing it without thinking now.

One time, she went a bit too far while training, using too much magic at once. That put her in bed for a day, so I've been watching her closely ever since. She seemed really cuddly immediately after, but grew impatient and difficult later on, before apologising and making up again.

If this month has proven anything, it's that we can work. She really does want to be with me, she's told me as much enough times. The word "forever" keeps coming up. I'm convinced she's dropping hints. I know that she knows what marriage is, but I may need her to wait a bit longer. I have to come up with the best place to propose, and I won't be doing it while we're going on patrols every day.

Catra has also been napping on me a lot, especially after sparring. Sometimes I lose feeling in my legs and Bow and Glimmer have to come and help me up from under her. I just don't want to move

her or wake her up. I live to hear her purr, it's intoxicating, and she knows it. She's steadily figuring out what I like, and often uses it to her advantage. Sometimes, during meetings, she-

On second thought, I'll keep that between us for now.

I'm going to go cuddle her now, maybe I can get her to purr.

Wish me luck, Book.

-

I put the book down, stretching my arms, and steadily got up from the bed. Stepping over a lounging Melog, I walked over to Catra, wrapping my arms around her shoulders from behind and burying my face in her neck, taking in her warmth.

'Hey, Adora.' She smiled at my reflection in the mirror, running a hand along my arm.

'Hey, Catra. Seeing if your hair has grown?' I asked, knowing the answer. Her hair had definitely grown back some over the last two months, but it was really starting to be noticeable now as it began filling out. Catra was eager for it to grow more so that it would cover her neck and the scar that was still there from the Horde chip. She hadn't said it out loud, but I knew she hated that scar and wanted to hide it as soon as possible.

'Yeah. The longer it grows the less it... the more it feels like me, you know? I wish it grew faster... I think I also want to try doing something else with it...'

'Hmmm...' I thought for a second, running my hands through her hair and managing to coax out a purr. *Success*. 'Maybe we should ask someone what you could do with it when it grows out more... I think Netossa does her and Spinerella's hair.'

Catra laughed, 'I don't want anything that fancy. I just... I want to...' she let out a sigh, 'I don't know what I want.'

I trailed a hand down the back of her head, reaching her neck and gently stroking my thumb over the scar there. She tensed up. 'I do,' I whispered.

She spun around on the stool, wrapping her arms around my waist before burying her face in my stomach. 'Adora...'

'Yes?' I asked, beginning to scritch behind her ears.

'Where do you...mmm.' Her voice trailed off as she started purring deeply, moving her head in time with my fingers. Her tail flicked around behind her happily.

I stopped moving my hands and smiled down at her, 'where do I what?'

Catra looked up at me, her eyes wanting for more. 'No, don't...' she began, before looking down again, 'don't stop...'

As she wished, I continued gently scritching behind her ears. It wasn't long before that purr sounded once again. 'Catra, you're adorable.'

'Shut up... you know I... you know I like this.'

'So what were you saying?' I asked, trying to hide how smug I felt at getting her to purr so easily. Book would be proud.

'Mmm... Where do you think they'll send us this time?'

'Oh, no idea. We've done our rounds of Elberon and Thaymor already, last week we did Plumeria... maybe it'll be Alwyn or Erelandia.'

'Maybe it will...' I felt a warmth against my back and gasped as Catra's hands slid underneath my vest top. She hooked her thumbs into the fabric and started pushing it up, exposing my stomach and planting kiss after kiss all over it.

'Catra...'

'What? I'm not doing anything...'

'You know exactly what you're doing.'

I felt her grin against my skin. 'Oh, you're right. I guess I do.' Her hands suddenly shot upwards, pulling my top over my head before sliding it down my arms. I shivered at the sudden exposure and flushed when I saw how blown out Catra's pupils were.

'Catra!' I laughed as she tossed the vest top across the room but was silenced as she rose from her seated position and planted her lips against mine.

Catra pulled away, looking deep into my eyes and trailing her hands down my body. 'Do you think we have time to...'

A heat sprang through me, followed by shivers as I felt her claws against my skin. 'Absolutely not...' I breathed, closing my eyes and relishing in the feeling of her hands exploring me.

'Should I stop?' She asked. I could hear the smugness radiating from her.

'Absolutely not.' I repeated sternly.

Catra began nudging me back towards the bed, smiling as she watched Melog vanish from behind us. 'As you wish, princess.'

I yelped as she pushed me backwards, bouncing on the softness of the mattress. Catra then climbed on top of me, planting one of her legs between mine and pinning my wrists above my head with her hands. 'Catra...'

She leant down, her lips brushing lightly against mine, sending shivers through me and making my whole body tremble with anticipation. 'Tell me you want me, Adora,' she whispered.

'I-I want...' I rasped, barely able to think straight.

She leant down, brushing her mouth against my neck before tracing the line of my collarbone with her fangs. 'Tell me what you want.' Catra moved back up, resting her lips just above mine.

I met her gaze and let myself get lost in those amazing eyes, almost black with her arousal. 'I want... I want you.'

I leant upwards and she kissed me gently, carefully. But that's not what I wanted, not after she got me so worked up. I pushed my lips harder against hers and she groaned softly, deep in her throat, before nipping my bottom lip, making me gasp, and using the opening to deepen the kiss. She gave in to my desires as our breathing became wilder, the kiss becoming more passionate. Her grip on my wrists tightened and she lowered herself against my thigh...

A loud knock on the door thundered through the room. Catra sat up immediately, her tail fritzed and her fur stood on end as she bored a hole through the door with a deadly stare.

'Guys! You're late for the meeting! Are you up?' It was Bow's voice.

Catra's expression relaxed and she grinned mischievously. She planted her hands on my breasts, hiding them, before shouting, 'what did you say? I can't hear you, come in!'

'Catra! No, Bow, don't - *ahh!'* My eyes shut tight and I accidentally let out a moan as I felt Catra's tongue on me, licking a line up from my navel to my sternum.

'I said you're late for the - OH! NOT AGAIN!' Bow shouted, slamming the door behind him as he sped back out of the room. 'Sorry!' He called, his footsteps quickly growing quieter as he ran from the door back towards the meeting room.

Catra howled with laughter as I pushed her off of me. She rolled to the side, curling up on the bed and clutching at her stomach.

'Catra! You're going to give Bow a heart attack if you keep messing with him!'

'He should know better than come in here when it's just me and you, Adora.' She grinned, leaning up on her elbow as she watched me walk over to the wardrobe.

'Bow's too trusting to doubt you when you say "come in", Catra.' I pulled out my usual clothes before tying my hair up in a ponytail and securing my hair poof.

I heard Catra groan behind me. 'Again with the hair? Leave it down!'

'No, Catra. If something happens, I don't want my hair in my face.'

She growled, laying back onto the bed. 'Fine, but I'm taking it out as soon as we're back.'

'You can *try.'* I shot her a playful glance and she fired a smirk back at me. *Challenge accepted.* 'Now come on, get dressed, you can help explain to everyone why we're late - if Bow's face doesn't tell them first...'

**

The meeting room fell silent as we entered. I immediately spotted Bow shifting uncomfortably in his seat next to Glimmer as she stared daggers at us. Netossa just smirked and Spinnerella avoided making direct eye-contact. *They all know.*

Micah cleared his throat, rising from his chair as Catra and I took our seats at the table. Melog sat next to Catra's chair as she put her feet up, resting their head on the arm of it as she stroked their head absently. 'Welcome, Adora and Catra,' he began, 'as you know, we are still no closer to finding whoever, or whatever, attacked Elberon over a month ago. To that end, we will be giving out your patrol areas for this week in this meeting. It is vital that we continue to patrol until the threat is found, we can only

assume that for the past month the patrols have been working as a deterrent but there's no telling when another attack may occur. Glimmer, if you would.'

Micah returned to his seat as Glimmer stood up. I could feel her gaze on me, but I didn't meet her eye. I would definitely be getting a lecture after this...

'Thanks, Dad. Netossa and Spinnerella, we're assigning you to the area within and around Alwyn. Adora and *Horde Scum*, we're assigning you to Erelandia.' I felt myself relax a little when I heard Glimmer call Catra by her nickname - she couldn't be *that* mad after all. 'Swift Wind will be going with you to Erelandia as there's a lot of ground to cover. Bow would like to request Melog goes with him to Thaymor.'

Catra looked down at Melog, petting their head. 'You hear that bud? Arrow Boy wants to borrow you again.' Melog mewled before vanishing, reappearing a moment later beside Bow's chair. Bow reached a hand out and scratched behind their ear, nodding his thanks to Catra before quickly averting his eyes. Catra grinned.

Glimmer clapped her hands together. 'Okay! I think that covers everything. Catra, Swift Wind is waiting outside the throne room if you would meet him there.'

She stood up, glancing at me, 'Wait, what? What about Adora?'

Glimmer teleported next to me, placing a hand on my shoulder. 'Don't worry, Horde Scum, I'll bring her back once I'm done with her.'

I gulped and smiled nervously up at Catra, who just shrugged and waved over her shoulder as she started walking towards the door. 'I'll see you there, princess.'

Standing up, I met Glimmer's eyes - she seemed to be waiting, asking permission. I nodded, letting her know I was ready. She then teleported us in a shower of sparkles and I found that a cool wind was suddenly blowing against me. Looking up, I saw that we

were standing below the Moonstone, in the flower-shaped tower that housed it. Glimmer let go of my shoulder, walking over to look down from the tower and out over Bright Moon.

'Glimmer...' I began but stopped as she held up a hand.

She sighed, slouching where she stood. 'I don't know what else to do, Adora. We've been sending out patrols for a whole month and haven't found anything. They must have caught on to what we're doing, stopping their attacks while we wear ourselves out. Do they know we're spread thin with all the princesses in their own kingdoms? We can't keep patrolling forever, but I worry that if we stop...'

'They'll attack again.' I finished. Glimmer nodded. 'Look, Glimmer... Catra and I are committed to finding whatever or whoever was behind those attacks. We have to wait for Hordak to find the signal again, but if the patrols are keeping whatever it is at bay...'

Glimmer turned to face me. 'Do you think we need to stop the patrols? Bait them out so Hordak can find them?'

I shrugged. 'It's a possibility. At the very least, maybe we should try being more secretive with what we're doing. Something was watching Catra and I the day Melog went missing, the same thing that had a First Ones crystal embedded in it. The same kind of crystal that was embedded in Ol'Pointy in Octopus Cove. Before, those crystals usually just affected First Ones tech, but now they're corrupting actual living things. And that's not even considering that the Forge in Underdryl was breached by a virus of some kind. All of these things have *that* green glow connecting them. There's something else going out there, Glimmer. Something we're missing.'

'And there's no way it's Horde Prime? You and I both know he's the only one that's been capable of hacking into First Ones temples. It stands to reason that he could somehow manipulate other kinds of First Ones tech too?' This had been a recurring

topic in a lot of our meetings, often the topic that hours of brainstorming ended up skating around.

'We've been over this Glimmer...' I started pacing back and forth, trying once again to fight the fear within me that Horde Prime was somehow still alive, 'I erased his mind from Hordak. He's gone. I felt it. It *has* to be something else.'

'What if it isn't, Adora?' Glimmer crossed her arms, watching me with a steady eye. 'What if he survived?'

'Then... then... then we'll defeat him again.' I looked up, meeting her gaze. I could feel my hands shaking at the thought of him returning. I closed my eyes, focusing. It had been so long since I felt this feeling rising within me... I recited those words in my head over and over again, trying to calm myself down...

I am afraid. I feel my fear. But I accept it, as a part of me. I will allow it to pass through me, I will not resist. When the fear has passed, there will be nothing. Only I will remain.

I felt Glimmer's hands on my shoulders, squeezing. 'Adora? Look, I know how this affects you. I'm sorry for pressing you about it, that was wrong of me, but... I have to think of the bigger picture.'

Once my hands stopped shaking, I took a deep breath and met Glimmer's concerned gaze. 'It's okay, Glimmer. I know you didn't mean to freak me out. You're just concerned as Queen, as you're right to be.'

Glimmer glanced over toward the throne room and I followed her line of sight. Catra was stood there talking with Swift Wind, waiting for me. 'Looks like your girlfriend is waiting. Maybe take it easy, Adora. Use this patrol as an excuse to breathe. Here...' she said, handing me two earpieces, 'these are for keeping in contact with the other patrols. Hordak also has the frequency so he'll contact you if anything happens. And, Adora...'

I looked up at her, stealing my eyes away from Catra.

'Maybe lock your door? I fear for Bow's sanity. There's a reason I don't teleport into your room anymore. I will *not* be making that mistake again.' She chuckled softly.

'Thanks, Glimmer.' I said, laughing along with her. 'In my defence, Catra was unusually forward this morning... I couldn't say no...' I could have absolutely said no, but I would never. She didn't need to know that.

Glimmer seemed undeterred. 'If only Bow were so bold, he's just a little bit *too* concerned about me sometimes... And I know this whole thing has gotten in the way of your proposal plans, if you had any, but there may be something coming up that could provide a perfect opportunity. I'm going to meet with a certain other princess today, after all. So try not to worry about it for now, leave it to me.'

I frowned, wondering which princess Glimmer would be meeting with that could provide me with a perfect opportunity to propose. That thought was interrupted by the sight of Catra and Swift Wind suddenly ahead of me. Glimmer had teleported us down to them, apparently content that our conversation had reached its end.

'Okay, Horde Scum,' Glimmer said, addressing Catra, 'she's all yours.' Glimmer then promptly teleported away after shooting me a quick, knowing smile.

Catra walked over and placed a hand on my shoulder, squeezing gently. 'Adora? Are you okay? I can smell when you're afraid, you know. Plus your horse could sense something was wrong.'

'Yeah. I'm good, I just had a wobble. You ready, Swifty?' I asked, looking up at him.

Swift Wind was visibly concerned, but his expression softened as I addressed him directly. 'Absolutely, Adora! Ready when you are! Just one question... where is it we're going again?'

I looked into Catra's eyes, smiling reassuringly while hoping she wasn't worrying *too* much. Her expression seemed impassive, as if

she was still deciding whether or not she would need to interrogate Glimmer later on. Looking back to Swift Wind, I took a deep breath before answering his question.

'We're going to Erelandia.'

Signal

Chapter Summary

> A fun day out in Erelandia where absolutely nothing goes wrong.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

'Are you sure you're okay, Adora?'

Catra kept pressing me about how she could smell the panic attack on me, but the whole way out I insisted it wasn't that bad and I was able to control it pretty quickly. We had landed not long ago and were doing a perimeter check in the woods around Erelandia. Catra and I walked together, hand-in-hand, while Swift Wind was scouting over the area from above. Usually he wouldn't do it by himself, but I guess he felt that Catra wanted to have a more private talk with me and left us to it.

'Catra, really, I'm fine.'

I knew that what terrified me most wasn't Horde Prime himself, it was what he could do to the people I care about. And, if this really was the work of Horde Prime, he was being very quiet about it. Especially compared to his previous invasion where he was almost constantly projecting himself across the planet. I looked up at the Horde Spire that pierced the skyline behind Erelandia, wishing it to somehow vanish. It had become clear early on that those Spires would have to be disabled one by one, manually. It hadn't been done yet. Glimmer wouldn't spare the resources from rebuilding to shut down Spires without a purpose just yet.

Catra adjusted the circlet on her head before regarding me with a quizzical stare. 'Neither of us are "fine", Adora. We've been through a lot; we carry it with us.'

I squeezed her hand, tightening my fingers between hers. 'I know. We've both been making great progress, too. But... sometimes I just, I don't know, *feel* him.'

'Adora, I *know* what it's like to have Horde Prime in your head. The *real* one. It's...' Catra reached up behind her neck, rubbing the scar that remained there. I could never begin to imagine the horrors she went through first-hand. Hearing about it, both from Hordak and Catra herself, was bad enough - but actually experiencing it...

'You don't have to say anything more, Catra. Not here.' The canopy above us parted once again, the blue sky shining through to greet us. 'Besides, you've already told me everything.'

'I was trying to make a point. He's not really in your head, Adora. It would be so much worse if he was.' Catra's ears twitched and she stopped, suddenly scanning the undergrowth around us. She visibly relaxed when a small blue animal hopped out into the path ahead of us, before vanishing into the foliage once again.

'You on edge?' I asked, looking down at her hand that was squeezing mine a *bit* too hard.

She let go quickly, looking down at the ground. 'Sorry. It's these woods... should we start heading towards the town?'

'Yeah, okay.' I pushed against her shoulder playfully, 'bet I can beat you there.'

Catra's eyes shone fierce as a confident grin appeared on her face, showing her fangs. 'Oh, you're on, princess.'

**

'You cheated!' Catra wheezed and she stumbled through the gate into Erelandia. 'You can't use She-Ra for a race!'

I looked back and grinned down at her, She-Ra's hip-length ponytail flowing behind me. 'I won. Also, you tripped me, twice, so this is fair.'

'Your legs are like, twice as long as mine are!'

'Wow, Catra, I didn't know you were *such* a sore loser.'

'I am *not!*' She stomped the ground, her tail firing out behind her in a straight line as she continued breathing heavily.

An idea shot into my head - I tried to hold in the resulting grin but failed as I slowly made my way back over to Catra. 'Hey, Catra...'

She blinked, looking up at me suspiciously. 'What? What are you doing?'

'You seem tired, come here...' I reached out, catching her before she could back away.

'Adora- what are you- no! NO! Put. Me. Down! ADORA!'

I rose to my full height, one arm under Catra's back and the other under her legs as I picked her up and held her close. Catra buried her flushed face against me, wrapping her arms around my neck.

'This isn't fair,' she mumbled.

I beamed as she started purring, planting a quick kiss in her hair. 'Let's go look around,' I whispered down to her.

'Whatever.'



Ever since liberating Erelandia from the clutches of Horde Prime, it had become something of a beacon of hope, a safe haven for a lot of folk that had been hiding out in the Whispering Woods. Now, the town was abuzz with life, no one locked their doors or

shied away as I proudly carried Catra through the streets in my arms. Many of the townsfolk gave us funny looks as they greeted us, thanking us for saving them and all of Etheria. Catra didn't look at any of them, thoroughly hiding her face in my neck. I could feel her ears swivelling as we passed through the crowds, picking up hushed conversations from small groups that had formed around us. A group of female Mushroomfolk stood beside a stall giggled as we passed by, quickly averting their gaze when I looked at them.

'What are they saying?' I whispered in Catra's ear, being careful not to startle her. I knew she had great hearing, so the topic of all these hushed conversations would be no secret to her.

Catra growled against me, apparently apprehensive about answering. 'They're talking about us. About the rumours of us kissing in that stupid market. Some of them are giggling about how... how we would...'

I kissed into her hair reassuringly. 'You don't have to say if you don't want to.'

Catra's grip around my shoulders tightened as I felt her exhale, her breath warm against my collarbone. 'How we'd... make good wives. Some of them are also saying how *they* want to be carried by She-Ra.' Catra definitely tried to deflect by adding that last part but I still heard it loud and clear, stopping in my tracks and my heart plunging to my stomach. My mouth felt dry as I swallowed deeply, fighting to control my reaction before Catra would be able to smell it on me.

I desperately wanted to ask. I wanted to know what she thought of that, if she also thinks we would make good wives, but I suddenly found that I'd lost the ability to speak. The heat that had no doubt already spread across my face burned hotter as I felt the rumble of Catra's purr intensify, continuing to hide her face from view. If she's purring so much at the thought of it, does that mean she agrees? Jumping to conclusions based on a purr may be

too big of a leap, she's been purring the whole time I've been carrying her. *But not this loud.*

'Your heartbeat is deafening me, princess. Calm down, it's not like I just asked you to marry me.' Her voice was quiet, but I felt her grip on me tighten as she rubbed her cheek against my neck - I angled my head upward to give her better access, she'd been doing this more and more recently and I'd been meaning to ask what it is but it could wait. After all, she seemed content; like I didn't have to say anything for her to gleam a response from me, instead just using my involuntary physical reactions to interpret how I felt about... marriage.

Hopefully, the answer she got from everything but my voice was something close to *"yes I want that",* or along the lines of nervous, excited, even eager to just get it out of the way and spend my life with her. That seemed like a long shot. More than likely she just felt my arms tense around her, my heartbeat speed up, the breath promptly leave my lungs, and I no doubt reek of nerves. But that's an answer in itself.

'Hey, guys.' Bow's voice broke through our mutual silence and brought me back to the land of the conscious. He sounded quite fed up and no doubt was, what with having to scout on his own with Glimmer preoccupied by a meeting with another princess. A meeting, I recalled, that would somehow present me with an opportunity to propose to Catra.

Catra squirmed in my arms and I took the hint, releasing my grip slightly and letting her jump down to the floor. I raised my hand to my earpiece as I watched Catra skulk away, hugging her arms around herself. 'Hey, Bow. How's Thaymor? Have you seen anything?'

'No, nothing. What about you?'

'All quiet here. We've lost track of Swift Wind but I know he's nearby.' It was starting to get to me, knowing that there's something out there just waiting for a moment to strike, to

destroy, to take lives. I tried to ignore the need to shout in frustration, instead focusing on watching Catra as she weaved between people, she seemed to be wandering without a set goal - just walking around aimlessly and kicking the odd stone about - probably deep in thought.

'Unrelated question but - Melog turned a pink colour not too long ago, that's actually why I called. I wasn't sure what it meant.'

Catra froze and looked up at me, eyes wide. I felt a grin trying to force its way onto my mouth but fought it down when Catra narrowed her eyes and shook her head slowly. 'Uhm - that uh... you can ignore that. You know that Melog's linked to Catra and she was just... happy, I guess.'

There was a brief pause. *'Oh, yeah. Makes sense. Never seen them turn that colour before so just thought I'd check that it's normal. I'm about to finish the perimeter sweep around Thaymor so I'll see you back in Bright Moon.'*

'Okay, Bow. See you there.' I lowered my hand from my ear and watched as Catra narrowly avoided being grappled into a hug by an overexcited Satyr toddler. I was about to make my way over to Catra when I felt a hand tapping my arm. Looking down, I noticed a rather short Mushroomfolk man giving me the stink eye as he craned his neck up at me, something I had become used to when towering over everyone as She-Ra. 'Uh, can I help you?' The question came out at a much higher pitch than I had intended, but something about the fire behind this guy's eyes made me shrink into myself, if even a little. Sure, defeat an entire Galactic Horde but get spooked under the gaze of a random citizen.

He huffed before pointing behind him, over to one of the stalls set up around the street. 'Is that your bird-horse?' His tone was unmistakably annoyed and his voice much deeper than I had been expecting. Sure enough, there was Swift Wind, apparently done with his sweep of the area from above and chasing apples across the ground from a spilled over sack. He kept getting close to one in particular before accidentally kicking it and giving chase once

again. The sigh that escaped me was deep and perhaps went on for a little too long. When I met the Mushroomfolk's eyes again it became clear he was growing steadily more impatient; if he had even been patient to begin with. I smiled sheepishly.

'Yes? I'm so sorry, are those your apples? I promise you can charge any expenses to the palace in Bright Moon, just give my name - Adora or She-Ra - whichever you prefer.' I spoke quickly, trying to ease the stall-owner's worries about losing revenue over some apples that Swift Wind had decided would be perfect for his lunch. Apparently it worked, the irritation slipped from his face as he grunted his satisfaction. It didn't stop him from mumbling about how paying up front was preferred outside of Bright Moon, but much to my dismay at overhearing it I didn't have any money on me to cover the costs right now.

Once the fellow was back at his stall, picking up the sack and trying to save any more apples from falling on the floor, I walked over to where Swift Wind had just finished chasing after another apple he had accidentally kicked away. 'Swift Wind! What are you doing? You can't just eat every apple you see!' I tried to keep my voice hushed to avoid making a scene in the middle of the street, but Swift Wind had other ideas.

Upon hearing my voice, he spun around, spreading his wings wide and almost took out a couple of passing folk who were just going about their business. 'Adora! I was just uh - saving these apples - from the ground, where they are. The uh - the sack, fell over and... I just couldn't leave them there, rolling around the floor, so I decided to help tidy them up. Into my mouth.' I crossed my arms and raised an eyebrow, thriving in how awkward he looked while digging a hole and burying himself alive under the weight of the web of lies he just tried spinning to someone with whom he shared a sacred bond.

'You can't fool me, Swifty. It's literally impossible. I bet you knocked over that sack and pretended like it was accident, didn't you?' I didn't try to hide the accusatory tone in my voice.

'Uh- I- Uh...' Swift Wind stammered over his words for a second, wanting to defend himself but realising that he couldn't. 'Hey, look, Catra wants you!' It was such an obvious feint, but I looked back anyway if only to see where Catra had gotten to on her aimless wandering. The answer: not very far. She was leaning against a stack of crates, looking around and just people-watching as the world passed her by. No one was whispering about her, no one was pointing. She was just there, existing, people around her and yet no one caring that she was there, who she is, or what she's done. It must be a strange feeling, especially compared to our first day out in Bright Moon, when everyone knew who she was and whispered about her behind her back.

A loud crunch dragged me away from that line of thought and my gaze settled on Swift Wind once again. He looked up at me, guilty, with his mouth right next to half an apple. He straightened his neck and continued to munch, regardless of the disbelief I knew would be showing on my face. 'You know what,' he began, 'I'm not even sorry. These are great.'

I laughed, loud and unreserved, feeling totally at peace and content with the world.

That was, until-

'Adora.' Another voice sounded in the earpiece, much lower and harsher than any other voice I would have expected to hear. I immediately felt a lump in my throat as the implications of hearing that voice flooded me with an uneasy dread. *'Adora, are you receiving me?'*

'Hordak.' I confirmed, forcing the lump in my throat back down while trying to keep my voice steady. Catra looked over at me, her expression quickly flicking between disbelief, shock, and dread.

'I have detected the signal.' He began, getting straight to the point. *'I am unable to determine its source as it is too heavily encrypted, but I can determine the location of the receiver. It is within one of the Galactic Horde's ships.'*

'Within? Not the ship itself?'

'Indeed.' He growled on the other end of the comm. *'I have a grave suspicion as to the nature of what is happening. The ship has just gone off the radar, but I am tracking multiple smaller objects in its place and-'* Hordak was cut off the sound of a rapid beeping that seemed to get louder, or closer, as if he was walking towards its source. The alarm stopped and was followed by a few seconds of silence. *'What is your current position?'*

'Er- Erelandia.' I struggled to speak past the lump that was pulling itself back up into my throat. I looked around rapidly, surveying my surroundings.

'Good. Call for reinforcements. If you remember your Horde training, this is a code black. You have incoming, Erelandia is soon to be under attack. I shall join you as soon as I can, keep your eyes on the sky.'

My eyes landed on Catra as Hordak cut the connection. She was watching me, waiting for me to act but - I couldn't. I was frozen to the spot. I knew what I needed to do but I found myself unable to move. 'Adora!' Catra shouted my name, trying to bring me back. 'You *know* what a code black means! It's an air raid! We have to get everyone inside!' When I didn't respond, Catra held a fist up into the air, her tech glowed a sudden bright blue and a bolt of red electricity fired into the sky, shattering the peaceful atmosphere of the early afternoon in Erelandia.

Everyone stopped. Everyone looked to the sky and then down to the source of the magic: Catra.

Catra didn't falter, her experience kicked in and she immediately looked around, surveying her surroundings just as I had done, but it was much easier now that everyone was still. Then she addressed those around us. 'Everyone! Do not panic! *Calmly* return home or get inside! DO NOT STAY OUTSIDE!' After a second, when no-one moved and a few hushed murmurs

started to sound within the crowd, Catra growled and fired another bolt into the sky and shouted, *'NOW!'*

That seemed to do the trick. All the folk around us started walking briskly in all directions, dispersing from the street to either go home or get inside shops or taverns that would let them inside. If this was a different town, one not already used to hiding from threats, it may have gone differently, there may have been a panic, but these people, dreadfully, already knew the drill. Catra turned to Swift Wind, determination filling her eyes, 'Swift Wind, get the message around the town, tell everyone to go home or get inside - anywhere that's not the street!'

Swift Wind nodded, quickly grasping the severity of the situation. He didn't argue, nor did he crack any jokes or make a silly remark - he spread his wings wide and set off, spreading the message for Catra. 'Go home! Everyone get inside! Stay off the street!' His voice growing quieter as he flew away, close to the ground.

I watched as Catra turned to me, her brows furrowed. I had been able to watch what she was doing, I heard what she was saying, but my body wouldn't move. Catra stomped toward me, her face set with a grim resolve. 'Adora! I need you with me, I can't do this without you! Snap out of it!' She reached up, grabbing me by the shoulders and yanking down. My knees buckled and I fell, my legs bending under me until I was sitting on them. Catra looked directly into my eyes now that our faces were on the same level, then she frowned before raising one hand and slapping me across the face.

'OW!' I reached a hand up to my face and held my cheek, trying to rub away the stinging sensation there, it didn’t last long. Catra's hands then held my face tightly and turned my head back to face her, but before I could complain about the slap I felt her lips on mine, kissing me forcefully. Before I chance to register it to kiss her back, Catra pulled back and stared into my eyes, her pupils flicking back and forth between them quickly.

'Adora? Are you back? I need you.' She sounded softer now, less frantic, less on edge, as if the kiss had calmed her down somewhat too. I nodded.

'Yeah. Yeah, I'm here. Sorry, I don't know what-'

'It's okay, Adora. Call your friends, we're going to need them here.' Catra stepped back, looking up at the sky and scanning it quickly. 'I'm going to get higher up, get a better vantage point. I'll contact you if I see anything.' If I didn't know better, I would have expected her to saddle up to the nearest building and claw her way up the side. But, after going out on patrols with her for this past month, I did know better. Catra had been experimenting with her magic, trying new things, and she had a new favourite trick. It was one I had expected her to use during our race into Erelandia when we first arrived, but apparently she was confident enough in just trying to trip me up.

Catra started running away from me, holding her arm out in front of her. I watched as her glove shone blue and an elongated energy shield appeared in the air before her. Catra had figured out that, because the energy of the shield repels by storing potential energy, if she were to aim it toward the ground…

She leapt up, propelling herself high into the air, moving her hand down as she did. The shield followed, until it was directly under her. Catra's feet landed on the back of the shield and her weight pushed it back down towards the ground, but before it made contact Catra released the pulse - firing herself back up into the air, upwards to the rooftops of Erelandia. I watched as she then effortlessly surfed over them, propelled by the near-constant build-up and release of potential energy. The tiles on the rooftops shifted below the pressure of the shield as Catra glided towards one of the watchtowers standing on the perimeter wall of Erelandia.

After rising up from the floor, I too looked to the sky. Learning the codes had been part of our training in the Horde, and code black was to be used in the specific eventuality of a Rebellion air raid. It

made sense for Hordak to use that term to quickly communicate what was happening; an air raid, just not conducted by the Rebellion. The reports suddenly made sense, why nothing was taken from the attacks, why no tracks or signs of ambush were found. There was never any evidence because the attacks came from above but - the question remained: what exactly was carrying out the attacks? What was on the receiving end of that signal? What, exactly, was going on?

That line of thinking, all those questions could wait. In that moment all that mattered was preparing for the coming attack. Thanks to Hordak's warning and Erelandia's residents' prior experience of making themselves scarce, the streets were much emptier now than they had been a few minutes before. Only a few folk remained, but they weren't hanging around, rushing off to wherever it was they thought they could find safety in the presence of this unknown emergency. I lifted my hand to the earpiece and accessed the open channel.

'Bow! Spinnerella, Netossa! Do you read me?'

'Adora? What's happening?' Bow's voice came through first, an edge of worry tinged the seriousness of his tone.

'This is Netossa, Spinny's here with me. Reading you loud and clear, Adora.'

'You need to come to Erelandia as soon as you can. There's... it's... Hordak contacted me.' The mention of Hordak alone prompted a silence in return from the others. All three of them knew what that meant, it's exactly what we were waiting for ever since we started the patrols.

'We're on our way, we'll be there soon.' Spinnerella's voice came through this time, urgency apparent in her words.

Bow sounded out of breath when he activated his earpiece again. *'Already on my way, Melog is giving me a ride - it's really hard to hold on!'*

'Just grab onto the glowy blue bit.' Catra's voice sounded on the channel now, offering Bow advice on how best to cling to Melog for dear life. *'Adora, I'm in position.'*

'Do you see anything?' I looked back to the sky, trying to spot anything out of place against the otherwise perfect day.

'Not yet - wait.'

'What is it?'

'I can hear-'

'Multiple blips have entered Etheria's upper atmosphere and are heading your way at top speed! You should be able to see them any moment now! Ohhh, this is so exciting!' Entrapta's excited voice barged into the communications channel, *'Hordak and I are preparing to leave, we should be there soon - just as soon as I've rebuilt one of Darla's engines!'*

I didn't quite have time to process whatever Entrapta said about Darla's engines before I heard Swift Wind rounding a bend behind me, rearing on his hind legs and neighing loudly before dropping down and looking around. 'I- I think that's everyone, those who aren't already inside should be soon. Are you going to tell me what's going on? I know Catra said something about an air raid, but I don't have a voice thing in my ear to explain.' I rushed forwards, jumping onto his back and settling myself there comfortably, quickly patting along his neck.

'Get us in the air! Hordak said something's going to attack Erelandia, whatever it is, we have to stop it!' I braced myself as Swift Wind startled galloping forwards until his spread wings caught the wind and we eased off the ground. Once we were safely above the rooftops, I braced, and Swift Wind beat his wings harder and faster, firing us up into the sky. After a moment Swift Wind giggled excitedly.

'Oooo! Are we going to get to use our sacred bond! I love when we use the sacred bond!'

'Adora! Can't you hear that?' Catra's voice pierced through the wind buffeting against my ears as Swift Wind levelled out far above Erelandia.

'Hear what?' I replied, 'All I can hear up here, besides the actual wind, is Swift Wind going on about our sacred bond.'

'There's a... screeching-shrieking sound, it's awful! Wait, Adora look out!'

I didn't have chance to look around before a titanium coloured, vaguely arrowhead-shaped blur, plummeted through the sky next to us.

'Woah!' Swift Wind yelled as he righted us in the air, angling his wings so as to stop us from following whatever it was and nosediving to the ground. 'What was that!?'

I looked up in time to see another one-two-four-seven of the blurs diving towards us. 'Dodge!' Swift Wind looked up in time to see what was happening before pulling his wings in and actually nosediving us alongside the arrowheads. They still passed by us, propelled by some kind of thruster that Entrapta probably knows the name of. Now that I could see them up close, they looked like the Horde ships I had fought in space while we were escaping from Horde Prime's flagship with Catra, but much smaller - far too small for one of Prime's bots to sit inside.

'Adora! What's going on? My ears- It hurts!' Catra shouted through the earpiece, I could hear the pain in her voice and I quickly realised the tears in my eyes had nothing to do with the wind.

'Catra! Swifty, stop diving!' I hugged onto Swift Wind's neck as he spread his wings wide, halting us in the air almost immediately before we started flying forwards slowly. Now that the wind wasn't rushing against my face I reached up to my ear, tapping the earpiece. 'Catra! What's going on!? Are you okay?' Peering over

Swift Wind, I watched as the arrowhead ships dived towards Erelandia.

A large circle of blue energy appeared above the town just before a series of explosions shook the ground below us. I watched as six of the arrowhead ships pulled up, avoiding a collision with the barrier, but the seventh crashed into it and crumpled into a ball of flame before exploding, fire and metal spreading across the surface of it before a pulse fired out, flinging the debris outside the circumference of the town. A moment later it fizzled out and a small voice sounded in my ear.

'Adora... I need...'

'Catra, where are you? I'll come find you!'

'No! I need to shield the town; you need to stop those - whatever they are!'

'Catra....'

'I can do this, Adora. I'll be okay. I promise.'

'Okay.' I tried burying the urge to just leap from Swift Wind there and then, to find her and hold her and protect her. But she said she could handle it, so I placed my trust in her once again. Trusting that not only will she protect the town but look after herself as well. 'I love you.'

'... I love you too.'

After a moment, an enormous dome of blue energy slowly formed around the town, encasing it within an unbreakable barrier made, unmistakably, of Catra's magic. It had been a long time since we were in Dryl, but Entrapta's warning to Catra had never left me: *"overusing it will cause you to lose consciousness... or worse... and you won't be able to heal yourself."*

'Swift Wind...' I said, summoning the sword in front of me.

'Is it time? Sacred bond time!?'

'Yes, it is.' I let the light of She-Ra take hold, felt her power flow through me and the sacred bond form. 'Let's get these things. For Erelandia - for Catra!'

Chapter End Notes

The illustration in this chapter is by the wonderful @ooka.art on instagram and @OokaArt on twitter!

Rendezvous

Chapter Summary

> This chapter features a head canon of mine with regards to the clones after they get their independence. I think it's great and I think it works, but of course I do, it's my story. It may seem like a small, minor thing, but to the clones it's a bit more meaningful and this will be a bit more apparent next chapter. If you have any opinions I'd love to hear them.

Chapter Notes

> Also, soft Catra is great.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Swift Wind as I moved as one, our thoughts connected, as the sacred bond took hold and our understanding of one another rose to new heights. No words were spoken as Swift Wind dived down in pursuit of one of the arrowheads. They were fast - incredibly fast - but Swift Wind was able to get close enough for me to send an arc of magical energy soaring through the sky towards the one we were chasing. The magic connected, tearing the ship in two before it exploded and rained debris down onto the blue energy shield.

Another series of explosions erupted on the surface of the barrier below as the remaining five attackers attempted to rain fire on the town, but Catra's shield held strong. I was vaguely aware of how much magic a shield of that size would take to maintain, especially when defending against bombs and bolts of energy relentlessly being thrown at it, and my worry for Catra was steadily growing the longer it went on. This vague awareness crept into the front of my mind - Swift Wind must have sensed it too. He suddenly angled down, beginning pursuit of another of the attacking ships.

Taking full advantage of our sacred bond, Swift Wind and I made quick work of the next four ships. The first tried to ram into us, but Swift Wind rose higher before folding in his wings and spinning around fully just as it passed by underneath us - while upside down I held my sword aloft and sliced the ship in two. Once righted, Swift Wind spread his wings wide again and I watched as both halves of the ship fell into the woods below.

I was able to lasso the next ship after transforming the sword and held on tight as Swift Wind slowed us down, forcing the ship to lose its forward momentum. Before it could divert more power to its thrusters Swift Wind rose higher into the air - the ship dragging behind - before folding in his wings and nosediving down towards it. He bucked the ship with his hind legs once it was level with us, sending it shooting off in a wide arc that I was able to steer with the lasso before hurtling it down towards the ground just outside of Erelandia, exploding on impact.

The next two went down almost too easily, one being caught in a blast of magic from Swift Wind's wings and the next I was able to shoot down with a beam of magic from She-Ra's sword. Finally, one remained. I could see it flying straight at the town, almost as if it intended to crash head-on into Catra's barrier but - it didn't - the barrier fell and the ship entered the town, firing bolts of energy into the buildings as it flew down the main street. I didn't have time to think, immediately throwing myself off the side of Swift Wind and free-falling down towards the town square. I had a sudden pang of *"I hope I haven't mis-timed this"* shoot through me but I ignored it, focusing instead on destroying the ship. The sword became a spear in my hand and I gripped it with both hands, my knuckles turning white under the pressure before swinging my legs under me and landing on top of the ship, running it through and causing a shower of sparks to erupt from within it.

Crashing was something I had not anticipated, for some reason, but I found myself clinging to the spear lodged in the arrowhead as it hit the flagstones, tearing up the main road into Erelandia. My impact onto the ship had forced it down, but a combination of

its momentum and dying engines caused it to continue carving a deep trench into the street until it ground to a halt just before the archway to the square.

Once I opened my eyes, the dust had settled. I dismissed the sword/spear and felt the sacred bond ebb away along with She-Ra. My legs felt weak as I hobbled off the wreckage of the arrowhead ship, and I fell to my knees, breathing heavy. It had been a while since properly becoming and fighting as She-Ra, which apparently means it really takes it out of me to suddenly use a ton of magic as well as form the sacred bond.

Catra.

It was like a jolt. Her name appeared in my head and it suddenly occurred to me why I was on my knees under the archway leading into Erelandia's main square.

The barrier had fallen.

Catra.

I had to find her, to make sure she's okay. I hauled myself to my feet and looked around, taking in the sight of the town around me. The first attack didn't affect the middle of town due to Catra's initial defence, but some areas around the edge of town had been struck, small trails of black smoke reaching into the sky around the perimeter of the settlement. A few scared faces poked out from behind closed shutters and doors, daring to look outside after silence had fallen.

Once my legs felt steady enough to walk, I made my way into the square. The barrier had been central to the town, so if Catra would be anywhere it must be... here. My body sudden felt heavy, weighed down a sudden wave of dread as my heart dropped to my stomach. I froze in place, fear gripping my throat and catching my breath in its icy embrace.

Catra was lying on the ground, sprawled uncomfortably on her side, facing away from me, not moving. I felt tears sting my eyes

and my hands began to shake just from the sight. Forcing down the dread, the panic, I clenched my fists and broke into a sprint despite how weak my legs felt. I dropped to my knees at Catra's side and picked her up, cradling her in my arms. A wave of relief washed over me once I realised she was breathing, but the tears began to fall regardless. With one arm securely supporting her back, I used my other hand to keep her head raised, threading my fingers through her hair, stroking the tuft of fur at the back of her jaw with my thumb. I removed her circlet, carefully placing it on the ground beside us. Then, slowly, I brought her head up to gently bump our foreheads together, something we've been doing ever since we were kids - a show of comfort, safety, love.

'I'm so sorry. If I had taken care of them faster, you wouldn't have been forced to go too far... to use too much...' The words came out as an unsteady whisper but sounded loud against the silence of the town. I could feel my hands start to shake again, the familiar tug of fear beginning to pull at my mind, my breath steadily becoming more erratic as I held on to Catra. I could hear *his* voice, too quiet to make out but it was there, trying to break through, trying to break me, trying to-

I felt a hand on my face, the thumb gently caressing my cheek, and suddenly the fear didn't matter anymore. I opened my eyes to see Catra looking up at me, just barely keeping her eyes open, a weak smile on her lips. '...Hey, it's okay... I'm okay. It's not your fault...'

'Catra... I'm-'

'No, Adora... stop being sorry... it's not your fault... I know... I went too far.' She breathed deep between the words, as if saying each one used up all the air in her lungs. Then her focus shifted, she looked past me, up at the sky. 'Did you...?'

I nodded quickly, 'yeah. I got them all. You did so well, Catra. You defended Erelandia, I'm so proud of you. You did good. The damage would have been so much worse if you hadn't-'

'Adora.' Catra interrupted, looking back into my eyes with a stern eye, or as good as one as she could pull off in her current state. 'Shhh. You're rambling. Just... just kiss me.' As if providing evidence of her strength slowly returning, she reached both of her arms up and locked them around my neck, pulling herself up to push her lips against mine. I kissed her back gratefully, letting the warmth spread through me and focusing on nothing except her, drowning out the little voice at the back of my head.

Catra broke from the kiss as her ears started twitching and she looked to the sky almost frantically, but visibly calmed down once a low rumble filled the air. I heard it too, recognising it immediately: Darla.

'Adora,' Hordak's voice came through in the earpiece, *'we have arrived.'* I looked up as Darla flew overhead, heading towards Erelandia's front gate. *'Our landing zone is just outside the town, what is your position?'*

I started to shift my hands from under Catra but she smiled and shook her head, reaching up to press my earpiece herself so I didn't have to let go of her. 'We're in the main square. Catra needs to rest, she used too much magic.'

'Oooh, she did!? Don't move her, just in case.' Entrapta's voice sounded on the comm now, quite faint, as if she was speaking from across a room. *'I'll need to run some tests to compare results with the last time this happened!'*

Catra dropped her hand from my ear and instead held on to my shoulder, her eyes filled with a fondness I wish I could absorb as she looked up at me. 'Catra...'

'Yeah?' Her voice was barely a whisper but it was still beautiful, everything about her was beautiful.

'Have I ever told you how much I love your eyes?' I didn't know what my face was doing in that moment, but I watched as Catra's face flushed a deep red. She didn't look away, holding my gaze as

her smile grew wider. Then, she closed her eyes before resting her head on my chest and started to purr. 'Catra?'

She didn't answer right away, instead adjusting herself in my arms until she was comfortable. 'You tell me in your own way every time you look at me. I- I love your eyes too. They calm me down, make me feel...' Catra's hand tightened on my shoulder as she pressed her ear against my chest. She then a took a deep breath, as if trying to breathe all of me in at once.

I held her a little closer, watching as her tail happily swayed back and forth just above the ground behind her. 'Are you okay? As nice as this is... you did just collapse from using too much magic.' I hoped the worry in my voice wasn't too prominent, not wanting to completely shatter the moment, but there were more pressing things happening despite how cute she was being.

'I am now... You're warm. You smell nice. Your heartbeat...' Catra's voice was low, sleepy. It reminded me of how her voice sounds just after she wakes up in the mornings or after a nap. It filled my heart and made my chest ache. Soft, cuddly Catra is definitely one of my favourites.

'Adora! I'm here! What happened?' Catra flinched and pressed closer into me as Bow's voice pierced through our momentary bubble of peace.

I looked up and glanced around, spotting him quickly. Bow clung on to Melog's back as they bounded into the square and he jumped off as they got nearer. Melog shrunk in size, bounding over to Catra before nuzzling into her side.

'Hey buddy! I missed you too.' Catra said, lowering one arm from around my neck to pet down Melog's ethereal mane. Melog mewled a response and climbed up to press themselves in-between Catra and I.

Bow looked around, spotting the smoke rising into the sky around the edge of town. He then looked back down at me, awaiting an

explanation. They had entered from the other side of town, so wouldn't have seen the downed arrowhead-shaped ship just beyond the archway.

'Erelandia was attacked.' I began, stating the obvious first. 'I don't know who by, but they used these small ships to do it - that's what's been attacking the supply routes. You'll see one if you go through that arch. Hordak and Entrapta just arrived in Darla, and I think Hordak may know more about what's going on, but he hasn’t explained yet.' Bow's brow furrowed, but he let me continue. 'Netossa and Spinnerella still aren't here, but they should be soon. Bow, you need to take Swift Wind and check on the fires, make sure no one's hurt.' I looked back down at Catra, brushing some hair out of her face and scratching behind her ear, hopefully keeping her calm.

'Okay. But... what happened to Catra? Why are you on the floor?' Bow asked, concern evident in his voice.

Catra nodded, sending me a small smile that I returned softly. 'Catra defended Erelandia from most of the attack, it would have been a lot worse if she hadn't, but she used a lot of magic to do it.' I said, meeting Bow's gaze. He nodded his understanding as Swift Wind landed behind us.

'Did somebody say -!'

'Swift Wind! Go with Bow, make sure the townspeople are okay and put out any fires you find.' Sensing the gravity in my voice, Swift Wind immediately dropped his goofy expression and nodded before bowing down and allowing Bow to climb up onto his back.

'You can count on us, Adora!' Swift Wind proclaimed as he began cantering towards the nearest smoke trail. 'Hey, Bow, do you want to hear about how Adora and I used our sacred bond to defeat-'

'Maybe later, buddy.' Bow interrupted, patting Swift Wind's neck fondly. 'But right now we have to help the townspeople.'

'No, yeah, of course. You're right. Onwards!' They then broke into a gallop, quickly speeding out of sight.

I looked back down at Catra once they were gone, only to find her looking up at me with a tenderness that made my heart squeeze. 'What?' I asked, curiosity peaked.

'You're hot when you order people around.' She said matter-of-factly. My face immediately felt warm as a furious blush exploded across it. After a moment I realised I was staring at her and tore my eyes away to look around as my brain slowly came back to life. Before I had chance to fully recover, I felt her hand on my face, turning me to look back down at her. Then she slowly leant up to whisper in my ear, 'I wouldn't mind following your orders, princess.'

All of my higher cognitive functions immediately ceased.

**

I was suddenly aware that Entrapta was standing over us, scanning Catra with her modified tracker pad. She hadn't been there a moment beforehand... She said something, but I wasn't quite aware enough just yet to catch what it was.

'Give her a minute.' I heard Catra say.

'If what Hordak said is true, we may not have that long. We have to get you into Darla so you can rest - you used up a lot of your magical energy and it will take a while to recharge. I would recommend not using any magic for two or three days.' I raised my head to look up at her, and Entrapta beamed when we made eye-contact. 'Hello. Adora. Please. Allow. Wrong. Hordak. To take. Catra. To the ship.' She spaced out the words as if trying to communicate a difficult concept with simpler terms.

I did a double take once my eyes landed on Wrong Hordak standing just behind Entrapta - he was wearing a pink and blue butler uniform, similar to that worn by Soda Pop. His hair also seemed to be turning a bright magenta at the roots, and his eyes were fragmented between that awful bright green and the same magenta that seemed to be affecting his hair.

'Greetings, brothers! Do not worry! I *will not* drop you!' Wrong Hordak spread his arms wide and winked down at us.

'Still not got the hang of this whole winking thing, have you?' Catra asked, as I strained against my wobbly legs to stand up while holding her. I had been on the floor with her in my lap in the same position for far too long. Wrong Hordak tilted his head and frowned slightly in momentary confusion.

'Don't worry about it, buddy. But *please* don't drop her. I kind of like her.' I said while passing Catra over to him with Melog clinging onto her. Catra looked at me indignantly but I just smirked and angled a brow at her in response.

I could tell Catra had a million different things she wanted to retort, but she gave up and looked up at Wrong Hordak, poking him in the chest. 'Do. Not. Drop. Me.' She said sternly, emphasising each word.

'Of course! You can count on me, brother!' He beamed down at Catra, and I noticed that his usually green smile had also started turning magenta.

'Wrong Hordak! Back to the ship!' Entrapta chimed while stuffing her pad into her hair and picking up Catra's circlet from the ground. I waved to Catra as she draped her head back over Wrong Hordak's arm as he turned away, smiling in response before closing her eyes.

'Entrapta, wait.' I placed a hand on Entrapta's shoulder, causing her to stop and look up at me questioningly. 'What's happening to Wrong Hordak? He's turning - purple?'

Her face suddenly lit up. 'Do you want to hear my theory?' I nodded apprehensively. 'I theorise,' she began, 'that it has something to do with his independence. When the clones were part of the hive mind, they were *"perfect",'* she emphasised the word with finger quotes, 'but now that he's broken off from that and started thinking independently, something in his DNA is responding to it. It's almost as if it was put in as a way to single out the clones who began thinking independently for too long... To summarise: imperfections really are beautiful! It's started happening to Hordak too! Ooh - that reminds me - he wants to talk to you.'

I watched as Entrapta turned away from me, running to catch up with Wrong Hordak as he dutifully, and carefully, carried Catra across the square and through the arch, toward the entrance of the town and to Darla. That was perhaps one of my favourite Entrapta theories so far - clones developing colourful hair and eyes when they think for themselves? That doesn't sound too bad. At least they'll be easier to tell apart.

Hordak was standing over the downed arrowhead ship that I had pummelled into the main road of Erelandia. A few curious townspeople eyed him warily from open windows, probably unsure what to think of the Horde clone standing in their street. He wore a dark purple cloak that covered most of him, leaving only his head exposed with the hood down. I could just barely make out his feet and saw that he seemed to be wearing some kind of armour there, a hint as to how prepared he is for this excursion from Dryl, as well as a hint into just what he's been up to when left to his own devices.

Just as Entrapta said, his hair and eyes were also changing colour, except they were going back to how I recognised him. Dark blue and red coaxing their way back into his hair and eyes respectively.

'Hordak.' I greeted, standing opposite him on the other side of the wrecked machinery. It wasn't much of a greeting, but he wasn't one for pleasantries. 'I'm guessing you know what this thing is.' It wasn't a question, merely a prompt for him to explain.

'Yes, I know what they are,' he began, slowly, looking up and down the titanium exterior plating, 'Swarm drones. Parts of the whole.' He reached a metal gauntleted hand out from within the cloak and dragged a finger along the surface, as if searching for something. 'Horde Prime used them to overwhelm enemy ships or space stations, thousands of them moving in unison like a single, living being. This synchronisation was only possible because they had but one pilot, a single controller, one mind to direct them to their target. If each ship was controlled individually, it would give way to error. The only way Prime could rule out error was to him to control the Swarm-'

'By himself.' I finished, gravely.

'Precisely.' Hordak looked down to his hand where it had stopped before stabbing his index finger through the armour, carving a loose square and ripping it away. He noticed my quizzical expression and decided to elaborate on what he was doing. 'I am searching for the drone's signal receiver. If I can analyse it, I may be able to begin decrypting the signal and home in on its origin. It has... been a while since I've seen one of these Swarm drones. Tell me, how many attacked the town?' He reached inside the drone and began digging around amongst wires and circuitry.

'Seven.'

Hordak stopped what he was doing and looked up at me, a momentary surprise spread across his face before it dropped away to reveal a heavy frown. *'Seven?'* I nodded. 'Where are those reinforcements?'

The implication of his asking that question struck me like a bolt. *There were going to be more.* 'I'll check.' I said, turning away and reaching up to activate the earpiece. 'Spinnerella, Netossa, how far out are you?'

There was a moment of silence before Netossa's voice came through, *'Adora! We had company - these things attacked us from the sky - what's going on?'*

'Erelandia is under attack, the drones are on the receiving end of the signal Hordak's been watching for and... there's going to be more of them, we need you here.'

'Got it, we'll be there soon.'

'Bow, did you get that?'

'I did, Swift Wind and I are making good progress. Damage was minimal and no one is hurt so far. Should we evacuate the town?'

I looked back to Hordak for his response but saw that he already had a finger pressed to an earpiece of his own. 'No.' He said, flatly, before looking up to the sky. 'It's too late for that now. We're out of time.'

Following Hordak's line of sight, I too looked to the sky. What I saw made my heart plummet into my chest.

'Adora? What's he talking about? Adora?'

I was vaguely aware of Bow's voice in my ear, but it seemed inconsequential compared with the sight above us.

A massive ship, blanketed in flame and breaking up as it entered Etheria's atmosphere, plummeted steadily downwards straight toward Erelandia.

A gust of wind signalled the arrival of Spinnerella and Netossa. I watched as they slowly began descending to the ground. Netossa jumped down from her position in Spinerella's arms before they landed, she ran a hand through her hair before turning and kissing her wife on the cheek. 'Thanks for the lift, Spinny.'

'You're welcome, darling.' Spinnerella smiled, gently caressing Netossa's cheek.

Netossa then turned to me, her expression suddenly serious. 'Adora, what's going - *oh.*' Her gaze wandered upward, her voice trailing off once she spotted the burning ship cascading through

the sky, heading straight for us. Spinnerella gasped as her hands rose to cover her mouth.

I nodded solemnly and looked back up at the ship. My mind was blank. I wanted it to think of a way to stop this from happening, to save everyone, but nothing came to mind. The ship falling towards us was huge, at least ten times the size of Darla. If that were to impact the damage would be-

My thoughts were cut off as I felt a hand on my shoulder. Bow was next to me, sat up on Swift Wind, looking up at the ship before meeting my gaze and smiling. 'We can do this, Adora. What's the plan?' His show of confidence in us spurred something within me, something that didn't want to give up, something that wanted to save everyone in Erelandia and everyone on Etheria. Something that wanted to win.

'We land it. Safely.' I replied, finding new resolve buried deep within myself. 'Hordak, what is it and how do we stop it from crashing?' I asked, looking across the remains of the Swarm drone.

Hordak gathered himself, rising to his full height as he looked back up at the ship. Then he cleared his throat and spoke clearly so everyone present could hear him. 'It is a Dreadnought-class Galactic Horde starship, the largest class of ship within Horde Prime's fleet. Each one is capable of untold destruction, and each one carries enough clones and bots to occupy a large moon. If it crashes into Etheria, it won't just wipe out this town, the shockwave will travel around the planet. The fallout could be catastrophic. It may be an extinction-level event.'

'Adora didn't ask about how we could all horribly die.' Netossa interjected, arms crossed and foot tapping on stone. 'We want to know how to stop it, how to save everyone. We're ready, and we aren't about to give up.'

Hordak looked between all five of us, reading our expressions before nodding. 'Very well. You will have to reach the bridge and

manually steer the ship off course. It's unlikely it will be able to land safely, but you may be able to put it down without causing an immense loss of life. But some of you will have to remain down here with me, we're about to have company.' He pointed back up to the ship and we all turned to look.

It looked like a large explosion had just gone off, a black smoke cloud trailing away from the ship and... *moving.*

'That's not smoke, is it?' Bow asked hesitantly.

'No.' Hordak confirmed, gesturing to the drone half-buried in the street. 'It's a Swarm, made up of perhaps a hundred of these. Whatever is transmitting the signal can only activate the Swarm drones, so to get them out it must have been destroying the Dreadnoughts from the inside.'

'Wait,' I said, holding up my hands, 'are you saying that's why the ships have been disappearing? Something is building up an army of drones but had to destroy the ships to get them out?'

'That is indeed my current theory. But we haven't got time to discuss this. Entrapta detected it after we left and has, brilliantly, devised a plan for how to stop it.' A smile tugged at the corner of his mouth when he said the word “brilliantly”.

'I'll go with you.' Spinnerella announced, stepping forward. 'I may be able to slow the ship down from the outside, give it some lift, maybe even cool it down so fires don't spread.'

'Spinny, no!' Netossa grabbed her hands, looking into her eyes with a pleading gaze. 'You could get hurt, let me go!'

'Darling, we both know you're better at defence. Stay here, help Hordak and Bow-'

'And me, Swift Wind!' Interrupted Swift Wind, swishing his mane melodramatically.

'Yes, you too Swift Wind. Stay here and help them defend Erelandia. I'll be fine.' Spinnerella reassured, smiling softly.

Netossa held back tears before pulling her wife in and kissing her on the lips. After they both pulled away, she looked to me, a fire blazing behind her eyes. 'Bring her back safe, Adora.'

'I will, you have my word.' I promised, holding her gaze.

Spinnerella then walked over to me, hooking one arm under my knees and the other around my back before lifting me up the same way she had been holding Netossa when they arrived. Now I knew how Catra felt when I carried her into town earlier. I looked up at Spinnerella and laughed nervously, but she just smiled down at me.

Spinnerella looked back over at Netossa and said, 'I love you, Darling,' as the wind around us started picking up speed.

'I love you too, Spinny. Good luck.' Netossa replied softly.

Then I watched as Hordak, Netossa, Bow and Swift Wind became smaller and smaller as Spinnerella lifted us into the air, flying us over to the front gate of Erelandia and toward where Darla was parked. All we had to do was avoid a cloud of Swarm drones, enter a crashing ship, and land it without destroying all life on Etheria.

I caught myself hoping that Entrapta’s plan would be enough.

Chapter End Notes

If you've read this far, firstly, thank you!
I can confirm there's at least 12 chapters left of the main story. 8.5 of them are half-written or yet to be written, but the plan is there, and the plan is solid.

"But that only takes us to 43 chapters and the chapter count says 50." - Yes, I know. Shh.

Next chapter will be next Saturday ~ see you then!

Dreadnought

Chapter Summary

> Adora, Spinnerella, Entrapta, Catra, Wrong Hordak, and Emily hurtle towards a crashing Horde ship to try and stop it from crashing. Simple, right?

Chapter Notes

> This chapter took FOREVER to write. Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak had apparently let Entrapta know we were coming. As soon as Spinnerella and I landed I realised that the engines were already running. We found Entrapta on the bridge, excitedly staring up at the fireball through the huge flight deck windows. Wrong Hordak stood nearby and his face lit up in a bright smile as we entered, waving almost shyly as we walked in. Emily hovered near Entrapta, and I noticed the tell-tale swishing of a tail coming from the administrator's chair.

'Brothers! Welcome aboard, we are prepared to-'

'Oh, good! You're here! Darla, fly towards that crashing ship!' Entrapta yelled, interrupting Wrong Hordak and laughing maniacally at the prospect of hurtling towards a crashing space warship.

<< Affirmative. >>

I felt a low rumble as Darla steadily lifted off the ground, aimed towards the Dreadnought, and launched upwards into the sky. Spinnerella and I joined Entrapta at the controls, looking up at the ship as we approached. The cloud of Swarm drones had completely separated from it now, hurtling down towards Erelandia. If they were to see us, that many drones would tear Darla apart-

A mewling from behind me caught my attention, and I turned to see a small Melog still lying on Catra's stomach. She was draped over the administrator's chair, fast asleep, her tail absently swaying from side-to-side. I walked over to them and knelt down in front of the chair, gently stroking down Melog's mane. If we were to get past the Swarm, we would need Melog's help.

'Hey, buddy,' I whispered, being careful not to wake Catra, 'do you think you can do your thing and hide us again?'

Melog cooed in response, before licking Catra's face, closing their eyes, and disappearing. After a moment, the ship seemed to glow, wisps appearing on the bridge and dancing around as Melog hid us from sight, cloaking Darla once again as they had done when we snuck past the blockade around Etheria. Catra stirred. She opened one eye and looked up at me, dazed and tired.

'Adora? Why are you here?' Catra asked as she reached out and lightly trailed her fingers down my face. I smiled and leant into her touch, holding my hand up to press her palm against my cheek and hold it there. Something about her warmth seemed to calm me. For the briefest of moments, I felt like it was just the two of us and we weren't flying head-first towards once of the single-greatest dangers we've ever faced.

'Would you believe me if I said I just wanted to see you?' I asked, keeping my voice low.

'That sounds sappy enough to be something you would say.' Catra teased, but her eyes darkened as she looked over my shoulder. 'Although judging by the view, I'm guessing that's not the case.'

'Yeah,' I said, lowering her hand. 'We have to stop that ship from crashing into Etheria. We have a plan. It will all be okay.'

'That's Adora for, "it's super dangerous and I'm going to risk my life to save everyone again," isn't it?' Catra sounded worried, fretful, but there was a hint of something else there too: resolve.

'Let me help you. I know I can be useful; I don't want you to do this by yourself.'

'She won't be by herself!' Entrapta appeared beside us, beaming while holding up a tracker pad. 'I'm scanning the Horde ship now and will transfer the map and data over to Emily.'

'Why can't Wrong Hordak take her?' Catra asked, as if it were the obvious thing in the world. Entrapta looked confused, puzzled at the question. I watched as Wrong Hordak nervously walked over, tapping his fingers together.

'If I may, brothers,' he began, 'I'm afraid a mission like this would be too much for me. So I was most grateful when our sister volunteered her services in my place.'

'That's okay, buddy.' I reassured, smiling up at him, vaguely aware that he just referred to Emily as their sister. He smiled back and, painfully slow, winked.

'If everything goes well,' Entrapta continued, undeterred, 'Emily should be able to plug directly into their systems and steer the ship herself. Adora just has to make sure Emily can make it there and back safely. Emily!' Entrapta scurried over to the waiting bot, plugging in her pad and began the transfer of data. I could see the ship getting closer now, the cloud of Swarm drones about to pass us by. Hopefully.

'And besides,' I added, knowing that wouldn't be enough to convince Catra not to intervene, 'you've already been told to rest for a few days before using your magic again. I don't want you to hurt yourself.'

'Alright, Adora. Fine. I won't help *you.'* Catra huffed, turning to look at the back of the chair.

I sighed and stood up. This was for the best, Catra would only hurt herself more by using magic to help, and she's too tired to do much of anything else. I turned to face the starship and the cloud

of drones ahead of us, before reaching forward and summoning She-Ra's sword out of the air.

<< Warning: Multiple incoming unknown energy signatures detected. >>
<< Collision is inevitable. >>
<< Recommendation: Change course. >>

'For the honour of Grayskull.' I said, making no show out of the transformation, but welcoming the surge of strength and power all the same. As the golden light dimmed, I walked forwards and touched Darla's controls, smiling as they glowed a little brighter under the contact of She-Ra's hand.

<< Administrator detected. >>
<< Hello, She-Ra. >>

'Hey, Darla. Evasive manoeuvres, we're going straight through that cloud of drones.'

<< Affirmative. >>

'Interesting...' Entrapta hovered to my side, watching as I removed my hand from the controls before pulling out her voice recorder. 'She-Ra observation log, entry one thousand and sixty-seven! No matter what changes I make to Darla's core structure, she still only recognises She-Ra as an administrator, despite allowing other living beings, such as myself, to pilot her.'

I was only half-listening to Entrapta leave notes for her future self, however, as the cloud of drones was almost upon us.

<< Warning: Evasive manoeuvres beginning in five... >>

'Oooo... this is so exciting!' Entrapta squealed beside me.

<< Four... >>

'Everyone, brace yourselves, hold on to something!' I called, before moving back toward the chair.

<< Three... >>

I picked up Catra, ignoring her hiss of protest, and placed her in my lap as I sat down, wrapping my arms around her waist. Her tail thudded against my armour and her claws dug into my arm, but I didn't care in that moment, she could be annoyed with me all she liked for wanting to keep her safe - but Catra will always be my first priority, above all else.

<< Two... >>

Spinnerella ran over too, holding on to the chair from behind. Entrapta and Wrong Hordak clung onto Emily as she seemed to magnetise herself to the floor.

<< One... >>

I felt Catra untense and lean back against me, the faintest hint of a purr rumbling in her chest.

<< Entering drone cloud, beginning evasive manoeuvres. >>
<< Recommendation: Hold on. >>

That recommendation really should come sooner.

I watched as the first Swarm drone passed by, then the second, the third, and then ten - suddenly we were surrounded on all sides as Darla spun and weaved around and between them. I clung onto Catra as the ship lurched every which way. Entrapta laughed as Wrong Hordak wailed. Spinnerella was silent behind us, no doubt just concentrating on holding on.

Catra, however, apparently content that I had a secure hold on her, took the opportunity to rub her cheek against my jaw and start kissing along it, as well as squeezing my arms and thighs with her hands while her tail wrapped itself around my leg.

'You really pick your moments.' I whispered, my voice coming out harsher than I thought as I strained against Darla's movements.

Hordak had been wrong in his estimation - there were a lot more than a hundred Swarm drones in this cloud.

'I'm distracting myself.' She replied, whispering in my ear.

'What do you mean?'

'The drones make this awful noise, it's like a high-pitched shrieking sound. I think only I can hear it, but it makes me feel sick, so just - let me distract myself.'

I nodded, 'Okay.' After hearing my approval, Catra buried her face in my neck, nipping and kissing down it while her grip on my arm and thigh tightened. I held in any sounds, very aware that Spinnerella was *right there.* Keeping my eyes focused on the drones outside, I distracted myself from Catra distracting herself all over my neck.

Then, as sudden as it had enveloped us, the cloud of drones vanished, replaced with clear blue skies. Except, of course, for the much closer crashing ship. Feeling me untense my arms, Catra moved away from my neck, looking back out the forward windshield. Melog then reformed in her arms, dropping our invisibility, and reached up to lick at her face. The Dreadnought-class starship was just ahead now, so close I could recognise it as one of the ones that had formed the blockade around Etheria, huge and hulking. I watched as parts of it broke away, hurtling towards the ground.

'Okay!' Entrapta shouted, looking down at her tracker pad. 'The scan of the Horde ship is finished and fully uploaded to Emily's memory. It looks like a combination of forward-facing thrusters are steadily slowing the entry of the ship into Etheria's airspace, but only a quarter of them are fully operational. So, while they will buy us some time, they won't be enough to stop the ship fatally impacting the planet.'

I shook my head, catching absolutely none of that. All I took in was that something was buying us time, which Emily and I would

need as much of as possible. I rose to my feet, placing Catra back down in the chair before joining Spinnerella and Entrapta as they looked out at the ship passing by. The front of it was blanketed in flames, with more fires starting and explosions erupting all over the hull.

'Darla, get us as close as you can to the bridge.' I said, watching as the view of the ship changed as Darla turned around, heading back towards the front of the immense spacecraft.

<< Affirmative. >>

Catra was looking out at the starship, her eyes wide as Darla moved around it. Melog was still laid in her lap, comfortable enough to seem unconcerned with the world. I walked back over to the chair and held her face in my hands, smiling when she looked me in the eye.

'Wait here?' I asked, hopeful, 'I'll be back soon, I promise.' I then closed the distance between us, pressing our lips together and savouring it when I felt her kissing me back.

When we parted for breath, Catra whispered in a flat tone, 'Now go rush off to be a hero, like you always do.'

My face fell, realising all too late that she was annoyed by my insistence that she stay behind, despite how she had just been distracting herself. 'Catra... that's not fair.'

'*You're* not fair, Adora. You better get going, you don't have much time.'

'No, Catra - you don't get to be mad at me for saying you need to stay behind. I care about you too much to let you endanger yourself like that. You know you need to rest; you *were* resting before Melog woke you up. You are *everything* to me, Catra. I don't know what I would do if I lost you.' All my worries came tumbling out of my mouth before I could stop them, but all I wanted was for Catra to understand that she needs to look after herself, that she *matters.*

'Oh, I don't *get* to be mad at you!?' Catra snarled, suddenly seeming more irritated than she had been just a moment beforehand. Melog flashed am angry red but remained curled up in her lap. 'What, is that a privilege reserved just for Glitter and Arrow Boy?'

'What- Catra, no, of course not I- I just want you to be safe!'

'I can look after myself, Adora! Stop babying me!'

'I'm not babying you! I'm trying to stop you from-'

'From what!? Using all my magic!? I didn't ask for this, any of this, but here I am left feeling completely useless because I tried to do something good!'

'What's gotten into you!? You were fine and happy and adorable and now you're- *ugh!'*

'Oh, I don't know, Adora. Maybe I've just woken up to how much of an idiot you're being! I can help! Why won't you let me help!?'

'Catra-' The flight deck was suddenly cast in shadow as we entered the Dreadnought through a jagged scar in the side of its hull, likely where the Swarm drones had blown their way out.

'No, Adora, I don't want to hear it! This is *your fault!* Just leave me alone!'

Those words struck something in me, a deep-rooted fear that I had tried not to think about ever since that first nightmare in Dryl. I stepped back from the chair, hands clutching at my head as Horde Prime's words suddenly rang through my head, loud and clear...

"The magic she has, it was not her choice! It was thrust upon her, and you know it's your fault! If anything happens to her, it will all be because of your *weakness!"*

'No... I didn't mean... I didn't want... Catra, *please-'* I felt my hold on She-Ra faltering as my emotions fluctuated and I shifted in and out of her form. I managed to hold on, just barely, as Entrapta suddenly yelled out, breaking through what had been a rather awkward silence among the rest of the group on Darla's flight deck.

'We're here! We're inside one of the Galactic Horde's starships... *while it's crashing!'* She laughed excitedly while urging Emily forwards. 'Okay, Emily, you know the route! Adora will help you get there and back; all you have to do is-' Her voice was cut off as the doors closed behind her. Wrong Hordak shifted uncomfortably, unsure of what to do given the sour atmosphere created by mine and Catra's sudden argument.

'I shall, um - prepare some tiny food in preparation for your successful return, brother!' Wrong Hordak declared, before quickly slinking out of the other door and making toward the storage area.

I knew Catra could be unreasonable at the best of times, but this felt like it was on another level. We hadn't had a fight like this since she left right before the Heart. It hurt. It felt raw, like she'd been holding down the frustration of being burdened with magic this whole time, as if she hates me for overlooking what kind of effect it would have on her. She was right, it was my fault. I should have stopped it, I should have realised, I should have... My breathing had started becoming unsteady, I could feel my hands shaking and I struggled to stay standing.

"Your Catra hates *you, Adora. It's all been a lie; every word, every whisper, every promise."*

Prime's voice was present in my mind again, I couldn't drown him out. I tried to think the words of our mantra again, to let him pass through me...

I am afraid. I feel my fear. But I accept it, as a part of me. I will allow it to pass through-

"Oh, Adora. It's too late for that. You've let me in again, and I won't be leaving anytime soon."

No... I looked up at Catra, who was curled up in the administrator's chair with her back to me, shaking in that way I recognised all too easily. She was crying, clutching her tail, holding it close for comfort. Melog pressed closed against her, nuzzling into the gap between her thighs and chest while glowing a soft pink colour. I reached out, wanting nothing more than to comfort her like I had a thousand times before - but a pressure on my arm stopped me. I glanced around to see Spinnerella smiling softly, her unexpectedly warm hand on my bicep and her eyes shining with nothing but kindness and understanding.

'Let me talk to her, Adora. You really do need to go. We don't have much time.' She was right, of course. I needed to focus, otherwise all of Etheria would feel the effects of this failure. As much as it pained me to admit, Catra would have to wait. She was my first priority, I love her more than anything, but if I didn't do this...

I thanked Spinnerella while moving towards the door. Before I stepped through, I risked a glance over my shoulder, spotting Catra watching me with tearful eyes before snapping her head away and hiding behind the chair again. Melog stayed watching me however, ever vigilant.

I sighed and stepped through the door, closing my eyes as I heard the door hiss shut behind me.

I'm sorry, Catra. I thought to myself. *You deserve better than me.*

**

I exited Darla into an empty Swarm drone hangar, noting the number of empty racks that the drones had been attached to, before following Emily down one of the many corridors that

converged on the empty chamber. The interior of the Dreadnought-class Galactic Horde starship looked eerily similar to the interior of Prime's flagship. The white walls were dimly illuminated by a combination of that horrible green and an obnoxious purple. The polished metal floors, patterned with swirling designs, reflected the low light back into the corridors, creating an ominous, unsettling aura throughout the ship.

Unlike the hangar, however, the corridors were far from empty. Clones lined the way, the majority on the floor looking confused. Some were rocking in place, muttering to themselves, others lay motionless with burns across their bodies. A good number just sat, watching us as we passed them by with a mild yet ultimately unbothered curiosity. All of these clones had been suddenly abandoned, left to just float in space for months with nothing but their own existential dread to keep them company, if Wrong Hordak's experience was anything to go by. Hordak had mentioned in Dryl that the clones didn't *need* food or even air to survive, but I noticed a good number of empty amniotic fluid vials scattered across the floor anyway.

Emily seemed in her element, rolling and bouncing through the corridors, weaving between clones strewn about the floor or wandering around, eager to fulfil her mission, beeping happily as she went. Keeping up with her was proving to be a good distraction. It kept my mind from dwelling on Catra, our argument, what I was going to say to try and make it up to her afterwards. Hopefully, Spinnerella would be able to calm her down, at least enough so she'll actually look at me again. Emily quickly rounded another corner at the last minute, causing me to skid to a halt before doubling back and following her, once again fully distracted from my thoughts.

Well, most of them.

My mind was playing tricks on me. I kept seeing Horde Prime among the faces of the clones, smirking at me as if watching an animal chase after its own tail. At least his voice had stopped for

now, I don't think I could handle listening to him berate me with obvious lies while trying to save my home.

Eventually, Emily came to a stop in front of a closed green energy door and pawed at it. Or, she would have, if she had paws. She did the equivalent with her metal legs, requesting access to the room beyond.

'Is this it?' I asked, panting, 'Is this the bridge?'

Emily beeped a response. I suppose it sounded positive, but I couldn't really be sure. I looked around, quickly finding what I was looking for: a clone.

'Hey!' I greeted, kneeling down in front of one the clones as he spun around in his spot on the ground. 'Can you open this door for us? Please?'

The clone stopped spinning and stared up at me in wonder. 'No one has spoken to me in such a long time!' He whispered, reaching up and hovering his hands in the air above him. 'Praise be to Prime! He has sent an angel down to us to reassure us that he has not forsaken us!'

"Go ahead, Adora. Tell him I'm actually dead and gone. See how helpful he becomes then." Prime's voice sounded like it was right next to me, speaking directly into my ear, but I resisted the urge to look and kept my gaze focused on the clone sat down before me.

'Sure, whatever, but I need you to open this door for me. Okay?' I tried to put on my best smile, despite the circumstances, despite the war raging in my head. The clone blinked up at me, expression blank for a moment before breaking into a wide grin.

'Of course! Anything for a beacon of Horde Prime's light!' The clone declared, rising to his feet and eagerly approaching the door. He then slid his hand down it, and the green barrier promptly disappeared. 'There you go, brother! May we all bask in the glorious light of Horde Prime!'

'Thanks, buddy.' I shot him a quick smile before following an incredibly eager Emily into the room beyond. It reminded me of where I had first seen Horde Prime, sitting in his chair "maintaining his vessel" with clone attendants hovering around him. Largely empty, the bridge was comprised of only three stations. The middle, main one featured that recognisable wall of screens with a control console below it, in front of a large chair with more controls along its armrests. There were another two, smaller chairs built into the floor either side of the larger one, each with its own control console in front of it. I had no idea where to start, but Emily seemed to know what she was doing. She scurried over to the middle console and climbed onto the chair before looking over at me and wiggling expectantly.

'Me? You need me to do something?' Emily trilled a series of positive beeps before dispensing a wire from within a panel that popped open on the side of her armoured casing. 'Oh, you need me to plug you in?' More beeps. 'Okay.' I made my way over and picked up the end of the wire, uncoiling it and scanning over the controls for somewhere to connect it. That's when I realised it was needle shaped at the end, and with no obvious places to connect it I settled for just jamming it into the controls on the arm of the chair. That seemed to work. I watched as a purple light flowed down the wire into the chair, before spreading through it and enveloping the bridge in the colour of Emily's eye.

The blast shield over the large windshield at the front of the bridge then started rising, basking the room in the glow of bright orange flames. After another moment, the entire ship lurched upwards, beginning to level out. Emily warbled victoriously, but it was cut short as a number of glowing green wires suddenly shot out from behind the chair and plugged into her. The ship began to shake violently, as if struggling between two conflicting commands. I rushed forward and started pulling out the wires from Emily, grunting in frustration when they just reconnected themselves. I began slicing them with my sword, but that just prompted more to emerge and take their place. I gave up, reaching up to the earpiece in my ear.

'Entrapta! Emily's plugged in, but it looks like the ship is fighting back, what do I do?'

'I hypothesised that this could have a chance of happening! It's most likely some kind of an anti-virus that's either trying to expel the intrusion, or just overwrite it completely. Nothing to worry about, Emily's AI is advanced enough to fight it off until she's able to land the ship!'

'But I can't disconnect her! What do I do?' I felt panic coursing through me. Emily means too much to too many people to just leave her here, plugged into who-knows-what as it tries to assimilate her into the ship's systems.

'It's okay! You can come back to the ship; we need to leave as soon as possible!'

'Entrapta... are you sure? Is it okay for me to just leave her?' I could hardly believe what I was hearing. Entrapta wanted me to leave Emily behind? That didn't bother her?

'Affirmative! There's nothing to worry about - I'll explain later!'

I looked down at Emily, only to see that she was looking up at me, that purple light shining bright. I watched as she raised a leg and... saluted? Before chirruping a series of electronic beeps and turning back to look out beyond the flames as the glass of the windshield started to crack. I was going to have to trust that Entrapta knew what she was doing, and that leaving Emily behind would not turn out to be a huge mistake.

'I'm sorry, Emily.' I whispered, trailing my fingers along the claw marks in her armour. *This is okay, right? Entrapta has a plan... right?*

Suddenly, a loud rumble violently shook the bridge and a burst of flame fired through the doorway just as the clone from before scrambled through it, diving to the floor. 'Brother!' He cried, looking up at me as the flames receded. 'The fires have spread to

this part of the ship! Glory be to Prime! We shall join him and bask in his light!'

'Not if I can help it!' I surged forwards, picking up the hapless clone and running back through the corridors of the ship. They were much livelier than before, all the clones that had been sprawled about were animatedly running back and forth, panicking as flames burst forth from the walls as mini explosions spread throughout the ship. Whatever Emily was doing, the ship was fighting back, breaking apart because of it.

'Where are you taking me?!' The clone protested, 'I only wish to bask in the light of Horde Prime!'

'I'm-' I faltered, unsure of what to say, 'I'm taking you to the light, okay?' It was a small lie, but if I could save at least one clone on my way back to Darla, it would be worth it.

**

'They have returned!' Wrong Hordak was waiting on Darla's ramp, watching for me. Darla began raising into the air as he shouted, and explosions began rocking the hangar all around us. A few more clones had followed me down the corridors and leaped up onto the ramp after me as Darla lifted off the deck and began moving back towards the jagged scar in the side of the ship.

Once we were safely inside, I put down the clone I had been carrying, reverted back to my regular self, and looked around. Catra was the only thing on my mind, I had to see her, I had to talk to her.

A cacophony of *"Brother!"* suddenly filled the cargo hold as Wrong Hordak greeted the four new arrivals, hugging each of them in turn.

The clone I had carried looked up at him, bemused. 'Brother?'

'Greetings, brother!' Wrong Hordak rushed forward and pulled the clone into a crushing hug.

'Where are your robes?' The clone did not return the hug and seemed entirely bewildered that Wrong Hordak had just wrapped his arms around him.

'Our brother, *Hor-dak,* said that this an important uniform that I must take care of as if my very life depends on it!' Wrong Hordak's tone was proud, but the other clone wasn't listening, instead he glanced around the cargo hold as if searching for something.

'Where is Horde Prime's guiding light?' He asked quietly. Then, when his eyes fell back on Wrong Hordak, he gasped, reaching up to his hair and hovering his hand above it as if it were on fire and radiating heat. 'Your impurity is showing, brother...'

'Brother, you must listen to me now - Horde Prime... *lied* to us! About everything! And now he is gone, and you must find your own light to follow!'

The expression on all of the new clones' faces was priceless, but I didn't hang around to hear their response. Instead, I rushed back to the bridge, only one thing on my mind. *Catra.* Had she listened to me? Had she stayed on the ship? There was so much I needed to say, so much I wanted her to know, the thought of leaving mid-way through an argument suddenly weighed heavy in my throat and the thought of leaving it stagnating any longer-

She wasn't there.

Melog, now full-size, whimpered softly while looking outside through the windshield. I followed their gaze, noting that the Dreadnought was no longer at such a deadly angle. It was pulling up, fires fading as magical purple wind buffeted against its hull, putting out the fires and helping to disrupt the ship's reckless infatuation with gravity.

Entrapta was sitting in the administrator's chair, her hands surrounded by bands of purple light and screens showing every angle around the ship. I vaguely noticed that one of the screens

displayed Hordak fighting off the Swarm drones down in Erelandia, firing lasers out the palms of his new gauntlets... Okay, he'd been busy tinkering... But I barely entertained the thought before my focus once again returned.

'Where's Catra!?'

'Oh, she left.' Entrapta deadpanned without looking away from the screens.

What? That's it?

'Where did she go?'

'I believe she left with the wind Princess to help slow the crashing ship's descent - but Adora, look! I'm currently *piloting* the Dreadnought! Darla is on autopilot to follow it, so I'm steering the ship away from any populated areas... It doesn't have the power to lift itself up again, so it *is* going to crash, but now we can vaguely steer it!' Entrapta was visibly excited by this prospect, so much so that it briefly lifted me from my Catra-focused haze.

'Can you put it down outside the whispering woods?'

'I can certainly try! It's still flying pretty fast, so it won't be short landing but-'

'What about Emily?' The question fell from my mouth before she could finish.

Entrapta paused for a moment, checking one of the purple screens floating in front of her. 'Emily's fine! She's able to fully hold-off the ship's systems now that I'm manually piloting the ship.'

'That's not what I mean, Entrapta. She's your friend, isn't she? Scorpia's too?'

'I- I have a plan! We just have to hope that her armour protects her black box during the crash, and that the ship's systems don't

breach its security.'

'Black box?'

'It's something I've been working on with the Dwells in Underdryl, although I wasn't planning on testing it in quite this fashion...'

I tore my gaze away from Entrapta and looked back out at the ship. Entrapta obviously had a plan, and wasn't worried about Emily in the long-term, so I let that thought go and instead focused back on where the love of my life had got to. I reached up to my ear, activating the comm channel.

'Spinnerella, where's Catra?'

There was a beat of silence before Spinnerella's voice yelled back, loud and strained. *'She's with me! Catra helped me to slow the ship! It took a lot more than I thought it would... I'm taking her back down to Erelandia.'*

My heart suddenly leapt into my throat. Catra had used magic again, a lot of it, despite me asking her not to. Was it on purpose? Was she getting back at me? Trying to prove something... this was all my fault. If I had just listened to her when she needed me to, believed in her more...

Wait.

'What do you mean you're taking her back?'

Another beat of silence. *'She- she's okay, Adora.'*

This can't be happening.

'Catra!? Catra, can you hear me!?' I tried to get through to Catra directly but received no response. I could feel the weight of my realisation trying to push me to the floor but somehow, I remained standing, staring out at the crashing ship in disbelief.

Not again.

Bow's voice came through this time, he was worried, but I could tell he was trying to be calm. *'Adora? Are you there? Spinnerella just landed back in Erelandia. She was carrying... Catra's breathing, but she isn't awake. The drones have dispersed too...'* I could tell Bow was still talking, filling me in on what had happened in Erelandia, how they had managed to hold off most of the drones thanks to Netossa's nets and Hordak's "laser hands", but I wasn't listening. Not really.

"What have you done to my precious little sister, Adora? I thought you cared for her? But you pushed her away, and now she's out of your reach." Prime's voice was back, low and measured. This time, I couldn't resist. I turned to the side where it sounded like the voice was coming from.

I could see him. He was standing right there, next to Entrapta. Could she not see him? I felt a mix of panic and anger welling up inside me and closed my eyes tight, fighting against the tears. I was ready to explode at Horde Prime, to shout at him to go away, to leave me alone, but when I opened my eyes again...

He was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Yay! Catra's insecurities have caught up with her and made her push Adora away before doing something reckless!

They were too happy and we all know it.

See you next week for 'Adora feels lots of different emotions and needs help sifting through them while also trying to ignore her new imaginary friend who does the opposite of help: the musical'.

Living with Fear

Chapter Summary

> Catra sleeps.
> Adora weeps.
> Horde Prime makes himself at home.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is a necessary bridge between the Erelandia Arc and the next one.
> The next story arc is roughly based around a quest in an abandoned D&D campaign I was writing that my group never got around to finishing because of the pandemic. Hopefully we'll be able to meet up again soon and finish it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'This is my fault.'

'How is this your fault, Adora?'

'I-'

'There's no way this is your fault.'

'It's just that-'

'Spinnerella already said-'

'Just listen...! Please.'

'Alright, fine, I'm listening.'

I sighed heavily, leaning against the wall beside the door to mine and Catra's bedroom. The events of the day had started to weigh heavily on my shoulders, my eyes and joints ached with the strain and fatigue of everything that had happened. Glimmer was crestfallen to find out that a potentially world-ending event had

happened while she was away, but she was quick to jump into action and took charge of the downed Dreadnought situation with ease. But that wasn't before she teleported Catra and I back to Bright Moon, allowing me some time to come to terms with what happened. The more I thought about it, however, the more I came to the same conclusion.

'It's my fault. It has to be. The day was going well, we were good, she was happy and then- that's when the drones attacked. She defended the whole town, Glimmer! It took a toll on her and I got worried but that's not... that's not what she needed. She needed me to believe in her, but I... I mean, I do, I did, but she must have taken what I said the wrong way... She lashed out at me and I guess she pushed herself to prove that she wasn't useless. I thought I was looking out for her, but all I did was make her mad with me and I don't know what to do.'

Glimmer sighed, crossing her arms as she leant against the wall opposite me. I could tell she was tired, but she had insisted on checking up on me once she got back from the crash site. Not a word had been mentioned about it to me yet, but to be honest I was miles away anyway. All I could focus on was the feeling that I had let Catra down, inadvertently pushing her to do something reckless to get back at me, to prove herself.

'Is it possible you're wrong, Adora?' She asked, looking up at me after a moment of silent contemplation. 'I've spoken to her a lot recently, but I didn't get the impression she was mad at you or anything. Maybe she really did just want to help and was just upset that you weren't letting her, despite what the consequences could have been.'

'But, Glimmer, she-'

Glimmer held up a hand, 'I know that her intervention ended up with her burnt out again, but she really did help to stop that ship, Adora. She helped Spinnerella slow it down enough to give Entrapta enough time to take control and direct it away from

Erelandia and away from the Whispering Woods. She *helped*. If anything, I think she'd want you to be proud of her. I know I am.'

'I- I am proud of her. She's amazing... but she said it was *my fault.* That she really didn't want the magic she has now, that it was my fault she did, my fault that she was useless... I can't help thinking that she's right. This whole time, I just kind of assumed that she was okay with having magic now, I didn't stop to think about what she actually thought about it.'

'If I remember correctly,' Glimmer said, pushing against the wall before stepping toward me, 'you were freaked out the first few times you had to use She-Ra. I know you never liked it, too. Catra told me how you never felt right when you had the First Ones' sword, so maybe she feels the same. She's also using First Ones' tech to focus her magic, isn't she?'

'Well, yeah, but that's... Glimmer, she could have been hurt! And she would have done that to herself even though-'

'Adora! Stop.' Glimmer interrupted again, placing her hands on my shoulders, and looking me in the eye with a scolding glare. 'She wanted to help. You said she couldn't, so she lashed out. I'm certain that's all it was. Maybe you should call Perfuma tomorrow, Bow and I will be busy with the surviving clones, but I think you should stay here and watch Catra. She was asleep for a while last time and we stayed with you then but...'

'It's okay, I know you're busy. Thank you, Glimmer. Give Bow my thanks too.' '

'I will.' She whispered as her arms wrapped around my back and pulled me into a hug. I returned it, just about, and smiled at her quickly before watching her disappear in shower of sparkly magic. I slipped back into my room and sighed, sliding down the door after closing it behind me. The room was empty, save for the furniture and... *him.*

Catra wasn't here. Something to do with making sure we both got the sleep we needed.

She had been laid down in the room that was originally intended for her before she spent that first night after the Heart in *my* room, then every night after that. But she wasn't here now, and that send a twinge of something awful through my chest. Sadness? Regret? Guilt? No. None of those things. I realised after a moment staring at the empty bed that what I was feeling was none other than... *loneliness.*

"It was bound to happen eventually." He muttered, standing at the entrance to the balcony and staring out into the night.

'Just go away.' I murmured, pulling my knees up to my chest and burying my face against them. I resolved to go and see Catra soon, just to check on her again. Maybe I could take something that smells of me, something familiar to comfort her while she sleeps. Would she even want that? Would we still be fighting when she wakes up? I didn't know. I hoped not.

"Hm. I shall do no such thing. Fighting with your Catra allowed me to surface higher and stronger than ever before. You can try reciting your mantra*, but it won't work. I'm here now. You can see me,"* Horde Prime looked back at me, over his shoulder, an evil grin spreading across his face, *"and I will be your undoing."*

**

'I just feel so terrible...' I admitted to Perfuma the next day during our Glimmer-prescribed call. She was still in the Fright Zone with Scorpia, helping the people there reconcile and find themselves while Scorpia mainly helped with the clean-up. 'The last thing we

did before she... We had an argument. She seemed so mad at me, but I just wanted her to be safe - and then she went and...'

It was only yesterday when Catra almost fell out of the sky, saved by Spinnerella who, thankfully, had been keeping a very close eye on her the whole time. Catra was still asleep, still not stirring despite a whole night of rest. That had been enough last time, but she'd used more magic this time around.

"Recharging," Entrapta had called it, "not sleeping. Well kind of sleeping. She is asleep, but that's not its intended function."

Glimmer was all too eager to point out the similarity to how she used to need to recharge, but placing Catra near the Moonstone earlier in the day didn't seem to have any obvious effects, so just keeping her in our room for now, in our bed, seemed the best thing for her. She had been in her own room the night before, but it was decided that this way, if she were to wake up while I was away for whatever reason, she would be somewhere familiar and know she was safe. I was incredibly thankful, indebted even, to Spinnerella, too. After all, if she hadn't been there, hadn't been watching her closely, Catra wouldn't be here at all, never mind asleep.

'Catra can be... stubborn, Adora.' Perfuma conceded after my silence dragged on for a moment too long, shaking me from my sudden descent into my own thoughts. *'You know, better than anyone, how lost within herself she can get.'* She looked off to the side for a moment, then closed her eyes and drew in a large breath, letting it out slowly. *'Normally I wouldn't share this much, but this seems like a special case, and I feel that you may need to know some things, Adora, because knowing them might help you better understand Catra's position, from her point of view.'*

I stared down at Perfuma in the screen as she waited patiently for me to process. I knew Perfuma was very protective of what was shared with her (which is why Scorpia was sent off to do something else when they took place), but for her to suggest sharing even an inkling of what Catra talked to her about made

my gut clench. Did I need to know? Was it my place to know? These are things Catra didn't talk about with me, so would be okay with me knowing?

'Judging by your face, I can see you're conflicted. But I honestly believe that hearing this will help you understand why she lashed out the way she did.' Perfuma's tone was patient, kind, understanding, as it always was. I nodded to her, content with the notion that she was only doing this to ease my mind and maybe, in the long run, Catra's too.

'Catra is...' Perfuma straightened her back against the wall of vines behind her, pulling in her legs to sit cross-legged and placed her hands on her knees. *'She's struggling. The magic is a burden on her, but she thinks it makes her useful, gives her a reason to be in your world and be by your side. Catra is very aware that while you've been together, as girlfriends, she's had the magic longer than she's been without it. She worries that if she loses it, she'll lose you too.'*

'But that's-'

'She knows. Catra knows it's a self-destructive way to think, and she's been working on that. She had been making good progress too. But this event, collapsing because of using too much magic... I think it made her lash out because it made her feel weak. Like she wasn't good enough. You said you told her to rest?' I nodded. *'She may have taken that the wrong way, given her unstable state at the time. I think, based on what I know and what you've told me, that Catra thought you were telling her to stop because she wasn't strong enough to be beside you.'*

Perfuma must have had a good grasp on the way Catra thinks for her to make such a guess, but over the past month of us patrolling around looking for *nothing*, apparently, Catra had been taking an hour or two every couple days to talk to her and Scorpia. When I first called about an hour ago, Perfuma had said she calls these discussions "therapy" and described them as "healing". She had been able to talk to a lot of people in the

Fright Zone since they effectively moved there, but Catra was by far her most frequent company.

'Glimmer... Glimmer said she thinks it was because Catra just wanted to help.' I offered, feeling conflicted as to the true cause of Catra's outburst. Something about not being able to read Catra myself was nagging me, I used to be able to notice these kinds of things, without hints from my friends, but apparently Catra had perfected the art of closing herself and her thoughts off from the world.

'That may be true as well. Perhaps it's a little of both. You need to talk to her, Adora. I can't tell you what to say, but she needs to know that you'll be there, no matter what.' Perfuma's tone was kind, understanding. But something about what she said clouded my mind, springing more confusion where I thought there had been clarity.

'I will. Of course I will. I just- I've told her I wanted to spend my life with her already. I've told her I love her more times than I can count. I guess I- I just don't understand how she could think anything else.' Catra was an enigma. She always had been, telling half-truths or lying to hide what she truly thought or to protect herself. Is that what's been doing? Protecting herself?

'I have some measure of your past as well Adora, from speaking with Catra. I hope you don't mind me saying, but it seems difficult for her to trust people based on your upbringing. You were her only real friend for the longest time, until Scorpia. Based on her experiences, I think it's safe to assume that for Catra... actions may speak louder than words. I believe that's why she's been helping so much, trying to communicate her sorrow and grief for what she's done. Trying to atone. As for your future with her...'

'Actions speak louder than words.' I repeated. Perfuma nodded. Catra needed actions, something tangible. Too many promises broken, too many betrayals. She needed something concrete to latch onto. My hand immediately wandered to the golden wing on my belt. It had been a while since I traced its outline under my

fingers, but now its meaning and importance shone blindingly bright. Catra needs this. She needs to know just how much I love her, just how much I'm willing to commit myself to her. She needs to know that she matters, that she isn't useless or unwanted. I looked down at the tracker pad in my lap as Perfuma squealed and clapped her hands together excitedly. 'What?' I asked, confused at her sudden gleeful outburst.

'You look like you've come to a decision, Adora. I'm glad I could help.' She beamed from ear to ear, and I couldn't help but smile back while wiping my eyes with the heels of my hands.

'Thanks, Perfuma. I know what I need to do now. I've been meaning to do it for a while, but it's never felt like the right moment...'

'I'm sure you'll find your moment, Adora. Now, is there anything else you want to ask me about before Scorpia gets back?'

I considered for a moment, before tearing my gaze away from the screen and looking across the room to where Horde Prime had been standing the whole time, just inside my peripheral vision. He was one of the reasons I barely slept at all, the other being away from Catra, but his constant, relentless assault on my mind just refused to let me sleep. 'Yeah, there is...'

Perfuma's brow furrowed for a moment before it was replaced with a smile that shone with nothing but kindness. *'What is it, Adora? You can tell me.'*

"Yes, tell her, Adora. Tell her how you have manifested your fears into an enemy long dead. Tell her how I'm picking away at your mind, piece by piece. Tell her how you how you're letting me do it, just as your insecurity about your Catra let me in to begin with."

His words sent a shiver down my spine and I had to brace myself and close my eyes until it had passed. 'I- It's... there's...' I took a

deep breath to steady myself before opening my eyes once again and focusing on Perfuma. 'I'm seeing things. Hearing things too.'

Perfuma dropped her smile, a more serious expression replacing it. *'Can you describe what you see and hear for me, Adora?'*

I nodded before looking up at him again. He grinned a wide green smile and regarded me with an intense, scrutinising glare. 'I see Horde Prime. He's in the room with me. Sometimes he isn't here, but sometimes he is. He is now. I hear his voice. I've been hearing his voice ever since Dryl. I didn't tell anyone because it was in my head. It was just in my head. It was like I was having thoughts, but they were in his voice but now... now they're not in my head. He speaks, and I can hear him, but it feels like more than just my thoughts in his voice. Sometimes it feels... it feels real.'

Perfuma looked to the side again, as if contemplating a response. *'How about... Is it okay if I suggest something?'* I nodded slowly. *'Ask him something you don't already know.'*

Prime laughed, he was suddenly right next to me and his unexpected proximity made me flinch. He then looked down at Perfuma on the screen. *"Oh, she's good. She's trying to understand if I really am just in your head."*

I ignored him, instead thinking of a question that I would never know the answer to. 'How many ships are still in orbit around Etheria?' I asked, loud enough so Perfuma could hear it too.

He grinned and held his arms behind his back before looking up at the ceiling, as if looking through it, out into space. *"Very well, I'll humour you. How many ships? I don't know, let's say* nine*."*

'What did he say?' Perfuma prompted, aware that I had been silent for a while.

'He said nine, but that could be a number in my subconscious somewhere. I'll think of another...' I closed my eyes and thought hard. What's something that only Prime would know, that I

wouldn't have an easy answer to tucked away somewhere? I opened my eyes and looked back up at him, he seemed almost amused. 'How did you defeat the First Ones?'

Horde Prime grinned. *"Now that's a good question. But I could say anything in response. You've been re-imagining my speech patterns and appearance for days now, it wouldn't take much else for you to imagine-"*

'Answer the question! I'll know if you're lying.'

"Hmm. Very well. The First Ones, as you know them, largely destroyed themselves from the inside out. All I had to do was clean up after them." Suddenly he was standing before me, his face inches from mine. *"Now, did I actually say that, or was it something you imagined I would say?"*

'Adora?' Perfuma's voice prompted me from the tracker pad again, there was no pressure in her prompts, just reminders that I needed to speak out loud as well.

'This isn't working.' I concluded; my judgement clouded by Prime's words. He was right: anything he says I could easily imagine being something he *would* say, even if I didn't know the answer, I could just make one up on the spot.

'Hmm...' Perfuma seemed to pause and consider for a moment. She then glanced quickly to her right as a muffled voice came within earshot. Perfuma pointed to herself, and her eyebrows shot up in surprise. *'I'm really sorry to cut this short, Adora, but something's come up. it looks like I'm needed. Feel free to call me anytime, but if not, I'll see you at the meeting in a few days.'*

'Okay. Goodbye, Perfuma.'

'Look after yourself, Adora.' And with that, she leant forwards and ended the call.

I let out a long sigh and placed the tracker pad on the floor beside me. I had been sat, leant against the foot of the bed where Catra

slept soundly. Once I managed to rise to my feet, I walked around the bed and flopped into the chair next to it. This had become my new permanent position and the familiarity of the situation stirred an uneasy feeling in my gut. After a quick glance around the to make sure we were alone, which we would have been anyway if my mind wasn't a mess, I reached forward and held Catra's hand between my own.

'I'm sorry, Catra.' I whispered into the darkness of the room, stroking the back of her hand with my thumb, and watching as the fine silky fur shifted beneath my touch.

**

My curiosity did get the better of me after the call with Perfuma. I contacted Hordak, asking how many ships were still in orbit around us.

'Nine.' He said.

Just a coincidence, I concluded. Because any other possibility terrified me.

**

I bolted upright with a start that night, sweating and gasping, confronted with Horde Prime standing over me, apparently staring down at me as I slept.

"Whatever is the matter?" He asked without a hint of concern. If anything, he sounded cheerful. *"Nightmares giving you trouble?"*

'Just shut up! Get out of my head!' I huffed and laid back down again on the hard surface of the cot that I had had replaced in my room. Catra was still asleep on my bed, and I had taken to sleeping separately because of the nightmares causing me to thrash about, reigniting my old sleep fighting habit. Prime was directly influencing my dreams, and without Catra there to talk me down these last couple of nights had not been fun.

"I don't know why you keep looking at her. She doesn't care for you."

I closed my eyes tight. Just wishing to sleep and to not hear his voice anymore. 'You don't know that.'

"You think it."

'No I don't.'

"Such intense denial. It's a wonder you even accepted her feelings in the first place."

'What would you know about feelings?'

"I know when the light leaves people's eyes. When the spark fades. The well of despair that opens when you tell someone that you have killed that which they love."

'Yeah, seems like you'd be an expert in shattering people.'

"I dare say it's working on you."

'I won't let it. I'm stronger than you. I won't let you break me.'

"Such confidence. Such bravado! But what if your Catra rejects you upon waking? Who knows if she'll even want to see you? You pushed her away again, after all."

'No I- that's not what I did. That's not what I meant to do.'

"She will reject you. How hard will you scramble to beg her for forgiveness?"

'I don't even know the real reason why she's mad. I just have guesses from friends.'

"She didn't even trust you with this. No wonder she thinks she's nothing in your eyes. You wouldn't accept her if you knew how broken she is, would you?"

'Of course I would. I'll always accept her.'

"Hmm. A beautiful sentiment. But is it one she shares?"

'I don't-'

"Hush, child." I felt an ache in my head, pulling me back to sleep. *"It's time to* dream *again."*

No...

**

Two days later, after taking a walk through the palace gardens at Perfuma's suggestion, something about "getting out for fresh air" to clear my head, I found two of the palace guards stationed outside my bedroom door.

This was weird for a number of reasons.

For one, there was no reason for them to be there. I had never had guards stationed outside my room for any reason, even if Glimmer had threatened it a couple times before. Like when I used to refuse to sleep, instead insisting that I was fine and the black circles under my eyes were an aesthetic choice.

As far as I was aware, Catra wasn't a threat or in danger. She had been soundly asleep for the past three days, after all, and had so far shown little to no signs of waking up.

And finally, it was especially weird because I noticed them tense up as I approached.

"Perhaps your Catra's died."

Shut up.

The nail in the coffin was when they angled their spears to block me out.

Of my own bedroom.

'Uh... what? This is *my* room.' I blinked at them, wondering for a moment if they were lost. Then I wondered quickly if I was lost and had just misidentified the room I was standing in front of. But after a not-at-all subtle glance around the hallway I was able to confirm that this was, in fact, my bedroom.

One of the guards shifted uncomfortably, their gaze was nothing if not apologetic. 'Apologies, Princess Adora, but this room is sealed by order of the Queen.'

Okay, what?

"They're shutting you out again."

Enough.

'Glimmer is literally one of my best friends, and this is my bedroom.' I watched as the two guards exchange anxious glances, but their block of the door did not falter.

'Princess, we-'

'Glimmer! Are you there!?' I would say that I tried fighting against the uneasy panic that had been steadily rising since I saw the

guards standing there, but that would make me a liar. 'This is my room! Catra's in there, let me-'

The sound of the door handle turning immediately killed the next words in my throat. Forgetting how to breathe was also a side-effect of my newfound tension. I watched as the door hesitantly swung open and caught a glance of Catra sitting up in the bed, *awake*, pointedly looking away from the door while Glimmer sat next to the bed with her hands on Catra's. No sooner had I saw her and felt the hope and relief spread through me, than the door closed once again. The relief was promptly replaced with *dread*. A moment passed before I realised that Bow had actually left the room and closed the door behind him, and he quickly wrapped me into a hug.

'Bow? Catra... what...' I could hear my voice quavering and felt tears pricking my eyes. 'I don't understand... *Bow*...'

Bow pulled back and tried smiling, but I could tell it was forced and strained. 'Catra's awake. She's okay. A little wobbly but, yeah, she's okay.'

'I want to... Can I see her? The guards...'

His smile faltered and, while fighting tears of his own, he pulled me into a much tighter hug than before. 'Adora... I'm sorry, but... she- she said doesn't want to see you. Catra's feeling... a lot of things right now and has asked for some space.'

"Ah. Did I not say this would come to pass?"

In a split second, it felt as though the floor had opened up and swallowed me whole. I was vaguely aware of tears rolling down my cheeks and landing on Bow's shoulder, but I had never quite felt so far away from my own body before. I knew I had questions, endless questions. I also had endless apologies lined up and raring to go, but I knew they would fall on deaf ears if I started rolling them off without knowing exactly what it was I was apologising for.

Catra didn't want to see me.

Over the course of those brief, painful moments, my world had completely and utterly shattered.

"Good."

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter will be up on Wednesday because I'm moving at the weekend!

Of Yogurt and Letters

Chapter Summary

Adora does some heavy lifting.
Glimmer runs out of patience.
Catra tries to make amends; Prime intervenes.

Chapter Notes

This chapter's fun :3
Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra kept me at arm's length for the rest of her recovery. Her being mad with me was nothing new, not if you looked at our history. But her being mad with me while I knew she was in love with me was, for lack of a better word, painful. She talked with Bow and Glimmer quite frequently, but I was not privy to the content of their discussions. Whenever I asked about Catra, they just kept saying she wasn't ready, needed time to think, needed some space. So much space, in fact, that she had started sleeping in her own room in the palace. Safe to say I had not been sleeping well, not since I had been falling asleep to her warmth for the past few months. Bow seemed more understanding, but Glimmer was slowly losing it and had, more recently, starting hinting that we just need to talk to each other. I did know, however, that Catra had accepted the position of Royal Advisor and had been busying herself with that task while actively avoiding me. Turning invisible with Melog's assistance made that an extremely easy task.

On the day of the next Princess Alliance meeting, Glimmer told me that Entrapta had contacted them requesting help with a project, "just moving some stuff around" she said. The "stuff" in question was the charred and melted remains of Emily.

Entrapta explained, while I carried the malformed ex-Horde bot into her lab from Darla, that the Dreadnought's windshield had broken during its uncontrolled entry, letting in the heat, and effectively turning the ship's bridge into a blast furnace. She's 50:50 on whether it happened due to the ship's prior damage or if it was the ship's systems purposefully purging the protective layer in favour of removing the intrusion.

'So...' I began, after placing the bot down in Entrapta's lab and reverting back down from She-Ra to my normal self, 'what's this plan of yours for Emily? You said you had one the day of the crash, something to do with a box.' Entrapta lowered her mask, scurried over to the bot and, tools in hand, began practically digging through the melted metal.

'Yes! Her black box. I've been working closely with the Dwells, analysing their robotic AI technology. I discovered that each one of their robots has a central processing and memory hub which acts as the brain of the machine. Emily's systems, by comparison, were incredibly crude. So, I made the upgrade! The last piece Emily needed was a voice synthesiser. I hadn't quite worked it out before the attack, but I have now! I've been working on this ever since you first introduced me to Darla – speaking to a complex system and interacting with it on a deeper level is so exciting!' Entrapta spoke with such speed from behind her mask that I really had to focus on her words to hear and understand her, especially over the sound of the tools doing their work.

Apparently, I was stood silently processing for too long, because a moment later Entrapta slowly lifted her hands into the air, cradling something as if were the most precious thing to exist, or as if it could explode any second – one of the two. Sure enough, it was a small black box, no bigger than my fist. 'Is that...?'

'This is Emily! Say "Hi"!'

'Hi, Emily?'

'Isn't she *cute?*'

'It's a box.'

'A *tiny* box!'

'O-kay.'

'Follow me!' Entrapta announced, loud and proud, before turning and taking the two or three steps over toward her wall of screens. I rolled my eyes fondly, following behind and watching as she carefully slotted the small black cube into an appropriately sized space on the control panel. A moment passed where she seemed to wait, almost expectantly, still with her visor down. Then she cheered and, after lifting her visor, pressed a button near the cube and watched as it started to glow purple. 'Oh good! It didn't explode!'

'What? That was a possibility?'

'It's always a possibility!'

'Remind me never to- you know what, never mind.'

'Okay!'

Entrapta then stepped back from the console and looked up at the screens as a word formed between them, fragmented slightly as different parts of the letters shone from different screens as part of the collage. It read: "E.M.I.L.Y."

'Say "hello" to Emily!'

'Again? Hi, Emily... I didn't know her name was an acronym. What does it stand for?'

'Oh, nothing. I just thought it looked *cooler.* Why, should it stand for something?' I shrugged and she continued, 'oo! How about: Even Mainframe Interfaces Love Yogurt!'

Before I had time to process *that*, a new cheery voice suddenly blared from *somewhere* as a thin line appeared on the screen and

pulsed in time with the speech.

>> Yogurt! <<

'Ahh! Emily spoke! Her first word was yogurt!'

'Oh, wow, okay...'

>> I can verbalise! An entire lexicon is accessible for utilisation! Oo, Internal Crypto Castle Systems... <<

Behind us, the door opened and closed a few times as the lights flickered quickly.

>> Downloading existing speech pattern data for effective communication, please stand by. <<

Entrapta was *glowing*.

'So, you look happy.' I said, watching as the wide grin on Entrapta's face somehow spread even wider.

'This is the greatest thing I've ever created! A true AI! That can speak!'

>> Download complete. <<
>> Wow, you guys, this is just - the best. If I had eyes, I would be crying. Similarly, if I had arms, I would hug you. Oh!
I *can* have arms, give me just a moment... <<

'What's happening right now?' I asked, watching as Entrapta seemed to be overloading with excitement.

'Emily is using our speech patterns to develop her own speech and convey what she's *feeling.* Right now, she sounds like Scorpia, which makes sense as they spent a lot of time together. She also seems to be exploring the new systems available to her!'

'And what systems does she have available to her?'

'Eventually... everything!'

'Everything?'

'Yes! Dryl, all the robots, the tracker pads, my exo-suit that I picked up from Beast Island and forgot to tell anyone I did that! All of it. Although not Darla, as Darla is mostly First Ones tech and that can make her difficult to deal with sometimes.'

A robot approached from behind Entrapta and spread its arms wide, inviting her in. Entrapta bounded over and hugged it tight with both her arms and her hair, smiling with tears in her eyes. 'Emily!'

>> Hug initiated! *Hurray!* <<

'It seems she's also registered that hugs are a form of affection through Scorpia's relentless demonstrations!' Entrapta laughed happily, perfectly content to be wrapped in the arms of her own creation.

The bot looked up at me after a moment and seemed to tilt its head, as if considering. Then Emily's merry voice address me directly.

>> Adora, would you like to bring it in? Aw shucks, I'm so sorry about what happened on the ship. <<

I blinked, wondering what to address. The screens? The robot? I settled on the robot. 'Oh, um. That's alright, Emily. I'm just glad to see you're okay. Scorpia will be thrilled to be able to speak with you.'

>> Oh! Scorpia! Entrapta, can we go see Scorpia soon? <<

The bot looked down at Entrapta as if asking the question itself, and it seemed to bounce on the spot with excitement.

'Of course we can! It has been a while. She's in the Fright Zone now, right?' Entrapta asked, looking back at me. I nodded. 'Then sure! We just have to get you properly calibrated first. You have a lot of new processes to test out too! Oo, think of all the

experiments!' She pulled her recorder out of her hair and spoke into it quickly. 'Emily project log forty-seven: The upload was a success! Now moving on to test complete functionality! Step one, Crypto Castle internal systems and Dryl compatibility.'

I watched as Entrapta moved back over to the control console, happily typing away. The robot just remained where it was, staring at me blankly. I cleared my throat, suddenly feeling quite uncomfortable under the unwavering gaze of the twin purple lights. 'Uh, Entrapta, was there anything else you needed?'

'What's that?' She looked at me quickly, tearing her focus away from the screen and seemed to regard me for far too long. Did she forget I was here? 'Oh! Adora! You're still here!' Yep. 'Hordak is in his workshop if you wanted to pay him a visit. He's working on some very exciting projects that he absolutely *loves* to talk about.'

I considered for a moment, weighing up my options. Glimmer said she would come back and get me when the meeting was about to start, so I had a little more time. 'Okay, I'll go see what he's working on. Thanks, Entrapta. Bye, Emily.'

>> Goodbye, Adora! Thank you for your friendship! <<

**

On the way to Hordak's lab, I was suddenly aware of an unwelcome presence beside me.

'Go away.'

"Why did they send you on this fool's errand, Adora? Are they leaving you out again? Deciding things without your input? Did your Catra ask them to send you away so she never has to see you ever-"

'Drop it! I know you're just in my head, trying to get to me. You won't break me.'

"I will certainly try. Although, it doesn't appear my interference is what is breaking you. Your own actions have caused you to push your love away. She no longer wants you, all because of what you *have done. Your childhood friend, your worst enemy, your first love. What* will *you do without her?"*

'You're wrong! I'll make it right. You'll see. I love Catra, and I want to make it work. It's just... hard to do that when she won't even talk to me.'

"Your friends seem to think the same. But will that really help? She's in pain, and it's your fault. She doesn't want the magic. She only used it to make you happy, and then you pushed her away."

'I didn't push her away! I just... she used too much, she needed to rest, and I didn't want her to push herself! She did it anyway and look what happened! She was asleep for days!'

"You are angry with her. Fascinating. It seems the resentment goes both ways."

'What? No... I'm not... I don't...'

I stopped walking and clutched my head in my hands. Was I angry with Catra? Do I resent her, what she did? That isn't right, I would never-

'Um...' I looked up to see Wrong Hordak in his butler uniform standing a little ways ahead, holding a tray of tiny food. He must have been on his way to Entrapta's lab. 'Are you alright, brother?' *Wink.*

'Wrong Hordak, hey... I'm fine, really, just- thinking out loud.'

A wide smile spread across his face. 'I see! You seemed in distress, brother, which in turn caused a feeling of distress in me.

How very distressing. But I am always here to help my dear brothers in their times of need.'

'Thanks, Wrong Hordak. You're a good friend. I'm fine though, really.' I smiled as I watched a look of absolute glee descend upon him, his eyes practically sparkling and a blush reddening his cheeks.

'Very well, brother! Thank you for calling me a good friend! You are also a good friend! Now, I must complete my mission and bring this tiny food to Entrapta. I wish you well, brother!' *Wink.* I watched as he sauntered on past with a skip in his step. When I looked around, Horde Prime had gone and I could no longer feel his presence. I steeled myself, ignoring my thoughts as I continued on to find Hordak.

**

Hordak was exactly where Entrapta said he would be, back in his workshop where he had first told me about the ships disappearing. But he wasn't alone. A Dwell wearing a heavily stained once-white apron sat atop a platform that seemed to be floating and warbling with some kind of energy as it zipped around the room, bobbing up, down and around various half-finished machines. Hordak didn't seem concerned with the incredibly distracting display, instead focusing heavily on the metal gauntlet laid out on the worktable. He was wearing the other one, and after a moment I recognised them as the same ones he had been wearing in Erelandia.

'Ah! A guest!' The Dwell exclaimed suddenly as his eyes landed on me, his ears wiggling with restrained excitement. Hordak turned to regard me with a brief curiosity before the recognition set in and he visibly relaxed.

'Ah, Adora. This is Skien, a Dwell specialist in robotics.' He said, skipping over a "hello" or a "welcome" and settling straight on introducing the small green fellow who seemed far too excited just to exist.

'Awe, Hordak - you've made a friend?' I teased, relishing in the expression he made before his brow furrowed. Hordak simply grumbled a response, but Skien leant forward on his platform, content with the notion of being called Hordak's friend.

'Greetings, newcomer!' He beamed, reaching out and vigorously shaking my hand. 'From what I've heard, and from Hordak referring to you as Adora just now, you must be the She-Ra! It's an honour to meet you, really. And yes, Hordak here is correct, I am a robotics expert. I've been helping our Princess develop her understanding of AI, as well as aiding our mutual friend here with his own personal tinkering. Quite the pair, these two.'

Hordak grumbled again, turning back to the gauntlet on the worktable.

'Tell me,' Skien continued, 'how is the Emily project going? Has Entrapta set it up? Was the box intact?'

I nodded, 'yeah, the box was fine. Entrapta plugged it in. Emily... spoke? I think Entrapta is just running through things with her now.'

'Ah, fantastic! With any luck, any second now we should be joined by-'

>> Hi, there! <<

Emily's chipper voice suddenly echoed throughout the workshop, Skien visibly jumped and Hordak dropped the tool he had been working with.

>> I have just discovered how to operate within different rooms! Aah! This is so exciting! <<

I laughed. Briefly forgetting everything that weighed heavy on my shoulders and enjoying the moment. 'Hi Emily!'

>> Oh! Adora! Hello again, long time no see, how are you? <<

'I'm good, but it hasn't really been that long.' I watched as Hordak grunted in frustration before turning and walking towards a door on the far side of the workshop.

>> My mistake! I never did have the concept of time figured out; I shall work on that! <<

'Adora.' Hordak grumbled from across the room. When I looked over, he was waiting expectantly by the now open door. Did he want me to follow him?

'Okay, well I'm gonna go again, Emily. Skien, was it? Are you coming too?' I asked, pointing to Hordak.

'Oh, no my child. I am going to stay and ask Emily here some diagnostic questions of my own, and then I shall re-join Entrapta in her lab. Have fun with the observatory, Hordak's very proud of his progress with it. Although he'd never admit to it.' Skien whispered the last part and winked before floating his platform closer to the screen. 'Now, Emily, how much of Dryl can you see right now?'

>> That's a good question! Wow, you really are a specialist! That's just swell. I can see *sixty-seven percent* of Dryl as of this moment... sixty-eight... sixty-nine... <<

'Fantastic, Emily. Now, can you run by me every process you don't recognise as...' The rest of Skien's sentence faded to obscurity as I crossed the room towards a waiting Hordak. Once I reached him, I could have sworn I noticed the faintest trace of a smile tugging at the corner of his mouth.

'Come,' he said, 'let me show you the progress I have made on the observatory.' Hordak stepped through the door and I followed, hot on his heels.

We entered a new corridor, one I hadn't seen before, and followed it until it ended in a circular room. No, it wasn't a room... a tower? A staircase spiralled its way around its interior wall but Hordak ignored it completely, instead walking directly to the middle of the floor, standing there with his arms held neatly behind his back. I joined him, and after a moment he tapped a button on the gauntlet he was still wearing. The floor shifted, began to rise, and it soon became clear that we were standing on a circular platform that would take us directly to the top of the tower. I recognised the concept from the Horde prison in the Fright Zone - which meant that Hordak must have been the one to design those platforms that could rise and fall to get you to different levels.

After a moment, I started whistling absently, watching as we passed by the seemingly redundant staircase. If Hordak was displeased with the sound, he didn't voice it, but he didn't look happy. 'Soo...' I began, desperate to break the awkward silence, 'what's the story behind the new metal gloves? Bow said you were firing lasers out of them. He seemed quite impressed.' Hordak's eyes went wide for a moment and the faintest hint of a blush tickled his cheeks. Was he not used to being complemented? After a moment, he cleared his throat and slowly began to speak.

'My previous arm cannon was clunky, oversized, but it served its purpose. With etherium available to us, we are able to make things... smaller. Much to Entrapta's joy. The circuitry, when made with etherium, is capable of handling far more processes than before. It is also stronger, more lightweight, and infinitely more adaptable than any metal we ever had available to us in the Fright Zone.' He paused for a moment and I noticed the slight tilt to his head. Was he remembering? 'I... I was somewhat inspired by Catra's First Ones tech to adapt my arm cannon design to be more... utilitarian. Skien has helped me considerably on the path to perfecting the design, but my new gauntlets have twice the power and far more practical use than any before them. Of course, the rest of the armour is just a precaution. There is something happening on Etheria, Adora. Something we cannot see. The signals are evidence enough of this.’

'Yeah, I've kind of been thinking that for a while, but there's nothing linking everything that's happened except for-'

'A green light.' Hordak finished the thought. 'Catra filled me in on every time you've come across it. First in Underdryl. Then, the data crystal her pet found-'

'Hey! Melog isn't her pet.'

'-followed by the creature in the Cove. And, finally, the Swarm drones. I think it's safe to assume that these instances are linked and are *not* isolated events. From that, you can assume that whatever it is can hack into First Ones temples, First Ones technology, as well as the Horde's Swarm drones. What we should be thinking of next, is not when the next attack will occur, but what else could be hacked.' Hordak said all of that while keeping a straight face, his mouth set in a firm line and his brow furrowed in contemplation.

'You've... you've given this a lot of thought, haven't you?' I asked, looking up at him with wide eyes.

'I was Horde Prime's top general; I built an Empire from the remains of a crashed ship... this should be child's play, but one detail alludes us.'

'And what's that?'

Hordak looked down at me and I gazed into the intense stare of his half-green, half-red eyes. 'The source.'

'The source?'

He nodded once, then turned to face forward again as the platform finally reached the top of the tower. What I assumed to be the observatory looked to be a huge dome, with two halves to the ceiling that were opened out to allow a long metal tube to poke out the side. It took a moment for the gears to turn in my head, but after a moment I realised what it must be.

'Is that a huge spyglass!?' I exclaimed suddenly, pointing to the metal tube. Hordak ignored me, instead walking over to a row of worktables off to the side. Spread over them was an array of blueprints, drawings, screws, nuts, and bolts. Metal sheets were propped up against one wall and large crates dominated the rest of the space. Inside were various sizes and shapes of circular glass. I moved back over to one of the blueprints, picked it up and examined it closer, before finding a label that would be more helpful than the silence that Hordak was offering.

'"Telescope"?' I read out loud, looking up at Hordak for confirmation. He simply nodded again.

'Yes. A means of looking out to the stars. It is mostly built, except for the lenses. I am having to rely on the Dwells and their forge's assistance with the precise measurements I require, and it is taking... far longer than I'd hoped. Once it is complete, we will be able to clearly see what is in orbit around Etheria. And then, if you wish, you may use it to look beyond.'

'Beyond?'

Before Hordak had chance to elaborate on what exactly he was offering, and why he was offering it at all, Glimmer teleported into the room behind us.

'Ugh!' She groaned, leaning every which way to crack her back. 'Why did you have to go walk-about in *here* of all places? I've been teleporting around the castle for *way too long!*' Before I had chance to protest, she marched forwards and grabbed my wrist. 'The meeting is about to start, come on!'

I had time to shoot Hordak an apologetic glance before we disappeared in an shower of pink sparkly magic.

**

Glimmer teleported us straight into the meeting room. It was empty, except for one person. Catra was already sat at the table, directly opposite her usual chair, which remained empty next to mine. She had her arms crossed over her chest and was very clearly looking off to the side, actively avoiding making eye-contact with me. I sighed, taking my usual seat at the table, eying the empty one next to me mournfully. I heard Glimmer groan her frustration before walking around and taking her seat.

Moments later, the palace guards opened the doors behind us, and the rest of the meeting's attendees filed in and took their seats. Micah sat between Catra and Glimmer. From the look he gave me, I could tell he was uneasy about the situation. Bow sat down on Glimmer's other side, rubbing her arm, and offering a small smile before shooting me a similar look that didn't do much to help my unease, but I appreciated him trying.

Netossa and Spinnerella sat down next to Catra, I watched Spinnerella engage in brief small talk with her, no doubt asking about Catra's recovery. I sighed and rested my head against the table, not wanting to watch anymore. I heard Mermista, Perfuma, and Scorpia enter too. Scorpia began to greet Catra, but stopped short when she noticed how far apart we were sitting. I felt the tip of a pincer on my back and peaked up to see a look of worried apprehension. I offered a smile, but it didn't do much to ease her expression. Perfuma just smiled sadly, she of all people knew exactly what was going on. Mermista looked miles away.

'Thank you all for coming.' Micah began, addressing the room. 'As you all know, a Galactic Horde ship crash-landed on Etheria a few days ago. Thanks to the efforts of Adora and Catra, Spinnerella and Netossa, Bow, Entrapta, Hordak and Emily, we-'

'And me! Don't forget me! I too was there.' Swift Wind piped up from behind me, proudly swishing his mane back and forth. When

had he even entered the room?

'Yes, of course.' Micah cleared his throat before continuing. 'Thanks to their efforts, the ship had a controlled landing in the plains between the Whispering Woods and the Fright Zone. There was no loss of civilian life, and no damage to any infrastructure or the woods themselves. As far as we know, the Swarm drones that attacked Erelandia returned to orbit and have since powered down, but we will know when they are activated again and this time, we'll be ready.' He looked around the room, and everyone nodded their agreement. 'Now, I'm sure you're all wondering what the plan is for the displaced clones. For that, I hand you over to my daughter, Queen Glimmer, who has a proposition. Glimmer, the table is yours.' Micah smiled fondly at Glimmer before taking his seat. Glimmer returned the expression as she rose from her chair and looked around the room, making sure everyone's attention was on her.

'Okay. Thank you, dad. Bow, if you could...' Bow suddenly sat up straight and nodded, tapping on his tracker pad. After a moment, a hologram showing the downed ship appeared on the table. The Dreadnought was huge and looked half buried in the ground, chunks of it had broken away and fragments were spread far and wide around it.

'So,' Glimmer continued, 'as you all know, the ship was landed successfully. This is where it came to rest. The ship itself is in bad shape, but the evacuation efforts have gone well. So far, we've managed to rescue about 130 clones from the wreckage, alive or injured. There have also been a number that were too injured to save or were already gone when we found them.' Glimmer fell silent for a moment, none of us ever expected to be talking about a mass loss of life *after* the war had finished. 'For now, they're in an emergency camp that was set up close to the ship. As they don't *need* food or water or... anything, really, there aren't any shortages to consider. But, they will need *some* sustenance eventually, which means they have to go *somewhere*. I know a lot of you may have mixed feelings about what we do with the clones, but please keep in mind that since being removed from

the hive-mind they're no better than lost children, just like Wrong Hordak was. Before I make my suggestion, does anyone have anything to say?'

No one said anything. Catra extended her claws and picked at them. Scorpia sat up in her chair.

'Okay.' Glimmer continued, looking around the table. 'Glad to know none of you have had any weird ideas for what to do with the clones. Honestly, it's a huge relief. My personal suggestion, is that the clones move into the Fright Zone.' Scorpia beamed and Perfuma rested a supportive hand on her thigh, squeezing gently. 'I've already approached Scorpia about the idea, and she... well, I'll let Scorpia cover this bit. Scorpia?' Glimmer smiled warmly at Scorpia, offering her the floor before sitting down.

'Oh, wow, okay.' Scorpia mumbled as she slowly rose to her feet.

'Yay!' Perfuma could barely hold in her excitement, clapping quickly as Scorpia finally reached her full height and blushed as she looked around the room. All eyes were on her.

'O-kay. Well, hello there, I guess. Heh. I'm Scorpia, obviously. Princess Scorpia. Uh- I have been- I mean, Perfuma and I have been helping out at the Fright Zone, over there, and uh... well, there's plenty of room for the clones, I mean, compared to everywhere else. They are also, technically, ex-Horde so, y'know, it makes sense that they could live where all the other ex-Horde guys are... oh, jeez, I'm not explaining this very well am I?' Scorpia rubbed her pincers together nervously, but Perfuma just beamed up at her.

'You're doing great, honey. Tell them about the other thing.' Perfuma waved her hand, and a small bracelet of flowers seemed to grow around one of Scorpia's pincers. The small act seemed to calm her down, and she looked down at her girlfriend in time to see Perfuma mouth something that looked like "Lonnie".

'Oh! Right, yes. *Ahem*. I have also decided, *we* have decided, that once the Fright Zone is rebuilt Perfuma and I will move back to Plumeria. More permanently. As much as I like it in the Fright Zone, and as much as it is my ancestral home, it doesn't really *feel* like home. And I think I've found that, in Plumeria, with Perfuma. So, I would like to recommend Lonnie to take over once we do leave. She's always been much more put-together than I was anyway. Practically ran our operations together when Catra wasn't there, oh man, you should have seen us, *quite* the squad... Well, that's uh- that's all from me. Thank you all for listening, you're a great audience.' Scorpia then awkwardly saluted and promptly sat back down, letting out a huge breath as she did and smiling happily at Perfuma as if the rest of the room had melted away.

I caught a smile on Catra's lips as she watched her friend, but as soon as she noticed I was looking at her she turned away, but... was she *blushing?*

Glimmer then cleared her throat and stood up again, addressing the room. 'Thank you Scorpia. Any objections from those seated here to the notion of sending the clones to live in the Fright Zone?'

'It's, like, fine with me. Honestly, I'm just glad they have somewhere to go to.' Mermista deadpanned while somehow slouching further down into her chair as if she regretted speaking.

'I agree.' I said while rising out of my chair, surprising myself by speaking up. 'The Fright Zone definitely has enough room, and the clones could even help with any work that needs doing once they've adjusted to their new reality.'

"Say it. You know you want to. Bring her into it. Antagonise her."

No, I won't. Get out of my head!

"Address her directly, see how she responds. You know you want to..."

'Adora, are you okay?' Glimmer asked. It then occurred to me that I had been staring at Catra while having an argument with a figment of my imagination.

'Yeah, I'm fine...' The curiosity won. 'What do *you* think, Catra?'

I watched as Catra's ears twitched in my direction before I had even finished saying her name. She quickly sat bolt upright, eyes wide, and looked me in the eye for the first time in days. 'Uh...' She was caught off guard, but didn't look angry... 'I um- I guess it's fine? I don't really care what happens to that place.' She said, confidence returning as she folded her arms over her chest and leant back in her chair. What was that about? Was she not mad? I sat down again slowly, pondering.

'Okay. That settles that then.' Glimmer concluded the discussion and Bow removed the hologram of the ship from the table, looking between me and Catra as he did. 'There is one more thing I need to announce before I can let you all go. On the day of the crash, I met with Princess Frosta in the Kingdom of Snows at her request. She has asked that her kingdom be allowed to host the Princess Prom again, in a couple weeks' time.'

A few excited gasps sounded from around the table, and I found myself leaning forward to listen better. Is this what Glimmer meant by an opportunity to propose? But with the way Catra and I are now... that line of thinking stirred an uneasy feeling in my gut. Catra would surely say no if I asked her outright. But she said it’s in two weeks… maybe I can make up with Catra again in that time…

That train of thought was interrupted as Glimmer continued, 'I know that this breaks two of the conventions of the Princess Prom. The first, is that it is usually held once every ten years. The last one was only three years ago, but it was also cut short by the antics of two people who are sitting at this table today.' I watched as Scorpia's smile faltered and she shrunk into her chair. Catra didn't seem to be affected. 'Also, the Prom would normally be held in a different kingdom each time, but that also relates back to the

previous one being cut short. Frosta would like a redo, a “Princess Prom 2.0”, if you will, where she wants to see it through to completion. However, she has also made the point that she is doing away with the mile-long instruction manual as she said it was painful to play along with the last time. So this Prom is more about having fun than upholding the tradition, and honestly, it sounds awesome! Are we all in favour?'

I heard a combination of: 'That would be lovely.' 'Hell yeah!' You know I am!' 'Absolutely.' 'I guess.' Spoken from around the table. Catra, Scorpia and I remained silent, until...

'I just want to say, I am *so sorry* for how the last one ended. That was seriously not cool on our end. It had been such a fun time too, huh wildcat?' Scorpia ventured, seeking a response from the feline across the table where she was trying to disappear into her chair.

'Yeah, I guess it was pretty fun until...you know...' I caught her glance over to me briefly. 'Sorry for messing it up, and for, you know, kidnapping you guys...'

'No hard feelings, right Glimmer?' Bow spoke up for the first time during the meeting in an attempt to lessen any potential blow from the reminder of what followed that kidnapping. 'You're a part of the Best Friend Squad now, Catra. And Scorpia, you're officially a princess in the Princess Alliance, and a darn good friend.'

Glimmer nodded along while he spoke. 'Of course. There are no hard feelings on our end and this Prom will be chance to heal those old memories with new ones. Frosta would have been here to announce it herself, but unfortunately she had some business to attend to.' Glimmer looked at me pointedly, as if I should somehow know what she was talking about. 'Okay! With that, this meeting is officially adjourned. Thank you all for coming. Oh! I almost forgot; you will all receive an invitation shortly. A *much shorter* invitation.'

Once it was clear the meeting was finished, everyone started standing up to leave. I noticed Catra immediately reaching over to Melog. As soon as her hand rested on top of their head, they both disappeared from their place at the table.

After Catra vanished, Glimmer suddenly appeared at my side. Before I knew what was happening, I was standing in an unfamiliar bedroom, but the cushions and duvet on the bed were arranged in a... in a nest. *Catra.* This was Catra's bedroom.

'I can't take this anymore!' Glimmer really did try not to shout. *Bless her*. 'Adora, Catra isn't mad at you! Well, she was, but she isn't now so just get yourself together and talk to her! You're both such stubborn disasters!'

I scoffed, looking around the darkness of the room. It was barely furnished and definitely did not look inviting or lived in, but then Catra had only been sleeping here a few days. 'Glimmer, you and Bow told me multiple times that she doesn't want to talk to me. What do you want from me?'

'We said that because that's all she says! Bow and I are convinced that she's just waiting for you to talk to her, and you're waiting for her to talk to you. So, unless I literally trap you in a room together, this stalemate is never going to end. Well, here I am, ending it! When she gets here, talk to her. If she leaves, I'll bring her back. I'm sick of this. Bow is sad. I'm sad. It's not nice watching your friends fight over literally nothing.'

'I don't think it's nothing...'

'It feels like nothing... anyway. Here, these came for you. You *and* Catra.' Glimmer handed over two letters. The one on top looked crinkled and battered. I glanced back up at Glimmer questioningly.

'What are these?' I asked, confusion and surprise evident in my voice.

'Letters, Adora... Catra really isn't wrong about you being slow. They're from Frosta. There's more to why she wasn't here today. Read them, show them to Catra, and *talk*.' And with that, Glimmer teleported from the room.

I sighed and sat down on the end of the bed before opening the first of the letters.

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Muscles-for-brains and Stupid Face,

Get your butts over here before Prom 2.0, Glimmer already accepted for you, so suck it.

Ask for Greybeard at the Inn. Wear disguises.

Frosta

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I read through the letter a few more times, marvelling at its lack of usable information, before putting it down next to me on the bed and looking at the second of the two. This one was much tidier, professionally sealed, with impeccable handwriting.

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Princess Adora & Royal Advisor Catra,

I hope this letter finds you well.

You will no doubt be aware by now that the Princess Prom 2.0 has been announced, with all the Princesses invited once again.

However, there are suspicious forces at work under the ice of the kingdom. I fear those that oppose Princess Frosta's rule have made plans to usurp her from the throne.

We believe that the recent announcement of the Princess Prom has delayed what plans they may have had, but our suspicions remain. They may try something else on or before the day of the Prom itself.

Therefore, the Princess should like to request that you come to the Kingdom of Snows with haste. The sooner you can come, the better, for she needs your help to root out those that wish to melt the ice from under her.

Once you arrive, ask for 'Greybeard' at the Glistening Icicle Inn.

Iceric
Royal Advisor to Princess Frosta

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Just as I finished reading Iceric's letter, the door to the bedroom burst open. I didn't have to look up to see who was standing there, because I could see her ears and tail in the shadow cast by the light from the hallway behind her, framing her form in the doorway on the floor. Before I had chance to even think of what to say I could feel the tears forming in my eyes. Was I mad at her? I couldn't remember. I honestly didn't care anymore. Just the feeling of her staring at me across the room, just the two of us, not part of some act, was enough to reduce me to tears.

After what felt like an age, I folded the letter back up and placed it next to Frosta's on the bed before wiping my eyes with the heels of my hands. I was then suddenly aware that the door had closed and I glanced up in a sudden panic, expecting Catra to be gone - but she wasn't. She was watching me, her eyes glowing in the gloom.

'Catra...' Was all I managed to say before a shuddering breath rocked through me and gave way to sobbing. Catra was on me immediately, surrounding me, holding me, her hands stroking my back, her breath hot on my shoulder. Something within me broke, and all the pent-up emotion, turmoil, and distress I felt over the last few days came pouring out before I could stop it.

'Catra... I'm sorry, I- I don't... I miss you- I can't... I need... I need you! I've been so lonely! I've- I've hardly slept... I can't sleep with you gone, and I just- I just want you there with me, all the time and it's- I'm just so sad but you didn't- you didn't want to see me and it hurt and... I- I- Catra... I'm sorry about what I said, I'm sorry. You- you were right, I should have listened but I didn't... you- the magic, you don't want it but I don't know what to do or how to make you not hate me anymore...' My rambling eventually gave way to stuttering sobs, and I cried into Catra's shoulder freely, feeling the weight of the last few days ebbing away with each tear that rolled down my face.

'Oh, you beautiful idiot.' Catra whispered, her voiced laced with emotion.

'Wha...?' I asked, dumbly, leaning back slightly to look at her face and only vaguely aware of the snot dripping from my nose.

'Look...' Catra continued, easing one arm out from behind me so could wipe her own eyes. 'I was mad at you. I was. I'm sorry for how I took it out on you, but running is all I know, and I couldn't just leave so... I guess I pushed you away. Your friends are stupidly supportive, by the way.' She chuckled lightly and tucked a loose strand of my hair behind back behind my ear before kneeling on the ground and looking at up me, her hands holding onto my waist as if I might float away.

After I didn't say anything and just stared down at her, Catra took a deep breath and looked me in the eye. 'Listen, there's more to what's bothering me than the magic. I don't even really care about you babying me, not really, I just... I'm not used to it, I guess, so I lashed out. Again, I'm sorry about that. But please,

when I say there's more on my mind, don't push me, okay?' I nodded, willing to accept any terms, and willing to wait for Catra to trust me with more of herself. 'I promise I'll tell you about it soon. It's about... It's- ugh. I'm no good at this stuff. Listen, Adora... I love you, okay? I do. I've been horrible, and I know that, and you're obviously upset so... I'll make it up to you. I promise.' Catra's voice sounded so *nice*, just hearing it was enough to calm me down. But *something* in the back of my mind told me this didn't add up, why was she saying all of this now, after leaving me to wallow for days with no hints or anything?

'Why?' Was all I managed to ask.

Catra frowned, her gaze searching. 'What do you mean?'

'Why now?' I reiterated.

Her shoulders slumped and she looked down at the floor, her grip loosening around my waist ever-so-slightly. 'When I saw you in here, I knew you couldn't have arrived before me unless Sparkles... I've hardly slept either, you know? You're like a furnace and I... I missed it, I guess. Missed you. So when I saw you here, I just thought, *screw it*, enough's enough. I pushed you away for so long before and I'm so sorry I did it again, Adora. I... I'm sorry there's so much wrong with me, you deserve so much better but - I know that, for whatever reason, I'm what you want. I do. I want you too, so I'm sorry that-'

'Catra.' I spoke firmly, cutting her off from her rambling and cupping her face in my hands. 'Stop apologising.' I let my fingers trail over the soft fur of her cheeks, my heart sinking when I felt how damp they were. But then I felt myself coming back to my senses and *something* told me that I needed to leave. I steeled myself and spoke as flatly as I could. 'Read the letters. Frosta needs our help. We have to plan and get ready to leave for the Kingdom of Snows.'

I rose from the bed quickly, mourning the loss of her hands on me while stepping around her, making straight for the door.

The feelings that stirred within me were confusing, conflicted. It felt like I didn't want to leave but I also felt so sure about it.

I shouldn't leave. I should talk.

'Adora?'

"You're sorry. You need time to think. It's a lot, and you've had a long day."

I stopped and looked back. Catra was standing now, her eyes pleading, her face showing such raw emotion that it took everything within me not to run over and just hold her. I missed her, I was angry with her, I was sorry; so many thoughts were twirling around in my head that I had to I close my eyes for a moment to block them out and stop myself from crying again. 'I'm sorry, Catra. I need to time to think. This is a lot, and I've had a long day.'

'... Okay.' Her voice sounded small, defeated, but understanding.

'I'll see you tomorrow.' I said, turning the door handle and opening it slowly, wincing at the light from the hallway as it forced its way into the room.

'Adora, wait!' I heard Catra take a step forward. I stopped, but didn't look back. 'Can I... can I sleep with you? In your bed? I-I miss you, and I hate this room. It's not yours, it doesn't smell like you...'

"Refuse her. Leave."

I sighed a shuddering breath, fighting down the tears welling up. I could already tell that I would be crying myself to sleep as soon as I got into my bed. Something within me gave, and I took off my jacket. It was a *no*, but not a complete rejection. I knew the scent on it would help her sleep, at least. I chucked it towards Catra, vaguely aware of where it landed between us.

"Leave!"

'Goodnight, Catra.' I spoke as clear and flat as I could while fighting back tears and stepped through the doorway. As I closed it behind me, I caught a glimpse of Catra on her knees, clutching the jacket tight to her chest and silently crying into it.

Wait for me.

Chapter End Notes

Would love to hear your thoughts on what happened in this one!

Next chapter is *next* Saturday, June 5th.
See you then for the beginning of the second-to-last arc of the story set in the Kingdom of Snows!

Conspir-ice-y

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra venture into the Kingdom of Snows and meet with their contact, "Greybeard".

Chapter Notes

This chapter is one of my favourites and is also the longest so far.
Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Come the end of the war, the Kingdom of Snows was by far the largest of all the kingdoms of Etheria, seconded by the Fright Zone, Underdryl, then Bright Moon. Of course, the main difference between the Fright Zone and the Kingdom of Snows is that the Fright Zone was sparsely populated by comparison. Over the course of the war, especially over the last few years, all manner of folk moved to brave the arctic climate in favour of staying out of the Horde's way, much preferring to wear ankle-length, fur-lined coats than be subjected to a war that claimed all in its path. Of course, being a princess, Frosta was not going to turn anyone anyway or check that they were who they said they were. Such things seemed trivial, unimportant, unthinkable in a time of war. Who would lie to breach the safety of a once-neutral kingdom whose ruler was barely an adult?

The answer: those with nothing to lose, and everything to gain.

Catra made that grim observation during our first actual talk the day after the Alliance meeting, remarking at how she knew the feeling all too well. Knowing that I had a hand in making her feel that way, I had ushered the conversation toward what our disguises would be. Catra opted for a hooded brown cloak over the top of a simplistic purple and pink dress. I could scarcely believe she had even suggested that for her disguise, but when

she pointed out that was, in fact, the whole point of a disguise, it all made sense.

My disguise, by comparison, was far less showy than Catra's. Dull grey and brown pants and shirt, with a tattered and frayed purple jacket. When Catra pointed out that I looked ridiculous, I told her to hold that thought and far-too-eagerly pulled out a ridiculously ornate, carved wooden box, the image of a boat gliding toward a roaring sea-serpent engraved into the lid. Catra eyed the box suspiciously as I slowly prised it open. Then, beaming, I presented my prize for helping Sea Hawk with his romantic adventure: my own fake moustache.

Catra was not impressed.

I was.

Having to plan this trip with Catra was... weird. There were obviously mountains of things we both wanted to say to each other, but I couldn't bring myself to mention it and Catra, in turn, also avoided the topic entirely.

By the time we were ready to leave, bags packed with our disguises and huge, winter coats ready and waiting, Catra and I were back to talking as normal. Well... normal in the sense that we could have conversations. We still hadn't slept in the same bed since the day of the Dreadnought crash, Catra hadn't been teasing or flirting with me at all, and we hadn't even said "I love you" even once. The last time was in Catra's room when she said it to me. Back then, I hadn't said it back, and it still remained unspoken. Whenever I was alone, Prime would remind me of it mercilessly.

"You've pushed her away for the last time."

"She'll never forgive you."

"Your Catra... well, she's not yours anymore, is she?"

"How does it feel to lose the one person who ever, truly, loved you?"

"You abandoned her again, leaving her to cry alone *in darkness."*

After a while, I started to wonder if he was right...

Glimmer didn't recognise the name of the inn Frosta's advisor had given us, so instead she opted to drop us off at the entrance to the kingdom and let us find our way from there. It made sense, technically, for us to enter through the front, especially if we were to keep up the guise that we weren't members of the Princess Alliance sent to dismantle a group that wanted to dethrone a personal friend from her birth-right.

Of course, something we had somehow managed to completely gloss over when planning and discussing how to go about this was the *shape* of the kingdom. Yes, its shape. The Kingdom of Snows was built around a mountain, with various levels connected to one another by what looked like little rooms suspended by cables or incredibly dangerous-looking routes and pathways that were all almost entirely covered by snow.

Safe to say, the majority of people, including us, it turned out, lined up to take the - I squinted to read the sign through the blizzard - *"cable carriage"* between the various levels of the Kingdom of Snows.

Catra and I were entirely covered by our fur-lined, almost floor length winter coats. Our hoods were up and we both had a scarf wrapped around the lower half of our faces. Wearing clothes that entirely covered me and my face, while also being buffeted by a relentless blizzard, made me wonder why exactly the disguises were needed. It took far too long, but I eventually realised that *the indoors* existed and this wintery weather wouldn't follow us into it.

I, very suddenly and very desperately, wanted to be somewhere warm and not snowy. Somewhere safe and soft, fluffy and

purring...

Okay, yes, I had been thinking non-stop about sleeping in the same bed as Catra ever since she asked me if she could a few days ago. I kicked past-me for refusing, but I knew that in the moment it wasn't what I needed. Or, at least, I don't think it was. My endless pile of thoughts and feelings had needed sorting through first. And now, as we finally reached the front of the line for the cable carriage, I wished for nothing more than just to hold Catra in my arms again.

I'd be lying if I said I didn't almost immediately fall over upon entering the carriage, a combination of tripping on the step up and being woefully unprepared for how it would tilt under my weight. Catra held out a steadying arm, catching me before I could make an absolute fool of myself and potentially blow the cover we were trying to keep up. Catra kept holding on to my arm as she led me towards the front, sitting me down in a window seat before taking the one next to it. She pushed herself up against me to let someone else squeeze past, and suddenly I found I was much too warm to be wearing such a big coat.

It had nothing to do with Catra.

...Fine.

It had something *to do with Catra.*

But it was also due to the carriage slowly filling with people, all of which were wearing huge coats, and whose presence only served to warm up the interior. I watched as condensation crept up the windows, almost entirely blocking out the snow that clung to them from the outside.

Catra and I had promised each other before setting out that no matter what, the coats and hoods were to stay up and on until we got to wherever it was we were going. Then, once we had a moment to ourselves, we would fully implement our disguises.

I pulled on the scarf around my face a little, so I could breathe a bit more freely for a moment, and decided to take the opportunity to check in with Catra.

'How are you doing?'

'Fine.'

Okay. Better than nothing. 'We're in the right carriage, aren't we? That... *person* we asked for directions didn't seem entirely sure they wanted to tell us where to go to find the Inn.'

'Yes, it's correct. Even if it's not, we'll just keep asking around. Would it have killed them to give us at least *some* directions?' Catra took off her (adorable) mittens and rubbed her hands together for warmth. I watched as she stretched out her claws and set to picking bits of fluff out from under them. I swallowed thickly at the sight of her extended claws, looking away before my mind could go somewhere that would be decidedly unsavoury considering the setting.

Too late.

Images of Catra pushing me to the bed, straddling me, putting her hands on me and licking up my torso had suddenly started playing on loop in my head. That was the last time anything remotely intimate had happened between us, right before the crash, and I missed it terribly.

A sudden jolt shook the carriage, wrenching me from my unwelcome (yet not entirely unpleasant) daydream. We were moving, steadily descending down to the lowest level of the Kingdom of Snows.

The trip in the cable carriage was long, boring, and silent. After Catra finished cleaning her claws, she double checked that her ears and tail were still hidden, then reluctantly put her mittens back on. When we neared the end of the line, I also fixed my scarf and prepared myself for the biting chill of the blizzard.

When we stepped out into the cold, part of me was relieved to discover that the wind was not nearly as strong down here as it had been higher up. On the lowest level, what was a blizzard up high was simply a curtain of thick snow. Still hard to see through, but not biting as we trudged our way through the ankle-deep white carpet that had already settled.

The other folk who had been in the car with us filed out and strode purposely in various directions, leaving Catra and I standing there looking very clearly lost.

'Which way?' I attempted to ask; my voice muffled by the scarf. Luckily though, without the wind, my voice seemed to carry enough for Catra to hear me.

'How should I know?' She sounded tired, fed up. 'I just want to get out of the cold.'

'Yeah, me too...' I mumbled, before choosing a direction at random and walking down it. I half expected Catra to protest, but upon looking back I saw that she was following a few steps behind.

The streets were mostly empty, quiet, and through the haze of relentlessly falling snow I could just make out the light from windows shining through cracks in the shutters that covered them. Some of the buildings looked to be igloos, made of snow and compact ice, but those that were made of wood looked incredibly warm and inviting. There was hardly anyone else around, which gave the whole street a very eerie, unsettling

atmosphere, especially when compared with the bustling town above that seemed to be thriving despite their blizzard. Down here though, the snow just kept falling calmly, without a care or worry in the world.

'Adora... hey, Adora...' Catra whispered my name and I stopped in my tracks, turning around on the spot to look back at her. I could see her eyes perfectly well through the fog of snow and followed them to see what she was looking at. We were standing next to a two-story wooden building, caked in snow except around the windows which seemed to glow with the warmth from within. Sure enough, above us, a sign creaked slowly back and forth, hanging off of a wooden pole. It was emblazoned with the image of an icicle, painted in bright blues and white, and seemed to be shining.

The Glistening Icicle Inn.

Of course I had almost walked right past it.

'Is this the place?' I shot the question out there without thinking, and immediately realised that I set myself up for Catra to make fun of me. But, to my surprise, no teasing came. Instead, she turned toward the door and stomped up the wooden steps.

'It better be.' Catra muttered as she pushed open the door and stepped inside. I immediately felt a rush of warm air hit me where I stood out on the street and rushed to follow her in.

Relief and warmth surrounded me as I crossed the threshold into the lobby of the Inn. It was quite, surprisingly, quaint. For some reason, with the eerie vibe I had convinced myself existed outside, I expected the place to look almost abandoned, dangerous, or spooky, even. But it was none of that. Instead, as we shook off the snow from our boots and crossed the wooden floor, covered by a thick blue carpet, I looked around to find only warmth. Lamps lined the walls, casting the whole place in a cosy orange light.

To the right, a few tables were set up in an arrangement spreading out from the fireplace which looked incredibly inviting. I could all too easily imagine Catra curled up in front of it, dozing happily within the heat it provided.

To the left, a staircase led up to the next level, but a corridor stretched away below it. I noticed it was lined with doors to private rooms and I found myself wondering if we would be staying in one of them.

In front of us, behind what I initially thought to be just a front desk but also doubled as a bar, a rather muscular, incredibly pale man wearing simple clothes and a purple apron was ferociously cleaning his way through a row of glasses that he had lined up in front of him.

Catra walked straight up to the bar and, if she weren't wearing a huge winter coat she would've looked incredibly intimidating while doing it, growled at the man to get his attention.

'Is this the Glistening Icicle Inn?' She asked, sounding far too angry for such a simple question. I hoped he wouldn't take offence to her tone, as the lousy weather we had to trudge through to get there was mostly to blame for it.

'Who wants to know?' He asked, unbothered by Catra and without looking away from his task.

'We're supposed to meet someone here, by the name of Greybeard.' I supplied, walking up behind Catra and placing a hand to the small of her back. It wasn't as effective as I'd hoped through the thickness of the coats and gloves, but she seemed to get the message. *Calm down.*

The man, who I was assuming to be the Innkeeper, grumbled quietly while reaching down below the bar. He planted something down onto it before looking back at us. A key. Strung onto it was a small square of varnished wood engraved with the number 12.

'Your room is up the stairs. You're to wait there.' He muttered, before quickly going back to his task.

I tried not to focus too hard on the thought of finally sleeping in the same room as Catra again, and definitely did not hope to find that there would only be one bed in the room. Catra took off her mittens and picked the key up off the bar, examining it quickly before huffing and moving off towards the stairs. I followed behind, smiling at the innkeeper before I remembered I still had my mouth covered by the scarf and he couldn't see my face.

'Okay,' Catra began as we put our bags down on our respective beds and started removing the huge snow-caked coats, 'remind me of the plan.'

I frowned, confused. Looking over at Catra from where I stood at the end of what Catra had deemed to my bed in this small, two single-bed room. 'It's *your* plan. Why do you need me to remind you what it is?'

'I'm making sure *you* know what it is, prin-' She quickly covered her mouth and coughed to cover the slip.

It may be worth mentioning that Catra also hadn't called me by any nicknames since the day of the crash either. I ached for it, desperate to cling to some familiarity. Judging by her slip-up, Catra must be conflicted on it too, going along with her own stubbornness despite wanting to talk a few days prior.

I swallowed the words I wanted to say, and instead forced myself to relay our plan. 'We meet with Greybeard, whoever they are,

and hear what they have to say. Then, depending on what they say, we either act on it or we ask around to see if any of the locals know anything. If that doesn't work, we make some noise and draw out the gang forcefully. I'm still not sure what you mean by that, and I don't know if I want to.'

'Leave that to me.' Catra shimmied out of her thermal pants after discarding the boots and set to getting her disguise out of her bag.

I tore my eyes away, not sure if she would be comfortable with me staring or not. Were we still together? We hadn't exactly been affectionate recently but Catra hadn't made any indication that we *weren't* together anymore. That line of thought began to form a knot in my stomach and I fought the nausea that came with it, instead occupying my mind with removing my own warm layers and replacing them with the drab disguise I had prepared a couple of days beforehand.

It felt nice to be wearing relatively light, soft clothes again. That coat really had been heavy.

I swallowed the uneasy feeling rising in my throat, and instead tried to smile as best I could, turning to face Catra once I was sure she had finished changing. 'How do I look?'

Catra eyes regarded me with nothing but indifference, but I could see the flicks of her tail below her dress giving her away. She was conflicted too. 'At least you're not wearing a red jacket for once. And aren't you putting that *thing* on your upper lip?'

'Oh yeah!' I gasped, fumbling around in the bag looking for the box with the fake moustache inside.

'Also, don't forget to change your hair, at least a little. Put that hat on too.'

'Catra, why would I wear a sun-hat indoors during a snowstorm?'

'I don't know, Adora, why would you put your hair up when you look perfectly good with it down?'

I looked up at that and caught the redness on Catra's cheeks before she huffed and quickly turned away, opting instead to stare out of the window at the falling snow.

'Catra...' I began, briefly abandoning my task of finding the box, 'if you want to talk... I'm here. I'm ready if you want to. I'm sorry that I left before when you were ready. I wasn't then, but I am now. I promise. I don't want to keep-'

'Enough, Adora. Just... finish getting ready.'

'Catra?'

'Adora!' I stopped, realising I had been reaching out toward her and pulled my hand back slowly. The contents of my bag suddenly looked really interesting. 'Just... let me think. This whole thing has been a mess, and I don't want to mess it- mess *us* up again.'

'Okay.' I breathed, barely a whisper. Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Catra's ear flick. She heard me.

After a moment, I took a deep breath before continuing my search for the box. Catra stayed by the window the whole time and didn't look round when I exclaimed a victorious *"aha!"* upon finding said box. I wordlessly applied the moustache to my face, brought out the redundant sun hat, and sat on my bed before scooching up to rest against the headboard.

It became increasingly clear as the seconds passed that the moustache probably wasn't going to work, mainly due to the fact that every time I breathed out my nose or even slightly moved my upper lip it tickled like crazy.

Barely able to control my own giggling at how ridiculous I felt versus how ridiculous I must have looked; I was woefully unprepared for the eventuality of Catra turning around. As soon as she saw me, the dam broke, and we both immediately gave in

to fits of laughter that had us doubling over. Every time our hysterics died down, Catra would look up at me again, try so hard to keep a straight face and fail miserably every time - which only set me off again.

Eventually, my laughing subsided to soft hums as I tried to control myself. When I opened my eyes, I realised that Catra had managed to sit down on her own bed. She looked at me with an incredibly soft expression, immediately shutting down my brain and spreading warmth across my cheeks. She hadn't looked at me like that, with those eyes, in too long.

Noticing my sudden shift in expression as my eyes met hers, Catra suddenly sat up straighter, looking sheepish as if she's been caught stealing food from the palace kitchen. Again.

'Look, Adora...' she began, suddenly finding the flicker of the lamp in the room to be the most interesting thing in existence. I tried not to feel jealous of a lamp, I really did. 'I... I do still mean what I said. That night. I hate this, and I know it's mostly my fault but-'

'What I don't understand,' I began, surprised by my sudden confidence but letting the words flow before I could stop myself from saying what I wanted to, 'is why you've been able to talk to me about so much else, but whatever caused this... rift, you never mentioned. Why, Catra? What is it?'

I watched as she shifted uncomfortably on the bed, her ears pinning back (embarrassment? Nerves?). Her tail thudded loud on the bed behind her. Catra grabbed at it, stopping it from thrashing and held it close. *Nerves.*

'It's because...' she started, taking a moment to try and find the words, 'all those things... they're the past. They've happened. You were there for a lot of it, and for what you weren't there for, I've told you about. You know me, maybe more than I know myself. But to me, compared with... the past is easy to talk about compared with what hasn't happened yet. What's to come. The future... *our* future.'

Oh.

I hadn't expected her to be quite so forward in her partial confession of what's been bothering her but-

Oh.

It actually made sense.

I'd been worrying about nothing *but that* ever since the Moon Market. Our future. It hinges on a question, doesn't it? One she knows about, one I hadn't asked yet, one she... expects? In trying to find the right moment, in waiting to make sure everything would be perfect had I... had I actually managed to form this rift of uncertainty myself?

Actions speak louder than words.

We both spent our whole life being lied to, manipulated, controlled by words we were convinced had meaning. We were convinced that *she* actually cared for us, because she told us she did.

Catra needs the promise.

Saying "I love you" is no longer enough.

She thinks I don't mean it.

It's starting to rattle around her head, losing its meaning, day by day. Just like *her* words did.

I hadn't realised but... she *needs* it.

Catra needs to know just how much I care for her, how much I *need her too,* before it's too late and she convinces herself that it's a fluke, that I was just using her like *she* did.

'Okay.'

'What?'

I smiled as Catra turned to look at my again, her eyes searching my face. 'Okay.' I repeated, grounding the acknowledgment in reality.

She must have found what she was looking for on my face, because her ears perked up again and the ghost of a smile appeared on her lips. 'Okay.'

A knock at the door shook us from our trace and Catra leapt up, claws out ready to defend, and cautiously made her way over to see who had knocked. I took the opportunity to grab my belt from my bag, setting it down on the nightstand next to my bed and watching the golden metal of the wing glow softly in the low light.

A reminder.

I decided, in that moment, that I would propose during the Prom, and a heavy weight lifted off of my shoulders.

Or, it did, until I saw Horde Prime standing at the window, right where Catra had been just minutes before.

"Why would she ever say yes to you?" He spat, unmoving. I noticed there was no reflection of him in the window. A true apparition of my mind. *"Why would she devote her life to you, who so casually toys with her feelings? Are you blind to what you have done to her?"*

But she just said-

"I know what she said. But, it's too late, she's fooling herself. The damage is done. You don't want her and deep down, she believes it."

But I do want her-

"Does she want you? Really? You pushed her away, again. Left her, again. She'll come to her senses soon and refuse you your oh so beautiful *wish. It was always going to go this way. You*

don't deserve *happiness, and you yourself have ensured that you will* never *have it."*

The sound of our room's door closing caught my attention, and I looked over to see Catra walking back over to the beds. Her expression was firm, her eyebrows furrowed in concentration as her mind raced at a mile a minute.

'Time to go, they're here.' She said simply, reaching into her bag to pull out a pair of elbow-length fingerless purple gloves.

'Greybeard? Here? Where?'

'Downstairs, in the dining area. I think they've paid off the owner or something. There's no one else here, and there won't be, because the doors have been locked and the windows downstairs shuttered and sealed.' Catra slipped the gloves up her arms, flexing her fingers to make sure they sat comfortably. She wasn't wearing shoes, but you couldn't tell with her feet hidden below the hem of her dress.

'Okay.' I shot up off the bed, briefly discarding my hat so that I could re-do my ponytail and tie it lower down than I would usually and, regretfully, releasing the hairpoof to let my bangs frame my face instead. 'How's that?' I asked, turning back to Catra, fiddling with loose strands of hair over my forehead.

Catra moved forward and batted my hand away, sorting the loose hairs herself until she was satisfied. 'For the record, *any* hairstyle you do that isn't the hairpoof is a winner in my books.'

'Noted.'

'You ready?'

I replaced the hat on my head, noting how it sat much more evenly without the hairpoof in place. 'Yeah, I'm ready.'

Catra nodded and moved toward the door again and I followed close behind, ignoring the urge to look back toward the window

where I knew *he* was still standing. Watching. Staring.

It's just in my head...

Once we descended the stairs and crossed the foyer, entering the Inn's dining area, Catra and I immediately noticed the two figures seated at separate tables. One appeared to be a guard from Frosta's castle, complete with long blue coat and jewelled mask. They sat at one of the tables across the room from the fireplace, with an ice spear leaning against the wall behind them. The other figure occupied a table closer to the fireplace. They looked quite short, wore blue boots and a thick blue and white coat, and had a big grey beard that heavily contrasted their young features and short cropped blue hair with a tiara of ice-

'It's just Frosta.' Catra observed plainly. 'Frosta with a beard. Hey, what kind of game-'

Catra's rant was cut short by the sound of Frosta suddenly bursting out with laughter and thumping the table with one hand while pointing at us with the other. 'You...!' She cut herself off with another bout of laughter, the sound echoing through the rest of the Inn. 'You both look ridiculous!' She wheezed as her laughing subsided enough for her to form actual words.

'Well, duh!' Catra shouted, visibly annoyed. I watched her claws extend and fur stand on end as she fully prepared to launch herself at the younger Princess. 'You told us to wear disguises! So we're here - in disguises! And all you're wearing is a dumb beard!'

'I'll have you know, stupid face, that this is an extremely well-crafted dumb beard.' Frosta leant back in her chair and crossed her arms. If we could've seen her mouth, I had no doubt that

there would have been a smug smile there. I did notice, however, that she was sitting on a couple of pillows so she could be at the right height for the table.

'Catra, it's alright.' I said, emphasising the reassurance by placing a hand on her shoulder.

'How is it alright? We both look ridiculous and it's all just part of some idiotic game concocted by the Princess of Brain Freezes.'

'Hey-!'

A cough from the other table broke through the building tension of the room and all heads turned to look at the guard sat at the other table.

'Princess Frosta,' he said, his voice calm yet stern, 'we do not have long. We must soon return to the castle.'

Frosta turned back to face us and removed her beard, placing it down carefully on the table. Her expression then shifted and she took a deep breath, before looking up at us with more determination than I've ever seen her wear. 'Adora, Catra, please - take a seat.'

Catra and I shared a *look* and had a silent conversation that went something like this:

Who's that guy?

I have no idea. Since when could Frosta get all serious like this?

You tell me, I still can't believe she punched me with an ice-fist.

Get over it.

She'll get her dues.

Catra!

And then we sat down at the table.

'So, chilly pipsqueak, who's your friend?' Catra asked, nodding toward the guard who had managed to singlehandedly move this whole thing along.

'Oh, that's Iceric, my advisor. He's *actually* in disguise.'

Catra looked incredulous. 'What? Why? Shouldn't you be in disguise too?'

'I am, I have the *beard.* Anyway, that's not important. What is important is that ever since I returned to my kingdom, it's become increasingly clear that there's a group of baddies wanting me gone. Like, out, off the throne. *Gone* gone.'

'Why? Who would do something like this?' I asked. I could feel my temper rising at the absurdity of what was happening. Frosta was nice, a good ruler, and I couldn't understand why anyone would wish for her to leave or to potentially cause her harm.

'We don't know. Everything was fine while I was off helping you guys and the rest of the princesses defend the world, but now that I'm back... Iceric's men have managed to track them to this level of the mountain, so we know they're here. Somewhere.'

'Any hints?' Catra leant forward, voice low and no longer mocking or jovial. Instead she looked calculating, focused, ready to take down a gang of ne'er-do-wells and so, so hot. 'What kind of things have they pulled already?'

'Theft of goods, food. Property damage. Threatening people who support me... hmm.' Frosta tapped her chin thoughtfully and turned to look at her advisor. 'Have I missed anything, Iceric?'

He cleared his throat before rising from his seat and crossing his arms behind his back. 'There have been some reports of people going missing, Princess, and those that have... they've yet to be found.'

'Oh yeah, that too. Basically they've threatened that unless I step down as ruler of the Kingdom of Snows they're going to keep

causing mischief. Recently, it's been getting more common and the thefts and damage have been more frequent and bolder than before. I've made my position clear: I will not give in to threats and violence!' Frosta slammed her fist into the table and a halo of ice surrounded it. I felt a chill go up my spine and shivered. 'That's why we announced the Prom, we figure it'll give them something to plan for where I'll be "vulnerable", also we get to have a party with all our friends too.'

I frowned, considered everything, then asked: 'What do you need from us?'

'You guys are my secret weapon. Hopefully, you were able to get here with no-one noticing who you are, which really isn't difficult considering everyone wears these *huge* coats all the time. I don't see why, cause it's not that cold, but anyway... I need you to poke around and see if you can find anything. Ideally, find out who the leader is. If we can get the leader then-'

'The whole thing will crumble.' Catra finished. She caught my eye and shot me a toothy grin, fangs and all. I smiled back, silently wanting nothing more than to kiss that grin off her face.

'Exactly, think you can do it?' Frosta asked, looking between the two of us.

'No problem, snowflake. Hey - is it alright if I bring in someone of my own? Outside help?' There was a glint in Catra's eye, a confidence. Who does she know who can help? Someone from the Horde, maybe?

'I don't see why not. Just try and keep your cover for as long as possible, if they know She-Ra is snooping we may miss our chance to catch them.'

'Hey!' Catra rose from her seat, 'what about me?'

Frosta actually laughed at that and looked Catra in the eye. 'Barely anyone in this kingdom knows your stupid face, stupid face. Even if they did, you don't exactly look like the *evil* Force

Captain Catra anymore, you look more...' *Cute? Adorable? Floofy?* '... soft.'

'Soft? Is that it? The best you got?'

'Pfft. You've gone soft, it's a fact. Adora's a good influence on you.'

'I don't want to hear this from an eight-year-old.'

'I'm *fifteen and a half*, actually.'

'OoOooOo, sorry, I really care.'

'Well how old are *you?*'

Catra looked at me then, and I could see the question in her eyes before she asked it. 'How old *are* we?'

I scoffed, far too loud, and shook my head. 'I have no idea. If I had to guess... early twenties? Birthdays... they weren't a thing in the Horde, so we don't know when they are and we've never celebrated them before. The first time I even heard the word "birthday" was the first day I met Bow and Glimmer.'

'Huh.' Frosta sat in total silence for a moment, staring at something on the wall behind us as she let that revelation stew for a bit. 'Whatever, we should be going. Don't come up to the castle until the day of the Prom, we can't have anyone suspecting anything.'

'You got it, you can count on us!' I proclaimed with a sudden burst of confidence. Things seemed to be going well, after all. Catra and I were fixing our temporarily wounded relationship, despite Prime's nagging, and we were being trusted with finding a few would-be revolutionaries. The fact that hundreds of Swarm drones were still deactivated in orbit was somewhere at the back of my mind for now, this potential threat was much more immediate.

'Well, duh. That's why I asked for you too. I'm not stupid. I know Catra's good at being sleazy so I figured this would be perfect for her.' Frosta jumped down from her chair and reapplied the beard before putting her hood up and grabbing the cushions she had been sat on. Iceric, who still hadn't sat down, simply picked up his spear and moved toward the door.

'So Adora's just the muscle then?' Catra asked, a huge smug grin plastered to her face.

'Well I wouldn't expect her to figure this out on her own.' Frosta replied, matching the grin while staring me down.

I sputtered for a moment, before finding the perfect defence. 'Hey!'

It may need some work.

'Don't you worry that little brain of yours,' Catra drawled, tapping a claw to my forehead, 'let me do all the thinking.'

'My brain is *not* little!'

'Shh. You'll overheat.'

'As fun as this is to watch,' Frosta interrupted, 'I do have to leave. See you both at Prom.' She turned and pointed a finger at Catra, 'no heat bombs this time!'

'No promises.' Catra quipped with a wink.

Iceric unlocked the door with a pair of his own keys before holding it open ready for Frosta. The chill from outside flooded into the building and I immediately found myself rubbing my arms and shivering. Catra didn't seem as affected by the chill wind, but that's one of the advantages of a fine layer of fur insulating you. Frosta waved and then quickly disappeared out into the cold. Iceric lingered for a moment, looking between Catra and I. He seemed unsure, as if he was about to say something, but gave up

and nodded once before following after the Princess and closing the door behind him.

'Alright.' Catra said while standing up and stretching. 'First things first, I'm shredding this stupid dress.'

'I dunno, it's not that bad.'

'Oh please, I look ridiculous. So do you. She only did this to mess with us, we'll be wearing huge coats the whole time anyway. I knew it didn't make any sense.' Catra started back toward the stairs and I got up to follow behind.

'Hey, who is it you're calling? You mentioned outside help?'

Catra stopped and looked back at me, she seemed unsure, considering. 'Honestly, I don't really want to call them in, but I figure they owe me one.'

'Who is it?'

'Who do we know that's perfect for sneaking around and not getting caught?'

I racked my brain for any of our friends who would be good at this kind of thing. I came up empty, none of our friends are exactly subtle people. 'I don't know, I give up. Who?'

'Double Trouble.'

'Are you sure about this?' I asked, after closing the door to our room and locking it. Double Trouble was a wild card and I was

uneasy about getting them involved, especially considering how Catra's last interaction with them went in Seaworthy.

Catra huffed and marched over to her bed, fiddling with the straps of her dress and working to remove it. 'I am. They're perfect for this kind of thing.'

I frowned as I watched her struggle with the dress, which wasn't surprising really. I had never seen Catra in a dress before and she was obviously not used to taking one off. 'Do you- do you want some help?'

'Ugh!' Catra growled, dropping her hands to her sides and hiding her claws. 'Yes. Just undo it so I can take it off before I *rip* it off and shred it!'

I took off my sunhat and, after chucking it to the side, wordlessly stepped forward, making quick work of the dress and loosening it enough for Catra to easily slip out of. The sparks heating the tips of my fingers as they brushed against her fur tempted me to let my hands linger, just for a moment, but I fought off the feeling, unsure at how Catra would respond. 'How did you even manage to do it up in the first place?'

'I dunno, I just put it on... Glim showed me how to do it up when we picked it out.' She said as she slipped her arms out of the dress and shucked it over her head. Glimmer had helped Catra pick out her disguise, and Bow helped with mine. Although, if he had really gotten his way, I would have been wearing something that showed off my midriff.

'*"Glim"?* Since when do you call Glimmer, "Glim"?' I asked, quirking a brow at Catra's new choice of nickname as I sat down on the edge of my own bed. It was one Bow and I were familiar with, a friendly one as opposed to the usual teasing synonyms the feline opted to refer to the queen as.

'What's up? You jealous?' Catra threw the dress to the floor like it was on fire. She refrained from stomping out the blaze, however,

instead returning to her bag to pick out her red and black bodysuit. It had been a while since Catra wore that particular choice of outfit, usually opting for the more colourful hues of her unofficially official Bright Moon clothes. I tried not to let my eyes linger too long on her partially nude form, but when her eyes flicked over to mine and she didn't protest, I instead worked harder on hiding my glee than looking away.

'No. Not at all, just... you usually call her "sparkles", or "glitter", "twinkle", "confetti"... you're not usually so... *familiar* with her. Friendly. It's nice.' My tone was soft as I watched Catra visibly relax in her old clothes, the familiarity of them washing over her. I had to admit, while the bright and colourful garments of Bright Moon just seem to work for Catra, she did look *good* in darker tones.

'Yeah, well... maybe your friends are rubbing off on me. The Best Friend Squad is contagious, what can I say? Do you have your comm pad?' Catra asked, trying to change the subject while holding out an expectant hand for the tracker pad I knew was in my bag.

'I can't believe you just called it the Best Friend Squad without, like, gagging or something.' I chuckled as I leant over the bed to drag the bag up next to me before rifling through it.

'Shut up. They're... nice, I guess. You have good friends, Adora.' She sat back on her bed when I handed over the tracker pad and I dropped the bag back to the floor. 'I'm glad you had people like that to look after you, after you...' She trailed off as she looked over the device in her hands, her brows furrowing while she looked it over.

'Yeah... they were awesome. They really helped me feel at home, even if it took a while to really feel like home... you okay?' I asked, noticing Catra's scrutinisation of the tablet in her lap.

'Yeah, yeah, just... is this new? It looks nothing like your usual pad. It's purple and says... "E. M. I. L. Y." on the

back. *Emily?'* Catra's questioning gaze looked up at me, scanning my face for any hints.

'Oh! Yeah, it's new. Entrapta sent it over. Something to do with an expansion experiment or... something.' I chuckled lightly, rubbing at the heat on the back of my neck as the embarrassment from forgetting what the tablet was for set in. 'But,' I started again, remembering at least one piece of the puzzle, 'Emily is a computer now. I think? Entrapta plugged her into Dryl so I guess she might be in the tablet too? Maybe that's what she meant...'

'She did *what* to Emily? I thought she loved that bot. Scorpia definitely did, thing followed her everywhere around the Fright Zone.'

'Yeah well she kind of... maybe... melted? During the crash landing. So I guess Entrapta found a way to bring her back? I don't really know the details but- oh! She can speak now!'

'Speak?' Catra deadpanned.

'Yeah! She doesn't just beep and boop anymore.'

'Uh huh.'

'Go on, say "hi". I bet she can hear us.'

'She's listening right now?'

'I don't know, to be honest. Maybe you can ask?'

'Ugh, this is so weird. Your friends are all so weird. Why do I put up with this?'

'Because you *like* me. How embarrassing for you.'

'I do *not* like you.'

The words to retaliate were on the tip of my tongue, the familiarity of the banter setting in almost naturally between us,

but something about those last words struck something in me. Something that grounded me back in reality. Something that made me question: *Does Catra actually not like me right now?*

"Of course she doesn't." Prime's voice answered my thoughts, but I ignored him, or tried to, and instead focused back on Catra.

'Go on, say "Hi".'

'Fine!' Catra barked, holding up the tracker pad a little more and looking at the screen. 'Hi, Emily?'

>> Beep Beep *Boop*. <<

'What?' Catra glanced up at me and quirked a brow as the chipper voice sounded from hidden speakers somewhere on the device.

'I guess she could.' I said, shrugging, while mildly amused at Emily for managing to crack a joke.

'Could what?'

>> Hear you! I am voice activated upon hearing my name. I heard everything after you said "Emily" the first time. But you were having such a lovely conversation, I didn't want to interrupt. <<

Catra seemed unsure of how to proceed with this new development. It occurred to me that if we had been on speaking terms, I would have talked to her for hours about the Emily development, probably about Hordak's observatory too.

'Are you the same Emily that I... y'know... scratched?' Catra looked nervous, sheepishly fidgeting on the spot while the question lingered in the air.

>> I am! <<

She sounded far too happy about that, which seemed to only confuse Catra more. 'Oh, uh...'

>> Do not worry! It shocked me at first, but I know you were just frustrated. I forgive you. <<

'Huh. Forgiven by a voice in a screen. Whaddaya know?' Catra's eyes shone as she looked back up at me. I could tell that deep down, that forgiveness meant a lot to her. Hearing it had lifted another of the many weights Catra had burdened herself with.

I smiled in response, wishing that I could bridge the gap between us and cradle her in my arms but... I still didn't know where we stood with each other. Sure, we were getting along again, but she could just be forcing herself. Getting along with me would be easier for the mission, after all. Maybe once it's over she'll go back to avoiding me, back to leaving me alone, back to leaving the room whenever I walked in.

Something shone in the corner of my eye. Distracted, I turned to seek out its source. My golden wing. Still on the nightstand where I left it. I shook the negativity from my head, wondering how those thoughts had managed to root themselves there at all, and resolved that I would ask her to marry me at the Prom.

Maybe with that question, we could start over, we could heal. Catra would finally know just how much I want her and I, in turn, would know just how much she wants me.

'Adora?'

Catra's voice shook me from my thoughts and I whipped my head back around to catch her looking at me. I winced at the pain the sudden movement elicited in my neck. 'What- what did you say?'

'I asked if you're okay for me to call Double Trouble.'

'Oh uh.. yeah, I am. Only if you think they'll be helpful. I don't want you to put yourself in an uncomfortable position.'

Catra frowned, her eyes narrowing as she scrutinised my face. 'What do you mean?'

'Well...' I looked around the room, seeking a way out from answering that question. But of course, one did not present itself. 'You've told me before, about what they were like. And the last time you saw them, in Seaworthy, it didn't exactly go... well.'

Catra scoffed, 'I can handle them. They manipulate people, I have nothing they can use to manipulate me anymore.' She hauled herself further onto her bed and crossed her legs. 'Look, I can see the questions on your face. I'm not getting into this right now. I can tell you the details later just... trust me, for now. I can handle them.'

'Okay.' I replied. If there's one thing I knew, it's that I will *always* trust Catra. 'I trust you.'

The warmth of the smile Catra gave in response made my heart do a flip in my chest. But my eyes must have lingered on her lips for a fraction too long before I looked back to eyes, because I saw that her warm expression had shifted to one of cocky confidence. The heat *that* look sparked in me was not unfamiliar. She was giving me the "sex face", so of course it would cause desire to begin pooling in my gut. I shifted uncomfortably, clenching my thighs together and willing for it to not be noticeable. Catra could always smell the desire on me, and I didn't want to give her a reason to be even more cocky than she already looked.

If Catra noticed my discomfort at being aroused just from a *look,* she didn't say anything.

'It's probably good that isn't your usual comm pad, it may actually pick up the frequency they use without me needing to fiddle with it.' Catra said, breaking from the impromptu staring match we were accidentally participating in while tapping away on the screen.

'Entrapta made it, so it probably does a lot more than it needs to. Do our regular ones not pick up some frequencies?' I pulled off my boots, shimmying back onto the bed and crossed my legs, idly watching as Catra stared down at the screen in her hands.

'They do not. We had one up on you ever since Entrapta practically re-wired the entire Fright Zone and reversed engineered most of our tech. Secret communication was a walk in the park after that.' I caught the ghost of a smirk on her lips.

'Huh.'

'Yeah. Emily, you still there?'

>> I am incapable of being anywhere else! <<

'Okay... can you scan along the frequency I just input and contact any devices also connected to it.'

>> I sure can! Give me just a sec. <<

Catra looked up at me, she seemed... nostalgic? 'I can hardly believe this is the same robot that rolled around the Fright Zone like an excited puppy.'

'It's not the weirdest thing that's ever happened. I'm just glad she's okay. Seems to be thriving and can control other robots so it's not like she's without a body.' I paused for a moment, considering. Just how much *could* Emily do now?

>> I have found - *one* - other device connected to this frequency. Oooo, shall I call them? <<

Catra *cackled*. 'Go for it, Emily. Scorpia's going to *love* this, I can already tell.'

I beamed at Catra. Just so happy to see her smiling again after what seemed an age of us just scowling at each other across rooms. 'I bet she will. Aren't you going to visit soon?'

'Oh yeah, I almost forgot. I did promise her that, didn't I?' Catra shrugged. 'Ah, I'll talk to her about it at the Prom, she'll definitely be there.'

'I really hope nothing weird happens during the-'

'Kitten!'

The sound of Double Trouble's voice suddenly filled our cosy two-bed room. It felt intrusive, until I remembered that Catra had literally just said to call them.

The reluctant sigh that carried away Catra's brief show of glee at the thought of Scorpia *speaking* to Emily was long and drawn out. 'Double Trouble.'

'It's an absolute gift *to hear from you, Kitten. To what do I owe the pleasure?'*

Catra glanced up at me quickly, but her gaze didn't linger to watch for any kind of response. 'I- we need your... skills.'

'I have many skills, darling, you'll have to be more specific.'

'Look, there's a re-hash of the Princess Prom happening in a few days. We have until then to find the leader of a group that's *this close* to just flinging Princess Frosta from the top of the Kingdom of Snows. I want your help to weasel into their group and dismantle them from the inside.'

There was a brief silence.

'Oh, the drama! That's sounds delectable, kitten. Not the scrounging around in the dirt part though. Let me guess, you're wanting this as an apology for abandoning you like everyone else did and won't *be paying me?'*

Catra groaned and flopping onto her stomach, hiding her face in the duvet of her bed.

'Not to worry, kitten. Your mate *told me about us all getting some kind of second chance or pardon or something. I'll help you out as a show of good faith to that.'*

The *look* Catra gave me after that disclosure of information promptly dried up any lingering arousal I had as I sheepishly

looked away. Oh look, a vanity with a grubby mirror. I should clean that.

'Whatever Double Trouble, how soon can you get here?'

'Seems as we're friends now and there isn't a war on, just call me DT, it's how everyone down under knows me.'

'Down under?' I asked, perplexed as to what that could mean. The only underground thing I knew of was Underdryl and I wasn't sure how widespread the knowledge of its existence was yet.

'Is that the blonde? Turn me, I want to see.'

Catra huffed and turned the screen to me. I saw DT raise a hand as if to wave hello, but it quickly stopped and their ears drooped.

'What are *you wearing, darling?'*

I scoffed. 'It- it's a disguise!'

'Uhuh, sure… Anyway, by "down under" I was referring to the underworld. You know, shady dealings, black market, criminals and killers that get away with it for the thrill. I'm guessing whoever you're *dealing with has feet in that murky pond. To answer your other question, kitten,'* Catra moved the pad back round to face her, *'I'm already on my way. Word travels fast and if the last Prom was anything to go by, I* won't *be missing this one.'*

'Wait - you were at the last Prom?' Catra seemed genuinely surprised by this admission. Honestly, I could see it happening.

'Of course I was. Don't think I didn't see your little thrill-seeking. The band had nothing *on the entertainment you two provided. Oh, the* tension. *It was enough to shake the foundations of the castle! Or was that the heat-bombs? Eh, details.'*

'Whatever DT. I'll send you coordinates of where to meet up in the morning.'

'I look forward to it. I'm eager to re-kindle our burning partnership, working together once again but this time on side of good*, aiming to out those who-'*

Catra ended the call and rolled onto her back, dropping the tracker pad with an indignant growl. I got up from the bed and stowed the pad away in my bag again, before getting out my much more comfortable combat gear. No doubt having the same thought process as Catra for the reasoning behind wearing our old clothes: to be ready for anything, even when sleeping.

I could tell by Catra's body language that she was done for the day. A silent agreement was made in the room to turn in for the night and leave any further discussion until the morning.

Once changed, I turned off the lamp on the wall and got into my bed. The mattress wasn't amazingly comfy, and it certainly *looked* much softer than it actually was. The duvet was also kind of scratchy, but I was happy with the warmth it provided. When I looked back over at Catra, I saw that she was still laid on top of her covers, just facing away from me. We had both had a long day, physically and mentally exhausting from the travelling and all the discussion and planning.

I couldn't help but think more on how I wanted to fix us. We had both contributed in some way to the wedge that divided us still, but it felt more and more like that wedge was crumbling as familiarity set in. My arms ached to hold her close to me. Sleeping in the same room in itself was a kind of progress, but the separate beds were almost like a symbolic representation of that distance that remained. I decided to try one last-ditch attempt to gain ground on that distance before my exhaustion caught up with me completely.

'Hey - hey, Catra...'

'What?' She grumbled, her ear flicking round to listen better.

'It's a conspir-ice-y.'

The silence was almost deafening. Almost, because Catra's tail thumped twice against her bed. Was she annoyed, amused, or charmed by my awful joke?

'Is this your way of trying to make up with me?' She asked after the silence dragged on for a few moments too long.

'It might be part of the plan... is it working?' I whispered back.

'Just go to sleep, dummy.'

Dummy.

I tried to stifle my glee at Catra finally using a nickname. Granted, it wasn't my favourite, but I still accidentally made an audible squeak just from the shock of it. Catra definitely heard, but I *didn't care.* I rolled over so I was facing away from her and stopped fighting the huge smile that wanted to possess my face.

That night, in a room alone with Catra, separated only by a few feet between our beds, I slept soundly for the first time in nearly a week.



Chapter End Notes

The amazing illustration that perfectly captures the final scene is by the equally amazing @the.r.account on

Instagram! Go give them some love!

Next update does not have a set date, as the chapters are getting longer I'm needing longer to write them and life is, unfortunately, catching up.
I'm also working on another piece of brain-rot at the same time for my Tales from Bright Moon series. It's a Cyberpunk/Matrix/SAO kind of AU. Lots of swearing. Should be fun.

Until next time!

For the Honour of Horde Prime!

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra begin their investigation into the conspir-ice-y.

Chapter Notes

> Hi all!
>
> I'm not sorry for the wait, I've been working on a new AU that was supposed to be a oneshot but it's pulling me in — help.
>
> Enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I shot awake to the sound of our room's door slamming closed, instantly roused from a particularly nice dream that... escaped me. *Damn.*

It occurred to me then that Prime hadn't fed me some kind of nightmare at all that night, a far cry from what he had been doing previously. Had it been because I was actually kind of happy when I went to sleep? That could explain it.

Any further thoughts about Prime were washed away when I heard Catra clear her throat from just inside the door.

'Sorry, did I wake you?'

She grimaced and quietly shuffled across the room, picking up her backpack and starting to search through it. 'Honestly, I didn't think you'd still be in bed.'

Glancing toward the window, I saw that it was light out and the sky was completely clear of any trace of clouds – the snowstorm

from the night before must have stopped overnight. I leant up on my elbows to watch as Catra pulled out her First Ones' tech. She threaded the silver circlet through her hair between her ears and pulled on each fingerless black glove, flexing her claws, and watching as the crystal discs on the back of each began to glow a dim blue.

I rubbed my eyes and finished sitting up, steadily coming to from my unexpectedly deep sleep. 'How long was I out? And are you going somewhere?'

Catra flashed me a knowing smirk and raised an eyebrow, cocking her head as she watched me come back to the land of the living. '*Hmm*. Well, to answer both your questions, I've already been out for half the day. You missed breakfast. The inn-keep's a good cook though, so that's a bonus.'

'What? Where did you go? You should've woken me up, I would have come with.' I pouted, slouching forward on the bed and glancing round the room to get my bearings.

Catra dismissed the notion with a wave of her hand. 'It's fine, I could tell you needed the sleep. Besides, all I did was meet up with DT. Nothing too exciting.'

'You met with them? Without me?'

Catra nodded. She put her pack back down on the floor and kicked it up against the wall.

'Well what happened? Don't keep anything from me, we're supposed to working on this together, Catra.'

Catra's ears drooped as she shifted from one foot the other. Then she crossed her arms over her chest and hugged herself tight, her tail wrapping around her leg as she looked down at the floor. Just from that display of body language I could tell she felt bad about leaving me out and I, in turn, felt bad about making her feel bad, even if it was what I think she needed to hear. It was, after all, what got us to this stalemate in the first place.

'I'm... I'm sorry, for going without you but – you *needed* the sleep. I could tell, Adora. You had bags under your eyes and you were kind of slow yesterday. You almost completely walked past this place when we first arrived.'

That was fair. I hadn't realised how tired I was until I actually got into bed the night before. Hearing her call me a nickname had filled me with such a strong sense of warmth, of relief, that whatever tension had been keeping me awake, keeping Prime's grasp on my dreams strong, simply ebbed away.

'Yeah, okay, you're right.' I saw as the tension left her shoulders and her ears perked up a little. 'But we are supposed to be working together so – are you going to tell me what happened with DT?'

Catra let out a long breath and slouched down on the end of her bed. She idly picked at the fingers on her gloves, eyebrows furrowing as she contemplated where to start.

While I waited, I swung my legs out from under the duvet, got out of bed, and tidied it up. Then, when I saw Catra's tail begin to sway behind her and her ears perk up, I sat at the end of my own bed and waited for her to begin.

'Honestly, there's not a lot to say. We met up a ways down the street, talked about a plan and then they went off to go be sneaky, or something, I don't know.' Catra shrugged, looking away from me toward the window.

I sighed and leant forwards to grab my boots, wondering why Catra was being purposefully vague.

Does she not trust me? We're supposed to be a team.

'Are you actually going to tell me what the plan is, Catra, or are you just going to be difficult? First you go off without me, and now you're keeping things from me? Is that it? I don't understand you sometimes!' I shot up from my perch on the end of my bed and grabbed my jacket out from my pack, slinging it over my

shoulders before diving into the bag again and pulling out the belt and fastening it around my jacket. I glanced over at the gold wing on the nightstand and almost moved to grab it but decided against it.

That belongs to Catra now, I just have to give it to her.

If she ever stops being difficult!

Instead, I reached back into the bag and rummaged around until I found what I was looking for: the deep-orange desert snake scale pin that I had Anga make for me back in Bright Moon during the Moon Market. I ran my fingers over the glossy surface, once again marvelling at how smooth it was. Then, after standing up, I used it to clip my belt together. Pointy side down, so that it looked vaguely like a shield.

When I glanced up, I found Catra watching me, a fond smile tugging at the corners of her mouth. She quickly turned away as soon as she realised I was looking, but her tail gave away that she'd been caught red-handed.

I cleared my throat. '*Ahem.* Catra? Sometime today, maybe?'

'Alright! Fine. I just... didn't want to worry you.' Catra conceded, her tail wrapping around her waist as she hugged herself again.

'Worry me? A friend is being threatened, of course I'm worried.' I said, pulling my hair back into a ponytail.

'No, I know. But I meant, *more* worried. DT knows— don't you dare put up that hairpoof. Don't do it, Adora!' Catra suddenly launched from her position on the bed, crossing the room to stare daggers at my hair. I quickly dropped my hands to my sides, letting my bangs fall back down over my eyes.

Before I had chance to fix it, Catra's hands were already working to move it aside so I could see, styling in a way that kept it out of my face.

After she tucked a final loose strand behind my ear, she stepped back and surveyed my head before nodding her approval. 'There.'

I found myself beaming at her. 'Since when did you care so much about my hair?'

Catra clicked her tongue. 'I don't! I just– ugh. I accepted the position of Royal Advisor, right?'

'Yeah...' I said, nodding a couple times to emphasise that I did, in fact, know about that. 'Congratulations, by the way, I don't think I've had the chance to say that yet. I'm proud of you.'

Catra stared at me with a blank expression for a moment before bursting into laughter. 'Thanks, Adora, but it's really not that different from what I was doing before. Except now *Queen* Sparkles can *order me* to do things and follow her places, instead of just doing it of my own free will.'

'It can't be anything bad right?'

'Oh no, Adora, she's totally abusing her power. She *orders me* to follow her to the *mundane* things! Stuff I don't care about! The colour of new curtains, the type of wax they use on the throne room floor, and – this is the big one – what I think of her hair every morning. *Every*. Morning. I've been her advisor for what, a week? She only has one hairstyle, Adora! *One!* But she asks me every time if it looks right!' Catra looked utterly exasperated during her rant, and I couldn't help but burst into laughter.

'Your *face!* It's just her hair, Catra!'

'No but Adora, you don't understand! I asked her once, "why don't you ask Arrow Boy what he thinks of your hair?", and you know what she said?'

'No! *Please* tell me!'

'She DOES! But she doesn't believe him because he's *biased!* A conflict of interest! So she subjects *me* to it as well, as if I actually

care!'

I doubled over, clutching at my stomach.

'And now she's conditioned me! I've started actually caring whether or not her hair looks perfect every morning! What is *happening* to me? Princesses are terrifying, Adora... I wonder who she's asking while I'm gone...'

'Probably her hair stylist...' I said, wiping the tears from my eyes.

Catra narrowed her eyes. 'Her *what*?'

I held down another laugh. 'She has a stylist, Catra. Did you actually think she does her hair herself? It was all over the place before she was queen. She's probably been messing with you the whole time; she knows it looks good!'

She stared at me wordlessly for a moment while I composed myself again. 'Adora?'

'Catra.'

'I take back what I said yesterday about your friends being nice. I'm going to kill them.'

'Please don't.'

As the moment passed, and a new silence spread between us, I noticed Catra's ears pin back and her tail slowly started wrapping around her leg. I knew what she wanted or, at least, I knew what *I* wanted and hoped she wanted the same. That conversation felt just like old times, but our reality was setting in again as the fog lifted. So, I decided to plough ahead and not worry about any awkwardness. I took a deep breath and, slowly, opened my arms wide.

'Come here.' I whispered.

Catra's eyes went wide and her ears perked up as she processed what I had just said. 'A– Adora?'

'Come on.'

'But I thought– are you sure?'

'I've never been more sure of anything.' I said, smiling softly. It must have been almost two weeks since I last hugged Catra, and I hoped beyond anything to feel that kind of warmth again.

After a moment, Catra stepped forward. 'Adora...'

'Catra, please.' I felt tears pricking at the corners of my eyes. 'I... I...'

Catra tentatively stepped forward again, then launched herself at me. Her arms wrapped tightly around my shoulders and my arms slipped into their familiar position around her waist. I held her close, held her tight and felt her warmth, her breath, the rise and fall of her chest. I almost started crying when her arms tightened around me. She breathed in deep before rubbing her face against my cheek like she used to. It was so familiar, so nice, so *right*. I love her. I missed her.

I missed you, Catra.

'I missed you too, Adora.'

Oh, I said that out loud.

'We still have to talk,' I reminded her, 'but, for now, this is nice.'

Catra nodded against me, burying her face into my pulse point. 'It *is* nice. We'll talk. I don't want to lose this again. It feels like I've come home after being away.' She whispered. Then, as if I needed reminding of what else I had missed out on all this time, she started to *purr*.

I squeezed a little tighter, reluctant to pull away after feeling her warmth and hearing that adorable sound for the first time in *so long*.

'You don't want to move away, do you?' Catra asked, her voice muffled by my jacket. I laughed a little and shook my head.

'No, I don't,' I admitted. 'How did you know?'

'Because I don't either.'

The words I wanted to say were on the tip of my tongue.

I love you, Catra, can we go back to how we were before all of this? I miss you; I just want to hold you close like this all the time. You're so warm, you make me feel complete, you're everything to me and I don't ever want to let you go again. I promise I'll be better. I'll make sure you know just how much you're wanted, how much you matter, how much you're loved. I love you so much, Catra, and I promise, going forward, I'll never give you reason to doubt that ever again.

But I didn't say them. There was another set of words I was already planning on saying that would carry the same message.

I took a deep breath.

It's just until prom, and then we'll begin again.

'Me neither, but...'

'Yeah, we have to do what we came here for.' Catra reluctantly pulled away from the embrace and looked up into my eyes. I could see she'd been crying against me, and I had to hold back from wrapping my arms around her again. 'Walk with me?' She continued, 'I'll tell you what DT told me.'

'Okay,' I nodded, 'that sounds good. I'll just grab my coat.'

'See you down there.'

Then, Catra left, closing the door behind her. I breathed in deep again, closing my eyes and holding back the tears that wanted to fall.

We were fixing it.

We were healing.

I love her so much, and all I want is for her to know that.

To understand it, embrace it, live with it.

To make it a part of her.

To make *me* a part of her.

Just her and me. Catra and Adora. As we always have been.

I picked up my huge blue coat and shrugged it onto my shoulders, locked the door behind me, then followed after her.

Catra and Adora, as we always will be.

The warmth from the brightest of Etheria's moons felt nice against my face, but the wind's chilly bite kept routinely nulling any warm comfort I had the *audacity* to enjoy. There were more people out and about now than there had been the night before, and the area surrounding the inn was buzzing with life. There were countless trails through the now knee-high snow that hugged close to the buildings and igloos around us, but there was also a more well-defined path through the centre of the street that had already been mostly flattened by the morning's footfall.

Catra looked snug in her coat as she walked along beside me, but I could tell she'd rather not be wearing it. The conflicting temperatures couldn't be fun for her.

As if in answer to my thoughts, she undid the front of her coat and let it hang open.

'*Why* is it so warm?' She grumbled, 'it's the Kingdom of *Snows.* What, did it not get the memo this morning or something?'

I smiled and glanced at Catra's hands, silently wishing I could hold one of them. Then, randomly, a thought popped into my head.

'Hey, Catra?'

'Hm?'

'Why didn't you bring Melog?'

Catra stopped and turned to look at me curiously. 'I thought I told you why?'

'Oh, I don't—'

'Relax, Adora. It's okay.' Catra assured me whilst starting to walk again. 'Sure – Melog would be useful for turning invisible, but the whole point of us sneaking in was to keep under the radar. What if we were seen with Melog when we're not invisible? And what if when we're invisible someone sees the footprints in the snow? Plus, if we were to use them to sneak into the kingdom, we would just appear out of nowhere. We have to be careful, Adora, we can't just assume that we're dealing with a group of idiots.'

'I guess you're right. It makes sense, at least. Now, are you actually planning on telling me what DT told you or am I supposed to guess?'

'Okay! Alright.' Catra looked around before leaning in and speaking in a hushed tone. 'DT made some calls last night, after I

hung up on them – turns out this group hasn't been around for very long, pretty much ever since Frosta came back after we stopped Prime. They call themselves the Stewards of Peace.'

'Oh!' I exclaimed, recognising the word. 'Micah's a Steward! Or, at least he is when Glimmer's outside Bright Moon.'

'Yeah, exactly. Iceric, the advisor guy, was the Steward for this place while Frosta was away. This group basically want him back in charge and don't think a magical teenage princess is good enough for them.'

'But Frosta's nice!'

'Adora! She literally punched me in the face!'

'Yeah, but, c'mon, it's *you*. We've all wanted to at least once. You *can* be a stubborn brat.'

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose and sighed.
'Look... *whatever*. That's not the point. The point is: most of the people who are part of the Stewards are just that. *People.* Not just criminals, like we first thought. It could literally be anybody, Adora. We should assume that anyone is in on it, especially on this level of the kingdom.'

'But that... that can't be right. Why would ordinary people not want Frosta to rule them? She's their princess!'

'They were happy with her when they were neutral. But as soon as Frosta joined the Princess Alliance, opinion turned against her. Now, they don't want her back.'

'Yeah, okay.' I didn't really get it, but I could instead focus on the main task at hand. 'So, what's the plan?'

Catra quickly scanned over my face and a smile tugged at the corner of her mouth. *She knows I don't get it but she's going to move on anyway.* 'DT is working on infiltrating them using their

connections. They said they know a guy who knows a guy who can help them get in quick.'

'Okay, that sounds good... If it goes well, we should be a step closer to finding out who's leading them. So, if they're doing *that*, then what are *we* doing?'

'*We're* making some noise. I know Frosta said to sneak around, but the prom is only a few days away and if we take too long doing this then we won't be ready for whatever they have planned.'

'So we, what, blow something up?'

'Adora! *No*. As much I would *love* to blow something up, I was thinking more just along the lines of asking people directly about the Stewards. Where we can find them, tell them who *you* are, that kind of thing.'

'Wait, just who *I* am? What about you?'

'Adora, you're literally She-Ra. You saved the world.'

'No, Catra, *we* saved the world. By kissing.'

'Well... yeah.' Catra conceded, hiding a blush. 'But even if people did recognise me, that's not what I'd be recognised *for.* A lot of the people here fled the Horde within the last few years. And who was basically leading the Horde's ground forces for most of that time? Oh yeah, me. They ran from *me*, Adora.'

I snorted and stifled a laugh. 'But you're so *cute* now.'

'I am *not* cute.'

'We'll continue this debate later.'

'We absolutely will not.'

'Will too.'

'Will not.'

'Will too.'

'Adora!' Catra whisper shouted.

'What?'

'Can you focus? *Please?*'

'Alright, fine, lead the way, *boss*.'

Catra huffed and sped ahead, literally leading the way down the street. I chuckled while making sure to keep up with her.

We spent the next few hours knocking on doors, stopping people in the street, and being as loud about asking after the Stewards as we possibly could. Once Catra was happy that enough people were whispering about us and spreading the word that the Legendary Warrior She-Ra, Princess of Power, was looking for the Stewards, we stopped and took a moment to discuss our next steps.

'Do you think that was enough?' I asked, trying to look around inconspicuously despite just telling everyone who I am.

'I'll say, you're already the talk of the town. It's sort of half *"wow, I can't believe she's here!"* and half *"should we report this?"*. Mixed reactions all round, basically.' Catra said, leaning back against the wall of the wooden building we found ourselves next to.

'So what now? Do we just wait?' I asked, joining Catra in leaning against the wall as casually as possible. Then swapping which leg I was leaning on. Then swapping back. Suddenly, I was very aware that I had no idea what to do with my hands. Pockets? Yeah, pockets.

'Shush. I hear something...' Catra craned her neck to the left. She lowered her hood and angled her ears to better pick up whatever

sound she was hearing.

'What is it?'

'Adora, I literally just said "shush", so *shush.*'

'Sorry!'

A moment passed where Catra was completely still, just listening, taking in all the sounds from around us. Then her ears quickly snapped to the left. Her eyes followed and she scanned the alleyway that led around to the back of the building we were leaning against. 'I saw something. Down that alley. Wait here.'

'Wait–' I began to protest, 'shouldn't I come with? I'm supposed to be—'

'No! Just wait here. It could just be nothing.'

I watched as Catra slinked away down the alley, keeping to the shadows. After a moment, she disappeared around a corner and I was left alone.

Mostly alone.

"This seems promising."

'What do *you* want?' I asked Prime out loud. I almost forgot that he was just in my head, he seemed to have his own presence next to me but, when I glanced down, I saw that he made no impression in the snow. *Just my imagination*. 'You're losing your grip on me, aren't you? You didn't mess with my dreams last night.'

Prime laughed. It was cold, heartless, and sent a shiver down my spine. *"Oh, Adora. Adora, Adora. You, my* dear *Adora, have gravely miscalculated.* Again*."*

I looked up at him, meeting his deathly stare for the first time in days. 'What do you mean?'

"It was naïve to let yourself believe that my apparent absence from your sight and hearing meant that I was, what? Weakening? Gone? I would never allow an opportunity like this to slip through my grasp."

Instinctively, I stepped away from him. His presence was suddenly making me feel heavy, like I should lie down and... and let him take control. That seemed like a good idea.

No, what? That's a terrible idea.

No it isn't, it's what I want.

"I've been with you, the whole time, all I had to do was wait."

Prime will make me happy.

No, he won't! Shut up, Me!

"Just as I did before with your Catra, I will make you anew. I've seen your mind, Adora, so confused for so long. So many thoughts, so many emotions, but none of them are what you truly want."

'You don't know what I want!'

"What you want, Adora, is to be brought into the light."

'No!' I shouted, clutching at my head. *Why does it hurt so much?*

"It has become clear that words are no longer getting through to you. So I will have to take matters into your own hands, little sister."

'What does that even mean? You are *not* taking control of me! You're– you're just in my head!'

"Your time is up, little sister, your place is with Prime now. I will give you peace, something your Catra could never do. She's only

ever caused you pain, confusion, and hurt. Relinquish yourself to me, and I shall make you whole again."

I realised then that my breathing was shallow and I felt incredibly lightheaded. I swayed from side to side, stepping back and coming into contact with the building behind me. Prime was everywhere, he was all I could think about. I tried picturing Catra, her smile, her warmth, the feeling of her pressed up against me, her lips... her lips? I can't remember how her lips feel against mine, it's been too long—

I opened my eyes to see only darkness.

Then, a voice.

'For the honour of *Horde Prime!'*

My voice.

That can't be right.

Suddenly, the darkness was filled with a blindingly bright gold light.

Oh, I can see again.

Wow, I'm tall.

Wait... I'm She-Ra?

Why am I looking at my own hands?

I didn't do that.

I'm walking forwards now, but *I'm* not walking forwards.

I'm not in control.

Oh, I see now. *Prime's* in control... of She-Ra.

But how? He's gone. *Isn't he?* I erased him. *Didn't I?* I used the magic to purge him from Hordak's mind. That should have been enough.

Shouldn't it?

That doesn't matter right now, I have to focus on what he's doing. Is he following after Catra? Why else would he go down the alley? That's right, she went round here...

Who's that? They have a knife and its– it's against Catra's throat! *What are you waiting for?! GO! Yell at them! Tell them to—*

'—get away from her!' Oh, that was me. I'm in control again. *No time to think about it*. I surged forwards, grabbed the stranger by the scruff of their cloak and shoved them roughly against the wall. My other hand brought the sword up to their neck and began *pushing*.

No! I'm not doing that! *Resist it!*

"Kill them!" Prime's voice boomed in my head, more present than it's ever been before.

'No! We– we need them alive! We– we need to—'

"They were going to kill your Catra. Kill them now before they achieve their goal!"

'I *won't* do it!'

'Adora!? What's going on? What are you doing?' Catra was standing to my right, watching me argue with myself while holding a gasping stranger up against the wall. I realised that I had my hand around their neck, but I couldn't pull away or loosen my grip.

'Catra! You have to stop me! *Please!'*

'What do I do Adora? Tell me! How do I—'

'It's Prime! He's still in my head, he's controlling me! I think– I think he– I don't have *time!* He wants me to kill and– you have to stop me Catra! *I can't*... I can't hold off much longer!' I fought against the urge to crush this person's neck under my grip, to plunge my blade between their ribs. *It would be so easy, just to extinguish them, take their life, get revenge for what they almost did to Catra.*

I was only half aware of Catra scrambling round behind me to look at my neck. 'There's no chip, Adora! I don't know what to do...'

What was I thinking? I don't want revenge!

"You're mine, Adora! Give in to the light!"

'Aaaah! Catra! It hurts!' My whole body felt like it was on fire, I could feel the strain the conflicting commands were having on my muscles and it *burned.*

'Where?! Where does it hurt?'

'My head! *Everywhere!* It burns– it hurts so bad! Catra, *please!'*

'Okay, okay. Uhm. Adora! When you were fighting me, back when I was under Prime's control, there were moments, flashes, when I could see clearly! I could see you and his hold was weaker! What caused those moments, Adora?' Catra sounded panicked yet calm all at once. She was clearly shaken by what was happening, but no doubt her sharp mind had decided to focus on helping first and figuring out the details later.

'Uh, uhm, I think the – *Aaah!* – I think you were up against the screens, and there was a power surge, right before they exploded.'

'A power surge? Like– like electricity?'

'Yeah, I guess– why? *Ghhh!*'

'Okay, I... I think I have an idea. You're not going to like it.'

'Do it!'

'What?'

'Whatever it is, just do it, Catra! I don't want to kill them!'

'Okay... okay. Here goes... you ready?'

'Do it, Catra!'

The gem on Catra's circlet and the crystal discs on her gloves began glowing a bright blue. After a moment, I felt the hairs on my arms stand on end with static as a ball of red magical electricity began forming in the palm of Catra's outstretched hand. I closed my eyes and waited for the blast to connect – it was a vague plan, one filled with holes. I didn't even have a chip, so the possibility of electricity working at all was slim, but it might stop me for long enough to allow this person to escape my – *Prime's* – grasp.

"I think not."

Then, as I heard the buzzing of the electricity grow louder, my sword arm swung around to intercept it. Catra's magic cracked through the air but didn't connect with me. Instead, it seemed that I had somehow managed to store the magic within my blade. I watched as it began glowing red and crackled with the absorbed power. I had managed to do something similar before, storing and redirecting the energy from Horde starfighter weapons while out in space, but I never would have thought it would be possible with magic too. Or, maybe I just assumed I'd never be defending myself against a friend's attack.

But I hadn't defended myself, *he* did.

'Adora...' Catra sounded worried. She started taking steps back, the electricity around her hands crackling with growing intensity.

'Catra?' I asked, looking her way. She looked... scared? No, worse than that. She looked *terrified*.

'Your– your eyes... they're *green*, Adora.' I could make out the tears forming in her eyes and I wanted to—*hurt her, make her bleed*—hold her close, kiss her forehead, stroke her ears—*make her regret ever hurting you, she doesn't deserve your love, only your wrath*—let her know how much I love her, how proud of her I am.

"Kill her. Kill your Catra."

No.

My body turned of its own accord.

No!

I dropped the stranger, not even glancing at them as they whimpered and gasped for air. I took a step towards Catra.

NO!

Then another. Her eyes were wide with fear—*as they should be*—as I raised my sword and aimed it toward her.

...no...

"Little sister... what a waste. *Time to die."*
'Little sister... what a *waste.* Time to die.'

Prime's voice and mine spoke at the same time. He was leading again, but I could feel every movement, every step, the stretch of muscle as my arm pulled back ready to thrust toward Catra. I felt so light, so weightless, like the problems of the world had just ebbed away. Maybe it would be okay to give in to the light after all, it seemed so peaceful, so much simpler. I didn't have to think,

Prime took care of everything for me, made me feel complete in a way I didn't even know I needed.

The tranquillity I felt in that moment didn't match up with what I was watching unfold in front of me. I watched as Catra summoned an energy shield to defend against the thrust of my sword and the resulting crack of electricity that fired out from it.

Why won't she just give in to the light? Why won't she join me? Everything would be better if she would just offer herself to Prime and let him guide her, as he's guiding me.

Another block. And another. Another. Another, *another another another*. Catra defended against strike after strike from my sword until her energy shield was visibly vibrating before her.



Surely attacking Catra wasn't the best way to help her find the light. *Right?* I didn't want her to get hurt, just to bask in the glory of Prime's wisdom.

'Adora, I'm sorry.'

Oh – she's going to—

Just as Catra released the stored potential energy from her shield in a powerful pulse directed at us, Prime shifted the sword into a shield and knelt down behind it. The movement was fast enough that the majority of the pulse was absorbed by the shield and only pushed us back two or three feet from where we were. All the snow around us didn't have the defensive capability of a legendary warrior princess though. The shockwave from the release of built-up energy sent all the snow around us billowing up into the air, buffeting against my shield while also raining down from above.

Almost immediately after the alley was filled with snow and our vision obscured by the curtain of white, Catra leapt into action. She had formed the energy into bright blue claws that extended her usual reach considerably and, fully taking Prime by surprise, managed to get him on the defensive as she turned the tables and forced him to block against her instead.

Catra was now on the attack, fully utilising her vastly superior speed and agility to land blow after blow against us. Prime tried changing the shield back into a sword, but it did little to deter Catra from her attack. Instead she parried us, again and again, kicking out with her feet as her blue winter coat billowed behind out behind her. Catra's tech was shining with energy and she showed no signs of slowing down. Her face contorted in anger and concentration, methodically picking us apart until we were forced down onto one knee, Prime cowering beneath the shield.

What Prime hadn't considered was, in forcing me to take a backseat within my own mind, he had also pushed down my knowledge of how to actually fight as She-Ra. Without that knowledge, Catra had the upper hand. We had spent hours and hours sparring against each other in the weeks patrolling Etheria waiting for the signal, and now all that practice had allowed Catra

to gain the upper hand and beat down on my weak points until Prime was forced to retreat back into my head.

"Fight her! Kill that waste of life!"

Catra paused, watching as my shoulders sagged and the sword disappeared.

"What are you doing!? Fight for the honour of Horde Prime!"

'No.' I said, my own resolve kicking in. 'I won't. Catra... *do it.'*

'Are you sure?' Catra asked, almost a whisper.

I nodded, feeling Prime's rage and anger boiling over. His apparition appeared behind Catra, scowling, and shouted, *"rise, little sister! Strike down this beacon of betrayal! She's done nothing but cause you pain all your life, take your* revenge *now!"*

'You miscalculated.' I said, a smile actually spreading across my face despite how everything *ached*. 'I love Catra more than I fear you!'

Prime roared and surged forwards to take control again, but a beam of red electricity pierced his spectral form and surged towards me. I grit my teeth and held back my own scream as the excruciating magic coursed through me.

'Cat–! Keep–! Going–!' I managed to shout, straining against the searing pain as the shocks caused my body to go fully rigid.

I felt a metal finger on my chin, lifting my face. I opened my eyes to find myself looking directly at Prime. Despite what was happening, he looked completely calm. Unfazed by what was taking place, even as the edges of his body began to fizzle, like watching something on a screen with a bad connection.

"No matter." He said, standing up and stepping away from me. *"You were nothing more than a side-project, a simple curiosity."* He folded his arms behind his back as he began to

dissipate. *"You can expel me from your mind, Adora, but I* will *bring Etheria to its knees – regardless of your intervention."*

Then, in a blur of grey, white and green, Prime was gone.

The magic stopped.

For the first time since I touched that crystal in Dryl, I could think clearly.

I shrunk back down to be regular old Adora and suddenly felt extremely heavy. I collapsed forwards and would have hit the ground had Catra not ran forwards and caught me.

'Adora!' She cried, tears streaming down her face. 'Did it work? I'm so sorry, Adora! I didn't want to fight you but I– I–'

I smiled weakly, lifting a hand to caress her cheek. 'It's okay.' I whispered. 'He's gone. You did so well, thank you...'

'Adora...' Catra leant forwards, planting a soft kiss against my forehead. I tried to savour the feeling, but I felt so weak and I could feel my heavy eyelids trying to close. 'It's okay, Adora… you can sleep. I'll take you back to the inn.'

I nodded, still smiling dumbly. *Catra's so beautiful*. I booped her on the nose. *'Boop.'*

Catra giggled, but her fanged smile didn't last. She looked up as a shadow blocked out the light between the buildings. 'What do *you* want?'

I followed her gaze.

Oh, it's the stranger – the one I held against a wall. He brought friends. *That's nice.*

One of them walked around behind Catra and zapped her with a taser. She yelled, before falling limp by my side. Did they think she needed to sleep too?

How considerate...

I think I'll just... go... to sleep now...

Chapter End Notes

Many thanks to @beardofanart on Instagram for doing the amazing illustration for this chapter!

Sorry for the wait, and for the cliff-hanger. The original chapter 36 was cut in half because it got too long so now you have to wait again, but next chapter there will be lots of talking. So you've got that to look forward to!

Until next time!

Shadow of Deceit

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora find themselves alone in rooms together, and talk.

Chapter Notes

> Hey, look, it's the second half of chapter 36, now dubbed chapter 37, with an extra 10k words and everything.
>
> When I said you'd have to wait, I didn't mean you'd have to wait very long.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke me up for the second time that day, not by accidentally slamming a door, but by roughly shaking me by the shoulders.

'Adora! Please wake up! *Adora!*'

She sounded panicked, afraid.

'Catra?' I gasped, suddenly coming to, and remembering what had happened just before we'd been surrounded.

'Adora!' She pulled me into a tight hug, and I returned it as best I could considering *everything ached*. 'You're okay!'

'Yeah... yeah, I'm okay.' I reassured her, petting her back gently while looking around us. 'Where are we now? We have really got to stop blacking out...'

'Some kind of cell. But it's made of ice and snow, because *of course it is*. I feel like I should know what kind.'

'How would you know what kind of snow it is?'

Catra faltered. 'Adora– there's kind of other things I want to talk about, to ask you.'

'I know.' I quietly conceded. 'But I need to just, I don't know, organise my thoughts? Plus I ache all over. Tell me a story while I wake up properly?' Never had I made a truer request. I did feel like I was properly waking up from a dream that began ever since that first nightmare back in Dryl. Touching that crystal had somehow allowed Horde Prime to literally get into my head, but he'd convinced me it wasn't really him, that he was just my fears personified... I needed time to process, and to stop *tingling* from the intensity of Catra's magic.

Catra sighed and dragged a hand down her face. 'Okay, alright. When we were up in the Northern Reach before you showed up and I...' Catra winced and withdrew a little into herself. I watched as her ears pinned back and her tail twitched anxiously behind her, as a memory she'd rather not remember made itself known.

Honestly, that whole trip was a little fuzzy for me, Sea Hawk had recounted an entirely different take on events than Bow and Glimmer had, but the crux of it was that She-Ra had been corrupted, again, and only stopped when disarmed. Then something to do with big snow monsters which I had no memory of, but they all *swear* were real. *Sure.* I snapped back to the present as Catra continued.

'... *whatever*. But while we were digging for tech, Entrapta would not shut up about how *"fas-cin-a-ting"* the snow was. She went on and on about it. New, old, firn, seasonal, perennial, powder. All these different kinds. But what she found most interesting were the soil and sand samples that came up.' Catra sighed and picked at her claws, but I just sat and waited patiently for her to continue. 'I wish I had paid more attention, just enjoyed myself a little more. She seemed so excited about her theories of what type of landscape it would have been centuries ago before it was ice and snow but I– I just yelled. I told her to shut it and focus on

finding the tech, because apparently that’s all I cared about back then.' Catra leant forwards after that, just holding her head in her hands.

I reached out and gingerly touched her shoulder, wincing at the flinch the gesture elicited. 'Are you okay? Do you wanna talk about it? I'm here for you, I always will be.'

Catra laughed. It was empty, devoid of humour and instead rife with self-loathing. It was the only of Catra's laughs I absolutely hated to hear. 'What's there to talk about? I have all these memories of me being awful and I just... I don't recognise myself anymore. Is the old me the real me... or am I?' She asked, looking up at me with wide eyes as if I held the answer.

A soft smile tugged at the corners of my mouth as Catra's eyes searched mine for any hint of negativity. I was determined she wouldn't find it. I know Catra. I do. She's amazing and she's my girlfriend, and I wouldn't trade her for the world.

'You're just you, Catra. I know you did bad things, but no one is completely innocent. It was war, we all fought and did things we weren't proud of. But we're here now, and you're here with me. Your past is part of who you are, not some other version of you.' I looked at the ceiling, trying to piece together what it was I was trying to say. 'You... are never more you... than the you... you are now?'

Catra was silent for a moment and, when I looked back down at her, she was grinning. 'What was *that* supposed to be?'

'Shut up, brat.'

'Never, dummy.'

'I was trying to be wise.'

'It's honestly not a good look on you. Go back to be being dumb and cute.'

I beamed at the compliment and Catra just smiled through her blush. She hadn't meant to say it, but she didn't regret it either. *I love her so much.*

'Noted, but did you...'

'Get what you meant? Yeah, Adora. I got it. Thanks. For what it's worth, sometimes I do find myself liking who I am now. Not fighting all the time is nice, I guess. Not fighting you is nice too.'

'Yeah... not fighting me...'

Apparently, Catra had successfully led the conversation toward what she really wanted to ask, because as she asked her next question her ears perked up and she shuffled toward me. 'Do you want to tell me about it?'

'About what?' I deflected, immediately trying to find something else to look at, or maybe something to occupy my hands. I settled for just picking at the sleeves of my blue winter coat. The fact we both still had them on at least hinted that our captors weren't *complete* monsters.

'Why I had to fight you. It was... really hard for me to do that, you know. I never want to fight you ever again.' Catra's gaze was icy, stern. I took a deep breath, hoping to match her sincerity.

'I don't know if this helps but... it wasn't me?'

'Is that a question? Because that would mean you don't know if it was you or not, and that definitely doesn't help.'

I stared into those mis-matched eyes, hardened with resolve, for as long as I could before I relented and let out a long, deep breath. 'It was... not really clear. When he started taking control, my thoughts and his kind of started... overlapping? It was horrible. For a moment, I actually—' I paused, just starting down at my hands. How close had I been to actually hurting Catra?

'Hey, it's okay, Adora.' Catra said, resting her hand on top of mine. 'I'm not going anywhere.'

Smiling sadly, I nodded and shuffled a little in my spot on the floor. 'I actually... felt like I wanted to kill you.' I muttered, forcing the words out and wincing when I did. To my surprise, Catra simply nodded, signalling for me to continue. 'I could barely even register that killing you was the *last* thing I wanted to do. He was just so... *there*. Steering my body and mind. Looking back, I know it was horrible. Thinking about it makes me feel sick but... at the time, it was oddly peaceful. I don't really understand it.'

'I understand, Adora.' Catra reassured me, her voice patient and soft. 'That's exactly what it was like for me too, until you damaged the chip... how long have you been seeing him?'

'Uhm...' I shifted sheepishly. 'Well, I could hear him ever since I touched that crystal in Dryl. But the first time I actually *saw* him was the day that... the Dreadnought went down.'

Catra nodded, her gaze downcast. 'So it's my fault that his grip on you got stronger.'

'No, Catra—'

'Shut up, Adora! It's my fault. It is. If I had just *said words* at you, we could have avoided this. But that goes for you too. You haven't told anyone else about this, have you?'

'No one other than Perfuma. How'd you know?'

'How did I know? Really? Adora, if your overly in-your-face-with-niceness friends knew about this I don't think they would be sitting on their hands. Plus, you didn't tell *me*, and you tell me everything.'

'Yeah, well, apparently we've both been keeping things from each other. Even though—'

'Even though we both said we wouldn't do that.' Catra ran her hands through her hair and sighed, her breath forming a little cloud of steam in front of her face. 'I can't believe how bad we are at this... not only did we immediately jump to sex right after saying we loved each other, but we've apparently forgotten how to just talk to one another too.'

'It's no wonder Glim is so done with us all the time.' I joked, trying to lighten the mood somewhat.

Catra scoffed. 'No kidding. We're infuriating!'

I sat there for a moment, just looking around the cell. It was like the whole thing had been carved out of the inside of the mountain, with no obvious join lines or marks to show how it had been built. The door looked tough, securely bolted to the thick, resilient ice.

Eventually, as it always does, my gaze landed back on Catra as she too stared into space next to me, equally lost in thought. I studied her profile, her freckles, her ears. The way her eyebrows furrowed in concentration, the way her hair almost reached her shoulders, the way her lips part for her tongue to lick them. What I wouldn't give to feel those lips on mine. When I glanced down at her lap, I wondered if I would be allowed a moment of self-indulgence. People were always telling me to want things, after all.

'Hey, Catra?'

'Yeah, Adora?' She asked, turning to look at me with eyes full of love and curiosity. I found myself briefly wondering what she'd been thinking about to cause such an expression.

'Would it be okay if I...' The absurdity of the unspoken request caught up with me and I averted my eyes, looking elsewhere while rubbing at the back of my neck. 'Sorry, doesn't matter. It's stupid.'

'No, go on.'

I met Catra's eyes again. She looked so earnest, ready to hear me out, to hear whatever I had to say. To listen to me, and really consider it. My heart felt full.

'Could I, maybe, lay my head in your lap?' I asked quickly, closing my eyes to avoiding the judging stare.

But no judgement came, just a soft "hmm" as Catra weighed the request in her mind. 'You've never *asked* to lay in my lap before.'

'I know, sorry, it's stupid...' I muttered, turning away.

'No, Adora...' Catra reached out and gently squeezed my shoulder, bringing me back round to look into those beautiful eyes that sparkled with glee. '... it's okay, you're allowed to ask. It's not stupid to want things. I... I want you to. Go ahead, lay in my lap.'

Her smile was so soft, so reassuring. Marrying Catra suddenly seemed far more important than unearthing the Stewards of Peace and it would, by far, be the best decision I've ever made.

Once positioned comfortably in Catra's lap, with her warm thighs supporting me, I allowed myself to close my eyes and just feel my girlfriend near me. Catra was a grounding presence that always seemed to calm me, and being close to her again felt like a gift that I didn't deserve. Catra had summarised it well: it felt like coming home.

But we still hadn't kissed, or told each other that we love one another. Sure, I said I loved her to Prime right before she zapped me, but that's not the same. It was a defiance to him and a reassurance to her. To let her know I trusted her to do it. And she did.

Prime was gone.

If he wasn't, he would surely be making the most of this moment of silence in the cell. But, as I laid there with my eyes closed and shut off my brain for a moment, there was only silence.

No voices.

No presence.

No anxious tugging at my heart.

Just the feeling of warmth, of love.

And with that feeling, the silence was instead filled with Catra as she pulled out the elastic from my ponytail and started running her hand through my hair. I didn't protest. It felt nice. I understood, then, why it was she loved this so much. If I could purr, I would.

But then her thighs tensed below my head, and I realised the attention to my hair was meant as something to reassure and calm me, keep me grounded while she asked the as yet unspoken question that I'd been dreading.

'Does this mean he's alive?' She whispered.

No one had brought up the idea of all the past events being attributed to Prime since my conversation with Glimmer on the morning of the Dreadnought crash. The idea of Prime returning had almost caused me to spiral into panic, and she no doubt told everyone to lay off the topic.

But now, with what he had said to me and what he managed to do, I would be a fool to deny that in some way, Prime was still out there.

I thought it would panic me, cause me to scream in fear, force me to want to run away to somewhere far off-world and never come back...

But it didn't.

Instead, I felt resolute. Confident.

Maybe Prime's influence had more of an effect on me than I thought. He made me scared of him, made me second guess Catra and... it was him that made me leave that day, when Catra wanted to talk. It was him. It's *all* been *him.* Everything.

But I wasn't afraid. Not anymore. After all, I had Catra by my side, I had the best friends in the universe. And together we had an unbreakable bond. Magic. Love. Friendship. We beat Horde Prime before, we could do it again.

When I opened my eyes, determined blue met worried cyan and gold. As Catra took in my confident stare, her drooped ears rose and a grin slowly spread across her face as she spoke.

'You're right.'

I frowned, immediately confused. 'I didn't say anything?'

Catra shook her head and laughed that adorable squeaky laugh. 'You didn't have to, princess, I can see everything you're thinking in your eyes. You know we can beat him, don't you?'

I smiled at the return of *that* nickname. *Stars, I love her.* 'Yeah. Without him in my head, I feel like I can think clearly for the first time in months.'

'So,' Catra began, 'care to fill me in?'

'I mean– if you want.' I said, wiggling my eyebrows.

Catra groaned but I didn't miss the flush of her cheeks. When she looked down at me again, it was with an amused smile. 'You're such an idiot. I can't believe I'm in love with the biggest dork on Etheria.'

I fake-gasped and held a hand against my heart. 'You love me? How embarrassing for you.'

'You're impossible.' She snickered.

I held my breath for a moment, before throwing caution to the wind and saying the words that had been on the tip of my tongue, but needlessly held back, for the last couple of weeks.

'I love you too.'

And there it was, that soft, wide eyed expression that I first saw after the first time I told Catra I love her in the Heart. It seemed so long ago that we coincidentally saved the world because we *happened* to love each other, confessing that love and kissing at just the right moment for me to transform into She-Ra and *not die.*

I smiled at that thought.

I very much enjoyed not being dead.

But the thought of kissing Catra made my eyes travel down from hers to her lips. I didn't miss the tell-tale flick of Catra's pupils either, that meant she had done the same. I watched as her tongue shot out to wet her lips, and mine copied the action.

'Adora...' Catra whispered. I heard the slight break in her voice, the crack in her armour, as she laid her wants bare for me, even unspoken. Once again, I knew what I wanted, and hoped that my guess was right, and she really did want the same.

'You can kiss me… if you want.' I whispered back, reaching a hand up to cup her jaw and stroke her cheek with my thumb. Her face was so soft, I missed touching her. When she leant into the touch, I once again knew that feeling was shared.

Perhaps she really did miss me as much as I'd missed her.

'Trust me, Adora,' she began, looking down at me with a new kind of hunger, 'I've been wanting.'

Hearing her say that made every moment of intimacy we shared to pass through my mind at once. I took a moment to think

through everything that's happened between us, and how it could have possibly veered so far of course.

'You don't regret it, do you?' I asked, my voice suddenly small considering the moment.

'Regret?' Her eyes shifted to less hungry, and more just confused. I nodded. 'What would I regret, Adora?'

'You know... how we just– jumped right in, after the Heart. We didn't rush it did we? That's not what caused us to drift apart?'

'No, Adora, I don't regret it. And it definitely wasn't what caused us to drift.'

'You sure?'

'I'm sure. I... I'd wanted you, like that, for a long time. Knowing that you felt the same, paired with what you said to me that morning... it just felt *right,* and it was amazing.'

I felt a burst of confidence appear from somewhere and decided to act on it before it disappeared. 'Amazing, huh?'

'Oh *yeah*.'

'What about in the tent in the Waste?'

'That was...' I watched as Catra closed her eyes and shivered, her fur bristling at the memory. '... *Adora*...'

'What about after that? In Dryl? You seemed to enjoy teasing me.'

'I did. I could smell how much you wanted me; it was torture but...'

'So worth it, right?'

'Definitely.'

'When was the next time?' I asked, knowing full well when that well and how undone she'd been afterwards.

'Salineas. You held me up against the wall of our cabin in the ship.' Catra said, her eyes still closed but I could see her breathing becoming heavier. I swallowed, feeling a familiar heat rising within me. 'The next time was about a week into patrolling for the signal, we were both so pent up and that one was particularly...' Catra trailed off with a growl. Only then did she open her eyes. She looked down at me again with blown-wide pupils, licking her lips again to emphasise her returned hunger.

I bet she can smell me already, because with my proximity I could certainly smell her.

'Catra... do you want me?' I wasn't sure why I sounded so unsure; the answer was inches away from my head.

'I never stopped wanting you, Adora.' Catra said in that low, sultry voice that just *does things* to me while starting to lean down to meet me.

'Catra?' The word was more a breathless gasp than anything, just to confirm that this was, in fact, happening.

'Adora?' Catra returned, the word dripping with enamoured confidence. I felt like prey. I was the prey she was stalking me, eyeing me up, considering the best way to feast before even giving chase. Then, apparently deciding on the best way to enjoy her meal, she moved me off her lap and fully onto the floor before straddling my hips and pressing herself up against me with her arms braced beside my head. Wordlessly, she leant further down, nipping along my jaw until she was close enough to whisper in my ear... 'Hey, Adora.'

The whimper that escaped me may or may not have sounded extremely needy, and with it came a new realisation.

We were still in a cell.

'Catra... we're in a cell...'

'So what?'

'What if they see us?'

'I'm so relieved that that's your only problem with this. And, honestly? They should've known better than to put us together, although I don't know if they know who I am yet.'

'I could probably use my sword to cut through this ice you know, if you wanted to break out of here.'

'Yeah, and I could use my claws. But we're not going to break out of here.'

'W– Why not?'

'Well for one, I'm *really* comfy right now.' Catra whispered while gently biting at my ear. I held in a gasp at the feeling of her teeth and breath on me as she continued. 'But we're also waiting for them to come to us and tell us their evil plan.'

'What do you mean?'

'They're just making us wait around as some kind of scare tactic. It's supposed to make us afraid, not think straight, panic - whatever. We're sure showing them though, huh?' Catra's fanged grin should not have turned me on as much as it did, but *when in love*...

'Wait– you said with your claws. Where's your tech?'

Catra leant up just enough to look me in the eye. 'I don't know. I guess they took it, they did watch me go toe-to-toe with She-Ra, and win.' She added on that last part with a devilish grin.

'Alright, you won against *Horde Prime* in She-Ra's body. If it was *me* behind the wheel, I'd have either won already or we'd have tired each other out again.'

'Why didn't he win?' Catra asked, suddenly curious. 'He was in control of the most powerful wea–' Catra stopped herself, frantically searching her mind for another word.

'You can say "weapon", Catra.'

'No!' Catra's outburst was so sudden it almost made me jump. But that would be difficult while lying on the floor with her draped over me. 'You're not a weapon, Adora. You're just... you.'

'I get what you mean, Catra. The new She-Ra feels more like me. Before though, that She-Ra from before I broke the sword... she was *definitely* a weapon. Designed to be the trigger for the Heart of Etheria.'

'Whatever. I'm not arguing this with you right now. I'm just confused why he wasn't able to get the upper hand.'

'I don't know. He pushed me quite far back into my mind so maybe he couldn't read me for my moves. Or maybe it had something to do with his weakness being magic.'

'But he controlled the other Princesses, they have magic.'

'They also had chips. I *didn't*. Maybe his connection to me was less... artificial.'

'Closer, you mean? Stronger?'

'Yeah? I don't know, Catra. It's not like we can ask.'

'Just ask him to come back, I've got a few choice words I'd like him to hear.'

'I've had enough power-crazed evils in my head for a lifetime already, thank you very much.'

'Me too... She really was awful, wasn't she?' Catra asked, finally sitting up. With mention of *her,* the mood had definitely deflated.

'Yeah, she was. You know, right after the Heart, I thought that maybe her sacrifice could have been something she did genuinely for good. But the more I thought about it, the more selfish it seems. She never did anything if it didn't benefit her in some way, and doing that just one thing that seemed like she was helping us... I just can't believe she did it without an ulterior motive.'

'Maybe she knew it would mess us up. Think things like *"oh maybe she was just looking out for us all along and wasn't really that bad at all"*,' Catra scoffed, 'yeah right. Good try. She deserves to *rot*, but she doesn't even get that because she completely obliterated herself.'

'That could be part of it. If there was a body, it would probably feel more real. But because of who she was, I still find myself double checking oddly shaped shadows... just in case.'

'I know I'm all for you sharing things with me, but maybe don't include that particular thought when we have a sleepover and tell each other ghost stories.'

'What? Ghost stories? What's that?'

'You mean you don't...?' I shook my head. 'Huh. I would've thought the Super Lame Squad would have tried that with you already. Anyway, Sparkles mentioned at one point that once this is all over, she wants to have a girls-night. Some kind of sleep-over the boys aren't invited to. Snacks, gossip, and ghost-stories are apparently on the menu.'

'That... honestly sounds really fun.'

'Yeah I guess, it could be fun.'

'Aw, look at you wanting to hang out with everyone.'

'Yeah, well, Scorpia will probably go so it would be rude if I didn't.'

'Aww… and look at you not wanting to be rude!'

'Don't push it, dork.'

'Wouldn't dream of it, brat.'

At the twitch of Catra's ear towards the cell's door it seemed that our time alone was, unfortunately, coming to a close. 'Someone's coming.' She said, angling her ears back to better analyse the sound of approaching footsteps. 'For the record, I still want to kiss you.'

I grinned far wider than I should have. This almost felt unreal. 'Done. Anything else?'

Catra closed her eyes and hummed to herself. 'I wouldn't mind being picked up again. You've got me thinking about what we did in Salineas.'

'Deal. Done. Yes, absolutely. After Prom?' I almost faltered with my words but somehow managed to get through by keeping them limited.

'After Prom.' Catra agreed, her tail brushing my cheek as she got up from her straddle, relinquishing her position over my hips. I reluctantly sat up too, just in time to hear voices outside the cell.

'Let me go in, alone.'

'But he said—'

'I know what he said, let me go in, you stand guard out here in case I need backup.'

'Yeah. Yeah, okay. Don't take too long.'

'Pfft. Ye of little faith.'

The hushed words were followed by the rattle of keys, and the clunk of the cell door opening followed soon after. A cloaked man entered. His features fairly bland, simple beard, small nose. But

his eyes? They flashed a bright reptilian green before blinking back to straightforward brown.

'If it isn't my two favourite co-conspirators, kitten and her mate.'

'DT?' I asked, finding that to be the only thing I was capable of thinking in that moment.

'Obviously. Now, keep it down. By the way, great job getting captured, truly a stroke of genius.'

Catra scoffed and began to defend us. 'Well, we weren't exactly trying to—'

'Oh hush now, of course you were. Listen, I don't have long. Leave finding the leader of this group to me. You two need to get out of here.'

'What do you mean? That wasn't the plan.' Catra was whispering as loud as she could without alerting the guard outside. Luckily, both her and DT had good hearing, while I was left straining to pick up on what they were saying.

'Neither was you getting caught. Plans change, kitten. The missing people you mentioned are here, get them out. I'll probably be taken to see our glorious leader for failing to keep you locked up.' They held up the ring of keys in their hand. 'I'm so going to regret this... you need to knock me and my friend outside out cold, then there's a few more down the hall. You'll also find a crate with your things in. *All of them.* You'll have to find somewhere else to stay.'

The weight of that statement settled on me almost at once. The Glistening Icicle was compromised? All our stuff had been taken? I hoped beyond hope that one particular item I'd left on the bedside table hadn't been sold off or something already and had just been put with the rest of our things.

Deep in my own thoughts, I almost missed the way that Catra nodded resolutely while silently taking the keys from DT. They closed their eyes and whispered something I couldn't make out.

I snapped out of my own thoughts just in time to hear Catra whisper, 'don't be so dramatic.' Then I watched as she leant forwards, took the stun baton from their belt, and wordlessly stunned them without a second thought.

'Catra!' I let slip, a little too loud.

'What?' She asked, turning to look at me like I'd said something offensive. 'They literally asked me to. Plus, I've wanted to do that for a long time.'

I didn't have time to press further however, because a harsh shout of 'What's going on in there?' pushed Catra into action.

Just as the cell door opened inward, Catra leapt behind it and forcefully pushed against the door, dazing the guard as they entered the cell. Not wasting a second, she followed the motion of the door, coming up behind the guard, stunning them with the baton, and kicking them forward to lie neatly next to the still disguised Double Trouble.

Apparently, the baton had been on a low setting when Catra stunned them, because they winked a reptilian green eye at me before closing it and continuing to "play dead".

'Adora!' Catra's voice brought me back to the moment and I shot up, immediately at the ready. 'Come on! We've got to the find the missing people.'

I stepped forward, following Catra out of the cell and watching as she locked it behind us. 'Do you think they're the same missing people Frosta's advisor mentioned?'

Catra nodded and grabbed the keys in her hand to stop them from jingling. 'I'm positive. I only told DT about them in case they might be able to tell us where they are, but they've given us the perfect opportunity to break them out, as well as handing us the keys.'

We started down the corridor, following Catra's nose and ears as she followed the smell of cooking food and the sound of harsh laughter. The whole place looked like it had carved out of ice, but it was dirty and unkempt, a stark contrast to the Ice Castle where Frosta would be holding her re-do of Princess Prom in a couple of days.

Eventually, Catra motioned for us to stop, directing us toward a couple of crates blanketed with cobwebs that we could safely duck behind.

'What do you see?' I asked, voice hushed while watching as Catra pinned her ears back and peeked over the top of the smaller crate she was knelt behind.

'Four guys, all wearing cloaks. They're sat around a campfire. I smell booze, lots of it. This should be easy.' She looked back at me and grinned, but her smile faltered when she saw the conflict on my face. 'What are you thinking, Adora? Care to share with the rest of us?'

'I just– do we have to fight them? Is there any way we could sneak past? Are the missing people definitely this way?'

'Yes, they are. I can hear, and sort of smell, them. They're on the other side of this room, down that passage.' Catra nodded ahead, motioning past the group of drunken guards. '*I* could potentially sneak past, but I don't know about you.'

'Hey! I can be sneaky.'

'*Sure* you can.'

'A little faith would be nice but– yeah, you're probably right.' I sighed and ducked back down behind the box. 'How do you want to do this then?'

Catra continued watching the rowdy bunch for a moment before nodding to herself. 'I could do it.'

'Do what?'

'I could get past. If I leave my boots and coat here with you, I can sneak behind those boxes. It'll be even easier with them drunk like this, they won't be looking out for me and you know how quiet I can be.'

'Catra–'

'Plus, I've got the keys with me and this stun stick if I need it.'

'Catra–'

'Adora, we both know this is the best chance we have of getting past unseen.'

'I know! I'm trying to tell you it's a good idea.'

'Oh, right.'

'Just one thing. Do you know where the way out is?'

Catra faltered, her mouth opening and closing a few times. She looked behind us, then ahead, before closing her eyes and sighing. 'No, I don't. Do you think the prisoners will know?'

'Maybe? When you've freed them come back where I can see you and point in the direction of the exit if you're able to find out which way it is.'

'Okay,' Catra nodded, turning back to look out into the room, 'sounds like a plan.'

I watched and she pulled off each boot as quietly as she could, leaving them stood against the crate. Then, once she had taken off her coat and rolled it up next to her winter footwear, I grabbed her wrist and held tight.

'Adora, what's wrong?'

But words escaped me in that moment. Instead, I simply cradled her face in my hands and brought her towards me. I heard her breath hitch, but she didn't pull away, meeting my lips with hers in a chaste kiss that flooded me with warmth.

I pulled away after a moment, but Catra's hand in my hair brought me back in, this time for a much deeper and longer kiss that had far more intention behind it than the first. I held back a moan, because that would be an embarrassing way to give away our position, but I'd be lying if this kiss wasn't everything I'd hoped it would be.

A reminder.

A promise.

A *stay safe*.

Catra pulled away eventually, leaving us both a little breathless and flushed to our ears. She grinned, and I returned the smile with one of my own. *She's so gorgeous.*

'See you soon.' Catra whispered, leaning in to kiss my forehead before peeking over the crate again. 'I won't be long.'

'Okay.' I managed to breathe out just in time before she vaulted the crate and silently stalked to one edge of the room, keeping out of the light and behind other crates while avoiding the guards' line of sight.

I watched Catra go until she was lost to the shadows and then, not wanting to risk giving myself away, I slunk back down to sit on the floor behind the crate. I raised my hands to my lips, brushing them ever so slightly and feeling how they were still a little swollen from the kiss. The bright smile that overtook my face couldn't have been stopped if I tried, and I had to fight down the urge to squeal in delight.

I kissed Catra!

She kissed me back!

It was *amazing!*

In that moment I decided, perhaps not for the first time, that kissing Catra was absolutely one of my favourite things to do. Ever. Just, *wow*.

It wasn't until after I had sat there for a good few minutes, pondering when I would be able to kiss Catra next and peeping over the top of the crates intermittently, that eventually I caught sight of those glowing cyan and gold orbs across the way staring back at me. I practically froze, caught out. Somehow, I hadn't been expecting to actually make eye-contact again with her so soon. Something about the way her eyes *shone* in the dim light just seemed so beautiful to me in that moment.

But that's when I noticed she was frowning and waving her arms about trying to get my attention. Oh, right, yeah– need to focus.

She was making some kind of chopping motion toward me, then swinging her arms about like she was holding a sword before pointing to the drunken guards between us.

I was completely lost.

"What?" I mouthed.

Catra tried to say something silently, but I was no lip-reader. My brows just furrowed more in confusion.

"What? I don't understand." I mouthed again, unsure if Catra would even be able to lip-read me if I couldn't lip-read her.

Catra visibly groaned, dropping her face into her hands as small blue shapes started appearing behind her in the passage.

'Adora!' Catra growled, her voice loud enough to fill the cavern. 'We have to go back that way, attack these idiots with your sword!'

Oh!

The idiots in question ceased their revelry, blinking up in confusion at the unwelcome commotion.

'Why didn't you just say so!' I shot back, tearing the guards' attention away from Catra and back to me.

As soon as they stood and brandished their swords, I made a show of summoning She-Ra's sword in front of me. 'Okay! Who's first?' I taunted, watching out of the corner of my eye as Catra started pointing a number of winter-coat clad people around the outskirts of the room. Two of them looked particularly young, clutching each other tightly.

The first of the drunken oafs swaggered toward me, but they were so out of it I barely had to dodge when they swung at me, the weight of their sword dragging them to the ground. I side-stepped, expecting some kind of follow-up but– they just stayed on the floor, snoring.

Okay.

I glanced up to see Catra grab hold of two bags, our bags, and sling them over her shoulders before following the last of the prisoners around the room. Smiling, I turned to the other three guards. They seemed unsure, unsteady on their feet as they swayed side-to-side. Obviously, they had not been expecting to have to fight anyone today, let alone She-Ra herself.

Sighing, I decided not to drag this out. I slashed at the air in front of me, sending out a wave of magical energy that careered into the three stooges simultaneously, sending them flying backwards and knocking them all out cold at once.

'*Adora!* You could have at least *pretended* to go easy on them.'

I turned to find a smirking Catra glaring at me with a mischievous glint in her eye.

'*Please.* We don't have time for me to play with them.'

'Oh, I'm *sorry*, I forgot the great and powerful She-Ra could just so easily wipe the floor with drunken idiots but doesn't understand basic hand signals.'

Scoffing at Catra's indignation, I let the sword disappear from my hand. 'Well I'm sorry I don't remember all the signals from the Horde, that was years ago!'

'Adora!' Catra cackled, the laugh soon turning high and squeaky. 'Those weren't Horde hand signals, I was literally miming swinging a sword around, it was so simple I thought you might actually understand. You were always awful at them.'

'Yeah, yeah, whatever.' I brushed Catra's teasing off and tried to hide my blush. She was *right*, but I didn't want her all smug about it. 'Where are these people going?'

I watched as they shuffled past, back down the passage we had come from. Almost all of them were wearing those big blue winter coats that everyone in the Kingdom of Snows seemed to own.

'They know the way out. *Most* of them weren't *unconscious* when they were brought here.' Catra explained, a little mirth to her tone. 'So we're going to follow them and then think of what to do next, then lay low I guess.'

I was about to point out that finding somewhere to lay low would be incredibly difficult in a town where you couldn't trust anyone, when a little voice piped up from behind Catra. It was a small girl, clutching her hands to her chest as if holding onto something precious. An older boy loomed behind her, but neither looked any older than Frosta.

'You should stay with us!'

Catra, almost imperceptivity, jumped. I shot her a knowing look and she just growled, shrugging off the momentary lapse in her hyper-awareness of our surroundings.

'You want us to stay with you?' I asked, bobbing down to meet the girl at eye-level. She nodded under her coat's hood and beamed at me. The boy behind her frowned, placing his hands on her shoulders protectively.

They looked adorable all bundled up in their coats.

'Where are your parents?' I had been thinking it, but Catra asked the question. There was no malice to her tone, and she seemed to regard the kids with a gentleness that she rarely let show around people other than me. Would Catra be good with kids? I wonder if she'd want—

Nope.

Nooope.

Not thinking about *that* right now.

I haven't even proposed.

Yet.

'They should be at home.' The boy provided; his voice quiet despite the death eyes he was giving us. He must not be trusting of us, and very protective over this girl. 'They sent us to get more bread, because we ran out, but then we were grabbed and brought here.'

'Are you siblings?' Catra asked again, briefly glancing up as the last few people made their way down the passage toward, what I assumed would be, the exit. The boy nodded once. 'What's your names? Unless you want me to call you Child One and Child Two.'

The girl giggled and Catra beamed, she looked so genuinely happy to have made her laugh that something tugged on my heart.

'I'm Lanche, and this is my sister, Ava.'

I didn't miss the smirk when it spread across Catra's face, so before she could butt in I circled us back round to why they were standing here with us instead of escaping. 'Are you sure we can stay with you? It would be awesome, we... kind of have nowhere safe to go.'

'Yeah! I wanna show a real princess my room and all my teddies!' Ava proudly declared.

Well, that settles that.

Wait– 'How did you know I'm a princess?'

'I had to tell them who I was here with when a few of the adults gave me funny looks.' Catra explained quickly, she had reluctantly pulled her boots back on and stood with her coat over one arm.

'Also I saw you get the bad men with magic! It was so cool! I wish I was a princess...' Ava grumbled that last part while staring down at whatever it was she had in her hand.

'Yeah, well, take it from me kid, they're all *coocoo.*' Catra just grinned when I scoffed. 'Can we go? We've stayed too long already.'

'Yeah, alright. I guess we're following you guys.' I said, taking my pack from Catra and smiling when Lanche nodded, steering his sister back the way we came.

Catra pulled on her coat before mirroring me by also putting her backpack on. She maybe lasted a whole minute before she turned to me with that glint in her eye. *'Adora!'*

'No, Catra. Don't be rude.'

'But, *Adora!* Do you think everyone here has slightly snow-themed names?' She watched Ava and Lanche as they turned a corner, holding hands while speeding up to catch-up with the rest of the procession.

'Not like your name is much better.' I mumbled, but of course she heard me.

'Well I was literally named by a toddler who happened know what a cat looked like, whose name ended in RA, could somehow recognise what kind of box I arrived in, and for *some reason* took me complaining about being cold to mean I wanted that in my name, so I don't think *you* can pin that one on me.' Catra Applesauce Meowmeow crossed her arms and stormed off ahead, catching up to the avalanche siblings.

'I thought you liked your name?' I asked once I caught up with her. Catra just rolled her eyes and looked at me with a glare that said everything, but she voiced her thoughts anyway.

'I hate *most* of my name. The first one I can live with. If you *ever* tell anyone the other parts—'

'Alright! I won't tell... *Yet.*' I couldn't hide the smirk and Catra's warning growl didn't phase me one bit. 'What? What if I accidentally mention it or something when we're joking around and having fun?'

'I am literally not having this conversation with you right now. Let's just get out of here.'

And despite her stoic attitude, Catra still took my hand when I offered it.

It turned out that we had been kept in a mined-out basement complex under some kind of old abandoned warehouse. No-one stuck around long enough to get a good look however, as all the no-longer-missing people were pretty eager to get home to their families. For whatever reason, we didn't meet any more resistance

on the way out, and all the people were able to speed off relatively quickly under the cover of the snow that had started falling sometime between us getting captured and escaping.

Catra and I kept close to the kids who had offered us shelter, hiding our faces as best as we could under our hoods while traversing the snowy streets. Their house was large, and their parents grateful. With a moment to finally calm down and check, we found that our packs still had all our stuff inside them, including Catra's tech which was carelessly shoved in the top of one of them. But the whole thing kind of sped past for me as my thoughts were all turned around.

Was it okay to just let everyone go home?

Wouldn't they just be captured again?

Why was there so little resistance to us escaping?

Would DT be okay?

Why is Catra so good with kids?

How are we going to stop the Stewards of Peace from carrying out their plan?

When I spotted Ava giving Catra something out of the corner of my eye, she looked so incredibly grateful that it warmed my heart and brought me back from whatever hole my mind had dropped in.

All we had to do was lay low and wait to hear from DT, maybe contact Glimmer to update her before the Prom, and form a plan based on that new information. As Frosta had said, we only really had to focus on finding the leader of the group now that the missing people were found, and DT said they'd handle that.

When Catra excused herself to the spare room we'd been lent, I waited maybe five minutes before doing the same and following after her.

What I saw nearly gave me heart attack.

Catra.

Looking at herself in the room's vanity's mirror.

Wearing the wing pin.

When she noticed me standing in the doorway, frozen almost in shock, her eyes widened, and she sputtered briefly before finding her words.

'W-What? Don't worry, we're not engaged or anything, I was just trying it on.' Catra said quickly, stepping away from the vanity and back towards the middle of the room.

'Where'd you get that?' I asked, gobsmacked at the sight before me.

Catra shrugged. 'Ava gave it to me not too long ago, she found it on the floor when you were busy helping them escape and held onto it until we got her back here.'

Everything I could feel was screaming at me to deflect the conversation, to talk about the moons, the grain of the wood in the floorboards, how my heart was thumping so hard in my chest I thought I was about to explode. I didn't say any of those things, instead pushing past those thoughts and asking the one thing on my mind, despite the deep red blush that flooded down to my shoulders.

'Is... Is that something you would want? To be engaged?'

Catra sighed and sat down at the end of the bed and absently thumbed the outline of the golden wing that was pinned to her clothes, right over her heart. She seemed lost in thought for a long moment until I closed the door behind me. Catra watched as I crossed the room and smiled softly when I sat next to her. She held out her hand for me, and I didn't hesitate to thread our

fingers together. Then, she took a deep, shaky breath, and started to finally, truly, *talk.*

'Honestly, Adora? There have been a few times where I thought... y'know... *this is it, she's proposing, don't freak out*... but you didn't.' Catra looked up, out of the window, staring up at the three moons shining high above. 'Don't take this the wrong way but... I don't know if I was disappointed or relieved. I'm almost certain you were going to ask that one night, during Sparkles' light show but... I think if you had asked then... I don't know if I could have given you the answer you wanted.'

Catra let go of my hand to gently take the pin off, placing it in my hand like it was the most precious treasure on the planet. Her fingers lightly trailed over it before she curled up on the bed behind me. 'All of this was so fresh then. The Heart, the magic, us... I think it would have been too soon. Do you remember our talk in Salineas? That's kind of why I asked where you wanted this to go, between us. Despite the weight of what I was keeping from you, I think that was the day I decided that, yeah, I do want to be with you forever.' Catra's tail thudded down on the bed before I could speak. A clear signal that she wasn't done. I resisted the urge to turn around, worried that if I did, I would whatever spell this was, and she wouldn't continue.

'Before you say anything; I know that we practically promised ourselves to each other when we were young, and I know that you love me, have always loved me, but... that doesn't change how we fought during the war. Those wounds are still healing, I think, especially since I'm still coming to terms with how I treated you. I convinced myself I hated you when really, I just loved you and missed you so much it hurt. I couldn't handle it, so I did the only thing that made sense and I turned that pain against you, your friends, my friends, and countless innocent people who I don't deserve forgiveness from...' Catra's words were calm, punctuated. She didn't falter, her tone remained firm, decisive... she'd thought about this – a lot.

'Catra...'

'Wait, Adora. Look... before Salineas, when I went out on those missions with Glimmer and Bow, I asked them what they thought of us. Sparkles looked like she was ready to burst when I asked about... It doesn't matter. I guess, what I'm getting at, is even though you told me you loved me, made all these promises about how you want me in your life it just... I'm struggling to believe you actually want me around.'

'I do!' I burst, unable to hold it in, spinning around to look at Catra. She looked so cute curled up on the bed and I wanted nothing more than to join her.

'You– what?' Catra leant up slightly at my sudden proclamation, her brows furrowing but her eyes glistening with unshed tears.

'I do want you around! You're right, Catra. Everything you've said is right. I've always loved you, I still do, and there have been countless times where I've wanted to propose to you but... I don't know. At first, I was just... scared, I guess. That you'd say no. But then after Dryl– I think Prime got to me. Almost to the point where I stopped thinking about it. But then you'd do something, anything, and it would remind me and I just...' I sighed and rubbed at my forehead, trying to find the words while also trying not to cry. 'I also didn't want to ask you just anywhere. I wanted it to be special.' I hoped I sounded as earnest as I thought I did and could feel tears welling up in my own eyes. This is it; we're finally talking.

'Adora... you're unbelievable.'

'W-What?'

'Anywhere with you is special. You could have asked me in the *shower,* and I'd have said-'

'Wait.' I sat back and wiped my eyes, trying my best to look serious. 'I know I could have asked whenever. I know. But... a part of me wanted to do it properly. I want you to know how much it means to me, that it's not just some spur of the moment

thing.' I took a deep breath, wincing internally at how my breath shuddered when I breathed out again. 'I've been... I've been agonising over this for so long. Ever since Glimmer told me what marriage was, it's been something I knew I wanted. With you. It was only recently when I realised that you... you need it, don't you? You need the promise.'

Catra's were wide and shining with tears. After a moment, she tore her gaze away and looked around the room blankly before looking back at me and nodding slowly. 'I think... I think you're right. Look, I'm sorry I pushed you away, but I couldn't handle thinking that– that...'

'Hey...' I smiled and placed a hand on her shoulder, nodding for her to continue. 'It's okay. It's alright. You can tell me; I won't be mad.'

That's when Catra's dam broke and the tears she'd been holding back, for the stars only knew how long, began to flow freely. She practically launched herself at me, burying her face into the pulse point at my neck and sobbed into my shoulder. I could feel her tears soaking through my top, but I didn't *care*. I simply raised my arms and wrapped the love of my life in a tight hug, holding her close and whispering soft reassurances into her ear.

'You are loved. *I love you.* Nothing can ever change that. I'll- I'll prove it to you.'

Catra pulled back to look me in the eye. The fur on her face was dark with tears and her eyes red from crying. There was a tremble to her lip and her ears had never been lower. 'You- you'll prove it? How?'

I smiled softly and cradled her face in my hands, scratching at the base of her ears with all the gentleness I could muster. 'You'll see.'

'When?' She whispered, closing her eyes as her ears perked up, leaning into my touch.

'Soon.' I whispered back, closing my own eyes and resting my forehead against hers.

'How soon?'

'Very.'

'You mean—?'

'Yeah.'

'Oh... wow.'

'I promise.'

Catra shivered and I felt the rumble before I heard it. When I opened my eyes, she was smiling, and her eyes were shining. She looked like she was going to burst. 'All this time... I thought that maybe you didn't want me, that I wasn't good enough. I thought that if I pushed you away, it would make it easier for you to forget about me, to leave me behind again. I didn't talk to you because I thought if I did, I would just hear you say the words that I didn't want to hear... *I'm such an idiot!*'

'Yeah, you are.' I found myself laughing, despite hearing everything she just said. 'I can't believe you thought I didn't want you.'

'Yeah, well, let's just say while you were hearing *his* voice, I was hearing *hers*. But Shadow Weaver is *actually* gone, so maybe I'm just crazy. Despite knowing you love me, despite you telling me every day, it still got to me. Just the memory of what she used to say, the kind of things she'd fill my head with when you weren't around... I'm sorry I let it get to me so easily.'

'It's okay,' I promised, 'it's not your fault. But we should absolutely promise to talk to each other about this kind of thing from now on. What do you say?'

'Yeah, okay. I promise. I'll talk to you instead of letting my stupid brain drag me into the ground.'

'That sounds great.' I whispered, holding her close while her soft rumbling began to fill the room. Her tail swayed happily behind her while we both just absorbed everything that had been said.

Our contemplation was interrupted by a beeping coming from Catra's backpack, leant up against the bed near my feet. Catra groaned and reached down, pulling the tracker pad out and answering the call with an indignant 'What!'

'Hey there lovebirds! Sorry to crash whatever it was you were doing, but I may or may not have the identity of the leader of this little attempt at a coup.'

'DT! You saw them?' Catra asked as she sat up, suddenly alert. I climbed up onto the bed next to her and peered down at the familiar sight of the reptilian shapeshifter.

'I did, kitten. He arrived not long after you finally left, really *took your time with that by the way. What caught me off guard at first was his personal entourage of palace guards.'*

'Palace guards?' Catra asked, sharing a confused glance with me. 'From the castle? Not just people off the street?'

'Oh, yeah. Full military takeover. He interrogated me, of course, but I gave him nothing. After all, I was so swiftly beaten by such a skilled warrior—'

'Shut up.'

'—that I stood no chance. He seemed furious at the oversight of keeping you together and demanded to know why there weren't more guards present, yadayadayada, anyway...' DT paused, looking between us as a toothy grin spread across their face. *'You don't care about that, do you darlings? No, you just want to know who he is. Very well, I suppose I'll tell you...'*

But rather than use their words, DT simply *changed* into them. Their form shifted to black, then to blue. They looked just like one of the palace guards, complete with jewelled mask.

'It's one of Frosta's guards?' I asked, confused. How could a guard lead an entire conspiracy?

DT shifted again, losing the mask from their face. The features that stared back at us were old, hardened with age. Their eyes a stony grey, matching their thick eyebrows and the hint of long hair below their hood.

'This still doesn't help.' Catra deadpanned, staring down at the face neither of us could place. 'I've never seen this guy before.'

The grin that took over DT's face was no doubt their usual toothy one, but on this face, it seemed more... *sinister.*

'Are you telling me you never saw his face? What about his voice? Ring any bells, kitten?'

Calm yet stern.

'I know that voice!' I started, 'It's—'

'Iceric.' Catra finished, looking up at me with wide eyes.

'Iceric – the Royal Advisor Iceric?' I asked, incredulous. It couldn't be...

'The Princess has no immediate family, if she were to disappear, he would be made regent and gain control of the kingdom again.' DT started, chuckling dryly. *'Guy really likes to talk when you know which buttons to press. Anyway, it checks out. My guess, if you want it, is that he's been trying to get her to step down willingly. But after all this ruckus, I wouldn't be surprised if he has something else planned.'*

'What about the people who were down there with us, are they safe?' I needed to know that they wouldn't just be hunted down

again, that we could move on and focus on the next part of the mission.

'Oh, absolutely. They're "of no consequence". His words, not mine. He's fully focused on what comes next.'

'Do you know what his next move is?' Catra pressed, but DT just smirked and shifted back to their regular self.

'I'll keep you updated, kitten. Keep the line open. I'll hang around here until the party, stay in character, see what shenanigans I can get up to while you two just sit pretty and lay low for a while.'

Catra looked to me and I nodded. It made sense to lay low, give ourselves chance to prepare. 'Okay, DT. Thanks.' She said, the hint of a smile teasing at the corner of her mouth.

'Don't mention it, kitten. Stay safe.' And with that, the call went dark.

I sighed and let myself drop back onto the bed, staring at the ceiling. Catra put the tracker pad down and curled up next to me, her fingers tracing lines across my stomach. As if it was the most natural thing in the world, my hand reached up and started stroking through her hair and scritching softly at the base of her ears. She trilled at the contact and I smiled to myself, enjoying the moment for a second before sighing, giving in, and voicing my thoughts.

'Are we going to be able to pull this off?' I began, glancing over at the adorable sight next to me. 'I wasn't expecting it to literally be Frosta's right hand guy.'

'We'll be fine.' Catra supplied, her voice unwavering and confident. 'We'll contact Glitter and Arrowhead tomorrow and talk it through, but...'

'But?'

'But, right now, I just want to cuddle and sleep. It's been *a day*.'

'It has.'

'Adora?'

'Yeah?'

'Did you mean what you said?'

'About what?'

'Well, you didn't say it outright, but...'

'Oh, uh... Yeah, I meant it. I'm going to ask. At Prom.'

'Okay.'

'Okay?'

'Yeah. I can't wait.'

'Cool.'

'Dummy.'

'I love you.'

'I know.'

'Hey!'

Catra laughed her squeaky laugh, her gaze filled with nothing but warmth.

'I love you too, Adora.'

Chapter End Notes

What are we thinking?

Yes, next chapter is the Prom.

Literally been building to this since Chapter 12.

Unlike this chapter, next chapter isn't already two thirds written, so there may be a much longer wait. But it'll be worth it. More fluff is coming, I promise.

Winter Wonderland

Chapter Summary

The All-Princess Ball begins.

Iceric makes his move.

Adora asks a question.

Chapter Notes

Hey everybody!

Welcome! Sorry about the wait, those who follow me on Instagram and Twitter may know of my obsession with my new cyberpunk AU 'dive into me' which took up a lot of my brain space.

What's new? Chapter 23 and Chapter 5 now have Illustrations! Check those out and give @the.r.account and @apples_dashie the love they deserve!

Now then... this chapter. Brought to you by @the.r.account telling me I should finish this story before I get too deep in my AU. A lot happens, and I'm very happy with it. Hope you all like it too.

I aimed to write 4k words. It ended up being 11k. Don't ask.

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'So, how do we prove that it's been Iceric this whole time?' I asked, throwing the question out there. We were all thinking it, at least I think we were. *I hope we were.* Seeing the expressions on Bow and Glimmer's faces through the tracker pad shift to more thoughtful ones, as opposed to the downright suspicious ones

they had before, kind of hinted they were thinking about something else beforehand.

But what?

'We could just capture him. Torture him into telling us everything?' Catra suggested from her position *in my lap*. I batted her tail away from my face.

'Catra! We can't do that... it wouldn't be, um...' I forgot what I was going to say as Catra leant her head back against my shoulder, looking up at me with wide, adoring eyes. I couldn't hold myself back from planting a soft kiss against her forehead and gently squeezing my arms around her waist.

Glimmer's eyes narrowed and Bow beamed a wide smile. I could tell I was going to be interrogated about this later, but for now neither of them commented.

'Why don't we just show up and see what happens? The entire Princess Alliance is going to be there, whatever happens we'll be fine!' Bow provided, bouncing a little as if to emphasise his boundless optimism.

Glimmer sighed and rest her head on his shoulder as I buried a hand in Catra's hair, scratching behind her ear. Catra then let her eyes drift closed and she leaned into the touch, purring softly.

'It really says something that "wing it" is our best plan so far.' Glimmer mused, content to just close her eyes and melt into Bow.

'In my defence, "wing it" was not *what I said.'*

'It was implied*, Bow.'*

'Yeaahh, you're right.' He chuckled, knowing better than to stoke the flames of an apparently tired Glimmer.

Catra shifted in my lap, bringing up her legs and tucking her head under my chin. I chuckled when I heard her growl; apparently removing my hand for a second to let her get settled was *not allowed*. Her purr continued when I replaced my hand and resumed providing her with her coveted ear scritches.

'Bow and I will be arriving tomorrow in time for the Prom, so you two make sure to stay out of trouble until then. Okay?' Glimmer warned, trying to sound authoritative but failing as she steadily succumbed to her sudden bout of tiredness. Bow just smiled fondly at his girlfriend, reaching up to take off her crown when it started running up her forehead at an odd angle.

'*Okay*, Glim. I'm not sure much can go wrong overnight, and we've managed to keep quiet in Lanche and Ava's house for a whole day without any problems.' I said, keeping my voice down. I could feel Catra's breathing getting deeper by the second, which meant any moment now she'd be dropping off. It was either the excitement from the last few days catching up with her, or she was ridiculously comfortable and my hand in her hair was helping to lull her to sleep.

'Yes, but it's you two*. And from the look of Catra I'm not convinced you'll make it through tonight–'* Glimmer interrupted herself with a yawn, *'–keeping quiet.'*

'I make no promises... Sparkles.' Catra grumbled quietly from her position over my chest.

'Ugh, you two are so gross.' Glimmer dismissed us with a lazy wave of her hand and then, finally, flopped down into Bow's lap.

'What Glimmer means *to say,'* Bow started, fondly shaking his head, *'is that we can't wait to see you tomorrow for the first actual Princess Prom since the war ended! Even if, you know, Frosta's advisor may be planning on completely ruining it.'*

'Ha. Well, as long as he doesn't use *heat-bombs* and crash the ceiling onto us, I'm sure we'll be fine.' I smiled as the ear under

my hand twitched, the faintest sign that Catra was actually somewhat paying attention.

She made an amused noise in response, which just merged with her ongoing content and blissful purring. 'Hmm... Don't tempt me...'

After that, the conversation entered a peaceful lull, Bow and I just contentedly stroking through our girlfriend's hair while they... *fell asleep?* Bow and I shared a bemused glance before stifling a laugh.

'Did both Glim and Catra just–'

'Fall asleep? Yeah, looks like it. I think Catra's just... happy, maybe. Comfortable. The last couple days have been really great. I think she's been able to relax a bit despite us literally hiding out here.'

'That's good, it really is great to see you two getting along again.' Bow said, looking at us through the tracker pad with a soft smile and wide heart-eyes.

'What about you? Why has Bright Moon's queen just collapsed?' I asked, quirking a brow.

Bow furrowed his brow and grimaced apologetically. *'Uhh... I don't think she wants me saying too much. But she's* kinda *been rushing around while you've been gone and she finally finished up what she was doing today.'*

Interesting. 'Well if you're not allowed to tell me I won't pry. You're just lucky Catra's asleep because she *would not* let it go until you tell her.'

'I... have to agree with that statement. She was doing this thing before where I swear her eyes doubled in size. It was so cute! *I just can't say no to that adorable widdle face.'*

'Oh, yeah, that was one of her favourite tricks when we were younger. Always worked a treat on Kyle. She'd get him to swap ration bars with her if he got one of the grey ones and she got a brown. The grey ones were always better.'

'I can't even begin to imagine what they tasted like. But, remembering your face when you ate real food for the first time? They can't *be good.'*

'Yeah they were... not great. They had all the stuff in them you needed to be fit and strong, but... yeah. Not amazing. Hey! Maybe we can see if there's any left in the Fright Zone for you to try, and maybe Catra and I could show you around where we grew up. That could be a fun Best Friend Squad trip, right?'

'That... sounds great, Adora. Although, part of me is reluctant to see exactly what kinds of conditions you grew up in, and I'm sure there's a bunch of stuff there that you've not thought about in a long time. But, in case you do see something that triggers a... weird memory, I guess we'll be there to support you. Both of you.'

'Yeah, thanks Bow. I want to. I want to go back with Catra but... I don't know if just me and her going alone would be a good idea. So, I guess... I'm glad you'd be okay to go along with us.'

'Of course, Adora. That's what best friends do.'

'Thanks, Bow.'

'As much as I would love staying up late to talk, I should probably go,' Bow said, reaching over a sleeping Glimmer to pick up the tracking pad. His face filled the screen not a moment later. *'If I don't make Glimmer change into her pyjamas, she'll kill me in the morning. Just-woken-up Glimmer is much scarier than super-tired Glimmer.'*

Adora giggled quietly, very aware of the sleeping feline slumping further into her lap. 'Okay Bow, see you tomorrow.'

'You will. Goodnight, Adora.'

'Goodnight.'

The morning of the Prom was a flurry of activity from the moment we woke up to a loud banging on the door of the bedroom Catra and I were sharing in Lanche and Ava's house.

'If you two aren't up and dressed in five minutes I'm breaking this door down! We're going to be late!'

Luckily, I'd pinged Glimmer our location the day before so she could easily find us. Not so luckily – we'd slept in.

Catra *growled*. Like a proper growl, *a scary one*, against the pulse point at my neck. She was draped over me, completely naked against my equally naked self.

Yes, okay, maybe I had given in when Catra started protesting halfway through us getting changed the night before. In her defence, I had just nudged her awake from the very peaceful sleep she'd slipped into. In my defence... well, *naked Catra*. *Cuddles*. Soft, warm fur...

Who was I to refuse the woman I planned to propose to?

Oh.

That's today.

I'm proposing *today.*

With that thought in mind, getting up and ready became much more exciting than it seemed it would be just a moment beforehand.

As soon as we were ready and Glimmer's foot looked like it was about to impatiently tap a hole through the floor, we thanked the "avalanche" siblings for their help, thanked their parents for putting up with us for a whole day, and then made to leave. But not before Ava managed to coax Catra into one of the most adorable hugs I've ever witnessed.

I was just a *little bit* jealous.

Of a child.

But then I took another moment to see how *gentle* Catra was when leaning back from the hug, looking at Ava with such *kind* eyes the likes of which I've hardly ever seen her show another person, and my heart panged with a new kind of longing.

A new longing, yes. But a *scary* one. One that's definitely *too soon*. One that can *wait*.

One thing at a time, Adora.

Propose first, then get married, *then*...

... *Then we'll see.*

I squeezed the golden wing in my hand, the meaning behind it lying heavy in my heart, and joined hands with Glimmer.

'Ta-Da!'

'What's this?'

'Your dress! What do you think? Frosta wanted this Prom to be ice-themed, *very original*, so everyone's wearing cold colours.

Whites and blues and such.'

'Is Catra—'

'*Yes*, you're matching with Catra. Don't worry, we picked her out a *killer* suit. Part of me is more excited to see her than you...'

'Hey! That's my girlfriend you're picturing, you know.'

'*How* exactly am I supposed to know? You two have been at the opposite end of every room you're in together for weeks! Then you go on a trip where you're *supposed* to be tracking down the leader of a dangerous group, but Catra just loads *that* job onto Double Trouble! And then, what, you elope!?'

'Woah, okay. One: we did not elope. Two—'

'Okay! Whatever. Look, I'm happy for you, I am. But seeing you fight was not fun.'

'Yeah, sorry about that. You were right; we really did just need to *talk* to each other.'

'See? I'm always right.'

'*Well*...'

'Shut it! Now, put that dress on before your girlfriend storms in here when you're not wearing it. Speaking of, I'm going to go check on Bow and Catra. I want to see the look on her face when she sees you.' Glimmer paused at the door, looking back at me with a glint in her eye that made me swallow nervously. 'And I want to see *your* face when you see *her*.'

Once the door closed behind her, I looked down at the folded bundle of light blue that Glimmer had left me with.

The dress looked phenomenal when I held it out in front of me. It had just the right amount of areas for skin to show through, in all the places that I knew Catra would love to see. The back was

almost completely bare, with the front leading down from the neck. My shoulders and collarbones would also be on display, and I briefly imagined Catra's hands making the most of the exposure.

Wasting no more time, I set to work undressing myself and changing into the dress. It took me a moment to work out exactly how it fit over my head, but I was able to work it out eventually through some annoyingly testing trial and error. Eventually, I managed it, then set to work trying to tie the back of the neck together. Briefly, I wondered how I would be able to defend myself if Iceric had some kind of attack planned, but that was a problem for future Adora. The Adora standing in front of the mirror in the small guest room within Frosta's castle just wanted to impress her girlfriend and (hopefully) future fiancée.

Hopefully? Catra wouldn't say no, right? Not after all this? I practically told her I would propose a couple days ago after we escaped from that ice cell and rescued the missing people. She didn't seem opposed to it then. But people can change their minds... No, Adora, *focus!* Just ask, then take it from there.

The sound of the door opening behind me brought me back to the present, where I was still struggling to do up my dress. 'Glimmer, thank the stars, I need help with my—'

'*Hey, Adora*.'

My brain immediately ceased to function.

'How's it hangin'?'

Catra. Just *talking*. All she's doing is talking, but why does it sound so *good*? Her voice is lower than usual, sultrier, with an intent and desire behind it that I'm *very* familiar with.

'Need a hand?'

Please put your hands on me.

'Please.'

Catra hummed to herself and walked up directly behind me. I saw the briefest flash of blue in the reflection of the mirror as she moved but she was hidden from view before I could get a good enough look.

Next, her hands appeared at my hips, slowly working their way upwards, over the dip of my waist, past my ribs, across the bare expanse of my back, dipping between my shoulder blades then finally coming to a rest at my shoulders, her fingertips only just brushing my collarbones. My skin turned to gooseflesh under her touch and a shiver ran down my spine. I heard a soft chuckle, followed by a firm kiss to the exposed skin at the back of my neck where I had still, so far, failed to tie the dress up.

'Sparkles got you all dressed up for me, didn't she?'

I nodded, incapable of speech.

'You look amazing. Let me do up your dress, and then maybe I'll let you turn around.'

'Okay.' I whispered, nodding to my own reflection in the mirror.

Catra's hands then left my shoulders and released the offending fabric from my grip, but I kept my hands there to continue holding up my hair. It was half up – Glimmer had insisted that she do *something else, anything else* with it, so I relented and *allowed* her to tie some of it back so that it stays out of my eyes in case I need to move or fight in the near future.

'There.' Catra whispered, dropping her hands from my neck to trace along the scars on my back, the ones from before I knew how to heal with She-Ra's magic. 'Your scars are showing, don't you mind?'

'No.' I said. *Because it's true.* 'They're a part of me. Just as much as you are.'

'You're such a sap.'

'I mean it, Catra.'

'I know, dummy.'

'Can I see you?'

I could almost feel the smirk boring a hole in my back, but the feeling of Catra's claws lightly pressing against my skin left trails of fire in their wake. 'You want to see me?'

'I do.'

'Why?'

'"Why"?'

'Yeah, *why*, princess?'

'Because... because I want to see how handsome you are, and I'm going *crazy* trying to imagine it.'

The light pressure of her claws against my back vanished and I heard Catra step back from me by a few paces. 'Alright, dummy. You can look.'

I took a moment to prepare myself, breathing a deep breath in and out, before turning around as slowly as I could physically manage despite my excitement.

And then, regardless of how grounded I thought I was, how well I was hoping to take seeing Catra in a suit again, I was blown away speechless anyway.

She was blushing, a hand rubbing the back of her neck nervously. But she had no reason to be nervous, no reason to be shy. Cool, confident Catra, wearing a suit that looks *this good* on her, was nervous?

Her hair was up. That was new. It was only a small ponytail, but it was enough to keep her hair off her shoulders.

As my gaze dropped to her shoulders, I was finally able to take in the whole spectacle. Catra looked amazing, stunning, and so, so handsome. Her suit was a dark blue, comprised of trousers that she's (so far) managed to resist clawing holes into, as well as a very nice waistcoat. The sleeves of her white shirt were rolled up to her elbows, showing off her forearms, and the top two buttons on the front undone just enough to hint at the sharpness of her collarbones. Altogether, it's like this suit on Catra was made just to short-circuit my brain. Her waist, her hips, her arms, her neck... I wanted to touch every part of her, hold her close and...

That's when I realised Catra was staring at me too. I watched as her pupils darted all over me and the dress, taking me in with so much focus. 'Adora... you look—'

A sudden pink flash accompanied by a shout of 'You guys better be decent!' suddenly filled the small room as Glimmer teleported her and Bow inside. They both looked between us, at our outfits, at our flushed faces, then at each other. They had a silent conversation for a second, nodded, then looked back at us with the most knowing smirks I've ever seen.

Catra narrowed her eyes immediately. 'What's that look for, what did you do?'

'Yeah, guys, I know you said you picked out our clothes but... I almost *died* when I saw Catra.'

'Adora and I almost *died*, Sparkles. What's the big idea!?'

'You're both so adorably dramatic.' Bow observed, wrapping an arm around Glimmer's shoulders.

'Well, just in case you were still being stubborn and not talking to each other, we came up with a *little* back-up plan...' Glimmer started.

"We"? Who's "we"?

'And this little back-up plan of yours, *Sparkles*, was to have Adora and I accidentally seduce each other, is that it?' Catra shot back. But I flushed even redder at the thought that I've just seduced Catra by turning around in a dress and barely saying anything. Truth be told, Catra had me as soon as she said *"Hey, Adora"* when she walked in, but *that* suit on *her* was doing dangerous things to the heat between my legs.

'Uhh... well, yeah, pretty much. *But* – looking at Adora's bright red face, and considering that your tail hasn't stopped going *crazy*, I think the plan would have worked just fine.' Glimmer's confident smirk didn't waver once, even if Bow's face was steadily turning from *confidently smirking* to *excitable beaming*.

'Whatever.' Catra huffed, crossing her arms over her chest.

'Just admit it, Horde Scum, your girl's hot as fu–'

'Can it, Sparkles!'

With Catra glaring at Glimmer and Bow moving to mediate between the two of them as they entered some kind of argument of *"I was just trying to help, why are you so mad!"* and *"I didn't need your help!"* back to *"But you both look great, shut up and enjoy it!"*, I slipped away to attach the golden wing to my dress where it will stay until I pass it on to its new owner. *If* she accepts it. Which she will.

She will, right?

The ballroom was exactly as I remembered it. Enormously tall ceilings, extravagant decor, tons of food, and loads of people dressed extravagantly in winter-themed Ball clothes. I could only

wonder which of these people were princesses and which were their plus ones; everyone was just dressed so *nice*. The band played some kind of funky music while we waited for the host to officially announce the Prom's commencement.

I was stood at the bottom of the stairs, waiting for Catra, when Bow appeared next to me. He smiled sheepishly and fiddled with the snowflake buttons on his light blue dinner jacket.

'Alright, Bow, what's happening? You're making me nervous.'

'Oh! What? I mean, nothing's happening. Not yet anyway.' I narrowed my eyes. And people tell me *I'm* a bad liar? 'Yes, okay. Nothing's happening *yet*. My Dads have decided to move to Bright Moon.'

'Oh! Bow that's great!'

'Yeah... I haven't told Glimmer yet, but I wanted to run this by you before I just blurted it out of nowhere. Do you think I should ask her to appoint them roles within the castle? Like Royal Archivists, or Royal Researchers, or something?'

'I don't know, Bow. Have you talked to them about it?'

'Well... Not really. But the issue of funding has come up a few times. I don't know if I'm overstepping but having a Royal contract would open up so many more opportunities for them. I know they love doing research, into pretty much everything, but they've had to cut back on other projects due to funding difficulties since the war escalated. Not to mention our home in the woods was kind of trashed. The ceiling caved in at some point.'

'Oh no.'

'Yeah, so it would cost too much to fix. Which is why they're moving and—'

'Bow!' I interrupted, stopping him from spiralling any further. 'I think it's a great idea. Your dads are both great guys who love what they do. Having them closer to Bright Moon would mean I could help them more with translations too. Speak to Glimmer, then sit down with her, Micah, and your dads and talk it all through together.'

'Yeah, okay. Thanks, Adora.'

'No problem. I have *no idea* where that came from. Maybe I'm picking up some of what Catra's putting down—'

'You're proposing today, aren't you?'

I froze. 'What?'

'You're focused, but probably more focused than I've ever seen you.'

'Oh, right.'

'Good luck, Adora. I'll keep an eye out for anything suspicious too. But if anyone notices anything, it'll be Catra. Nothing gets past her. I'm going to go find Glimmer before they announce the first dance.'

'Thanks, Bow. And enjoy yourself.'

'You too Adora.'

I watched him disappear into the crowd and continued scanning it for any sign of Catra in her amazing suit. It was a sea of whites and blues. A few pink accents here and there. But by-and-large everyone had met the themed clothing request head-on and smashed it. I could make out a few familiar faces in the crowd. Spinnerella and Netossa were already dancing despite being the only ones doing so, Mermista was grabbing a drink while an attentive Sea Hawk kept offering up each item of the buffet one at a time, and Entrapta was here sitting on the shoulders of... Tall, pale, magenta hair... *Wrong Hordak?* Typically, Entrapta was the

only person not dressed up, her overalls stained as usual. But Wrong Hordak was *quite* the picture in his three-piece suit and snowflake tutu combo. They both looked like they were having a great time, for very different reasons, and no-one seemed at all phased by a pink-haired suit-wearing tutu-sporting clone allowing Entrapta to ride on his shoulders around the ballroom.

Then all but one of the lights dimmed, lighting up the staircase to the throne where Frosta now stood. She looked out across her guests and raised a hand for silence.

'Hey nerds! I don't want to hear a single one of you call me "Revered Hostess" tonight or I might actually gag.' A few laughs sounded from the gathered guests. A cough. '*Ahem!* Anyway, welcome everybody! Princesses and plus ones alike, to the All-Princess Ball Winter Wonderland 2.0! This time we go by *my* rules because we're in *my* house. Not the rules of some centuries year-old tradition that none of us were even around to remember the founding of. Dance however you like, eat whatever you want, do and say whatever you want. But nothing too dangerous! The guards are here for everyone's safety, and that includes protecting you from yourselves if anyone fancies taking a nose-dive off the balcony. And with that, I officially announce the first dance of the Ball!'

Catra suddenly appeared next to me from nowhere, scaring the life out of me and beaming like a love-struck... well *me*, because I was beaming too. 'Hey dummy, what have you been up to? I was just chatting with Scorpia.' Before I had chance to reply Catra grabbed me by the hand and quickly pulled me towards the main floor where other couples were pairing up. 'Dance with me! This is our song!'

'Our song!?'

'Yeah, the one we danced to last time?'

'Oh, is it? I was, uhm... a little too *distracted* last time to really pay attention.'

Catra grinned and stopped us in the middle of the floor, effectively surrounding us with other couples. 'Oh *really*?' She asked, an eyebrow raised, cocky smirk engaged.

Engaged.

I shook my head to stop myself spacing out and spoke before Catra could question it. 'Yeah, I had to make sure you weren't up to something and, you know, *that* suit.'

The smirk grew wider, as if defying the laws of smirks, baring a fang for my own personal torture. 'That suit, huh? You liked it?'

'Catra, I literally forgot how to speak when I saw you.' I confessed as we began to step around the dance floor, hands and eyes never leaving the other.

'I'd have loved to have seen your face.'

'You saw my face earlier when I saw *this* suit, although this one's definitely a contender for top spot.'

'Top spot? Considering I've only worn two suits it's not much of a competition.'

'Oh, I don't know, seems to me like it could get pretty... *heated*.'

'Is that a heat bombs joke or are you suggesting something, princess?'

'Hmm. Maybe you'll find out.'

'Maybe I will.'

'Also, I would *never* joke about bombs. I know how much they mean to you.'

'Jokes or bombs?'

'Yes.'

'Ha!'

'Plus, I'm not about to joke about bombs just in case, you know, there actually *are* some. I'm not you.'

Catra grinned and I saw that mischievous glint in her eye. 'Whatever do you mean, Adora? I would never joke about bombs before setting some off.'

'"Having a blast"? Really?' It was true that I had eventually got the joke, but Catra didn't need to know that it only occurred to me three weeks after the fact.

'Hey! I actually *was* having a blast. I had your eyes on me for the whole thing. I mean, sure, it was part of the plan, but it was also... nice for... you know, other reasons.'

'Uh-huh. Is that why you dipped me?'

'Is that why you raised your thigh between my legs?'

'That's part of the move!'

'Poor defence, Adora. You'll have to try better than that.'

'No, it is! I did my research. I bet you liked it a whole lot more than you let on, didn't you?'

'What! No! Why would you—'

'Why would I what?'

'Hey, Adora, this is unrelated but when did you start leading our dance?'

'I don't know what you mean.'

'I think you d-AHH!'

And just like that I was looking *down* into Catra's beautiful mismatched eyes, and Catra was staring back *up* at me. I watched

closely as her pupils began dilating, an inky blackness spreading across those wonderful pools of sapphire and amber. I could only imagine my eyes were doing the same as I watched Catra's tongue poke out to lick her lips and leave them parted.

An open invitation.

One I would never refuse.

And, of course, the kiss was perfect.

Catra's lips met mine readily, her arms wrapping around my neck both to hold herself up and keep us close. The rest of the room ceased to exist except for Catra. Catra. *Catra*. All I could think and feel was her, the ways she felt against me as I squeezed my arms around her, gently guiding her back to a standing position. The way she kept making the smallest of sounds. The way I greedily swallowed them all. The press of her lips against mine after every time we parted just for a moment. The way she—

'Guys, seriously, just get a room already!' Mermista's voice cut through the illusion and suddenly I remembered it wasn't just me and Catra in the room.

I opened my eyes and laughed nervously, blushing as my eyes scanned the crowd of friends and guests that seemed to have formed around us.

Right. I'm She-Ra.

Of course people are going to be watching.

'Yay!' Perfuma's happy and high-pitched voice cut through the murmur of the crowd, quickly followed by her rapid clapping. 'I'm so pleased for you two making up with one another. Love really is so beautiful.' If anyone else noticed her looking wistfully at Scorpia when she said that last part, they didn't comment.

'I don't know... Looked more like *making out* to me.' Netossa teased from the other side of the crowd, earning a few laughs and

whistles. Someone clapped, and then more people started clapping, and then for some reason we were receiving applause.

Embarrassed, I sought out Catra's face to see how she was taking it and... She... Was just... *Staring* at me. I found myself blushing redder under her gaze than the applause as her eyes, wide and full of love, took in every part of my face as if committing it to memory.

'Catra?'

'You're beautiful, Adora. I love you.'

Against all odds I felt my blush spread even further as I smiled a dopey love-struck grin at my girlfriend.

'I love you too, Catra.'

'All our friends are clapping for us.'

'They are.'

'They must like you or something.'

'They like you too.'

'Whatever.'

Truthfully, I almost did it then and there. I was seconds away from reaching for the pin where it was attached to my dress. *Will you marry me?* was on the tip of my tongue and I felt so, *so* ready to ask it. Surrounded by our friends giving us their full support, Catra's eyes just so full of love to the point where I could see it; and it was all for me.

But I'd forgotten about the one thing that could ruin the party.

Catra didn't miss it. Despite everyone clapping and cheering, her ears still perked up, registering the sound that didn't belong.

A *chirrup.*

A *warning.*

Melog.

They had been a last-minute addition to the plan. The plan that was still, effectively, *wing it*. Apparently, when Glimmer was getting ready to teleport the small gathering of people from Bright Moon to Frosta's Castle, Melog had decided to invite themselves along. No one noticed at first, of course, because they were invisible. Or they were, until Glimmer teleported Catra and I into the castle from the lower level of the kingdom and Melog effectively tackled Catra to the ground.

Now, Catra was receiving a warning from an invisible Melog, hiding somewhere in the room, that Iceric had arrived. We weren't sure when he would show up, or even *if* he would show up, but the way Catra's ears twitched and her eyes went wide and focused told me all I needed to know.

'Hey! *Let me go*!'

The sounds of Frosta resisting soon followed, and Catra whizzed around in my arms to face the throne. Everyone stopped clapping and did the same, looking up the stairs toward where two of Frosta's own guards were holding her aloft by the arms, her legs swinging wildly as she tried to kick at her captors.

One figure stood before her, facing the crowd with a face of stern indifference. His long grey hair was tied back in a low ponytail. Old, stony eyes looked out across the gathering of princesses from under those thick dark eyebrows. He chuffed to himself when all attention was on their little show at the top of the stairs near the throne.

'I'm going to sneak away, see how many other guards are around.' Catra whispered, turning quickly to peck me on the cheek before disappearing into the crowd.

My gaze followed her until another voice filled the ballroom and commanded everyone's attention.

'Greetings, esteemed guests of Princess Frosta's Winter Wonderland All-Princess Ball!' Iceric boomed from the top of the stairs. The band had stopped playing its music at some point, but I hadn't noticed when. 'By the will of the people, Princess Frosta is to be removed from her station as ruler of the Kingdom of Snows, effective immediately. Her reign has been looked upon with disdain for many years. She is too young to rule, she made impulse decisions, was too eager to please and worst of all, involved our once peaceful and neutral kingdom in a war we wanted no part of. During her time away from her post, I took charge as Steward, and led this kingdom as if it were my own. The people wish for my rule to continue, and as Steward I must carry out the will of the people. Any objections?'

'*Is* this the will of the people!? Or just *your* will?' Glimmer shouted from the ballroom floor. Iceric didn't so much as flinch.

'Very well,' he began again, ignoring Glimmer entirely, 'then if there are no objections—'

'Ahem!' Someone cleared their throat loud enough to interrupt Iceric. I looked around for the source and noticed Catra, who had slipped on her First Ones' tech during the confusion, lowering a gloved and glowing fist from in front of her mouth. I couldn't help but marvel at the confident yet utterly perplexed expression adorning her features. 'I don't even know where to start. You know... We had an entire, practically fool proof plan for how to out you as the leader of the Stewards, and yet you stand in front of the entire Princess Alliance and do it yourself. Are you, by any chance, an idiot?'

Iceric glared at her something fierce. He was *not happy* that Catra had just interrupted him to call him out and brand him an idiot. The obvious bluff about us having a plan almost made me laugh out loud, but I managed to control myself enough to watch this play out.

'Who, exactly, do you *think* you are?' Iceric spat the words like venom out into the ballroom, face contorting in anger.

'My name is Catra. Royal Advisor to Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon. You had me imprisoned alongside Adora two days ago and we escaped, freeing others who dared to speak out against you, and others you were using as leverage. Some of them were *children*.'

'*Catra*? As in *Force Captain* Catra?' Iceric asked, effectively ignoring everything else she just said. He knew exactly who she was, he invited her here, but he was choosing instead to weave a dialogue of his own. 'You spent the better part of the last two years personally leading the Horde's ground forces. Do you even know of the destruction and death you've caused? You are a *blight* on this planet, and we would benefit being rid of your existence! You are dangerous, not to be trusted, and if the Princess Alliance had any kind of sense you would be put to death for your crimes!'

I could barely believe what I was hearing and opened my mouth to voice my protest but stopped when I felt a hand on my shoulder. Glimmer. She was smiling and gestured to look around us.

At first, I looked at Catra. Her eyes were closed, like she'd been expecting this kind of verbal attack as soon as she said her name.

But then I looked around at everybody else. Not one of the others in attendance was looking at Catra with anything even close to hatred, and those that were looking looked at her like they could not believe what they were hearing.

'Catra is a good person, and a good friend!' Scorpia announced, breaking the silence that had fallen over the room. Iceric scoffed, but before he could say anything—

'Catra singlehandedly began the rebuilding of Salineas!' Mermista added with a fire in her eyes.

'Catra almost gave her life to defend Erelandia!' Spinnerella yelled with Netossa hanging off her arm, both wives glaring daggers up

at Iceric.

'Catra helped me learn more about my family and make more friends to help with my research and experiments!' Entrapta contributed from atop Wrong Hordak's shoulders.

'Catra was among those who patrolled Thaymor when there was threat of danger!' One of the other princesses in the crowd yelled.

'And Elberon!' Another added.

'As well as Plumeria!' Perfuma's voice rose up. 'Catra has been working on herself and making up for everything she did, and she's earnt our trust and friendship along the way.'

I looked around at all my friends as they defended Catra, the woman they fought against for three years, like a friend they've known all their lives. I could feel myself welling up with emotion at this show of support, but the first tear didn't fall until I looked at Catra herself.

She was looking at *me*. Smiling. Tears of her own falling down her cheeks. I couldn't even imagine how this moment felt for her, for all the people she used to fight against stick up for her like family. I watched as she swallowed and took a deep, shuddering breath before walking over to me and resting our foreheads together.

'*Catra—*'

'Don't speak. You don't need to defend me. Just– let me handle this. Okay? And... Thank you, Adora. For this. For all of this. For, *I don't know*, giving me somewhere to belong. A people to belong to. It's... it's different, and I'm never going to take it for granted.'

I nodded and reached up to cradle her face in my hands, wiping away the tears lining her face.

'I love you.' I whispered.

Catra chuckled. Such a soft, quiet sound. 'I said not to speak, dummy.' She planted a quick kiss against my nose. 'But I love you too.'

I hadn't realised it, too absorbed by having Catra in front of me, but Frosta had managed to break free of her captors up there with Iceric and had formed a slope out of the staircase that she slid down to get away from them. Both the guards stood, frozen, encased in their own separate blocks of ice. Iceric simply watched the event unfold, unfazed, and allowed Frosta to join up with the rest of us down below.

Catra turned away from me, her fingers brushing mine fleetingly, and walked to join Frosta at the front of our gathering. All eyes were on Iceric.

'Very well.' He said simply before holding out a hand ahead of him. A ball of black and purple energy formed in his palm, but before it grew too large he slapped his hand down on the ice of the floor below him.

At first, nothing happened.

'Wait,' Glimmer started, 'was that—'

She was cut off by what followed.

The ice around Iceric's feet grew dark, and that darkness spread quickly throughout the rest of the ballroom. Everything formed by ice and magic turned dark, glowing with the unmistakable aura of dark magic.

'He's got dark magic.' I observed out loud, summoning She-Ra's sword almost by instinct. Everything in me was screaming that this was bad news, that we should either run and escape or stand and fight. But that decision was made for me when Catra stepped forwards, her tech shining bright.

Catra lifted an arm, sending a magical purple whirlwind careening towards him at the top of the slope.

He barely reacted, simply flicking his wrist to erect a wall of ice, corrupted by dark magic, between himself and Catra's wind magic. It hadn't been anywhere close to what she was fully capable of, but she'd been able to make him show his hand. If I could see her face, I'd bet she'd be smirking.

'Behold:' Iceric announced, 'the culmination of dark magic and ice magic. Black Ice!' He pushed against the wall of black ice in front of him, sending it flying down the slope towards Catra.

Everyone else moved out of the way automatically, but Catra simply summoned a large energy shield and crouched behind it, allowing it to absorb the potential energy that would have transferred had the wall of black ice hit her straight on. The shield kept the wall from impacting Catra, but the icy floor meant that she slid back regardless, pushed by the force behind the wall. She tried digging her claws in, but it didn't slow the wall's progression. She growled with frustration and exertion, then pushed off from the wall, aimed the shield down, and released the pulse. The force of it propelled her up and over the wall and she landed in the middle of the ballroom, rolling once before springing back up onto her feet. The wall of ice stopped behind her almost immediately.

'Impressive.' Iceric remarked blandly.

'Catra!' I heard myself shout. I stepped forward, joining her in the centre of the room and aiming my sword up toward Iceric. 'You're going to regret that!'

'I sincerely doubt it.'

'Wildcat!' Scorpia shouted, stepping forward, her claws crackling with red electricity. 'Don't worry buddy, we're all here to back you up. No one attacks one of the Super Pal Trio and gets away with it!'

'Ooooo, an altercation! Please give me just a moment to set up my instruments!' Entrapta declared, tapping on Wrong Hordak's head excitedly, mussing up his once slicked-back hair.

'Don't worry Catra, we're all on your side.' Perfuma said, drawing on her power to create vines along the ground to give us all some purchase against the black ice on the ground.

'Every one of us!' Glimmer appeared next to me, her fists shining with orbs of sparkly magic.

'Say my name!' Netossa shouted, forming two small net balls in her hands ready to toss.

'Not sure about the new catchphrase, darling.' Spinnerella said, winking at her wife before summoning magical winds around her arms.

'I'm here too, don't make a big thing about it.' Mermista droned from behind me.

'But, Mermista, my guiding star, my muse; such an occasion calls for... a BATTLE SHANTY OF—'

'NO!' Mermista yelled, shutting down Sea Hawk before he could break out into song.

'Ha-ha!' Bow yelled, pulling a new foldable bow out from under his jacket. 'I smuggled in my new bow in case this happened!'

'Ooooo,' Entrapta leant down from Wrong Hordak's shoulders to get a closer look. 'Where have you hidden the arrows?'

'Oh! Uh...' Bow shifted nervously while patting down his jacket, rapidly searching for arrows.

'Don't worry, wonder boy, I'm out too. I can't form any ice without it getting corrupted by Iceric's dark magic influence.' Frosta sulked, grabbing onto the corner of Bow's suit jacket.

Bow looked to me as if asking what he should do. I looked around quickly, scanning over everyone else still in the ballroom. 'Bow, Frosta; make sure everyone in here who isn't a magical princess is safe. Get them out of harm's way.'

They nodded, looking suddenly determined. Bow tucked his bow back into his jacket and began leading the other Ball guests up the staircase opposite Iceric, all of them being careful not to touch the wall he had flung toward Catra. Entrapta, Wrong Hordak and Sea Hawk also went with them, helping to direct the sudden small evacuation.

'Are you all quite finished?' Iceric deadpanned from up near Frosta's throne.

I looked back at him, joined hands with Catra, and smirked up at him. 'You're outnumbered, all of us together can easily overpower you. Just make this easy and surrender now.'

'I think not! It's over for you, Princesses!' He spat. 'I have the high ground!'

'Don't you think you're underestimating us, just a little?' I asked, smiling when I felt Catra's hand squeeze mine. 'For the honour of Grayskull!'

The glow of my tranformation soon subsided, and then She-Ra took my place standing among all my friends, still holding on tight to Catra's hand.

'Don't try it!' Iceric yelled, readying his hands as they began to glow with a deathly purple light.

I lifted my sword, letting my magic flow into it. The gem in the hilt began glowing a bright blue, and the sword shone with a golden light. That light then flowed down my arm, and I felt the aura surround me as She-Ra's magic became concentrated, more focused, ready to be unleashed. Around me, all the other princesses readied their magics too, glowing their respective colours and taking their stances. Catra let go of my hand, readying both of her fists as four different glows began surrounding her. Water and wind magic encircled one fist, with plant and electricity magic circling the other. She was calling upon each of the magics she's been able to practice with since finding

her power, baring them all at once and controlling them, ready to unleash it alongside the rest of us at our combined foe. I swelled with pride as I looked around me at my friends, all ready to fight this dark mage who, all things considered, none of us had expected to last even a second.

Because none of us expected what happened next.

Before I could give the signal to attack, Iceric pushed down with his hands. Almost immediately, the floor beneath our feet melted, and we sunk into it quickly. Iceric then lifted his hands again, and the floor froze over once more.

There were shouts and yells of surprise from all around me, but one shout stood out more than the others.

Catra.

'*Ahh!!*' She immediately dropped her magic, instead clawing at the ice around her mostly bare feet. 'Cold!' She yelled through gritted teeth, fighting back the pain of her feet being suddenly soaked and frozen.

'Catra!' I tried to move toward her, to help her out the ice, but my own feet were equally frozen in place. Thanks to my boots, the cold wasn't effecting me as much and the same was true for the rest of our friends. I tried to break free, but She-Ra's brute strength wasn't enough to break the blackened ice.

I only noticed too late that we had hesitated too long.

Iceric, however, did not hesitate. He formed his hands into fists and began punching them forwards, one after another, throwing block after block of black ice towards us.

Luckily, Netossa had kept her eyes on him. 'Incoming!'

Perfuma responded quickly, throwing up a shield of vines to cover herself and Scorpia.

Netossa flung out two nets, securing another two blocks of ice.

Glimmer teleported out of the ice, grabbed one of the ice blocks out of the air, and teleported herself into position to fling it back toward Iceric. He stopped it mid-air before it made contact, but it was a good enough distraction for Glimmer to teleport back and get Catra out.

I watched as Catra immediately began rubbing at her feet, getting some warmth back, and wasted no time in yelling 'NOW!'

All the princesses who were still able to attack unleashed their magic at once, with mine soon joining them. Our magic combined in the air, forming a rainbow beam of glowing magical energy directed straight for Iceric where he stood looking down at all of us.

Before it made contact, Iceric lifted his arms in a defensive stance, and a wall of black ice formed ahead of him. The magical beam struck straight into the wall, but it didn't so much as crack. Instead, it was almost as if the dark magic inside the wall of ice was absorbing, or nullifying, our combined magics.

'Keep going!' I shouted, pouring more magic into the blast. Catra was soon on her feet again, adding her own combined magic to the cocktail as it barrelled into the immovable wall.

'Dark magic is a mysterious power!' Iceric called from behind the wall. 'No one fully understands all of its secrets. Some use it to leach power from others! Some use it to form power from themselves. But I... I have managed to unlock a way of corrupting your princess magic into dark magic. Testing for years on parts of the castle and on the Fractal Flake itself! None of your magic can break my barrier, because as soon as it makes contact it becomes dark magic and has no effect! Give up now! For the Age of Princesses has come to its grand conclu—'

Something cut Iceric off.

The darkness surrounding us, all the dark magic within the castle itself, seemed to ebb away until it vanished completely. We all dropped our arms, cancelling the magical beam, watching as the ballroom returned to its previous state. Frosta appeared before us almost instantly, sliding down an ice slide of her own making, and releasing us from the floor before reforming it under our feet. At the top of the stairs, near the throne, the wall of black ice that had been protecting Iceric crumbled to reveal the Steward on his knees.

Then he fell forwards, crumpling onto the ground and sliding down the slope left by Frosta's escape until he eased to a stop in front of us.

'Arrest this man!' Frosta yelled, and two guards immediately complied. It was suddenly very clear who their true ruler was and if they wanted to keep their jobs... Frosta could certainly keep them in line, and she was more than capable of handling herself.

But while that was going on, I couldn't help but notice the figure that still loomed by the throne.

It was a guard, holding a stun baton.

They pulled back their hood.

A toothy grin. Long green ears, flowing blonde hair, reptilian eyes.

'Really? You're all *so* dramatic. Not that I don't love that, don't get me wrong, but this farce of a coup was starting to drag, don't you agree?'

Double Trouble.

I started laughing. Catra joined in. Then suddenly everyone else was laughing too. After all that, DT had just wandered up behind him and zapped the wannabe ruler while he was *successfully* defending himself. The absurdity of us winning using such a method was not lost on any of us, but none of us cared to comment on it. Instead, all I could think was...

Now *that's* a spy.

After Iceric was arrested and Frosta used the Fractal Flake to repair what damage the ballroom had sustained, the All-Princess Ball continued as normal. Despite Iceric's... interruption and interference, all the guests were happy to return – even if they were mostly interested in trying to talk to the Princess Alliance about what had happened. We tried to find DT after the fact, but no matter where we looked, we couldn't find them. They'd vanished into thin air.

The guards in attendance admitted to following Iceric's orders, but only because he had threatened them and their families. Frosta said she would deal with matters much more closely once the Ball was over and root out any who had been fully indoctrinated under Iceric's madness.

We're pretty sure it was madness anyway, because a search of his private study with Melog sniffing around revealed that he had some kind of shrine to a First Ones crystal, glowing bright green and whispering in the same way it had been when I smashed the one lodged in Ol'Pointy's claw. Thankfully, no-one touched this one, and Entrapta took careful measures to ensure that it was securely packaged for their trip back to Dryl. She planned to perform experiments on the crystal, to see how they were able to influence the minds of others. So far, her hypothesis is that they do it by touch, a more direct method, and the vocal projection, a more subtle method which likely caused Iceric's madness.

Once everyone was settled, and the party was back in full swing, I leant down to whisper in Glimmer's ear. 'I'm just going to get some air. If Catra wonders where I am tell her... tell her I'm in Frosta's ice sculpture garden.'

Glimmer spun round to look at me, all nervous and red-faced, and beamed a wide smile. 'I will, don't worry.'

'Okay, thanks.'

Frosta's ice sculpture garden wasn't far. It was where Glimmer teleported us to when we first arrived earlier in the day. Still part of the castle, but without a ceiling to obstruct the beautiful view of the magical sky, the stars, and three of Etheria's moons shining bright. The sculptures themselves were... *interesting*. Some depicted a super-buff Frosta battling a range of scary looking monsters, but some were less intense. Like the sculpture of a tree. Just a *tree*. But, I supposed, there weren't any trees in the Kingdom of Snows, so perhaps she wanted to try to make one of her own, the only way she knows how. One of the last and biggest sculptures in the garden was a scene depicting She-Ra, my new form, versus what I could only guess was Frosta as the Winter's Bane coming at me with a dangerous looking Snowstrike.

I paused while looking at that sculpture, and let my mind wander back to why I had slipped away from the party in the first place. I had almost proposed to Catra before Iceric interrupted, would it still be okay to do it now that he'd been arrested? What would I even say?

'Adora? You out here?' Catra's voice filled the silence, permeating the peaceful tranquillity and almost making me panic on the spot, like she'd somehow be able to know what I was thinking just because she's managed to find where I ran off to.

'Yeah,' I called back, 'over here!'

Catra found me easily after that and scoffed when she saw what I was looking at. 'My money's on Frosta. Girl has a mean punch.'

'Yeah, she does.'

'Are you okay?' Catra punctuated the question with a supportive hand on my shoulder. I smiled, placing my own hand over it, squeezing gently.

'Yeah, I'm good. Just thinking.'

'Well don't think too hard; you'll melt the whole castle.' Catra teased with a cheeky smirk.

'Oh, har har. No, I was just thinking about what happened back there. Everyone stood up for you. Defended you. It was... really amazing.'

'Yeah that was... that was a lot, honestly. I don't think I realised that everyone does, kind of, accept me now? I guess? I guess I just never expected it to happen.'

I turned to face her at that, frowning slightly at the insinuation that she was still unforgivable. Catra didn't look upset, per se, but she did look thoughtful. She caught me staring and smiled immediately, her eyes lighting up. 'What are *you* staring at, you creep?'

'You.' I said simply, soaking in the way her cheeks blazed red at the word. I smiled and lifted a hand to stoke a thumb across her cheek. 'Always you.'

I'm going to do it. I'm going to do it now. I'm going to ask her, and it will be fine.

I closed my eyes, taking deep breaths. My hands at my sides, balled into fists, while I worked up the courage to ask a stupid question of the woman I love.

No, it's not stupid. It's important. It's our future. It's everything I never knew I wanted, never knew I needed. To have and to hold Catra for the rest of my life, as my wife, and just *be* with her in any way we want to be.

I'm going to ask. It'll be fine. She loves me. There's no denying it. She wants this just as much as I do. She's said so herself. Everything will be fine.

'Adora? What's on your mind? Talk to me.' Catra stepped forward, taking both my hands in hers, squeezing them gently to reassure me. I took a deep breath, steeled myself, and looked her in the eye.

When my eyes met hers and saw the amount of love in them, directed at me, all my fears and anxieties about asking her to marry me just... vanished.

'Catra... I love you.' When I saw she was about to respond I reached up, placing my index finger against her lips. 'No, wait, let me finish, then you can say it all you want – if you still want to.' Catra looked like she was about to protest for a second, but relented, nodding. I lowered my hand back down to hold hers once again. 'I love you, Catra. It feels so good to say, so right, and I know it's because it's the truth. It's always been the truth, even if it took me forever to figure out the words. I know now that I've always loved you. You were always there for me, and I was always there for you. We looked out for each other.'

I looked away from her eyes, scanning the ice sculptures around us as if they may come to life any second. 'Neither of us came away from the war without our scars, on the inside and on the outside, and we'll both need more time to fully heal...' I looked back at Catra, searching her gaze. 'So, putting everything else on hold for just a second, leaving just me and you in this moment, right now...' I let go of her hands and reached up to where the wing clip was pinned to my dress, taking it off before running my thumb over the smooth surface. I could feel tears welling up in my eyes. 'Catra... I want for us to stay together, to continue healing together, to always look out for each other... I've always loved you, and I always will, and I promise to cherish you for the rest of our lives no matter what you say next, so... Catra...' I choked back a small cry but stopped when I felt Catra's hand on my cheek. She caught a rogue tear with her thumb and looked up at me with eyes full of nothing but love and understanding.

'Say it.' She whispered.

I swallowed and held out the golden pin.

'... Marry me?'



Catra smiled, grinned, perhaps the widest and purest smile I've ever seen. Then, as if it was the easiest thing in the world, she picked the wing out of my hand, clipped it to the top of her waistcoat, and looked me in the eye – I could swear in that moment she was glowing, shining, with the radiance of pure and utter joy.

'I'm all yours, Adora.' Catra whispered, stepping forwards to wrap her arms around my waist and bury her face in my neck, purring softly while peppering small kisses in a line from my collarbone up to my jaw.

I chuckled, lost for words, as a few rogue tears fell from my eyes and dripped down my cheeks into Catra's hair. Just holding her, my hands spreading over her back to keep her close, a content smile on my face. I'm not entirely sure what I had expected: fireworks, maybe? Some kind of inner turmoil forcing my stomach into knots of nerves?

But no, none of that happened.

In that moment, standing there while holding Catra, *my fiancée*, as close as I possibly could, all I felt was...

Peace.


I'm all yours, Adora
hehe
@Theraccount

'Ugh! I'm so glad you two have stopped fighting. That was exhausting! I never want to be subjected to that ever again.' Glimmer groaned and slumped onto Bow dramatically and he chuckled while bracing to hold her up.

Catra and I returned to the ballroom floor after a few minutes of... well... *kissing*. Kissing and hugging. Maybe some crying. It was quite emotional.

'Yeah, it's great to see you getting along again.' Bow added, cradling his girlfriend against him. 'I do *not* handle conflict well, the last time Adora and Glimmer fought for real was *extremely* stressful and emotionally taxing!'

'Well–' I began to interject but Catra beat me to it.

'I don't know what you guys are talking about, Adora and I have never fought, ever.'

I looked over to see her somehow managing to pull-off a face of pure indifference, but the swish of her tail and the flick of her ear suggested she was only just holding back a cocky smirk. I, however, was awful at hiding any kind of facial emotion and broke out into a stupidly large grin.

'You're both impossible, I can't believe—' Glimmer cut herself off and her eyes grew two sizes when she noticed the pin on Catra's suit. '—AAAHH! BOW!' She started jumping on the spot and slapping Bow's shoulder excitedly. 'BOW! Bow she did it! I can't believe Adora actually managed to beat you to it!'

I didn't miss the shade of red of that Bow's face turned, but before I could question it I was smothered in a powerful hug from behind and pressed up against Catra.

'Hey there, gal-pals! What's all the excitement? Ooo are we still celebrating beating that awful guy!? This calls for a dunk in the chocolate fountain! Please tell me there's a chocolate fountain because I would *love*—'

'Scorpia!' Glimmer yelled above the larger woman's monologue as well as mine and Catra startled wheezing as our life was slowly being squeezed out of us. 'Adora proposed to Catra!'

The death grip Catra and I had been in suddenly dropped. We both I held onto each other while catching our breath, and when I looked up at Scorpia I almost burst out laughing. She was frozen in place, just staring wide-eyed at the pin on Catra's suit.

Suddenly realising she was under the scrutiny of her best friend, Catra became sheepish, reaching up a hand to rub the back of her neck. 'Uh, yeah Scorp I'm...' She looked at me, and I smiled, wrapping a hand around her waist, squeezing affectionately. Catra kissed me on the cheek, causing my face to turn bright red and my eyes to meet hers just as she said: 'I'm getting married to the most beautiful woman in the universe.'

If Scorpia responded... Stars, if *anyone* said *anything* after that, I didn't hear it. Mainly because Catra had reached up, wrapped her arms around my neck, and pulled me into a searing kiss. Before I knew it, my arms were around her waist, holding her close while we kissed each other and not caring if anyone was watching.

Nothing else mattered.

Catra was marrying me.

I was marrying Catra.

Nothing else even came close.

'Hey, Adora,' a pretty lady with interesting ears said as she walked up to me, 'enjoying the party, aren't you?'

'Hey! You look like a cat! That's amazing. You're so pretty. Are you single? We should totally just get married like right now.'

'Ah, sorry babe I'm already engaged. This killer blonde asked me to marry her earlier tonight.'

'What!? That's no fair – you've got to marry me! You're too pretty for anyone else.'

'Wow, you're really confident with yourself when you're drunk, huh?' She caught me when I stumbled a little, holding onto my arms to stop me from swaying.

'Uhuh. It's true. I know you like what you see, you wish you could marry this. Too bad you're marrying some other loser.'

'Y'know, you're totally right. I am marrying a complete dork. But you know what? She's my dork, and I love her, and I wouldn't trade her for anything. Not even you, hotshot.'

'That's a shame. She's really lucky. I wish I was her.'

'I'm the lucky one, princess.'

'Nuh-uh! And only Catra can call me that.'

'Oh yeah, and who's she?'

'She's... Catra's my... OH! I am getting married! I'm so happy! Did you know she said "yes"?'

'I did.'

'Well, she didn't say "yes" exactly. She said "I'm all yours", do you think that means "yes"?'

'Yeah, I think it does."

'Okay, that's good. Do you know where she is? I wanna cuddle. She's so soft and warm and she's wearing a really nice suit that makes her butt look nice. Heh, butt.'

'Oh, I dunno, I'll go find her. Wait here, okay?'

'Yeah, okay. I love Catra. Her eyes are so nice. But are they nicer than her butt? Hey, you have nice eyes too!'

'Close your eyes, for me okay, then when you open them again Catra will be here, alright?'

'Mmm, okay.'

I closed my eyes and the pressure of the woman's hands left my arms. It felt like someone walked around me in a circle, but then I felt nice soft warm hands on my cheeks and forgot all about it.

'Etheria to Adora? It's me, I came to find you.'

'Oh! Catra! You found me! Thank you! Make sure to thank the other hot cat lady for finding you for me.'

'Wow, princess, we've only been engaged for a few hours and you're already calling other women hot?'

'Wha– no! She looked like you! Don't worry, she's already getting married to some other blonde loser.'

'She sounds really lucky.'

'I'm the luckiest! Because I get to marry Catra, my best friend. I love her. I know her favourite number, it's:—'

'Hey, Sparkles, we could do with a lift home. I think Adora needs a lie down.'

'No, I don't! I'm fiiine!'

'Princess, I love you, but you're hardly piecing your words together. I can just barely understand what you're saying.'

'What? No, I'm not! All my words are great!'

'Until now, apparently. Because I actually didn't understand any of that. Wait, Adora– Adora NO! Get back here! Put that drink down! Adora! Stop!'

And that's all I remember.

Chapter End Notes

The comic within the chapter is by the amazing @the.r.account on Instagram and @theraccount on twitter!

With that, the next chapter begins the final arc of this story.

Exciting times.

Only 6 chapters left.

Let's do this.

Find me on Instagram @iorekofthehorde and Twitter @IorekoftheHorde

The Days Without You

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra do long-distance.

Chapter Notes

Hello hello hello!

Welcome back, one and all, to the continuation of MoE! This chapter officially kickstarts the FINAL ARC of the story! That feels so weird to actually say.

The illustration in this chapter is by the ever-amazing @the.r.account on **Instagram** and **Twitter**!

I'm also on **Instagram** and **Twitter**

Enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'Owww...' I groaned, wondering why the moonlight was deciding to *fight me* first thing in the morning. My head was killing me, and the light streaming into the room through the open curtains was doing little to help. I sat up slowly, rubbing my head and attempting to open my eyes to look around the room... to no avail. It was still *far* too bright.

'Catra...?' I asked blindly, hoping that she was somewhere nearby while I rubbed at my eyes in a vain attempt to get them to cooperate and show me the room I had woken up in.

Why does my head hurt so much?

Dangling my legs off the edge of the bed, I gripped the sheets, concentrating on using She-Ra's healing magic on myself. It wasn't often that I used it for me, but I *really* wanted to be able

to see without my head killing me. Sure enough, once the magic was flowing freely around me, my head began to clear up and I could open my eyes without issue; but I still felt weirdly groggy.

Catra, it turned out, was not in the room. Melog was, however, and seemed to be perfectly content to stay curled up at the end of the bed, sleeping peacefully.

It was then that I realised that this was the first time I'd woken up in my (*our?*) bed, in my (*our?*) bedroom in Bright Moon in four or five days, ever since leaving for the Kingdom of Snows. I groaned and rubbed my head as events slowly came back to me despite the grogginess persisting.

Catra and I had been fighting. That was hard, painful, and not something I ever wanted to go through again. Did we make up? I felt like we did. I hope we did.

I groaned again and let myself fall backwards into the duvet behind me before flipping over and burying my face in the sheets, accidentally startling Melog awake. They chirruped and sniffed at my head and I lifted my gaze to meet the curious glint in their glowing blue eyes.

'Morning, buddy. D'y'know where Catra is?'

They mewled and looked toward the bathroom door, their ethereal tail swishing lazily in the air behind them. I followed their gaze and noticed the door slightly ajar, squinting as if that would somehow let me see through the solid walls into the room beyond. I moved my legs to try and stand but only succeeded in pushing myself face-first across the bed until I was lying flat again.

I groaned into the sheets.

'My body is... betraying me. *Again*.' I mumbled, getting increasingly more frustrated with my apparent lack of mobility. *What happened to me last night?*

Melog chirruped again, louder this time, in the direction of the bathroom.

'Alright, alright! I hear you! I'm almost done.'

Catra. Her voice is so nice. I need cuddles.

'Catraaaaaaa.' I mumbled into the sheets some more, hoping by some miracle she'd be able to hear me. 'What happened to me?' I think I said, but it could have sounded more like 'Whb habbnbd buu muu.' *Who can say?*

'Is that your voice I hear, princess?' I heard from the bathroom.

Groaning, I lifted my head to look defiantly in the direction of that husky voice I loved so much. Sure enough, Catra was looking back at me with an annoyingly amused expression covering her gorgeous face. I guess we made up, then? Otherwise, she wouldn't be here. *Come on brain, catch up!*

'Cuddles.' It wasn't a question. 'I feel *weird*.'

'You want cuddles? From me?' Catra asked, placing a hand against her chest. I nodded. 'What about Melog, they're right there, can't you cuddle them?' I shook my head, mumbling my discontent. Catra chuckled to herself.

'I want *you*. I need *you*. You're *warm* and *soft*.' I buried my face in the covers again and tried to get some use out of my arms to push myself up again.

'*Someone's* clingy when she's hungover.' I heard Catra say as the sound of claws tapping on the floor filled the room and rattled around my head, but the last word didn't quite sink in; its meaning not registering for me.

'What? Hung– hungover?' I asked, opening my eyes again just in time to see Catra pounce onto the bed and knock me back with an *oompff!* 'Catra!' I tried to chastise her but found that I couldn't

stop grinning when I felt her drape over me, her weight a comforting presence.

There was a dip in the bed as Melog jumped off to inspect an open bag on the floor, but it was just a momentary distraction once I realised Catra was staring up at me while resting her chin on my chest. I was in my pyjamas, somehow, which meant that I must have been changed when we got back here from... 'from the Prom!'

I said that last part out loud, and Catra's amusement would have been annoying if she wasn't looking at me like *that*.

'What's happening?' I asked, trying to decipher the absolute *heart eyes* she was looking at me with.

'I'm waiting for you to catch up,' Catra drawled, grinning a fanged smile and tilting her head in the *most adorable* of ways. She looked amazing, once again dressed in that cropped and sleeveless white and blue top with the grey leggings that just seems to *work* on her.

I felt my brows furrow as I searched my foggy mind for what she meant, but the answer wasn't rearing itself and I was starting to become frustrated with how annoyingly slow I was being.

'Here's a hint,' she whispered, leaning up enough to show me her chest and—

The wing.

It's there!

Of course it is, because—

'I proposed and you said yes!' I realised with a yell, a huge beaming smile immediately spreading across my face.

'There it is,' Catra smirked, moving further up the bed until she was draped over me, staring down into my eyes with what I

realised was *so much love*. So much love for *me*.

Remembering your life-long love is now your *fiancée* is a very sobering thought, it turns out, and most of the night thundered its way into my head all at once. Putting on my dress, seeing Catra in her *suit*, dancing with Catra and *dipping* her, *kissing* her, fighting with Iceric, destroying a crystal, *proposing*, returning to the party and then... nothing.

'The last thing I remember is another feline woman showing me where you were,' I whispered, looking up into those beautiful sapphire and emerald eyes.

'Then you're missing quite a lot there, Adora,' Catra whispered back, tapping my forehead, and grinning in a much less lovely way that bordered on downright malicious.

'What happened? Catra, *tell me,*' I said, trying to keep my voice stern despite the way Catra's hips ground down against me as she sat up to look at me with a curious expression.

She hummed to herself and lifted a hand, checking her claws. 'No, I don't think I will.'

'*Catra*. What did I do?' I'm not sure when my hands raised to rest on her hips but there they were, so the *when* doesn't really matter.

'You'll have to ask Queen Sparkles all about *that*, dummy. After all, I'm not sure that the *Master Archer* himself will remember much either. You two were *quite* the chaos twins.'

I groaned and hid behind my hands if only to avoid the teasing smirk I knew would be adorning Catra's wonderful face. Whatever I had done last night, somehow *Bow* was a part of it too...

'But we're supposed to be helping Bow's dads move house soon. He's supposed to be asking them to meet with Glimmer and Micah at some point to discuss—'

'Adora,' Catra interrupted, prising my hands away from my face and gently holding them between hers like they're something precious. 'This may be a good time to tell you that you've slept through an entire day. That light you're trying to hide from isn't the moonrise– it's the moonset.'

'What?'

'Yeah. They've already had that meeting, my love.'

'Y– *your love*?'

'Well, you are, aren't you?'

'Yeah, I– I guess, but... you've never called me that before.'

'Well, maybe my *fiancée* will have to get used to it. It's about time I did anyway, as payback for all the times you called me it.'

I flushed bright red, but the other detail from what she said suddenly settled in my mind as well. 'Wait– they already had the meeting? Does that mean it's happening? *Catra*... you should have woken me up!'

Catra stared at me, totally blank, for about ten whole seconds. Ten seconds isn't normally a long time, but under her gaze it felt like hours. That is, until she scoffed and proceeded to laugh that adorable squeaky laugh of hers, and I found myself smiling despite how I was supposed to be annoyed.

I love that she does this to me.

'I should've woken you up!? You're kidding, right? You don't even know when you actually fell asleep! Plus, I know you weren't sleeping great before. So, that along with all the *"fruity deliciousness"* you drank last night—your words not mine—means you crashed. *Hard*. And if I *had* woken you up, I'm not sure that even your magic could have saved you or anyone else from *that* fallout.'

I groaned and flopped my head back into the covers, rolling my eyes playfully. 'Alright, fine, you win.'

'Always do.'

'That is *so* not true.'

'It is and you know it is.'

'Only because I let you win.'

'You do not!'

'No...' I trailed off, smiling up at my *fiancée* with all the love I could muster. 'I never had to. You're just that amazing, Catra. I love you so much.'

Catra paused, blushing something fierce, her ears pinning back out of embarrassment with how I'd managed to catch her off guard with a compliment. 'Shut up. *You* don't get to be cute.'

'Why, is that *your* thing?' I teased, angling a brow.

'What?! *No!* I am not cute!'

'Pfft. I'm sure *everyone* would dispute that claim.'

'Yeah, whatever. And... I love you too,' Catra mumbled, her voice soft as she leant down once again, burrowing her face into my neck as she dragged her cheek along my jawline. 'So much.'

This is when I let my curiosity get the better of me. I'd been wondering it for a while. Well, if *my whole life* counts as a while. 'Why do you do that?'

'Do what?' She asked innocently, while continuing to rub her cheek along my neck. I didn't protest it, instead moving to give her better access.

'What you're doing now, with your cheek. Don't get me wrong, I don't mind it, but I guess I've always wondered...'

Catra sat back upright, looking down at me with a perplexed expression like I'd just told her all the secrets of the universe are actually attributed to a sea snail.

'I have no idea.' She said plainly.

'You... you don't know?' I asked, confused. For as long as I could remember, Catra had always rubbed her cheeks against me. Any part of me, whatever was nearest in our brief moments of closeness in the Horde. She does it when we cuddle too, or if she's happy, or when she's just about to go to sleep. I just went for days without her doing it while we were... apart... and I felt *off* the entire time, like something was *missing*. It felt far too important for her to not know what it is or why she does it.

'No, I don't know *why*. I just... get a feeling? Like I *have* to do it. And whenever I do, you... you smell like *me*. But not just like me, it's... I don't know how to describe it... I guess it's like the scent you give off just makes you...' Catra trailed off, her blush coming back full force as her tail lashed behind her, whipping softly at my calves.

'Makes me *what,* Catra?' My voice was small, soft, hopefully inviting. I hoped she knew that nothing she could say would worry me or make me run away. 'It's okay. Whatever it is, I'm here. I'm not going anywhere.' I reached forward again, intertwining our fingers together and squeezing in a way that I knew would ground her and bring her back.

'It uhm...' She swallowed and took a moment to breathe deep. 'The scent makes you... Mine.'

I blinked. 'Yours?'

'Yeah, I mean... that's the best way I can describe it.'

'So when you do that it, what, *marks me* as yours?'

'I suppose so, yeah. I'm sorry I didn't tell you! Honestly, it just never occurred to me to think about it because I've always done it

and it feels so right when I do and... I kind of...'

'What?'

'I like the way other hybrids look at you after I've done it!' Catra rushed out the words like she was ashamed to say them. 'I like knowing that they know. That you're...'

'That I'm yours? That I belong to you? That I'm... your mate?'

Catra closed her eyes tight, refusing to look at me. '... Yes.'

I laughed then, loud and freely, and seeing Catra's bemused face only made me laugh harder.

'Adora! Why are you laughing!? I was so worried about what you would think—'

'Catra! It's okay!' I managed to say between wheezing breaths. 'It's alright. I love it.'

'You love it?' Now it was Catra's turn to look blank.

'I do. Did you think I wouldn't like everyone to know I'm yours? Because that's exactly what I am, Catra. The pin you're wearing does the same thing, doesn't it? We belong to each other; belong together. We always have, and we always will.'

Catra smiled, moving her hands to cup my face and kiss me softly on the lips. 'You're sappy after drinking. Maybe you should do it more.'

'Ha! No, thank you. I want to actually remember what I get up to the next day. Are you really not going to tell me what I did?'

'Nope,' Catra said, with a pop of the "P". 'But I might give you *hints* while I'm away.'

Wait.

Away?

'What do you mean, "away"? Where are you going? You're not helping with Lance and George's move? I thought we'd do it together...'

'Adora... I– didn't I tell you already? I'm going to the Fright Zone for a while; six or seven days at most. Scorpia asked me about it during the Ball, before Iceric, before... before you proposed.'

Oh.

'Oh, well... yeah, okay. That's okay, I'll just—'

'Adora. No. If you want me to stay, if you *need* me to stay, I will. Just say it and I won't go.'

'But you– you've wanted to have that time, haven't you? To make it right with Scorpia. Properly, not just over the tracker pad, face to face.'

'Yeah. Yes, I have. But Adora—'

'No. No, it's okay. I know she's important and you want to spend the time healing your friendship with her.'

'Adora if you need—'

'Catra! It's okay. Really. We can talk on the pads or Glimmer can teleport either of us if there's an emergency or if something comes up with Prime.'

Catra stared down at me for a long moment, searching for my face for any hint that I was somehow not being completely honest with her. I was. I really was. Sure, it was kind of a bummer that Catra was going away for a week right after I proposed, but this is something she decided before that and I didn't want to get in the way of her reconciling with Scorpia. They've only had fleeting interactions ever since the Heart, during meetings or brief *hellos* and *how are yous* that really aren't enough to cover everything I knew they needed to talk through.

So, yeah. I was okay with it. Then, when Catra came back, we'd make sure to make up for lost time.

A selfish part of me didn't want her to go. I wanted her to stay in Bright Moon with me and help with Bow's dad's move. I wanted to hold her hand as much as possible, watch her as she walked around pretending to help while wearing my pin. The pin that means we're engaged. To be married. Me and Catra; *married!*

I'm going to be married to Catra!

Thinking that over and over helped. After all, what's one week apart when we have the rest of our lives to spend together?

I knew that Catra must have had mixed feelings about returning to the Fright Zone, especially without me, but ultimately I knew she'd be in good company. Nevertheless, we agreed to stay in contact and talk to each other every night over the tracker pad with the knowledge that it would only be a week, and we were only a teleport away if there were any emergencies.

When the time came and Scorpia arrived the next morning, Catra slung her packed bag over her shoulder and smiled back at me while Melog stood attentively at her side. There was a sadness there, sure, but there was also *hope*. Hope of rekindling an important friendship, of righting more of the wrongs that I knew still weighed her down.

'Catch you later, Adora.' Catra said, her voice steady and her smile maintained.

'Not if I catch you first.' I replied, trying not to cry.

——— Day 1 ———

'Hey, Adora.'

My smile was immediate upon hearing Catra's voice come through the tracker pad. I'd had a long day of going over everything that would need moving and beginning to organise artefacts and scrolls into the two categories of *salvageable* and *pristine*. It was always disheartening to add something to the salvageable pile, but Lance and George insisted that the photos they'd taken when cataloguing everything would help them piece anything that was broken back together. *"There's no such thing as irreparable, not with enough time, patience, and care,"* George had mentioned in passing while I looked mournfully at *half* an intricate wall hanging. They actually seemed to be looking forward to piecing old First Ones odds and ends back together, because apparently they'd run out of jigsaws some time ago and this would be the next best thing.

'Hey! How was your first day?' I tried to sound chipper about it but being away from Catra for the whole day *ached*. I've been away from her before, but something about feeling this new level of closeness with her and then being so far apart had settled weirdly in my gut. I knew it was just me being weird, and it nothing to worry about, not really. It was only a week, I could do this for a week, and then I wouldn't let go of her once I saw her again.

'It was... weird, but kind of nice? I don't know. Scorpia sang.'

It took me a moment to remember I had to reply, lost in the sound of her voice and the way her tail curled behind her wherever it was she was laid down. 'She– Scorpia did what?'

'She sang, *can you believe it? She actually sounded pretty good.'*

Scorpia can sing? 'No way.'

'Yeah, it's great for morale, you can tell everyone is hooked every time she gets on stage.'

'That sounds amazing. I'll have to see it for myself one day.'

'I'm sure she wouldn't mind. Perfuma said Scorp was super nervous the first time she sang, because apparently they were supposed to be undercover, but Scorpia somehow ended up on a stage singing all about how she was a spy.' Catra cackled after that, rolling around a bit while taking the tracker pad with her. I smiled fondly, just watching, waiting for her to calm down before continuing.

'How did she not get caught? No one was suspicious at all?'

'Nope.'

'I don't believe you.'

'Believe it, princess. Apparently, Mermista, Sea Squawk, and DT can also back me up on this.'

'Wait– you said she performed on a stage? Where in the Fright Zone have they set up a stage?' I asked, completely unfazed by Sea Hawk's new nickname.

'Oh, the whole place has changed quite a lot actually. Everything's being slowly broken down, melted, and re-forged into other stuff.'

'They're using the forge?'

'Yeah, but only one of the smaller furnaces. Perfuma isn't overly happy about it but with all the scrap metal lying around it's the easiest way to tidy it all up and re-use it.'

'But weren't there, like, hundreds of furnaces?'

'Yes. Yes, there were. So you can imagine the piles of scrap we're accumulating with just one tiny furnace going.'

'I bet you're itching to take charge of it aren't you?'

'What!? No! What's that supposed to mean?'

'They're not doing it right, are they?'

'Well...'

'You know of a more efficient way.'

'I mean...'

'And you've already meticulously planned it in your head, but you feel like you shouldn't overstep because you're supposed to be a guest.'

'How... how do you just read me like that?'

'We're getting married Catra, I know everything about you.'



Catra's head fell forwards at that and she groaned into something. *'This is gonna be hard.'*

'What is?'

'Being away from you.'

'You could come back. Glimmer wouldn't mind—'

'No! We said we'd only teleport if there was an emergency. Me being... me wanting to... cuddles aren't an emergency.'

I gasped dramatically and threw a hand over my heart in mock offence. 'How could you say such a thing!?'

'You're such a dork. You know what I mean.'

'Yeah... I do.'

After a moment of silence I found myself wondering, 'where are you, anyway?'

'The Fright Zone, dummy.'

'No, I know that, *obviously*. I mean specifically. Where are you staying?'

'Oh. Just my old Force Captain quarters. At least for tonight, anyway.'

'Is that... are you okay with that?'

'Yeah, why wouldn't I be?'

'I don't know...'

'I just realised; you never saw this room did you? I don't even think you were a Force Captain long enough to step foot in your own private quarters.'

'No I didn't, everything happened so fast back then.'

'It did. But I'm fine with being in here. I mean, yeah, *I cried myself to sleep in this room more times than I can count, but overall this room was pretty safe. I guess, if I could do anything to make it better, it would be to have you here with me.'*

I took a long, shuddering breath while considering carefully how to follow that up. 'I would love to be there with you.' I whispered, meaning every word of it.

'You are, *dummy. Plus, check it out,'* Catra said, holding up a blue blanket, *'your blanket is still here.'*

'Oh wow. *My* blanket? You kept it?'

'I did. It stopped smelling like you after a while, but I just couldn't bring myself to get rid of it.'

'Maybe you should bring it back with you?'

'Maybe. I might just leave it here. It doesn't really compare to the blankets in Bright Moon. Plus, those actually *smell like you.'*

'I suppose. But wouldn't it be, I don't know, sentimental?'

'I don't know. There might be other stuff in here I've not seen in a while. I'll dig around some more tomorrow,' Catra said, while failing to stifle a yawn.

I immediately yawned too.

'That sounds great, Catra, really. I'd love to see whatever you find,' I said, smiling and watching Catra stretch out on her bed.

'Don't worry, Adora, whatever I find I'll show you tomorrow. Goodnight.'

'Goodnight, Catra. I love you.'

'Love you too.'

I sighed when the connection closed and the room was filled with darkness, no longer alight with the beautiful face of my wife-to-be. I chuckled to myself, wondering too much about the applications of that particular metaphor.

With Catra in my life, everything was fun, bright, happy. I found myself smiling all the time, in awe of her, unable to look away. But as soon as she leaves? My life feels like this room. Empty, lonely, cold. A district lack of smiles and laughter. No luminescent eyes staring at me from under the covers, no warmth to cuddle up to, no Catra to whisper sweet nothings to until we fall asleep. She's my person, and I feel incomplete without her.

I rolled on my side, trying to picture happier times, and willed myself to sleep.

——— Day 2 ———

'It's weird to be back,' Catra said, out of the blue. We had been enjoying the relative silence of just *being* with the other until she spoke.

'Yeah?' I answered after a moment, because it took me a minute to remember I had to respond.

'Yeah. I get a lot of side-glances. Everyone knows not to whisper near me, because I'll hear them, but I know they're saying things when I'm far enough away. Atleast the clones didn't know me before, you should see their hair. '

When I lifted the tracker pad so I could see Catra's face, I saw that her ears were droopy and her eyes downcast. I wanted to hold her. This is the kind of conversation that requires cuddles and not being able to provide them, separated by an enormous expanse of woodland and plains, tied a knot in my stomach that would remain there for hours.

'What–' I started, pausing when Catra's eyes flicked up to meet mine. She nodded for me to continue so, with a little reluctance, I did. 'What kinds of things are they saying?'

Catra immediately flopped back down onto her bed, chucking the tracker pad away from herself so it landed face-up, showing me a great view of her quarter's ceiling. With the screen now filled with green metal panelling, I strained my ears to pick up any distinct sounds.

I could hear a faint thudding—most likely her tail idly swaying into something—but nothing else.

Then, a deep sigh, and Catra's disembodied voice asked: *'You really want to know?'*

'I might help to talk about it,' I offered, hoping that Catra would pick up the tracker pad again so I could see her face.

From what she's told me in the past, I knew that Catra tended to be hard on those under her when she was leading the Horde. It came with the job. I probably would have had to as well, had I stayed there. You have to show strength, confidence, and cunning. You have to be the strongest and smartest person in the room and have everyone's attention at all times. Everyone you command had to hang off of your every word, else you're not doing it right. *Weakness* isn't an option. *Hesitation* isn't an option. *Kindness* isn't an option.

And Catra filled that position perfectly. Something she's hoping to atone for, even partially, with this trip. It's one thing for Scorpia and our old friends to be okay with her, but she wants to make it up to the rest of the ex-Horde soldiers too, if she can. Even if it's just one.

But, sadly, some resentment on their side must still remain.

'Basically, there's a lot of people here who don't like the way I ran things. Especially toward the end. I kind of... ran everyone into the ground. Efficiency was good, perfect even, but morale wasn't. I didn't listen, I didn't let them rest, didn't give them enough time to recover from missions, or eat, or sleep. I was awful to them. Even more to the little guys. You know, the ones who're ordered

to never take off their helmets? The grunts. Well, none of them are wearing helmets now. They all have faces, names, personalities. They all have friends, things that make them laugh, favourite new foods. But their eyes... it's the eyes that are the worst. I can see the way they look at me now, and... it's not good, Adora. It's really... not good.'

Catra didn't show her face to me once while she spoke, which I could kind of understand considering the topic at hand. After all, she made me look at the ceiling once before too, when she opened up about everything that happened to her that I didn't see when we on opposite sides of the war.

Carefully, I asked, 'Catra?' Just hoping to get a glimpse of her face.

'I'm here, just, give me a minute.'

I took a breath and decided to say what was on my mind anyway. 'I don't know if this will be helpful, but, it's just a time thing, right?'

'Time?' Came the soft reply.

'Yeah. Time. Over the last few months, before and after we defeated the Galactic Horde,' I was careful not to say "defeated Prime" there, who knows what's happening with that right now, 'you showed the rest of the Princess Alliance that you can be trusted, and they've all warmed up to you. Just like I knew they would. So, I think all you need to do is show those guys back in the Horde who you are now. You're Catra, soon-to-be wife of She-Ra.'

'Pfft!' Catra exclaimed before bursting out into laughter. *'I can't introduce myself like that!'*

'Why not! Once we're married, that's the only way I'll ever introduce myself: "Hi, I'm Adora, Catra's wife—so nice to meet you, Random Ambassador, I'm Catra's wife—did I mention that

I'm married to Catra? She's my wife—oh don't mind me, I'm just over here being married to Catra—'"

'Adora! Stooop!' Catra yelled before groaning into something, the sound muffled. *'Is that what you're going to be like? I can't believe I agreed to marry you. Is it too late to take it back?'*

'Oh, absolutely. Are you still wearing my pin?'

'... Yes.'

'There you go.'

'I could just take it off.'

'You won't.'

'I could.'

'You like me too much.'

'I do not *like you.'*

'Nope, you loooove me.'

'Shut up, Adora, jeez.'

'I'm gonna marry you.'

'Shut up! You're impossible. I was being sad and now I can't stop smiling like an idiot because my idiot actually proposed to me and it's the best thing that's ever happened to me.'

I beamed, unable and unwanting to hold down any of joy I felt at that moment. Catra saying *"the best thing that's ever happened to me"* can play on loop in my head for the rest of my life and I wouldn't even mind. 'That's right, I am your idiot. Thank you for saying yes, by the way.'

'Why are you thanking me?'

'I don't know, I'm just happy.'

'Yeah, me too...' Suddenly, Catra's face came back into view and she was smiling brightly with a renewed energy I was proud to have been a part of bringing out. *'Hey!'* she said, *'guess what I found today?'*

'Oh! Yeah, you said you were going to look around some more.'

Catra grinned a beautifully devious smile before leaning the camera up against something and moving back to stand where I could see her fully.

'I found my old uniform,' she began, then as if I wasn't already reeling from that she reached off-camera and brought out– 'as well as my jacket and whip from the Crimson Waste. No mask, though. What do you think? Should I keep them?'

I swallowed, or I tried too, but my mind was reeling from *jacket* and *whip* and very vivid memories of being *tied up* on my knees looking up at Catra dressed exactly as she is now.

'Yes,' I squeaked before filling my lungs with air again and focusing on making a convincingly normal and *not-flustered-at-all* expression with my face.

It didn't work.

'Hey, Adora?' Catra asked as she closed in on the tracker pad, filling the screen with her stupid, sexy face and grinning at me through it like she *knows.*

'Mhm?' Was all I managed to articulate, because she *does* know and she's a brat for it but also–

'Be a good girl, and tell me: what are you wearing?'

We didn't end the call until much, much later.

——— Day 3 ———

Catra didn't call in the evening of the third day.

It wasn't like she gave me no warning, though.

hey, adora
sorry but im exhausted, call tomorrow?
long day
love you

It just kind of stung.

Of course, it's absolutely fine that Catra was busy. She's helping her friends to rebuild the Fright Zone, giving them plans, sharing her opinions and actually being part of a team instead of forcing herself to lead it.

I'm proud of her.

I am.

But...

Is it wrong to feel... whatever this is I'm feeling, just because she didn't call?

Maybe this was a bad idea. Maybe I should have asked her to stay.

No, that's not what either of us would have wanted. She wanted to go, she agreed to it. I agreed to help Bow's dad's sort their stuff and move them into Bright Moon. That's just how it is. Was I being too clingy? I wasn't sure. I had only just got her back after our fight, our fight that having Horde Prime in my head did nothing to help. Not only had I got her back, but she was now my fiancée. We were engaged to be married! Is it so wrong to wish

for more time to cuddle the woman I'm engaged to? This is stupid. It's only a few more days, and then I'll see her again.

I placed the tracker pad beside the pillow before flopping onto the bed, lying on my back, and letting out a long, deep breath while staring up at the brightly coloured moonset. I watched as the breeze from the balcony took the lead in a dance with the curtains, swaying back and forth to some silent music of the night. Closing my eyes with a sigh, I decided to indulge in some of my curiosity.

'Hey... Emily?'

» Hi, Adora! What can I do ya for? «

Emily's chipper voice filled the otherwise stale and silent void that was my bedroom, and I winced at the sudden volume of it.

'Can you...' This was stupid. Stupid. Catra's fine, Adora, you don't need to know everything she's done on a daily basis.

» Say again? «

Screw it.

'Can you tell me what Catra did today?' I asked, biting my bottom lip and closing my eyes tight to somewhat hide from the disembodied voice of a robot I left to get melted on a crashing ship.

» Hmm. I would need to request permission from Catra herself before I can tell you anything specific. Should I request permission now? «

'No!' I yelled suddenly, sitting up on the bed to stare down at the tracker pad, because I didn't want Catra to know how desperate I was to hear something about her day. 'No. That's okay. Uhm, cancel that question, Emily, I don't need to know.'

» Right you are, Adora! Goodnight! «

'Goodnight,' I said, slumping back down to lay my head on the pillows and absently stare up at the ceiling. After taking a deep breath, I reached across and picked up the tracker pad again, typing out my response to Catra's message.

That's okay, whatever you need. Love you too. Goodnight.

——— Day 4 ———

I'd be lying if I wasn't nervous that Catra wouldn't call again. It would be fine if she didn't! Totally fine. Completely fine. She's allowed time to herself, to do what she wants to do, without me getting in the way of it. She's allowed to have things of her own that she doesn't share with me.

Those were the things I kept telling myself while I was sprawled out on my bed after a long day of doing *nothing*.

Well, not nothing, exactly. Glimmer and Bow were able to pick up on my warring emotions pretty quickly from not talking to Catra the night before, and promptly called a time-out. They both exchanges a conspiratorial glance before nodding and grinning like lunatics. Then Bow messaged his dads and before I knew what was happening Glimmer had teleported us straight to Mystacor to "unwind and relax for a bit".

I protested, of course, arguing that we needed to finish helping Lance and George, but Bow just shook his head and played the video his dads sent us hoping we have a nice time and that they'd see us tomorrow.

Despite trying to relax all day—and I really did *try*—I couldn't stop thinking about Catra. Thinking about what she had been doing that meant she couldn't call me because it had been a "long day". Wondering whether or not she would have had another "long day" and would once again pass on calling me.

I shook my head, tucking my legs up to chest and squeezing my arms around them to give myself something else to focus on for a second. I took a deep breath. Worked on calming myself.

Obsessively thinking about it wouldn't be healthy, so I tried to stop thinking about it, tried to stop worrying. Catra is fine, and she said she'd call today so there's that. She'll probably tell me why she didn't call the day before and then all of this stressing out will have been for nothing. I trust Catra. I do. I just...

I just miss her. So much.

Imagine my relief when the tracker pad startled into life and Catra's caller ID filled the screen. I sprang up immediately and hit the answer button so fast I was afraid I'd punch a hole through it.

'Hey, Adora! I'm so sorry I didn't call you yesterday, that must have sucked. But yesterday was... a lot, and I needed some time to kind of process it all.'

See? It's fine. Everything was fine. I took a deep breath to steady myself before replying in a way I hoped sounded confident and self-assured. 'Hey, Catra! It's so good to hear your voice. I don't mind about yesterday; I just miss you and can't wait to hold you again.'

Catra laughed, a wonderful sound that seemed to give the grey walls around me colour again, if only for a moment. *'That, we can agree on.'*

I couldn't help but ask, I needed to know: 'What were you doing yesterday?'

'*I spoke to Scorpia,'* came the curt reply. *'The flower princess was there too. And then I just kind of thought,* why not? *and spoke to Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle as well.'*

Oh, right, okay. That made a lot of sense, actually. Everything quickly clicked into place and I felt like idiot for some of the places my mind had taken me over the course of the day.

Without me needing to ask, Catra elaborated, seemingly more than willing to share. If this fact alone filled me with a welcome warmth, that was my business. *'Scorpia was actually pretty easy to talk to. She forgave me instantly, because of course she did. She's a really good friend. I apologised for everything, the way I treated her, and do you know what she said?'*

I shook my head.

'She said that she's proud of me,' Catra said, choking back a cry and sniffing before wiling at her eyes.

'Are you okay?' I asked, worry seeping into my voice. 'You don't have to talk about this if you don't want to.'

Catra smiled and sat up, stretching her arms above her and took a deep breath. She smiled. *'No. I do, I'm okay. I want to tell you.'*

'Okay,' I said, smiling softly and nodding, a silent communication for Catra to continue when she's ready.

Catra cleared her throat and fiddled with her claws in her lap, then began to speak, her eyes flicking between the tracker pad and her hands as she did. *'After everything I did, said to her, Scorp said she's proud of who I am now. That she forgives the way I was because she knows now how much you leaving affected me and how much I'm trying to be better now. She's very conflicted about you, y'know? On one hand, you left me there which led to me lashing out all the time because my trust in people was shot. But on the other hand, you're the reason I'm even here right now. Plus, on top of everything, I'm engaged to be married to you, so, there's that.'*

'There is that,' I agreed, nodding to no-one in particular, 'I've still not had a lot time to talk to Scorpia one on one.'

'I know, and you should. Scorpia and Perfuma will be leaving for Plumeria in a month or so when Lonnie's got a grasp on things here.'

'Lonnie definitely taking over?'

'Looks like it. The Fright Zone at least. Horror Hall belongs to Scorpia because it's her ancestral home, but other than that everything else is being handed over to Lonnie.'

'Have you spoken to them?'

'I have. I apologised to each of them, Kyle especially. Lonnie then demanded a sparring match, which I won, obviously.'

'What do you mean, "obviously"?'

'I've always been able to beat Lonnie. I'm stronger than the last time I sparred her too.'

'You didn't cheat with your magic, did you?'

'Cheat? No. I just used a staff like I did against you back in Dryl.'

'Uhuh. Sure.'

'I did! Promise. Oh! Moving onto what I did today, Entrapta came to visit. Something to do with technological infrastructure whatnot and Emily's expansion. Scorpia was ecstatic about the Super Pal Trio's grand reunion.*'*

'And *you* make fun of the Best Friend Squad.'

'Yeah, but this is just Scorpia being sweet. Your thing is just annoying.'

'I think it's sweet. Bow came up with it, Bow's sweet.'

'Bow is too nice for his own good.'

'See, you get it.'

'Ugh.'

'What about Scorpia?'

'Scorpia's sweet.'

'You're impossible. It's the same thing. If Bow had Scorpia's strength, he'd be hugging us all the time too.'

'He is *hugging you all the time.'*

'No, but like, in a lift-you-off-your-feet way where you can't escape.'

'That's just how Scorp expresses her happiness, and it also shows how trusting she is towards literally *everybody.'*

'Well, Scorpia *is* a hugger.'

'That she is. Anyway, tell me about your day, princess.'

'Oh, uh, actually... Glimmer, Bow and I went to Mystacor.'

'That's the floaty place, right?'

'Yeah, Catra, it's the "floaty place".'

'Where the failsafe was?'

'Yeah...'

'Why would you go back there?'

'Uhm... well... I've kind of been pretty restless since you left, so they took me to soak in the baths and calm down.'

'Baths?'

'They're actually really warm and relaxing. I'd love to take you one day! If that's something you'd want.'

'I don't know...'

'We could get a private one? Just you and me. It's nothing like the baths they have in Bright Moon, it's much more...'

'More...?'

'Just more... relaxing. *Warm*. The steam is nice too. And then, afterwards, you go and lay out on the cloud beach and just... relax.'

'You? Relaxing? Now that's something I gotta see.'

'*Yeah*... the first time I went I didn't really get into it, but after a while I was able to enjoy it.'

'When I'm back you can show me all the dumb stuff you've been up to.'

'I will!'

'I don't doubt it.'

Catra stayed on the call until much later that night, and we talked and talked about everything and nothing for hours until we fell asleep with the call still going.

I woke up the next morning to the sound of Catra purring.

——— Day 5 ———

'Hey, Adora?'

'What's up?'

'Do you think we should, I don't know, have like– couple nicknames?'

'What do you mean?'

'Like—I don't know!—nicer nicknames for each other.'

'Hmm. What's wrong with the nicknames you call me already?'

'Besides "princess", they mostly just insult your intelligence. I want to call you something more personal.'

'You're so cute. I love you.'

'Dork. I love you too. Any ideas?'

'What about... kitty?'

'No.'

'Kitten?'

'Never. DT ruined that one.'

'How about just... Cat?'

'Cat?'

'Yeah like, hold on. I think we need some context for these nicknames.'

'Okay. I'm game.'

I cleared my throat and in my best bedroom voice said, low and slow: 'Take off all your clothes for me, Cat.'

Catra eyes widened just a smidge and she bit her lower lip, exposing a fang.

'How's that?' I asked, a smug smile planted firmly on my face.

'Yeah that... that'll work. But if you're going down to three letters then so am I.'

'What like... Ado?'

'No, dummy,' Catra facepalmed, then cleared her throat and lent in close to the camera. *'Be a good girl, and take off all your*

clothes for me, 'Dor.'

I closed my eyes, imagining that phrase in-situ and groaned a little at how easily I could get used to hearing it.

'That good, huh?' Catra asked, a teasing lilt to her already sultry voice.

'All I'm going to be able to think about whenever you call me that is you asking me to take my clothes off.'

'It was your idea, 'Dor.'

'I know, Cat. I know.'

'So,' Catra began, after a lingering moment of silence stretched between us, *'did you manage to get any hints of your drunken exploits out of Glitter? You haven't mentioned anything to me.'*

I groaned and dropped my head down into my pillow, mumbling, 'because you're going to make fun of me.'

'What? Me? Make fun of you? Never!?' I looked up at that, only to see that her expression suggested otherwise.

'Catra,' I deadpanned, hoping my tone and very serious eyes would have the desired effect.

They didn't.

'Okay, fine, if you really want me to; get ready to be made fun of.'

'That's not—oh, never mind.' I sighed and rolled onto my back, holding the tracker pad above me at arm's length. 'She said that Bow and I sang and danced on the table.'

'Did she tell you what *you sang?'* I nodded. *'Can you sing it for me?'*

'Absolutely not,' I defended quickly, 'it was just Sea Hawk's friendship song—and besides, you were there!'

Catra's squeaky laugh filled my room before I'd even finished speaking, and I couldn't help but let a fond smile creep onto my face at the welcoming warmth in my chest that it elicited. *'What about when you started crying because you thought you'd lost me?'*

'What?' No, Glimmer hadn't mentioned that one.

'Ohh, yeah, 'Dor, it wasn't long after that song actually. You got down off the table and launched yourself into my arms, then started crying because you thought I'd gone.' Catra cut herself off with another laugh before continuing, *'and then when you realised it was me holding you, you started crying again because you didn't think you'd be able to find me so quickly.'*

'Please,' I implored, 'do not let me get that drunk again.'

'You should see how much food you ate.'

'Catra, please.'

'You were also very openly telling people how soft the fur on my stomach is.'

'Well, it is pretty soft,' I had to agree. It's the softest.

'I know, 'Dor, but all your friends didn't need to know. They also didn't need to know how soft my fur is everywhere else either, or how it feels when we cuddle naked.'

'You're joking?' Catra shook her head, a small smirk just visible at the corners of her mouth. 'Catraaa, you can't let me speak when I'm drunk.'

'How, my betrothed, am I supposed to shut you up?'

'You could just kiss me.'

'What, like how you tried to kiss all your friends?'

I dropped the tracker pad on my face. Catra's reaction was immediate, her laugh once again filling my otherwise silent and dark room. I groaned, lifting the device away and rubbing at my nose and forehead. 'Ow.'

'Good going, Adora.'

'Are you being serious? I actually...'

Catra nodded, her smile spreading wider, *'oh yeah, you got very sentimental at one point. Started gushing about much all your friends mean to you and started trying to ambush them with kisses to prove it.'*

I rolled back over onto my front to hide my embarrassment, which Catra saw through immediately and promptly started laughing again. I sighed, tilting my face to watch her laughing at me, and couldn't help but think about how lucky I was to be engaged to her.

——— Day 6 ———

'Do you still have it?'

'Have what?'

'The sword?'

'You mean the Sword of Protection? The one I found in the woods?'

'Yeah, the one that stole you from me in the first place.'

'It did not steal me from you. It just... caused a series of events that led to me realising how evil the Horde really was.'

'Yeah, yeah, I know all about how you didn't realise the place we grew up in, ran by Shadow Weaver *of all people, wasn't evil.'*

'What was I supposed to believe!?'

'Oh, I don't know, Adora. Maybe your own two eyes?'

I sighed and pinched the bridge of my nose. 'I don't want to argue with you about this, Catra. I was blind to it, okay? I was. And as soon as I realised what was going on I wanted to get us out of there because I found a safer, nicer, kinder alternative.'

'So now it's my fault for not going with you?'

'No, Catra, that's not—'

'I regret it, you know.'

'What?'

'Not staying with you. Not going with you to Bright Moon. Everything would have been different if I'd just gone with you.'

'You don't know that.'

'It might've.'

'*Might*, yes. I do regret the time I spent anywhere other than at your side, but we're here now. We're together. On the other side of the war that separated us, happy, getting married. You don't regret *this,* do you?'

'No! Of course not! Just... the way I jumped to conclusions back then. The way I didn't follow my heart, even though I wanted to. I was confused, felt betrayed and abandoned.'

'I know, Catra, and I'm sorry that's the way it happened. But we're here now.'

'We are.'

'You wanted to know if I still have the sword?'

'Yeah.'

'Why?'

'Just curious, I suppose.'

'Well, yeah I do.'

'Where is it?'

'Bundled up in a drawer at the moment. I think it's under some clothes.'

'Ah, yes, those clothes you never wear.'

'My usual clothes are perfectly comfortable.'

'Adora, your usual clothes are combat fatigues.'

'Yeah.'

'Yeah, so, when I get back I'm ripping all of them up and there's nothing you can do to stop me.'

'I could think of a few ways to stop you.'

'Not when I'll have you on your knees, being a good girl and staying still for me. Watching while I shred all your Horde uniforms.'

'Catra...'

'What? If you move, I swear on the moons above that I'll have to punish—' Catra was cut off by the sound of a door slamming open somewhere behind her.

'Hey, wildcat! What'cha doin'?'

'Scorpia!'

'Is that Adora!? HEY ADORA!' Scorpia appeared behind Catra, all smiles and waving limbs. The absolute picture of unbridled excitement.

'Hi, Scorpia...'

'Wildcat, I hate to interrupt, but are you coming along to the thing? Entrapta's got the fireworks all set up!'

'Oh! Yeah, I'll be right there. I almost completely forgot about it.' Catra turned back to me with an apologetic expression as Scorpia left the room behind her, *'sorry, Adora, gotta go, speak tomorrow?'*

'Yes, absolutely. Go have fun. Just one thing: what are fireworks?'

'Ha!' Catra laughed, *'I have no idea! From what I remember Entrapta saying, it sounds like the whole Fright Zone is about to find out. Hordak's addressing everyone too before it starts.'*

'Hordak is there?'

'He is. He's been surprisingly cordial. Most of the people and ex-soldiers here have never seen him before. He's mostly been apologising for the awful conditions—saying that he was blinded by conquest yada yada.'

'I see.'

'Anyway... I should be going, otherwise Scorpia will come back and carry me there.'

'Okay. Bye, Catra! Have fun! Goodnight!'

'Goodnight, Adora. Speak tomorrow, I love you.'

'I love you too, Cat.'

After the call closed, I laid back in my bed and smiled into the darkness of my bedroom, feeling warm and content. Lance and

George were almost fully moved now, just with the last few things to take across tomorrow, despite our day of rest in Mystacor.

Not long now.

——— Day 7 ———

I flopped onto my bed on the evening of the seventh day of Catra's absence, a mix of excitement and melancholy swirling around my stomach. Excitement, because Catra would be coming back tomorrow and I would finally be able to hold her again. Melancholy, because I'd had another long day and I'd missed Catra so much throughout everything I had to do. Why did everything feel so much harder when she's away? Why is every box just that little bit heavier? Why does it feel like there's a pit in my stomach that aches every time I think about her?

"It's okay to miss her, Adora. She'll be back soon, anyway, and you can be as attached at the hips as you want," Glimmer had said yesterday. Or was it the day before? I suppose it doesn't matter.

For now though, I shook those thoughts away and reached for the tracker pad, my lifeline, my only form of communication with the woman I'm going to marry, and started the call. While it rang, I wondered I should tell her that we finally finished moving the last of Bow's dad's stuff over, or if I should mention that I'm going to donate my old sword to the museum they're putting together.

I was pulled from my contemplation by the call connecting.

'Oh! Hey there, Adora. Gosh, it's good to see you! Properly this time too. How are things in Bright Moon?'

Scorpia. That's not right, I definitely dialled the correct frequency.

'Hey, Scorpia... Yeah, everything's fine, um– is Catra there?' A lump formed in my throat and the almost constant pit in my stomach that appeared on the first day Catra was away somehow got deeper.

'Wildcat? We thought she left early. Is she not with you?' Scorpia's brow furrowed in concern, and my stomach did a few unwelcome flips as my body began to feel extremely heavy. I felt like I was sinking but I knew I wasn't, and I didn't know what to do so I did the only thing I could think of.

I panicked.

'Scorpia! Are you sure she's not there! She would have said something if she left! Please tell me she's there, that she's okay! Please! She has to be okay!'

Scorpia looked alarmed on the other end of the tracker pad, glancing around as if trying to look for something. *'I'm sorry, Adora, I've not seen her since last night. She left the fireworks display pretty early. But you know our wildcat, always sneaking off to who-knows-where. Plus, she can definitely handle herself. Wherever she is, I'm sure she's fine. If she's not lounging about somewhere here, she's probably on her way to you and forgot to let you know.'* She was quiet for a second, before her eyes went wide and she sucked in a breath. *'Unless it was supposed to be a surprise and I've gone and ruined it! Ah, dang it!'*

Despite the sinking feeling protesting in my stomach, I actually managed to chuckle at that. 'Okay, Scorpia. Let me know if you see her and I'll let you know if she turns up here.'

'Right you are, Adora. Hey– you've no idea how much she wouldn't shut up about you this past week. You're really good for each other. I'm happy for you.'

'Really?' I asked, taken aback. 'I could've sworn you didn't like me.'

'Oh I didn't.' Ouch. *'Yeah, I don't know why, and I'm not usually one to hold a grudge, but for some reason I just* did not *like you. Maybe it was just because Catra used to talk about you all the time back in them war days when it was just the two or three of us. She'd always talk about you. Now that I think about it, it was only you she ever really focused on. Maybe I should have picked up on that a little more.'* Scorpia scratched at her undercut with the point of her pincer and laughed a little, looking a little tense.

'Well, maybe we can have a Best Friend Squad and Super Pal Trio meet up? Play some games or something?' I suggested. Making nice with Scorpia was definitely high-up on my list of to-dos since she's Catra's best friend.

'That. Sounds. Awesome! Wow! What a great idea! Entrapta and Hordak left pretty quickly this morning but I'll definitely chase her up on that and get back to you!' Scorpia replied, beaming from ear to ear.

'I can't wait to—' I started, but stopped when I heard Glimmer's magic behind me. I flipped around, finding her looking breathless and panting while doubled over, her hands on her knees. 'Glimmer? Are you okay?'

'No! I'm not. I've just been running and teleporting all over Bright Moon gathering people up. You have to—oh, good, you're still dressed—come on, come with me, it's urgent!'

'Oh, okay,' I said, jumping up from my prone position on the bed. 'Shall I bring Scorpia?'

'What?' Glimmer asked, confused until she saw the display of my tracker pad. 'Oh, I see. Sure, she'll need to know this too. Saves me a trip, I guess.'

'Where are we going?' Scorpia's voice asked from the little screen in my hands.

'The war room,' Glimmer replied, before taking my hand in hers and teleporting us straight there.

It was busy. That's the first thing I noticed. Practically everyone was here except for Mermista, Sea Hawk, Frosta and Perfuma. I had questions, but one of them was rising to the surface faster than the others.

'Hey guys!' I began, then just in case anyone else had seen her, asked, 'Scorpia said Catra's not in the Fright Zone anymore, you've not seen her have you...?' But as I looked around the room, quickly taking in the sight of everyone with varying degrees of concern on their faces, I realised there was something else afoot. 'Guys? What's going on? Why's Hordak here?'

Hordak being here in person was strange because as far as I was aware, he had only just left the Fright Zone that morning– although Scorpia did say they had left in a rush. Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged a nervous glance, their fingers intertwining. Bow held onto Glimmer as she rounded the table and gave him a quick hug. Micah was standing close to Hordak, looking over his shoulder at something on the tracker pad the ex-Lord was holding. Juliet stood nearby, exchanging hushed words with Castaspella in the corner.

'Emily,' Glimmer said, speaking up so the whole room could hear her as she stepped out of Bow's embrace, 'would you mind telling Adora what you just told us?'

» It would be my pleasure! «

I watched as Bow took Glimmer's hand, then held out his other hand toward me. I crossed the floor automatically, accepting his hand in mine and scanning his face. He looked... unsure? Worried? Scared? My thoughts were interrupted when Emily's chipper voice once again filled the room.

» I have detected a massive planet-wide energy surge! All the First Ones temples on Etheria are coming online and feeding their

power directly into the Horde Spires! «

'Wait,' I started, quickly thinking over what she just said a number of times, 'the Spires? What do you mean? They're all shut down—aren't they?'

Hordak cleared his throat and handed his tracker pad to Micah, who looked down at it disdainfully. 'I shall take it from here, Emily, thank you.'

» No problemo! «

'Adora.' Hordak turned and looked me in the eye. I noticed that his eyes were a little redder, and his hair a little more blue than they had been that last time I saw him, making him appear almost back to the way he had been before. 'The Spires Horde Prime placed around the planet have a secondary purpose. I understand you used a failsafe to stop the Heart of Etheria from activating?' I nodded, and he continued, 'the Spires secondary function is, in a way, a kind of failsafe. If, for whatever reason, Horde Prime was unable to conquer a world, he would simply destroy it, leaving the surface entirely uninhabitable. It's called the Ember Protocol. All the Spires connect to one another, forming a shield around the planet. Then, once the atmosphere is sealed, the Spires begin to heat the planet's surface from within. Rock turns molten, plants burn to ashes, all the water evaporates under the intense heat. Once that stage is fulfilled, the Spires cause a thermobaric reaction, using oxygen, breathable air, to generate a devastating explosion. Effectively setting the air on fire. I need not state what happens to living creatures, but once the ordeal is complete the entire planet will be nothing but a lifeless, desolate husk.'

I looked up at the hologram hovering above the table—it showed Etheria being pierced by spires all across the surface of the planet, lines forming between them into a kind of grid, sealing off the sky. I wouldn't let fear grip me, not like it did in Erelandia. Wherever Catra is, I just hope she's safe.

'What do we do?' I asked, looking between my friends gathered around the table.

'We stop it. Best Friend Squad style!' Bow's confidence in the face of yet-another world ending threat and the squeeze of his hand made me smile. 'No matter what happens, we'll defend Etheria. And this time, we won't be going in blind. Emily! Triangulate the origin of the signal activating the spires!'

'Wait, we know the source?' I asked, glancing away from Bow back up at the hologram of Etheria and it spun around and began to zoom in. 'Is the same one from before? From Erelandia?'

'No, but it's similar!' Bow practically cheered, letting go of my hand to point up at the hologram. 'This signal is much stronger than the one that activated the Swarm drones before, and because Hordak's been scanning it for a while already we've been able to track it to the source which is... here!'

Everyone leaned in, trying to get a closer look as the map rotated and zoomed in on a desolate land filled with mountains and harsh rock, almost on the opposite side of the planet from the Crimson Waste. A single word floated over the whole region, identifying it as:

Spikeheart

Chapter End Notes

And here... we... go...

If for whatever reason you'd like to support me more directly, I now have a **ko-fi!**

Scratches

Chapter Summary

The Ember Protocol begins, Adora runs.

Chapter Notes

Hi! Welcome back!

The final arc of Magic of Etheria continues..

Thank you all for your patience with me while I write this, it tends to take me a while to wrap my head around the story as everything comes together, while everything also falls apart.

I'll stop rambling now, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I don't think I'm exaggerating when I say that everyone on Etheria was watching, the day the sky turned green. All the Spires, left behind by the Galactic Horde and untouched since their defeat, started activating one by one. They each fired a blindingly bright beam of green light up to the edge of Etheria's atmosphere, where the light stopped and split apart, forming a lattice around the planet and effectively caging us in. Hordak said it was there for two reasons: to stop people from escaping the surface of the targeted planet, and to protect any ships in orbit from the wildly unpredictable desolation that was to follow.

Everyone in the war room ran outside to see what was happening as soon as the ground started to shake. The nearest terrace happened to be the gardens, Shadow Weaver's greenhouse of suspicious plants still standing—although now filled with a range of delightful gifts from Plumeria—so that's where we found ourselves.

Netossa whistled admirably, remarking on the size and scale of was she said was effectively "just a big net".

As I watched this happen, watched the sky seal off with a wave of green light, watched as Etheria's potential final moments drew upon us (again), all I could think was: *where's Catra?*

'The Swarm drones have already descended,' Hordak was saying, 'hundreds of them, maybe thousands. Far more than were present at Erelandia.'

'So they're trapped in here with us?' Micah asked, 'that doesn't seem smart.'

'With Horde Prime gone,' Hordak continued, 'I am unsure as to the motivation behind the activation of the Ember Protocol, but whoever has started this cannot stop it without—'

'It's Prime,' I said, speaking up and interrupting Hordak, 'he's back. Or, I guess he never really left.'

'What do you mean?' Glimmer asked, and rightfully so followed up with, 'you were so adamant that it wasn't Horde Prime! To the point you had a panic attack just thinking about it!'

I felt a reassuring hand land on my shoulder and looked to see Bow smiling at me with a soft expression. 'How about,' he started, keeping his voice low and calm, 'we let Adora explain in her own time instead of losing our cool?'

Glimmer sighed and crossed her arms over her chest, nodding reproachfully, 'you're right, Bow. Sorry, Adora. But, *please* tell us how you know it's Prime.'

I looked down at my hands, but realised I'd left the tracker pad back in the war room. Only Perfuma and Catra knew about me having seen Prime, and only Catra knew that he *actually was* in my head. I took a deep breath to steel myself and looked around everyone's patient faces before landing my gaze on Glimmer. 'Ever since I picked up that crystal in Dryl, and up until just before

Princess Prom, I could hear and see Horde Prime. But he was just *in my head*, no one else could hear or see him, so I thought for the longest time that maybe it wasn't real. But it *was*. He was affecting me, making me scared, making me doubt myself and say and do things I didn't mean. When Catra and I were fighting and you left me in her room to talk to her, she tried to make up with me, but I pushed her away again even though I didn't *want* to. That was *him*. He did that. I'm sure of it. I don't know what else he specifically had a hand in, but it took until he brought out She-Ra to attack Catra that I knew how bad it really was.'

'Why didn't you say anything?' Bow asked, voice laced with concern and eyes full of worry.

I laughed dryly, 'he was in my head, Bow! I don't think I could've even if I wanted to. The only people who knew were Catra and Perfuma. I don't even know *why* he let me tell Perfuma. He could have planted little ideas in my subconscious, and I would have acted on them without even realising it.' I sort of had an idea of the moments when I wasn't entirely in my right mind, but thinking about it too hard is not what we need right now. Not what Etheria needs. I need to—I *have* to—protect everybody, defend the planet from him, whatever it takes.

Whatever it takes.

I'm ready.

I'm ready to fight him again.

I am.

I am...

But...

"It doesn't always have to be you!"

Catra...

No. I need *to find Catra, I can't do this without her.*

"—can't believe you didn't tell us about this—!"

"—this really isn't the time—"

"—converging on major settlements around the planet—"

"—going to be swarmed—!"

Everyone suddenly seemed to be talking over one another. Glimmer was talking at me, Bow trying to calm her down, Hordak looking at a holographic map projecting from his arm covered in red blips, Castaspella watching it in horror, Netossa and Spinnerella holding each other while looking up at the sky. I followed their gaze, eyes widening as I was confronted with a familiar yet equally mortifying sight.

Swarm drones. Hundreds of them, descending on Etheria as the barrier closed behind them. They must have been lying in wait just outside the atmosphere, all those drones from all those ships that steadily disappeared off of Hordak's radar.

This was Prime's plan.

Complete and total annihilation.

'Adora! Snap out of it! We need She-Ra!'

"What do you want, Adora? When do you get to choose?"

I blinked, tilting my head down to see an exasperated Glimmer staring up at me. She looked scared, uncertain. I shook my head.

'I don't.'

Glimmer blanked. 'What?' She breathed, her eyes going a little glassy at my sudden curveball.

'I don't need She-Ra,' I repeated, finding my voice and confident in the conviction behind my words. 'I don't need *her*, but I do

need Catra. I have to go and find her; I *have to know* that she's okay.' I smiled hopefully, extending a hand to the Queen of Bright Moon. 'Will you help me?'

The Queen sputtered for a moment, eyes flitting between me and the cloud of drones above us. After a moment, she closed her eyes, relaxed her shoulders, and took in a deep breath. She released it slowly, her expression blank and mind made up. I saw the flicker of a smile on her lips as she turned to Bow, planting her hands on his shoulders. 'Bow,' she began, 'tell Juliet to equip her troops with the staffs from Mystacor.'

He gasped, a realisation dawning on his face. 'The magic ones!?' Glimmer nodded. 'Yes! Operation: Counter-Drone is a go!'

Bow turned to excitedly speed away to do something with magic staffs, but Glimmer grabbed his wrist and pulled him into a soft embrace. I turned away quickly, giving them a moment while seeing what everyone else was doing.

Around us, Hordak rapidly spoke to Entrapta through a projection on his gauntlet, Micah and Castaspella formed the beginnings of a spell above our heads, Netossa and Spinnerella stepped back from their own embrace, exchanged a chaste kiss, and then broke into a run towards the city to direct and help the people there.

When I looked back, Glimmer and Bow were crying. Crying and smiling; crying and laughing. As Glimmer turned to look at me, I noticed that she was missing her earring, and Bow seemed to be wearing it. *Huh?*

'You ready?' She asked, wiping the tears from her eyes as Bow kissed her cheek.

I nodded dumbly, not really sure on what just happened between them.

'Then let's find your girl,' Glimmer said, stepping back from her embrace and clearing her throat. 'Bow!' He straightened his posture and saluted, a cheeky smile scrunching his flushed

cheeks. Glimmer snorted, 'you're in charge. Make sure the citizens of Bright Moon are safe, keep everyone indoors, evacuate people to the palace if you need to.'

Bow beamed, 'leave it to me. Adora,' he said, turning to me as he dropped his hand to his side, 'find her. Wherever she is, she'd want to be found. Leave Bright Moon to us.' I opened my mouth to reply but was cut short when Bow pulled Glimmer and I forwards into a group-hug. 'Go, Best Friend Squad! We got this, even one member down!'

'But not for long,' Glimmer added, smiling, 'we'll find Catra and then come get you Bow, and then we move on Spikeheart.'

'Sounds like a plan,' he confirmed, kissing her on the forehead. I fake-barfed, which earned a scoff from Glimmer and a chuckle from Bow. 'Now get lost, I've got a city to defend,' he said with confidence, pushing us from the hug and standing with his hands on his hips, puffing out his chest. Glimmer laughed, shoving at his shoulder lightly, without malice.

'I'm sure you do, *Master Archer* Bow,' she intoned, before turning to me and holding out a hand. 'You ready, Adora?'

'As I'll ever be,' I replied, voice cracking just a little. Bow shot me a thumbs up as well as a comforting smile. We exchanged a nod, a silent *thank you* and *you're welcome* that didn't need words for the message to carry. He was doing this *for me*, so I could go and look for Catra despite the weight of She-Ra on my shoulders and everything that she stands for. I should be defending these people from attack, defending Etheria; but here are my friends, smiling and showing me that it's okay to be selfish, to want things for myself.

It was time to go find my wife.

Future wife.

'Okay. Let's go.'

Seeing the Fright Zone again was something I thought I was prepared for. I'd been there not too long ago, after all, when we tried to rescue Scorpia from Prime's control. But what I was not prepared for, in any way shape or form, was seeing the Fright Zone look so... *different*. Gone was the smog. Gone was the unending, incessant clang of machinery, the sounds of constant training. Gone was the errant foreboding that something terrible was about to happen to you. It even *smelt* better, something I'd never even considered could be possible, the scent of burning garbage replaced with something fresher, more *alive*.

However, my chosen moment of pause was ill-timed. A nearby explosion showered Glimmer and I in hydrated soil, caking us in healthy ground that I also realised *crops* were growing in. Another explosion further away caught my attention, as well as the shout of pain that followed.

That's when I felt the tap on my shoulder, stopping me from sprinting toward the shout as my legs had automatically moved to do. When I looked back, I saw Glimmer's shocked face as she looked to the sky.

Green. The sky was green here too. Of course it was, but that wasn't what glued our feet to the ground—we'd seen the hologram in the war room, as well as the skies over Bright Moon. No, what caused us pause was the thick blanket of Swarm drones that convulsed overhead, the green of the Ember Protocol's net only just peeking through the breaks in whatever formation they held. If one can accurately describe *utter chaos* as a formation.

'There's so many,' Glimmer said simply, her words barely a whisper, 'why are there *so many*?'

I had no words at first, simply shaking my head in disbelief at the sight developing above me. The drones appeared to be flying in groups, or clusters, soaring high into the sky before looping back on themselves and diving again, beams of hot green energy firing from their cannons, bombs dropping from their hulls.

The Fright Zone was falling.

Despite looking different, despite everything being covered in plants, despite the ground being cleared of pipes and redundant machinery left to rot with nowhere else to put it, the horizon was still red. Red, because the Fright Zone was burning. Why had they attacked here before Bright Moon? Had I not left the tracker pad back in the war room, would Scorpia have been able to warn us about what was happening? Would we have been able to jump into action sooner?

But no, this would soon be happening to Bright Moon too.

A blast of red electricity shot up into the sky some distance away, arcing through a dozen drones at once, their explosions thundering across the war-stained sky, and shook me from my thoughts. I looked to Glimmer, the Queen, one of my best friends, standing stock-still beside me, and grasped at her shoulders.

'You have to go back!' I shouted, pleaded. 'Bright Moon is going to need its Queen. If it's going to get this bad, you have to be there to defend everyone!' I realised that I sounded desperate, suddenly very aware of the danger that this attack meant for Etheria. If we didn't play our cards right, if someone wasn't careful, we could lose before the very ground we walked on was scorched to dust, and we wouldn't even be alive to see it happen.

Glimmer just held my gaze, a stern glare in her eye that told me she'd already made up her mind. 'Bright Moon will be fine,' she said, confidence radiating from her brighter and hotter than the flames of destruction around us. 'I trust Bow, I trust my dad, I trust everyone who's there to defend Bright Moon with everything they have.'

'But—'

'No, Adora.' Glimmer stopped me from protesting, removing my hands from her shoulders with a gentle push to each of my wrists. 'You're here to do what you want, what you need, and that's finding Catra. Go, find her. But don't tell me what I need to be doing, what I want to do. This place, I can see how much it's changed, how beautiful it would look if it wasn't burning down. I want to help protect it for as long as I can. Perfuma and Scorpia are here, I'm going to try and find them, support them. Who knows, maybe I'll even save a few Horde scum soldiers while I'm at it.'

I smiled at her light-heartedness, appreciating the way she tried to reassure herself that everything would be fine. I appreciated it because it worked on me too.

Stepping back, I cast a quick glance around us, scanning the buildings to gauge where exactly I was in relation to where I needed to look for Catra. If she's here, hiding, there's any number of places she could be. I just had to hope that she's okay, that she isn't injured, and that maybe she'll be up to helping us with whatever challenges Spikeheart presents.

'Okay,' I said, turning back to Glimmer. She straightened her back, rising a little taller. 'I trust you.'

She smiled and, pulling me into a hug, firmly squeezed me despite us just sharing a Best Friend Squad group hug a moment beforehand. I didn't hesitate to return the gesture however, wrapping my arms around her and squeezing just as tightly. 'Be careful,' she whispered, 'find that future wife of yours. I have a lot of paperwork from this last week I need her to go over.'

For the first time that day, I laughed, shaking Glimmer with the sudden force of it. 'Paperwork? Are you sure it's not just because you miss having her around? Admit it, she's growing on you.'

Glimmer just huffed, shoving me from the hug and rolling her eyes. 'No!' She protested, 'we just have a few things in common is all. She keeps me on my toes. Although, I can see why you like her – she's surprisingly soft behind that spikey armour she wears.'

I felt myself beaming, inwardly proud of Catra for lowering her walls around more people than just me, trusting my friends with more of her, allowing herself to *be*. 'You should feel her tummy,' were the words that dropped from my mouth before I could stop them.

Surprisingly, Glimmer just looked thoughtful for a moment, as if the words *yeah, I should* briefly waltzed through her mind, but the moment ended as quickly as it began. 'Be careful,' were the last words Glimmer said before she teleported away, leaving me standing there in a clearing of fertilised soil and struggling crops as fires raged around me and death circled overhead.

'Always am,' I whispered, to the space where Glimmer had been standing.

Running through the Fright Zone after Glimmer teleported away should have been easy. I knew the way. Or I thought I did. *I used to*. But Catra was right: everything really had changed so much since the last time I was here. Most of the little shortcuts or faster routes Catra and I used to race down were just gone now, dismantled, most likely melted down to be used for some of the newer buildings that I didn't recognise. The tallest of the Fright Zone's structures still remained, however, and using those to direct myself meant I found the first likely hiding place Catra would choose fairly quickly, despite my initial disorientation and having to dodge around explosions and fleeing civilians (a second glance told me that, no, they weren't civilians, they were just Horde soldiers without their helmets on. The sight almost made me trip over a loose root of a nearby tree).

When I first entered the building where Catra and I spent a lot of our time together, up until I left, I noticed how run-down it was. The walls seemed grubby, doors jammed at odd heights having gotten stuck halfway down, and the lights overhead flickered even without the attack outside shaking the foundations.

I found the training room first, as it was on the lower level. I wasn't really sure why I initially checked there, but something made me stop outside the door and peek inside for the first time in almost four years.

It was exactly as I remembered it: wide, open space with hexagonal pillars forming the unsteady floor. I watched as a few segments fell away and *"Hey, Adora. How's it hanging?"* closed my eyes as a memory shunted to the front of my mind. It wasn't unwelcome, far from it, but I couldn't afford to be distracted now. Catra wasn't here, time to keep looking.

The locker room was next, being fairly close to the training grounds. There were a few places in here where Catra had hidden herself over the years, having little other options, but it was hard to imagine her actually being able to physically fit into many of them now. Some of the lockers had fallen over, spilling their contents—a few training shirts, armour, and batons—onto the ground. I could tell from how cold the room felt that Catra wasn't here but seeing it in such disrepair sent a pang of sadness through my heart. This room had so many memories within its walls and yet here it was, barely able to keep itself upright as the world ended around us.

But right then at that moment was not the time to wallow in memories of how life used to be. The world had changed a lot since then, Etheria had finally come together. It occurred to me in some random part of my mind that the vast majority of buildings and rooms within the Fright Zone no longer had any actual purpose without a war on. It was as if the whole kingdom had lost its purpose, its function, and everyone here, everyone who'd chosen to stay or moved in since the war ended, was helping to find the Fright Zone's new purpose.

Maybe it would even be renamed.

I moved on, continuing with my initial quest to find the love of my life somewhere in the wreckage of our past, literally represented by this building, its rooms, and all the memories stored within. As I ran down the corridors, ducking and weaving around debris and loose piping, I could almost see a younger Catra and I giggling and running along without a care in the world. We'd been so free, back then, just me and her, young and naïve, thinking we could actually grow up in the Fright Zone and everything would be okay. Looking back, I'm not sure that would have ever happened. Even if I hadn't found the sword, I would have figured it out eventually: that everything the Horde did was evil, bent on Etheria's destruction, on enslaving hundreds of innocent people and forcing the Princesses to their knees.

My thoughts were interrupted by a painfully familiar sight through the next door I stopped outside of. I wasn't quite sure how far I'd ran, but I knew that our old bunkroom was not especially close by and I shouldn't have been able to get here so quickly. As I braced myself against the doorway, leaning down to peer inside, I noticed that my forearm was covered by a shiny gold gauntlet.

I'd managed to unconsciously change into She-Ra while running, so lost in my own thoughts and warring emotions at being back and letting myself think about it. The last time I was here, I didn't let these kinds of thoughts in, too focused on saving our friends. But now, with a weight forming in my chest of still having not found Catra, I could feel my distress rising. Maybe She-Ra had sensed that, coming out to support me as best she could, to stop me from falling and helping me the rest of the way.

The bunk room was dark, darker than I remembered. Many of the beds were in disarray, obviously not slept in for quite some time. Apparently, whatever other accommodations the Fright Zone's new management had set up was far more desirable than this. I didn't blame them.

However I, of course, was drawn to my old bunk. I'd spent so much of my childhood in this very bed, alone or with Catra, and seeing it in an awful state of disrepair kind of made me want to fix it myself. Driven by some unknown force, I found myself bending down to lie flat on the mattress, struggling to fit with my sheer scale as She-Ra. It wasn't comfortable. My bed in Bright Moon was much nicer to my back, not to mention it usually had a certain someone in there too, warming up the sheets.

That's when I happened to turn my head, muscle memory leading me to look at that one place on my bunk that always brought me such a sweet sense of comfort—and held back a sob. We made it years ago, I could barely remember when, but drawing our faces side-by-side on my bunk had always felt far more meaningful than it actually was. In reality, it's just a silly drawing, the idle scribbling of children so bored out of their minds that they started doodling on their own bed. But to me, it was important. It was so much more than a stupid little doodle. I used to stare at it as I would fall asleep, every night, usually with Catra at my feet, dreaming of the day when we could be that happy together without reprimand or a war stopping from just being with one another and enjoying each other's company.

But, as a sharp and painful reminder of the wedge I formed between us all those years ago, four distinct claw marks were sliced through my face, forever breaking the image and threatening to replace the memory of it in my mind with something far more painful. Regret washed over me like a tidal wave, as well as grief and a longing to hold Catra and whisper apologies for what I did back then, even if I knew she wouldn't want to hear it. We both knew, after all, that if given another chance, I wouldn't do a single thing differently. The scratches through the crude drawing of my face sent home just how broken Catra must have felt after I left, for her to do this to something that I knew meant as much to her as it did for me, and I couldn't stop the tears from rolling down my face once they started.

But I wiped at my eyes, getting up from the bed and moving back towards the door. Casting one last glance at my old bunk, a

remnant of what felt like a past life, and left.

Catra needs me, and right now, I need her.

The Fright Zone was a mess, every building left behind from Hordak's reign had already looked mangled to the point where you wondered how they remained standing, but now it was a different story. Catra and Hordak's "disagreement" left much more of it in ruins than I thought. Many rooms were distinctly missing their ceilings, were filled with rubble, and the holes melted through walls that still had a set of armoured footprints walking through them was a little disconcerting.

Hordak's Sanctum was not a place I thought I would ever see again if I'm being honest. But, when I walked through one of those perfectly circular holes in the wall, that's exactly where I found myself.

Vats not too dissimilar to those from the First Ones temple in the Crimson Waste dotted the ruined space within, many of them broken, smashed, their contents long since oozed onto the ground around them. Disused machinery, cracked screens, abandoned tinkering, and the remnants of the portal also haunt the vacant sanctum. I had never been invited to see Hordak whilst living in the Horde, not once, and this marked only the second time I had actually been inside.

The first time...

I could distinctly remember the look on Catra's face when she pulled the lever. When she almost ended the world and didn't seem to care. For a long time, I didn't know why she did it. I didn't understand. I do now. She'd explained it to me; how broken she was, how alone, adrift, hollow and shattered to her core she felt after learning how Shadow Weaver abandoned her in the exact same way I did.

If I were to bring that up with her again, now, after all this time, she'd probably argue that I didn't abandon her, I just did what I had to. That's what I used to tell myself too, all those years ago, when the wound was still fresh. The truth of it is that I *did* abandon her. I didn't mean to, but I did. I left her behind, even though she was everything to me, and let her believe she didn't matter.

I've already resolved to spending the rest of my life atoning, and to never let Catra feel like I don't want her, need her, and love her with all of myself ever again.

To do that, I have to find her first. I have to make sure she's okay.

I left that room, hopefully for the last time, with a heavy feeling in my chest and tears stinging at the corners of my eyes as I made my way through the abandoned halls, the sounds of the battle outside only just reaching me past the sound of my own heartbeat thundering in my ears.

The Black Garnet chamber was empty.

I knew it was unlikely that Catra would be hiding *there* of all places, but something drew me towards the room anyway, to peek inside. What I found was an echo, ruined and abandoned, left without a purpose by the lack of Scorpia's Runestone.

Catra hadn't mentioned them moving it, but perhaps she'd been so busy that it just sort of blended into their activities.

When I closed my eyes, I could hear the distant memory of cries and screams coming from that room. So much pain, so much fear, so much hatred.

I shook the memories away as I turned and left the room behind, for good. Bow had been right to be cautious when I suggested we

come back and look around, maybe it wouldn't be such a good idea after all...

Finding Catra's Force Captain quarters should not have been so difficult. I should have asked her where it was while we were talking over the tracker pad if only to give myself some kind of hint as to where exactly her new quarters were located. How did I know Catra's quarter's when I saw them? Claw marks. *Everywhere*.

From what I could remember of the background from Catra's calls, these were definitely new. The metal was freshly cut, gleaming in the flickering light as another nearby explosion rocked the building. Catra had been here, recently, and she'd been fighting *something*. I wasn't sure if I'd ever seen Catra claw up a room like this before. A few older instances came to mind, but nothing as severe as this. On the bed, I could see her whip and jacket; on the floor, her old uniform, torn and shredded.

My heart started thumping my chest as thoughts of *something happened* and *Catra's not okay* and *Catra needs me* started thundering through my mind.

I turned on the spot and ran.

Everything I hoped I wouldn't find was there; the place where Catra had been staying, had sworn was safe, was apparently *not safe* and clawed up like she'd trying to seriously *hurt* something.

Or *someone*.

She-Ra is fast, I often forget how fast, but when I finally stopped running and just stared out across the expanse of the Fright Zone below me, I finally allowed my mind to catch up with my body.

Seeing Catra's quarters like that, in that state, confirming in the worst way that something awful could have happened to the woman I love, threatened to break something deep inside of me. Something that couldn't be broken, *shouldn't* be broken. I had to keep it together. I had to be strong. I had to be brave. I'm She-Ra. She-Ra isn't weak. She-Ra isn't vulnerable. She-Ra isn't—

'Adora?!'

My head immediately snapped up, scanning the rooftop around me for some kind of hint as to where the voice came from.

'Adora, up here!'

I followed the sound of the voice again, standing to my full height and looking up at the antennae that sprouted out from Catra and I's secret place. No-one had known about this place before, so seeing Lonnie of all people up here caused some kind of possessive emotion to flare up within me, as if she was somehow trespassing.

But then I remembered that Lonnie is technically in charge of the Fright Zone now and I, while trying not to focus too hard on the Swarm drones above, eventually registered that Lonnie was literally *tied up*.

Upside down, swaying from side to side in the wind that was definitely stronger than I remember it, most likely an effect of the Ember Protocol messing with the balance of Etheria, suspended from an antenna by a thick and sturdy coil of *vines*.

My initial thoughts sounded something like, *but why would Perfuma—*

But then I remembered.

Catra.

'Lonnie?' I called back, 'what happened, why—'

'As much as I'd love to just *hang out*, Adora, I'd appreciate it if you could just cut me down already. We don't have time to catch up or chit-chat.' Her glare left little room for argument.

'Right! Yes, sorry,' I mumbled, summoning my sword, then swinging an arc of magic up at the vines, cutting her loose. Lonnie hit the ground skilfully, using a method I recognised from our training, bending her knees, and rolling to prevent any serious injury. She stood quickly, brushing herself off before moving to stand at the railing and watch as Swarm drones dive-bombed the kingdom. Another arc of red electricity shot up into the sky, followed soon after by an explosion of pink, sparkly magic.

'What's the sitch?' Lonnie asked without looking at me. I shifted my weight from one foot to the other, suddenly nervous in front of one of my old friends who I'd been fighting against for three years.

'Horde Prime,' I said simply, watching as Lonnie's eyes widened and she looked to me in shock, a million questions on her lips. 'He's back, somehow,' I continued quickly, aware that time was pressing, 'but we're going to beat him. We know where he is I just... I had to come and look for Catra. I haven't heard from her in a day and I'm worried that—'

'Tch,' Lonnie scoffed. 'She's a real piece of work, you know that?'

'Uhm–I–uh...'

'She apologised to us. All of us. Me, Rogelio. *Kyle*. And then she had the gall to cause a ruckus scratching up her old quarters, running off when I heard and came to check on her, stringing me up, and then vanishing with that cat of hers.'

There was so much in that last sentence that I had to absorb, but I didn't have time to before Lonnie pointed behind me and shouted, 'look out! Behind and up!'

I turned immediately, swinging my sword down and up towards the approaching formation of seven drones, cleanly destroying

them with the arc of magic the move created. Lonnie watched, stunned, before turning to me again. 'If you can stop this, *do it*. I don't know what's gotten into Catra, but we're not gonna last much longer out here if this carries on the way it's going.'

'Lonnie– hang on– what do you mean? What happened to Catra?' I pleaded with the woman in front of me, practically begging for any kind of hint as to where she is, 'why are her quarters like that?'

Lonnie sighed, turning back to look out over the Fright Zone. At this height, with the smog lifted, the horizon was clear. Except for the green that tarnished it, alongside the smoke from the fires that raged under the drone's onslaught. 'We don't have time,' Lonnie began, voice heavy with her new responsibility to protect this place, this newfound beacon of hope for so many displaced souls, 'I have to get down there, to help my people.' She turned to me then, looked me in the eye when she whispered, '*our* people.'

I closed my eyes, clenching my jaw to avoid the cry that wanted to escape. The truth of it was that I'd *missed my friends*. My old friends. Lonnie, Rogelio. Even *Kyle*. I still cared for them, so much, that was the truth of it. But right then, at that moment, my person was missing, and nothing else came close to mattering to me. 'Catra is my priority,' I said, opening my eyes to stare into Lonnie's calculating gaze, 'we're getting married, Lonnie! I have to find her, just– *please*, if you know what happened, you have to tell me. *I need her*.'

We both flinched as a fireball erupted from on of the buildings nearby, a formation of drones flying away from the blast while raining fire on the kingdom below. Lonnie turned to me then, face set with determination. 'You'll stop this?' She asked, 'if I tell you what happened, this stops, right?'

I nodded quickly, sure that with Catra's help, I would be able to think straight, to put an end to Horde Prime's plan once again. To save Etheria, the planet I love, full of the people I love. My home.

'I promise.'

Lonnie nodded. She stretched her hands out in front of her, cracking her knuckles, then set me with a firm stare. 'I followed her away from the celebration last night,' she began, voice sure and gaze unwavering. I felt myself step forward, eager to listen, 'she was holding her head, didn't look too good. I was going to check on her, make sure she was okay. She's been helping out, *a lot*, since she came to stay, so, I guess I was worried. Anyway, I heard Catra shouting, shouting *at* something. Screaming, almost. It was terrifying, *she* was terrified, I've never heard her sound so scared in my life. I heard her yelling for someone to *get away*, to *get out*, all while the tearing up the walls of her quarters. I managed to get the door open, but she bolted past me, knocked me down. I yelled after her, but she used this magic wind to get away from me. I followed her, found her up here, which is when I asked again if she was okay. She just... smiled. But there was something off about it, weird. Then she used these vines to string me up before vanishing right after her big green cat showed up. I can't *believe* no-one came looking for me! Kyle is *so dead* if he's still alive down there, I swear—'

'Green?'

Lonnie blinked at my question. 'What?'

'The cat... was green?'

'Yeah,' Lonnie said slowly, unsure as to what I was getting at. 'That thing's been changing colours all week while she's been moping and complaining about missing yo—'

'Adora!' Glimmer's voice appeared behind me, snapping me back to reality before my mind became too clouded with the implications of what Lonnie had said. 'We have to go! We're running out of time– where's Catra? Did you find her?'

I turned to see Glimmer standing here, on the rooftop where Catra and I spent so much of our time as kids, one arm linked

through Bow's who was frowning down at his tracker pad, the other placed palm-open on the side of Swift Wind's neck.

'Guys—' Bow began, voice breaking with his gaze set firmly on the tracker pad.

'Hold on,' Swift Wind said, voice low and calm, 'something's wrong.' He trotted forwards; eyes locked with mine. I could feel a warmth in the back of my mind, Swift Wind reaching out through our sacred bond, feeling everything I felt in that moment. I watched as his eyes began to water, his face betraying the feelings I was fighting to contain. Anguish. Anger. Fear. Worry. Sadness. An internal, warring desolation that I fought to keep down. I couldn't let myself feel everything he was feeling within me, not if I wanted to get Catra back. I had to keep my head, to not succumb to this weakness, to not get distracted.

So I did the only thing I could; I blocked him out.

'Let's go,' I said, surprised at the conviction behind my own words.

'What?' Glimmer and Bow said in unison, equal looks of surprise on their faces. Glimmer looked back at Bow, around the rooftop, then glanced back to me, 'but what about—'

'Wherever we're going, wherever that signal is coming from; Catra's there.'

Bow looked unsure, 'Adora, how do you—'

'I just know, okay!?' I recoiled, instantly guilty at snapping at one of my best friends in the whole world. 'I'm sorry, it's just, she always is, isn't she? In the middle of everything.'

'Adora,' Glimmer stepped forward, taking my hand in hers, 'what do you mean?'

'She's always where the danger is, right?' I could feel the emotions coming back, tears threatening to escape from the

corners of my eyes. I looked back at Swift Wind, who's face was set firm in his determination. I could feel it. He was pushing back against me, trying to fill me with confidence, to make me feel brave, to help me believe that everything would be okay.

I let him back in, and let the tears fall.

Glimmer swallowed, nodding. Bow patted me on the back. Swift Wind enveloped us in his wings. Before I knew what was happening, we had formed a group huddle, arms and wings around one another, heads pressed together.

'We can do anything,' Bow began, his voice sure yet laced with emotion, 'because we're the Best Friend Squad. We're not afraid, because we have each other, and we have love. We'll find Catra together, then we'll defeat Horde Prime together too. I know we can.'

Glimmer giggled, and I found the sound to be a welcome one. 'We've done both of those things before, who's to say we can't do them again?'

'Exactly!' Swift Wind, proclaimed, stepping back from the huddle to spread his wings wide and lift his head to the sky. 'This is nothing! We got this! Right guys? Yeah?'

I smiled, reaching across to pat his neck. 'Yeah, we got this,' I reassured him. This time, I believed the words I was saying. I'd almost lost myself to the thought that Catra was gone, but with my friends by my side, we can find her, we can save Etheria. 'Let's do this. Horde Prime's played his last move, we just have to throw a wrench into whatever it is he's done and get rid of him. For good, this time.'

Glimmer beamed as Bow clasped his hands together to his chest with hearts in his eyes, looking close to tears. I took both their hands as Swift Wind wrapped his wings around us once again.

I heard the faintest *'what the heck was that all about'* from behind me before Glimmer teleported us away.

Catra, please be okay.

Chapter End Notes

:)

If you'd like to support me and my writing, consider buying me a coffee on *ko-fi* !

King of the Trolls

Chapter Summary

The BFS arrive in Spikeheart.

The world continues to end.

Chapter Notes

Heeeeeey. How are we all? Good?

Anyway, CW for minor character death in this chapter.

tags will have been updated accordingly

See the end of the chapter for more notes

My first impression of Spikeheart was not an overly comforting one. It was similar to the Crimson Waste; a desolate, dead place. Filled to the brim with jagged mountains and harsh rock that reached far into the sky, but not high enough to penetrate the glaring green of the net encircling the planet. The silence was deafening, save for the sound of wind howling between the jagged, sun-kissed peaks of the expansive mountain range before us.

'So, uh, not be a downer on an honestly *great* day where *absolutely nothing* has gone wrong so far, *buuut*,' Swift Wind drawled, clacking forwards on the rock face below us to peer over the edge of the cliff we were standing on, 'where the hay are we even going? There's nothing here.'

Bow stepped forwards, holding the tracker pad out in front of him again as if that might somehow help. 'Before Glimmer came back to get us, Micah warned me that this area could be a technological dead-zone. Frankly, we're lucky that I'm getting a signal at all. No-one has lived in this part of Etheria for centuries. At least, no-one with tech.'

'So what do we do?' I asked, glancing around the surrounding peaks, 'can you still trace the signal that Hordak detected?'

Bow grimaced, looking back at me over his shoulder with an almost apologetic expression. 'Kind of? Whatever Horde Prime is doing to the planet, it seems to be creating some kind of electromagnetic force around Etheria, which is allowing me to sort of, maybe, be able to trace the signal. But it's not accurate at all. It's going to give us a general direction, at best.'

'Well then,' Glimmer announced, stepping forward and grabbing Bow and I by the arms, 'what are we waiting for? Let's follow whatever it is you're picking up and see where it takes us. It doesn't look like the drones have reached this part of Etheria yet, so we have some time to find wherever it is the signal is leading us.'

'We should still hurry,' I said, climbing up onto Swift Wind's back as he lowered himself down. 'Catra's out here somewhere, and Etheria's still under attack. The faster we stop this, the faster we find Catra and the faster we help our friends.'

When I looked back, I saw both Bow and Glimmer exchanging a very snug looking hug. Both of them had their eyes closed and seemed to be smiling softly, while just soaking in as much of the other as they could.

'Uh... guys? World-ending event going on, right now, everyone's counting on us?'

Glimmer sighed, pulling back from the hug just enough to get lost staring into Bow's eyes. He smiled back, utterly content, and reached up to fiddle with the earring that Glimmer had given him before we'd left for the Fright Zone.

'We should get going,' Bow whispered, his hesitance to break the moment seeping through into his body language—making no move to pull away either.

'Yeah,' Glimmer sighed, 'I guess you're right.' Then she kissed him, quickly, on the lips, before teleporting both of them behind me onto Swift Wind's back.

Why had Glimmer given Bow her earring? And why were they choosing now, of all times, to be super clingy despite the world literally ending (again) and all of our friends fighting while Catra—

Wait.

Catra... My pin... Engaged...

Oh.

OH!

'Wait! Did you guys—?!'

'Everyone ready?!' Swift Wind yelled abruptly, then proceeded to not wait at all for an answer before launching into the air and soaring through the sky. He went up, higher and higher, until he was weaving between the peaks of the jagged mountains of Spikeheart.

From our newly gained height, I could three or four of the Horde Spires firing their deathly green beam up into the sky, continually supplying power to the energy field around the planet. I couldn't help but wonder how much longer we had until those Spires would start destroying Etheria from the inside out. Hordak's words looped through my head again, I remembered how he described rock turning molten, plants turning to ashes, the water evaporating until, finally, the air itself was set aflame.

Nothing would remain.

'Adora! ADORA! Snap out of it!'

Glimmer's shrill voice pulled me back from my thoughts, just in time for me to grab on tight as Swift Wind lurched out of the way of a fireball that soared past us.

'Woah!' Swift Wind yelled, fighting to keep himself upright as another fireball hurtled passed, a little off the mark compared with the last one.

'Okay!' Bow shouted, 'Micah may have mentioned we wouldn't get a warm reception, but this is *NOT* what I thought he meant!'

'What else would he have meant, Bow?!' I yelled back, before materialising my sword just in time to cleave a fireball in two with a sharp arc of magic.

'I thought he was making a joke about the weather!' Bow replied tightening his arms around Glimmer's waist.

I felt Glimmer's arms tightening around me, too, just before she shrieked back to him, 'my dad is awful at jokes Bow! He's been secretly taking notes while we moved your dads into Bright Moon! If he sounds serious, *he's being serious*!'

Another fireball came speeding toward us, but Swift Wind dropped just in time. We watched as it zoomed overhead, leaving a trail of black smoke in its wake.

'Not the time, guys!' I yelled over the sound of them shouting as Swift Wind continued to juggle dodging fire balls and avoiding crashing into the surrounding mountains. 'We need to get out of range of these fireballs! Swifty! Use the sacred bond; find us somewhere to land!'

'You got it, Adora! Sacred Bond, GO!' He yelled. I felt the connection form as much as I saw it. In the back of my mind, Swift Wind's thoughts and movements were present in my head, and mine in his. We started to glow a bright gold, shining like a beacon in the green-stained sky.

Which, I realised all too late, was probably not the best idea.

Another volley of fireballs, much more than before, suddenly breached the fog that hid the base of the mountains from view, whizzing past as Swift Wind dodged between the ones I couldn't

swipe with my sword. I was vaguely aware at how fast we were flying, how tight Glimmer's hands were around my waist, how quickly we were weaving between the peaks, up and over and down and under, dodging fireball after fireball.

Bow gasped, pointing down toward the peak of a particularly low mountain that looked to have a crater at its precipice. 'Look!' He yelled, his voice cracking just a little, 'down there! There's some kind of settlement! And CATAPULTS!'

I eyed the settlement wearily, watching as they unleashed yet another volley of fireballs at us from the edges of the crater, which curved up and around the simply built structures almost protectively and hiding it from the ground, but not from the sky. 'Swift Wind! Dive!' I shouted, leaning forward to wrap my hands around his neck just as his wings folded in and we began to plummet down towards the mountain village.

'Hold on!' He warned, before clamping his jaw shut against the wind as we fell, picking up speed and aimed straight at a clearing near the middle of the small village where—

Wait.

Is that *Darla*?

We were falling too fast for me to voice my realisation, and two bolts of fire suddenly shot out from behind me. Glimmer had her staff at the ready, aimed down at the village with a circular spell spinning around the tip. I sent her a warning look and shook my head, which had me receive a questioning glare in return, before she vanished her staff. The damage was already done, however, as both of the bolts of fire already released made contact with the catapults they were aimed towards, setting them ablaze and causing... Well... Large, hairy *beings* to stomp away and vanish into huts or holes in the ground.

Swift Wind spread his wings as we approached, lining us up for a clean landing in the clearing at the centre of the mountain village.

'Look out!' Bow yelled, accidentally leaning too far as Swift Wind banked to the left and slipping off of his back, taking Glimmer with him.

'Guys!' I yelled, looking down after them just in time to see a cloud of pink, sparkly magic in place of where they had been falling.

Which is why I didn't see the net coming.

It wrapped around us in an instant, forcing Swift Wind's wings to fold in at an uncomfortable angle that I felt in the back of my mind, through the bond, as a weird twang of discomfort. The metal weights tied to the corners of the net tangled with one-another until Swift Wind was too restricted to fly, and we immediately began to fall. It all happened so quickly that I didn't have time to slash at the net with my sword until it was almost too late. It came apart, unravelling from its restrictive hold on Swift Wind's wings just as we hit the ground. He whinnied in pain until he was able to angle his wings to stretch outside of the net, just laying there for a moment while I, cushioned from the fall by being encased in the soft feathers of his wings, shot to my feet, waving my sword around. Glimmer and Bow appeared behind me soon after, bedraggled and dazed.

The things that had been firing fireballs at us from catapults ever since we arrived quickly surrounded us, bearing all kinds of interesting looking weaponry. Lots of spikes. I couldn't help but think that being attacked with any of those weapons was the last thing I wanted to happen. They looked like they'd hurt. But their hesitation in attacking us once they had us surrounded gave me pause, time to think, time to take in our new surroundings and properly look at who, or what, was brandishing spikey hurt sticks at us. They were like nothing I'd ever seen before. Larger than lizardfolk, thick skin, hairy arms and chests, as well as impressive, braided beards that matched the hair on their heads. Each of them stood at eye-level with She-Ra, or maybe a head taller, absolutely dwarfing Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta.

Wait—

'Friends!' Entrapta screeched, appearing out of nowhere and scaring the life out of all of us. I jumped so hard that I flung my sword into the air, it didn't land anywhere so it must have just disappeared. Bow panicked and picked out all of his arrows at once, hurrying to nock them so fast that he just ended up dropping them all over the floor. Glimmer– I lost sight of Glimmer, but she must be nearby.

'Entrapta?!' Bow screeched back, arguably in a higher pitch than Entrapta, after he recovered from the initial shock of being surprised and instead moved onto the shock of her just randomly appearing next to us within the circle of death poles.

'That's me!' Entrapta replied, shouting and excited, as if her being here was a set fact that we were all supposed to know. 'This is so exciting! Are you also here following the signal?' She asked, but then— 'Did you know that a Troll's diet is primarily comprised of a glowing fruit that only grows underground and contains enough nutrients and protein to allow them eat nothing else?! This is especially impressive considering that their average size and muscle mass is larger than—'

Glimmer reappearing at Bow's side is what brought me back from zoning out while Entrapta explained the dietary habits of... *Trolls?*

'Entrapta, stop!' A voice interrupted. It took a moment before I realised it was me that had spoken. 'Oh, um—'

Glimmer spun around quickly, surveying our current predicament quickly before her eyes came to rest on Entrapta. 'Entrapta,' she began, as if we weren't surrounded by massive Trolls frowning and aiming pointy-pointy hurt things at us, 'a clear and concise sitrep, stat.'

Entrapta *saluted*, of all things. *Bow* saluted earlier. Should *I* be saluting when Glimmer speaks to me?

'Affirmative, your Majesty!' Entrapta replied, beaming from ear to ear. She dug around in her hair, pulling out her tracker pad before she jumped up, suspended by her long purple locks, then perching on it as it seemed to form a kind of stool under her. 'Last night during the fireworks display, which I was initially confused about because firing exploding rockets into the sky for no reason doesn't seem like something that Hordak would suggest out of nowhere, I detected a signal! As we know from previous incursions, these signals are especially central to finding out what is going on around the planet. Horde Prime activating his drones as well as the Spires can only mean—'

'Wait,' I interrupted, as one part of what Entrapta just said stuck out to me more than the rest as she spoke a mile a minute.

'Yes?' She looked up at me, totally unfazed and ready to listen.

'You said Horde Prime,' I stated, looked to Bow and Glimmer and seeing the realisation on their faces too. Entrapta hadn't been there when I told them who was behind everything. 'How do you know it's Horde Prime?'

Entrapta's eyes narrowed for a moment, and then her face literally lit up in a toothy grin. 'Well, who else would it be!?' She said, as if it was obvious. 'It's kind of obvious when you think about it. All the evidence points to the same conclusion. I had my suspicions ever since Underdryl's Forge was hacked, as it matched the patterns from the last time Horde Prime hacked the planet when he tried accessing the Heart of Etheria! Since then, I've been compiling a database of analysis every time an irregular event occurred that featured either green light or an unknown, hostile signal.'

And, well, yeah.

'Okay,' was all I could think to say. Entrapta had once again connected dots where no one else had seen them, and then completely failed to tell anyone about it, assuming everyone else

already knew and was noticing the same things as her. 'Good work.'

Entrapta beamed.

I realised then that the trolls surrounding us had long since lowered their weapons. They seemed to be whispering to each other, watching, content to let this play out before them. We weren't readying to attack them, so they must have felt at ease enough to let their guard down. Entrapta was already here too; had she befriended them already? If so, her loudly declaring us as "friends" would be a great signal to them to stand down if they trust her.

'—so I followed the signal here after Hordak said he would stay in Bright Moon to warn the princesses of what was happening. You'll be pleased to know that Darla's upgraded shields *excelled* at dampening the effects of large rocks coated in a flammable moss that the trolls of Spikeheart seem to employ as their main defensive capability. Once Darla landed and I explained to the troll's designated leader that I used to work for the Horde, but the Horde technically doesn't exist anymore, and so therefore am no longer a direct threat to their village, he allowed me to stay as long as I tell him things! They haven't been able to keep up to date with the state of the planet, what with being so isolated out here, but they were very keen to listen to me explain the state of events as well as some of my more abstract theories about what's happening right now. Oh! I was also able to ascertain that they know nothing about the signal that I followed to get here, but I was able to narrow down the possibility that the trolls are protecting something, which I'm assuming to be some kind of old First One's temple based on this particular similarity in the wavelength when compared to other previous signals that I've recorded that were immediately followed by a drone incursion or similar event.'

There was a moment of silence after Entrapta finished speaking that no-one, not even the trolls surrounding us, seemed to want to interrupt in case the tech princess wasn't done with her

rambling. Glimmer looked exasperated, as apparently she had somehow expected Entrapta to stick to her requested "clear and concise" explanation of what was going on. Bow just looked thoughtful, as no doubt he had been able to take in every word she said and was currently thinking through the best way for us to respond to this new information. I, however, was distracted by the arrival of a new presence in my peripheral vision, one that commanded the ground it walked on with a surefooted step and a self-assured confidence.

Entrapta also noticed the new arrival, lighting up immediately and waving a tendril of hair in their direction. 'Hello! These are my friends! They're here to—'

'Silence!' The word bellowed around the village, a deep and guttural voice booming between the peaks of Spikeheart. 'Who dares to enter my kingdom?! Agho does not entertain visitors! Not when the sky shines green, an omen, warning us of the death and destruction to follow! It is as was described to us! This planet shall die, doomed to meet the same fate as many, countless others before it!'

I stepped forward, standing to my full height, looking up at the figure of Agho, the *King of the Trolls*. He really was a sight to behold, much larger and stronger than his brothers and sisters, a crown of iron upon his head, a staff of uncharacteristically intricate design in his hand. His face was set in an expression of anger, glaring down at the four of us encircled by his people, who, after his sudden appearance, had once again picked up their weapons and aimed them toward us.

'Please!' I began, spreading my arms wide to show that I was not armed. Well, *not anymore*. 'We come in peace! We mean you no harm! Horde Prime is back and—'

'Horde!?' The King's voice boomed around the clearing; sudden rage apparent as he spat the word back at me with a seething malice. 'When the Horde first came to power, we trolls offered to aid you humans. But our help was not accepted, you hated us!

Feared us! Mistrusted us! So we came here, to Spikeheart, away from the Horde and away from your hate!'

I looked to Glimmer and Bow, who just shrugged, the reason for Agho's outrage not known to them. 'We don't hate you!' I insisted, turning back to face the troll towering over us, 'and if we mistrusted you, would we really be here asking for your help?'

'You require the assistance of Spikeheart?' He asked, his voice quieter. I saw him glance toward Entrapta, who nodded eagerly.

'We do,' Glimmer said, stepping forward to stand beside me, hand-in-hand with Bow. 'And we offer you our help, as well, if you should need it.'

'Hm,' Agho grumbled, scratching at his bearded chin in thought. 'It is true you are not like other humans. You have courage. You are all brave to stand before me, to speak as though we are equals.'

'If I may, your eminence,' Bow said, theatrically bowing before the king, 'Glimmer *is* your equal. She's the Queen of Bright Moon, and Adora is the She-Ra, the Princess of Power. We would be honoured to call you an ally.'

Those revelations caused a murmur of hushed whispers to spread throughout the crowd, but Agho seemed to may them no mind. He just continued looking down at us with a thoughtful expression upon his brow.

'Do not believe them, Agho,' a voice in the crowd seethed, 'they attacked us!'

'And yet, they did you no harm,' Agho replied without looking at the one who had spoken, his eyes taking on a look of kindness, of acceptance. 'Friends of Entrapta, the one who talks of the wider world and fantastic impossibilities, who have come seeking aid, whilst offering aid in return. Very well. The new Queen of Bright Moon, the She-Ra, I accept your allegiance.'

'Woo! Yes!' Glimmer shouted, fist-pumping the air with a ball of magic before wincing and pulling her arm back into herself. 'Oops. Sorry,' she giggled, a nervous smile on her face.

Agho just laughed, a deep, almost comforting sound that stood out in stark contrast to his earlier outbursts of rage and malice. The trolls around us seemed sceptical but lowered their weapons anyway. Some were smiling, apparently pleased with the outcome. Others were scowling or staring at us with suspicion. I didn't blame them, if what Agho said is true, these trolls had been hiding out here since the beginning of the war, when they offered their aid. What I couldn't wrap my head around, was why the humans—or, *Micah?*—would have refused their help, causing them to hide from apparent scorn out here in the mountains, somewhere I had, in all my time on Etheria, never even heard of, let alone been to.

I was pulled from my thoughts when the murmur of curious voices around us hushed to silence. Everyone around us had turned, facing toward where the king stood upon his perch. But there was a new figure beside him, leaning over to whisper into his ear. The king paid rapt attention to every word, his brow furrowing in contemplation as the new arrival spoke to him, and him alone.

Then they finished and turned to face the crowd. Immediately, all the trolls around us brought the palm of their right hand up to their face, then gestured out toward the figure. It was a bizarre sight, to see of this happen simultaneously. Glimmer and Bow were equally enraptured by what was happening, looking around wide-eyed with curious confusion. Then, I saw Entrapta do the same thing with her hand beside me, and felt my confusion deepen.

Entrapta caught me looking, a wave of understanding washing over her face as she used her hair to raise herself to my height. 'It's a sign of respect,' she whispered, glancing over to the where the king was still deep in thought as the troll beside him took in the crowd, waving her hands as if to dismiss the affection she was

receiving, and laughing when none of the trolls put their hands down. 'She's the healer of this settlement, a doctor, and in this societal bubble the trolls have formed, that puts her reputation above that of even the king. She answers to him, but he respects her too much to dismiss anything she says.'

I felt a light pressure around the pocket of my jacket, but I forgot about it completely once the healer's attention moved my way.

As soon as her eyes locked with mine, I could feel myself blush as heat spread across my face, having been caught staring; but I was finally able to fully take her in. She was a troll, that much was clear, but her stature was smaller than that of the others, less muscular, more frail. Her body was wrapped in what appeared to be a white sheet. It draped over her shoulders, wrapping around her waist a few times before dangling off her hips. Her legs were bare, save for the same wrapping around her feet that the other trolls possessed, and wore an intricate headdress upon her head that rivalled that of the king. It was a marvel, beautifully crafted, with a single, purple crystal in the centre from which all manner of plants seemed to interweave out from. I felt observed as she looked at me, her gaze dropping to take in She-Ra's form, before her soft smile returned.

From beside me, Glimmer coughed. '*Ahem! Engaged. Ahem!*'

'What?!' I sputtered, taken aback by Glimmer's insinuation that I was– that I– that she– 'Glimmer! *No!* I wasn't– I wouldn't—'

'Adora, I presume?' The healer's voice was soft, so far removed from the gruff, low tones of her kin. 'Or... no, I suppose not. This form is the She-Ra, isn't it?'

I blinked up at her for a moment, feeling caught off-guard by the healer's stark contrast to those around her. 'Uhm, yes, I'm Adora, or She-Ra, it's nice to—'

'Let me see you,' the healer said, her voice, despite being so soft, easily stopping mine from continuing. At my apparent confusion,

she elaborated, 'your true self, Adora. I wish to see *you*.'

Realisation dawned, and I nodded, letting She-Ra go. I felt myself shrink back down to my regular height, suddenly feeling dwarfed by the height of the trolls that surrounded us, and smiled up at the healer, awkwardly waving a little.

She smiled back, her eyes darting down momentarily to take me in... *again*. '*Hello, Adora*,' she drawled, in a way that was reminiscent of how Catra often spoke to me, and I felt my cheeks flush involuntarily with warmth, 'I am Sajo, the current healer of Spikeheart. If you would indulge me, I should like you to meet someone.'

Spikeheart's healer held out her hand toward me, waiting for me to take it and to let her lead me elsewhere to meet... someone. Agho simply nodded, his mind made up.

'Yes,' he boomed, as if he'd thought of it, 'yes, go with Sajo, meet the hermit. Perhaps you can make sense of his ramblings.'

I looked back at my friends. Glimmer seemed dubious, Bow looked intrigued, and Swift Wind, now recovered and standing upright, had his wings spread wide while a few trolls ran their fingers through the feathers of his wings, praising his majesty. I rolled by eyes, because he was eating up the attention and was, unsurprisingly, paying no attention to anything else going on around him. A quick glance back to Bow and Glimmer told me everything I needed to know. The expressions on their faces were ones that looked like they wanted to know why I hadn't already gone with Sajo, and secretly wished that they'd been invited to, but—

'Go with her, Adora,' Bow reassured me, wrapping an arm around Glimmer's waist, 'we'll ask around and see if we can't find out where that signal is coming from.'

Glimmer nodded, folding her arms in front of her chest as she dutifully tried to ignore Bow's hands and remain dignified in front

of another reigning monarch. 'Yes. Absolutely. That, we can do. Yes.'

I offered them a smile in thanks, secretly glad that me being whisked away by a beautif– by the healer of Spikeheart would not impede the real reason we were here.

Time was ticking, after all; the world can only end for so long.

'Thank you, guys,' I said, already moving forward to take Sajo's hand, 'come get me if you find anything.'

As soon as my hand met the healer's, she turned and pulled me forwards, almost dragging me through the rest of their village. Most of the houses were made of huge stones and rocks, a feat I imagine only a race as strong in appearance as the trolls could pull off, whereas some were chiselled away from the rock itself, disappearing into the floor or mountainside where only the faint flicker of a flame inside gave away their location. A quick glance to the sky showed me that the green grid was still in place, the clouds swirling below it menacingly, a swarm of drones beginning to form.

Oh, that's not good.

'So, uh, Sajo... who *exactly* is it that you want me to meet? You know there's... there's kind of a lot going on and I have to find Catra because I'm worried about her and don't really know where she is or if she's okay and I'm concerned about Melog because of what Lonnie said and I don't know how that affects Catra if at all and I'm hoping that what I'm thinking has happened hasn't happened because I know it would really, *really* hurt her if it did and I'm worried about the state she'll be in afterwards, and that's only if I *can* help, if I can get her back.'

Sajo regarded me with a patient smile, reaching out to place a hand on my back as I caught my breath. It was warm, a comforting weight that helped to ease my worries, if only for a moment.

'Breathe, Adora,' Sajo whispered, her voice steady and calm, 'breathe. All will be well, I am sure of it.'

I nodded, breathing in and out deep and slow as Sajo resumed her tugging on my hand. I did ask why she was holding my hand, but all I got in reply was an immediate *"you have nice hands"*, so I was left trying to hide my blush.

She led me forwards, toward one of the more secluded entranceways, far from the main area of the village. "Hermit", the king had said, and I couldn't help but feel that the word was accurately chosen.

Briefly, I wondered if Razz would somehow be the person beyond the threshold of the rocky abode, mined out of the side of the mountain with tools and sweat. Her showing up here at all places would not surprise me at this point, she had a knack for getting herself into impossible situations.

But, as Sajo urged me forwards, almost pushing me through the doorway, I saw that it was not, in fact, Razz that sat within.

Sitting on a carpet on the floor, crossed-legged, hands on his knees and head thrown back staring at the ceiling, was a person who, if it was who I thought it was, I'd only ever heard stories about. Rough rumours, hushed whispers, far-fetched theories. As I moved closer, the image I'd built of him in my mind altered to match who I saw in front of me. His skin: blue; his short, wavy hair: blue; his rather sharp looking outfit was also various shades of... *blue*. He and his moderately decorated housing, filled with things definitely *not* from Spikeheart, seemed entirely out of place in this remote, mountainous village.

I looked back at Sajo, who only nodded for me to proceed, her eyes locked on the figure before us.

'Um, hi? I'm Adora. You wouldn't happen to be—?'

'Adora!' He suddenly reached out and grabbed my hand, glancing down from the ceiling to look me in the eye. Or he would have, but his eyes were like windows looking directly into space—a black void speckled with stars and nebulae. 'I see him. I've been watching him for a while, he's taking such a long journey, all for you. All on his own, so lonely, a last resort to save his people and bring you home.'

'What? What are you talking about?' I asked, unprepared for the sudden outburst. Before he could reply, he blinked, his eyes immediately returning back to normal. Blue. Soft.

'Ah!' He jumped back, scrambling back away from me to the far wall. 'Who are you?! How did you find me?'

I stared at him, bewildered. 'You just said my name! I'm Adora — *who's coming?* What were you talking about? You said something about my home, do you know where I'm from?!' I couldn't help the rise in my voice. This person, this person *knew something* about where I come from, before Etheria. He'd seen it. He said he could see someone coming to take me... to take me *home*?

'Oh, I did it again, didn't I?' He almost wailed at the realisation, a hand coming up to shield his face in... in *shame?* 'I must have been using far-sight. You see, I can never remember what I've seen once I come out of the trance, so I'm sorry, I *really* am, but whatever I said I cannot explain it.'

I was stunned. Stuck. Frozen to the spot. 'You mean—?'

'Oh, I'm sorry, I forget myself. Where are my manners?' He launched to his feet, a wide (fake?) smile on his face as he fell into a rehearsed motion, theatrically bowing to me before rising

again and swishing his hair out of his face. 'Prince Peekablue, at your service. Or, *not*, I suppose. I'm afraid I'm a tad useless.'

My hunch was correct, and the image I'd built in my head based on vague descriptions and rumour solidified itself into the person standing, sheepishly and ashamed, in front of me.

'"Useless?"' I repeated, stuck on the word, until, 'is that why you left? Why you—?'

'Why I *what*?' The Prince fired back, immediately defensive, 'what have they been saying in my absence? It can't have been worse than what they were saying while I was *present*. I'm a failure, it's true. I can't wilfully control my far-sight, and for that I was looked upon like I was worth less than the ground I walked. *D* understood. They always understood. And if they did their job, the rumours surrounding me should sound much more fanciful than the truth.'

And... why did that sound so familiar?

'Your worth is...' I started slowly, Mara's words coming back to warm my heart, 'you're worth more than you can give to other people, you're worth so much more than your powers. Whoever looked down on you was wrong to do that. I'm certain that you were doing your best, and they just couldn't see it. It doesn't matter if you can't control it, you just have to embrace it, let it be a part of yourself. Because hiding everything, running away, bottling it up, never goes well. *Trust me,* I know. And Etheria is different now! The Horde is gone, everything is peaceful again. Or, *y'know*, it *will* be, we just have to save it all again. But if we come out of this okay, I'm sure the Princess Alliance would love to meet you. The *real* you, not the "*you"* from the rumours.'

Peekablue looked stunned, his eyes wide and expressive as my words washed over him. *Where did that come from?*

A warm hand landed on my shoulder. Sajo, coming round to stand between myself and Peekablue, looking between us with a hand

on each of our shoulders. 'In all the years I've spoken with you, Prince Peekablue, it is only now, after listening to the words of someone who overcame so similar a conflict, that you have found peace. Adora, from the bottom of my heart, thank you.' Sajo then, mirroring the actions of her breathren in the way they showed their respect for her, covered her face with the palm of her hand before lowering it, and handing it out towards me.

I was stunned, frozen that someone who commanded the respect of everyone in this bizarre, mountain village would offer *me* her respect. Peekablue just nodded, stepping back from Sajo to sit cross-legged on the floor. I wasn't so easily placated, however, as I couldn't help but wonder how Sajo knew that this is what Peekablue needed to hear. And from *me*? It occurred to me, then, that Sajo likely heals more than just the body, and Entrapta had probably been a bit more loose-lipped than she should have been.

I opened my mouth thank her in return, and to ask if she'd learnt about me from Entrapta, but a loud boom shook the mountain underfoot. Peekablue braced himself, leaning back on his hands to stay upright, while Sajo and I just held onto one another, anchoring each other to the floor. Once the shaking subsided, we simultaneously realised that we were perhaps stood a little *too* close, and promptly stepped apart.

'*Ahem*!' Sajo coughed, patting down her robe before hiding her cheeks behind her hands, I mirrored the action, and felt that my cheeks were *burning*, 'it would seem we are out of time, I hoped we would have more of it. Please, follow me once more; if you would.'

Sajo didn't offer her hand this time.

Outside, it quickly became apparent why that initial boom was the only one we felt from within Peekablue's dwelling. Entrapta had brought her mech from Beast Island, setting it higher up the mountain where it fired energy beams up at the now descended and swirling cloud of drones. Bow and Swift Wind were on the ground, still in the clearing toward the middle of the village where I'd left them. Bow's arrows exploded in balls of flame and Swift Wind's magic disabled groups of drones at a time. Showers of drones and parts rained down on Spikeheart, littering the ground and cascading down the sides of the mountain. All of the trolls were back at action stations, firing their flaming rocks up into the cloud and hoping for the best. Others threw spears tipped with sharpened rocks or jagged pieces of metal, and a select few fired arrows from the largest bows I'd ever seen. They were far longer than Bow's bow, and the arrows larger and sharper.

It took me a moment to place her, but once I did, Glimmer...

Glimmer...

She *soared* above Spikeheart, her father's staff in hand, defending and attacking all at once. Wings formed of bright pink magic beat with the unleashed strength of her full magical power. Glimmer was *shining*, her blinding light combating that of the harsh green atmosphere that threatened to burn Etheria to the ground. From her staff, bolts of fire shot out from a purple circle at its tip. From her other hand, formed into a fist, she smashed through drone after drone and defended against bomb after bomb.

And she was *smiling*. Her eyes were alight with the power she was unleashing and, while it was a sight to behold, a part of me was concerned for her.

'We must away,' Sajo said beside me, 'time is running out. Your friends and my people will defend the village, but we must *away*, Adora.'

I blinked back at her, seconds away from running off and joining the fight myself. But the image of Catra and a corrupted Melog

entered my head again, and in an instant my priorities shifted. I trusted my friends, I trusted Sajo's people, and... and I needed to find Catra, or to end this entirely, whichever came first. 'Where to, Sajo?'

'To our sacred cave!' A booming voice behind me roared. I turned to see Agho stomping toward us, empty handed, signs of battle evident on his bare arms and armour. 'To the Temple of Query! Sajo, you know the way! Take Adora to the Lady of Light!'

'Yes, my King,' Sajo said before offering her respect, and he returned the gesture in kind, 'it shall be done.'

'Good. Good. And Adora,' said Agho, King of the Trolls, turning to me and planting his huge hands on both of shoulders, 'stop this madness. Save Etheria. Save us all.'

I nodded, face set with determination. 'I will.'

'So...' I ventured, tentatively bringing up the subject while following Sajo through winding tunnels that apparently weave through the mountain below the village, 'Temple of Query? Lady of Light?'

'Yes. There is a door within the mountain that is guarded by a lady made of pure light, like the moons themselves shine from within her. It is believed that she tests all who approach, but none have yet to ask the right question to gain passage. It has fallen to myth what lies within, but, I hope to dash those simple-minded ideas today by entering by your side.' Sajo looked back at me, a playful glint in her eye and a wide smile on her face.

'You don't think the story is true?' I asked, trying to be careful about stepping on any cultural toes.

Sajo just shook her head, waving the torch in front of her to light the way through the dismal caverns. 'No, absolutely not. They are old ideas, and I've always suspected there is more at play. Temple of Query and Lady of Light are just the names my people have always used, and I have nothing else to call them.'

'You've been down here before then?'

'I have, many times. The people of the village believe me some kind of saint because I heal them, but my teacher was wise, and I carry that wisdom with me. Such a cooky woman, none who I tell stories of her believe me when I have finished—' and I was about to interject and ask if her teacher was someone I knew when '—ah! We're here! Behold! Isn't it magnificent?'

It was certainly something. Just like many of the other First Ones temples the Best Friend Squad has found over the years, this one was geometric in appearance, decorated with First Ones writing with the visage of She-Ra depicted in-between.

But it was wrong; this temple entrance, jutting out into the cavern before us, was glowing with a sickly green light. It reeked of evil, and a weight settled in my gut at the thought that, finally...

This was it.

Prime *has* to be here.

Or all is lost.

Sajo hung back to place her torch in a nearby sconce attached to the wall, and I stepped forward. Each step was slow, painful, and all I could wonder is if Catra was beyond this door.

A beam of light suddenly shone from a point above the angular door, projecting the image of the familiar holographic guardian of most First Ones temples. But she was wrong too, distorted, glitched, and spliced with shards of green light.

» *Wha-a-a-at is y-ur qu-ry?* «

Her voice was as distorted as the rest of her and, briefly, I wondered if holograms *could* feel pain, how much would she be in?

'Ah! The Lady of Light!' Sajo called from behind me, 'she looks... different. Usually her appearance is much more, um, *put together?*'

'She's part of the temple beyond the door,' I said, kind of believing my own words. Truthfully, I still wasn't entirely sure how the holograms worked. 'Kind of like a caretaker. *What happened to you*?'

» *W-w-w-w-w-wha-t is yourrrr quer-y?* «

'She requires the correct question,' Sajo said, her voice closer now as she made her way towards the temple entrance.

'No. She just needs to see.' I cleared my throat, held my arm out in front of me, and called, 'for the honour of Grayskull!' A quick glance over my shoulder showed me that Sajo was watching, a blush gracing her cheeks, as She-Ra appeared before her. She clapped a little when the transformation was complete, despite already seeing it the other way round.

» *We-e-e-elcome, She-She-She-Raaaa* «

The hologram vanished with an ominous finality as the door behind her began to scrape open as if it was struggling, a loud screeching sound filling and echoing throughout the cavern. I immediately covered my ears, She-Ra dropping away as my hold on her vanished with the intensity of the sound.

Then, as quickly as it began, the horrible screech of metal on metal stopped. The cavern once again falling to silence.

Until I heard Sajo squeal in delight behind me and start clapping again in earnest.

'Oh! Fantastic! I never thought I'd live to see this day; this is just magnific–*AAH*!'

I spun round instantly upon hearing her words cut short by a pained cry and froze.

In that moment, it was as if everything *stopped*. My breath, my heartbeat, my ability to blink; everything vanished. Time stood still as Melog—with eyes, mane and tail bright green, face contorted in an angry snarl just as Lonnie had described—dropped their invisibility from behind Sajo, revealing themselves and the blue glow of an energy sword piercing her torso.

Sajo gasped, one hand coming up to touch the side of the blade, as if making sure it was really there.

She *smiled* at me. It was a *farewell*. So full of sadness longing for this not to be goodbye. Oh, how I hoped it wasn't goodbye.

But the red kept spreading down and along her white robes, staining them with her once beautiful life, and yet she *smiled*.

'It was nice to meet you, Adora,' the words were choked, and I almost sobbed at how she struggled to speak them, '*go*. I believe in—'

—and the blade vanished, as if it was never there, and Sajo fell.

'Hello, Adora.'

Behind her, the one person I'd wanted to see most, in a position I never imagined seeing her in. Catra stood over the body of my friend, someone who, in such a short time, I'd come to care for as if I'd known her as long as the other princesses. But, just like the hologram, Catra was *wrong*; her smile lopsided and alien, her eyes, gloves, and circlet glowing the same green as Melog's mane. It was all *wrong*, and I couldn't speak for the shock and total helplessness I felt in that moment. Part of me wondered, *hoped*, that this was a hologram—some cruel vision projected from the temple—but the moment didn't end, and the unbelievable reality

set in with the echo of a harsh laugh and a low growl against the cavern's walls. Sajo had been beautiful, so full of kindness and so important to so many people and... and—

'It's about time you showed yourself. Thank you for opening the door. How does it feel to *lose*?'

—and Catra, *my* Catra, the woman I love with all my being, the woman who agreed to marry me with tears in her eyes, the woman who I couldn't *do this* without...

She was *gone*, and Horde Prime stood in her place.

Chapter End Notes

uuhhhhhhh

well…

next chapter is gonna be a doozey huh?

Fear Incarnate

Chapter Summary

The Final Confrontation.

Chapter Notes

oh hey, how's it going?

almost 4 months on the dot, here we are again for some Pain.

hope you like!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

‘If only you had let the activation of the Heart of Etheria run its course. None of this would have had to happen. You only delayed the inevitable.’

It was definitely Catra's voice, but the words were *wrong* .They felt too formal and mocking coming from her because they *weren’t* hers, they were *His* ; he was in my head for months, so recognizing his haughty tone had become second nature. Too soft, lacking any kind of emotion, head held high as though He was worthy of commanding the ground He walked on.

Catra laughed again, but it wasn't *her* laugh. It wasn't high-pitched or squeaky, and it didn't make my chest feel warm or cause butterflies to flutter in my stomach. No, this laugh was dead, remorseless, totally void of anything Catra. When she looked down at me—where I’d fallen to my knees on the floor, staring up at her in disbelief and not wanting to look at the body at her feet—her face contorted into something between fury and

pain, her pupil-less eyes glowing bright green to match the crystals on her First Ones tech.

A single tear rolled down her cheek.

'Catra...' I whispered, my heart shattering at the sight of her being controlled like this *again* , 'No...'

Catra's head tipped forward as *He* regarded the body at her feet. 'Who was this?' He asked, kicking at Sajo's body with Catra's foot.

'A friend,' the words felt far away, like I didn't really say them. They should never have been said, not in this context, not to her killer. It should have been an introduction, an explanation to the other princesses when they met her that Sajo could be trusted, welcomed with open arms.

But that wouldn't happen now, because he'd killed her without even knowing who she was, how much light she had to offer the world, how she was a healer who helped those who needed her and commanded the respect of her people. She was gone now, and he didn't even care.

'No matter, once the Ember Protocol is complete, none shall remain.'

'Let Catra go!' I yelled, suddenly finding my voice, 'you don't need her! Just– just give her back to me. *I need her.* ' My own tears

were beginning to blind me, clouding my vision. My arm felt heavy when I lifted it, using the base of my palm to wipe them away before they could fall.

'Hmm,' He held Catra's hands out in front of her, spreading her fingers to observe the gloves, glowing bright with malice and hatred. 'I think not. This vessel, *your* Catra, is more powerful than you could possibly comprehend. I don't believe even she knew of the true power she wields.' Her—no, *His* —eyes flicked back to me, 'I think I'll keep her. She's going to be very, very useful to me.'

'You can't do this to her! *Not again*!' I pleaded, desperate, just trying to make Him *see,* 'You can't! She's already suffered from you stripping away everything she had, leaving her hollow—she's had so many nightmares, and I've held her through every single one—so doing that to her again– I– I don't—'

'Please, Adora,' he drawled, moving Catra toward me one step at a time. He stopped inches away, using her hand, her fingers, to grip my chin and force me to look up at her— *at Him* . 'Do not misunderstand. What I did for your Catra before, that was simply a *mercy* . She was in pain, and I healed her. Her mind became one with mine, and she was not alone. It is a surprise that even after you saved her, she still came crawling back. But of course, she's *your* Catra, isn't she? Bitter enemies… and yet the two of you can never seem to stay away from each other, can you?'

'We're not enemies! Not anymore! We mean more to each other than you'll ever understand!'

‘Do you?’ He asked, Catra’s eyes narrowing as he stared down at me through them. I swallowed, mulling over the question because… he was lying, right? We do… but he's in her head, so… No. *No, Adora, don't listen to him.* 'You used to talk of ruling this paltry world together, up on that little spot on the roof that only you knew about. Then you left. You broke her heart. You always wanted more… but all she ever wanted was you.’

I shut my eyes tight, not wanting to look at Catra's face. He was weidling her like a saber, a tool that he could use to exert his will, a vessel for his poisonous words. He was doing that to my *wife* and I— I couldn't stop him. Everything he was saying was so confusing and overwhelming on top of everything else swirling around in my head and it was *too much.* The world was ending, Sajo was dead, all my friends were fighting a losing battle against thousands of drones, Catra and Melog were lost to Prime and… *and* …

‘There it is,’ Prime glowered down at me, his gaze predatory as he used her eyes to take me in. ‘ *There* is the look of total despair. Have you finally accepted your defeat, the end of your world as you know it? There is nothing you can do to stop me now. *Nothing* .’

Catra’s hand dropped from my face as he used her body to step away, around me, and through the door to the temple. ‘Follow if you choose, it won’t matter. Your world will end either way, it is up to you whether you watch it happen. Or sit here, with your dead friend, and cry for your world as it burns to cinders.’

I stayed there on the floor of the cavern, barely holding back tears as the sound of Catra’s footsteps faded into the ambiance of

the cave. If I focused, tuned everything out, I could still feel the slight vibrations of explosions rocking the mountain. Glimmer, Bow, Swift Wind and Entrapta were still up there, fighting alongside Agho and his people and I… I was down here, right where I watched Sajo die, unable to help her. Too *late.* I crawled over to her body, turning it over so she was laid on her back, and saw that her face was peaceful. Her last words were… she was going to say that she believed in me, wasn't she? *Me?* The person who watched as life drained from her eyes? The person whose fiancée stabbed her through the chest? I didn't deserve her trust. She shouldn't have put her faith in me. I was useless. I'll always *be* useless. This was always how it was supposed to end. Prime was right, maybe it was inevitable. Maybe this was how it was always supposed to be.

But…

But Catra's words, things she told me over the last three months, little things, big things, important and fleeting things, filled my head until she was all I could think about…

"Of course I'll stay with you, dummy."

"'I meant what I said earlier. I'm going to make it up to you, and you are not going to know what hit you..."

"I did what you said! I thought about you, how much I love you, how much you mean to me…"

"I'll follow you anywhere. I just don't want you to get hurt."

"Now that I have you I… I finally feel… happy. You complete me, Adora. All I want in the world is to see you happy too."

"I want to know where we're going. I want to know us being together is okay. That it's right. That it's not a mistake, or a dream, or something that's going to vanish, Adora, because I don't know what I'll do if I lose you… I don't want to be alone again. I can't be alone again… I need you."

"You're such an idiot. I can't believe I'm in love with the biggest dork on Etheria."

"I'm all yours, Adora."

Prime was wrong. This world wasn't finished. It had so much more to give. *I* had so much more to give. There was a whole life stretching before me, one where I could hold Catra close and show her how much she means to me, show her how loved she is and… and I was failing her again. In letting Prime walk away in her body, I was leaving her. By not following, I was leaving her behind. *Again.*

No more.

Enough is enough.

I rose to my feet, placing the palm of my hand against my face before holding it out toward Sajo's still form. A final show of respect for someone who showed me so much happiness in the fleeting moments we spent together. I made a silent promise to come back for her, to take her back to her people, so they could bury her with all the honour and respect that she deserved.

Then I wiped my eyes, straightened my jacket, and—

—and something fell out of my pocket. It bounced a little, rolling away across the floor until it was stopped by a rock and came to a rest. I followed after it cautiously, because I didn't recognise it, and there was certainly nothing in my pocket before.

Wait…

Entrapta…

Suddenly, I remembered feeling a weight in my pocket while Entrapta was explaining the Troll's etiquette to me. She'd been suspended next to me, held aloft by her hair, and would have been in the perfect position to slip something into the pocket of my jacket. Sure enough, when I bent down to pick up what I'd dropped, there was a tiny illustration of Entrapta's winking face scrawled on the side. It was a device, one I partially recognised. It had the same connector that Emily had used to plug into the chair back on the Dreadnought, right before I had to leave her behind. The rest of the thing was made of a smooth metal, a single, blinking purple light on the opposite end to the plug.

Entrapta had a plan. Of course she did. No wonder she came here while Hordak went to Bright Moon to warn the others. *Was this their plan?* I wondered, rolling the thing around in my hand, pondering its purpose. Was me showing up what Entrapta had been expecting, or was this her way of entrusting her plan to me? A final way to save Etheria, in the palm of my hand?

There would only be one way to find out.

With a new sense of duty surging within me, I set off into the temple, following after Catra with the determination to end this once and for all.

The interior of the temple was nothing new. Beyond the entryway at the end of the scrawling cave system within the Troll's mountain home, was what looked like every other First Ones temple I'd been in. Glyphs and writing lined the walls, glowing with the same green light that'd been following our adventures ever since Prime's initial defeat, when I first thought I'd finally erased him for good. If anything, this temple looked more like the first temple that Glimmer and Bow took me to, when I was still bound at the wrists and Glimmer wouldn't let me take the sword to fight off the monster that we'd aggravated in its own home, so close to its nest of young. Disrepair was evident all around, as if the walls themselves had been pulled apart while something went on a rampage. Or, no, not a rampage. If watching Entrapta scuttle

about Darla was anything to go by, then I would take a guess that whatever happened in this temple was something similar.

Speaking of scuttling, I soon realised I could hear some, faintly, coming from the shadows all around me. The sound was not quite as contained to my own imagination as I had thought. It felt like I was being watched, followed, monitored. My hand hovered protectively over my pocket, where Entrapta's device still sat, and my nervousness took form by fidgeting with its positioning,making sure it wouldn't fall out again.

After a while, I found that if I listened carefully, I could make out the distant sound of a voice. It was faint, coming from further in, so I followed it, because as far as I knew there was only one other person down here, and I needed to be wherever she was.

'She's going to follow you– no, not you. She'll follow me—

'—Because she's an idiot—

'—Yeah, well, try telling her that. No doubt she's got some stupid plan that won't work—

'—Well, then maybe she'll just want to see me one last time, how am I supposed to know? All I know is that she won't leave me. She promised. We don't break our promises anymore—

'—NO! Just do me a favour and stay out of my head! I want to be able to talk to her and tell her– I need to tell her that I— Adora? Adora, is that you?'

I blinked.

I must have zoned out while following Catra's voice because suddenly, there she was, sitting in the center of the room. I couldn't remember the path I'd taken to reach her, or how I ended up so tired and sweaty, but all thoughts of How I got there were vanquished when I finally *looked.*

The room was hexagonal with a high ceiling, full to the brim with machinery, screens, and wires. All the walls were coated in screens and blinking lights, many of them displaying different parts of Etheria through… cameras? No. Not cameras. *Eyes* . I remembered Ol'Pointy back in Octopus Cove, as well as the creature that Melog had chased for days while Catra and I ventured into Underdryl, and the realisation dawned on me that Horde Prime must have done that to hundreds more innocent creatures. Using them, controlling them, seeing *through* them.

It was horrible. Cruel. *Evil.*

But even worse was what I saw central to the room, towering above everything else. Wires and cables cascaded away from it in all directions, snaking across the floor like roots, hanging from the ceiling like vines; a column, made entirely of machinery, screens, and blinking green lights. But the images on the screens affixed to the room's central control column were not from the perspective

of unwilling creatures, forced to do Prime's bidding through his manipulation of First Ones crystals. No, these screens displayed a live feed from the drones. I watched as they descended on Bright Moon, the Fright Zone, Salineas, Plumeria, the Kingdom of Snows, Mystacor, and Spikeheart. Everywhere, all over Etheria, was being attacked simultaneously. I saw my friends, each of them defending their homes with everything they had, fighting to the last as everything burned around them anyway.

The sight broke my heart.

What shattered it, though, was catching Catra's eyes, where she was curled up at the base of the column, shaking, afraid, and alone.

'Catra?' I asked as I searched her eyes, seeing only her familiar cyan and amber looking back at me from the gloom of her hiding spot. 'Catra!'

'Adora!' She leapt up immediately, bounding across the room on all fours and leaping into my arms.

I *held* her. I held her with so much force that a voice in the back of my mind was afraid of hurting her, but she only held on tighter, not protesting to the intensity of the sudden hug as our bodies interlocked together.

‘Adora,’ she continued, pulling back from our embrace to look me in the eye, ‘I don’t have long. It’s the tech. He’s using the tech to control me to get to Melog. He couldn’t control Melog without going through the connection I share with them, so he’s *using me.’* I almost sobbed at the way her voice broke around those last two words, but just nodded that I understood. ‘I can’t take it off. It’s too late. He’s already in my head and won’t let me take it off. Adora, do whatever you have to, even if you have to kill me, just stop him! And remember that no matter what happens, no matter what you have to do, I will always love you, and the day you asked me to marry you was the happiest day of my life.’

‘Catra,’ I breathed, the words barely audible above the noise of the room, and surged forwards to meet her in a kiss. It was harsh, rushed, biting and *not enough* but it was all I would get, as Catra soon pushed me away, gripping her head as she screamed in pain. I watched her claws extend, her hands fisting into her wild, unkempt mane as her tech began to glow that horrible bright green once again.

Then she looked at me, her eyes full of sadness and regret, and smiled. ‘I love you, Adora. I always have,’ she whispered, as her pupils vanished behind a bright, green light.

‘Catra, no! I can’t do this without you!’ But my declaration came far too late, as it was no longer Catra standing before me. Her posture straightened, her neck cracking as it moved around at odd angles, as if *He* was getting settled into her body again. The thought of him in there, violating Catra’s control over herself, made me sick to my stomach and ready to burst with anger.

But then I realised that Melog wasn't nearby, even though Catra said that's why Prime was using her. So where were they?

'What have you done with Melog?' I demanded through gritted teeth.

Prime just smiled. It was a dead expression, with no real happiness behind it at all, just contempt. He held Catra's arm out in front of her, allowing a small, green wisp of magic to settle into her hand, before it floated away again.

I gasped, recognising the ambience of the room, the familiar way that magic permeated the air, the wisps of light, previously golden and bright, now a menacing and deadly bright green. 'Melog is…'

'All around us, yes,' he turned Catra's head, making her look around the room, before her gaze settled back on me. 'A curious creature of pure magic. This Krytonian evaded the Ember Protocol once before. It remembers how, and it will carry me to the other side, unscathed, while your world burns to the ground.'

'You can't do this,' I spat through gritted teeth.

'I *can* , and I *will.* We don't have long now until the Ember Protocol takes full effect. The drones are a useful distraction, are they not?'

I paused, momentarily taken aback by just how heartless, how uncaring, Prime really was. ‘You sacrificed all those ships, all those clones trapped in space, for a *distraction?’*

He grinned again, that awful, evil smile splitting Catra’s beautiful face in an ugly, unnatural way. ‘More clones can be made,’ he sang, sounding amused that I would actually care for the lives of his army. ‘Once I am free of this world, I shall make myself a new vessel. After all, your Catra won’t last nearly as long as I require.’

I could feel my eyes welling up against my wishes, betraying the thought that we could still win this, that we still had a chance. I couldn’t give up, not yet, Catra still needed me, *Etheria* still needed me. I had to stop him, to save everyone, it wasn’t too late.

My hand closed around the device in my pocket. *It wasn’t too late.*

I had to distract him, keep him talking, enough that he’d lower his guard and give me a chance to get close to the machinery. Maybe that’s why he positioned Catra between me and the column, to keep me away. Was he worried I had a plan? That I had something up my sleeve? One last flicker of hope?

He should’ve been, because thanks to Entrapta, I did. *We* did. Etheria had one last hope.

I just had to distract him first.

‘How are you here, alive? I destroyed you with the magic from the Heart of Etheria. I erased you from Hordak’s mind. I *felt it.* You were *gone* .’

Catra’s head tilted back, as if Prime wasn’t expecting this kind of response. He quirked her eyebrow, considering, before delicately lacing her fingers together behind her back. ‘Yes,’ He began, a curious tone to Catra’s voice, ‘Gone from that defective waste of life’s excuse of a mind. Would you believe me if I said I barely understand my revival myself? I remember standing above you all, about to witness the universe consumed in undying flame and then… I awoke here. An echo of myself trapped within ancient temples and *crude,* outdated technology.’

He brought Catra’s hands around, seemingly inspecting the gloves that became *shackles* the moment he used them to invade her mind, and smiled, glancing up at me with an almost threatening glare.

‘This *Focus* your Catra uses to channel her *magic* ,’ he said, spitting the word “magic” like it burned him, ‘Do you know if its true purpose?’

I stared back at him, at her, my eyes flicking between the gloves and the circlet like they would somehow tell me the answer. They didn’t, instead they just continued to glow that menacing, sickly green. ‘No,’ I whispered, having found my voice, ‘I just—’

‘You know not of its purpose, and yet you approved of its use anyway? I thought you *loved* your Catra.’

‘Well, we found it in that temple and—’

‘Yes, I know the story,’ Prime waved Catra’s hand, silencing me, before turning to pace around the room. I took my first tentative step forward. ‘The First Ones, as you call them, used that facility to collect magic from the planet. Not enough to harm it, but enough for their purposes. They attempted to artificially integrate living subjects with the planet’s raw magic, and the Focus technology was at the forefront of this project. This is the prototype of that technology, developed for any successful subjects to wield and harness their magical energy and create weapons out of *nothing* . Another try at weaponizing the raw power of Etheria, all in a futile attempt to stop me. Like with everything though, they failed, and none of the test subjects survived. They gave up. The project, abandoned. The facility, forgotten.’

While Prime spoke, making Catra pace around the column of screens that showed the relentless attacks by his drones, I managed to inch closer, step by step. But, as he finished his speech and came to a stop before me once again, as I stared into pools of horrible green where only beautiful blue and amber should be, his words sunk in.

‘How do you know so much about it?’ I asked, mortified at the implication that the First Ones had been trying to, what, replicate She-Ra? Make an army of magical fighters by harvesting Etheria’s magic? Yet another in a long line of twisted experiments bent on using this planet for war.

He smiled and straightened, trying to make Catra as tall as possible. Briefly, I remembered how he used to tower over his clones, his *brothers,* always taller, always in a position of power and authority. But, if there's one thing Catra didn't have on me, it was height. I'd always been a little taller, and now Prime was experiencing being truly *shorter* for maybe the first time in his long, long life.

'Not only was I assimilated as part of the First Ones' temple network, accessing all the available data I could for any way to create myself a new vessel, but I have also been at war with the First Ones for millennia. Their barbaric practices are well known to me. I had thought their empire crushed beneath my heel, and when I was in the final stages of annihilating the last remnants of that long-dead civilisation, I detected a far more interesting signal and followed it here, to *your* annihilation.'

Prime continued speaking, detailing his campaigns against my ancestors, but I wasn't listening; all of my thoughts orbited a single part of his monologue that, to him, seemed like a forgone conclusion.

'Wait,' I started, and to my surprise he actually stopped, turning Catra's head toward me with a glare, her ears perking up, *listening* , 'There are First Ones out there? They're alive? Back on your ship, you said you crushed them entirely but… You *lied,* didn't you? You just said you were pushing against them but we *defeated you* . What if they survived because of us? Because of what we did?'

He made Catra growl, deep and threatening, which may have worked on anyone else other than me, before spitting in a rush, 'Then you had better hope they have forgotten this world! Why do you think I was fighting them? Why else would I rid the universe of their filth?! Eternia fell aeons ago, and it's empire will remain in ashes!'

I gasped. 'Eternia?' I saw Catra's brows furrow in confusion as Horde Prime watched the realisation dawn on my face. 'Eternia is a *planet.* That must be where the First Ones came from… Where *I* came from…'

'You are a fool to cultivate any kind of hope!' He yelled through Catra, 'What are you doing here, so far from home, if they did not abandon you? You were unwanted! A failure even to them!'

I shook my head, staring through Catra and straight at Horde Prime. 'No,' I said, 'I wasn't. I was taken. Light Hope brought me here through a portal. That means they're still out there, I can find them, I can…'

'It matters not!' He spat, a pulse of energy disturbing the moss on the floor as he swung Catra's arms down beside him, bearing her claws. 'That world is ash! That empire is *ash!* Just as this one soon shall be!'

That's when the lights in the room, casting their hateful green ambiance around the machinery, switched to a hate-filled, vengeful red, and Catra's face erupted in sick glee. Horde Prime

turned to me, grinning, and opened his arms to welcome the end of Etheria.

'To think one such as I, the emperor of known space, should be bested by the likes of *princesses* . I have toppled entire civilisations on a whim, burned entire stars for their energy, reigned over a perfect dominion. Everything was as it should be, and so it shall be again. Prime is eternal! Prime is forever! I am the Emperor of the Galactic Horde! Ruler of the known universe! Regent of the seven skies—'

While he was distracted listing his absurd amount of titles, I leapt into action. With a burst of adrenaline I shot forward, my heart hammering in my chest, and plunged Entrapta's drive deep into the machines at the heart of Prime's control.

'Rejoice, Adora, for you and your pitiful world shall finally meet your end!'

At first, it seemed as though it had no effect. A million different ways I failed flashed through my mind. Maybe I put the drive in the wrong place, maybe I broke it somehow, maybe I mis-juged what it was for and had just completely ruined Entrapta's plan, maybe—

But then, a sliver of purple light spread out from the base of the drive, steadily pushing back against the green of Horde Prime's very *being* .

I had to hide my smile of relief. 'You're wrong. I won't let that happen!'

'Naive girl, it's too late!' He shouted, grinning as he watched the desolation of Etheria unfold across the planet. 'Nothing can stop the cleansing flame of the Ember Protocol. Not your "Alliance", not you, and certainly not your Catra! You will all suffer as this world is engulfed in fire and ash, and then my glorious conquest of the universe can proceed!'

Entrapta's tech was working slowly, *too* slowly. I would have to distract him again, to get his attention while— *Emily* , who's recognisable AI interface lit up one of the screens on Prime's column with a happy winking face in the style of Entrapta's doodles—slowly took over the systems in the room just as she had back on the Dreadnought.

'NO!' I burst, mainly out of desperation in an attempt to keep him from seeing what Emily was doing. It worked, he turned to face me, unsheathing Catra's claws in silent threat. 'You– you don't understand! There's so much– *so much* that will be lost if you destroy Etheria!' I realised I was probably about to ramble, but if there was ever a time for it, it was then. Adora, rambling to save Etheria. 'There's so much happiness, and hope, and– and love. *So much love* ... All my life, I haven't let myself want *anything* , I haven't been selfish, I have *never* put myself first. Well... I'm changing that, right now. I love Catra, and Catra loves me. Nothing you say or do will ever come between us. I have more, so much *more* love to give, to show her. She's my entire world, she always has been; my person, my *everything* . I proposed to her and she said *yes* .'

I fixed him with a determined glare. I could feel She-Ra's power become a raging inferno as I let everything *Catra* form a whirlwind in my mind. Everything we ever did together, everything we whispered behind crates where no-one else could hear. All those promises of a life together. I'd be an idiot to let something like this come between me and my happiness. For once in my life, I let myself fight for something *I* wanted. I let myself fight for Catra.

'For the Honour! Of! Gray— *Aaaaagh!!!* '

I screamed as bolts of red electricity arced across the floor, coursing through me and forcing my body rigid like stone. I dropped to my knees, unable to hold myself up. I couldn't open my fists, even when I felt my fingernails digging painfully into my palms. It was a familiar pain. It burned my clothes and singed my skin, but two decades of this specific torture meant I knew exactly how long I could hold out for.

'Catra!' I shouted for her, trying to get through, 'Catra! I won't fight you! Not anymore! Never again!' I screamed as the pain intensified, 'You have to fight it! Catra!'

I strained to open my eyes, to look at her... She was standing close to me now, her face contorted in rage. But it's not *her* , those aren't *her* eyes staring down at me, bright green and filled with hate. They're *His.*

His hold on her is too powerful, amplified by the First Ones tech on her head and hands… she would need more than words to bring her back from this. I caught a glimpse of the golden wing on

her belt and felt a surge of determination rise within me. I wouldn't let this happen... This was not what I *wanted* to happen!

Straining against the pain, screaming as my muscles fought against me, I rose from the floor, standing as best I could. Then, I began to move forwards, inch by inch. Each step was agony, my body burning with the pain, but I pressed forward. I *would* get through to her.

' *Catra!* I finally proposed! You said yes! We're going to get married!' I felt myself crying against the pain, the tears stinging as they dripped down my face. I was close now, close enough to see the conflict burning behind Catra's eyes. 'I want that! I know you do too! So fight him!' I was face to face with her, staring straight into her eyes as best I could through the cloud of tears cascading down my cheeks. 'Please come back to me,' I whispered, before I leant forward and pressed my lips against that awful snarl.

The effect was instantaneous. All the arcs of red electricity flowing from Catra's hands ceased, all the pain stopped, instead reduced to a dull ache, as I fell forwards into Catra's arms.

She caught me, holding me and kissing me while slowly leading us down towards the floor. Her tech was shining blindingly bright with Prime's light, but Catra didn't stop as I yielded my lips, my tongue, my *everything* to her. Even when the crystals on her gloves, the crystal on her circlet, began to crack, the green light flickering from them, she didn't stop kissing me. It was *our love* that finally broke Prime's hold on my wife, making the gems explode into a thousand splinters.

It was only after the crystals finally shattered, their tainted shards falling to the ground around us, that she pulled away. She took off her gloves, throwing them across the room; She removed her circlet, tossing it aside; She looked at me, brought her hands up to cup my face, her thumbs stroking over my cheeks…

And then she kissed me again.

'Catra–' I gasped, trying to catch my breath as we rested our foreheads together. I brought a hand up to hold her shoulder in that way I always did, if not to soothe Catra, then to reassure myself that she's here, in front of me. She's real, and she's of her own mind again.

'I know,' Catra whispered against my lips, her shallow breaths sending shivers down my spine, 'I love you too. But it's not over, Adora. Prime still has Melog, I can feel them. They're hurting.'

I hated that I felt so weak after Prime used Catra to attack me, my muscles still spasming of their own accord every now and then. Everything ached, and I could barely hold myself up in my position on the floor, but I wanted to help. I tried to stand, protesting against my muscles that screamed at me in defiance, but Catra stopped me. Instead of helping me stand, she moved me over to the column, leaning me against it so I was no longer struggling to stay upright. I felt so useless, so exhausted, *weak* . I had to be stronger, I *wanted* to be stronger, but I just *couldn't move* . So drained after forcing myself to take the full force of Catra's magic, that she had to carry me to safety afterwards.

‘Wait here,’ she whispered, planting a final kiss on my forehead before stepping away, leaving me sat up against the central column of monitors, now mostly shining with Emily’s purple glow, exactly where she had been when I first entered.

'Catra, wait. What are you doing? Please...'

'I'm doing what I have to, Adora,’ Catra said, glancing around the room as the wisps of Melog’s magic danced around us. ‘Prime has to be stopped. I can't let him destroy everything. I–I can't let anything happen to *you* .’

‘Catra—’

‘What a pity,’ Prime’s voice grated from nowhere as a flicker of green light began to form in front of Catra. ‘Such a waste.’ The light grew, expanded, shimmered until it formed a full hologram of Prime, exactly as I’d pictured him in my head but… *green,* translucent *.* An echo of himself, reduced to a hologram, a fragment. ‘It will be a shame to destroy such a perfectly fine vessel, one that held such promise and power. What are you now, Catra, without the Focus? Hm? I’ll tell you… You are a failure, *powerless* to stop me.’

‘I might be,’ Catra smirked, confidently placing a hand on her hip, before calling back over her shoulder, ‘But what about you, Emily?’

» I estimate at my current rate of erasing and overwriting data that the virus in these systems will be totally gone in, uhhh, 5 to 10 minutes! «

‘What?’ Horde Prime gasped, all the colour draining from his face, if that was even possible.

» I don’t know if you want a percentage, but I’ll give you one! The virus is already eighteen point seven percent eradicated! «

‘What?!’ He snapped, his holographic form flickering for a moment before vanishing entirely.

» Oh! Yeah, okay, the virus is fighting back at full strength now! Gonna just… «

I tried to stand up again, getting increasingly frustrated at myself when my limbs just *would not* cooperate, instead deciding to act like they’ve been filled with sand, the weight dragging me down. The effort made me dizzy, and I had to stop and blink to right the world around me as it began to blur. Which is when I noticed a shift in the air or, *no* , not a shift *per se* , because there was no wind, but all the pinpricks of light, the green wisps of Melog’s magic, their *being* , began coalescing in the place Prime had been standing moments before he vanished.

Catra was already watching, her tail curling in that way it always did when she was unsure, yet cautious. Her ears stood rigid, alert. Her pupils thin slits of black against familiar heterochromatic eyes, laser-focused on what was happening before her.

Melog, forming again out of thin air—their mane, tail, and eyes a sickly, horrible green—snarling at Catra with nothing but contempt.

And yet I still couldn't stand up.

'For the Honour… of Grayskull…' I said, my voice fragile, without its usual confidence. I realised I was shaking. I clenched my fists, trying to stop my hands from betraying me, trying to power through the residual pain from being shocked with enough volts to power one of Entrapta's biggest inventions.

It didn't work.

Instead, I was forced to watch as Melog pounced at Catra, snarling and biting with claws enlarged and sharp, and felt my entire body tense as she only just managed to dodge out of the way.

'Melog!' Catra yelled, after dodging another close-call with their claws, 'You can push him out, I know you can! I know you'd never hurt me, I can feel you still in there, you just have to show him how much stronger you are!'

Melog faltered, their angry, spiky mane rounding and shifting colours for a moment before it reverted back to green. Their face contorted in a roar and they pounced once more, forcing Catra to dodge, but…

They got her. I watched as a trail of red stained Catra's waist, a cut in her side visible through the tear in her top. She winced at the pain, bringing a hand up and putting pressure on it for a moment before she was forced to leap aside again, Melog giving her no chance to recover, to rest. Another wound appeared on Catra's thigh, she was limping now, clearly in pain and *tired* .

I tried to get up again, shouting against the pain as my joints and limbs protested. 'Catra!'

'Stay there, Adora!' She called back, holding out a blood-soaked hand as if to hold me in place, 'Stay there! I can get through to them. I can. I can do it.'

The banks of machinery around us began to spark, little fires erupting where the green of Prime's light met the purple of Emily's. It looked like a stalemate, each of them attacking and defending an equal amount while the systems fell apart and exploded around them.

Catra screamed. I looked back to see Melog atop her, claws holding her down by the shoulders as she desperately tried to push them off. But Catra's hands just swiped *through* Melog, as if

they weren't there at all. She was trying to speak, to tell them to fight it, but her words were drowned in her screams of pain as Melog's claws sunk deeper. They opened their jaw wide, and I watched as their teeth grew longer, bigger, sharper, as they leant down towards Catra's neck.

'Help her,' I begged, my body still protesting.

' *Help her* ,' I whispered, a last-ditch plea.

'She-Ra, *please* . Save Catra.'

What happened next, what I *felt* , was unlike anything I'd ever experienced before. It was like I got weaker, so much weaker than I'd ever been, as my entire body began to glow with She-Ra's magic. And then, instead of transforming *me* , the light began to move *away,* flowing out of me and circling in the air above. I watched, entirely captivated by surprise and fascination, as the light descended, flowing into Catra just as Melog's jaw closed around her neck.

Then there was a glow, followed by a burst of blindingly bright golden light as *Catra* became *She-Ra* .

'That's not exactly what I meant,' I whispered, stunned, as Catra turned to face me.

She was standing now, her wild mane dancing in an non-existent breeze. All of her was dazzling. Her eyes, radiant, shining brighter than ever before. Her armour, white and gold, covering most of her taller, stronger body as she towered over me. She even had her mask back. And all of her was glowing, but not just gold—not just She-Ra—all the colours of the princesses. A spectrum of light surrounded her, and this time I really *could* feel a shift in the air.

The hairs on the back of my neck stood to attention as a breeze swept past me, the air abuzz with static electricity. Vines snaked down from the ceiling, water filtered in through cracks in the floor, ice crystals forming in its wake. And Catra…

Catra was looking at me. A question in her eyes, and sadness too. She opened her mouth to speak but was cut off by Melog who, still green yet cowering across the room, mewled in fear.

Then, all at once, the wind picked up, surrounding Melog in a gale as the vines descended and wrapped around their form. Next, the water surged forwards, a mini tidal wave washing over them before crystallising and freezing them in place. Finally, red lighting coursed through the vines and the ice, and Melog's glow shifted from that horrible green, back to their familiar blue.

Catra approached them slowly, holding out her hand, smiling when Melog willingly offered her their head. She placed her palm between their ears, closed her eyes, and poured her magic into them.

After a moment she pulled back, smiling as Melog licked at her hand, and whispered, 'Welcome back, buddy.'

Melog mewled happily, shaking their coat out once the ice had melted away and the vines released them. The wind vanished too, its whistle vanishing as suddenly as it had appeared.

Then Catra turned to me, a soft look in her eyes. She approached, knelt beside me, and held my face in her hands.

'What did you *do,* Adora?' She whispered.

'I don't know,' I replied. 'I don't know.'

The heat warming my cheeks from Catra's palms slowly got more intense, but not unbearable. And, as Catra started to glow with that familiar golden light, she closed her eyes, her brows furrowed in concentration. I gasped as the heat from her palms spread throughout me and, with it, the ache in my joints vanished, and I found I could move again.

'Well, that's just unfair,' I commented, 'It took me years to get the hang of healing!'

Catra just smiled and pulled me to my feet as Melog approached, demanding head-scritches. Of course I indulged, it'd been a while since I saw them and… I *needed* it. I think they knew that.

‘Adora,’ Catra said, nudging my arm. ‘Look.’

I turned, my eyes widening in astonishment when I saw that all the machines, everything in the room, now shone with a friendly, purple light. Not a hint of green or red anywhere. The screens mounted on the central column, as well as those attached to the consoles around the room, were also turning black, shutting down one by one as Prime’s control faded.

» Ember Protocol deactivated! Along with every other nastly little sub-system in here. Wow, that’s *a lot* to unpack. «

‘That’s it?’ I asked, incredulous, ‘It’s…over?’

‘No,’ Catra said, closing her eyes. ‘I can still feel him. Like he’s clinging on somehow.’ She stepped forward, towards the column in the middle of the room, and looked it up and down as if searching for something in particular. ‘Emily? Where do I hit?’

There was a pause, and then:

» I have managed to cut off Horde Prime’s control of this facility and any other technological gizmo’s and whozits! But what I can only describe as his *consciousness* , buried far past a very *tricky* looking firewall, is not something I can directly attack and therefore— «

‘ *Emily!* ’ Catra huffed, impatient.

» Hit here! «

A panel opened up at Catra’s eye level, 8 feet off the ground (which looks a lot taller from an outside perspective), revealing a green orb glowing with such intensity that it shone like a beacon out of the intestines of the column. Catra had to shield her eyes with one hand, using the other to summon a sword not too dissimilar to my own. The only difference; the cross-guard was more rounded, a half-moon shape that came together at two pointed tips. It looked like her old mask, and I couldn’t help but smile at the familiarity of the design.

Melog bristled beside me, standing to attention and mewling at Catra as she readied her blade.

‘Catra?’ I asked, stepping forward, ‘What are they saying?’

‘They’re telling me not to do what I’m about to do,’ Catra replied without turning back to face me. ‘That it’s too risky.’

‘What are you doing?’ I asked, then begged, ‘Catra, please, don’t do anything stupid!’

‘I’m only doing what you would do, Adora. I have to make sure he’s gone. For good, this time. I can do it. I’m ready.’

I froze as I heard my own voice echo in my head…

“It’s okay, I’m ready.”

No. No, no no no no…

‘Catra, no! *Please* , Catra, *wait!* ’

But my cries came far too late, the wind beginning to pick up, to get louder, flooding my ears with nothing but thunderous white noise. It surrounded the central column in a vortex that only grew in strength and speed, picking up debris, moss, as well as loose paneling and circuitry from around the room, flinging it in all directions. I could only just make out Catra’s form, shining with all the magic of Etheria, as she readied her blade, pointed it at the swirling green orb buried within a mess of ancient circuits and wiring, and lunged forwards.

Melog saw an opening and took it, easily leaping through the wall of wind, but the intensity of it was too much for me. I couldn’t stand too close without potentially being swept off my feet or hit by something heavy, and the magical purple glow prevented me from seeing inside.

This situation felt too familiar, too vivid. In the Heart, I thought I was ready, but I was *wrong* . Catra, she– she was there *with me* . Holding on to me. Not letting go. And I– I was stuck out here, once again on the other side of a wall of magical wind, this time without She-Ra. No way in, no way to get to Catra. No way to be there for her in the same way she was there for me.

‘CATRA!!’ I screamed, tears blinding my vision both from the wind and the sensation of pain and *loss* already burning bright deep down inside me.

Which is when I noticed the figure beside me, flickering in and out of existence, staring impassively as Catra single handedly saw to his end.

'You’re just letting it happen?’ I said, noting the impassive expression on his face. ‘You’re giving up.'

A grating sound, a hum, maybe, sounded from a speaker nearby. Disconnected from his body, yet still recognisable. 'I am old,’ Prime said, ‘Tired, but do not think I die *dissatisfied* . Your Catra will drain herself of magic and it will not replenish, I've made quite sure of that. Once she expels the last of her power, she will never be able to use magic again. The process will leave her *weak* , maybe even finish her, and she doesn't even know it. How brave. How sad. How *unfortunate* that you can't do anything to save her. My *final victory* .'

‘What do you mean?’ I asked, turning back to face where Catra should be, ‘What do you mean she’ll drain herself?’

Prime chuckled in the way one would when someone knows they're about to die, I supposed, before saying, through a sad smile, 'The First Ones truly were a vile people. Driven by greed and power. They had this desire to prolong their own existence, and so built devices which harboured their very *souls* . The device which your Catra has no doubt already plunged her blade, is called the Well of Echoes, and contains the souls of those long dead that I have since assimilated into extensions of myself. It will take everything she has to destroy them all. Make no mistake, Adora, she *will* have to destroy them all if she truly wants to erase me. Do you think she'll be able to do it? I had hoped it would be you, She-Ra's power alone would not have been enough. But Catra has more, doesn't she? More power to use, the gift you gave her in the Heart of Etheria. Perhaps you have saved her one last time, after all. But, perhaps not. Either way, you have seen to my definitive end and, for that, I commend you.'

I opened my mouth to say… *something.* I wasn't sure what, maybe to protest his words, try to reassure myself that Catra would be fine. Maybe to denounce his commendation at finally killing him for good, that's not something I wanted his approval for. But whatever it was I was going to say, it died in my throat as the image of Prime, smiling in morbid delight, glitched and fizzled from existence.

The wind died down soon after, and the room succumbed to *silence* as all the consoles shut down, their light fading. Emily's purple light lingered too, for a moment, before vanishing entirely, her part in Entrapta's plan complete, Horde Prime completely wiped from the systems.

It was Melog's mewl that drew my focus next, it was long, sad, almost… *mournful.* I glanced back around to the central column where Catra—who had been standing there moments before looking radiant, strong, glowing with the power of She-Ra—now lay motionless on the ground, not a hint of magic in sight, illuminated only by the soft blue glow of Melog's mane. I ran over immediately, falling to sit beside her body and pull her onto my lap, into my arms. Melog was purring, trying to comfort her, to get through to her, nudging her arms and legs with their nose.

I brushed her hair out of her face, looking for any sign that she was okay, but there were none. Her eyes were closed, she wasn't breathing, and she felt heavy again, just like how she did when… After she… Before I…

She-Ra wasn't with me this time, I wouldn't be able to save her.

I didn't even get to say *goodbye.*

Thank you.

I love you.

And then she coughed, her body contorting with the strain. I only began to feel relief after she opened her eyes and I could see the familiar hues of my wife's beautiful eyes.

‘Adora…’ Catra croaked. Her voice was weak, strained.

‘Catra?’ I could feel the tears streaming down my face, and laughed in relief when I heard her speak. ‘You’re okay, you’re okay. I promise. I’ve got you. We did it. *You* did it. We’re safe.’

‘Is he gone? Is everyone safe?’ She asked, her eyes opening a fraction to look up into my eyes. She looked so weak, so tired, so…

“Drained,” The memory of Prime’s voice supplied, and I pushed it out of mind in favour of holding my future wife close to me.

‘He’s gone,’ I sobbed into her hair, stroking it gently while planting kiss after kiss against her forehead, her cheeks, her nose and her lips, ‘He’s gone.’

The hint of a smile tugged at Catra’s lips, and I felt *relief* for the first time in months. Prime had found a way to hold on, to continue hurting the people of Etheria, but he was gone for good now. We were safe, finally, *truly* safe. For a long time, I just held Catra, whispering to her how much I loved her, how much I’d missed her while she was away, and how happy I was that I’d found her, that she was okay.

‘Lon–,’ Catra croaked, ‘Lonnie– is she—’

‘She’s fine,’ I replied, a laugh soon following. ‘We found her. She’s okay.’

‘Good,’ Catra breathed, clearly relieved. ‘I was worried I’d hurt her.’

‘Lonnie’s tough, she can handle you roughing her up a bit.’

‘Only cause I go easy on her.’

‘You do *not* . She’s just that good. If the princesses didn’t have magical powers and went up against *Lonnie* —’

‘Adora,’ Catra interrupted, and I broke from my ramble before it began to look down at the single most beautiful woman on Etheria. There were tears in those soft, dazzling eyes that gazed up at me so full of love I thought I might melt. ‘I love you. I always will. I’m sorry I—’

‘No,’ I cut her off *hard* ‘Don’t be sorry. We couldn’t have known he’d use the tech like that. It’s not your fault.’

I felt her relax in my arms, her eyes finally falling closed, as she allowed herself to succumb to her fatigue. Melog was still purring, licking at Catra’s arm every so often, cleaning her, showing they care, apologising in their own way.

‘Wait, Dor’,’ Catra said, her voice heavy and tired, ‘What about She-Ra?’

‘I don’t know,’ I whispered back, stroking my hand through her hair. She-Ra didn’t matter to me, not right then, I had everything I needed right there in my arms. ‘All that matters to me right now is that you’re okay.’

‘You’re such a dummy,’ Catra whispered, smiling. She rested her head against my chest, her ear pressed right over my heart as she finally let sleep wash over her.

‘Yeah, I know, Cat. I love you too.’

Chapter End Notes

the last two chapters are basically the story winding down. we're out of the woods, folks!

join me again in [redacted] days for the next part!

(idk when the next part will be but BMCC will update soon so you should go read that if you haven't already and crave Gender in word form)

PLEASE READ (Author's Note)

Hi everyone!

I'm re-writing this story!

Slowly.

A quick apology for this not being an actual chapter. The main plot and villain was finished and defeated with chapter 42 but it's not the official last chapter. Originally what would have been chapter 43 was a montage of Adora checking up on what everyone else is up to plus hints of Catra's recovery in Mystacor. Chapter 44 would have been the wedding and finale.

That said…

This story was written in the first person from a single point of view in the past tense.

My rewrite is in the third person, present tense, and features multiple points of view.

You can imagine how this might open things up a bit.

If you have read this story I urge you to please read the new version.

You can find it here

I fully intend on revisiting most plot points and original locations, improving upon them and, since I wrote this story without an actual plan, hopefully tying everything together a bit more fluidly. Oh and also, you know, properly finishing it.

To those who have this bookmarked and have read this far, I thank you for your support.

To those who haven't read the whole thing and have skipped to this chapter because of its title, go read the new one! (please)

With thanks,
iorekofthehorde

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!